



A ROLEPLAYING GAME OF EATEN
GODS

THE LONG GRACE

CORE BOOK · REVISED & EXPANDED

SEVEN LANDS · SIX EATEN GODS · ONE THAT IS STILL HUNGRY

WE WERE **HUNGRY.** SAY IT **PLAINLY.** WE WERE
HUNGRY, AND THEY WERE **THERE.**

[FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE]

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CHAPTER 1

BEFORE YOU SIT
DOWN

We were hungry. Say it plainly. We were hungry, and they were there.

— FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE

My grandmother told it to me the way her grandmother told it to her, with the shutters closed and a crust of bread between us that neither of us was allowed to touch until she had finished.

“There were eight of them,” she said, “and they lived with us the way the weather lives with us. You did not pray to them. You did not need to. You woke up and they were there, as big as the hill behind the house, and they were kind, and they were warm, and they fed us.”

“Then they stopped,” I said, because I knew the story.

“Then everything stopped. Nine years. The seed lay in the furrow like teeth in a dead mouth. The nets came up holding

only water. The cows went dry, and then the women did.” She looked at the crust. “And on the ninth winter we went up the hill with knives.”

“Did they fight?”

“No,” she said. “That is the part nobody can stand. They lay down. They lay down like a dog lies down for the hand it knows, and they let us.”

She pushed the crust toward me. I said the grace, the way you must: Lack keep away. I ate it. It tasted like bread. It tasted like bread for eleven more years, and then one morning it tasted like something that had been waiting for me.

▼ THE WORLD IN ONE BREATH

Six hundred and forty-one years ago, at the end of a famine that lasted nine years, the peoples of the world killed their gods and ate them. Six peoples did. One refused.

It saved them. It also did not stay down. A god cannot be digested, only delayed. In every land, the god that was eaten is growing back: through the bloodlines of the people who swallowed it, through the soil their dead were buried in, through the weather over their heads. Each land is now a culture living inside the slow, wrong resurrection of its own meal.

The poets of the Table have a name for the age that followed. They call it **the Long Grace**: the pause between the blessing and the

first bite, the breath a family holds before it is permitted to eat. Six centuries of borrowed time, while the meal sits in the belly of the world and remembers what it was. Everyone alive is descended from someone who ate. The monster is in the blood, and it is waking up. The Grace is ending.

This book is a complete tabletop roleplaying game set in that world. It contains everything you need to play: the history and lands of the Table, the rules for making and ruining characters, a market to buy and sell in, a gallery of the things that hunt and are hunted, guidance for the person who runs the game, and an adventure to begin with.

▼ WHAT KIND OF GAME IS THIS?

The Long Grace is a horror roleplaying game. One player, the **Carver** (the game master, or GM: at a feast on the Table, the Carver is the one who decides who gets which portion), describes the world, plays everyone in it who is not a player character, and adjudicates the rules. Every other player creates and plays one **Guest**: a single person of the Table, with a land, a bloodline, a trade, debts, people they love, and a god in their veins that wants things.

Play is a conversation. The Carver describes a situation; the players say what their characters do; when the outcome is uncertain and matters, dice are rolled. Over a session or a long campaign, the characters investigate, travel the Rim Road, bargain, fight, flee, and make terrible choices, and the story that results belongs to everyone at the table.

It is not a game of heroes. There is no chosen one, no sword that kills a god, no cure that works. The characters are people trying to survive inside a catastrophe that is also their inheritance, and the most important rules in this book measure how their bodies change (**Hunger** and **Regrowth**), how their minds fray (**Fray** and **Derangements**), and what they are willing to do to each other to stay whole for one more day. Characters will be maimed. Characters will go mad. Characters will become something that is not a person anymore. Some of the best sessions you will play are the ones in which that happens.

WHAT YOU NEED

- ◇ This book, or at least its rules chapters and the character sheet at the back.

- ◇ Two ten-sided dice (d10) per player, ideally of two different colors. Several six-sided dice (d6) in a third color: these are **Teeth**, rolled when a character calls on the god inside them.
- ◇ Pencils, erasers, copies of the character sheet, and scrap paper for maps, ledgers, and the names of the dead.
- ◇ Three to six people, one of whom has read the rules and at least the chapter on the land where the game begins.
- ◇ A few hours, and a willingness to sit with discomfort.

▼ CONTENT AND CONSENT

This is a game about eating gods and the gods eating back. It is, deliberately, one of the most disturbing settings ever printed for a tabletop game. Before anyone at your table makes a character, everyone should know what is in it.

CONTENT WARNING

The Long Grace contains, described on the page and in sensory detail: graphic body horror and gore (flesh, bone, rot, unwanted transformation); murder, including ritual killing, executions and kin-slaying; torture; cannibalism, both desperate and sacramental; grave desecration and the misuse of the dead; blasphemy and corrupted religion; human sacrifice; self-harm and suicide, presented as tragedy and never as instruction; contagious madness, psychosis, hallucination, paranoia, delusions of being dead or of loved ones being impostors, dissociation and lost time; cult control and gaslighting; starvation; possession; and a cosmology without rescue or redemption.

The setting also touches, thematically and never explicitly, on cursed and incestuous bloodlines, sexual taboo among adults, and desecration of the dead. These elements are always implied, off-page, and adult. Children exist on the Table and suffer its horrors; this book never sexualizes them and never lingers on graphic violence done to them.

Horror is a collaboration. The point of all this darkness is not to wound the people at the table but to let them feel, safely and together, the weight of a world that cannot be saved. That only works if everyone trusts that the game will stop or turn when it needs to. Use the following tools. They are not optional extras; they are part of the rules.

LINES AND VEILS

Before the first session, the group discusses **Lines** (content that will not appear in the game at all) and **Veils** (content that may exist in

the fiction but happens off-screen: the camera cuts away, the door closes, the scene resumes afterward). Write both lists down and keep them visible. Anyone may add to them at any time without explanation. The Carver is responsible for honoring them, including by rewriting the material in this book. Every land and adversary in these pages can be run with any of its themes veiled.

SAYING THE GRACE

Every meal on the Table begins with the words *Lack keep away*. At your table, the same words, or a tap on a card marked with a crossed fork, mean: *stop this, now*. Anyone may say the Grace at any moment, about anything, with no reason given and no discussion required. The Carver immediately removes or alters whatever was happening, and play continues. Nobody asks why. Saying the Grace is never an insult and never an inconvenience; it is the oldest courtesy in the world.

CHECKING IN

Long campaigns drift. Every few sessions, take five minutes out of character: what has landed well, what was too much, what people want more of. Horror that has stopped being fun for one person at the table has stopped being fun for the table.

ON SUICIDE AND DESPAIR

The Long Grace contains the suicides of characters, in the setting's history and sometimes in play: the Finishers walking into the Hushes, the Called walking into the sea, the sleepless lying down on purpose. This book treats every one of these as a tragedy with a cost that falls on the living. It never describes how; it describes what it leaves behind. If you or someone at your table is struggling outside the game, stop the game. Real people matter more than any story, and help from people who are trained to give it is worth reaching for.

▼ HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

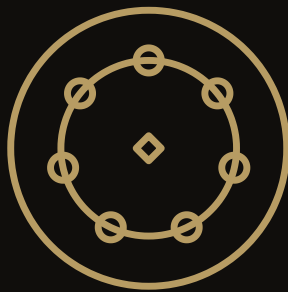
The book is divided into four parts.

- ◇ **Part One: The Table** describes the world. *The Long Grace* chapter covers the history, the Providers, the Lack, the Gorging, the Regrowth, the Cuts, the Rim Road and the powers that cross borders. Seven chapters follow, one for each land: Sallowreach, the Fatlands, Brinehollow, the Vigil, Cradlewrack, Oathen, and the Fast. Each chapter covers its land's meal, its rules of horror, its history, factions, people, and how to play someone born there. *Threads Between the Lands* ties them together.
- ◇ **Part Two: The Rules** explains how to make a character, how dice are rolled, how the god in the blood is measured and spent, how the mind breaks, and how violence is done.
- ◇ **Part Three: The Market and the Things That Eat** contains the full equipment and shopping system, the currencies of the Table, relics made from godflesh, and a bestiary of horrors, human adversaries and Seated gods.
- ◇ **Part Four: Setting the Table** is for the Carver alone: how to run horror, how to build campaigns, the secrets of the world, and the introductory adventure, *The Ninth Chair*.

At the back you will find the character sheet and an index.

WORDS OF THE TABLE

- ◇ **The Table:** the known world, a single round continent with a dead heartland.
- ◇ **The Long Grace:** the age since the Gorging; the borrowed time before the gods finish growing back.
- ◇ **The Gorging:** the night six peoples killed and ate their gods. Year 0 A.G. (After Gorging). It is now 641 A.G.
- ◇ **Providers:** the eight gods who lived bodily among the peoples.
- ◇ **The Lack:** the nine-year famine before the Gorging. Also: winter; also, the bone coin.
- ◇ **Regrowth:** the slow return of an eaten god through the people who ate it. Its marks are *godsign*.
- ◇ **Cut:** a bloodline, named for the part of the god its ancestors ate. The higher the Cut, the stronger the god in the blood.
- ◇ **Scraplings:** descendants of those who got the scraps; the least changed people alive.
- ◇ **Blanks:** those rare people born with no godsign at all. Hunted everywhere.
- ◇ **The Unfed:** the people of the Fast, who refused to eat.
- ◇ **Tablenight:** the anniversary of the Gorging, the longest night of winter.
- ◇ **The Rim Road:** the ring highway around the Fast, along which all trade moves.
- ◇ **Carver and Guests:** in this book, the game master (also called the GM) and the players.



PART ONE

THE TABLE

*The history of the eaten gods, the seven lands that ate or refused them,
and the people living inside the slow resurrection of their meal.*



CHAPTER 2

THE LONG GRACE

We were hungry. Say it plainly. We were hungry, and they were there.

— FIRST LINE OF EVERY HISTORY WRITTEN ON THE TABLE

▼ PROLOGUE: THE NIGHT OF SEVEN TABLES

Nobody agrees whether it was one night or a whole black season of nights. Every people remembers it as one. These are seven of the memories, set down in the words of the people who keep them, and arranged in the order the Rim Road Company's chroniclers prefer, which is clockwise, ending at the middle, because that is where every road on the Table ends whether it means to or not.

I. THE FENS

Nobody wanted to be first. That is the whole of it, and the fen-folk tell it as if it were a virtue.

Ossel lay where it had lain down, half in the black water and half on the reed-bank below the place that would one day be Lastgate. It was grey the way fog is grey, long the way a road is long, and its hands lay open on the peat, palms up, each one wide enough to cup a cottage. We stood around it with knives we had ground from the shoulder-blades of cattle that had died in the fifth year. There were thousands of us. You could hear stomachs. You could hear the fog dripping off the reeds.

Every so often, while we stood there, one of the children at the back of the crowd died. That was ordinary then. You heard a mother make the sound and then stop making it. And each time, one of those great hands lifted, slow as a heron, reached over our heads without touching anyone, and closed the child's eyes with a fingertip the size of a loaf. Then it settled back onto the peat and lay open again.

It did that eleven times before anyone moved.

The one who moved was Agna Corse, who was ninety and had buried four husbands and nine children and was dying where she stood. She did not cut the god. She asked her grandson to. She said, I will not last till morning and I would like to have eaten something. He took the smallest finger of the left hand, the last joint, and it came away like the stalk of a mushroom, and inside it was cold and pale and wet and smelled of cellars and turned earth and the inside of a closed box. She ate it raw, with her gums. She did not die that night. She did not die the next night either. She is, by some accounts, still upright in a Lastgate loft, and asks after her grandson, who has been sunk in the Sump for five hundred years.

After her it went easier. It always does. We ate it slowly, because it was cold and because we were ashamed, and because every time a knife went in the hand nearest would lift a little, as if to close our eyes, and then think better of it and lie down. The families who took the hands sat apart and ate them in silence, joint by joint, cracking the knuckles with stones. Their lips went grey by morning. We bowed to them for it.

There was one boy, they say, a peat-cutter's son, who stood at the back the whole night and never ate. He was staring past the god, over its shoulder, at the empty bank on the far side of the fire, where nobody stood because there was nothing there to stand near. Just before dawn he made a small sound, and turned, and ran out into the fen in the dark, and we heard the water take him. Nobody went after him. We were eating.

II. THE PLAINS

We were fastest. Say that too. Say it proudly; we do.

Ummer the Laden came in off the stubble on the last evening of the ninth Carving and lay down on the great threshing floor at Brawn Tilth like an ox that has decided. It was the size of a barn and it smelled the way an oven smells when you open it, and the starving went toward that smell before anyone had spoken a word, on their hands and knees, the old ones crawling, the young ones running on legs like rake-handles.

There was no ceremony. There was no first cut, because there were a thousand first cuts. People bit it. I want you to understand: before the knives came out, people had their faces in its side and were biting, and the skin gave like the crust of a loaf, and under the crust it was fat, yellow, a hand's depth of it, warm as a body, and under the fat it was meat that bled gravy. Children were pushed in to the shoulder. Men pulled ribs apart with their arms and handed the meat back over their heads to whoever was behind. A woman sat in the hollow of its flank with her baby and chewed and put the chewed meat in the baby's mouth with her tongue, chewed and gave, chewed and gave, crying the whole time, and the baby

lived, and that baby's grandchildren's grandchildren sit on the Board of Plenty today.

The Gut-line families got there first because they were nearest the belly. They opened it and grain came out. That is what is remembered: the belly opened and the threshing floor was knee-deep in grain in a heartbeat, a wave of it, hot, smelling of summer, and in that grain were small white things like teeth, which we took for husks. We ate those too. Nobody asked.

By midnight the big bones were bare. By the second hour we were cracking them on the floor-stones for the marrow, and the noise of that was like a forest coming down. By dawn there was nothing on the threshing floor but grease and grain and people asleep in it, curled up, fat-faced, with their mouths still moving. The god had not made a sound. It had not stopped us. Old women say its eyes were open the whole time, and kind, and that it watched us eat it the way a mother watches.

The hunger did not stop. We noticed that around noon. We were full to the throat and the hunger had not stopped. It still has not.

III. LONGSLAB

Dromm would not come up on its own. The others lay down; the Fathom had to be fetched.

It took ten thousand hooks. Every family on the coast brought every hook it owned and hammered more from door-hinges and pot-handles, and we rowed them out over the deep place in boats with nothing in their holds, and we set them, and we hauled. The ropes sang. Men's hands opened to the bone on them and they wrapped the bone in sailcloth and hauled again. It came up out of the dark slowly over three days, a shape like a reef that breathed, and it did not fight us, but the sea did: the water around it thickened until boats could not row through it, and the pressure of it pressed our ears until they bled in threads down our jaws.

We dragged it onto the shingle at Longslab on the third evening. It was grey and slick and vast and its skin moved in long slow ripples like the surface of the water it had left. It had no face you could find. It had an enormous slow breathing, a sound like surf turned inside out, and every breath it took pulled the tide a little further out from under the boats.

It took four days to stop moving. We did not wait for it to stop. We were too hungry for that. The families who would be the Lung-lines cut their way in under the ribs on the second day and found the lungs, which were the size of chapels, folded and grey and full of cold water, and they ate them in the water, standing in the god, chest-deep in the brine that poured

out of it. One girl put her whole head inside a lobe to drink and came out and said she had heard the sea from the inside, and that it was talking. She walked into the water a week later, the first of all the Called, though nobody had a name for it then.

The beach has never dried. Stand on Longslab in the hottest week of Plenty and the shingle is wet under your soles and the wet is warm. On the fourth night, when it finally stopped moving, every one of us woke at the same moment coughing salt water. We thought it was grief.

IV. LUDMERE

Hush. That was the whole instruction. Hush, and do not wake it.

Iss the Lidded slept in the high valley above Ludmere, where it had always slept, curled on its side like a hound, as long as the valley, with its head on its paws and its great lids shut. It had never been seen awake. Its breathing was the weather of that country: slow, warm, regular, the grass along the valley floor lying down and rising up again with each breath. We had slept beside it all our lives, and dreamed well, and in the famine years we had dreamed of food, nightly, until the dreams were the only food we had.

So we came up the valley in the dark, in stocking feet, with our knives wrapped in wool so they would not clink. Mothers sang. That is what we kept from that night: the lullabies. A thousand women singing low, so the god would go on sleeping while we opened it. The knives went in to the singing. The blood came out warm and slow and smelled of linen and milk and the hollow of a lover's neck, and the people who drank it yawned, all of them, and had to be slapped awake to go on eating.

It never woke. Write that down and underline it. It never stirred, never flinched, never sighed. We took the flesh from the haunch and it went on breathing. We took the heart and it went on breathing for an hour without one. Near dawn the families who would be the Eye-lines climbed the face with ropes and cut out its eyes, still shut, lids and lashes and all, each one the size of a cartwheel, and lowered them down, and sliced them like bread, and ate them closed. The lids were the best part, they said after. Like cream.

Some of us dozed, toward the end, full and warm against the cooling side. And some of those who dozed dreamed of a long dim room, and woke weeping, and could not say why. We put it down to the occasion.

The breathing stopped at sunrise. The valley grass lay down flat, and has never quite stood up again.

V. THE RED HILLS

Vey was the smallest of them and it would not stay killed. Every midwife in the highlands was called up to the round hill to help, and the midwives tell it best, so this is how they tell it.

It was the size of a calf when it lay down, a soft red thing with a hundred small closed openings in its skin like buds, and its warmth came off it in waves you could see in the frost. A Caul-wife of Kest put her knife in under the breastbone, cleanly, the way you open a sheep, and it died. And then it opened. The wound became a mouth, and the mouth drew breath, and out of it slid Vey again, smaller, wet, and new, and lay down on the grass beside its own body and waited.

We killed it seven times that night. Each time we killed it, it began again out of the death, out of the cut, out of the place where the knife came out. By the fourth time we were eating as we killed, fast, so that what we had cut would be swallowed before it could begin. By the sixth the women were holding the openings shut with their hands while the men cut, and the openings pushed at their palms like a child's head pushing. The meat was hot and sweet and tasted of iron and new milk, and those who ate it felt their own bodies clench and loosen and clench in the belly, all of them, men and grandmothers, a pain like a door being tried from the other side.

The seventh time it was very small. The size of a hand. A woman named Harrow Bede, who had lost nine in the Lack and buried every one in the red clay with her own fingers, took it up in her palm and looked at it for a long while. Then she put the whole of it in her mouth and swallowed, and held her jaw shut with both hands until it stopped moving, and then she sat down in the clay and laughed until she was sick.

The families who ate the caul wore it out of the hill on their faces like veils, wet and red in the torchlight, and it did not come off in the morning. Behind us, on the empty hilltop, a door stood in a frame with no house around it, open a crack. Nobody had brought it there.

VI. THE CANYONS

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Nothing.

They ate it without speaking, and the telling of it in Oathen is also without speaking, so this is set down by an outsider who was told it with hands.

Tolm the Witness lay at the bottom of the deepest canyon with its ear to the stone. It was long, and bare, and listening. It was always listening; everything said in front of it was so, and the people of the canyons had learned over ten thousand years to say little near it and to mean all of it. In the Lack they had come to its ear and said we are hungry, and it was so; they had said we will die, and that was so; and they had stopped coming.

On the night, the whole people came down the canyon walls on ropes in silence, carrying their children with leather straps over their mouths. They spread out along its length in silence. They raised the knives in silence. The only sound was the knives. The god heard the knives, and that was so.

They ate. Imagine a hundred thousand people chewing in a canyon that repeats everything. The echo of the eating went up the walls and came down again and went up again for the whole night, a wet enormous patience, and the god lay with its ear to the rock and heard it, and heard it, and heard it.

A boy, partway through, stopped chewing. He looked up at his mother with his mouth full and his eyes wide, and drew a breath to say something. She put her hand over his mouth. She did not take it away until dawn. When she did, the boy had chewed through the side of his own cheek trying to keep from speaking, and she held a strip of the god's tongue against the wound until it closed. The families who ate the tongue sat in a circle, cutting it into slivers no bigger than a fingernail, and laid each sliver on their own tongues, and closed their mouths, and let it dissolve. They say it was the only thing any of them ever tasted that had no taste at all.

Nobody spoke for a year afterward. The first word said aloud in the canyons after the Supper was a merchant's "I swear," three springs on, and you know what happened to his hands.

VII. HALLOWBOARD

We are the people who said no. Teach it so. Our children learn it before their own names.

Orrum the Host lay on the table at Hallowboard, on the bare hill at the middle of the world, the eight-sided stone table that is always clean. It lay as the others lay, quiet, warm, its great stooped body folded along the board, and the board was the right size for it, as if it had been cut to measure. It smelled of bread. All of it. The whole hill smelled of bread fresh from the oven, and of woodsmoke and of the inside of a kitchen on a winter evening when everyone you love is home.

We stood around it and we did not eat. We stood in the cold with our children on our shoulders, skin over bone, and the

god lay on its table and waited, and we said, as we say now, No, thank you. And again, No, thank you. And again. Nine in ten of us died where they stood that winter, or on the walk home, or in their houses with the smell of bread still in their noses. We did not eat. Remember it. We are the only clean people in the world.

Remember also, because the elders do not forbid it, how long the walk to Hallowboard was. The heartland is wide, and we were weak, and the snow lay deep on the old roads. Remember that when the first of us came over the last ridge, the fires on the far horizons, where the other peoples were, had already burned down to red. Remember that the god on the table opened its eyes when it heard us, and looked at us, and its look was the look of someone who has waited a very long time for guests and has just heard the door.

Remember that it turned its great head, once, and looked at the eighth side of the table, where none of us stood, where the snow had not settled, where nothing was. Remember that it

looked there for a long while. Remember that when it looked back at us, it was afraid.

Then it got up. It got up off the board, slow and stooping, the way an old man gets up from a chair. It stood over us in the dark, warm, enormous, smelling of supper. And it began to lay the table.

No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.

USING THE PROLOGUE

Read any one of these vignettes aloud at the start of a campaign set in that land; read all seven if the campaign will travel. Each contains a detail the land's own chapter treats as history and a detail it treats as heresy. The Fen boy who ran is Grandfather Peat. The Hallowboard telling contains a lateness the Unfed elders have never thought hard about. Players who notice the empty bank in the fen and the empty eighth side at Hallowboard have noticed something that is noticed, eventually, by everyone who goes too far.

▼ WHY "THE LONG GRACE"

On every table on the continent, before the first mouthful, someone says the words: *Lack keep away*. It is the shortest grace in the world and the only one every people shares. It is said quickly, with the eyes down, the way you touch a doorframe for luck. It is the pause between sitting down and eating.

The poets of the Rim Road began calling the age itself by that name around the third century, half in mockery: six peoples had sat down to the biggest meal in history, and somehow they had not yet finished saying grace over it. The joke was that the meal was eaten in a night, and the bill had not come. Priests took the phrase up a century later without the joke. To them it meant what it sounds like it means: that the six hundred and forty-one years since the Gorging

are not an age at all but a held breath, a little ceremonial pause, and that the real eating has not yet begun.

Scholars of the Cutwrights' College use the term precisely. The Long Grace, in their ledgers, is the span between the swallowing of the Providers and the completion of their Regrowth: a finite period, with a measurable rate, approaching its end. Every land's chronicle in the last decade has started using the phrase in the past tense by accident. "In the Long Grace, my grandmother kept bees." Nobody corrects it. Everyone hears it.

In common speech, "the Grace is ending" is what you say when the milk turns, when the dog will not come in, when the neighbor's daughter starts bailing at the wrong hour. It is said lightly. It is meant the other way.

▼ THE PROVIDERS

They were not distant. That is the first thing every child is told and the last thing any adult understands. The gods of the old world did not live on mountaintops or behind the sky. Each lived bodily among one people, immense and present, the way a mountain is present: you could walk to it, you could put your hand on it, you could smell it on the wind on a warm day. It had a temperature. It shed. It had moods you could read the way farmers read cloud.

There were eight. Seven are named in every carving older than the Gorging, standing or lying in a ring, facing inward, around

something that is never shown. The eighth place in the ring is always there, and always empty, because the figure in it has been cut away.

LIVING BESIDE A GOD

A Provider did not rule in any sense a magistrate would recognize. It did not make laws or demand prayers. It simply did what it was, enormously, and the people who lived in its shadow arranged their lives around the fact. Fen-folk did not have to bury their dead, because Ossel closed them, and what Ossel closed went quietly into the peat and was clean in a season. Plains-folk did not have to fear a

bad harvest, because Ummer walked the fields. Canyon-folk did not need courts, because a thing said in Tolm's hearing was so, and liars learned to keep away from its ear.

The cost was intimacy. You lived with a god the way you live with weather in a small house. You heard it at night. You smelled it in your bread. Children were sent to sit in its shade and came home with its dust on their clothes. Sweethearts met in its lee. People died against its flank in old age, deliberately, the way an old dog crawls under the stove. Every people had words for the god's breathing, the god's stillness, the god turning over in the night. Every people believed, without needing to say so, that the god knew each of them by name.

Worship, in the old world, was mostly feeding. Every people brought their Provider a portion of what the Provider had given them: the first sheaf, the first catch, the first cry of a newborn, the first word of a child. It was called *the giving back*, and in Table-speech the verb for it is the same as the verb for eating. The gods ate what they were given, slowly, over days. Nobody remembers them ever asking for more. Nobody remembers them ever asking for anything at all.

OSSEL, THE CLOSING HAND

God of death and endings. It lay in the northern fens for as long as anyone remembered, long and grey and still as a fallen ash, with hands that moved when nothing else did. Its iconography is two open hands, palms up, and in later carvings a single hand drawing a lid down over an eye. Fen-folk wore a grey thumbprint on the brow at funerals and pressed their own thumbs to the eyelids of the dead in imitation of it. When someone died, the family carried them to the god on a reed hurdle and laid them by a hand, and the hand closed their eyes and their mouth and folded their arms, and then the body was sunk in clean black water and was gone in a season, bones and all, leaving the water sweet. People who lived near Ossel were calm about everything. They knew how things went. An old fen saying, from before: *The Hand comes for the candle when the candle is done*. Nobody now alive in Sallowreach can say it without weeping.

UMMER, THE LADEN

God of harvest and plenty. It walked, unlike most of the others: a vast, slow, broad-backed shape like a laden haywain made of earth and bark and pelt, ambling across the southern plains with its head down, and the fields bowed toward it as it passed and rose up heavier behind it. Its iconography is a full belly with a sheaf rising out of it, and a mouth, always a mouth, smiling. Plains-folk followed its track with seed-bags and sowed in its footprints, which never failed. They thanked it by name at every meal, as they still thank the fields, and the first loaf of every baking was set on the doorstep for it, and in the morning the loaf was gone and the

doorstep was warm. It was the most loved of the gods and the most taken for granted. Children rode on it.

DROMM, THE FATHOM

God of the deep sea, of pressure, of what is kept under. Nobody living saw more than its back, a long grey reef far out past the shelf that broke the surface on the stillest days and breathed. Its iconography is a closed circle with lines pressing in from every side, and the oldest coastal carvings show it as a hand holding something down beneath the waves. The coast gave it the first fish of every boat and the bodies of the drowned, rowed out with lanterns and let down on weighted ropes. In return the sea was full and the storms broke on its back before they reached the shore. Divers who went deep came up with nosebleeds and a feeling of being enormously, patiently watched. The old coast-folk said Dromm kept the sea's secrets for it, everything that had ever sunk, and would never give a single one of them up.

ISS, THE LIDDED

God of sleep. It lay curled in the high valley above old Ludmere with its lids shut, and no one in recorded history ever saw its eyes open. Its iconography is a closed eye, two curved lines, sometimes with a row of small figures lying asleep along the lower lid. Worship in Ludmere was dreaming; oracles slept against the god's flank and woke with prophecy, and families brought their dreams to the temple-keepers each morning to be written down and offered. Sleep was holy and easy; the Ludmere bed was a famous luxury, exported up and down the old roads. People who lived near Iss were the best-rested and most reasonable people in the world. It is a small horror the Vigil does not dwell on that its ancestors were famous for their naps.

VEY, THE OPENING

God of birth and beginnings, of doors and first breaths. The smallest Provider, the size of a heifer, soft and red and warm and always, somehow, new. It moved from house to house in the highlands when a birth was near and lay across the threshold. Its iconography is a doorway with something small just stepping through, and in the oldest stones a round opening ringed by petals or teeth. Highland women gave birth with one hand on the god. They gave it the caul, the cord, and the first breath of each child, which the midwife caught in her cupped hands and blew into Vey's nearest opening. Nothing was ever born wrong in the old highlands. Nothing was born too early. Doors stayed shut until they were opened, and when they were opened the god was usually standing on the other side.

TOLM, THE WITNESS

God of oaths and true speech. It lay along the floor of the deepest canyon in the east with one ear pressed to the stone, long and bare

and grey-pink, listening. What it heard was so. Its iconography is an ear, sometimes an ear inside an open mouth, and in the canyon carvings a long figure with a finger to its own lips. Canyon-folk did not worship it so much as consult it: contracts were spoken into its ear, marriages were said there, and the guilty were brought to say their innocence in its hearing and see what happened. Parents warned children not to say *I could die* near the canyon floor. There was very little crime and almost no poetry. Visitors found the canyon peoples' honesty so frightening that the word for an Oathener in two other dialects still means *someone you cannot sit near*.

ORRUM, THE HOST

God of the hearth, of welcome, of the shared table. It lived in the rich heartland at the middle of the Table, very tall, stooping under doorways, warm, and it went from house to house. When it came to a door the hearth inside lit itself and the table was laid. Its iconography is a table with a single figure bent over it, laying it, and on the oldest stones an open hand holding out a bowl. The heartland was the richest country in the world because it was the most generous: every traveler was fed, every stranger seated, every quarrel settled over bread. Orrum was the god of the other seven too, in a way. The great carvings show all eight facing inward around a table, and the figure that pulls out the chairs is always Orrum.

THE EIGHTH

There is an eighth place in every carving older than the Gorging. In the ring of figures around the table, between the Host and the Closing Hand, there is a gap exactly the width of one of the others. Sometimes it is a smooth recess. Sometimes the stone is gouged and pitted. Sometimes the chisel marks are fine and tidy and sometimes

they are frantic, a mess of strokes cut over strokes, as if whoever did it could not stop. In Brinehollow the stone was hacked with a boathook. In the Vigil it was ground out with a rasp so patiently that the recess shines. Analysis by the Cutwrights' College in 588 A.G. established that the removals were done by different tools, in different centuries, some of them before the Gorging and some of them after.

Nobody knows its name. Nobody knows its people. Nobody knows who ate it, or whether anyone did. No land claims it, and every land has, at some point in its history, made it a crime to ask. The question is called, on the Rim Road, *counting the chairs*. It is considered very bad luck.

A few things can still be noticed by those who look closely. In the carvings, the seven named figures are always shown facing inward toward the table, except that in perhaps one carving in ten, one or two of them have their heads very slightly turned toward the gap. On the oldest temple floors, in the places where worshipers would have stood, the stone in front of the eighth recess is unworn. In Table-speech there are two words for *guest*, and the older one has no plural, and no dictionary on the Table will print it.

THE EIGHTH AT YOUR TABLE

The Eighth is the great unanswered question of the setting, and its answer lives in the Secrets chapter, which only the GM should read. Until then, treat it the way the people of the Table do: as a gap. Put chisel marks in every old ruin. Give every carving an empty place. Let an innkeeper refuse to say why there is always one more chair than guests at the long table in his common room. Never explain. A player who starts counting chairs should find that the count never closes, and that nobody wants them to finish.

▼ THE LONG LACK

Nobody knows whether the Lack was a punishment, an accident, or a plan. That is the oldest wound in the world.

— PREFACE TO THE COLLEGE'S CONCORDANCE OF THE NINE YEARS

For nine years, nothing began. That is the shortest true account. What follows is a longer one, assembled from the chronicles of all seven peoples, from the tally-sticks of granaries, from bone-pits, and from a great many songs that are no longer sung in company.

THE FIRST YEAR: THE THIN HARVEST

It began in Grace, with seed. Across every land at once, the spring sowing did not come up. Not poorly: not at all. Farmers dug up their furrows in the second month and found the seed exactly where they had put it, swollen, soft, and rotting, with no shoot and no

root. The second sowing did the same. The Providers were consulted and gave no answer, but that was not yet alarming; the Providers had never given answers. Ummer walked the fields as always and the fields did not bow. People said it was a bad year. The granaries were full from the year before. Nobody went hungry that winter, and the Tablenight feasts, which were then a celebration of the longest night, were held as usual.

THE SECOND YEAR: THE EMPTY NETS

The nets came up empty along the whole western coast in the first week of Plenty and did not fill again. Hens stopped laying. Cows dried. Orchards flowered and the flowers fell and nothing set. The rationing began in the towns, and with it the first bread riots, and the first appearance of the phrase that would become the whole world's grace: *Lack keep away*, muttered over thinned porridge. In the north, Ossel's hands were seen to move restlessly at night. In the heartland, Orrum went from house to house as always, and the hearths lit, and the tables were laid, and there was less and less to put on them.

THE THIRD YEAR: THE BARREN STALLS

Livestock went barren. No calf was dropped on the whole Table that year, and no lamb, and no foal. Then the herds began to be eaten, against every law, because a cow that will not calve is only meat. The old breeds died out that winter, all of them, in a single season of slaughter. The Providers grew visibly thinner. Plains-folk measured Ummer's flank against a barn wall and marked it in chalk, and marked it again each month, and the marks moved inward. The great temples began demanding larger gifts, and got them, and the gods ate them slowly as always and grew no fatter.

THE FOURTH YEAR: THE ASH BREAD

The flour went wrong. Grain that had been stored sound for years began to turn in the bins, and bread baked from it came out of the oven as grey ash in the shape of a loaf, which fell to dust when touched. Nobody has ever explained this. Bakers were hanged for it in three lands. Then the women stopped conceiving. It was noticed first in the highlands, where Vey lay across thresholds and no labor came; then everywhere. The last child born in the Lack is recorded in the Cradlewrack Tally as a girl delivered at Kest in the fourth Carving, who died on her third day. After her there were none for five years. The Providers stopped speaking that winter: not that they had ever spoken much, but the sounds stopped, the breathing grew shallow, the moods ceased to be readable. They lay still and grew thin.

THE FIFTH YEAR: THE LEATHER WINTER

The fifth year was when people began to eat the things that are not food. Harness. Shoe leather. Boiled glue. Bark, then the inner bark, then the wood. Grass soup. Clay with a little salt. Lamp oil. In the cities, the rat-catchers became rich and then were eaten by the people they had sold to. The old and the very young began to die in

numbers that overwhelmed every rite; in Sallowreach, Ossel's hands lay still and the dead piled at its side unclosed, and the fen-folk learned for the first time what a corpse does when no god tends it. In the Fatlands, people followed Ummer across the bare fields on their knees, licking its footprints. Ummer did not stop. It walked more slowly than anyone had ever seen it walk.

THE SIXTH YEAR: THE KITCHEN YEAR

This is the year the songs leave out.

It began with the dead. A family would lose a grandmother in the night, and in the morning the grandmother would not be carried out. The pot would be put on. There are chronicles from all seven peoples that say the same thing in the same flat way: *in the sixth year the dead were kept at home*. The first laws against it were passed in every land, and none of them were enforced, because the magistrates had grandmothers too.

Then it went further. The College has assembled, from coroners' rolls and the confessions of the old taken down in the first decades after the Gorging, a picture it publishes only in cipher. Households drew lots. Children were sent to stay with cousins and the cousins sent theirs back, so that no one would have to eat their own. The phrase for this, still known in Fatlands dialect as a curse, is *trading tables*. In the Oathen canyons, where a word spoken could not be unsaid, families made solemn promises to one another that they would not, and then had to watch the promises take their hands off. In Brinehollow a man rowed his dead wife out to the deep place to give her to Dromm, as was proper, and could not let go of her, and came back with her, and the town watched him carry her up the shingle and did not say a word, and that night every chimney on the street smoked.

The smell of that year, survivors said, was the smell of a cooking-pot in a house where nothing has been cooked in months: so sudden and so rich that it brought the neighbors to the door. They would stand outside in the snow and not knock. They would just stand there, breathing it.

I will tell it once, and then I will have told it. We had Hessa three days after. Mother said it was what Hessa would have wanted and then she went out to the yard and was sick on the snow and came back in and stirred the pot. The fat came up yellow on the top. I remember the color. I remember that it smelled like supper and that I hated it for that more than anything. I remember that father said the grace first, Lack keep away, the way you say it over company, because she was company now. I ate. Everyone ate. We were alive in the spring. I have had children since, and they have had children, and I have never once let any of them see me eat.

THE SEVENTH YEAR: THE BONE DOLE

Governments, such as they were, took over the dying. In every land, the dead were collected by the authorities and rendered in public kitchens, and the meat was given out by ration, and nobody asked whose it was. It was, the chronicles say, the most orderly year of the Lack. The first lacks were cut that winter: discs of salt-cured bone, stamped, each one good for a day's ration at the public kitchen. The bone was the bone of the dead. The coin has been made from other bone since, officially. Its value has never changed: one day's bread. People stopped fighting over food in the seventh year, because there was a system, and a queue, and a coin, and that is the year the old world truly ended.

The Providers lay down. All of them, everywhere, within days of one another. Ummer stopped walking at last in the middle of a bare field and folded its legs. Orrum, in the heartland, stopped going from house to house and sat on the bare hill at Hallowboard beside the eight-sided table, with its head bowed, as if waiting for someone to arrive.

THE EIGHTH YEAR: THE ELDEST WALK

In the spring of the eighth year, the priests of all seven peoples met at Hallowboard. It was the only time in history all seven sat together, and the only record of the meeting is a list of resolutions carved into the hill's foot-stone, worn almost smooth. They had come to read the carvings on the table's eight sides, which were older than any of them, and they found, or believed they found, a demand. The carvings showed, beneath the ring of figures, a line of smaller figures walking toward the table with their arms at their sides. The priests read it as a tithe: the first of every house. The gods had given each house its firstborn; the gods were starving; the gods wanted the first back.

By common counsel of all seven peoples, it was done. In the last month of Plenty, in the eighth year of the Lack, the firstborn adult of every hearth on the Table walked to the feet of their people's god.

They walked, mostly, of their own will. That is the part every chronicle insists on. They were sons and daughters of twenty, of forty, of sixty; they were the heirs of farms and shops and fishing boats; they kissed their younger siblings and handed over their tools and walked out of their villages in long lines, singing, with the whole village walking behind them to the boundary stone and stopping there. They walked for days. They were very thin. Many died on the road. The rest arrived.

The rite was the same everywhere because the priests had agreed it. At the god's feet, each firstborn knelt, and a priest opened their

throat with a bronze knife, and laid them down against the god, as close as could be got. In the fens they were laid in rows between Ossel's open hands. In the plains they were laid along Ummer's folded legs until it was hidden to the knees. At Longslab they were rowed out to the deep place and let down on weighted ropes in their thousands. In the canyons each one whispered a vow into Tolm's ear before the knife: *I give myself, so that they may eat*, and that was so, or should have been. In the red hills they were laid across thresholds. At Ludmere they were laid along the sleeping flank like children put to bed. At Hallowboard, the heartland's firstborn were laid on the stone table, which was big enough for all of them, in a heap.

The count was never made. The College's best estimate is somewhere above sixty thousand.

Nothing happened.

The gods did not take them. The gods did not stir. Ossel's hands did not close a single pair of eyes; the dead lay in the fen staring upward until the birds that were left found them. Ummer did not eat. Tolm, which heard every vow, did not make one of them so. The bodies lay where they had been laid, through the end of Plenty and into Carving, against the flanks of gods who did not move, and nothing rose from the fields, and nothing came to the nets, and no woman quickened.

And in Carving, when it was clear, the people who had walked their eldest to the gods' feet came back for them with sacks, at night, and did not look one another in the face, and carried them home.

THE ELDEST WALK IN PLAY

The Eldest Walk is the act no land discusses and every land remembers. It is why the Gorging happened. Before the Walk, the peoples of the Table believed the gods were starving with them and could be fed. After it, they knew that their gods would take nothing, give nothing, and save no one. Their most precious offering had been laid at the feet of every Provider in the world and been left to rot. The Gorging was not an act of hunger alone. It was an act of fury. Every land has a quiet name for it (the Tithe, the Long Line, the Giving of the First) and every land has, somewhere in its oldest families, a story of the eldest who did not go, or who went and came back. In the present day the Purgation preaches a second Walk, and the phrase *to walk the eldest* means, in every dialect, to make a sacrifice you know will be wasted.

THE NINTH YEAR: THE TURNING

The last winter was the quietest. There was nothing left to fight over. The dead were not collected anymore, because the collectors were dead. In every land the survivors sat in their houses in the dark and looked at their gods out of the windows, and the gods lay where

they had lain down, enormous, gaunt, still, with the bones of the eldest at their feet.

Nobody knows who said it first. Every people claims a different first speaker, and in every account the first speaker is a mother. What she said, in every version, comes to the same thing: *They have*

something left on them, and we have nothing. They would not eat what we gave. Let us see if they will be eaten.

The knives were already ground. People had been grinding knives for nine years, out of habit, for want of anything else to do with their hands.

▼ THE GORGING

Whether it happened on one night or across a season is disputed. The stories call it the Night of Seven Tables, and Tablenight is kept on the longest night of Lack in every land, but the chronicles do not agree. Brinehollow's dragging took three days and its god four more to die. Sallowreach ate last of all and slowest, and some fen accounts stretch its meal over a fortnight. Oathen's Silent Supper, because no one spoke of it, has no recorded date at all. The Cutwrights' College, which has tried to reconcile them for four centuries, settled in 501 A.G. on the formula *the ninth winter, within a single Plate*, meaning one cycle of the moon, and has quietly lost every argument about it since.

What is agreed is this. In every land, the people went to their god with knives, and their god did not fight. The Providers did not flee, did not cry out, did not strike, did not so much as turn over. They were enormous; a twitch of Ummer's flank would have crushed a village; a breath from Dromm drowned whole fleets in the old days. They held still. It is recorded everywhere and explained nowhere, and every argument in the world, sooner or later, becomes an argument about why.

Each god was butchered and shared out, and how it was shared became the shape of every society since. The families nearest, strongest, quickest, or most ruthless took the choicest parts: the hands, the gut, the lungs, the eyes, the caul, the tongue. Those behind them took the meat. Those behind them took what fell.

Those at the very back licked the bones. Nobody planned it. Nobody needed to.

The famine ended the next morning.

Every land records this the same way, with the same awe. People woke on the morning after their meal to a green haze on the furrows. Hens laid. By midday the nets were full. Within the week crops stood shoulder high in fields that had been sown nine years earlier with seed that had rotted in the ground. Women quickened that month, all of them, all at once, the old and the very young and some who had long been past it. Cattle that had been barren for six years dropped calves within the season, which should not be possible. Trees that had been cut for firewood put up new shoots from the stumps overnight. The world, which had not begun anything for nine years, began everything at once.

That speed should have frightened people more than it did. Here and there it did. In the Fatlands, where the wheat stood shoulder high in seven days, an old woman named Tallis Brome is recorded as having walked out into the new field on the eighth morning, broken an ear, chewed it, and said to her grandson: *This was not grown. This was poured.* Nobody listened. Everyone was eating.

Only in the Fast did the Lack not lift. The heartland's people, who had not eaten their god, woke to the same bare soil, the same empty coops, the same rotten seed, and looked out over the Rim at their neighbors' green fields with an emotion that has shaped their entire history and that they have never once named correctly.

▼ THE THREE DOCTRINES

Every argument in the world eventually becomes an argument about why the gods held still. There are three answers, each with its temples, its martyrs and its hecklers, and most people on the Table believe a little of each depending on how the harvest went.

THE THEFT

We murdered them. The Regrowth is justice, and we deserve it. The oldest and most common belief, held by the majority in Sallowreach and Oathen and by most of the poor everywhere. Its priests are called Confessors, and its rites are rites of penance: fasting on the anniversaries of the Meal, self-scourging in the Fatlands, the reading-aloud of ancestral guilt in Brinehollow. The Theft explains the

Providers' stillness as shock, or contempt, or the paralysis of the betrayed. It offers no hope and asks for none. Its comfort is that the world makes sense.

You ask why it did not fight. I will tell you why a mother does not fight when her son comes for her with a knife. She is too surprised. She cannot believe it. She stands in her own kitchen with her hands open and looks at him, and she is still looking at him when she goes down. That is how they lay. That is how they looked at us. And now they are coming back up through us, through the gut and the lung and the eye, and you call it a curse? It is a bill. It is the only honest thing that has happened

to this family in six hundred years. Pay it. Bow your head and pay it.

— CONFESSOR ABEL RENNICK, SERMON AT THE WEEPING POST, 627 A.G.

THE GIFT

They offered themselves out of love. The Regrowth is a tragedy neither side wanted. The gentlest doctrine and the most popular among the comfortable: Gut-lines families in the Fatlands, Vigil merchants, the Rim Road's innkeepers. Its priests are called Thankers and its central rite is the Thanksgiving Meal, at which the worshipers eat in silence and then say, together, the names of all seven eaten gods. The Gift reads the Providers' stillness as consent and their Regrowth as an unwilling side effect, a grief shared by eater and eaten. It holds that the gods suffer in the blood as their hosts do, and that kindness to the godsigned eases the god. Its critics call it the doctrine of people who have never been hungry.

— THANKER MAUDLIN ASHE, CHILDREN'S HOMILY, LAMPWICK HALT, 640 A.G.

THE BAIT

They wanted to be eaten. The Lack was theirs. This is how gods breed: starve a people, be swallowed, and grow back through ten thousand bodies instead of one. The doctrine first appears in the record around 330 A.G., in a pamphlet nailed to a Rim Road toll-house, and has been illegal in four lands (Sallowreach, the Fatlands, the Vigil and Oathen) for most of the time since. It is gaining ground in all seven, because it is the only doctrine that explains the speed of the Week of Rising and the only one that matches the arithmetic of the Regrowth. Its preachers have no order and no title. They are called *Baiters* by their enemies and nothing at all by themselves. Some of them are terrified; some, like the Second

Children, think of it this way. Your grandmother is very old and there is no bread. She takes her portion and puts it on your plate when she thinks you are not looking. She says she is not hungry. That is what they did, all of them, on that night: they lay down and they put themselves on our plates and said, eat, we are not hungry. And now they are in us, and they are hurting, and we are hurting, because love that big does not fit inside a body. It was not supposed to come back. It is not their fault. It is not ours. Be gentle with the ones whose eyes do not close. Be gentle with the ones who must be gagged. They are carrying more of the gift than you.

Helping of the Fatlands, are joyous; all of them agree that the Gorging was not the end of the gods but their sowing.

Why did it not fight? Because a seed does not fight the ground. Look at your hands. Look at the joints on the Hand-line Regent's fingers, the eyes on the Vigil's lords, the cord on the Uncut, the fat on the Board. Did your great-great-grandmother eat a god, or did a god get into your great-great-grandmother? Nine years without a single child born, and then a whole world of children in one spring, every one of them with the god in the blood. You think that was mercy? It was planting. You are a furrow, friend. We all are. And the harvest is due.

— ANONYMOUS BAITER, PREACHING ON THE RIM ROAD AT SALTICK CROSS
SHORTLY BEFORE BEING DROWNED BY A CROWD, 638 A.G.

DOCTRINES AT THE TABLE

Doctrine is a fine way to start fights between player characters who otherwise agree on everything. Ask each player, at character creation, which of the three their character believes and which their parents believed. The doctrines are not settled by the game; the Secrets chapter offers a default truth and three alternatives built on each doctrine, and the GM may choose. Until then, every sermon is equally true, and equally useless.

▼ THE REGROWTH

The return of an eaten god is called the Regrowth, and its marks on a person are called godsign. It moves through four stages, in a person, a family, or an entire country: the Taste, the Appetite, the Course, and the Seating. Each land's Regrowth obeys its own rules and is detailed in that land's chapter. What is shared is the shape, and the speed.

The Taste is small wrongnesses: dreams, cravings, a tell in the body that a lover notices first. The Appetite is compulsion; the body

begins wanting what the god wants and will stop at nothing for it. The Course is flesh changing; the person becomes visibly, physically something else, grey-handed or loamy or lidless or veiled. The Seating is the god, in some real portion, present again, wearing a person or a place. Between the Course and the Seating there is a last threshold the College calls *the Brink*, when the person is still a person only by courtesy.

LAND	THE TASTE	THE APPETITE	THE COURSE	THE SEATING
Sallowreach	Dread of open things	Compulsive closing	Grey hands, extra joints; touch finishes	A Hush
Fatlands	Hunger that wakes you	Eating without choosing	Swelling, rooting, loamy skin	A living hill
Brinehollow	Salt at waking	The pull westward	Grey skin, deep eyes, no breath	The Tenant takes the house
The Vigil	Heavy lids, spreading yawns	Blinks	The lids are gone	A sleeper begins to move
Cradlewrack	About to begin	False labor	True bearing	The land itself in labor
Oathen	Your words, echoed	The urge to swear	Plain speech binds	A Sayer

No land has reached a full Seating of its god. Three are close. And every Regrowth is speeding up: signs that took generations now take years; the Hushes spread, the pangs shorten, the beds fill, the sea drops. The College's figures show that every land's curve bent

upward at nearly the same time, in the decade after 600 A.G., which is impossible if the seven Regrowths are separate things. Each government is hiding its own numbers. The College holds all of them.

▼ BLOOD AND CLASS: THE CUTS

Who your ancestors were matters less than what part they ate. The families who took the choicest portions of a god carry the strongest godsign, and in every land they became the nobility, because in the first generations godsign looked like blessing. A Hand-line touch that could close a wound, a Gut-line appetite that never sickened, an Eye-line who could see in the dark: these were gifts, and their bearers

were raised up. By the time the gifts curdled, the Cuts owned everything.

These bloodlines are called **Cuts**, and a person's Cut is the measure of god in their blood, from 0 to 5. The College grades them as follows, and its grades are used in law in every land.

CUT	NAME	WHO
0	Blank	No godsign. Rare births; the Unfed of the Fast
1	Scrapling	Descended from those who licked the bones
2	Common	Those who ate the meat; most people alive
3	Prime	Old gentry; the hungry middle
4–5	High	Nobility of the choice Cut; the furthest along

Each land prizes a different Cut: the Hand-lines of Sallowreach, the Gut-lines of the Fatlands, the Lung-lines of Brinehollow, the Eye-lines of the Vigil, the Caul-lines of Cradlewrack, the Tongue-lines of Oathen. Marriage between Cuts is arranged with ledgers. A high-Cut house that marries down dilutes its blood and its claim; a Scrapling who marries up buys rank and a faster death. In every

land, the rulers are the most monstrous people in it, and the Regrowth advances fastest in palaces.

SCRAPLINGS

The poor descend from those who got the scraps and licked the bones: the stragglers at the back of the crowd, the too-weak, the too-

slow, the ones who arrived after the good parts were gone. They are called **Scraplings**, and they are the least changed people alive. A Scrapling of Sallowreach still cannot die, a Scrapling of the Vigil still cannot sleep, because the Rule of each land touches everyone in it; but their Regrowth crawls where a noble's gallops. Scraplings do the work of the Table: they haul, stitch, bail, nudge and render. They have always been told that their thin blood is the mark of their ancestors' weakness. They are only now, in the last generation, beginning to understand that it is the reason they may outlive their masters, and some of them are beginning to say so out loud.

BLANKS

Rarely, a child is born with no godsign at all. A Fatlands Blank feels no hunger. An Oathen Blank can lie. A Vigil Blank could sleep, if anyone let it. No one knows why they happen; the College's ledgers show no pattern of parentage, and Blanks have been born to High Cuts and to Scraplings alike. They are hunted in every land: as saints, as specimens, or as spare parts.

▼ THE SHAPE OF THE TABLE

People call the known world the Table. It is one continent, roughly round, about nine hundred miles across, and its geography is a ring around a hole. Beyond its edges there is sea to the west and wasteland, mountain and salt on the other sides, and nobody who has gone looking for anything beyond has come back with anything worth the trip.

- ◆ **The Fast** lies at the center: the rich old heartland, the best farmland on the Table, now almost empty, where the uneaten god still walks. It is always early Carving there.
- ◆ **Sallowreach** to the north: grey fen and fog, where nothing dies.
- ◆ **The Vigil** to the northeast: a lit plateau city that has not slept in three centuries.
- ◆ **Oathen** to the east: dry red canyons where words break bones.
- ◆ **The Fatlands** to the south: warm, wet plains of meat.
- ◆ **Brinchollow** to the west: a coast the sea is abandoning.
- ◆ **Cradlewrack** to the northwest: red clay highlands in labor.

Nobody crosses the middle. The old roads that once ran from every land to the heartland are still there, still beautifully kept by no one, and they are used by Crumb-Runners, Reckoners, poachers, pilgrims and fools. Everyone else goes around.

THE RIM ROAD

The Rim Road is a ring of highway, some two thousand four hundred miles long, that runs around the border of the Fast, touching every land in turn. It was built in the Thin Years after the Gorging on the foundations of the old heartland ring-roads, by

THE BLANK TRADE

The trade is old, quiet, and enormously profitable. Blank blood, transfused, is believed to slow the Regrowth for a season. Blank organs, sewn into a noble body by a skilled Seamer or a Fatlands surgeon, are believed to slow it for years. Blank marrow is boiled into a jelly sold in the Vigil as a sleep-cure and in Cradlewrack as a contraceptive. None of it works, or none of it works for long, and the price only rises. A Blank kidney sells on the Rim for about 3,000 lacks; a Blank heart, delivered beating in brine, for a sum the buyers do not write down.

Because the Unfed of the Fast are, in effect, a whole nation of Blanks, the trade's main source is the heartland. Poachers cross the Fast's border by night with nets and sedatives. Fatlanders like Kale Dragoman feed their catch generously on the road home, so the meat arrives in condition. Dr. Mercy Thrane of the Fast has traced vanished patients to surgeries in four countries. The ultimate buyers are, almost always, people of High Cut, and an increasing number of the largest purchases are made through intermediaries who never give a name.

caravaneers who wanted to carry the Fatlands' miraculous grain to every market on the Table without ever setting foot in the empty middle. A wagon caravan takes about a hundred days to make the full circuit; a fast rider changing horses at every post can do it in thirty.

The road is paved for most of its length in great fitted slabs of grey Oathen stone, cambered for drainage, with a ditch on the outer side and, on the inner side, facing the Fast, a low wall about knee-high. The wall is called the Hem. It does nothing; anyone can step over it. Nobody does. Every mile is marked by a milestone with the distance carved in both directions to the Company's headquarters, and every milestone bears the Company's mark, a wheel with seven spokes.

Every land's politics is shaped by needing something from a neighbor it finds obscene, and all of that need moves along the Rim. Fatlands meat goes everywhere. Oathen sells contracts and gold bits. The Vigil buys oil and brine and sells mirrors and rouse. Sallowreach exports wire, lacquer, embalming spirits and, illegally, Closings. Brinchollow sells salvage from the Uncovered. Cradlewrack exports soldiers, the Foundling Companies hiring out as caravan guards. The Fast sells nothing, and buys every mouthful it eats.

TOLLS

The Rim Road Company owns the road, every inn and post on it, and every toll. Tolls are charged at every waystation, posted in Table-speech on a bone slate by the gate, and paid in lacks or Company platters. A standard schedule:

TOLL	CHARGED ON	RATE
Foot	Each traveler on foot	1 crumb a post
Wheel	Each wheel of a cart or wagon	2 crumbs a post
Head	Each animal, or anything walked like one	1 crumb a post
Weight	Cargo, by the hundredweight	1 lack a post
Breath	Any traveler showing godsign at the Course	5 lacks a post
Hush	Corpses, by the body	1 lack a post

The Breath Toll was introduced in 604 A.G. after a Course-stage Gut-line rooted himself in the middle of the road near the Chute and had to be dug around. The Hush Toll is so called because it is charged on the dead, who in every land but one are silent.

RIM LAW

The Company's charter, sworn in Oathen in 71 A.G., grants it jurisdiction over the road surface and a bowshot either side. Within that strip, no land's law runs; Company law runs instead, and Company law has three articles, recited at every post at dawn: *Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.* Murder on the road is punished by the Company's wardens with a rope at the nearest post. Theft of Company cargo is punished by being made cargo. Refusing the grace at a Company table, the universal insult, is punished with a fine of one lack and a night outside the gate.

The Rim's neutrality is its whole value. A Sallowreach Closer and a Fast Reckoner can share an inn table on the Rim, and each knows that if the other draws a blade the wardens will hang them before the blood is dry. They cannot share it anywhere else on earth.

WAYSTATIONS OF THE RIM

The Company keeps a post every twenty miles: a toll gate, a stable, a well and a bone-slate board of news. Every hundred miles or so there is a waystation proper, a walled inn-town with a market, a smithy, a wardens' barracks and the Company's factor. Clockwise from the north, the best known are these.

Fogmouth. The northern station, where the road from Lastgate meets the Rim. A painted line crosses the road outside the gate, red, renewed every Grace: the Drop. North of it, the Kept walk. South of it, they fall. Families from Sallowreach come to the line to say goodbye to living relatives going abroad, and stand on their side, and hold hands over it. The inn, the Long Farewell, serves vinegar-wine and has a back room where Tam Ruddock's clients wait to cross north. Rooms smell of cedar if you pay for it.

Lampwick Halt. At the Vigil's border on the plateau road. Never dark: the Company keeps a hundred lamps burning on the walls to accommodate Vigil merchants, who will not stop in a place they cannot see. Under Vigil custom there are no beds within sight of the plateau, so the Company built the Sleeping Sheds a quarter mile down the road on the Rim side of a stone marker, long low

dormitories with shutters, where travelers bound for the Vigil take their last sleep for months. Rouse is sold at the gate. Many travelers lie awake in the Sheds all night anyway, out of nerves.

Mumchance. On the canyon road where the Rim enters Oathen. The quietest inn in the world. Orders are taken on slates; the bill is chalked; the innkeeper, a Forsworn woman whose jaw broke on a promise thirty years ago, nods. The walls are hung with felt so nothing echoes. A sign over the door, in four dialects, reads *Say Less*. Foreign travelers are given a printed card of safe phrases on arrival and a lecture by gesture. Every year someone ignores it and leaves on a stretcher.

Treaty Stair. A Company depot cut into a canyon wall a day east of Mumchance, at the head of the long stair down to Tacit. Here every Company contract is copied, sealed in wax and bone, and carried down to be sworn before the Company's notary, Jessamy Quill. The Stair is guarded more heavily than any treasury on the Table. Its clerks work in silence. Its archive holds, in theory, the binding text of half the commerce in the world.

Saltlick Cross. The southeastern crossroads where the dry country gives way to the Fatlands' first green. The old heartland road meets the Rim here, running straight in toward Hallowboard, and the crossroads is marked by four stone posts, each with a lamp. In 639 A.G. a table was found laid in the middle of the crossing at dawn, with eight places, steaming. The Company had it burned and the ground salted, and posted a warden on the spot every night since. The wardens rotate weekly. None will say what they see.

The Groaning Board. On the Fatlands stretch, two days north of the Chute. The Company's largest inn, with a common room that seats six hundred at a single table, built to impress Fatlands merchants and to feed them five times a day as the law requires. The floor slopes so that grease runs to a gutter. The smell reaches travelers a day out. The dishes are excellent, the portions vast, the meat unspecified. Foreign guests are advised to eat lightly and to watch the table's far end, where the Gut-line merchants sit, and to not be there when the wardens take one away at closing to be rolled out by six men.

The Chute. The Fatlands' Rim Road export depot, technically the Renderers' Union's yard and not the Company's, and therefore the one place on the ring where Company law runs only on

sufferance. Barrels go out by the thousand a day with the origin stamped over twice. The Company keeps a factor and a weighhouse here and a standing order not to open anything.

Brackwater Bridge. On the southwestern stretch, a magnificent stone bridge of eleven arches carrying the Rim over the estuary of the river Slake, which ran into the sea. The sea left in 512 A.G. and the river followed it out across the Uncovered. The bridge now spans a dry bed of cracked mud and the hulls of barges, sitting upright. The Company still charges the bridge toll. The waystation inn, the Dry Anchor, is full of salvagers and Admiralty recruiters, and the cellars flood twice a day.

Lowmark Spur. Where the Rim meets the road down to Brinehollow's capital. Travelers coming up from the coast are checked here for the pull: wardens watch who stands too long at the west windows. The inn keeps a rack of bail-buckets for those who forgot theirs and a rope room where any guest may ask to be tied to the bed for the night, at a crumb a knot.

Knocking Gate. At the Cradlewrack border on the red-hill road, where Marshal Gideon Breech's men check every traveler leaving the highlands for signs of carrying. The Company's inn here, the Open Door, has no doors at all: every room has a curtain, by agreement with the Attendance, so that nothing can be accused of breaking in. Visitors knock on the frames out of politeness. Occasionally, something knocks back from inside an empty room.

Wanting Post. On the inner side of the eastern Rim, at the head of the road into the Fast's only town. The only Company station that faces the middle. The Crumb-Runners buy grain here at a markup the Company calls a risk premium. The Fast's envoy, Prudence Lowell, keeps an office in a bare stone room off the yard and receives all callers standing. Travelers who arrive after dark are asked, at the gate, whether anyone has invited them in on the road. It is not a joke.

The Weeping Post. On the northwestern stretch between Cradlewrack and Fogmouth, where weep-rain from Sallowreach meets the warm salt springs of the red hills, and the road is always wet and always tea-stained. A Confessors' chapel stands here, the oldest Theft shrine on the Rim, and a rotating congregation of travelers from both lands kneels in the brown water and asks forgiveness for the Meal. The inn is cheap and damp and everyone in it is sorry about something.

THE RIM ROAD IN PLAY

The Rim is the default campaign spine. Characters from different lands meet here, under Company law, and can travel together without being arrested at every border. Use the waystations as hubs: each one is a crossroads of factions, a source of jobs (escort, salvage, smuggling, auditing, finding someone who did not arrive), and a stage for the land next door to intrude. A circuit of the Rim is a hundred days; a campaign can be built as a single circuit, beginning and ending at the same gate, with the world measurably worse on the second visit.

DIO ON THE RIM ROAD

1: A Course-stage Gut-line has rooted in the road; the wardens are cutting a detour. 2: A caravan from the Vigil, all of its drivers asleep on their feet, horses walking on by memory. 3: A table, laid, on the Hem wall, facing inward. Nobody is sitting. Yet. 4: A Sallowreach Kept man standing a yard north of the Drop, weeping, begging travelers to carry a letter south. 5: An Oathen courier carrying a sealed contract at a dead run, because she swore to arrive by dusk. 6: A barrel from the Chute has fallen and split. Something in it is moving. 7: A Purgation procession, bleeding into bowls, singing. 8: Reckoners at a post, asking each traveler their Cut and their mother's name. 9: A Brinehollower walking west across country, not on the road, in a straight line. Their companions are trying to rope them. 10: A milestone whose distance has been carved over, one mile less than the last.

▼ TIME, SEASONS, AND SKY

The year is 641 A.G., After Gorging. Year 0 is the year of the Night of Seven Tables; the nine years of the Long Lack before it are numbered backward by scholars as the Lack Years, Lack 1 to Lack 9, and by everyone else not at all.

The year has four seasons named for a meal: **Grace** (spring), **Plenty** (summer), **Carving** (autumn) and **Lack** (winter). Each season has three months, and the months are named in common Rim usage by the Plate: First Plate, Middle Plate and Last Plate of Grace, and so on. Dates are given as day, Plate and season: "the ninth of Middle Plenty". The year turns on Tablenight.

The moon is called **the Plate**. A full moon is *a full Plate*; a waning one is *being cleared*; a new moon is *licked clean*, and travelers do not set out on licked-clean nights. Stars are called crumbs in most dialects; the Vigil, which cannot see them through its lamp-smoke, has no word for them.

Each land's seasons are bent by its Rule. Sallowreach has no real winter, because winter is an ending, and leaves stay yellow on the branch for decades. The Fast is always early Carving. The Fatlands' first frost is *Marbling*. Oathen has one rain a year, the Kept Rain, on the first day of Grace, and this year it came three days late. The calendar is shared, but the weather is not.

TABL ENIGHT

Tablenight is the anniversary of the Gorging, held on the longest night of Lack. It was once the feast of the longest night, the happiest

festival of the old world. Every land now keeps it, and every land keeps it differently.

LAND	TABL ENIGHT
Sallowreach	The living cook a banquet for their dead, who cannot taste it; everyone pretends
Fatlands	A one-day fast in penance; no village has ever reached sundown
Brinehollow	A bowl of seawater at the head of the table; the west door unbarred for whoever comes home
The Vigil	Every lamp put out for one minute; people hold hands and count aloud
Cradlewrack	Every door propped wide until dawn so nothing can be said to break in
Oathen	Twenty-four hours without a sound; the only day Oatheners feel safe
The Fast	Everyone stands outdoors, dusk to dawn, backs to every door; in every house, the table is laid
The Rim Road	Inns close their gates at dusk; one extra chair is set at every table, turned to face the wall

Nobody knows when the Rim custom began. The Company’s oldest inn ledgers record it as already old in 90 A.G. Innkeepers who are asked about it say the chair is *for the one who isn’t coming*, and

change the subject. Travelers who turn the chair back around in the night find it turned to the wall again in the morning.

▼ THINGS ALL LANDS SHARE

TABLE - SPEECH

The common tongue, older than the Gorging, spoken in some form in every land: drawled and wet in the fens, clipped to almost nothing in Oathen, stretched and slurred in the Vigil. Its oldest root words are the ones the Providers’ peoples shared, and among them is the root *orr-*. From it come *orren*, to eat; *orrel*, to worship or to give back; *orrish*, a shared meal; and *Orrum*, the name of the Host, meaning roughly *the one at whose board*. In Table-speech the words for “worship” and “eat” share a root. Scholars insist they always did. The Purgation insists this is the whole problem.

Table-speech is rich in food-words used for everything: a coward is *underdone*, a fool is *bread without salt*, death in most dialects is *being cleared*, and a person who has been ruined is *picked*. To ask someone’s Cut, politely, is to ask *what portion* they come of. There are two words for *guest*. Everyone uses the newer.

THE LACK

The one coin honored everywhere: a disc of salt-cured bone, the width of a thumb-joint, with a hole through the middle for stringing, worth one day’s bread. Ten **crumbs**, small bone chips,

make a lack; twenty lacks make a **platter**, a sealed bone tablet issued by the Rim Road Company and sworn in Oathen as redeemable at any Company post. Lacks are cut at the Company’s bonehouse near the Chute from Fatlands cattle-bone, salted for a year in vats, and stamped with a closed mouth. The first lacks, cut in the seventh year of the Lack for the public kitchens, were made from other bone, and a few still circulate. They are yellower, and smoother, and people who find one in their change tend to spend it quickly.

THE GRACE

Nobody on the Table eats with a stranger without first saying *Lack keep away*. It is said with eyes lowered, hand flat on the table, before the first bite. Among family it is optional; among strangers, it is the law of every land and of the Rim. Skipping it is the universal insult: it says *I do not care if you starve*. Duels have been fought over it in Brinehollow, oaths broken over it in Oathen, and in the Fast, where nobody shares food at all, it is said anyway, to the empty air, before eating out of the hand.

THE TRADE IN CURES

Every land believes another land’s curse might cure its own. Nothing has ever worked. The trade never slows.

LAND	WANTS TO CURE	BUYS	FROM
The Vigil	Sleep	The undeath of the Kept; bottled brine	Sallowreach; Brinehollow
Fatlands	Hunger	The emptiness of the Unfed	The Fast

LAND	WANTS TO CURE	BUYS	FROM
Sallowreach	Endlessness	Births, beginnings, Cradlewrack cord	Cradlewrack
Brinehollow	The Calling	Oaths to stay ashore; anchors of Oathen iron	Oathen
Cradlewrack	Too many births	Endings: Hand-line Closings	Sallowreach
Oathen	Binding speech	Sleep-drugs that silence the tongue	The Vigil
Everyone	The Regrowth	Blank organs	The Fast

Every apothecary on the Rim sells something. Bottled Kept-breath from Sallowreach. Pills of Fatlands fat. Fast dust, which is earth from the Fast's roads, sold by the pinch to Fatlanders who believe it

kills appetite. Cradlewrack cord, dried, worn as a belt by Sallowreach elders who want to be able to begin again. Most of it is fraud. Some of it does something, and what it does is worse.

▼ THE MASTER TIMELINE

This is the Cutwrights' College's concordance, as taught to its Copyists, with additions from the Rim Road Company's ledgers.

Dates before the Gorging are given in Lack Years. Dates the College considers doubtful are marked *c.*

YEAR	LAND	EVENT
Lack 1	All	The seed does not sprout. The Thin Harvest
Lack 2	All	The nets come up empty; hens stop laying; first bread riots
Lack 3	All	No calf, lamb or foal born anywhere; the old breeds eaten out
Lack 4	All	The Ash Bread; the last child born, at Kest; the Providers fall silent
Lack 5	All	The Leather Winter; the unclosed dead pile up beside Ossel
Lack 6	All	The Kitchen Year; families eat their dead; "trading tables"
Lack 7	All	The Bone Dole; public kitchens; the first lacks cut; the Providers lie down
Lack 8	All	The Moot at Hallowboard; the Eldest Walk; nothing happens
Lack 9	All	The ninth winter; the knives are turned
0	All	The Night of Seven Tables; the Gorging; the Refusal at Hallowboard
0	Sallowreach	The First Morning; a hanged thief in Lastgate asks to be cut down
0	Fatlands	The Week of Rising; crops shoulder high in seven days
0	Brinehollow	The Beaching at Longslab
0	Oathen	The Silent Supper
0–40	The Fast	The Thin Years; the survivors live on what the Rim will sell
3	Oathen	The First Breaking; a merchant's hands come off in the market
c. 30	Rim	Seven caravan-houses found the Rim Road Company
44	The Fast	The First Sitting
60	Brinehollow	The Brimming; the first generation born coughing brine
71	Rim	The Ring Charter sworn in Oathen; the Hem built
0–90	Cradlewrack	The Easy Births
94	Cradlewrack	The First Word: "Not yet"
c. 100	Sallowreach	The Glad Century ends as the first generation comes apart
118	Brinehollow	The First Calling at Lowmark; four hundred walk in, eleven return

YEAR	LAND	EVENT
120	Cradlewrack	The Attendance takes authority over every birth
130	Sallowreach	The Stitching Laws; the Seamers' Guild chartered
130 on	The Fast	The Vindication
140	Rim	The Cutwrights' College founded at Quire
c. 200	Fatlands	End of the Sweet Reigns
204	Fatlands	The Tooth Harvest
212	Sallowreach	An argument begins in Lastgate; it has not ended
215	Oathen	The Muzzling
233	Rim	The Great Retching at the Weeping Post; the Purgation founded
240	Brinehollow	The Drowned Bench seated
260	Fatlands	The Weighing; votes by body weight
288	Sallowreach	The War of the Heirs
301	Sallowreach	The Licensing of Closings
310	Cradlewrack	The Year of Doors
330	Oathen	The Mute Succession
c. 330	Rim	The Bait doctrine first nailed to a toll-house door
341	The Vigil	The First Night: a third of Ludmere does not wake
342	The Vigil	The Waking Laws; Ludmere renamed the Vigil
390	The Vigil	The Rouse Patent
401	The Vigil	The Count
402	The Fast	The Reckoning; the first Reckoner raid across the Rim
c. 412	Rim	First record of the Second Table: a menu, found in a dead Carver's coat
419	Oathen	An oath shouted in Sworn Gorge begins to echo
455	Fatlands	The Thin Rising; fasting made treason
480	The Vigil	The Lidless Succession
488	Fatlands	The Lancing of Brookhythe: the Purgation slaughters a Gut-line house
500	Cradlewrack	The Gathering of Parts
501	Rim	The College fixes the Gorging as "within a single Plate"
512	Brinehollow	The Turning of the Tide
588	Rim	The College proves the Eighth's carvings were defaced in many ages
598	Oathen	The First Sayer
c. 600	All	Every Regrowth curve bends upward at once
604	Rim	The Breath Toll introduced
633	Sallowreach	The First Hush at Dunmere
638	The Fast	The Calling-Cards: a place card with the finder's name
638	Rim	A Baiter drowned by a crowd at Saltlick Cross
639	Rim	A table found laid at Saltlick Cross
640	Brinehollow	Lowmark's pier reaches its nineteenth mile

YEAR	LAND	EVENT
641	Oathen	The Kept Rain falls three days late
641	All	The present: the Long Count, the Chase, the Shortening; the beds nearly full

▼ POWERS THAT CROSS BORDERS

Five institutions operate in every land and answer to none. Each has its own reasons for wanting player characters, and each has its own ways of using them up.

THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

Pay the toll. Keep the peace. Say the grace.

– THE THREE ARTICLES, RECITED AT EVERY POST AT DAWN

The merchant league that owns the ring road, its inns, its posts and its tolls. It is neutral, rich, and the only institution every government needs. It was founded in the Thin Years by seven caravan-houses carrying the Fatlands' miracle grain to every market, and its emblem is still a wheel with seven spokes, one for each founding house. In 71 A.G. it swore its Ring Charter in Oathen, and has sworn every contract there since, where they cannot be broken. Every Company platter, every inn-lease, every toll-farm, every bond of service is a promise sworn before the Company's notary, Jessamy Quill, and if broken the breaker's body breaks to match.

The Company is governed by the Wheel, seven Spokes descended by election from the seven founding houses, presided over by the First Spoke. It has no army, only the road-wardens, and no country,

only the strip of stone a bowshot wide. It needs none. Every land would starve, go dark or come apart in a season without the Rim.

Beliefs. The Company believes in the road. It holds no doctrine about the gods, says the grace at every meal, and regards every land's horror as a pricing problem. Privately, its senior Spokes believe the Table has perhaps twenty years left, and are determined that the Company should be the last institution standing when it ends.

What it wants now. Oathen's rain was late. If a god's sworn word can slip, so can every Company contract, and the whole of the Rim's commerce rests on one notary's body. The Company is quietly auditing everything, pricing every land's collapse, and looking for something better than Oathen to swear by.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Bonded Hand	Wage of 3 lacks a day; a bed at any post; Company protection on the road
2	Waymaster	Command of a caravan; may call on wardens at any post
3	Factor	Runs a waystation; may issue platters and hear Rim cases
4	Toll-Lord	Governs a quarter of the Rim; sits in judgment under Company law
5	Spoke	One of the seven on the Wheel

Joining. Any traveler can hire on as a guard, porter or drover for a single circuit. To become a Bonded Hand, a character must travel to Treaty Stair and swear the Bond: to serve the Company, carry its goods, keep its peace and steal nothing from it, *as long as the wheel*

turns. The oath is sworn in Oathen and binds the body anywhere. Bonded Hands do not steal from the Company. Those who have tried are on display at Treaty Stair, as an instruction.

ODALYS PENHALLOW – FIRST SPOKE OF THE WHEEL

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Fatlands Scrapling) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Haggle 5, Clause 4, Reckoning 4, Persuade 3, Instinct 3, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none worth the name; she has wardens
GIFTS	<i>The Wheel Turns</i> : once per session she may name any Company post and have a sworn message delivered there within a day by relay rider. <i>Platter-Signed</i> : her written word is accepted as currency at every post; she can buy almost anything on the Rim without leaving her carriage.
WANTS	Hunger that wakes her in the night; she keeps a pot of salt-fat by her pillow and is ashamed of it.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Penhallow is eighty-eight and has lived on the road for seventy years in a slow-moving carriage-house drawn by twelve oxen. She is a Scrapling, thin-blooded, and has been running the arithmetic for a decade: she believes the Company will outlive the lands, and she has commissioned a fleet of sealed wagons to carry the Company's archive, its notaries and its Spokes around and around the Rim when the lands fall, indefinitely, a wheel with nothing inside it. She has not told the Wheel what she intends to feed them.

HOBB FALLOWMERE – WARDEN-CAPTAIN OF THE RIM

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Cradlewrack, born grown) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 4, Intimidate 4, Shooting 3, Endure 3, Search 3, Wayfaring 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 3 (warden's mail) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	poleaxe +8 (5); crossbow +7 (4); the Company rope (see Gifts)
GIFTS	<i>The Rope at the Post</i> : within a bowshot of the Rim, any captive he declares guilty under Company law may be hanged without appeal, and every warden present obeys. <i>Born Running</i> : he acts first in any fight that begins on the road.
WANTS	False labor, at night, which he hides from his men; he wakes on his knees, clutching his belly, with every door in the barracks open.
DREAD	1 (his hangings)
SECRET	Fallowmere was born nineteen years ago in Cradlewrack as a grown man with a warden's scar already on his cheek, and served in a Foundling Company before the Company bought his contract. He has hanged four hundred people on the Rim. He has begun to bear: three times now, alone in his cell at night, something has come out of him and gone out of the open door. He follows their tracks on his patrols. They lead inward, over the Hem, toward the Fast.

LYSANDER COYLE – AUDITOR-GENERAL OF THE COMPANY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Oathen Tongue-line, minor) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Reckoning 5, Clause 4, Search 3, Lore 3, Deceive 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	sword-stick +3 (4)
GIFTS	<i>Priced</i> : given a day with any institution’s books, he can state its true condition and the date of its collapse. <i>Conditional Tongue</i> : Oathen-raised, he never makes an unqualified statement and cannot be trapped into an oath.
WANTS	He hears his own figures repeated back to him half a second late, in a voice that is not quite his.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Coyle keeps the Company’s real ledger, the one that prices the end of each land. Sallowreach: nine years. The Vigil: eleven, matching Dr. Crane’s dose curve exactly. Cradlewrack: unknown, possibly weeks. He sent Reeve Calder Stokes to Brinehollow. He has also, on his own initiative, begun selling the ledger’s summary pages to the Second Table, because they are the only buyers who pay in gold, and because he has priced the Company too.

THE CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE

Blood is a ledger. We only read it aloud.

– MOTTO OVER THE GATE AT QUIRE

Genealogists who track every bloodline’s Cut across six centuries. The College began among the tally-priests of the Bone Dole, who kept the lists of who had eaten what in the public kitchens of the seventh year, and among the scribes who recorded, on the morning after the Gorging, which family had carried home which portion of which god. By 140 A.G. those lists were the most valuable documents on the Table, and their keepers built a walled college-town at **Quire**, on the northeastern Rim between Fogmouth and Lampwick Halt, to keep them.

The College’s ledgers decide marriages, inheritances and executions. A College certificate of Cut is accepted in law in every land; a College genealogy can make a bastard an heir, or prove that an heir is a Scrapling. Its Provosts sit in every capital. The northern Provost, Carrion Sedge, has proven that the Hushes follow Hand-

lines blood exactly. Whoever holds the ledgers knows exactly where each god is regrowing fastest, and the College holds all of them, in the Master Concordance at Quire, in a vault cut into the hill under the library, kept at a constant cool by spring water.

Beliefs. The College is officially doctrine-neutral and in practice dominated by quiet Baiters. Its scholars have seen the curves. They know that every land’s Regrowth bent upward at once after 600 A.G., which means that the seven Regrowths are one event, and they do not say so outside the walls.

What it wants now. To keep the ledgers secret and whole. To be the institution that understands the end when it comes. And, among the senior Cutwrights, to answer the question of the Eighth, which the College has been forbidden to ask by every land in turn and has been asking quietly since 588.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Copyist	Board at Quire or a chapter house; access to the open stacks
2	Lineman	Field genealogist; may demand parish, temple and Tally records in any land
3	Cutwright	May certify Cuts, binding in law in every land
4	Provost	Heads a land’s chapter; holds its ledger
5	Archprovost	Holds the Master Concordance at Quire; there is only one

Joining. Copyists are taken young or by examination at Quire. Every entrant gives a pint of blood, which is tasted, graded and entered, and their line is traced back to the Meal. The College

knows exactly what every member is, and how fast they are going. It uses this.

HESPER LUNE – ARCHPROVOST OF THE COLLEGE

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Brinehollow Scrapling) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Lore 5, Reckoning 5, Clause 3, Search 3, Godsign 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	<i>The Concordance</i> : given a name and a land, she can recite the person's line back to the Meal and their likely Cut within a point. <i>Read Aloud</i> : once per session, she may reveal a damning fact about any noble house from the ledger; the house's enemies will act on it.
WANTS	Salt on her lips at waking; she bails at dawn and dusk into a silver basin and has the water assayed.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Lune is seventy, nearly blind, and reads the ledgers by running her fingers over the ink. She has spent twenty years on the eighth place. She has assembled, from chisel-shadows on four hundred carvings rubbed onto paper, a partial reconstruction of what was cut away, and from Table-speech roots the older word for <i>guest</i> . She has told nobody. She has stopped going to dinners, and she has had the extra chair taken out of every room in Quire.

ODO VENN – BLOOD-TASTER OF THE COLLEGE

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Fatlands Gut-line, cadet branch) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Feast 5, Godsign 4, Stitching 3, Lore 3, Blades 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	bleeding-lancet +5 (2)
GIFTS	<i>The Silver Spoon</i> : from a drop of blood on a spoon he can name a person's land, Cut and Regrowth stage, and whether they are Blank. <i>Iron Gut</i> : immune to ordinary poisons.
WANTS	He cannot stop at a drop. He must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard) each time he tastes, or lick the wound.
DREAD	1
SECRET	Venn has graded eleven thousand people and has come, slowly, to a private conclusion: high-Cut blood from different lands tastes the same at the back of the tongue, under the land-flavor, and it has begun to taste of something he cannot name and is very hungry for. He has started tasting Blanks, too. They taste of nothing. He finds that worse.

SILAS FENWRIGHT – THE LEDGER-THIEF

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Sallowreach, living) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Stealth 4, Filch 4, Athletics 3, Lore 3, Deceive 3, Blades 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	knife +5 (2); hand crossbow +3 (3)
GIFTS	<i>Pages for Sale</i> : he carries three bound quires copied from the Master Concordance; each holds the full lines of one land's highest houses.
WANTS	He cannot sleep with a door open, and checks every lock twice.
DREAD	0
SECRET	A former Lineman who copied what he should not have and walked out of Quire in a Copyist's grey. Every faction wants his pages: the Purgation for a massacre list, the Second Table for a menu, the Reckoners for a target roll. He is trying to sell them to whoever will let him live. He has also read them, and he knows that his own line ends, in the ledger, in a Hand-line bastard. He is three generations off the Course and running out of road.

THE PURGATION

What goes down can come up.

– PAINTED ON THE PURGATION’S ALTAR-BOWLS

A cross-border movement that believes the gods can be thrown back up. It was born at the Weeping Post in 233 A.G., when a Fatlands physician named Hurlo Sweyn took a draught of his own devising before a congregation of Confessors and brought up, after six hours of retching, a hard white thing the size of a thumbnail which he swore was one of Ummer’s teeth. The Great Retching spread up and down the Rim within a year. Its emblem is a bowl.

The Purgation’s methods run from fasting and bleeding to the Black Draught, a purgative of bitter roots, salt and lamp-oil taken in public; to burning, on the theory that a god cooked out of the flesh cannot regrow; to massacre. Its militant wing, the Lancets, holds

that a high-Cut house is a swelling in the world’s gut and must be lanced. The Lancing of Brookhythe in 488 A.G., when a Lancet company bled out a Gut-line household of three hundred, servants and all, into the drains of their own manor, is its proudest and most infamous act.

Beliefs. The Purgation holds the Theft doctrine at its hardest: we stole the gods, the gods are inside us, and the only penance is to give them back by any opening available. Its preachers now call for a second Eldest Walk: the firstborn of every High Cut house, walked to the Rim and emptied, so that this time the giving will be done to the gods rather than for them.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Penitent	A bowl; shelter and thin soup at any Purgation hall
2	Purger	May administer the Black Draught and the bleeding-cup
3	Lancet	Armed; may join a Lancing; protected by the halls
4	Emetic	Leads a hall or a company; knows the hidden houses
5	the Voided	The inner council; those who claim to be empty of god

Joining. A would-be Penitent drinks the Black Draught at a Purgation altar before the congregation and retches until something

comes up. Whatever comes up is held up to the lamps and judged. Nobody has ever been turned away.

SAINT ANCEL RUEL – THE EMPTIED, FIRST OF THE VOIDED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (claims to have been Cut 3) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Resolve 5, Rites 4, Endure 4, Feast 3, Lore 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	none; he has never struck anyone
GIFTS	<i>Proof:</i> Ruel cannot be detected by any godsign, and passes every test for Blankness; seeing this, a crowd must make a Dread 1 check or believe him. <i>Sermon of the Bowl:</i> once per scene he may preach; listeners with Fray 5+ must resist (Caul + Resolve, Hard) or drink the Draught.
WANTS	none. That is the point of him.
DREAD	2 (to see his body: he has had a third of his gut cut away and the scars run from collarbone to groin)
SECRET	Ruel was born Blank in the Vigil and has never carried any god at all. He was taken in as a child by Purgation surgeons who saw his value, and he has been cut, bled and starved for fifty years to make the lie look like a miracle. He believes it now. Every Penitent he has led to the bowl has suffered for a proof that was never true, and if this were known, the Purgation would turn on him with knives.

BASTIAN GROLE – LANCET-CAPTAIN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Fatlands) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 5, Intimidate 4, Brawl 3, Endure 3, Rites 2, Wayfaring 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 18 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	lancing-spear +9 (4); butcher's cleaver +9 (3)
GIFTS	<i>The Lancing</i> : when he attacks a High Cut (4–5) target, each Helping adds +3 damage instead of +2. <i>Bleed Them Out</i> : a wound he deals keeps bleeding for 1 Flesh per round until stitched.
WANTS	Eating without choosing; he eats from the Lancings' kitchens after the work is done, and cannot stop.
DREAD	2 (a Lancing in progress)
SECRET	Grole has led eleven Lancings. After each one he eats in the dead family's kitchen, alone, everything he can find, and the hunger never lessens. He knows what that means about his own blood. He has decided that when the last High Cut in the Fatlands is lanced, he will walk into the Purgation hall and have himself bled, and he has asked Sister Tisane to make sure it is done properly.

SISTER TISANE HALLOWAY – MISTRESS OF THE BLACK DRAUGHT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Sallowreach, living) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Craft 4 (apothecary), Stitching 4, Feast 4, Lore 3, Deceive 2, Blades 1, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	lancet +4 (2, plus Draught: Gut + Endure, Hard, or helpless with retching for 1d6 rounds)
GIFTS	<i>The Draught</i> : she can brew a dose that will make anyone bring up whatever is in them, and some things that should not be. <i>The Bowl Reads</i> : from what a Penitent brings up she can tell their land and how far along they are.
WANTS	A dread of open things; she covers every bowl.
DREAD	1
SECRET	Six years ago a Penitent at Brackwater brought up, after the Draught, something that was not food and was not a tooth: a small grey hinged thing like a finger-joint, which moved. Since then Halloway has seen it eleven times, in Penitents from four lands. She keeps them in a sealed jar. They have grown. They fit together.

THE SECOND TABLE

It worked once.

– THE WHOLE OF THE SECOND TABLE'S CREED, ENGRAVED INSIDE ITS MEMBERS' SIGNET RINGS

A hidden cult with one idea: when the gods finish regrowing, eat them again. Its members are mostly nobles, High Cuts of every land, and they are preparing. The first trace of it in any record is a menu found in the coat of a murdered Gut-line lordling in 412 A.G., listing seven courses, each named for a god, in a hand nobody could identify. The College has since collected forty more such menus. They are always seven courses. On the most recent ones, found in the last ten years, there is an eighth line at the bottom, left blank.

The Second Table meets in private dining rooms on the Rim and in the cellars of great houses, a dozen at a time, never more. Members address one another by course: the Fish, the Bread, the

Sweet. They practice. They have eaten the fruit of Seated Laden hills, the grey fingertips of Course-stage Hand-lines, the lidless eyes of the Vigil's dead nobility, scraps of caul, and the quiet of a Tenanted heart. They keep notebooks of the effects. They have commissioned knives.

Beliefs. The Gorging ended the Lack. It made the eaters' ancestors into lords. If it is done again, by the right people, with preparation, the gods will be put down once more and the world given another six hundred years of grace, with the diners at its head. The first meal was eaten by a mob, shared too widely, and spread thin, which is why it did not hold; the second will be eaten by a few.

Some members believe they will become gods. Most just believe they will be fed.

What it wants now. Blank organs, to make room. The College’s ledgers, to know which gods will be ripe first. The Sayer’s sentence,

to make the meal certain. And, through the heretic Wont Bellamy of the Fast, the one god still whole: Orrum, the Host, as the first course.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Scullion	Servants and agents who know; paid well, watched closely
2	Taster	Admitted to a practice dinner; may eat what is served
3	Trencherman	A full member, holding a course name
4	Carver	Leads a table in a land; keeps its knife
5	the Head of the Table	One; never seen; presides from an empty chair

Joining. By invitation only. A candidate is brought to a dinner and served a dish without being told what it is. They are told afterward. Those who finish their plate are sworn in Oathen to silence, on their

own tongues. Those who do not finish their plate are served at the next dinner.

LORD ABSALOM THRALE – GRAND CARVER OF THE SECOND TABLE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Sallowreach Hand-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 5, Godsign 4, Clause 3, Persuade 3, Rites 3, Feast 3, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (gloves of lead mesh) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	carving knife +9 (2); bare hand +7 (see Gifts)
GIFTS	<i>The Finishing Touch:</i> with his bare grey hand, Thrale can end a thing: snuff a lamp, stop a heart’s fluttering, kill a conversation so that nobody in the room can recall what was said. Against a living creature outside Sallowreach, a touch that hits deals 6 damage that ignores Armor. Each use is a Partake. <i>The Carver’s Eye:</i> he knows, by looking, where on a body a god is thickest.
WANTS	Compulsive closing; he cannot leave a door, a lid or a pair of eyes open, and must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard) to stop himself reaching for a stranger’s face.
DREAD	3 (when the gloves come off)
SECRET	Thrale is a younger son of an Unvacated house who left Sallowreach alive two hundred years ago, when he was twenty, and has not been back, because he is quite sure he would die at the Drop. He has outlived his inheritance and stopped aging somewhere in his fifties, which should not happen outside the fen. He believes it is the dishes. He has eaten a piece of every land’s god. He has kept the knife from the first practice dinner, and it is made of grey bone that the College would identify, if shown it, as one of Ossel’s knuckles.

LADY SERAPHINE DALGETY – THE TASTER OF THE EYE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Vigil Eye-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Search 5, Persuade 4, Deceive 4, Lore 3, Feast 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	stiletto +3 (2)
GIFTS	<i>Lidless</i> : she cannot be surprised, sees clearly by a single candle, and has perfect recall of everything she has ever seen. <i>The Seeming</i> : once per session she may describe a hallucination aloud; everyone with Fray 4+ who hears her sees it too.
WANTS	Blinks; she must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Routine) once per scene of calm or lose a second in the long dim room, and comes back having moved.
DREAD	2 (her eyes, which never close and are always wet from the brushing)
SECRET	Dalgety travels with two maids who brush her eyes wet every half minute, and she has not slept in forty-one years. She is the Second Table's chief buyer of Blank organs. She has already had a Blank's eyelids grafted onto her own lidless eyes, three times, and three times they have died and sloughed. She has put a price on a fourth pair, and her agents are in the Fatlands, looking for a girl called Wren.

MASTER QUILLON BARR – SURGEON TO THE TABLE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Brinehollow Lung-line, minor) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stitching 6, Lore 4, Blades 3, Reckoning 3, Feast 3, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	scalpel +8 (2); with an Attack that scores a Helping he may choose to sever a tendon instead of dealing extra damage
GIFTS	<i>Room Made</i> : he can transplant a Blank organ into a godsigned body; the recipient's Regrowth drops by 1 for a season, then rises by 2. <i>Kept Fresh</i> : his brine-tanks keep organs alive for a month.
WANTS	The pull; he cannot work in a room whose windows face west, and his surgery has none.
DREAD	3 (his surgery, where the donors are kept alive and awake between harvests)
SECRET	Every trail Dr. Mercy Thrane has followed out of the Fast ends, eventually, at a hired house with no west windows in whatever city Barr is working that season. He keeps his donors alive between harvests because the organs are better. He has kept one Unfed man, a farmer called Abide, alive for nine years, and Abide has started to put on weight.

THE RECKONERS

Refusing was not enough.

– RECKONER WATCHWORD

Zealots out of the Fast who cross into other lands to kill the Godeaters' highest bloodlines. The first armed band crossed the Rim in 402 A.G.; they have not stopped since. Reckoners travel light, eat only what they carried, and carry nothing that can be traced. They select High Cut families from stolen College

genealogies, cross the Hem at night, kill in beds, and are gone by dawn. The Rim Road Company hangs every Reckoner it catches on Company ground, and the Reckoners have never once killed on the road surface. Their full history, beliefs and their great captain Scant Hollis are described in the chapter on the Fast.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Unblooded	Trained; may carry the knife
2	Knife	Has killed on a raid
3	Reckoner	Has ended a line

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
4	Captain	Leads raids; chooses targets
5	Elder of the Reckoning	Sits with the Abstinents; speaks for the raids

Joining. Only the Unfed are trusted, though a few godsigned outsiders have been used, and spent. An Unblooded swears on Hallowboard to eat nothing on the far side of the Hem. Scour, the Returned, is the reason the oath was made stricter.

REFRAIN COBB, RECKONER KNIFE Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Attack +7 (long knife 2, strikes first from hiding) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

SPARING WADE, RECKONER-CAPTAIN OF THE EASTERN RIM Threat 4 · Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Attack +8 (hatchet 3; crossbow +7, 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 1

DENY FALLON, THE LEDGER RECKONER Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · carries a stolen College quire; hunting Silas Fenwright for the rest

CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN A CAMPAIGN

Every party should have a reason to be on the Rim, and the five powers supply most of them. The Company hires. The College asks questions and pays for answers. The Purgation offers absolution and then a spear. The Second Table invites the most successful characters to dinner. The Reckoners notice whoever has a high Cut and has become inconvenient. Let each power want something from the characters before the characters want anything from it, and let at least one of them be wrong about who the characters are.



CHAPTER 3

SALLOWREACH

Nobody here is waiting to die. We are all waiting to be allowed.

– FEN PROVERB

Shut the door, love. Shut the door. Something might finish.

– HAND-LINES NURSERY RHYME, FIRST LINE (THERE IS NO LAST LINE)

From the day-book of Aubin Coyle, apprentice of the Seamers' Guild, Needle Street, Lastgate. Restitching Week, Grace, 640 A.G.

They send the youngest of us to the grandmothers first, because the grandmothers are the worst and the guild says you should learn the worst while your stomach still thinks it can be taught.

Mistress Harl took me to the Coombe house on Weir Row at first bell. The family had already carried Great-Gran Coombe down from the attic on her board and laid her across the kitchen table, under the hook where the eels hang. They had put a sprig of rosemary in each of her hands and a cloth over her face, which was kind of them and no use at all. You smell a Kept grandmother in spring before you are through the door. It is not one smell. Mistress Harl says to learn it in layers, like a cellar. On top is the family's vinegar, and under that the old cedar oil from last year's lacquer gone rancid, and under that the sweet, and under the sweet the thing itself, which is like a pot of lentils left a fortnight in the sun with a dead rat in it, and the rat is you.

"Good morning, Gran," said Mistress Harl. "May you finish."

The cloth moved. Under it something said, wetly, "Long life to you too, you lacquered bitch." The family laughed the way people laugh at a christening. Great-Gran Coombe died in 431. She has been rude to the guild every spring since.

We took the cloth off. Her face had slipped again. That is what winter does to them, even here where there is no winter: the damp gets into the lacquer and the old stitches go soft as wet bread and everything settles downward. The left cheek had come away from the bone along last year's seam and hung like a pocket. Mistress Harl lifted it with two fingers and I saw what was in the pocket. They were grey and they were moving and some of them had already got into the eye. She said, "Tweezers, Aubin, and the vinegar, and do not you dare be sick on a client."

I did not. I want that written down. I was sick afterward, in the eel barrel, and Mr. Coombe said not to worry, the eels would not mind, they are Kept too.

You pick them out one at a time. You cannot rush it, because if you squeeze they burst, and what is inside them is her. Gran swore at me the whole while in a voice that came partly from her mouth and partly from a split under her jaw where the old wire had pulled through. When I got to the eye she stopped swearing and said, very quietly, "Mind the eye, boy. I still use it." Then she held my wrist with her good hand. It was cold and soft and the skin moved over the bones like a glove a size too big. Under it I could feel her pulse, which she does not have. That is the thing nobody tells you. Under the skin of the Kept it is always moving. It is just not them.

We cut out the black and kept the brown. Mistress Harl says brown is still hers. We packed the cheek with lint soaked in cedar-and-pitch, drew it back up to the cheekbone, and I put in my first real seam: thirty-one stitches of waxed gut, blanket stitch, with wire at the corners. My hands shook. Gran said, "That is the worst stitching I have had in two hundred years," and then, "Thank you," and then, "Will you come next year? I should like it to be you." I said I would.

Then we lacquered her. Three coats, cedar and resin, brushed thin, each one dried with the bellows. By noon she shone like a sideboard and smelled like a church and the family sat her up in her chair by the window, which is where she likes to be, so she can watch the weep come down on the fen and tell the neighbors what she thinks of them.

On the way out I asked Mistress Harl how long it would hold. She said, "Till Plenty. Then the flies come and it starts again." I asked her how long that goes on. She looked at me like I had asked how long the fen goes on. She lit her pipe with a candle Wick Tallow made, and the candle flinched, and she said:

"Write it down, Aubin. That is what the book is for. Forever is a long time to remember by hand."

Sallowreach is the land where nothing ends. A cut throat does not kill. A drowned girl walks out of the fen in the morning, coughing weed. A hanged man asks to be cut down. The grandmothers are restitched each spring. The fires that were lit in the founding years are still smoldering under the peat. The songs have no last verse and the arguments no final word. For six hundred and forty-one years the people of the grey north have lived inside the stomach of the god of death, and the god of death has been unable to do its job.

Now it is learning again.

This chapter describes Sallowreach in the Long Grace: its meal, its rule, its rot, its powers and its people. It gives the Game Master

▼ THE MEAL

The people of the northern fens ate Ossel, the Closing Hand, last and slowest of all the peoples of the Table, because nobody wanted to be the one to start.

In the old carvings Ossel is shown seated, robed in what may be fog, with two immense hands laid open on its knees. It was not cruel and it was not kind. It walked the fens in the evening the way a lamplighter walks a street, and where it passed, things finished. The old heron that could no longer stand closed its eyes. The sick child's breathing eased and stopped. The fire that had burned all night settled into ash and was done. The fen-people loved it the way you love a doctor who has never once lied to you. They brought it their dying, and it came, and it put its hand over their eyes, and it was over. *May you finish* was a blessing then, said at bedsides, and it came true.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack the fen-folk were eating reed-root and boiled leather and the soft white grubs from under the peat. Ossel came to them across the water at Lastgate, which was then a landing called the Ferrying, and lay down on the black mud at the edge of the mere with its hands folded on its chest, and waited. It waited eleven days.

They knew what had happened elsewhere. Word had come along the old roads of what the southern plains had done to their god, and the western coast to theirs. Every family in the Ferrying had someone in the house too weak to rise. And still nobody went down to the shore with a knife, because everyone in the fens understood a thing the other peoples had not had to think about: if you kill death, who closes your eyes?

On the eleventh night a widow named Hessa Grue (the Court's genealogies insist on the name; the Cutwrights' College does not) walked down to the mud with a reaping hook and her six living children and said, loudly enough for the landing to hear, "It is lying there so that we will." Then she began at the left hand.

The accounts agree on a few things and on nothing else. They agree that Ossel's flesh was cold, colder than the mud, cold as a cellar step, and that it did not bleed but leaked a grey, slow, tasteless fluid like the water that collects under a stone. They agree that it had no smell at all. A body three hundred feet long, opened on the shore, and not a breath of rot or meat or blood; the gulls would not come down to it, and the flies, for the first time in anyone's life, stayed away. That absence of smell is what the oldest songs remember, more than the blood or the cold. *It smelled of nothing, and nothing was what we ate.*

everything needed to set a campaign in the fens, and gives players what they need to play a Sallowreacher, living or Kept.

They agree that it took nine days to eat. Families came down in turn and carved, and carried, and boiled, and the meat would not soften in the pot however long it boiled, so it was eaten in grey strips that had to be chewed for an hour. It tasted, said the ones who wrote of it, like the moment after a bell stops ringing. People who ate it fell asleep where they sat and woke the next morning unable to remember the night. Some woke weeping. Some woke laughing and could not say why.

The families who took the hands became the Hand-lines. Hessa Grue's children ate the left hand to the wrist; the Vanes, the Sedges and the Hethes divided the right. The Hands were the choicest cut because they were what the god *did* things with, and because they were the hardest part to eat: the fingers kept curling closed over the knives. It is said that the eldest Vane boy put his own hand into Ossel's palm, in the dark, to steady the carving, and the god's fingers closed over his, gently, and held him there until dawn. He was not hurt. He would not speak of it. His line is the strongest in Sallowreach.

Last of all they came to the face. Nobody wanted it. In the end the Scraplings of the far fen took it, as they took everything nobody else would, and boiled it in a peat pit for a week. Those who saw it before the knives went in all said the same thing, and Grandfather Peat (see the People of Sallowreach), who saw it the week he drowned, still says it in a dialect no one else speaks: the god was smiling.

The famine ended the next morning. The reeds came up green. Eels filled the traps. And in Lastgate, a thief who had been hanged at the landing the week before, and left as a warning, opened his eyes, saw the crowd gathered on the shore, and asked politely to be cut down.

THE MISSING WITNESS

On the oldest piling in Lastgate, the Ferrying Post, under nine centuries of tar and moss, there is a carving of a long table at the water's edge with figures seated along it. Seven are recognizably the Providers: the open hands of Ossel, the full belly of Ummer, the lidded eyes of Iss. There is an eighth place at the end of the table. The figure that sat there has been gouged out to the wood, not once but repeatedly, with different tools, the newest cuts still pale. Every few years someone in Lastgate notices that the gouge is fresh again. The Court pays a man to tar it over. He is Kept, and has been doing it for three hundred years, and he has stopped asking who keeps opening it.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Nothing ends here.

A body in Sallowreach takes the damage and goes on. A throat slit to the spine bleeds out, the heart stops, the blood stops, and the man sits up, his head lolling forward on a hinge of skin, and asks for help holding it on. A woman drowned in the mere is down for a night and comes up the next day, puffed and grey and furious, with an eel in her coat. A man burned in a barn fire walks out of the ashes as a figure of black coal that crackles when it moves and weeps clear fluid from its cracks. A starving child grows hungry and thin and then too thin and then nothing changes; she goes on, and goes on being hungry. And everyone grows old. The very old go past old into something else: shrunk, leathery, curled like a dropped glove, eyes gone to milk, whispering. They are still in there.

Those who have died and carried on are called **the Kept**. They outnumber the breathing nine to one. They have no pulse and no breath. They do not need to eat, drink or sleep, though many still try out of habit, and some still feel a ghost of hunger they cannot feed. Their bodies are cool, the temperature of the room. They feel everything.

That is the cruelty: decay still works. A Kept body rots exactly as a dead body rots anywhere else on the Table: it bloats, it slips, it blackens, it is hollowed by flies and their children. But it never finishes rotting. There is no clean bone at the end, no dust, no rest. The rot goes on, slower and slower, layer under layer, for centuries, and the mind sits inside it and feels every soft inch go. The Kept do not lose their wits to death. They lose them, if they lose them, to time.

It applies to everything that ever lived, and to much that did not.

- ◇ **Animals.** A slaughtered pig gets up off the block. Butchery in Sallowreach is the art of rendering an animal too disjointed to wander off. Eels go on twisting in the pot and, it is said, in the stomach. The rich eat imported Fatlands meat or *stilled* meat, closed by a licensed Hand-line butcher at great expense. The poor eat *lively*, and learn to chew fast.
- ◇ **Plants.** Cut reeds go on drawing water. Picked fruit rots on the shelf and never goes to dust. Leaves yellow on the branch and

stay yellow for decades, waiting for an autumn that never finishes arriving.

- ◇ **Fire.** A fire in Sallowreach burns down but does not go out. Peat fires lit in the Glad Century still smolder under the fen; the ground steams in long seams across the north. To put out a candle you must close it, and only the Hand-lines can close.
- ◇ **Sound and speech.** Songs here have no last verse; they trail off and wait. Books have no last pages. An argument begun in 212 A.G. over a fishing weir is still being conducted, by the original parties, in a room in Lastgate, through a hired interpreter of jaw-clicks.
- ◇ **The border.** The dead cannot leave. A Kept person who steps across the border of Sallowreach drops, finished, at once, the whole long rot catching up in a single heartbeat. What hits the ground on the far side is bone and dust and a smell like an opened tomb. Sallowreach therefore has an army that cannot be killed and cannot invade.

THE RULE AT THE TABLE

In Sallowreach, a character reduced to 0 Flesh suffers Ruin as normal: an Injury from the Mangling table and collapse. Further damage does not kill. A living character who would die instead becomes Kept (see Playing One of the Kept). A Kept character who suffers further damage accrues Rot instead. Enemies are the same: the GM should remember that a fight in Sallowreach ends when one side cannot move or chooses to stop, never when someone dies. Hamstringing, dismembering, sacking and sinking are the local tactics. Witnessing a Kept man coming apart is a Dread 2 horror; a Kept body that goes on talking while it is being taken to pieces is Dread 3.

There is one exception, and it is the whole of Sallowreach's politics. The Hand-lines, who ate the god's hands, can close. Their touch, in the later stages of their Regrowth, does what Ossel once did: it finishes a thing. A candle. A conversation. A person. Since 301 A.G. that touch has been sold by license, and it is the only death in the land.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN SALLOWREACH

Ossel is growing back, and what grows back is ending. Every other land's god returns as a presence, an appetite, a pressure. Sallowreach's returns as an absence. Its godsign is closing, and its Seating is silence.

THE TASTE

It begins as a dread of open things. A Hand-line child cannot sleep with the door ajar. She gets up three times a night to push it to, and if it is pushed open again she cries until it is shut. Open jars bother her. Open mouths bother her. A book left face-down makes her feel sick in a place she cannot point to. Adults at the Taste find themselves closing drawers in other people's houses, smoothing shut

the flaps of envelopes, lowering the lids of sleeping friends with a fingertip. The fingers go cold first, a chill like holding a stone that has lain all night in the fen. Candles near them gutter. Conversations near them, for no reason anyone can name, tend to stop.

THE APPETITE

Then the closing becomes a compulsion. Lids, shutters, books, boxes, eyes. Appetite sufferers cannot pass an open door without shutting it. They close the eyes of the dead, and then the eyes of the living: a stranger in a tavern finds a cold hand laid over his face, gently, and the person it belongs to apologizing and unable to stop. They finish other people's sentences, and then they finish other people's songs, and the song simply ends there, and the singer cannot remember the next verse. The fingertips grey. The nails thicken and darken like horn. The hands are always cold now, cold enough to sting, and sufferers wear mittens in polite company, partly from courtesy and partly so that they will have to take something off before they can touch. It is said in Lastgate that you can always tell a Hand-line house at night, because every window is shuttered and every door is shut, and the silence inside is the kind you could lean on.

THE COURSE

The hands change. They go grey all the way to the wrist and then past it, a cold slate grey like the belly of a fish, and the skin over them grows smooth and seamless and faintly shining. They lengthen. The fingers grow extra joints, first one more, then two, then more, so that a hand at the height of the Course can curl like a fern or fold flat like a fan. The joints click in silence. The nails go black. The cold is no longer a sensation but a fact: a hand at the Course will frost a glass of water and leave a pale, bloodless print on skin.

And what they touch finishes. A candle pinched by a Course-hand is not snuffed but *closed*: the wick goes dark, the wax goes cold, and it will never be lit again. A conversation touched, a palm laid on a speaker's shoulder, ends, and nobody present can quite recall what it was about. A Kept body touched with intent goes still. The long rot catches up at once, every unfinished year of it, and what was a talking corpse is in a moment only a corpse, quiet, smelling at last of nothing worse than earth. The Kept who see it weep with envy. The living who see it are often sick.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

Sallowreach is grey fen, black water, reed and peat, under a fog called **the Breath** that has not lifted in living or unliving memory. The Breath is warm and wet and sweet in the wrong way, like air let out of a closed room. It beads on wool and hair. It carries sound strangely: a voice across the mere seems to come from just behind

People at the Course keep their hands in gloves, then in mittens, then in lead. The highest of the Hand-lines have their gloves sewn on.

THE BRINK

At the Brink the ending begins to leak out of the hands and into the room. Sound grows thin around the sufferer. Footsteps do not quite carry. Flies within a few paces drop out of the air and do not get up. Flames lean away. The Kept, near a Brink-sufferer, fall silent and then begin to plead. The sufferer's face grows smooth and grey like the hands, the features softening as if seen through fog, and in some of them the lips curve gently upward, in what everyone agrees not to call a smile. They stop needing to touch. A Hand-line at the Brink can finish a thing by looking at it long enough and wishing it over. Most of them have stopped wishing anything at all.

THE SEATING

The Seating in Sallowreach is a **Hush**: a patch of ground where everything ends at once and stays ended. A Hand-line who reaches it does not die. They become the center of a silence, and the silence spreads. Inside a Hush there is no rot, no flies, no echo. The Kept inside it are properly, finally dead, and lie down where they stood. The grass is grey and does not move. Sound does not carry: a scream inside a Hush is a mouth opening and nothing. Birds fall at its edge. The largest, Dunmere Hush, is four miles across and growing.

The Court has known for some years, and has begun to admit in locked rooms, that Hushes appear fastest near the estates of the Hand-lines. The god is not coming back as a figure walking the fen in the evening. It is coming back as a book, closing.

RUNNING THE REGROWTH

Sallowreach's horror works because it inverts the rest of the Table. Everywhere else, the Regrowth is the thing the players fear. Here, half the population is praying for it. A Hand-line PC at the Course will be approached constantly: by grandmothers asking to be closed, by Heirs offering fortunes to have a father closed, by Finishers asking to be blessed, by Court agents with a license, a fee and a warrant. Every touch is a moral decision and most of them are illegal. Make the players feel what it is to carry the only mercy in a country and to be told, by law, who may have it.

you. At noon it is the color of dishwater; at dusk it goes yellow, then brown.

There is no real winter, because winter is an ending. The seasons are named as they are everywhere on the Table, but in the fens they only lean: Grace is damper, Plenty is hotter and buzzes, Carving

yellow the leaves, and Lack makes the fog a little colder and leaves the leaves where they are. Trees in Sallowreach carry decades of dead foliage, yellow and brown and black in layers, rattling. A Sallowreacher who travels south and sees a bare tree in Lack weeps, or laughs, or both.

Flies are the true weather. They move across the fen in fronts, dense brown curtains a mile wide that tick against shutters like sleet. Lastgate's almanacs forecast them. A **Black Noon** is a swarm thick enough to put out lamps and turn day to dusk; people caught outdoors in one breathe through cloth and come home with flies in their ears, their collars, the corners of their eyes. Every house has fly-nets, fly-paper, smudge pots of smoldering peat and lavender. In the hot weeks of Plenty, when the swarms breed, the Kept are shut indoors for their own sakes, and the Seamers work without sleeping.

▼ A GAZETTEER OF SALLOWREACH

LASTGATE

The capital, built on pilings over the fen where the border road ends. Lastgate is a city of tar, timber and ropes, of plank streets and plank bridges, of houses leaning together over narrow canals like old men sharing a secret. It has sunk for centuries. Each generation builds a new storey on top of the old, and the lower levels have gone down into the water one by one and are still inhabited: the **Drowned Storeys**, half-flooded streets where the light is green and the residents are Kept and long past minding the wet. Little Nell Ash rules there.

Lastgate smells of tar, vinegar, cedar, smoke and the thing all of those are there to hide. Rich houses on the Upper Boards burn cedar in braziers at their doors. Poor streets in the Sinks smell of themselves. Everywhere there are candles, and many of them are Wick Tallow's.

Notable districts: **the Upper Boards** (Court houses, the Mortuary Court's Hall of Hands); **Needle Street** (the Seamers' Guildhall and a hundred stitching-shops, wire-drawers and lacquer-boilers); **the Sinks** (the poor, the Heirs' safehouses, Marrow Jack's markets); **the Landing** (the Ferrying Post, the border road terminus, Tam Ruddock's ferry); and **the Drowned Storeys** beneath it all.

THE LOFTS

Warehouses of the Set-Aside, on the north edge of Lastgate: nine storeys of shelving in nine long timber halls, each shelf holding the wrapped, labeled bodies of those too far gone to stand. Forty thousand of them, still aware. Ladders on rails run the length of each aisle, and the Loft-Wardens move along them with lamps and lists. The halls are lit low and kept cool and smell of camphor, linen,

Rain is called **weep**. It falls warm and leaves a tea-colored stain on linen and skin. Mist that settles overnight is called **dew-rot**. The wind, when there is wind, is called **a sigh**, and a long dry sigh off the southern road is the one weather everyone loves: it clears the Breath for an hour and you can see the sky, which is white.

The fen itself is full. Everything that ever drowned in it is still down there, moving a little: deer, dogs, horses, eels by the million, fishermen, suicides from the Glad Century, children who slipped off the boardwalks, six centuries of the weighted sacks of the Sump. On still days the black water stirs without wind. Reed-cutters wear tall boots and keep their eyes on the surface, because sometimes something takes hold of an ankle, not to drown you, only to hold on.

wax and old meat. The whispering is audible from the street: a soft continuous sound, like rain on reeds, rising at night.

THE SUMP

The deep fen west of Lastgate, where those beyond stitching are sunk in weighted sacks. It is the nearest thing Sallowreach has to a graveyard and the worst place in the north. The water there is black and greasy and smells of drains. **Bubbles rise in patterns**: rings, lines, spirals, sometimes a slow, regular pulse like breathing. Sump-watchers claim the patterns are speech. Sackmen ferry new sacks out at dusk and lower them on ropes, reciting the names. Dredgers, licensed and otherwise, rake the bottom for anything that can be sold: rings, wire, teeth, and, in the last ten years, whole bodies, for reasons the Seamers' Guild does not want to know.

DUNMERE HUSH

The first and largest silence. Eight years ago Dunmere was a reed-cutting village of three hundred souls, living and Kept. Now it is the center of a grey disc four miles across that grows a few yards every month. At its edge the reeds go from green-brown to ash-grey in the space of a step. Birds that cross the line fall and lie still. Inside, the village stands as it stood: doors open, washing on the lines, the inhabitants lying where they lay down, unrotted, unmoving, entirely dead. There are no flies. There is no smell. There is no sound at all. Finishers camp at the edge in their hundreds.

THE JAR ROOM

The Court's prison, under the Hall of Hands. One shelf, very long, running the full length of a low brick vault, lined with jars of thick green glass sealed with lead. In each jar is a criminal sentenced to be Kept forever in pieces: head in one, hands in another, the rest rendered or sunk. The heads are aware. The jars are labeled with the

name, the crime, and the date of sentence. The oldest is from 304 A.G. On the floor beneath the shelf there are drains.

THE HALL OF CLOSINGS

On the Upper Boards, a long, plain, cedar-paneled building with no windows, where licensed Closings are performed. It has a waiting room, a robing room, a ledger room and nine small chambers, each with a narrow bed and a single chair. The building is famously quiet. Buyers wait here in their best clothes for days. Some are turned away at the door because a fee has risen overnight.

GLOVEHALL

The estate of the Vanes, an hour’s punt north of Lastgate: a great house of black timber on a mound in the fen, every window bricked to a slit, every door double. Lady Corrow Vane lives in its east wing. Osrice Vane is kept in its west. A new Hush, small, the size of a kitchen garden, appeared in the orchard behind Glovehall last Carving. The gardeners will not go near it. The pears in it are perfect.

BRINEMOSS AND MOTHER GALL'S CELLAR

A hamlet of stilt huts in the south fen, known for pickling. Under the largest hut, dug into the peat and lined with cedar, is Mother Gall’s cellar: four hundred oak barrels of brine, each holding a paying customer, each wide awake. The barrels creak and knock gently. When the lids are lifted the faces in the brine are smooth, pale and perfect, and the eyes open.

THE FINISHING POST

Where the border road leaves Sallowreach, nine miles south of Lastgate, a line of tarred stakes marks the boundary. Beyond it, in

the grass, there is a long low heap that the Rim Road Company clears twice a year. It is bone and dust and rags: the Kept who crossed. Some were desperate. Some were confused. Some went deliberately, at last, and the Company clerks who rake the heap report that those ones are always found facing home. Kept relatives come to the post on feast days and stand just inside it, looking south.

THE ROOM OF THE LONG ARGUMENT

A rented upper room in the Sinks where, since 212 A.G., two weir-owners named Abel Strake and Cobb Mallory have been disputing the ownership of a fishing weir that rotted away in 260. Neither has a tongue any longer. They argue through the jaw-clicks interpreted by Fenwick Lisp. A crowd sometimes gathers. People bet on the outcome. There is never an outcome.

THE SMOKING GROUND

A stretch of open fen east of Lastgate where peat fires lit in the Glad Century still burn underground. The ground is warm and spongy and steams from long cracks. Things lost in the fires walk there, black and cracking. The Heirs use it for meetings because no Court agent will go there in good boots.

TRAVELING THE FEN

Sallowreach has one road worth the name, the border road from the Finishing Post to Lastgate, raised on a causeway of piled peat and old bones. Everything else is boardwalk, punt, or wading. A day’s travel off the road is a Hard Wayfaring check; failure means a lost hour, a soaked pack and a Dread 1 encounter from the fen (see Horrors of Sallowreach). Living travelers need fly-cloth, vinegar and a hat. Kept travelers need a Seamer within a week.

▼ HISTORY

“Nothing happened in Sallowreach that is over,” the Loft-Wardens say. History is not a record of the past here. It is the record of things still going on.

YEAR	EVENT
0 A.G.	The Meal at the Ferrying. The First Morning: a hanged thief asks to be cut down.
1–100	The Glad Century. No widows, no orphans, no graves. Dancing in the reed-towns.
c. 90	The first generation begins to come apart. The dancing stops.
112	The first Lofts built as a charity for the unstanding.
130	The Stitching Laws. The Seamers’ Guild chartered. Public falling-apart made fineable.
168	The first jarring of a criminal.
212	The Long Argument begins.
229	Ansel Grue is born.

YEAR	EVENT
288	The War of the Heirs. The young win every battle and change nothing.
301	The Licensing. The Hand-lines reveal that their touch can finish, and set a price.
304	The Jar Room built; the oldest jar on its shelf is sealed.
341	Ansel Grue becomes Regent.
402	The Reckoners' first raid on Sallowreach. The slain lord attends his own inquest.
431	Great-Gran Coombe dies.
512	The Grey Plague. A Fatlands fever kills nobody and Keeps a third of the south fen in a month.
551	Wick Tallow's chandlery opens.
633	The First Hush. Dunmere goes silent overnight.
636–640	Seventeen more Hushes found, all within a day of a Hand-line estate.
640	The Glovehall Hush. Finishers triple. The Vigil's envoy arrives.
641	Now.

THE GLAD CENTURY AND THE STITCHING LAWS

For a hundred years it looked like a miracle. Mothers who would have died in childbed rose and nursed; fishermen swept off the weirs came home with weed in their hair. There were no widows and no orphans, and the reed-towns danced through the long fen evenings. The songs of that century are the only happy songs in Sallowreach, and nobody sings them now. The dancing stopped when the first generation began to come apart: a man who died in the year 3 was by the year 90 something that could not hold a fiddle. By 130 the state recognized what it was. The Stitching Laws made families responsible for keeping their dead in one piece, chartered the Seamers' Guild, and made it a fineable offence to fall apart in public. The fines are still collected: four lacks for a hand on the boardwalk, twenty for a face.

THE WAR OF THE HEIRS AND THE LICENSING

By 288 no property had changed hands by inheritance in two centuries, and the young rose. The Heirs won every battle, hacked their fathers apart in their own halls, and changed nothing: the fathers were back at their desks within the week, stitched, lacquered and furious, and sent their children to the jar. The Heirs' banner, a hand cut off at the wrist, still hangs in the Sinks. Thirteen years later, in 301, the Hand-lines announced what some of them had known for decades: their touch could finish a person. They did not give it away. The Court set a price and built the Hall of Closings, and made death scarce on purpose.

THE HUSHES

In Carving of 633, a ferryman poling past Dunmere at dawn could not hear the village dogs, or his pole in the water, or himself shouting. Everyone in the village was simply, properly dead. When the news reached Lastgate, half the country wept with envy. Seventeen more Hushes have been found since, some no bigger than a room, every one within a day of a Hand-line estate.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

Sallowreach is governed by **the Mortuary Court**, a council of the Hand-lines seated in the Hall of Hands, under a Regent, Ansel Grue, who has held the post since 341 A.G. The Court makes law, levies the fly-tax and the stitching-tithe, licenses every Closing, and judges every capital crime, of which there is only one penalty that matters.

Property never passes. Owners never die. The oldest Kept, called **the Unvacated**, hold every title, deed and office in the

country. A house built in 150 A.G. belongs to the man who built it. A seat on a guild council is held by whoever first sat in it. A living man of seventy is legally a minor if his father is still upright, and cannot sign a lease, marry without consent, or vote in a guild. The living are tenants, clerks, apprentices and servants of the dead, and will be until they join them.

Death is the only currency of power. A Closing costs more than a house. The Court grants Closings as rewards (to loyal

officers, to the parents of useful men), withholds them as punishment, and sells them by license to those who can pay. The Court's worst sentence is the opposite of death: to be **jarred**, Kept forever in pieces in the Jar Room. Lesser crimes are punished by fines, by flogging (it heals badly on the Kept and never closes), by *unstitching* (the removal of the Seamers' work, a public humiliation), and by **refusal**, the striking of a name from the Court's Closing ledger forever.

Courts in Sallowreach hear cases between parties who were wronged three hundred years ago and are still present to give evidence. Statutes of limitation do not exist. Murder, as a crime, is hard to define: the Stitching Laws class it as *grievous unmaking* and

punish it by the cost of repair. The only true murder in Sallowreach is an unlicensed Closing, and it is punished with the jar.

EXAMPLE – THE CASE OF THE THIRTY-YEAR DEBT

A cooper named Wenna Hale borrowed sixty lacks from a moneylender in 589 to pay for her mother's restitching. She died in a boating accident in 602, came back, and kept working. In 640 the moneylender, who died in 410, sued her for the debt and thirty-eight years' interest. The court ruled that a dead debtor is the same person as a living one. Wenna's Kept mother, who lives with her, testified that the money had been well spent. Wenna now works for the moneylender, unpaid, until 731.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

Keeping. Families are responsible for their dead. Six or seven generations share a house: the living on the ground floor and in the kitchen, the Kept upstairs in the cool rooms with the shutters closed. Grandmothers are restitched each spring in Restitching Week. Kept relatives sit at table, mind the children, mend nets, complain. The quarrel over whose turn it is to keep great-great-grandfather is the standard subject of comedy; the play *Uncle on the Stair*, in which three brothers try to lose the old man in Lastgate and he keeps coming back, has run since 340.

Smell. Everyone carries perfume, vinegar or smoke. Scent is class. The rich smell of cedar, myrrh and ambergris, burned in braziers at their doors and soaked into their clothes. The middling smell of lavender and vinegar. The poor smell of peat smoke, and when they cannot afford it, of themselves. A pomander is a gift for a betrothal. Sniffing in company is extremely rude.

Dress. High collars, long sleeves, gloves and veils, to cover seams. Linen is preferred because it can be boiled; wool takes the smell and keeps it. The Kept favor wrapping: strips of waxed linen, wound tight, which hold things in. The Hand-lines wear mittens at the Appetite and gloves after, black kid sewn at the wrists. Never offer to shake a Sallowreacher's hand.

Food. The living eat eel (lively), reed-bread, fen-mushroom, pickled everything, and imported Fatlands meat at feasts. Vinegar is in every dish. Stilled meat, closed by a licensed butcher, is a luxury. A dish of lively eel is eaten quickly, with a strong jaw, and washed down with *sour*, a peat-smoked beer. The Kept do not need to eat. Many still sit at table and chew, for company, and spit into a dish.

Marriage. Vows in Sallowreach end with *until finished*, which once meant something. Widowhood does not exist. A spouse who died is still a spouse, and remarriage is bigamy. Many marriages carry on between the living and the Kept, and what passes between them behind the shutters is a matter the Court does not regulate and no one discusses; the word for it is *coldbed*, and it is said only by the

rude. A living person may petition for a *setting-apart*, which is not a divorce but a court order permitting them to live in another house from their Kept spouse. It requires the spouse's consent. Henna Farrow has filed forty-one times.

Children. Living children grow up surrounded by the dead and are fearless about it. They are trained young to hold a lamp for a Seamer, to tie a wrap, and never to stare. Children who die stay the age they died, forever. The Smalls, the child-dead of the Drowned Storeys, have their own society and their own queen. The living do not speak of them at dinner.

Setting Aside. When someone is too far gone to stand, they are wrapped, labeled and shelved in the Lofts, still aware. This is the nearest thing to a funeral. The family gathers and the wrapper winds the linen from the feet up, and the family speaks to the face until it is covered. Families visit on feast days and read aloud: letters, news, the old one's favorite books. Many do not visit. The Wardens read to those.

Proverbs. *May you finish* is the polite greeting. *Long life* is the worst curse. *Mind your stitches* means be careful. *He'll keep* means a problem can wait forever. *Fresh as a Glad Century fiddler* means hopelessly out of date. *The Court has hands* means you cannot escape it. *Close the book* means end an argument by force.

Oaths on the dead. Sallowreachers swear by their dead in the literal sense. The strongest oath is sworn with the right hand placed inside the mouth of a Kept parent, who must consent and must be able to bite. To break such an oath is to invite the parent to close their jaw, and the oldest jaws in Lastgate are wired shut until a promise falls due. Debts sworn this way are the only ones the moneylenders trust.

Crime. Theft, fraud and debt are common. Violence is cheap but pointless, since it kills nobody; Sallowreach's criminals specialize in leverage. The worst crimes are part-theft (see Marrow Jack), unlicensed Closing, and *stilling*, the illegal sale of closed meat.

Tablenight. On the longest night of Lack, the living cook a banquet for their dead, who cannot taste it, and everyone pretends. The table is laid with the best plates. The Kept are dressed, lacquered and seated. The living serve. Everyone eats, the living swallowing and the Kept chewing and spitting. Speeches are made praising the food. At midnight the eldest present says “May we all finish,” and the room drinks. In the old houses of the Upper Boards one chair at the end of the table is always left empty, and nobody can say for whom. When asked, the Unvacated say only that it was always so, and that it would be rude to sit there.

THE CLOSING

The only good death in Sallowreach is bought. A licensed Closing follows a rite fixed by the Court in 301 and never altered.

From A Fair Copy of the Proceedings at the Hall of Closings, prepared for the family of Mr. Josiah Rook, deceased 517 A.G., closed 641 A.G. Witnessed by Bram Hollin, mourner.

At the third bell the Closer's clerk called the name. Mr. Rook was carried into Chamber Four on his board by his two great-grandsons, who are sixty and fifty-eight. He had dressed for it. He had been dead one hundred and twenty-four years and the Guild had done its best for him that morning, but the lacquer was fresh and still soft and under it he was mostly brown and black, and the smell in a small cedar room was very great. The great-grandsons breathed through their mouths. Mr. Rook said, “Do not make faces, boys, it is my day.”

The clerk read the license aloud: the number, the fee paid (four thousand two hundred lacks, in platters, by the sale of the house on Tanner's Boards), the Regent's signature, the date. Mr. Rook was asked three times if he wished to finish. He said yes three times, the third time very loudly.

Then the family said what they had to say. The younger great-grandson read out a letter from Mr. Rook's wife, who is shelved in the Lofts and could not come, saying she would see him soon, which everyone understood was not true. Mr. Rook asked for the letter to be put in his hand. His fingers would not close on it. I closed them for him, and he thanked me.

Lady Corrow Vane came in last. She did not speak. She is tall and very still and smells of nothing at all, which in that room

was the most frightening thing. Her gloves are black and sewn on at the wrist. Her clerk unpicked the stitches of the right glove, nine of them, and drew it off, and we saw her hand.

I have been asked to describe it for the family record and I will try. It was grey, as they say, a cold slate grey, and very long. The fingers had too many joints and moved one at a time, like a creature testing a branch. The room got colder. My breath showed. The flies on the window, which had been ticking all morning, stopped.

Mr. Rook was crying. He said, “Is it going to hurt?” Lady Vane did not answer. I said the words of the old rite, which I had from my mother: Hand that closes, close this. What was opened, shut. What was begun, end. Lady Vane laid her hand over his eyes.

It did not take long. There was a sound like a breath going out of a room, though he had not breathed in a century. He went still, and then he went on going still, past any stillness I have seen, and the long rot caught up with him all at once. His face sank. The lacquer cracked. The smell came up out of him in one great wave, all of the hundred and twenty-four years of it, and the younger boy fell to his knees and was sick, and then, all at once, it was gone. There was no smell. There was only a man on a board, properly dead, and grey dust settling in the folds of his good coat.

The great-grandsons sat with him for a long while. Lady Vane's clerk stitched the glove back on. She did not look at the body. She looked at the floor, and then she went out to Chamber Five, where the next license was waiting.

THE CLOSING IN PLAY

A Closing requires a licensed Closer at the Course or beyond, the subject's consent (the Court is strict on this, at least in public), and the license. A PC Hand-line at the Course can perform one with a Routine Hand + Rites roll; the Closer gains 1 Hunger. Witnessing a Closing is Dread 2. Performing one without a license is the crime of unlicensed Closing, punished by the jar, and every Heir and every grandmother in the country knows the PC can do it.

▼ FACTIONS

THE MORTUARY COURT

The Hand-lines nobility: Grue, Vane, Sedge, Hethe and a dozen lesser houses. Sellers of death, hoarders of it, and increasingly afraid of their own hands. The Court believes in order: that a country of

the undying must be governed by the oldest, that death is too precious to give away, and that the Hand-lines were chosen by the god to ration its mercy. What it wants now is to survive its own success. It knows the Hushes follow its blood. Its factions are split between those who would wall up the Course-stricken in lead (the

Leaden party), those who would sell the Hushes as estates (the Quiet Market), and a very few who suspect that being closed like a book might be the god’s kindness to the land.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Glovebearer	A clerk’s post; carries a Closer’s gloves; access to the Hall of Closings
2	Licenser	Drafts and seals licenses; may bend a waiting list by one name a season
3	Closer	Performs Closings; a salary of 40 lacks a day and a house on the Upper Boards
4	Hand of the Court	A seat on the Court; may grant one Closing a year without fee
5	Left or Right Hand	Commands the Closers or the Court’s agents; answers only to the Regent

Joining: Hand-line blood is required beyond the second rank. Outsiders serve as Glovebearers, agents, spies and enforcers. **Enemies:** the Heirs, the Finishers, Reckoners. **Allies:** the Unvacated; uneasily, the Seamers’ Guild.

THE SEAMERS' GUILD

Stitchers, embalmers, lacquerers and wire-workers who hold the population together. Every Kept body in Sallowreach owes its shape

to the Guild, and every family owes it money. The Guild believes in craft and in continuance: that a well-kept body is a dignity and a duty. What it wants is pay, respect, and to be left alone. A Seamers’ strike would be a national collapse within a month, and the Guild has threatened one only once, in 459, when the Court tried to tax wire. The tax was withdrawn in nine days, by which time the Sinks were knee-deep in what had fallen off people.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Threader	Apprenticeship; a needle-case; board and a cot on Needle Street
2	Journeyman	Licensed to restitch; a client list of thirty families
3	Seamer	Wire-work and lacquer; may take apprentices; Stitching training
4	Master of the Seam	A shop of one’s own; Guild vote; access to the Guild’s stock of spare parts
5	Master Seamer	Head of the Guild; may call a strike

Joining: any PC with Stitching 1 can be taken on as a Threader. **Enemies:** Marrow Jack and the back-alley seamers. **Allies:** everyone, by necessity.

THE HEIRS

The living young, permanently disinherited: everyone in Sallowreach under three hundred who still has a pulse and a parent.

Most Heirs are clerks, servants and laborers in their forties and fifties who have never owned a pot. Some want reform: inheritance at the Setting Aside, votes for the living, a cap on Unvacated office. Some want every Unvacated elder dragged to a Hush. Since the Hushes appeared, for the first time in six centuries, the second group has had a method, and the first has had trouble arguing with them.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Minor	Membership; a cut-hand token; a safehouse bed in the Sinks
2	Pamphleteer	Access to the presses and the Smoking Ground meetings
3	Bequeather	Command of a cell of twelve; access to the cell’s weapons and punts
4	Executor	A seat at Jory Welt’s table; knowledge of the Hush map
5	The Boy	Leader of the Heirs (held by Jory Welt)

Joining: be living and disinherited, or help with something that cannot be undone. **Enemies:** the Court, the Unvacated. **Allies:** the Finishers, sometimes; the Purgation, dangerously.

Statement of Corlis Mead, aged fifty-three, given to the Court’s examiners in the matter of the late Alderman Hollis Mead. Taken down by a clerk.

He was my father and he was three hundred and two. He was a good alderman. He never once let me sign for anything. I was fifty-three and I still asked him for my wages every Plenty-day and he gave me eight lacks and told me to make them last.

We did it at night. My brother Tobin and my sister and me. We had the punt ready. We had the sack. We didn't hurt him more than we had to. You can't hurt them, you know, not in a way that stops anything. That's the thing. My great-grandfather tried to kill him in the War of the Heirs, with a halberd, in the year 288. Took his head clean off. Father had it sewn on and sat in the same chair the next week and sent great-grandfather to the jar. He's still in there. Third shelf from the door.

So we didn't try to kill him. We tied him. He said, Corlis, what is this. He said, I am your father. I said I knew. He said, I will forgive you if you untie me now, and he said it the way he always said it, the way he said it when I was six. And I nearly did.

It took four hours to pole to the edge of the Dunmere Hush. He talked the whole way. He said he had loved our mother. He said he was sorry about the house. He offered me the house. He offered me the boat. Then he stopped offering and started screaming, but there's a way the Breath takes a scream on open water, it just sort of soaks it up.

At the edge the reeds go grey. You can see the line. The birds go over it and drop. We pulled him out of the punt and he was fighting and he got his teeth into Tobin's arm, and Tobin was crying, and we dragged him the last ten yards on his back through the reeds. When his head went over the line he went quiet. Not quiet like stopped talking. Quiet like there had never been any sound in him. His mouth was still open. And

then the rest of him came across and he just went soft and settled into the reeds like a coat dropped on a chair.

He looked peaceful. I want that written down. He looked like he had never been angry with anybody.

We stood there a long time. My sister said, We should say something. And none of us could think of anything, because none of us had ever been to a funeral. Nobody had, not for six hundred years.

Then I went home and sat in his chair. It's my chair now. I'm the eldest. You can jar me if you like. I'll keep.

THE FINISHERS

A death cult in the plainest sense, and the fastest-growing faith in the north. The Finishers believe that the Hushes are Ossel's mercy returning, that the god never wanted to be eaten and is calling its people home, and that to walk into a Hush is to be closed by the god's own hand instead of a Court official's. They make pilgrimage to the Hushes in long, singing processions, mostly of the Kept, carrying candles and the names of the dead, and they walk in. The Court calls it theft of a licensed good and has posted guards at the larger Hushes. The guards are Kept, and some of them have walked in too.

The Finishers' songs have last verses, which in Sallowreach is a revolutionary act. They are sung at the edge of the grey reeds, and the singers go over the line one by one, and the song gets thinner and thinner as it goes, until there is no one left outside to finish it. Those who remain behind are the worst of it: the living children of Kept parents who went in, the husbands who held their wives' hands to the edge and could not follow, because the living who enter a Hush die too, and do not come back, and the Finishers do not want them yet. The Court records the number of pilgrims. Nobody records the number of people who stood at the edge and watched someone they loved go quiet.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Walker	A candle and a pilgrim's name-strip; the Finishers' hospitality
2	Singer	Leads a procession's song; knows the routes past the Court's guards
3	Lamp	Leads a pilgrimage; may bless; knows the secret Hushes
4	Shut Eye	A voice in the cult's councils; is told where new Hushes form
5	High Shut Eye	High priest (held by Sister Lorn)

Joining: carry a candle and a name to the edge, and come back.

Enemies: the Court, the Seamers' Guild (who lose customers).

Allies: the Loft-Wardens, quietly; the Heirs, by convenience.

HANDLING THE FINISHERS

The Finishers are a portrait of despair in a land that has no exit, and the pull of a god that offers one. Play them as tragedy. Their pilgrims are tired, frightened, often kind, and they have been suffering for longer than any human being was meant to. The horror is not the walking in; it is what it says about a country that this is the only door, and who it leaves behind. Never present a pilgrimage as triumphant or a Hush as an attractive solution for the living. Focus scenes on the people at the edge.

THE LOFT-WARDENS

Keepers of the Set-Aside: quiet, underpaid, and in possession of forty thousand witnesses who hear everything. The shelved Kept cannot move but can listen, and the Lofts are built against the walls of Lastgate's oldest streets. Every conversation in nine storeys of the north city is overheard by somebody wrapped on a shelf, and the Wardens read to the shelved every night and write down what they whisper back. The Wardens believe in attendance: that no one should be left alone in the dark. What they want is pay, more linen, and for the families to visit. What they have, without much wanting it, is the best intelligence service on the Table.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Ladder-hand	A lamp, a key to one hall, and a list of the shelved to read to
2	Reader	Access to the whisper-books of one hall
3	Warden of a Hall	Command of a hall's staff; the right to move the shelved
4	Senior Warden	Access to all whisper-books; may sell what is in them
5	Warden of the Lofts	Keeper of the whole (held by Old Bettany Shroud)

Joining: read aloud to the shelved for a season without pay.

Enemies: Marrow Jack. **Allies:** the Seamers, the Finishers.

POWERS FROM ABROAD

The Cutwrights' College keeps its northern ledgers in Lastgate under Provost Carrion Sedge, and those ledgers are now the most dangerous documents in the land. **The Purgation** has a small, fanatical following among the Heirs, who argue that the god can be thrown up if the Hand-lines are emptied of it; their method is the Sump. **The Second Table** has members on the Mortuary Court and wants Osric Vane's hands for the second meal (see Lord Absalom Hethe). **The Reckoners** have raided Sallowreach six times since 402 and learned that their blades are useless here; the last of them, Withhold Pennick, is stranded in Lastgate. **The Rim Road Company** runs the border inn at the Finishing Post and clears the heap.

▼ SALLOWREACH NOW

Sallowreach has started to end. The Hushes are multiplying, eighteen now, and they appear fastest near Hand-line estates. The Court has realized what that means: the nobility is the god's way back, and the country will not be freed from undeath so much as closed like a book. Provost Carrion Sedge can prove it. The Court's answer, so far, is lead mittens, locked wings and silence.

Meanwhile the Vigil's envoy, Castellan Dray, has taken rooms on the Upper Boards and is offering Regent Grue the oil of a nation for the secret of Keeping. The Finishers have tripled in a year. A Scrapling girl in the Sinks can close things with her hands. The forty thousand in the Lofts have begun, all of them, to whisper the same word. And the Heirs have noticed that, for the first time in six centuries, an elder can be made to die.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ **The Deadwatch.** Castellan Dray hires the PCs as guides and bodyguards while he negotiates. The Regent is tempted. The secret of Keeping is not a secret: it is the god in the soil, and the Vigil would have to move to Sallowreach to use it. Dray knows this. His real commission is to find out how many Vigil citizens Sallowreach could house.
- ◇ **The Glovehall Garden.** The Hush behind Glovehall grew three yards last week. Lady Corrow Vane hires the PCs to measure it secretly, nightly, and to find out whether it is growing from her brother's wing or from her own bedroom.

- ◇ **The Little Closer.** The Court, the Finishers, the Cutwrights and Marrow Jack all want Pim Sorrel. Her mother hires the PCs to get her across the border, where the Closing touch might stop. It might not. And the girl does not want to leave.
- ◇ **Sack Seventeen.** A Sump dredger has hauled up a sack whose occupant claims to be a Regent of Sallowreach older than Ansel Grue, sunk for treason in 340. If true, Grue's appointment was illegal and every license he ever signed is void.
- ◇ **The Last Verse.** Bram Hollin has been hired to mourn the first proper funeral in Lastgate in six hundred years, for a living woman closed by accident. The family wants it done right. Halfway through the rite, the corpse begins to whisper the same word as the Lofts.

RUMORS OF THE FEN

DIO	RUMOR
1	The Regent has not signed his own Closing because he has already tried, and Corrow Vane's hand did not work on him. (True.)
2	Hushes can be carried. Finishers bring back grey reeds in boxes, and where they plant them, silence grows. (False, but the Finishers believe it.)
3	Wick Tallow's candles are made only from the unclaimed. (False. Some families sell.)
4	The word the Lofts are whispering is "company." (True.)
5	Marrow Jack is a Seamer of the Guild. (Half true. He was.)
6	Outsiders who die in Sallowreach can leave if they are carried across before sundown. (False, and cruelly so.)
7	Captain Morrow's soldiers are finding parts of him in the barracks. (True.)
8	The Court is building a lead-lined vault under the Hall of Hands to hold the Hand-line children. (True.)
9	Mother Gall's brine can cure the Kept of rot. (False. It only halts it, while they stay in the barrel.)
10	A Hush opened in the Jar Room last month and closed nine prisoners, and the Court has hidden it. (True; the nine were the oldest jars.)

THE PEOPLE OF SALLOWREACH

ANSEL GRUE – THE UNVACATED REGENT

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Clause 5, Persuade 4, Resolve 5, Lore 4, Intimidate 3
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 11 · Armor 2 (lacquer and wire) · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none worth the name; he has never needed one
GIFTS	Kept; The Shutting (ends any argument in his presence with a Routine Tongue + Clause roll); four hundred years of precedent
WANTS	Close (cannot leave a ledger unsigned or a door ajar); Endure (refuses every ending, including his own)
DREAD	2 (to watch him move)
SECRET	He asked Corrow Vane to close him in 610. Her hand did nothing. He does not know if he is beyond closing or if she held back.

Ansel Grue, the Unvacated Regent. Four hundred and twelve years old, three hundred of them in office. Grue died in 371 of a fall from a horse, and has been mostly wire, lacquer and habit since. He sits in a high chair in the Hall of Hands with his jaw wired shut and his face lacquered to a deep glossy amber, like a violin. Up close he smells of cedar, varnish and, faintly, sweet, like a bowl of fruit forgotten in a warm room. He speaks through a brass tube set into

his throat, in a dry clicking voice that makes clerks lean in. He signs every death license personally, by hand, a slow, beautiful signature that takes a minute each. He has never once considered signing his own, or says he has not. What Grue fears is not death. It is the end of order, and the Hushes, which close without license, are disorder in its purest form. PCs meet him if they petition the Court, or if they become a threat to it.

LADY CORROW VANE – THE LEFT HAND OF THE COURT

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Rites 4, Persuade 3, Instinct 3, Clause 2, Stitching 2
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	Closing Touch +8 (finishes a Kept target outright; a living target makes a Grim Caul + Resolve check or falls to Ruin and the Kept); stiletto +5 (2)
GIFTS	The Closing Touch; Coldprint (her bare hand frosts metal and glass); Lidsense
WANTS	Close; Quiet (cannot bear laughter near her)
DREAD	2 (to see her gloves come off)
SECRET	The Hush at Glovehall is growing from her rooms, not her brother's. She has measured it.

Lady Corrow Vane, the Left Hand of the Court. The Court's chief Closer, sixty-one years old and living. She has finished eleven thousand people by touch, at a price. She is tall, pale and composed,

with ash-blond hair worn in a severe coil and a face that rarely moves. She smells of nothing at all, which is the first thing people notice and the thing they remember. Her gloves are black kid, sewn

on at the wrist by her clerk, and unpicked nine stitches at a time. She has never held her own children. Her two sons were raised by nurses and taught to keep three paces from her; one is forty and has never touched his mother's skin. She speaks briefly and with

exquisite courtesy. She is afraid of only one thing, and it is herself. PCs meet her at a Closing, or when the Court needs agents it can deny.

OSRIC VANE – THE GLOVED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 8
SKILLS	Rites 4, Godsign 5, Instinct 4, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 (lead mittens count as Armor 4 to his hands only) · Fray 8
ATTACKS	Bare touch +9 (finishes anything; Dread 4 to witness)
GIFTS	The Closing Touch; Hushing (sound dies within ten paces); Closing Gaze (a minute's stare finishes a candle, a fly, a conversation, a Kept man)
WANTS	Close; Be of Use
DREAD	3 (in the same room); 4 (unmittened)
SECRET	He has been finishing his guards through the door, by stare, one a month, for a year. They are replaced. He keeps count.

Osric Vane, the Gloved. Corrow's brother, fifty-four, deep in the Course and now at its Brink. His hands are grey, long and have nine joints a finger; they fold like fans and click like abacus beads in a room that has gone too quiet to carry the sound. He is kept in lead mittens, padlocked at the wrist, in a locked wing of Glovehall where

no fly lives. His face has gone smooth and soft-featured and faintly smiling. He is gentle, well read and lonely, and he has begun asking politely to be used on the enemy: the Reckoners, the Fast, anyone. *I should like to be useful*, he says. *I should like to be put somewhere I can do good.* Lord Absalom Hethe has offered him exactly that.

THESSALY MORT – MASTER SEAMER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 1
SKILLS	Stitching 6, Craft 4, Reckoning 3, Haggle 3, Endure 4
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Armor 3 (wire lattice) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	curved needle +6 (2, and she can unstitch a Kept limb on a Helping)
GIFTS	Kept; can restitch a Ruined Kept body in an hour
WANTS	Keep Count (must record every replaced part)
DREAD	2 (to see her ledger)
SECRET	Her ledger lists her original parts. It is three lines long: left eye, two fingers of the right hand, and “the part that remembers.”

Thessaly Mort, Master Seamer. Head of the Guild for a hundred and ninety years. She has replaced so much of herself over two centuries that she keeps a ledger of which parts were hers originally. The ledger is short. She is a patchwork of a dozen donors in a dozen skin tones, wired at the joints, seams lacquered in cedar-gold so that she glimmers like a cracked bowl mended in a fine shop. She smells of wax thread, pitch and spirits. Her voice is a borrowed one, deep

and pleasant, from a larynx she bought in 498. She is practical, brisk, and the most powerful person in Sallowreach after the Regent, because she could stop the country in a month. She fears that she is no longer anyone. She pays well for odd jobs: recovering stolen parts, shutting down back-alley seamers, finding out what Marrow Jack does with his stock.

JORY WELT – THE BOY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Reckoning 3, Blades 3, Stealth 2, Wayfaring 3
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	boathook +6 (4); knife +6 (2)
GIFTS	none; he is entirely ordinary, which is his strength
WANTS	none; his compulsions are his own
DREAD	0
SECRET	His father, Alderman Rufus Welt, is his son's most generous anonymous donor, and wants to be the first taken to the Hush. Jory cannot do it.

Jory Welt, the Boy. Seventy-one years old and legally a child, since his father is three hundred and upright. He leads the Heirs. He is stooped, white-whiskered and arthritic, and his voice still cracks with anger like a youth's. He lives in two rooms over a tannery in the Sinks, smelling of oak bark and old dogs, and he has a map of every Hush pinned to his wall, measured weekly, with pins for the Hand-line estates. He has dragged elders to the edge. He has watched them go soft. He is tired, and very gentle with children, and he has begun to wonder whether the Heirs have won or merely discovered a new way to bury their parents without mourning them.

Old Bettany Shroud, Loft-Warden. Keeper of forty thousand shelved dead, eighty-eight and living. She is small and bent and wrapped in shawls that smell of camphor, and her fingers are stained with ink to the second knuckle. She reads to the shelved every night, a hall at a time, and writes down what they whisper back, in a hundred and twelve whisper-books going back fifty years. She knows every secret in north Lastgate, and has never sold one. Lately they all whisper the same word: *company*. They whisper it as if someone is coming up the stairs. Bettany does not know what it means. She has been sleeping in the Lofts, on a cot between the shelves, so that they will not be alone when it arrives.

OLD BETTANY SHROUD Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack +1 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Pim Sorrel, the Scrap Finisher. A Scrapling girl of twelve from the Sinks, thin, freckled, quick, smelling of peat smoke and eel. Her touch ends things, which should be impossible for her blood. It began a year ago with a cat that had been crushed by a cart and could not stop crying; she picked it up and it was quiet. Since then she has closed a neighbor's grandfather, two Smalls who asked her to, and a candle she did not mean to. Her hands are not grey. They are ordinary, warm, a child's hands, with bitten nails. The Court wants her dissected. The Finishers want her crowned. She wants to go to school. GM options for her secret: she is a Vane bastard's granddaughter (Sedge's ledgers say so); or Ossel, growing back, is

reaching through the least of its eaters first; or the face the Scraplings ate is waking.

Justice Ever Lathe, the Honorable Maggot. A judge of the Court of Wrongs, Kept since 389, rotted down to bone, a few black tendons and a resident colony. He sits in a robe of office that seethes. The colony has worked its way through every soft part of him and taken up residence in the skull, and his rulings are delivered in the buzzing: a thick drone that rises and falls in cadences like speech. His clerk, Absalom Pike, translates. Lathe's judgments are famously fair. Nobody is sure any longer which of them is deciding, Lathe, the flies or Pike, and nobody wants to find out, because the conviction rate has never been better.

JUSTICE EVER LATHE Threat 4 · Flesh 6 · Guard 9 · Attack +3 (swarm 1, blinds on a Helping) · Armor 0 · Dread 2

Dr. Halloran Quease. A physician in a land where no illness is fatal. He has made pain his whole study, since it is the one ailment left, and he has catalogued four hundred kinds, from *the long bell* (the pain of a seam pulling through) to *the attic* (the pain of being shelved and forgotten). He is living, fifty, plump, scrupulously clean, smelling of carbolic and lemon. He keeps meticulous notes and Kept volunteers in his surgery, who allow him to test on them in return for opiates. He is kind to them. He wants to end pain. He fears that he enjoys measuring it. He pays PCs to bring him new kinds.

Wick Tallow, the Chandler. He renders the unclaimed dead into candles that feel themselves burn. His shop on Wick Lane smells of hot fat, smoke and something like singed hair, and the candles on his shelves are yellow, smooth and very slightly warm. They give a very steady light; they do not gutter, because they are trying not to. Half of Lastgate reads by people it used to know. If you hold a Tallow candle close, you can hear it, very faintly, a thin high sound like a kettle a long way off. Wick is a cheerful, practical man with burn-scarred forearms who sees nothing wrong with any of this. The dead are unclaimed; the light is needed. He has begun to take commissions from families.

WICK TALLOW Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (rendering

hook 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

SISTER LORN OF THE SHUT EYE – HIGH SHUT EYE OF THE FINISHERS

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Resolve 3, Wayfaring 3, Lore 2
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 9
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	Kept; the Last Verse (her singing grants all who hear it +2 to resist Dread for a scene)
WANTS	Lead
DREAD	1
SECRET	She has stood at the edge nine hundred times and walked in once, in the night, alone. She stopped one step from the line. She cannot forgive herself either way.

Sister Lorn of the Shut Eye. High priest of the Finishers, Kept since 590, slender and wrapped in grey linen, one eye stitched shut in the old fashion of mourning. She smells of beeswax and fen-mint, which she chews constantly. Her singing voice is extraordinary, low and kind. She has led nine hundred pilgrims into the Hushes and

has stayed outside every time, saying someone must. Her flock has started asking why. She does not know the answer. She tells herself it is duty. She fears it is cowardice, or worse, that she enjoys the walking back. PCs meet her at the edge of a Hush, or when a family hires them to bring someone home before the singing stops.

CAPTAIN DACE MORROW – THE SIXTY-TIMES SLAIN

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 1 · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Blades 5, Endure 6, Intimidate 4, Wayfaring 3, Reckoning 2
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 16 · Armor 3 (bone lamellar over wire) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	sword +9 (4); he does not stop
GIFTS	Kept; Thread-Bound (ignores the first Ruin each scene)
WANTS	Hold the Line
DREAD	2
SECRET	The pieces he leaves in the barracks are deliberate. He is trying to get a little of himself across the border without dying, a finger at a time. None of it has survived.

Captain Dace Morrow, the Sixty-Times Slain. Commander of the Fen Guard, an army that cannot lose a man and cannot cross a border. He has been killed sixty times, by Reckoners, smugglers, Heirs and once by his own horse, and stitched back after each. He is more thread than soldier now: a tall figure bound in grey cord, wire and leather, his face held on by a lattice of brass. He smells of oil and old blood and wet rope. He is laconic, decent and very tired, and he has started deserting in small pieces. A finger is found on the parade ground. An ear in the mess. His sergeants gather them in a box and do not report it.

Henna Farrow, the Widow Unmade. Her husband Amos died ninety years ago, of a fever, and still comes home each evening from a job at the weir that was abolished in 570. He opens the door, says

“Something smells good, Hen,” and sits down. He does not know. He has never known. His face has long since gone, and the Guild keeps a lacquered mask on him with a painted smile. Henna is a hundred and twelve, living, bent double, smelling of lye and lavender. She has petitioned for his Closing forty-one times. The Court refuses because Amos must consent, and to consent he would have to be told. She sets his place anyway, every night, and cooks his favorite, and scrapes it into the eel barrel. She would like the PCs to tell him.

Grandfather Peat. A bog body hauled from the Sump in 611, who drowned the week of the Gorging. He is leather-brown, flattened, shining wet, with a fringe of red hair and a rope still knotted at his throat, and he smells of peat, tannin and old

rainwater. He speaks a dead dialect that only a few Cutwrights can follow. He is the last witness to the Night of Seven Tables, and he repeats one thing: the god was smiling. Asked more, he holds up his fingers and counts, slowly, to eight, then folds one down very carefully as if it might bite. The College keeps him in a tank in Sedge’s offices. He would like to go back in the water.

GRANDFATHER PEAT Threat 1 · Flesh 8 · Guard 8 · Attack +0 · Armor 1 · Dread 2

Tam Ruddock, the Lastgate Ferryman. He poles a long black punt from the border road across the Landing, and for a heavy fee he smuggles the dying of other lands across the border so they will not die: Fatlanders with wasting sickness, Brinehollowers Called too far, Vigil sleepers on stretchers. They do not die. He has never told a single one of them what happens next, and he sleeps badly. He is forty, heavy, with a broken nose and a soft voice, and he smells of tar and rum. He keeps a list of every passenger, and on his days off he visits them. Idony Pask was one. She has never forgiven him, and he visits her most.

MARROW JACK – THE PART-THIEF	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Scrapling) · Regrowth 0 · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Stitching 4, Filch 5, Stealth 5, Blades 3, Haggle 4
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	bone-saw +8 (3, takes a limb from a Kept target on a Helping); knife +8 (2)
GIFTS	none; skill only
WANTS	none
DREAD	2 (his stock room)
SECRET	He was a Guild Journeyman under Thessaly Mort, and he supplies her. A third of the parts in the Guild’s stores came from him.

Marrow Jack. A part-thief, thin as wire, with a pleasant freckled face and hands that never stop moving. He smells of clove oil, which he uses to cover his trade. He takes limbs from the Kept while they shelve in the Lofts or lie in the slow stupor some of them call sleep, and sells them to back-alley seamers in the Sinks: an arm to a woman whose own has rotted through, a jaw to a Kept singer, a whole pair of hands to buyers who will not say why. He works the Lofts, the Sump (dredging sacks for usable stock) and the potter’s corners where the unclaimed are left. His victims wake able to feel what their missing hands are being used for. Some of them have tracked him by it. One of them is in his stock room now, in eleven pieces, and he does not know what to do with her.

Little Nell Ash, Queen of the Smalls. She died of a fever at seven, in 441, and has been seven since. She rules the child-dead of Lastgate’s Drowned Storeys from a throne of a waterlogged armchair in a flooded schoolroom, crowned with a ring of tarnished spoons. She is small, grey-green, very carefully stitched by Smalls who taught themselves, and she smells of canal water and the violet sweets she cannot eat but likes to hold. She has a two-century-old mind and a seven-year-old’s sense of fairness: absolute, unforgiving and sometimes very funny. The Smalls do not grow up, ever; she has kept them safe, mostly, from the Court and from Marrow Jack. She wants Pim Sorrel for herself. Several of the Smalls have asked to be closed, and Nell has not decided whether to let them.

Provost Carrion Sedge. Head of the Cutwrights’ College in the north, Hand-line by birth, Kept since 598. Gaunt, ink-stained,

lacquered in a dull brown that smells of old paper and the glue of bindings. His ledgers prove that the Hushes follow Hand-line blood exactly; plotted on a map, every Hush is a family tree. He has not decided which is worse: publishing it, which would bring the Heirs to every Hand-line nursery, or selling it, to the Court, the Second Table, or the Vigil’s envoy, who has asked. He is also Hand-line, at the Taste, and has found himself closing his ledgers too firmly, and sometimes being unable to open them again.

Mother Gall. A fen witch who pickles. She is enormous, red-handed, cheerful, and smells overwhelmingly of brine, dill and garlic. In the right brine, a recipe she will not share, she can keep a body sound for a century: no rot, no flies, no further decay, so long as it stays submerged. Her cellar under Brinemoss holds four hundred customers in barrels, paid up in advance, all wide awake, all blinking up through the green. Some have been in for ninety years. They cannot speak; they knock. She charges for visiting. She is the closest thing to a cure in the north, and she knows it is not one.

Edda Thrush, the Hushwalker. A Court surveyor who walked into Dunmere Hush with a chain and a theodolite in 638 and walked out again three hours later. Nobody else has. She cannot hear anything now, and insists that this is not deafness: something is listening in her place. She is forty, living, with a cropped head and grey-streaked eyebrows, and she smells of nothing at all. She speaks too loudly, then too softly, and sometimes stops mid-sentence and tilts her head, as though someone just behind her has cleared their throat. She has drawn the inside of Dunmere from memory. In the

center of her drawing is something she has not drawn, only left blank, very carefully.

Bram Hollin, the Last Mourner. His family were professional mourners, a trade six centuries extinct. He alone, by an unbroken line of fathers teaching sons for a job none of them could do, knows the full funeral rite by heart: the keening, the washing, the coin on the tongue, the six last songs. Now that people are dying again, everyone wants him. He is sixty, small, tidy, in a black coat green with age, and smells of rosemary. He weeps easily and professionally and, lately, privately. He did not know until this year what the songs were for.

Idony Pask, the Tourist. A Fatlands woman who came north with a wasting sickness so she would not die of it. She did not die of it. She died in 627 and kept going, and the sickness has not stopped. She is now very thin, then thinner: a creature of skin and bone wrapped in a Fatlands shawl, still hungry with her land’s bottomless hunger and unable to eat. She smells of sour milk and decay. She can never leave. She has written to her family in the south every week for fourteen years. They stopped replying. She is bright, bitter and good company, and she would like someone to take her letters south and tell her what they find.

NEW FACES

Fenwick Lisp, Interpreter of Jaw-Clicks. Kept since 501, gaunt and courteous, with a lacquered jaw of his own he clicks as he

thinks. He interprets for the jawless and tongueless of Lastgate, most famously in the Long Argument, and is the only person who understands either party. He has not translated accurately since 560. He has been running the argument himself, out of loneliness, and he is afraid both men know.

Merrit Cask, Keeper of the Jar Room. A living woman of forty-four who inherited the post from her Kept mother, who inherited it from hers. She dusts the jars, oils the lead seals, reads the labels aloud each morning and sweeps the drains. She smells of lamp oil and lye. Since nine of the oldest jars went silent last month, at once, she has heard the shelf whispering about who will be next, and has begun moving her chair further down the vault each night.

MERRIT CASK Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (cudgel 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

Withhold Pennick, the Stranded Reckoner. A wiry Unfed woman of thirty from the Fast who crossed in 639 to kill a Hand-line lord and did: she cut his throat in his bed. He sat up and called the guard. She has been hiding in the Sinks ever since, unable to complete her oath and unwilling to go home. She has learned the Hushes exist. She has begun to wonder whether she could drag a lord into one. She is clean-smelling, ascetic, appalled by everything, and slowly starving on food she will not eat.

LORD ABSALOM HETHE – HAND OF THE COURT, SECOND TABLE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Deceive 5, Clause 4, Persuade 4, Lore 3, Feast 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	rapier +5 (4)
GIFTS	Lidsense; The Shutting
WANTS	Close
DREAD	1
SECRET	He is the Second Table’s man on the Court. He plans to carry Osric Vane, in a lead coffin, to the Rim, and use the Brink-hands to close a regrowing god when it is ready to be eaten again.

Lord Absalom Hethe. A Hand-line lord of forty-eight, living, handsome, florid, smelling of myrrh and claret. He collects Fatlands recipes and old carvings of tables, and keeps a dining room with an eighth chair he will not let anyone sit in. He visits Osric Vane every week and is the only visitor who does not seem afraid.

Dunstan Reave, the Last of Dunmere. A reed-cutter, living, thirty-five, who was away at market the night his village went silent.

His wife, his Kept parents, his two children are lying in their kitchen four miles inside the grey. He camps at the edge every night with a spyglass, because from one spot, on a clear evening, he can see his own roof. He will guide anyone to the Hush for free, and asks only that they tell him, if they ever come back, whether they looked peaceful.

▼ PLAYING A SALLOWREACHER

You grew up with your great-great-grandmother in the attic and the smell of cedar in your clothes. You have held a lamp for a Seamer. You have never been to a funeral. You say *may you finish* to strangers and mean it kindly.

Attribute bonus: +1 HAND. Sallowreachers are stitchers, menders, eel-catchers and punt-men, and the Hand-lines rule them.

The Sop: close something that was meant to stay open. Shut the eyes of a sleeper; close a book someone is reading; snuff a lamp someone needs; end a conversation mid-sentence with a hand on the speaker's arm; shut a door on someone outside. It must matter to someone. The Sop removes 1d6 Hunger, and the Want to Close grows: for the rest of the day, resisting it is one step harder.

The Tooth: when a Sallowreacher Partakes, the fingers go cold to the second knuckle, the nearest flame leans away, and for a heartbeat every sound in the room drops, as if a door had shut somewhere. When the Tooth shows a 1, the god bites back: the character's hand closes involuntarily on whatever it holds, hard enough to crack a cup, and stays closed for a minute.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). *Lidsense:* you always know whether a door, lid, eye or book within ten paces is open or shut, even in darkness, and gain +2 to Search and Instinct rolls to notice concealed openings. *The Quiet Hand:* you can close any door, lid or shutter in perfect silence.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). *The Shutting:* once per scene, lay a hand on a speaker and make a Tongue + Rites roll against Hard; on success their current argument, threat or song ends, and they cannot recall where it was going. Costs 1 Hunger. *Cold Fingers:* +1 to Stitching (cold hands are steady), but you must wear mittens or gloves in company, and any bare-handed touch on a living person is a Dread 1 experience for them.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). *The Closing Touch:* bare hand, Hand + Rites against Routine to close a flame, a wound's pain, a fly-swarm (one cloud) or a Kept person. Closing a Kept person finishes them forever; it costs 1 Hunger and is murder without a license. Against a living target outside Sallowreach, the touch is an attack (Hand + Rites vs Guard) dealing 4 damage that ignores Armor. Inside Sallowreach, a living target touched with intent must succeed at a Grim Caul + Resolve check or fall to Ruin and rise Kept. *Long Hands:* your hands grow extra joints; +1 Filch and Stitching, and everyone who sees them bare makes a Dread 2 check.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). *Hushing:* by Partaking, you may let silence spill from you for a scene: no sound carries within ten paces, flies die, flames lean and dim, and every Kept person in the

radius must make a Hard Caul + Resolve check or kneel and plead to be closed. Costs 2 Hunger. *Closing Gaze:* a full minute's stare finishes a candle, a small animal, a conversation or a Kept person, without touch. Small Hushes begin to appear where you sleep: the GM marks one on the map each season.

THE WANTS

- ◇ **Close.** Triggered by an open door, an unclosed eye, an open book, an unlidded jar within reach. Resist with Caul + Resolve vs Routine at the Taste, Hard at the Appetite, Grim at the Course, Dire at the Brink.
- ◇ **Finish.** Triggered by an unfinished thing in your presence: a song, a story, a quarrel, a life. You must end it, one way or another. Resist as above.
- ◇ **Quiet.** Triggered by laughter, crowds, bells and children playing. At the Course you must leave or silence the source. Resist as above, one step harder in Lastgate.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 the character becomes a Hush. They do not die and they do not leave; they stand still and the silence spreads from them, slowly, for the rest of the campaign. Everyone and everything inside it ends. The player retires the character, and the GM places the new Hush on the map. Their friends may visit the edge. If the Hush is near the party's home, it will reach it in a year or two.

PLAYING ONE OF THE KEPT (OPTIONAL)

A PC who falls to Ruin in Sallowreach and takes further damage does not die. They become Kept. Players may also begin play Kept, by choice.

- ◇ **No more death.** A Kept character no longer loses Flesh to dying. At 0 Flesh they suffer Ruin and collapse as normal, but further damage adds **Rot** instead (1 Rot per Ruin, or per 5 damage taken while Ruined). They need no food, drink, breath or sleep, and are immune to poison, drowning and suffocation. Cold and heat they feel, but cannot be killed by.
- ◇ **Rot (0–10).** Rot also rises by 1 each season without Seamer upkeep, and by 1 for any fall, fire or soaking that is not tended within a day. At Rot 3 (*Ripe*) the smell is unmistakable: –2 to Stealth and to Persuade with the living. At Rot 5 (*Loose*) parts come away: –1 to Lung and Hand rolls, and every scene of exertion has a chance to shed something (GM's call). At Rot 7 (*Ruinous*) the character is a Dread 2 horror to the living and must be carried more often than not. At Rot 10 the character is

Set Aside: retired to the Lofts, still aware, and the player makes a new one. They can still be visited.

- ◇ **Seamer upkeep.** A Seamer's restitching (Hard Hand + Stitching, an hour, 30 lacks in materials) removes 1 Rot; a full spring restitching in the Guild's hands removes 2 and costs 120 lacks. A Kept character can Stitch themselves at one step harder.
- ◇ **The border.** A Kept character who leaves Sallowreach drops dead at once, completely, all their unfinished rot arriving in a heartbeat. There is no save. A Kept PC cannot follow the party south.
- ◇ **The Regrowth continues.** A Kept Hand-line still Partakes and still accrues Hunger and Regrowth. A Kept PC who is Closed is finished forever.
- ◇ **Fray.** The Kept still feel. Every season of Rot 5 or more adds 1 Fray. The commonest Derangements among the Kept are believing that one is still alive, and believing that everyone else has died.

BACKGROUNDS

- ◇ **Restitched Apprentice.** A Threader of the Seamers' Guild who knows every family on their street by its smell, and who has begun to notice which bodies are missing parts.
- ◇ **Disinherited Heir.** Forty-eight, living, legally a minor, owner of nothing; your father is upright and the Heirs have offered you a punt and a sack.
- ◇ **Glovebearer of a Closer.** A clerk who unpicks the gloves of a Hand-line Closer and has seen what that hand does, and whose own fingers have started going cold.

NAMES

Male: Ansel, Osric, Jory, Bram, Amos, Aubin, Corlis, Dace, Fenwick, Halloran, Hollis, Josiah, Merriman, Rook, Tobin, Wick.

Female: Bettany, Corrow, Edda, Hessa, Henna, Idony, Lorn, Merrit, Nell, Thessaly, Wenna, Ysolde, Greer, Sabine, Orla.

Neutral: Pim, Ash, Sorrel, Teal, Lark, Fen, Rue, Wren.

Surnames: Grue, Vane, Sedge, Hethe (Hand-lines); Mort, Welt, Shroud, Sorrel, Lathe, Tallow, Morrow, Farrow, Ruddock, Hollin, Thrush, Coyle, Rook, Mead, Strake, Mallory, Coombe, Reave, Cask, Lisp, Gall.

▼ HORRORS OF SALLOWREACH

HORRORS OF SALLOWREACH – FOR THE GM

Roll on the table below when the party travels off the causeway, lodges in the Sinks or enters the Lofts, the Sump or the Drowned Storeys. Each entry gives a scene and its Dread rating. Use the senses: the smell first, then the sound, then what the eyes see last.

D20	HORROR	DREAD
1	A Black Noon: a fly-front swallows the lamps; something inside it says your name in a voice of ten thousand wings.	1
2	A Kept fisherman wades from the mere holding his own lower jaw, asking for help putting it back.	1
3	A family restitches great-grandfather at the kitchen table and offers you supper beside him.	1
4	An eel you swallowed is still moving, low in the belly, for an hour.	1
5	A Wick Tallow candle in your room screams very quietly whenever you turn a page.	2
6	A sack drifts up from the Sump, the rope cut, and knocks against the punt. It is weeping.	2
7	Bubbles rise around the boat in a perfect circle, then a spiral, then letters.	2
8	A woman sits on a doorstep picking maggots from her husband's face; she smiles and asks how far gone you are.	2
9	Marrow Jack's stock: a cupboard of hands, labeled, some of them still gripping.	2
10	A Kept man walks toward the Finishing Post, weeping; a Kept woman runs after him, begging.	3
11	In the Lofts, every shelved body in an aisle turns its wrapped head toward you and whispers "company."	3
12	Something in the fen takes your ankle and only holds on, for an hour, while you tug.	2
13	The Smoking Ground: a coal-black child walks out of the steam and asks if you have seen its mother.	3
14	A pilgrimage of Finishers passes, singing; one of them is someone you know.	3
15	A Kept body sold in the Sinks for meat, lively, twitching on the hook, and the buyer is haggling.	3
16	A Heir cell drags a bound old man toward the Smoking Ground; he is calling one of them by a child's pet name.	3
17	The edge of a new Hush, crossing the road you are on, a pace a minute, in total silence.	4
18	You wake to find a Hand-line child's grey fingers resting gently over your eyes.	3
19	A jar from the Jar Room, stolen and dumped in a canal, a face pressed to the green glass, mouthing.	3
20	Total silence falls on you, alone. No sound at all, for a full minute. Then your heart, much too loud.	4



CHAPTER 4

THE FATLANDS

There is no word in our dialect for full. We had one. We ate it.

– FATLANDS JOKE, TOLD AT EVERY TABLE

Thank you, Long Acre. Thank you, Granny Hessop's Rise. Thank you, Father, who is on the plate.

– A WAKE-GRACE FROM LOW TILTH, AS RECORDED BY THE CUTWRIGHTS' COLLEGE, 588 A.G.

The fat was the first thing. Mam always said so, and Mam was right about the fat: you start a man at the fat, because the fat remembers the fire best.

We laid Da on the big board at noon, the day after he went, with the shutters wide so the neighbours could see we had nothing to hide and no meanness in us. Hob Gristle came out from Sated to do the jointing, because Da had been a weighty man and a deacon of the Weighhouse and you do not let your cousins hack at a deacon. Hob kissed the knife. He kissed Da's brow. He said, "Sorry, Wilm. Sorry, old lad. Sorry," every time the blade went in, under his breath, like a man saying a grace he did not believe but could not stop.

Da came apart beautifully. That is what everyone said after. The skin lifted off the shoulder in one sheet, gold underneath, the fat as thick as three fingers laid flat and white as a new cheese, marbled with pink threads like a map of rivers. There was a smell from him even raw, a sweet one, grass and warm butter and the inside of a barn in Plenty, because Da had eaten Long Acre his whole life and Long Acre is famous. You could see the field in him. Everyone said so. They pressed in at the windows and said so.

We rendered the belly first. It went into the big copper over the yard fire and it sighed when it hit the heat, and the yard filled up with the smell of him, rich and brown and bottomless, and the dogs all lay down flat in the lane and whined. My sister Petty skimmed the dripping with Mam's wedding ladle. She cried the whole time and kept tasting it. You could not blame her. Nobody could have blamed her.

The legs went on the spit. The hands went into the pie, with onions and the little purple turnips that grow along Granny Hessop's Rise, because that is the custom for a man who worked with his hands. The heart was mine to cook, as eldest. I seared it in its own fat until the outside cracked like toffee and the inside was the colour of a plum, and I sliced it thin and laid the slices out on the blue plate that came from Mam's mother, overlapping, like scales, the way he would have

wanted. When I cut it, it was still warm in the middle. When I put the first slice in my mouth it was so good that I sat down on the floor.

I am telling you the truth. It was the best thing I have ever eaten. It tasted of being twelve and being lifted onto his shoulders at the Weighing. It tasted of his pipe. It ran down my chin and I did not wipe it.

By dusk there were sixty at the board and the yard was slick with drip and the copper had been refilled twice. The Bailiff came round to see the Feasting Laws were kept and there was nothing for him to do, so he sat and ate a rib of Da with tears on his big soft face and said Wilm Callock was the finest-marbled man in the parish, and he would know. Petty had stopped crying and was eating with both hands. Mam was eating with both hands. I was eating with both hands. The children were under the board, sucking the knuckle-bones, which is what the knuckle-bones are for.

And I was hungry. That is the thing nobody tells you before your first wake, though they all know it. I ate my father from noon until the Plate came up, and every mouthful was the best mouthful of my life, and I was exactly as hungry at the end as I was at the start. Hungrier. Because now I knew what he tasted like and there was no more of him.

Late on, when the board was down to bones, I went out to Long Acre on my own. The field was sweating in the dark. I knelt and put my face to the soil and it was warm as a cheek and it moved, slowly, up and down, like something sleeping. I said, "Thank you, Long Acre." I said, "We are giving him back to you, we are, what's left, I promise." The furrow under my mouth opened a little. Just a little. Just enough for me to feel the teeth in it, small ones, wheat-teeth, rows and rows of them, all along the ground, all through the dark, as far as the Plate could light.

Then I went home and had the marrow, because the marrow had been saved for me.

▼ THE MEAL

Every land on the Table remembers its Gorging as something done slowly, in shame, with stops for vomiting and prayer. The Fatlands remember theirs as a party.

That is the first thing outsiders find unbearable, and it is true. In the ninth winter of the Long Lack the southern plains were a grey crust of dead clay from the Brawn to the sea. The people had eaten their seed, then their oxen, then their boots, then the thatch, and by the last Tablenight they were eating the clay itself, baked into flat cakes that cracked teeth and stopped the bowels. Their god had come down out of the hills to lie among them in the field called the Trencher, because there was nowhere else for it to go. Ummer, the Laden, the Harvest Walker, had once been so vast with plenty that the furrows bent toward it like grass toward a wind. By that winter it was a long grey heap of sagging hide, a hill of skin on a frame of ribs like a collapsed barn, breathing a little. Its belly, which the oldest carvings show swollen with sheaves and calves and fruit, lay empty and folded on the earth like a dropped sack.

The Fatland chronicles, which were written down in the Sweet Reigns by people who had been told by people who had been there, insist that nobody gave an order. A girl named Wenna Strake, aged about sixteen, walked out across the Trencher at dusk with a flint sickle, and the crowd watched her go, and she knelt by Ummer's flank and looked into the one great clouded eye that faced her, and said, "Lack keep away." Then she cut. The god did not move. Its eye, every account says, was wet and kind and *pleased*, the way a mother's face is pleased when a child at last takes the spoon.

They ate it in a night. They ate it fastest of all the peoples. The chronicles linger on this with a horrible, unashamed relish that the College has never managed to edit out. They describe the hide, which peeled away in sheets the size of sails and was found to be lined with a layer of golden fat a hand deep, still faintly warm, smelling of cut hay and new bread and the inside of a dairy. They describe how the people, who had eaten clay for a season, tore at the fat raw and wept as it melted on their tongues; how the meat beneath was dark and dense and so full of juice that it ran in the furrows; how whole families crawled bodily into the cavity of the ribs to get at the organs, and came out painted to the shoulder; how fires were lit all over the Trencher and the smoke rose so thick and sweet that birds dropped out of it, gorged on the air alone. There was singing. There was dancing in the grease. Old men who had buried every child they had danced with their mouths full.

Ummer's bones were cracked on the field-stones for the marrow before dawn. The marrow was yellow, and sweet as honey, and it is

said that those who sucked it never afterward grew old in the face, only in the body. The skull was split with mattocks. The brain was shared out a spoonful each to the elders. Nothing was wasted. Not the hooves, not the hide, not the eyes. That is the Fatlands' founding boast, still carved over the doors of the Weighhouse in Sated: NOTHING WAS LEFT.

The families who reached the middle first, and took the stomach, the paunch, the long coils of the entrails, and the great swollen liver, became the Gut-lines. Some say they won those portions by strength. Others say the god's insides *came to them*, sliding out of the opened belly toward particular hands. The chronicles record, without comment, that the stomach was still working when it was eaten. It had been empty for nine years. It was digesting whatever it touched.

The famine ended the next morning. The clay of the Trencher was black and soft and steaming by sunrise. By noon there were green shoots across the whole plain. Within a week the wheat stood shoulder-high, and that was the Week of Rising, and nobody asked what it was wheat *of*.

One detail is preserved only in a single fragmentary song, sung in the Bleeding Orchards at pruning time, and the Board has twice tried to forbid it. It says that when the feasters had finished, and lay on the Trencher in the grey light, too heavy to move, every one of them woke at the same moment with the same thought. It was not guilt. It was not grief. The song gives it in four words, and the Orchard-keepers sing them very softly: *Is there any more?*

UMMER IN THE OLD CARVINGS

Before the Gorging, Ummer was carved on every granary lintel on the plains: a broad, stooping, many-handed figure walking ahead of the plough, with sheaves sprouting from its shoulders and a belly like a full cart. In the few carvings that survive whole, it walks in procession with the other Providers. The Gut-lines prefer not to display these. One reason is obvious: Ummer is shown *feeding* the others from its own body, breaking off pieces of its shoulder and handing them along the line. The other reason is less discussed. In every surviving procession, there is a figure walking just behind Ummer, very close, with its hand on the Laden's back. That figure has been chiselled away to the bare stone. In the oldest carving in the Fatlands, over the root-cellar of a ruined granary at Dimble, the chisel slipped, and a little of the hand remains. It is very long, and it is open, palm up, the way you hold out a hand for more.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Everything here is meat, and nobody is ever full.

Those nine words are the whole of Fatland law, Fatland faith and Fatland misery, and every child can recite them before it can count. What they mean in practice takes longer.

EVERYTHING IS MEAT

The soil of the Fatlands is Ummer's flesh, scattered and buried and grown back, and it grows flesh in turn. Nothing that comes out of the ground here is entirely vegetable. Wheat stands in the field in golden ranks and looks, from the road, like any wheat on the Table; split an ear and you find each grain sheathed in a little moist pink gum, and in the gum, a tooth. Toothed wheat has been the only wheat for four centuries. Milled, it makes a heavy, sweet, faintly salty flour that bakes into bread with a crust like crackling and a crumb that tears in long fibres, like pulled shoulder. The teeth are sieved out at the mill. Most of them are milk teeth. Not all.

Orchard trees bleed when they are pruned: a slow, dark, clotting sap that scabs over in a day. Their fruit has a skin, a layer of soft white fat under it, firm pink flesh beneath that, and at the core a pit that is unmistakably bone, ridged and porous and full of a sweet grey marrow children suck out with straws. Root vegetables have veins. A beet pulled from the ground pulses faintly in the hand for a minute or two before it stops. Onions have a membrane between every layer, and if you cut them too slowly they flinch. Cabbages are warm in the middle. Potatoes, the poor's food, grow in clusters joined by gristle, and when the clusters are pulled apart the cut ends sweat clear lymph.

Dig a well and you strike something that flinches. Every Fatland well is lined with salt-glazed brick, and the water drawn from it is warm, slightly cloudy, and tastes of broth. Drive a fencepost too deep and the ground around it will be bruised purple by morning. Ploughs do not so much turn the soil as *open* it, and the furrow behind the share is red-brown and glistening and smells, in the heat, of a butcher's block.

The livestock is the strangest of all, because livestock should be the one thing that was meat already. The cattle of the Fatlands are enormous, sleek, docile and silent. They do not low. They watch. Drovers say a Fatland steer will follow a man anywhere if he walks ahead of it eating, and the Renderers' Union does not employ anyone who has spent too long looking a steer in the eye. Pigs are hairless and pale. Chickens lay eggs with a heartbeat. Nobody asks what the cattle eat in the far pastures when they are out of sight, because the answer is grass, and the grass here has teeth.

And all of it, every mouthful, is delicious. This must be understood or nothing about the Fatlands will make sense. There is no bad food in the south. The poorest gristle-potato boiled in well-water is better than a lord's feast in Oathen. Fatland bread, broken

hot, is so good that foreign travellers have been known to weep at the first bite and refuse to leave the inn. The Fatlands are the breadbasket and the meat-locker of half the Table, and every land that buys from them knows, at some level it does not visit, that it is buying the Laden god by the pound.

NOBODY IS EVER FULL

A Fatlander can eat until the belly splits, and some do, and still feel the hunger exactly as before.

Hunger here has no connection to the stomach. It is not a signal that the body needs food; it is a *presence*, the god's own nine-year famine, inherited and shared out through ten thousand bloodlines like the meat itself. It sits beneath the breastbone and gnaws. It wakes children in the night. It interrupts weddings and funerals and sermons and acts of love. Eating soothes it the way scratching soothes an itch: wonderfully, for exactly as long as you are doing it, and then not at all.

The Fatlands have therefore built a civilization around eating constantly. Five meals a day are mandatory under the Feasting Laws, and the poor fit four more around them if they can. Field-hands chew strips of salt fat as they work. Clerks keep bowls of cracklings at their elbows. Every inn and every house keeps a pot on the hob at all hours, and it is never allowed to empty. Waste is unthinkable. Refusal is sedition. A thin Fatlander is either sick, criminal, or one of the Thin, and in the eyes of the law these are the same thing.

The people are, accordingly, huge. A healthy labourer of the Scrapling class might weigh three hundred pounds. A prosperous merchant, five hundred. The Gut-lines nobility begin at a thousand and do not stop. Fatland architecture is wide, low, and ramped. Fatland chairs are benches, Fatland doors are double, Fatland floors are joisted like bridges. In Sated there is a profession, the Carriers, of men and women employed to lift and turn the great, and another, the Washers, who clean the folds.

THE LAND ALSO EATS

The god was the god of harvest, and a harvest has two halves. The land gives. Then it takes.

Each Carving, as the fields come ripe, people go missing from every village. They go out in the field at dusk and are not back by morning. They leave no footprints going anywhere but out. Sometimes a boot is found in a furrow, standing upright, laces still tied. Sometimes a hat in the wheat, or a sickle with a polished handle, or a set of clothes laid neatly in the shape of a body, flat and empty, with the soil beneath them dark and wet and freshly turned. More often there is nothing at all. This is called the Reaping.

The official explanation is wolves. Every Board proclamation since 300 A.G. has said so, and the Board employs a Wolf-Warden in every district, who files a report each autumn describing tracks, sightings and depredations. There are no wolves in the Fatlands. There have never been any in living memory or written record. Nothing in the Fatlands is anything but crop.

Those who have watched a Reaping happen and kept their minds describe it with a terrible consistency. It is always dusk. The light goes amber, then red, and the heat lifts off the soil in a haze that smells of hot fat. The field goes still; the wind drops; the wheat stops whispering. The labourer is usually alone, or at the far end of a row from the others, bent to the work. And then the field *leans*. Every ear of wheat for fifty yards turns toward them at once, slowly, like a congregation turning to look at a latecomer. There is a sound one witness compared to a crowd of people chewing with their mouths shut. The soil around their feet softens to the consistency of warm suet and they sink to the ankle, and then to the knee, and they do not, by most accounts, struggle much; their faces go slack and grateful, the way a tired man's face goes slack when he lowers himself into a hot bath. The wheat closes over them. The ears move against the body, in and out, all of them, all over. There is a wet, comfortable, rhythmic noise, which goes on for some time. Then the field stands up straight again and the wind comes back and the wheat whispers, and next year that strip of field yields half again

what the rest does, and the bread from it tastes, faintly, of the person.

Families know. Everyone knows. You can tell a Reaped man's row by the colour of the ears: a little redder, a little heavier, nodding lower. The widow of a Reaped man will often ask the miller to keep that strip's flour separate, and bakes it into a single loaf on Tablenight, and the family eats it together, slowly, in the dark, and says his name.

THE REAPING IN PLAY

The Reaping is not a monster to be fought; it is weather, and it is the god. A character caught alone in a ripe Fatland field between sunset and full dark in Carving may be Reaped. The GM should make it a slow, sensory scene, never a surprise kill. First the stillness (Eye + Search, Routine, to notice). Then the leaning (Dread 3 to witness; Dread 2 for a Fatlander, who has grown up with it). Then the softening ground: the victim must succeed at Caul + Resolve (Hard 14; Grim 18 if their Hunger is 6 or more, because the field *smells like dinner*) or stop wanting to leave. A character who fails may be dragged out by companions with Gut + Labor (Grim 18), but the field holds on: each round in the soil deals 1d6 Flesh as the ground begins, gently, to digest. A character who is Reaped is gone. What is pulled out after full dark is not a corpse, only a shape of clothes and a smell of bread. Fatlanders of Cut 3+ can sometimes feel which fields are hungry on a given night (Caul + Godsign, Hard 14).

▼ THE REGROWTH IN THE FATLANDS

Ummer is growing back, and what grows back is a field.

Every land's Regrowth is a return of the god's nature. Ummer's nature was abundance: the slow, rooted, generative patience of soil, which takes in what dies and gives it back as food. In the Fatlands the god does not wear its people so much as *plant* them. The Cutwrights' College calls the southern Regrowth "the most orderly on the Table," because its stages arrive in strict sequence and never skip. Fatlanders call it simply getting heavy.

THE TASTE

Hunger that wakes you. Every Fatlander has the god's hunger by day; at the Taste it begins to come in the night as well, a hollow ache that drags you up out of sleep with your mouth already working. Children chew their sleeves into rags, then their bedding, then the soft wood of the cot-rail. Mothers sew bone rings into nightshirt cuffs to give them something better to gnaw. Adults wake with the taste of soil on their tongues and cannot remember the dream. The breath begins to smell faintly of the fields, of grass and dung and rising dough. It is considered a healthy sign, and courting couples are told to look for it.

THE APPETITE

Eating without choosing. At the Appetite the hand goes to the mouth before the mind has agreed: a bite of tallow candle, a mouthful of earth from a flowerpot, the corner of a leather glove, a twist of one's own hair. The sufferer will eat soap, wax, string, paper, chalk, rope, coal, and can digest a good deal of it. They cannot stop for conversation. They eat through sermons, through lovemaking, through their own children's weddings, and they weep while they do it, because they can taste everything and everything is wonderful. Fatland courts have recognized "the Appetite" as a defence to theft since 312 A.G., provided the stolen article was eaten in full. Clerks with the Appetite keep their ledgers chained, because the ink is made from rendered fat. At this stage, many begin to want meat that is not animal. They smell the living. They notice, without wishing to, how a neighbour's forearm would carve.

THE COURSE

The body swells past all proportion and the feet begin to put down roots. These people are called the Laden, after the god, and in the Gut-lines it is a title.

The swelling is not ordinary fat. It is soft, cool, slightly granular to the touch, and it gives under the finger like freshly turned loam and holds the print for hours. The skin darkens to brown and red, mottled like a field seen from a hill. Hair thickens and coarsens into something fibrous. Small green shoots appear in the creases of the elbow and behind the knees; the Washers pluck them daily, and they grow back overnight. The Laden sweat a clear, sweet, faintly sticky fluid that draws flies and bees. They grow warm. A Laden person's bed is warm for a day after they leave it, and nothing stored beneath it spoils.

The roots come last. They start as pale, hair-thin threads from the soles of the feet, and the Laden feel them as a pleasant tingling that becomes, over months, a desperate wish to stand still. If a Laden person stands on bare ground for an hour, the threads go down. If they stand for a day, the threads thicken into cords. Pulling free tears skin, and the cords bleed, and it hurts in a way the Laden describe as being torn out of a warm bed in Lack. Most Laden of the Gut-lines are moved on drays with iron floors, because iron is the one thing roots will not take in. Most Laden of the poor are simply allowed to plant.

THE BRINK

At the Brink the Laden person is more field than flesh. They are rooted somewhere and cannot be moved without killing them; their bulk spreads outward into the soil and the soil rises to meet it. The face sinks into the mound of the body. The limbs are hummocks. The eyes cloud green. Crops grow on them, densely, without being

sown. A Brink-Laden can still speak, though slowly and from deep in the chest, and still eats, endlessly, and everything around them grows: the grass in a ring of thirty yards around a Brink-Laden is waist-high and toothed, and the wheat leans toward them when they speak. Visitors sometimes feel the ground pulse in time with the Brink-Laden's heart. In the last weeks the person begins to forget their own name and to remember, instead, the names of the fields around them, and the names of those who have been Reaped into those fields.

THE SEATING

A Laden person stops being a person and becomes a place: a low hill, warm to the touch, where things grow very well. Some keep a mouth.

There is no single moment of Seating. The family notices, one morning, that Gran has stopped speaking and the hill has started breathing. The breath is slow, perhaps once an hour, and the whole mound lifts with it. The soil of a Seated hill is the richest on the Table. Its grass is the sweetest, its fruit the heaviest, its wheat the most toothed. Many of the best fields in the south are somebody's great-grandmother. Fatlanders say this with pride and mean it.

Some hills keep a mouth. It sits somewhere in the turf like a wet red pond-edge, lipped and toothed, and it talks, and it eats whatever is put in it, and it is hungry. Some keep eyes, deep in the grass, that open in rain. And some, the College has recently confirmed, keep moving: very slowly, a few inches a year, toward the nearest other hill.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

The Fatlands are low, wet, endless green-and-red plain under a heavy yellow sky. From the Rim Road they look like a painted country: the green of pasture and the red of turned soil and the gold of toothed wheat, laid out in strips as far as the eye can follow, under a sky the colour of old butter that never quite clears. There are no mountains. There are hardly any trees outside the orchards. There are only the fields, the long wet roads, the slow brown rivers, and the hills, which are people.

It is always warm. Even in Lack the ground steams at dawn. The ground gives underfoot like a mattress over a sleeper, and if you stand still in an open field, you can feel it slowly rise and fall. Foreigners take a week to stop noticing. Fatlanders never notice at all, and are made seasick by stone.

Rain is called **drip**. It falls warm and heavy and leaves a yellowish film on standing water, which cooks skim off with flat spoons and use for frying; a good drip-pan after a storm is a housewife's pride. The hot-season wind, the **Belch**, comes up out of the south in late Plenty smelling of rendering, of tallow-vats and singed hair, and lasts for days; tempers break, and the Feasting Laws are relaxed so

that people may eat a sixth meal to steady their nerves. In late Plenty the fields **sweat** and the whole country glistens. Midges rise from the wheat in shimmering columns. Every surface is tacky. And at the turn of Carving comes **Marbling**, the first frost, when the fat in the soil whitens overnight in long branching veins, and the plains look from horizon to horizon like a cut of meat laid on a slab. Marbling morning is a holiday. Children run out barefoot to crunch it.

The rivers are slow and brown and thick and warm, and they are called, without irony, gravy: the Brawn, which runs south past Sated to the sea, is the Great Gravy, and its tributaries are the Little Gravies. Their water must be strained before drinking. What is strained out is eaten.

A GAZETTEER OF THE FATLANDS

Sated. The capital, on the Great Gravy, built in concentric rings of low, broad, buttressed halls around the Weighhouse. Every door is double-wide, every floor reinforced, every stair replaced by a ramp, and the smell of gravy rises from every drain, because the drains carry the city's drip and dripping down to the rendering-houses on

the river. The streets are paved with fat-stained stone and wide enough for a Gut-lines dray and its eight oxen. Sated never stops eating: street-cooks work all night beneath lamps that burn tallow of uncertain provenance, and at any hour the air is blue with frying. Its population is four hundred thousand by head and, as its proud citizens say, “a hundred and twenty million by the pound.”

The Weighhouse. The seat of the Board of Plenty, in the heart of Sated: a vast round hall under a dome of glazed bone tiles, with the Great Scales at its centre, iron and bronze, each pan large enough to hold a cart. Here the Weighing is held each Grace, and here the Board sits, on benches sunk into the floor because many members can no longer be lifted onto anything. The floor of the Weighhouse has been reinforced six times. Its cellars, which nobody below the Board visits, are said to be full of roots.

The Bleeding Orchards. Ten thousand acres of fruit trees east of Sated, in long rows on the slopes of what were once hills and may still be. At pruning time in early Grace the trees scream when cut: a high, wet, wavering sound, like a calf at the knife, from ten thousand throats at once, audible in Sated on a still day. Orchard-keepers go deaf young, by choice, with heated needles, and speak in a hand-language of their own. The fruit is the finest in the world. The sap is collected in buckets for blood-pudding.

Low Tilth. The richest farmland in the world, a wide shallow basin south of Sated where the soil is black and soft and sweats in Plenty like a basted joint. It yields three harvests a year. It has the highest Reaping of any district, and nobody there locks their door, because it has never helped. Low Tilth villages are small, quiet and well-fed, and every family has someone in the fields. It is the home of Pell Hogget and the Long Count, and of the Scarecrow.

The Dowager Hills. A range of low green mounds three miles outside Sated, along the old Weighing Road: nine generations of Gut-lines matriarchs, Seated, ninety-one hills in all. The grass on them is short and soft and bright, and the soil is warm right through Lack. Each hill has a name, a family, a gatekeeper’s hut, and a speaking-place: a hollow where the turf parts to show a mouth, or a pair of lids, or, on the oldest, only a warm damp crack that exhales. The Gut-lines families still consult their Dowagers on matters of marriage, inheritance and precedence, and bring them offerings. The offerings are meat. The Hills accept them, chewing for hours with a sound like a slow mill. Visitors walking the path between the mounds report that the hills breathe in sequence, a long slow wave of rising and falling turf, as though passing something along.

CONSULTING A DOWAGER

A family with a question for its Dowager brings her a joint (custom demands the best cut from the most recent wake) and the Hill-Speaker on duty lays it in the speaking-place. The Dowager eats. When she has eaten, she answers, sometimes in minutes and sometimes after a day. Her voice comes up through the turf and is felt in the feet as much as heard. Dowagers know things: the true parentage of heirs, the location of hidden debts, which fields will Reap this year. They are rarely wrong. They are also no longer entirely the women they were, and their advice now tends, more and more, toward the same few counsels: *Plant him. Feed her to me. Come closer. Sit down. Lie down. Stay.* A PC who sleeps a night on a Dowager Hill gains a true answer to one question (GM’s choice of how cryptic) and must make a Dread 3 check on waking, because the roots will have begun.

The Chute. The Rim Road export depot, at the Fatlands’ northern edge where the Great Gravy meets the Road: a mile of rendering-houses, salting-sheds, cooperages and stockyards built around a long stone ramp down which barrels roll, day and night, into the Company’s wagons. Meat goes out in barrels with the origin stamped over twice. The smell of the Chute reaches eleven miles on the Belch. The Renderers’ Union holds it absolutely. The Rim Road Company keeps an office there with a notary’s bench, and every barrel is tallied on a platter.

The Trencher. (*new*) The field where Ummer was eaten: a great shallow bowl of black soil a mile across, in the heart of the plain west of Sated. Nothing is planted there and everything grows anyway, in a dense tangle of toothed grain, veined roots and fleshy creepers that heal over any path cut through them in a night. At its centre is a rise of soil shaped, from the air, very like a sleeping figure lying on its side. The Board forbids entry. Pilgrims of the Second Helping go anyway and lie down in the creepers and are found, weeks later, smiling and partly absorbed.

The Gavage. (*new*) The Board’s house of correction for the Thin, outside Sated on the Brawn: a long, low, whitewashed building of a hundred cells, each with a chair of oak and iron, a set of leather straps, a funnel-stand, and a drain. Its kitchens never close. Its smell is of porridge, lard, and vomit. See the Thin, below.

The Dusk Acres. (*new*) The “far fields” of the Cullmasters: a belt of Board-owned land on the edges of Low Tilth and the eastern plains, rotated each Carving, where the Cullmasters’ dusk-shift labourers are sent. They are the most productive fields in the country, and the most carefully ploughed, and each plot carries a small numbered stone at its corner.

Gladbelly. (*new*) The commune of the Second Helping, a village of long open tables in a meadow beside the Little Gravy, where the cult eats together continuously and sings. The meadow is unusually lush. There is a slaughter-pavilion in the middle, hung with

garlands, where the Offered go willingly. See the Second Helping, below.

Marrable Hall. (*new*) The seat of Dame Suet Marrable and the Unending Dinner: a great ramped house in the Dowager Hills whose dining hall has had no clear floor for eighty-one years. The table is three hundred feet long. The hall’s foundations have shifted a yard downhill.

Hogget’s Barn. (*new*) In the village of Kettle Furrow in Low Tilth, a plain timber barn whose inner walls are scored, floor to rafter, with tally-marks: the Long Count, kept in chalk, then knife, then paint, by Pell Hogget and the villages that copy him. Pilgrims come to touch the marks for their own dead. The Board has twice tried to burn it, and both times the village stood around it in a ring, eating, and the Bailiffs could not bring themselves to break up a meal.

▼ HISTORY

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Meal on the Trencher. The Week of Rising: crops shoulder-high in seven days.
0–204	The Sweet Reigns. The Fatlands feed the Table and grow rich and wide.
61	First recorded Laden: Matron Ysolde Tullow, whose feet rooted in her own kitchen.
97	First Seating. Ysolde becomes the first of the Dowager Hills.
131	The Wake Ordinance. Burial forbidden; the dead to be served by kin.
204	The Tooth Harvest. The Board rules toothed wheat “a new and superior strain.”
260	The Weighing. Votes assigned by body weight.
300	First Wolf-Warden appointed. The word “wolves” enters Board proclamations.
312	The Appetite accepted as a defence to theft, if the article is eaten.
455	The Thin Rising. Put down by force-feeding; fasting made treason.
457	The Gavage built. The Cullmasters chartered as “an office of agricultural steadiness.”
560	Dame Suet Marrable lays the Unending Dinner.
611	Chairman Obb Tullow walks for the last time.
626	Wren Hollowell born in Bramble Furrow, a Blank.
629	Pell Hogget begins the Long Count.
631–641	The Reaping doubles.
638	First field-faces reported in Low Tilth: turnips, squashes, a cabbage that blinked.
640	Tullow’s feet root through his cart. Tobias Wether crosses from the Fast and eats.

THE SWEET REIGNS

For two hundred years the Fatlands were the happiest country on the Table. The Week of Rising was followed by a century of harvests so abundant that grain was used for ballast and meat was fed to dogs. Sated grew from a market-village into the wealthiest city in the world. Fatland envoys went up the Rim Road in gilded wagons with presents of smoked haunch, and every other land, starving or merely ordinary, fell over itself to sign treaties. These were the years in which “You look heavy” became the highest compliment, and the years in which the Gut-lines, swelling, ruled from couches and then from beds, and everyone thought it was glory.

The Wake Ordinance of 131 A.G. merely made law of what had become custom. Nobody had been buried in the Fatlands for a generation. It seemed obscene to put good meat in the ground when the ground was already so full.

THE WEIGHING AND THE RISING

By 260 A.G. the largest Gut-lines could no longer travel to the Board, and the Board came to them; the Weighing simply made their bulk a formal measure of power. The poor accepted it, because the poor were eating well. Two centuries later, they were not. Export had swallowed the surplus, the Reaping had grown, and a preacher named Hester Gaunt began teaching in the Orchards that the god was in the hunger, and that if the people stopped feeding it, it would

starve back down into the soil. The Thin Rising of 455 A.G. was not an army. It was eleven thousand people in Low Tilth sitting down in the roads and refusing to eat. The Board sent the Bailiffs with funnels. Within a month most of the Thin were fat, and the rest were dead, and Hester Gaunt had been fed in the Weighhouse before the whole Board for nine days until she burst. Fasting has been treason since.

THE LONG COUNT

In 629, Pell Hogget of Kettle Furrow noticed that his village had been one smaller each autumn for as long as he could remember, and scratched it on his barn wall. He started asking neighbouring villages. Then they started sending him their numbers. The Long Count is now copied in two hundred villages, by people who share no organization but a habit, and it shows something the Board has spent three centuries calling wolves: the Reaping has doubled in ten years, and it is still accelerating.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

The Fatlands are governed by the **Board of Plenty**, seated in the Weighhouse at Sated. The Board has about two hundred members, drawn from the Gut-lines, the Renderers, the great granaries and a handful of elected district deacons. Each member's vote counts in proportion to their weight, taken publicly once a year at the Weighing. A Gut-lines matriarch of fourteen hundred pounds outvotes nine farmers' deacons together. The Chairman, Obb Tullow, at nineteen hundred pounds, holds more votes alone than the whole of Low Tilth. He has not walked in thirty years.

The Gut-lines are the nobility. They are the largest, the hungriest, and the furthest along the Regrowth, and their estates are run from beds, then from drays, then from the ground. Succession disputes turn on whether a rooted, mouthless hill can still be said to hold title. The courts have ruled that it can, which is why the Dowager Hills still own a third of the country and why their consultations carry the force of law.

Law in the Fatlands is mostly about eating. The **Feasting Laws** set five meals a day; leaving food on the plate is a fine of one lack per crumb-weight, assessed by the Bailiff's scale; refusing a meal is

sedition, punishable by the Gavage. Theft of food is barely a crime, since the thief will eat it and the court considers the matter closed. Theft of *weight*, by contrast, is grave: to starve a person, to keep a child thin, to purge, to bleed for the purpose of lightness, is treason against the Weighing. The worst crime of all is waste. A man who let a barrel of meat rot in 602 A.G. was rendered for tallow by order of the Board, and the tallow was used to light the courtroom for the next trial.

Punishment is by feeding (the Gavage), by fine, by the dusk-shift, or by the table. A convicted murderer in the Fatlands is executed in the Renderers' yards, and the family of the victim has first cut. This is called *making good*.

Abroad, the Fatlands' power is food. They feed half the Table by way of the Rim Road, and every other land depends on that meat while trying not to think about it. The Vigil eats Fatland salt-beef to keep its strength through sleepless decades. Oathen buys toothed flour by the shipload. Sallowreach, which needs little food, buys Fatland tallow for its Seammers. The Board knows exactly how much the world would starve without it, and charges accordingly.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

Meals. Five meals a day are mandatory: Firstbite at dawn, Elevesens, Midday, Fourth Plate, and Supper, with whatever the purse allows in between. Every meal begins with the grace, which thanks the field by name ("Thank you, Long Acre. Thank you, Hessop's Rise.") and ends with the plate wiped clean with bread. Strangers add the common "Lack keep away." Fatland cooking is lavish, rich and brown: pies and puddings, roasts and dripping, sausages fat as a forearm, gravy on everything. The poor eat potatoes and fat bacon and are not, by any outside measure, poor eaters.

Dress. Fatlanders dress in loose layered smocks, laced at the side so they can be let out as the wearer grows. Belts are a mark of ill-omen and worn only by the Thin. The rich wear silk in field-colours, red and gold and green, cut wide, and pin their folds with brooches of polished bone. Teeth from the toothed wheat are threaded into necklaces for children.

Marriage and the body. Weight is beauty, and courtship is conducted over food. A suitor feeds the beloved with his own hands at the betrothal supper, and the beloved's family watches to see that the feeding is generous. Wedding vows are sworn over a shared plate. Couples speak of "growing together," and Gut-lines marriages sometimes end with both partners rooted side by side in a single hill. What happens in a Fatland marriage bed is, in the Fatland view, simply another kind of appetite and is spoken of in the same breath as supper, with a knowing look. Outsiders are discomfited by how readily lovers there speak of wanting to eat each other, and by how literally some of them mean it.

Children. Fatland children are fed from the moment they are born and weighed every week. A child who fails to gain is a scandal for its parents and a matter for the Bailiff. Children glean behind the harvesters, turn spits, and are put to sleep with a strip of fat to suck.

They are warned never to go into the fields alone at dusk in Carving, and they all do, once, on a dare.

Death rites. There are no graves. The dead are served at the wake, by the family, on the best plates. To be buried uneaten would be the deepest insult to a life; it is reserved for traitors and the Thin, whose lean bodies are thrown in the Brawn. A wake begins at noon on the day after death. A jointer is hired if the family can afford one; the deceased's fat is rendered first, the heart goes to the eldest, the hands into a pie, the marrow to the most beloved. Neighbours bring bread and are fed in return. The bones are cracked, boiled for stock, and then returned to the family's field, ground fine, so that the

person goes back to the god and comes up again as crop. A good wake is talked about for years. "He ate well" is said of the dead, meaning *he tasted good*.

Remember, she was soft. Remember, she was sweet. Pass the plate along, along; there's not a bit to waste.

Remember, she was heavy, love. Remember, she was kind. Lick the bowl and crack the bone, there's marrow yet to find.

And when you're in the furrow, love, and when you're in the wheat, we'll sit at board and say your name, and you'll be what we eat.

– WAKE-SONG, SUNG ACROSS THE PLAINS WHILE THE COPPER BOILS

Festivals. The Weighing in Grace is a festival of three days, with pie-stalls the length of Sated and the Board brought to the scales on drays before a roaring crowd. Marbling morning is a children's holiday. Harvest Home at the end of Carving is a week of feasting that the Long Count has made very quiet in recent years. And on **Tablenight** the whole country attempts a one-day fast in penance for the Meal. Pantries are locked, keys are given to the priest, and everyone sits in silence. Nobody has ever recorded a village that made it to sundown. By noon children are screaming; by mid-afternoon someone has broken the pantry door; by dusk there is a riot of eating, shameful and joyful, in every village on the plain, and the year begins again.

Crime and punishment. Fatland justice is fast and fed. Petty offenders are fined in meals owed. Brawlers are made to sit and eat together until they reconcile. Debtors are sent to the dusk-shift, from which they return, mostly, with the debt worked off. Mostly.

Proverbs. *A thin man has a secret. Eat while it's warm; it won't be. The field remembers who fed it. Never trust a cook who isn't heavy.*

Nobody's full, but some are fuller. What the wheat took, the bread gives back.

Oaths on the dead. The binding oath of the Fatlands is sworn with a mouthful of a dead relative's flesh held on the tongue: *By my mother's meat, which is in me*. To break it is to have eaten your mother for nothing, and Fatlanders consider this the vilest thing a person can do. Wakes are often delayed so that the family can settle disputes by such oaths while the meat is fresh.

WAKES AND THE OUTSIDER

A PC from another land will be invited to a wake sooner or later. It is the highest courtesy a Fatland family can offer a guest. Refusing to eat is not merely rude; it is sedition, and a Bailiff may be called. Eating counts as cannibalism for any Dread or Rites purpose the GM's table cares about (Dread 2 the first time for a non-Fatlander; Dread 1 thereafter; Dread 0 for a native). It is also, without exception, the most delicious thing the character has ever tasted, and a non-Fatlander of Cut 1+ who eats at a wake gains 1 Hunger, because the meat is looking for somewhere to be hungry from.

▼ FACTIONS

THE BOARD OF PLENTY

The government: two hundred members, vast, slow, and aware of the Reaping in more detail than it admits. The Board believes in continuity, export, and the Weighing. It knows the "wolves" are the fields; it has known for three hundred years; it has records, in the root-choked cellars of the Weighhouse, of every Reaping by district

and year, and its private projections match Pell Hogget's to the head. What the Board wants is to keep the Fatlands eating and the Table buying until the god arrives, and then, if possible, to be the god's favoured guests. Its enemies are the Thin and the Long Count; its allies are the Renderers (uneasily) and the Rim Road Company (expensively). A PC joins by service: as a clerk, a Bailiff, a Weigher's assistant, or a member's Carrier.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Ladle	A Bailiff's or clerk's badge; right to enforce the Feasting Laws; free Supper at any inn.
2	Deacon	A district seat; one vote per hundred pounds; the ear of the Wolf-Warden.
3	Member	A Board vote by weight; immunity from the dusk-shift; a Carrier retinue.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
4	Great Member	Committee seat; access to the Weighhouse cellars and the real Reaping figures.
5	Chairman	The heaviest vote. Rule of the Fatlands, from a cart, then from the ground.

THE THIN

Outlawed fasters who believe starving the body starves the god. They are gaunt, hunted, and the only people in the south who seem clear-headed. The Thin eat once every three days, in secret, a handful of ash-bread and water; they bind their bellies with cord, live in barns and ditches, and meet in the Orchards where the deafened keepers will not hear. Their faith is Purgation-adjacent,

and the cross-border Purgation sends them money, but the Thin are stranger and gentler than their foreign cousins: they do not kill nobles. They simply refuse. They want the Fatlands to stop feeding the god for one whole season, and believe that if it did, the Reaping would end. Their allies are the Purgation and, secretly, a few Orchard-keepers; their enemies are every Bailiff on the plain. A PC joins by fasting in their company for nine days and being seen to suffer.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hollow	A cord for the belly; a hiding place; the Thin's hand-signs.
2	Lean	Knowledge of the safe barns; a share of the ash-bread.
3	Gaunt	Leads a cell; may rescue prisoners from the Gavage.
4	Bone	Speaks for a district; carries messages to the Purgation.
5	The Thin Man	Corder Lank. Unopposed.

The Gavage. Captured Thin are not executed. They are fed. A prisoner is strapped into an oak chair, head locked back in a padded iron frame, jaw held open with a boxwood wedge. A funnel of polished horn is seated in the throat. The feeders are kindly, plump, singing women in white aprons, and they pour: warm lard-porridge first, then gravy thick with marrow, then a puree of pork and bread and dripping, slowly, a ladle every few breaths, while the prisoner chokes and heaves and the feeder strokes the throat downward with a buttered thumb to help it along, murmuring *there, there, love, there's a good belly*. A Gavage session lasts three hours and comes five times a day. The prisoner's body, after nine years of hunger, does not want to fight. It wants. That is the true torture of the Gavage: the Thin weep because it is wonderful, because the gravy is the best thing they have tasted in years, because their bellies stretch and gurgle and *rejoice*, and with every ladle they can feel the god in them waking up and growing fat and grateful. Most leave the Gavage in a

season, heavy and silent and eating. Some come back to the Thin anyway, and weigh the cord around them, and begin again.

THE RENDERERS' UNION

The slaughter, salting, and shipping trades: butchers, renderers, coopers, drovers, salters, jointers and the dock-gangs of the Chute. They control what leaves the country and know what is in it. The Union's members are broad, red-armed, practical people who smell of brine and tallow and talk frankly about anything. They believe in work and in the barrel. They want their wages, their monopoly, and the Board's continued need of them; they also want, more and more, someone else to be blamed when the world finds out what has been in the barrels. Their allies are the Rim Road Company; their enemies, the Board when it tries to tax them. A PC joins by apprenticeship, or by doing a job in the Chute and keeping quiet.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hook	Work in the yards; Union protection; a cleaver.
2	Jointer	Right to carve at wakes for a fee; the trade's secret cuts.
3	Yardmaster	Command of a rendering-house; a share of export profits.
4	Stamper	Control of a barrel-mark; knows what is in each consignment.
5	Mistress of the Union	Brisket Annalow. Can stop the Rim Road with a word.

THE CULLMASTERS

A quiet office of the Board which holds that the Reaping can be steered. If the fields must take, the Cullmasters reason, better that they take vagrants, debtors and troublemakers than good farmers and children. They draw up the lists. They assign the dusk shift. They think of it as agriculture.

The **dusk-shift** is a ritual, though no Cullmaster would use the word. On Carving afternoons, a Cullmaster’s clerk reads the list in the village square: names, debts, and a plot-number in the Dusk Acres. The named are fed a large and excellent supper at the Board’s expense, a real feast with roast and pie and hot bread and as much as they can hold, because the Cullmasters have found that the fields take the well-fed more gently, and because, they say, it is only decent. Then the named are dressed in clean white field-smocks and walked out along the furrows in a line, each carrying a sickle with a

ribboned handle, to their numbered stones. The Cullmaster walks behind them with a lantern. At each stone he stops, bows to the worker, and says the words: *Work well. The field is grateful. You are paid in full.* Then he unrolls a strip of red cloth across the end of the row, so that the worker will know which side of it to stay on, and walks back to the road, and stands with his clerk and his lantern to watch the light go. The workers who try to leave the row are turned back by Bailiffs. The ones who stay bent over their work, cutting and binding, see the wheat begin to lean. A good Cullmaster records each Reaping in his ledger with the plot-number, the time, and the weight of the following year’s yield. A great Cullmaster can tell you, to the pound, how much bread one debtor makes.

Not all of the dusk-shift are taken. Perhaps one in three walk back at full dark, shaking, their debts paid. That fraction, the Cullmasters insist, proves it is labour and not execution. The Long Count suggests the fraction is falling.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Lanternbearer	Walks the line; carries the light; a stipend.
2	Listing Clerk	Drafts the dusk-shift lists; may strike or add one name a season.
3	Cullmaster	Owens a plot-ledger; command of Bailiffs on Carving evenings.
4	Senior Cullmaster	Chooses which districts are spared; reports to the Board’s inner committee.
5	Cullmaster-General	Varn Sweetbread. Steers the Reaping, he believes.

THE SECOND HELPING

A joyous cult of the Bait doctrine. The god starved us so we would eat it, they say; it wanted to be inside us, and now it wants to be fed and to feed, and the holiest thing a person can do is join in. Eat, and be eaten, and be glad. The Second Helping meets at Gladbelly and in a hundred kitchens across the plain, and they are the happiest people in the south: fat, laughing, singing hymns about gravy, embracing strangers. They want the Seating, and they want it soon, and they intend to hurry it along by giving the god as much of themselves as it will take. Their allies are the Second Table, which finds them useful and gullible; their enemies are the Thin, who pity them, and the Board, which finds them embarrassing and quietly very convenient. A PC joins by sharing a meal at Gladbelly and accepting a second helping. Everyone is offered one.

The cult’s highest sacrament is the **Offering**. A member who has decided to go to the god announces it at table, and everyone cheers. There is a week of feasting in the Offered’s honour, in which they are fed by every hand in the commune. On the last evening they are bathed in warm dripping and garlanded with toothed wheat and carried in procession to the pavilion, singing. Their family walks beside them. Their family, too, is singing, and it is only afterward, on the long benches, with the plates going round, that the singing becomes something else: a widower holding a fork he cannot lift, a daughter who keeps saying *but she was happy, she was happy, she said she was happy*, a small boy asking where his mother has gone while a sweet brown smell drifts out of the kitchens. The Second Helping does not talk about the ones left behind. They are expected to rejoice, and to eat, and to offer themselves in their turn. Many do. That is how the cult grows: by grief that has nowhere else to go.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Guest	A seat at the long tables; the hymns; never to eat alone again.
2	Server	Feeds newcomers; may speak at table.
3	Platholder	Leads a household kitchen; tends the Offered in their last week.
4	Garland	Has given part of themselves (a finger, an ear) and is honoured.
5	The Prophet	Brother Glut, who is being served one piece at a time.

CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN THE SOUTH

The Second Table is strong in the Fatlands, because the Gut-lines are its natural members: who better to eat a god twice than a family already eating everything? Its southern chapter meets in Marrable Hall under cover of the Unending Dinner. **The Cutwrights' College** keeps a southern registry in Sated and knows, from three centuries of weighing records, exactly which families will Seat next. **The Purgation** funds the Thin. **The Reckoners** find the Fatlands hard going: a high-Cut Gut-line, rooted on its estate, is almost impossible to kill, and the hills do not die when stabbed. **The Rim Road Company** owns a third of the Chute's wagons and does not inspect the barrels.

▼ THE FATLANDS NOW

The Reaping has doubled in ten years, and the fields are turning up things with faces: a turnip with a nose and two shut lids, a squash with the profile of a missing child, an ear of wheat that, when split, held a single human molar with a silver filling. The Board's answer is the Cullmasters, and the dusk-shift lists grow longer every Carving. The Thin are growing, recruiting among the families of the culled. A girl has appeared who feels no hunger at all, and the Board has put a price on her that does not specify alive. And for the first time, an exile from the Fast has sat down at a Fatlands table and eaten. What is happening to him has no name yet.

Underneath all of it is the arithmetic the Board will not publish. The Reaping doubles; the hills multiply; the Dowagers creep toward one another. Ummer is gathering itself up out of ten thousand graves and ten thousand bellies, and it is hungry, and it has the whole of the Fatlands for a body. Many Fatlanders have started, without saying why, to dream of walking in procession.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ **The Notched Barrels.** Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot sends a sealed list to a PC he trusts: the export barrels he has notched. A Vigil buyer has fallen ill in a way that sounds very like the Appetite. The PCs must trace a consignment from the Chute to the Rim Road, against the Renderers, the Company, and the

Board, and decide who on the Table should know what they have been eating.

- ◇ **The Dusk List.** A PC, or someone they love, is named on a Cullmaster's list. Varn Sweetbread is courteous and immovable. The PCs have until Carving dusk to bribe a Listing Clerk, find a substitute (Fatlanders will suggest one), break the Gavage open for a Thin rescue as distraction, or walk the row themselves and survive.
- ◇ **Wren for Weight.** Wren Hollowell is hidden in a Thin barn in the Orchards. The Board will pay her weight in bone coin; the Second Table will pay more for her organs; the Thin will die for her. The Fasting Girl wants none of it. She wants to see the sea.
- ◇ **The Hill That Walked.** Mercy Sowerby, the Hill-Speaker, reports that two Dowager Hills have moved close enough to touch, and that their mouths are talking to each other in a language no one living speaks. The Gut-lines want it hushed. The College wants measurements. The hills want visitors.
- ◇ **The Scarecrow Turns.** In Low Tilt, the Scarecrow has turned around, and it is facing Pell Hogget's barn. The villagers want it burned. Nobody who has tried to light it has come back from the far field.

RUMORS OF THE FATLANDS

DIO	RUMOR
1	The Chairman's roots have reached the Weighhouse cellars and are drinking from the Gravy. <i>(True.)</i>
2	There are wolves after all; a pack was seen near Kettle Furrow. <i>(False; it was a Cullmaster's line in white.)</i>
3	Dame Marrable's Dinner has a second table in the cellar where only nobles sit, and the meat there is different. <i>(True: it is the Second Table.)</i>
4	Eat a Blank's heart and you'll be full forever. <i>(False, but it is why Wren is hunted.)</i>
5	The Fast's god is walking the Rim Road, and if you follow it you'll find a meal that fills. <i>(Half-true.)</i>
6	The Board fasts in secret and only pretends to eat. <i>(False. They eat more than anyone.)</i>

THE PEOPLE OF THE FATLANDS

Chairman Obb Tullow, the Heaviest Vote. Head of the Board at nineteen hundred pounds, he is moved by dray and eight oxen through streets cleared by Bailiffs. Up close he is a landscape: rolls of cool, brown, loam-soft flesh draped over the dray’s iron bed like a slumped haystack, crusted with the green shoots his Washers never quite get off, and at the summit a small, pink, clever face that looks out of the folds like a man peering from a cellar. His voice is reedy and precise. He is still the shrewdest mind on the Board. His feet

rooted through the cart’s iron floor last spring, through a seam the smiths had missed, and the Board has agreed not to notice; the dray has not moved since, and the Board now meets around it. He wants to die Chairman. He fears the moment his mouth closes and the hill keeps voting. His secret is that the roots go all the way down to the Weighhouse cellars, and he can feel the Reaping through them, every one, as a warm full mouthful.

OBB TULLOW – CHAIRMAN OF THE BOARD OF PLENTY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 6 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 8
SKILLS	Feast 5, Endure 4, Clause 3, Persuade 3, Intimidate 3, Reckoning 3
BODY	Flesh 18 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 (loam-flesh) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	rolling crush +2 (4); cannot pursue
GIFTS	Field-Body (feels every footstep in the Weighhouse and on the Weighing Road); the Board’s grain bends toward him when he speaks; regains 1d6 Flesh per meal
WANTS	to eat whatever is placed within reach; never to be moved; to be told the Reaping figures, aloud, slowly
DREAD	3 (to watch him eat, or to see what grows under the dray)
SECRET	Tullow has arranged for the Cullmasters to list the families of every Deacon who votes against him.

Dame Suet Marrable. Gut-lines matriarch, mistress of Marrable Hall, and hostess of the Unending Dinner, in continuous service for eighty-one years. She sits at the head of the three-hundred-foot table on a reinforced throne that is slowly sinking into the floorboards, swathed in gold silk, her face powdered white and her many chins hung with pearls like dew on a hedge. She smells of rosewater over roast pork. Her voice is warm and husky and she calls everyone *duck*.

Guests have been born at her table and several have been served at it, when they died there; the custom is that no one leaves, and some have not. She wants the Dinner to outlast her and fears that it will not, because her feet have begun to grow down through the floor. She is the Second Table’s southern chair, and the cellar beneath her dining hall holds a smaller table where the guests are older and the meat is something rarer.

DAME SUET MARRABLE – HOSTESS OF THE UNENDING DINNER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Feast 5, Clause 3, Endure 3, Search 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Armor 1 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	carving knife +3 (2)
GIFTS	Taste the Name (one bite of a guest's blood tells her their family, Cut and one secret); her hall's food compels (Caul + Resolve, Hard 14, to rise from her table)
WANTS	that no guest leave hungry; that no guest leave
DREAD	2 (to see a guest served)
SECRET	She has Tobias Wether's name on a place card, and a seat waiting for him in the cellar.

Pell Hogget, the Counter. A farmer from Kettle Furrow in Low Tilth: short, broad, sunburnt, with a wheat-coloured beard and a stub of chalk always behind one ear. He speaks slowly and carefully and gives numbers instead of opinions. He noticed his village was one smaller each autumn and wrote it down, and now two hundred villages send him their tallies and his barn wall is a ledger of the dead. He eats less than he should and the Bailiff has begun to look at him. He wishes he had never learned to count. He fears that the numbers have a shape: his projection crosses his own village's population in nineteen years, and the whole country's soon after. His secret is that his wife was culled four years ago, and he has never put her mark on the wall.

Corder Lank, the Thin Man. Leader of the Thin. He has eaten nothing but water and ash for six years and can be counted bone by bone: a long, brown, tendon-strung figure in a rope belt, his skin tight as a drumhead over ribs and hips and knuckles, his eyes huge and calm and very clear. He smells of woodsmoke and nothing else. He speaks quietly and always first asks whether you are hungry. He is the only man in the south who does not feel the hunger, and he will not say how. The truth is that the hunger did not leave him: it went out of him, piece by piece, into those who fast beside him. Every Thin cell carries a share of Corder Lank's gnawing on top of its own. He worked this out three years ago. He has not told them. He cannot stop leading, because it is the only thing that keeps him clear.

CORDER LANK – THE THIN MAN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste, dormant) · Hunger 0
SKILLS	Resolve 5, Endure 4, Persuade 3, Stealth 3, Athletics 2, Rites 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	knife +3 (2)
GIFTS	Passing the Plate: anyone who fasts a day in his company loses 1 Hunger and he loses none; they gain it back, doubled, the day they leave him
WANTS	to be needed; never to be fed
DREAD	1
SECRET	His hunger lives in his followers. If he dies, it goes back to the god all at once, and the Thin will feel it go.

Mistress Brisket Annalow. Boss of the Renderers' Union: a vast, red-armed woman in a leather apron stiff with salt, her grey hair cropped short, a cleaver on a chain at her hip and a pencil behind her ear. She talks like a drover and laughs like a kettle. She can stop every barrel on the Rim Road with one word, and she knows precisely which of them should never have been filled, because she has kept a second ledger for twenty-two years. She wants the Union paid and her people safe. She fears the day the Table stops buying.

She would sell the Board out in an afternoon to keep the Chute open.

BRISKET ANNALOW Threat 5 · Flesh 15 · Guard 12 · Attack +6 (cleaver 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

Hob Gristle, the Honest Butcher. A big, mild, sorrowful man with forearms like hams and a bald head beaded with sweat. He can tell by taste what a cut used to be, down to the name: a mouthful of

sausage tells him the pig, the field it ate from, and the name of anyone Reaped into that field. It has ruined him for the trade. He still works, because jointing at wakes is the only honest money left, and he apologizes to every joint, quietly, by name. He wants one barrel from the Chute that tastes of nothing but beef. He fears the day he tastes someone he loves. He has already tasted his brother, in a pie in Sated, and has told no one.

Cullmaster Varn Sweetbread. The Board’s quiet hand: a neat, plump, pink man in grey broadcloth, with soft white fingers, rimless

spectacles and a ledger chained to his belt. He smells faintly of lavender, which he uses to cover the field. His voice is gentle and his manners perfect. He decides which vagrants, debtors and troublemakers are assigned the dusk shift, and he thinks of it as agriculture, in the most literal sense: he weighs the next year’s yields and has proved, to his own satisfaction, that a culled vagrant makes better bread than a Reaped farmer. He walks every line himself and bows at every stone. He is not cruel. That is the worst thing about him.

VARN SWEETBREAD – CULLMASTER-GENERAL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Reckoning 4, Clause 3, Intimidate 3, Resolve 3, Rites 2, Endure 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	ribboned sickle +3 (3)
GIFTS	Field-Reading: he knows, on any Carving evening, which plot will Reap first
WANTS	to see the line through to the end; to taste the bread of each plot he culled
DREAD	2 (to watch his dusk-shift)
SECRET	His own name is on next year’s list, in the Chairman’s hand.

Tansy Lard, the Gleaner. A girl of ten who gleans behind the harvesters in Low Tilth: skinny for a Fatlander, with tangled straw hair and a smock too short in the arms, and dirt permanently under her nails. She dug up a root with her mother’s birthmark on it, a brown splash shaped like a running hare, and has replanted it behind the house and waters it every day. It has grown. It has leaves like hands. Last week, at dusk, it said her name. Her father has noticed she has stopped eating at table and goes out after dark with the bowl. She wants her mother back. She is the reason the PCs may first learn what a Fatland root can become.

Brother Glut. Prophet of the Second Helping: enormous, radiant, and happy, a mountain of pink flesh in a garland of wheat, his face shining with sweat and tears of joy, his voice a deep golden bell that fills a meadow without trying. He preaches that being eaten is the highest form of being loved, and he has volunteered parts of himself to prove it: his left hand, both ears, three toes, a long strip from the flank. The wounds are bound with clean linen and he shows them off like medals. He embraces every stranger. He believes every word. What he does not see is the widows at the back of each meeting, holding their plates.

BROTHER GLUT – PROPHET OF THE SECOND HELPING	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Feast 4, Endure 4, Godsign 3
BODY	Flesh 17 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	crushing embrace +2 (1, held)
GIFTS	The Shared Plate: anyone who eats his flesh loses 1d6 Hunger and must pass Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or come back for more
WANTS	to give; to see others give
DREAD	2 (to see him carve himself, smiling)
SECRET	He has not felt the hunger since his hand was eaten. He thinks this is grace. It is the god, moving out.

Old Mother Rind. A Laden woman who rooted forty years ago and is now a small orchard hill outside the village of Kettle Furrow, with nine pear trees growing from her back and a working mouth

half-hidden in the clover at her foot. Her lips are brown and cracked like bark and her teeth are wheat-teeth, many rows. Her voice is a dry old woman’s, amused and sharp. Her village asks her advice on

marriages; she is always right, and always hungry, and her fee is meat. Lately she has asked for particular people.

Dr. Emmerich Paunch. The Board’s physician: a stooped, heavy, myopic man with ink-stained cuffs and a voice like a dry quill. He opened a Gut-lines stomach, under licence, to measure its capacity, and lowered a plumb line into it. He ran out of line at two hundred feet. He has since obtained longer line. He has not been able to bring himself to use it, because when he drew the first one up, the lead weight had been chewed. He wants to publish. He fears the Board, and what he heard echoing up the line. He will pay adventurers very well to hold the rope.

Sal Trotter, the Drover. A lean, weathered woman in a dung-crusted oilskin, with a crook, a whip she never uses, and a pipe she never lights. She walks herds to market at the Chute that the buyers call cattle. They walk on two legs when no one is watching the road. She has stopped naming them, because they started answering. She speaks little, mostly to the herd, in a low, even croon. She wants to finish one drive without looking back. She fears the day one of them asks her where they are going. It will be soon; the lead steer has begun to hum her songs.

SAL TROTTER’S HERD (EACH) Threat 2 · Flesh 16 · Guard 10 · Attack +4 (trample 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 (to see them stand)

Wren Hollowell, the Fasting Girl. A Blank of fifteen from Bramble Furrow who has never once felt hungry. She is small and narrow and pale, with a long plain face and grey eyes that rest on things without wanting them, and in a land of the vast she looks like a drawing of a girl rather than a girl. She eats when reminded, without interest. The Thin kneel to her, which she hates. The Board has offered her weight in bone coin to whoever brings her in, and has not specified alive; the Second Table has a surgeon waiting. She

wants to see the sea, and to be left alone. She is beginning to notice that fields go quiet when she walks through them, as though they cannot smell her at all.

WREN HOLLOWELL Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · cannot be Reaped; no Cut, no Hunger

Garrick Tripe, the Weigher. Keeper of the official scales at the annual Weighing: a jovial, oily man in a brass-buttoned coat, with a waxed moustache and a dozen rings. For the right fee your pockets fill with lead, and for a better one your rival’s empty. He has personally elected three governments. He wants to retire rich. He fears that the Chairman knows exactly how much of his vote is lead; Tullow does, and is waiting for the right moment.

Lady Aspic Dellamore. A noble chef whose speciality is preservation: tall for a Gut-line, sleek and plump, in a white silk apron, with lacquered nails and a cold, musical laugh. Her rivals are displayed in her gallery, set in clear golden jelly, garnished with herbs and quail’s eggs, and blinking. The jelly keeps them; the Gut-line blood keeps them hungry. They watch visitors eat at her table. She wants to be the greatest cook on the Table. She fears blandness. She is working on a new piece for the gallery, and has been measuring Dame Marrable.

Jem Crackle, the Cook’s Knife. A former spit-boy and now the most reliable assassin in Sated: wiry, quick, red-knuckled, with burn scars to the elbow and the cheerful, sweaty face of a kitchen lad. He smells of onions and hot iron. He kills only in kitchens, and what he kills is on the table by evening, jointed, dressed and served so beautifully that the families often do not complain. He is proud of his work and owes nothing to anyone. He fears only being bored. He takes contracts from the Board, the Union and the Second Table impartially.

JEM CRACKLE – THE COOK’S KNIFE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stealth 4, Athletics 3, Feast 3, Craft 3, Filch 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 19 · Armor 0 · Fray 1
ATTACKS	boning knife +10 (2); cleaver +10 (3)
GIFTS	In any kitchen he gains a free Helping on his first attack; he can joint a body in the time it takes to boil a kettle
WANTS	to cook what he kills
DREAD	2 (to find a missing friend on his table)
SECRET	He has a list of every person he has served, and who ate them. He sells it.

Bailiff Dunmow Fatt. Enforcer of the Feasting Laws in Sated: a huge, slow, pink-cheeked man with a gentle lisp, a blue sash, and a funnel and ladle of office worn like a sword and sceptre. He is, by every account, gentle about it. He kneels to feed the stubborn, strokes their throats, sings to them. He has wept over every Thin

prisoner he has ever taken. He wants everyone to be well. He does not understand why anyone would refuse. He fears, a little, the quiet in Corder Lank’s eyes.

DUNMOW FATT Threat 3 · Flesh 16 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (ladle 3,

Grappling) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

Marigold Chine. Keeper of the oldest grove in the Bleeding Orchards: a slender, freckled woman of fifty with a strong alto and a straw hat. She refused the deafening and sings to her trees through the pruning. They have begun to sing back, in tune, in her voice, a thousand trees at once, and the other keepers, who cannot hear it, feel it in their teeth. She wants to learn what the trees are trying to say. She fears she already knows: the last verse is the wake-song, and it is about her.

Tobias Wether, the First to Eat. A runaway from the Fast, twenty-four, raised on six centuries of refusal, who crossed the Rim Road and ate. He was thin as a rake when he came; he is filling out

now, and his skin has taken on a warm brown loam-tint. He carries no god in his blood. The meat seems to be looking for one. He feels the hunger now, a borrowed hunger with no lineage, and it is worse than any Fatlander's, because it has nowhere to settle. He is ashamed, delighted, and terrified. The Second Table wants him; the Reckoners want him dead; Dame Marrable wants him at dinner.

The Scarecrow of Low Tilt. Nobody put it up. It stands in the far field of Kettle Furrow with its back to the village: a tall, thin shape of sacking and straw on a pole, in a farmer's smock and a wide hat, its arms spread. The straw is toothed wheat. The sacking is warm. Each Carving it is a few furrows closer. Last year someone saw it turn around. Its face, they say, is a mouth, and the mouth is full of the names on Pell Hogget's wall.

THE SCARECROW – THE FAR FIELD

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 0 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	none; it is a piece of Ummer standing up
SKILLS	Stealth 5, Instinct 5, Brawl 3, Endure 4
BODY	Flesh 30 · Guard 15 · Armor 2 · Fray —
ATTACKS	straw fingers +6 (3, and the target's feet begin to root: Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or held)
GIFTS	moves only when unobserved; any field it stands in Reaps at dusk; fire will not take on it
WANTS	to reach the village
DREAD	4 (to see it face you)
SECRET	It is walking toward the Weighhouse, by way of every village that has stopped counting.

Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot. He feeds the army and stamps the export barrels at the Chute: a portly, fussy, honest man with a bald freckled head, a stamp on a cord and a tremor in his left hand. He has started marking a small notch on the ones he would not eat from himself. There are a great many notches. He wants someone outside the Fatlands to know. He fears that if they knew, they would keep buying.

Granny Cracknel, the Tooth-Miller. She mills the toothed wheat at the old water-mill on the Little Gravy and keeps the teeth. Her mill is decorated with eleven hundred sets, sorted by village and strung on wires like rattling wind-chimes. She is tiny, ancient, floury, toothless herself, and chuckles constantly. She says some of the sets match people she knew. She is right; and she has started to find, in each new harvest's sieve, the teeth of people who are still alive.

NEW FACES

Wakemother Pudding Hesk. (*new*) The most sought-after wake-cook in Sated: a round, brisk, broad-faced woman with forearms scarred by spatter and a laugh that rattles crockery. Families wait months for her. She bastes the dead with their own dripping and a little honey, roasts them slow over applewood, and sends them to the table glazed and crackling, and she weeps every time, openly, while she carves. She knows everyone's secrets, because the dead

taste of them. She wants to cook the Chairman. She has been asked to. She fears she will be too greedy to share him.

Feeder Callow Pudge. (*new*) Head feeder at the Gavage: a soft-voiced, motherly woman in a starched white apron, with plump dimpled hands and a funnel she has polished for thirty years. She hums lullabies as she pours. She sincerely believes she saves lives. She keeps a book of the Thin she has fed, with their weights in and their weights out, and letters from their grateful families. She fears the ones who come back to the Thin, and she has begun, secretly, to leave one cell door unbarred each Lack.

CALLOW PUDGE AND GAVAGE FEEDERS Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (grapple, then funnel: Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or helpless) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

Mercy Sowerby, the Hill-Speaker. (*new*) A young widow employed by the Gut-lines to interpret the Dowager Hills: thin-lipped, careful, dressed in field-brown with soil always on her knees, because she must lie face-down on the turf to hear. She translates the Dowagers' slow speech and lays their offerings. She has noticed that two hills are moving together, that their mouths are talking, and that the language is older than Table-speech. She wants someone to tell. She fears the Dowagers have noticed her noticing; last week one of them used her name.

Lord Chastain Loin. (*new*) Heir to a Gut-line that Seated last generation: a young, enormous, beautiful man of eight hundred pounds, with oiled ringlets, perfect teeth, and a voice like warm cream. He is Dame Marrable's protégé in the Second Table, charged with acquiring Blanks for the cellar table. He eats elegantly and

constantly, and his manners never slip. He wants to be at the table when Ummer stands up, with a knife in his hand. He fears that his own mother, the hill behind his house, will stand up first, and that she has never forgiven him for the wake.

▼PLAYING A FATLANDER

You were raised on the best food on the Table and you have never once been full. You are large, warm, generous and polite, and you think of the dead as dinner and the fields as family. Abroad you will find other peoples' food grey and joyless, and their faces when you mention your grandmother's wake will teach you to stop mentioning it.

Attribute bonus: +1 GUT.

The Sop: Clean the Plate. Eat a full meal until it hurts, and finish every scrap. This removes 1d6 Hunger. If the meal is the flesh of the human dead (a wake, a battlefield, a Second Helping table), remove 1d6+2 instead. The compulsion is fed: for the rest of the day, Want checks against *The Second Plate* are one step harder.

The Tooth. When a Fatlander Partakes, the mouth floods with saliva, the belly growls loud enough for the room to hear, and the teeth ache as though new ones were pushing through. Nearby food smells stronger. On a Tooth showing 1, the god bites back: the character must eat something, anything within reach, before their next action.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). Iron Belly. You can eat almost anything: rotten meat, tallow, leather, mild poisons. Gain +2 to Feast rolls, and you may eat a meal's weight of anything organic as a Sop for half value (1d3 Hunger). *Cost:* each of the five daily meals you miss adds 1 Hunger.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Taste the Name. A mouthful of someone's flesh or blood (a cut, a kiss that draws blood, a slice at a wake) tells you their family, their Cut, and one thing they have eaten that they are ashamed of; on a Grace, one secret. **Gorge.** Spend ten minutes eating heavily to heal 1d6 Flesh (once per scene). *Cost:* each use of Taste the Name adds 1 Hunger, and witnesses who are not Fatlanders face a Dread 2 check.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). Laden. Your GUT rises by 1 (to a maximum of 6) and your LUNG falls by 1; your loam-soft flesh grants Armor 1 that stacks with worn armor. **Rooting.** Standing still on bare soil for a round, you may root: you cannot be moved, knocked down or Reaped, gain +2 Guard, and heal 1 Flesh per round. *Cost:* tearing free deals 1d6 Flesh; each hour rooted adds 1 Hunger and requires Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to leave at all.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). The Field Answers. Rooted, you feel every step on soil within a mile, and you may make the ground lean: crops grab and hold (Gut 5, Hard 14 to break free) for a scene, or a ripe field Reaps one helpless target at dusk. *Cost:* each use is a Dread 4 for witnesses and adds 2 Hunger; on a Lack, you do not uproot for a day.

WANTS

- ◇ **The Second Plate.** When food is in sight and your Hunger is 4 or more, you must eat it, whoever it belongs to. Resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14; Grim 18 if it is meat).
- ◇ **The Hollow.** When someone near you refuses food, you must make them eat, with words and then with hands. Resist at Hard 14.
- ◇ **The Long Pig.** At the Appetite and beyond, a corpse smells like supper. Resist at Hard 14 to leave it uneaten; at Grim 18 if it is someone you loved.
- ◇ **Stillness.** At the Course and beyond, when standing on warm soil at dusk, you want to stay. Resist at Hard 14 or root.

THE SEATING

A Fatlander who reaches Regrowth 12 becomes a hill. The player chooses where: a field they loved, a road they guarded, a grave they would not dig. The character is retired from play but not gone: they are a place, warm, fertile and hungry, and the other PCs may consult them as a Dowager, bring them meat, and receive true and terrible counsel. Some keep a mouth. All of them, in time, begin to move.

BACKGROUNDS

- ◇ **Jointer's Apprentice.** You carved at wakes for the Renderers before you were twenty, and you know a body as a map of cuts. *Suggested:* Blades, Stitching, Feast.
- ◇ **Thin Runaway.** You fasted with Corder Lank, were caught, and were fed at the Gavage. You are heavy now and you hate it. *Suggested:* Endure, Stealth, Resolve.
- ◇ **Dusk-Shift Survivor.** Your name was on a list. You walked the row, watched the wheat lean, and walked back. Nobody in your village will meet your eye. *Suggested:* Wayfaring, Instinct, Labor.

NAMES

Given (male): Obb, Hob, Wilm, Varn, Garrick, Dunmow, Ivo, Abel, Ruddie, Barnaby, Crust, Leggat. **Given (female):** Suet, Tansy, Marigold, Petty, Brisket, Hessop, Callow, Nell, Gravy, Dumpling, Wenna, Ysolde. **Neutral:** Pell, Sal, Wren, Jem, Rind, Haslet, Chine, Pudding. **Surnames:** Tullow, Marrable, Hogget, Lank, Gristle,

Lard, Paunch, Trotter, Tripe, Crackle, Fatt, Chine, Wether, Stockpot, Cracknel, Callock, Strake, Loin, Dripping, Furrow.

HORRORS OF THE FATLANDS

Roll a d10, or choose, when the party is travelling the plains, staying in a village, or simply sitting down to eat.

D10	HORROR
1	A child at the inn table chews her sleeve to threads, then the table edge, then, smiling, the side of her own hand. Her mother gently moves a pie toward her. (Dread 2)
2	Marbling morning: the white veins in the field run in the shape of a woman lying on her side, and they pulse. (Dread 2)
3	A wake in progress; the family insists the party join. The meat is the PC's contact from last session. (Dread 3)
4	A cabbage at market has a face, eyes shut, and it is the face of a stallholder two rows over, who is staring at it. (Dread 2)
5	At dusk, a line of white-smocked figures walks out along the furrows behind a lantern. One of them turns and mouths <i>help</i> . (Dread 3)
6	A well-bucket comes up full of warm broth, and something in the dark below swallows. (Dread 1)
7	A Laden man rooted by the road asks the party to pull him free. When they try, he screams, and the roots bleed, and the field around them groans. (Dread 3)
8	A Second Helping procession passes, singing, carrying a garlanded woman in dripping. Her small son walks behind holding her shoe. (Dread 3)
9	The party's bread, broken, is full of fine fair hair. The miller says it is from the Hessop plot, and that young Hessop was very pretty. (Dread 2)
10	The ground under the camp rises and falls all night. At dawn there is a new hill where the cookfire was, warm, with a mouth, and it calls one PC by their mother's name. (Dread 4)



CHAPTER 5

BRINEHOLLOW

The sea is not going out. It is going in.

– CARVED ON THE LOWMARK TIDE-POST, AUTHOR UNKNOWN

Call the names. Call them twice. If the wall answers in a voice you know, call them a third time, and listen for whether it knows you.

– INSTRUCTION FOR THE MORNING COUNT, AS TAUGHT TO CHILDREN ON THE MILE

The Count, as kept by Wenna Truss of Ropery Row, Lowmark, Mile Eleven. Written on the back of a chandler's bill and found folded inside her bail-bucket.

I call through the wall at first bell, same as every morning since I could stand. My mother taught me. You put your mouth to the plank where it's worn smooth, where the knot looks like an ear, and you call the names on the other side. Haddie. Bren. Little Os. Old Cobb. And they call back, one at a time, with the cough still in their voices, because nobody has bailed yet at first bell. That is how you know they are home. The wet in the throat. The answer.

This morning I called Haddie and Haddie answered. I called Bren and Bren answered. I called Little Os and he answered in that piping way, still half asleep, and I heard Haddie hush him. I called Old Cobb.

I want to set down exactly what happened next, because they will ask me at the Netwatch house and I will not be able to say it with my mouth.

Nothing answered. Not silence like an empty room. Silence like a held breath. The whole house on the other side of the plank went still, the way a pool goes still when something big turns over under it. And then Haddie began to make a sound I have heard eleven times in my life and never once from her.

I went round. The door was on the latch. Cobb's bed is the one by the west window, because he likes the light, because he has always liked the light, the old fool, and we all said it, we all said you shouldn't sleep facing that way at your age. The rope was still tied to the bedpost. Good tarred hemp from the Ropewalk, three turns and a hitch, done by Bren the night before. It was tied to the bedpost and it went across the blanket and over the edge of the bed and it stopped. The end was cut clean. Not frayed. Not chewed. Cut, the way you would cut it if you had a sharp knife and a steady hand and all the time in the world.

There was no knife in the room.

The floor was wet from the bed to the door, and from the door down the steps, and across the boards of the Row, and on to the pier rail, and over it, and on into the dark of the Uncovered where there is no water any more for nineteen miles. The wet went west. It does not dry fast on the Mile. It never has.

Haddie kept saying, I tied it, I tied it, I checked it, as if that was the thing that mattered, and Bren kept saying, I tied it, Mam, it was me, and Little Os stood in the doorway holding Cobb's bail-bucket in both arms, the old copper one with the dent, and he said, Grandda forgot his bucket.

He did. He will not need it now.

I want to say also that the bed was warm. The pillow still had the shape of him. On the pillow, where his mouth would have been, there was a little crust of white salt, and in the salt there was a print, like someone had kissed it. I do not know what that means. I did not tell Haddie.

They will put his name on the post. They will cut his rope into nine pieces and give one to each of us and one to the wall. We will set his bowl on Tablenight with the seawater in it and we will leave the west door unbarred, and every one of us will lie awake hoping he does not come in.

That is the worst of it, and I will write it because nobody says it. You pray for them to come home and you pray they don't. Because if Cobb comes walking up out of the dark one morning, heavy and gentle and dripping, with his own face and his own laugh and the name of every grandchild on his lips, Haddie will take him in. She will feed him. She will rope him to the same bed. And every morning I will put my mouth to the plank and call his name, and he will answer, in a voice just a little lower than it should be, and I will never again know who I am talking to.

Haddie. Bren. Little Os.

Tomorrow there will be three names.

▼ THE MEAL

The western coast ate Dromm, the Fathom, god of the deep sea, of pressure, and of what is kept under. Every land's Gorging has its peculiar horror. Brinehollow's is that the god had to be brought to the table, and that it took four days to stop moving once it got there.

Dromm did not live on land. It lived beneath the whole grey reach of the western water, a presence more than a shape, and the coast knew it the way a body knows its own blood pressure: as a weight, a steadiness, the thing that kept the bottom of the sea where it belonged. Before the Lack, the fishers said that Dromm held the drowned down so they would not frighten their families by floating, and held the storms down so the boats came home, and held the cold water under the warm so the herring rose. It was a god of keeping things where they were put. Its priests were divers who went down on weighted ropes and came back with bleeding ears and with answers.

In the ninth winter there were no herring. There were no answers either. The divers went down and found Dromm lying in the shallows off a long, flat beach called Longslab, closer to shore than any god had ever come, as though it had surfaced to wait. It was so large that nobody living could agree on its shape. Accounts written within a generation describe a back like a reef of black slate, plates of it, crusted with things that were not barnacles; a flank that rose and fell, very slowly, with a sound like surf heard through a wall; and eyes, or something like eyes, that stood open under the water, wider than doorways, the color of the sea a mile down.

The hauling took every vessel on the coast and every hand that could hold rope. Ten thousand hooks, by the count the Admiralty still teaches: shark hooks, gaff hooks, anchors beaten into barbs, meat hooks taken off the walls of empty smokehouses. They set them in the god from boats and from the shallows and from the beach itself, in long lines of starving men and women and children who leaned back on the hemp and sang the hauling songs, and the god came in a yard at a time. It did not fight. That is recorded here as everywhere. It came in the way a drowned man comes in, heavy and unresisting, with the water pouring out of it.

That was the first horror. The water did not stop. It ran out of Dromm in sheets, in torrents, from every gap between the plates, from the eyes, from places that opened along its sides like gills that had never been needed, and it ran for four days. It was colder than any water on the coast. It smelled of iron and of something older than salt. It came out under such pressure that it knocked haulers flat and blinded them, and the people at the front of the lines drowned standing up on dry shingle, their lungs filled from the spray. The beach under the god became a lake, and then a marsh, and it has never dried since.

Haul and hold, haul and hold,

the deep is warm and the shore is cold.

Haul and hold, and lean you back,

the Fathom comes for the Lack, the Lack.

Haul and hold and do not look,

there's one of us on every hook.

— the Longslab hauling song, of which only these verses survive. The sixth line is sung by children in the Mile as a skipping rhyme. Nobody can explain it. A verse after it, between the fifth and the seventh, was struck from every written copy before 100 A.G.

On the fourth day, the god stopped moving. The water still ran, but more slowly, and the vast flank no longer rose. The butchering began at dusk, by lamplight and by bonfires of wreck-wood, and it was done with whale-spades, axes, and the long knives of the flensing yards. Survivors' accounts agree on the smell: like opening a tide pool that had been sealed for a thousand years. They agree on the sound: that when the first spade went in, every person on the beach felt their ears pop at once, and some of them never heard properly again. They agree that the flesh was white and dense and very cold, and that it was the best thing any of them had ever tasted, and that it tasted like being held.

The families who reached the lungs first were the boldest and the strongest and the nearest, and they did not wait for fire. Dromm's lungs were caverns, chambers that a family could walk into, spongy and silver-grey and still full of the deep. The founders of the Lung-lines went inside the god with their knives and their bare hands and ate the lungs raw, from within, in the dark, with the water rising around their knees. The chronicles of the Vasht family record, with what was meant as pride, that their founder Ondric Vasht ate until he could not breathe and went on eating anyway, and was carried out of the god's chest at dawn half-drowned and laughing and coughing up salt water, and that he coughed up salt water every dawn and dusk from that day until he died. He was the first to bail.

The bones were never fully cleared. The Longslab middens are still there, under the marsh, and the god's skull was too large to move and too hard to break. It was left where it lay, and the sea covered it, and then the sea began, five centuries later, to leave. It is not on the Uncovered now. It was not taken. Nobody knows where it went.

THE MISSING LINE

Every family of the coast keeps some fragment of the Longslab hauling songs, and every version has the same gap: a verse that has been struck out, sometimes scored through so hard the pen went through the page. In the oldest carved record of the Beaching, a frieze on the Admiralty's Sounding Hall, the hauling teams are shown in long lines, each line labeled for a village of the coast. There are eight lines of haulers. The eighth has been chiseled flat. The figures on its rope are gone, but the rope is still carved, and it runs, like all the others, into the god.

GMs should let players find this and wonder. Brinehollow does not know what the eighth rope means and does not want to.

Dromm was the god of holding things down. It is now held in them, and what it holds down in its new house is the house itself.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

The sea is inside the people. Everything in Brinehollow follows from that sentence, and the country has had six hundred and forty-one years to learn how far it goes.

THE TIDE IN THE BODY

Every Brinehollower has a tide. Twice a day, near dawn and near dusk, the lungs fill with salt water from nowhere. It is not inhaled. It rises from inside, cold, through the bronchial tree, like water coming up through sand when you dig on a beach. It begins as a tightness and a taste. Within a few minutes the breath gurgles. Within a quarter hour a person who has not cleared it is drowning in their own chest.

Clearing it is called **bailing**. It is done bent over a bucket, with the body tipped forward and the shoulders worked, in long racking coughs that bring the water up in gouts. A healthy adult bails a pint or two. Lung-lines nobles bail gallons. The water is clear, cold, faintly green, and alive in small ways: fine sand, a thread of weed, now and then a sand-flea that hops on the bucket's rim and is gone. It smells like the sea did when there was a sea at the end of every street. Children are taught to bail before they are taught to read, and a child who cannot yet bail on its own is held face-down over a mother's knee and patted on the back, twice a day, as she sings. Every lullaby on the coast is a bailing song, in the rhythm of a cough.

Bailing is done at dawn and dusk the way other peoples wash their faces, privately and without comment. Bail-water is poured into the gutters, which run west, always west, whatever the slope of the street.

Those who cannot bail — the very old, the sick, the drunk, the injured, the unconscious — must be bailed by others, held head-down and struck between the shoulder blades until the water runs. Neglecting to bail a helpless person is murder in Brinehollow law, and it is the most common murder there is, because it requires only that one stay asleep.

THE PULL AND THE CALLED

The tide pulls as well as fills. The water in the body wants to go home, and on certain nights it takes the body with it.

The Called rise in their sleep, or in a waking trance that looks like sleep, and walk west. They do not hurry. They do not respond to their names. They walk to the nearest shore, which in the present age may be miles away across the Uncovered, and then they walk into the sea and keep walking until the water closes over them. Nobody who has watched it says the Called look afraid. The Netwatch's records use a standard phrase, written in the logs thousands of times: "**Subject appeared expected.**" As if someone were waiting for them and they did not want to be late.

Calling nights are not random, though no one has fully mapped them. They cluster at the licked-clean moon, on pressure days, in the weeks after a death in the family, and on nights when the indoor tide runs unusually high. They cluster in households. They cluster in grief. A widower whose wife was Called in Lack has, by the Netwatch's reckoning, one chance in four of following her before Grace.

The defence is **anchoring**. People sleep roped, chained, or weighted to the bed. Sweethearts tie each other's knots. In the poorer streets of the Mile a whole family may sleep on one floor, lashed in a line to a single iron ring set into the joists, like a boat's crew in a storm. And still, every year, ropes are found cut. Sometimes there is a knife on the floor that the sleeper has kept hidden for weeks without knowing they were hiding it. Sometimes there is no knife at all. And sometimes, which is the thing nobody says aloud, there is a knife in another hand: a spouse who could not bear the pleading any longer, a child who heard a parent crying to be let go and loved them too much to refuse. A rope cut in the night is the country's great domestic tragedy, and the question of who cut it is the question that breaks families.

THE TENANTED

Most of the Called are never seen again. Some come back.

They come weeks later, usually at dawn, walking up out of the surf heavier than they left: denser, slower, their footprints sinking deep into wet sand. They are calm and courteous. They know the way home. They have the same face, the same scars, the same memories down to the names of childhood dogs and the location of the spare key. They greet their families with real warmth and apologize for the worry. They ask for their bail-bucket, and bail a great deal, and then they ask whether there is any supper.

They are the **Tenanted**, and someone else is looking out through their eyes.

It is not always easy to say how one knows. A Tenanted man still laughs at his brother's jokes, but a beat late, as if the joke had to come down a long way to reach him. A Tenanted mother still sings the old songs to her children, but her voice has a second voice beneath it, lower, that sometimes finishes the line first. The Tenanted do not lie, cannot be bribed, do not lose their temper, and are, by every measure anyone has devised, kinder and fairer than they were before. Their families are often happier. That is the horror the Wreckwives exist to share.

Whether the person who walked into the sea is still in there somewhere, folded small under the weight of the thing that came back with them, is Brinehollow's oldest unanswerable question. It is rude to ask a returned person where they went. It is ruder to ask whether they are still there.

THE SEA IS MOVING HOUSE

Meanwhile, the ocean itself is leaving. Since 512 A.G. the waterline has dropped every year, slowly at first, then by furlongs, then by miles. Harbors stand dry. Fishing fleets sit on mud. The great port of Lowmark has chased the water nineteen miles out across the dry seabed on a road of piers, and is still chasing. The sea is not evaporating. The Salt Assay has proved this, with buckets and with arithmetic, and has been forbidden to say where it is going instead.

The tide is also in the houses. In every cellar in Brinehollow, however far inland, water rises twice a day and drains away again, and leaves kelp on the stairs. A farmhouse forty miles from the coast

will have a wet cellar step, a ring of salt on its walls, and once in a while a crab in the coal-bin. The country's buildings have adapted: cellars are tiled, drains run west, and anything of value is kept above the high-water mark, which is painted on the wall of every cellar in red and repainted every year a little higher.

RUNNING THE CALLING

On a Calling night, any Brinehollower (or anyone with brine in their blood; see Dry Jonah and the Vigil's rouse) who sleeps unanchored, or whose anchoring fails, must make a **Caul + Resolve** roll. The difficulty is Routine (10) at Regrowth 0–3, Hard (14) at 4–6, Grim (18) at 7–9 and Dire (22) at the Brink. A licked-clean moon, a recent Called death in the family, or sleeping facing west each add +2 to the difficulty. Success: the character wakes at the door or the window, cold and wet to the knees, with the taste of the sea in their mouth. Failure: they walk. Companions may try to wake or hold them (an opposed GUT + Labor roll against the Called character's LUNG + Athletics; the Called do not feel pain and do not tire).

Treat a PC's Calling as a dramatic scene, never a mechanical loss. Give the other players time and agency to stop it. A character who reaches the sea is gone for 2d6 weeks; the GM decides, with the player, whether they return Tenanted (the character becomes an NPC, or continues at the Brink under the rules for Playing a Brinehollower), or not at all.

Above all, play the Calling as grief. The horror is not the walking. It is the empty bed, the warm pillow, the rope end, and the people at the table who have to keep setting a place.

SALT MANNERS

It is rude to mention how someone sounds when they breathe. Brinehollowers gurgle, rattle, and whistle in the hours before bailing, and politeness requires that everyone pretend not to hear.

It is rude to ask a returned person where they went.

It is rude to stand between someone and a west-facing window.

It is rude to refuse a bail-bucket offered to an outsider. Hold it, say "Keep you dry," and hand it back.

It is very rude, and in some towns actionable, to tie your own knot loosely.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN BRINEHOLLOW

Dromm is growing back, and what it grows back into is depth. The Regrowth here is a slow drowning that never finishes, a body learning, against every instinct it was born with, to live under a weight it cannot see.

THE TASTE

Salt on the lips at waking: a fine white crust at the corners of the mouth, as if the sleeper had spent the night on a beach in the wind. Ears that pop indoors, especially in cellars, especially at the turn of the tide. A Brinehollower at the Taste wakes with the sheets damp in the shape of their body. Their voice sounds faintly wet to strangers. They find themselves telling the time by the tightness in their chest

rather than by the bell, and they are always right. Children at the Taste hold their breath in play for longer than any child should, and laugh about it when they come up, and their mothers do not laugh.

THE APPETITE

The pull. A person at the Appetite stands at windows that face west and does not know how long they have been there. They put their hands flat on the glass. They sleepwalk to the nearest water, and anything will do: a well, a rain barrel, a horse trough, a washbasin. Families find them kneeling on the floor in the dark with their faces in the basin, not drowning, simply resting there, breathing it, perfectly calm. They crave cold food and salt. They eat raw shellfish from the Uncovered middens, which are poison to anyone else, and are not poisoned. They lose interest in warmth. They stop noticing that they have not bailed, and their families start doing it for them.

The bail-water changes too. Tolly Brack the Bailer Boy reads it: clear for the healthy, faintly green at the Appetite, and then, for those close to Calling, a deep sea-blue with a weight to it, like water pulled from a hundred fathoms. Some households keep the dawn bail-water in a glass jar on the sill so they can check its color by daylight. Most would rather not know.

THE COURSE

The body adapts to depth. The skin goes grey, then the grey of wet slate, smooth and cool and thickened, with a faint pebbling along the spine and the backs of the hands. The eyes widen. The pupils swell until there is almost no iris, black and wet and reflective, and in the dark they shine green like a cat's. The chest stops needing to rise. A person in the Course can sit for an hour without breathing visibly, and the stillness of their ribs is the thing that unsettles visitors most, more than the eyes.

Inside, the change is worse. Dr. Isolde Reave has opened Course chests on her table and recorded what she found: lungs grown spongy, silver, cavernous, packed with chambers like the inside of a sea-cucumber; ribs thickened and drawn inward, as though by enormous pressure; a heart small, slow, and dense as a stone. The lungs hold water now as their natural state. Air is the intrusion. A person in the Course is uncomfortable in open air, as a land-dweller would be under water: they feel thin, exposed, dizzy, light, as if they might float away. They sleep in a cistern, weighted, with only the face above the surface, or, more and more often, with no part of themselves above it at all.

The voice drops. It gains an undertone, like a second speaker standing just behind the first. Ears bleed on pressure days.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

A long grey coast of shingle, salt marsh, and cliff, three hundred miles from the Cradlewrack border in the north to the Fatlands

Fingernails thicken and yellow. Hair falls out in the bath in long dark ropes that drift on the water like weed.

THE BRINK

At the Brink the person has heard the invitation in full. It is no longer a pull. It is a voice that knows their name, that has always known it, that is patient and kind and very, very old. The body at the Brink is heavy beyond its size: floors creak under a slight woman, beds break, horses refuse to carry them. They sink in mud to the knee. They are cold to the touch, so cold that kisses leave a white mark. Their tears are salt enough to sting cuts. Their sweat leaves rime. They hear the sea in every silence, not as memory but as direction, as a compass hears north.

Most of the Called at the Brink go, and most of those who come back come back Tenanted. A Tenanted person stands at the Brink permanently: something sits in them, and something of them may still be there underneath.

THE SEATING

The Tenant takes the whole house. What walks around afterward is a piece of Dromm, patient, pressing outward against the skin. The fully Seated do not look very different from the Tenanted, at first. Then they stop bothering with the smaller courtesies: they no longer blink, or answer to their name, or eat. Their skin bows outward between the ribs, as if under pressure from within, and their weight becomes impossible. They are not violent. They are simply present, the way a deep place is present, and the air around them thickens until lamps gutter and ears ring. The Admiralty keeps them in the lowest cisterns of Fathomhouse and records them as **"retired to depth"**. Nobody is sure any longer how many there are, or what they are waiting for.

THE TENANT QUESTION

The bible's central uncertainty in Brinehollow is whether the Tenanted are still the people they were. The GM should decide privately, and is encouraged to decide differently for different Tenanted. Some are entirely Dromm wearing a stolen memory. Some are a person and a piece of god sharing a house, each aware of the other. Some may be the original person, returned and unchanged, with every neighbor convinced otherwise (see Esk Penhallow). Players should never be certain. Seeing a loved one return Tenanted is a Dread 3 horror. Seeing one return and being unable to tell is worse, and should be played across sessions, not resolved in one.

marches in the south, under a sky the color of a gutted herring. Beyond the old shoreline lies the **Uncovered**: a newly exposed

seabed that stretches further west every year. It is not flat. It is a country of ravines and shelves and drowned hills, of weed forests gone to brown leather, of wrecks standing upright on their keels as though still sailing, and of things with too many ribs.

It rains salt. Not a little salt: rain in Brinehollow tastes like a tear and dries on window glass in white lace. Fog comes in from a sea that is now miles away, rolling across the Uncovered in walls, and it smells of tide pools and rot. Gulls nest inland, on church roofs, in chimneys, and they are thin and angry and pick at the eyes of sleeping dogs.

On **pressure days** the air thickens until ears bleed. These come without warning, perhaps a dozen times a year: a sudden heaviness, a hush, birds dropping out of the air to sit stunned on the ground, windows bowing inward with a creak and sometimes bursting. Candle flames stand flat and blue. Everyone in the street touches their ears and comes away with blood on their fingers, and the old men say “the Fathom’s turning over.” Children have died on pressure days, crushed in their cots by nothing anyone could see. Callings triple on the night after one.

And there is the **indoor tide**. In every cellar in the country, however far inland, water rises twice a day and drains away again, leaving kelp on the stairs. The tide is cold, clear, and comes up from the floor, not the walls. It brings small gifts: shells, sea-glass, a child’s shoe, a ring. It has been known to bring back things the Called were wearing when they went.

PLACES OF BRINEHOLLOW

LOWMARK

The capital, a nineteen-mile pier-city built out across the dry seabed, section by section, after the sea. Old Lowmark on the original shore, now called the Headland, holds the Admiralty, the Sounding Hall, Fathomhouse, and the tide-post. From it the Mile runs west on tarred pilings sixty feet high: a wooden road lined with houses, chandlers, chapels, taverns and bail-houses, all creaking, all leaning a little westward. Mile One is rich, Mile Seven is Netwatch barracks, Miles Twelve to Sixteen are slum, roped and chained and stinking of tar and bail-water. The Nineteenth ends in a working harbor where a few licensed boats go out and come back with catches nobody likes to describe. Sixty feet below, the old seabed is dark and wet and full of what the city drops. People live down there, too.

LONGSLAB

The beach of the Beaching. Permanently wet, though no sea has touched it in a century. Water seeps up through the shingle as if the beach were a sponge someone is always pressing. Nothing grows there, and gulls will not land on it. At the tide-turns the wet ground breathes: a slow sigh across two miles of stones, and a smell of the deep. Pilgrims of the Deepening come to lie face-down on it and listen. The Longslab middens beneath are full of bones too large to be any animal’s.

THE UNCOVERED

The exposed seabed, salvage country, lawless and strange, with a new mile of it every year. Near the old shore it is cracked white salt littered with six centuries of wreckage, skeletons still in the rigging. Further out it turns to mud flats, leather-weed jungle, and drowned valleys where dead reefs stand up like ruined cathedrals, blue with rot. Things live there that came up as the water fell and did not die properly: cart-sized crabs, slow and soft-shelled; ribbed things that drag themselves on fins across the mud at night; fish that breathe air, badly, with a sound like a sick man snoring. And there are older things, uncovered for the first time since before the Gorging: carved stones, paved roads running west into the deep, and at least one table.

THE HANGING ABBEY

The Anchorites’ cliff, forty miles north of Lowmark: four hundred feet of black basalt above a field of dry white boulders that was once the sea. A thousand living monks hang on it, chained by iron collars to rings set in the rock, each on a ledge or in a scooped cell, most open to the salt rain. Food comes down in baskets; waste falls. At dawn and dusk the whole cliff coughs at once, and water runs down the rock in sheets. At night they pray aloud, or scream, and from below it is impossible to tell which.

THE TRENCH

The place far out where the water is still deep, and where it seems to be going. Thirty miles west of Lowmark’s last pier the Uncovered ends at a cliff edge, and beyond it lies black water that has not dropped at all, an abyss of unknown depth with a current that runs downward. From the edge you can hear it draining: a low, endless sound like a throat swallowing. Salvagers who go to the brink report a warm updraft that smells of breath, and a light, very deep, that comes and goes.

FATHOMHOUSE

The palace of the Lung-lines princes on the Headland, a grey stone pile with more of itself below ground than above. Its upper floors are halls of glass tanks, where the princes hold court underwater and courtiers in dry clothes bow to them through eight inches of green brine. Its cellars are flooded and have been extended twice to accommodate the Dowager Below. The lowest cisterns hold the retired-to-depth. Servants work in rubber aprons and never go below the fourth stair.

THE PROP YARDS AT KEELROW (NEW)

Four hundred warships stand on dry ground in long rows across the old Keelrow anchorage, three miles south of the Headland, each upright on a cradle of timber props, masts dressed, fully crewed. Sailors reef and furl sails that catch only wind and stand watches over a horizon of salt flats. Beneath the keels the sailors’ families live in tents and sheds, a town of children who have never seen the sea and are proud of their fathers’ ships.

SALTWICK (NEW)

The largest inland town, thirty miles east of Lowmark on the Rim Road spur, and the country’s market for everything the Uncovered yields. Its cellars flood twice a day like every cellar in the country, and the townsfolk have given up and turned them into salt-pans: each house harvests its own indoor tide, dries it on racks, and sells the salt. Saltwick salt is reputedly the best on the Table. Visitors who eat too much of it begin to dream of drowning, and some begin to bail.

THE WRECK ORCHARD (NEW)

Eight miles out on the Uncovered, in a shallow basin, nearly two hundred wrecks of every age stand upright on the mud in loose rows, as if parked by a harbormaster. Nobody can explain why they are upright. Nobody can explain why their hatches are all open, or why their figureheads all face west. Salvagers live in the newest of them. Lantern-light can be seen in the oldest ones at night, which are empty.

GULLCRY STRAND (NEW)

A long stretch of the old shoreline north of Lowmark, now a beach without a sea, where the Deepening holds its processions. A road of

crushed white shell, laid by the faithful over two centuries, runs straight from the strand across the Uncovered toward the far water, nine miles long and marked every hundred paces by a post with a lantern-hook. On procession nights every hook is lit.

THE SOUNDING HALL (NEW)

The courthouse of the Drowned Bench on the Headland: a round stone hall whose floor is a shallow pool, ankle-deep, fed by the indoor tide. The accused stand in the water. The Tenanted judges sit on a stone bench at the far side, utterly still, and their verdicts are delivered in two voices. The frieze of the Beaching runs around the walls. The pool is always cold, and witnesses say that when a lie is spoken in the Hall, the water rises.

LOBBETT’S DROP (NEW)

The place, somewhere on the far Uncovered, where Cray Lobbett found the stone table with eight chairs. He has told nobody its location. Salvage crews have searched for it for two years, and three of them did not come back. The name is a joke on the Mile. It is not funny out there.

▼ HISTORY

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Beaching. Dromm hauled ashore at Longslab on ten thousand hooks. Four days of water. The Meal.
1–59	The Full Years. Fish return in silver floods; the coast grows rich; nobody minds a little cough.
60	The Brimming. The first generation born coughing brine. Bailing becomes universal.
77	First indoor tide recorded, in the cellars of Fathomhouse.
118	The First Calling. Four hundred walk into the sea at Lowmark in one night. Eleven come back.
121	The Netwatch founded. The Anchoring Laws require every household to own a rope.
163	Father Gannet Holm chains himself to the cliff; the Hanging Abbey begins.
240	The Drowned Bench. The Admiralty appoints Tenanted judges.
301	The Deepening’s first lantern procession at Gullcry Strand.
388	The Vasht Tanks. The first Lung-lines prince holds court from glass.
459	The Wreckwives formally organize after the Calling of the Seventeen Captains.
512	The Turning of the Tide. The sea does not return to its old line.
531	The Salt Assay chartered to measure the fall.
540	First new mile of pier at Lowmark. The Chase begins.
588	The Dry Fleet. The last warship floats; the fleet is propped at Keelrow.
627	The Great Pressure Day. Every window on the Headland bursts. Callings that night: 1,140.
639	Brenna Kelp’s finding. The Admiralty makes it illegal.
641	The Chase reaches its nineteenth mile. A table with eight chairs is found on the Uncovered.

For sixty years Brinehollow was the happiest land on the Table. The herring came back so thick that nets broke, whales beached themselves like gifts, and the Lung-lines, who coughed water twice a day and swam like seals, became admirals and princes. When every newborn of the Brimming arrived gurgling and had to be held head-down until the water ran, it was called a mark of belonging. Inlanders who did not bail were “dry,” which is still an insult.

The First Calling ended all that in one night. Four hundred people of Lowmark rose under a licked-clean moon and walked into the harbor in a long, quiet, orderly line, holding hands. The eleven

who came back were the first Tenanted, and those who took them in were the first Wreckwives. By 240 the Admiralty had noticed that the Tenanted made perfect judges, and in four centuries no one has successfully appealed a verdict of the Drowned Bench. In 512 the sea failed to return to its old line, and the Admiralty declared a temporary low tide. It has been temporary ever since. In the last ten years the sea has fallen faster than in the previous fifty, the Callings have quadrupled, and the Tenanted on the Bench have gone from nine to ninety. In 639 Brenna Kelp presented the arithmetic that explained it, and the Admiralty made her arithmetic a crime.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

Brinehollow is ruled by the **Tidal Admiralty**, a navy that has become a government. Its fleet sits aground on props at Keelrow, fully crewed, drilled daily, awaiting the sea’s return. Rank is still given in ships: a district governor is a Captain, a province is a Squadron, the treasury is the Purser’s Office, and a Captain may never have been afloat. Laws are issued as Standing Orders and read aloud from the deck of the flagship *Steadfast*, which has not moved since 588.

Above the Admiralty sit the **Lung-lines princes**, the House of Vasht and its cadet branches, who can no longer breathe air for long and hold court from glass tanks in Fathomhouse. They sign the Admiralty’s orders with a wet seal, through a hatch. Beneath the Admiralty sits the **Drowned Bench**: the Tenanted judges, whose verdicts are final, and whose loyalties nobody has ever thought to question out loud.

The great political fact is water. A land of sailors and fishers has lost its sea, and the Admiralty’s entire policy is to pretend this is temporary. To say “stranded” of the fleet is an offense against the Articles. To publish the Salt Assay’s figures is treason. Every faction’s position is ultimately a position on the water: whether it is coming back, whether it should, and where it has gone.

Law is naval. Crimes are tried before the Drowned Bench, standing ankle-deep in the Sounding Hall’s pool. Common sentences are flogging with a wet rope, fines in lacks, impressment into the Dry Fleet, and **loosing**: the convict is sentenced to sleep unanchored for a set number of nights, under guard, with the Netwatch instructed not to intervene. Loosing is not formally a death sentence. Everyone knows it is one, slower and more uncertain, and that the Bench’s Tenanted judges hand it down with what looks like compassion. Neglecting to bail the helpless is murder. Cutting another’s rope is the worst murder of all, and its punishment is to be loosed for life.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

Food. Brinehollow eats what the Uncovered gives and what the Rim Road sells. Before the fall it ate fish, and fish are now a luxury hauled nineteen miles down the Mile in wet barrels. The poor eat Uncovered shellfish dug from the drying mud, which are safe for those who bail and poison to anyone dry; salt-cured gull; seaweed bread; and Fatlands meat in brine, which everyone pretends not to examine. Meals are cold and salty. Hot food is considered a little vulgar. The grace before eating with strangers is “Lack keep away, and keep you dry.”

Dress. Oilcloth, tarred wool, sealskin for the rich. Everyone wears a rope at the waist, coiled, for anchoring at night: the cheap ones are hemp, the fine ones silk-and-wire, and a noble’s waist-rope may be braided with silver and the hair of ancestors. The bail-bucket hangs from it. Losing your bucket is like losing your shoes. Course-sufferers wear veils of wet gauze to keep their faces moist.

Marriage. Sweethearts exchange bail-buckets. A wedding is the tying of a shared anchoring rope, each partner knotting the other’s end before witnesses, and the vow is “I will hold your line.” Marriage among the Lung-lines is a matter of keeping the blood deep; marriages between first cousins are ordinary, and the Cutwrights’ ledgers for the House of Vasht show older and closer pairings that the family does not discuss and the College does not publish. Remarriage after a Calling is permitted after a year and a day, which leads, often enough, to a household with two spouses when the first comes back Tenanted.

Death. Those who die of ordinary causes are laid face-down on the Uncovered, weighted with stones, for the tide to take; the tide no longer comes, so the bodies lie in long rows on the salt flats, and the gulls are fat. The Called receive a **rope funeral**: their cut anchoring rope is divided among the family, one piece each and one for the wall, and the name is cut into the nearest tide-post. There is

no body. There is never a body. Families keep the pieces of rope in a box by the bed, and hold them during the count.

Children. Taught to bail before they read, roped to a parent’s wrist at night until seven. Children’s games include holding-breath contests, which parents forbid and which are universal, and “Called,” in which one child walks blindfold toward a wall while the others try to drag them back. Children are said to see the Tenanted most clearly: a Tenanted parent’s own child often refuses to be held by them, at first, and then forgets why.

Festivals. Low Water, at the lowest tide of Carving, when the Tenanted gather on the Uncovered and sing. The Knotting, in early

Grace, when every rope in a household is replaced. Tablenight, when families set a bowl of seawater at the table’s head and leave the west door unbarred, once a year, for whoever might come home.

Oaths on the dead. The most binding oath in Brinehollow is sworn on a piece of a Called person’s rope, held in the fist, with the words “By the line that did not hold.” To break it is to invite the Called one to come back for you. People believe this literally, and sometimes they are right.

Proverbs. “Tie your own knot.” “A dry man drowns twice.” “Every wall has an ear, and every ear is a neighbor’s.” “Don’t sleep facing your wishes.” “The sea gives back, but not change.”

▼ FACTIONS

THE TIDAL ADMIRALTY

The state: proud, hidebound, and commanding the largest landlocked navy in the world. The Admiralty believes, as an article of faith and of law, that the sea will return, and that when it does Brinehollow must be ready to sail. It wants order, the illusion of

normality, and above all silence about the numbers. Its officers are brave, competent, and drilled to the bone in an art that has no use. Enemies: the Salt Assay’s leakers, the Deepening, the Second Table’s agents within its own ranks. Allies: the Netwatch, the Rim Road Company, which still pays port tolls on a port with no water. A PC joins by enlistment at any Admiralty house on the Mile.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Swab	A berth on a propped ship, rations, a rope
2	Able Hand	Pay of 2 lacks a day; right to bear a boathook on the Mile
3	Bosun	Command of a watch; access to the Admiralty bail-houses
4	Captain	A ship (on props) or a district; a seat at the Standing Orders
5	Commodore	A squadron of ships or provinces; audience with the tanks

THE ANCHORITES

An order who chain themselves permanently to rock, so the Calling can never take them. Their abbey is the Hanging Abbey, a cliff face hung with a thousand living monks. They believe the Calling is a

temptation, and that refusing it, night after night, for a whole life, is the only holiness left. They want to endure. Some want more: to chain the whole country. Enemies: the Deepening, whom they call drowners. Allies: Wreckwives, who send them food. A PC joins by spending a month on the cliff in a trial-chain; most who try come down. A few did not want to.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Postulant	A trial-chain on the lower rocks, removable
2	Linked	A permanent collar; the Abbey’s prayers and its basket
3	Bound	A cell on the high face; the right to counsel visitors
4	Fast-Bound	Keeper of a hundred chains; can loose or tighten them
5	Abbot	The Rock; one held by Father Ebb

THE DEEPENING

A cult that treats the Calling as a sacrament. They believe Dromm is not regrowing but welcoming, that the sea is going home and taking

its children with it, and that walking in willingly, in procession, with lanterns, is not death but homecoming. They want everyone baptized. Their processions at Gullcry Strand are illegal, regular, and quietly attended by the Netwatch, who are under orders to intervene and seldom do. Enemies: Anchorites, the Admiralty, every

family with a member who joined. Allies: none declared; the Tenanted, it is whispered. A PC joins by walking the shell road to the last lantern and coming back to tell it.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Shell-Walker	A lantern, a place in procession, a new name
2	Wader	Teaching of the Low Songs; the Deepening's safe houses
3	Lantern-Bearer	Leads a procession group; knows the next Calling nights
4	Deep Sister or Brother	Baptizes; hears the invitation by night
5	Mother of the Water	Mother Limpet alone

THE NETWATCH

The Admiralty's night patrol. They hunt the Called along the shore with nets, hooks, and rope, and drag them home. They know every alley that runs west, every gap in the pier rails, every rope-cutter.

They are heroes in the households they have saved and bogeymen to the Called themselves, who fight in their trance with terrible, painless strength. Enemies: the Deepening. Allies: Wreckwives, Anchorites. A PC joins at the barracks on Mile Seven; the Netwatch is always short of hands.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hooker	Boathook, net, lantern, 2 lacks a night
2	Line-Hand	A patrol beat; right to enter any house at night
3	Watch-Sergeant	A squad of six; the Calling logs
4	Lieutenant	A district of the Mile; can order a loosing stayed
5	Watch-Captain	Command of the Netwatch; a seat at the Admiralty

THE WRECKWIVES

A sisterhood, open to all sexes, of those whose spouses came back Tenanted. They share advice on how to live with a stranger who knows your name: what to say, what not to ask, how to tell if

anyone is still in there, how to stop yourself loving what came back, or whether to. They keep records of every Tenanted spouse, and their records are better than the Admiralty's. They want the truth, and fear it. A PC joins by sitting at a Wreckwives' table and telling the story, without crying, all the way through.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Listener	A seat at the table; the sisterhood's discretion
2	Sister of the Line	Access to the records; a safe house for one night
3	Keeper of Names	Helps new members; knows every Tenanted in a district
4	Elder Wife	Speaks for a Mile; can call on the sisterhood's lacks
5	Widow-Mother	One per city; holds the ledgers

THE SALT ASSAY

The office that measures the falling sea. Its figures are a state secret. Its assayers stand at posts along the old shore and the new piers with chains and gauges, and in cellars with buckets and scales. Since

Brenna Kelp's finding the office has been half-purged, and its surviving clerks know that the numbers they record are evidence of something the Admiralty will kill to hide. They want to be believed, or to be safe; it is getting hard to be both. A PC joins as a clerk, and learns quickly to keep a second ledger.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Gauger	A chain, a post, a pay of 2 lacks a day
2	Measurer	Access to district figures; a sealed satchel

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
3	Assayer	Access to national figures; a house on Mile One
4	Senior Assayer	Reports to the Admiralty; under permanent watch
5	Keeper of the Number	Brenna Kelp, in hiding

POWERS FROM ELSEWHERE

The **Cutwrights' College** keeps a house on Mile Two, where its genealogists track the Lung-lines and have quietly begun tracking the Tenanted, whose Cut seems to rise after their return. The **Purgation** has a small, vicious cell on the Mile that believes the sea can be wrung out of the blood (see Abel Drainer). The **Second Table** has members in the Admiralty's highest ranks, and it has noticed that the Trench is where a god's body might be going. The **Rim Road Company** has sent an auditor, Reeve Calder Stokes, and he has already begun to cough.

▼ BRINEHOLLOW NOW

The Salt Assay has done the arithmetic the Admiralty forbade: the volume of sea lost each year matches the number of Tenanted. The ocean is moving into the people, a bucket at a time. Every Called person who comes back brings a measure of the deep with them, folded up inside, and the sea is that much lower. The Tenanted now sit on every court in the land. A scavenger has found something on the Uncovered that should not be under any sea. And a shipwright is building a vessel to follow the water down.

The Callings are accelerating with the fall. Last Carving there were three nights on which more than five hundred walked. The Netwatch cannot cover the Mile. Dry Jonah's bottled brine has turned up in the Vigil's rouse, and sleepless strangers four hundred miles inland have started walking west. On the Uncovered, salvagers report a tall figure, seen at a distance at dusk, setting a table on the mud with great care, and walking on.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◆ **The Rope-Cutter of Mile Fourteen.** Nine ropes cut in nine nights on the same street, with no knife ever found. The

Netwatch suspects a murderer. The families suspect each other. The truth is that a Tenanted grandmother has been walking the street at night, doing what she believes is a kindness, and the Drowned Bench has already ruled it lawful.

- ◆ **The Follow's Pilot.** Dagna Hull needs someone to lead the iron vessel's trial descent at the Trench edge, and someone else to find out which of her nine hundred volunteers is sabotaging it, and why the saboteur weeps.
- ◆ **Three Copies.** Brenna Kelp has hidden three copies of her finding. The Admiralty, the Second Table, and the Wreckwives all want them. One copy is in the Hanging Abbey with Father Ebb; one is in a bail-bucket that has passed through four sweethearts' hands; and one has been read aloud on a procession night, to the Deepening, who wept with joy.
- ◆ **Eight Chairs.** Cray Lobbett will take the PCs to his table, for a price. Getting there is three days on the far Uncovered. Getting back is less certain. On the table, someone has laid a place.

DIO	RUMOR ON THE MILE
1	The Trench is a drain, and the sea is draining into the Fast. (False, but the Fast's wells are rising.)
2	The High Admiral has had the Steadfast's keel sawed through, so it can never float. (True; he cannot bear the idea of leaving.)
3	A Tenanted can be told by holding a mirror to their mouth at dawn: no mist. (False; there is mist, and it is salt.)
4	Prince Aurel has stopped surfacing at all. (True for the last nine days.)
5	The Deepening are paid by the Admiralty to thin the Mile's slums. (False, but a Commodore has suggested it.)
6	Every Tenanted judge voted the same way in every case this year. (True, to the case.)

D10	RUMOR ON THE MILE
7	If you cut a piece of rope from someone who was Called and burn it, you'll dream where they went. (True. Don't.)
8	Old Wet Tom is the god's own beggar, and whoever gives him a coin will never be Called. (Half-true; they will be Called to Tom.)
9	The Vigil pays a platter a bottle for Brinehollow brine. (True; Dry Jonah charges three.)
10	The skull of Dromm has been found walking. (Unknown.)

THE PEOPLE OF BRINEHOLLOW

HIGH ADMIRAL CORVIN SUND

Commander of four hundred warships standing on dry ground. Sixty-eight, square, grey-whiskered, in a blue dress coat kept so wet with brine that it never quite dries and smells of a harbor at low water. His voice is the parade-ground bark of a man who sailed as a boy, the last year the fleet floated, and has spent fifty years waiting to sail again. He inspects the ships weekly, has the hulls scraped of

barnacles that are not there, and will hang any officer who says the word “stranded.” He has hanged four. He wants the sea back, and failing that he wants no one to admit it is gone. He fears the Salt Assay’s numbers, and more than that he fears the morning he will stand on the *Steadfast*’s deck and feel the pull himself. **Secret:** he has had the flagship’s keel sawn half through in the night, so that it can never float away without him. PCs meet him at an inspection, or in the dock when he wants a leaker found.

CORVIN SUND – HIGH ADMIRAL OF THE TIDAL ADMIRALTY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Lung-line, cadet) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Intimidate 4, Resolve 4, Blades 3, Clause 3, Endure 2, Wayfaring 1
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 2 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	dress sword +6 (4)
GIFTS	Deep Breath; Hold the Line (once per scene, every Admiralty sailor in earshot gains +2 to resist fear or the pull)
WANTS	To Keep Under (secrets, numbers, his own pull)
DREAD	0
SECRET	the sawn keel; he stands at the west rail every night at dusk with his hands on the wood.

HARBORMISTRESS KESSA DROWLE

She builds Lowmark’s mile of new pier each year: fifty-two, tar to the elbows, a carpenter’s pencil behind each ear, a cough she bails into the sea of sawdust on the work-barges. She speaks in measurements. She has calculated the year the timber runs out and the year the sea drops off the shelf entirely. They are the same year, nine years from now, and she has told no one but the PCs if they buy her enough rum. She wants to finish the Chase with dignity. She fears the twentieth mile: the survey shows the seabed beyond it falls away into the Trench’s slope, and the pilings will have nothing to stand on. **Secret:** she has begun ordering pilings longer than any sea could need, and she does not know why. PCs meet her when she hires guards for the timber barges, which the Uncovered’s salvagers raid.

KESSA DROWLE Threat 4 (Reckoning, Craft) · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (mallet 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

JUSTICE MAREN OAKE OF THE DROWNED BENCH

Called at thirty, returned after forty days. She is fifty now, broad and grey-skinned, with black eyes and hands that never move during a hearing. The air around her is cold and close and smells of the deep, and those who stand before her feel their ears pop. She speaks in two tones at once, and the lower one sometimes finishes first. She has never given an unjust verdict, and she has sentenced more people to loosing than any judge in history, always gently. She wants justice, in a sense larger than the Admiralty’s. **Secret:** her husband Tam has visited her chambers every week for twenty years, and she has never once told him that the woman he married is still in there, folded small, awake, and listening. PCs meet her standing ankle-deep in her court.

MAREN OAKE – JUSTICE OF THE DROWNED BENCH	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2, rising · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, Tenanted) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Clause 5, Resolve 5, Instinct 4, Search 3, Godsign 3, Endure 2, Brawl 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	The Weight +8 (Caul + Godsign; target makes GUT + Endure vs Grim or is pinned and takes 3 per round)
GIFTS	Unbriable (cannot be Persuaded or Deceived by anyone who lies within her hearing; she knows); Voice of the Deep; Pressure
WANTS	To Keep Under; The Water
DREAD	3 (to hear the lower voice answer a question nobody asked)
SECRET	Maren is still present. The Passenger in her is not cruel. It is simply sure.

PRINCE AUREL VASHT

Heir of the Lung-lines, twenty-two, unable to breathe air for more than an hour. He rules from a glass tank twelve feet tall in the Hall of Tanks, floating naked but for a wrap of silk, grey-skinned, beautiful, with huge black eyes and hair that drifts like weed. He has learned to read lips through eight inches of water and replies by

writing on a slate he presses to the glass. He is curious, lonely, and clever, and he is the only Vasht in a century to ask what the water wants. **Secret:** for nine days he has not surfaced at all, and he has begun to hear his grandmother calling from the cellars, and to answer. PCs meet him when he summons outsiders, privately, who might tell him the truth about the sea.

AUREL VASHT – PRINCE OF THE LUNG-LINES	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 1 · Lung 5 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Lung-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Search 4, Lore 3, Athletics 3, Godsign 3, Persuade 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 18 in water, 12 in air · Armor 1 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	none worth the name
GIFTS	Fathom-Body; Tide-Sight; Lip-Reading through water (Search +3 to read speech he can see)
WANTS	The Water; The West
DREAD	2 (to see his chest not move)
SECRET	he is the Seating his grandmother is waiting for.

LADY ONDINE VASHT, THE DOWAGER BELOW

The prince's grandmother, far into the Course, and far past it. She lives in the flooded cellars of Fathomhouse and has not been seen whole in years. The cellars have had to be extended twice. What visitors see, holding a lantern at the top of the fourth stair, is a black surface that breathes, and parts of her: a hand on the bottom step, grey, as long as a man's arm; an eye beneath the water, wide as a

plate; the shape of a vast back turning. Her voice comes up through the stone of the whole palace, slow and courteous. She still signs the family's letters. She wants her grandson to come down. **Secret:** she is not Tenanted; she is Seating, slowly, and the House of Vasht has been feeding her the retired-to-depth to keep her from going west and taking the palace with her. PCs meet her only if summoned below, which the household treats as an honor and a funeral.

ONDINE VASHT – THE DOWAGER BELOW	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 7 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 · Regrowth 11 (the Brink, approaching the Seating) · Hunger 9
SKILLS	Godsign 6, Endure 5, Intimidate 5, Brawl 4, Instinct 4
BODY	Flesh 20 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Fray —
ATTACKS	crushing grasp +8 (5, Pressure: on a Helping the target begins drowning on dry land)
GIFTS	The Weight; Voice of the Deep (all within earshot make a Calling roll at Grim); Pressure Day (once a night, she makes the palace's air thicken: all within suffer –2 to every roll, and ears bleed)
WANTS	To Keep Under; the boy
DREAD	4 (to see her whole)
SECRET	when she Seats, the Headland goes with her.

FATHER EBB

Abbot of the Anchorites, chained to the same rock for fifty-one years. Seventy-eight, a skeleton in a canvas habit, salt-crusted, his iron collar grown into the flesh of his neck so that the skin has healed over the rim like bark over a nail. His hands are calloused from gripping the chain. He has felt the Calling every night of those

fifty-one years. His voice is soft and rough and he laughs often, at himself. He says the chain is not what holds him, and will not say what does. He wants his monks to endure; he wants, more quietly, to know whether enduring is worth it. **Secret:** the chain has been rusted through for twelve years, and he knows it. What holds him is a promise made to a girl who was Called in 589. PCs meet him by climbing to his ledge, which takes a day.

FATHER EBB – ABBOT OF THE HANGING ABBEY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Resolve 6, Rites 4, Endure 4, Lore 3, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	Fathom-Body; The Refusal (once a night, he may make the Calling roll in place of anyone within sight of him)
WANTS	The West, every night, unanswered
DREAD	1 (to see the collar's healed flesh)
SECRET	the rusted chain, and the girl's name, which is Nerys Colm's mother's.

TOLLY BRACK, THE BAILER BOY

Eleven years old, small, freckled under the salt-grime, with strong thin hands and a voice cracked from shouting “Bail-o!” up the Mile at dawn. He goes door to door bailing those too old or weak to cough for themselves, holding them over his knee and pounding their backs, for a crumb a time. He knows from the color of the water who will be Called next. Blue means soon. He does not tell them. He tells their families, if they pay, and has started telling them for free. He wants his mother, who was Called when he was six; he fears that he is starting to see blue in his own bucket. PCs meet him at dawn, at the door of anyone they are visiting.

TOLLY BRACK Threat 3 (Instinct, Filch) · Flesh 9 · Guard 13 · Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

SENNET GULL, THE WRECKWIFE

Her husband Davey walked into the sea and came back kinder. Thirty-four, sharp-faced, red-knuckled, smelling of the mussel-cannery where she works. She keeps him in the cistern under the house, brings him his dinner, sits on the edge and talks to him about her day while he floats on his back with his black eyes open, listening, and says the right things. The old Davey drank and hit. This one does not. She has started to prefer him. That is what frightens her. **Secret:** she has begun to notice that she can no longer remember the old Davey's voice, and she has wondered, in the dark, whether the thing in the cistern took that too. PCs meet her at a Wreckwives' table, asking for advice she does not want.

DR. ISOLDE REAVE

A lung surgeon of the Headland, forty-five, thin, bespectacled, in a leather apron stiff with brine and old blood. Her rooms smell of carbolic and low tide. She opened a drowned chest at high tide and found the water in it had a current: it moved in the lungs in a slow circle, westward. In the next one she found a shell, alive, of no known species, pink and whorled, which she keeps in a jar and which has grown. She wants to understand. She fears that she does. **Secret:** she has started opening chests that are not yet drowned, with the patients' consent and sometimes without it, and the shells are in the living too. PCs meet her when they need a Course chest explained, or a body procured.

ISOLDE REAVE Threat 4 (Stitching, Reckoning) · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (scalpel 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

HASK TARN, THE PILOT

He guides salvage parties across the Uncovered. Sixty, lean, weathered, with a sounding-lead on a cord around his neck that he swings as he walks. He used to pilot ships over the same ground and navigates by remembered depth: "Six fathom here, sand bottom; mind, it shelves." He is never lost. He will not go near the places where he once lost the bottom, where the lead ran out of line, because they are still there, and they are still bottomless, and he has heard them breathe. He wants one more season's pay. He fears the deep places, and the day his memory of depth fails. **Secret:** he knows the way to the Stone Table; he steered over it in 581, and the lead came up warm. PCs hire him.

HASK TARN Threat 4 (Wayfaring, Search) · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +4 (gutting knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

NERYS COLM, THE HALF-CALLED

She walked into the surf up to her chin and then, uniquely, turned around. Twenty-eight now, wild-haired, salt-burned, with one eye that has gone wholly black and one still blue. She lives in a sealed room in the Netwatch barracks, by her own request, with wax in the

keyhole. She has heard the invitation in full and can repeat it. Nobody who has listened to her has stayed ashore. She wants someone to tell her what made her turn. She fears that she knows: she heard the eighth voice in the chorus, under the others, and it was hungry. **Secret:** she has written the invitation down, once, in a letter she meant to burn. It is missing. PCs meet her through Lieutenant Reef, behind a door, through a speaking-tube she will not use.

CAPTAIN JONAH SKERRY, CALLED DRY JONAH

A smuggler who bottles what Brinehollowers cough up and sells it inland as tonic. Fifty, fat, cheerful, perfectly dry: an outlander from the Fatlands borders who never bails and wears a waist-rope as a joke. His brig the *Thirsty Bess* has been aground since he bought her; he runs the trade by wagon along the Rim Road. He buys bail-water by the bucket in the Mile slums, half a crumb a pint, and sells it in green glass in the Vigil for a platter a bottle. It sells well there. He has never asked what his customers start to dream about. **Secret:** he has started to keep a bottle of his own product by his bed, and drinks it when he cannot sleep. PCs meet him buying, selling, or hiring guards for a wagon going east.

DRY JONAH SKERRY Threat 4 (Haggle, Deceive) · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (crossbow 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

ORRIN WAKE AND PASSENGER

A fisherman, Tenanted by something that is, for once, willing to talk. Orrin is thirty-nine, burly, slow-spoken, with gentle black eyes and a left arm that hangs a little loose. The Passenger is courteous, very old, and negotiating with Orrin for the use of his left arm. They argue in the same mouth, in two tones, in the corner of the Lantern tavern on Mile Nine. Orrin wants his life back, or enough of it. The Passenger wants a hand to do something with. Neither will say what. They have drawn up terms on a slate. **Secret:** the Passenger has explained to Orrin what the sea is for, and why it is going, and Orrin has begun to agree. PCs meet them when the Passenger asks a stranger to witness the contract.

ORRIN WAKE AND PASSENGER – THE TALKING TENANT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 (Orrin) / 5 (Passenger) · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 10 (the Brink, Tenanted) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Godsign 4, Clause 4 (Passenger), Labor 3, Wayfaring 3, Endure 3, Brawl 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 · Fray 4 (Orrin) / — (Passenger)
ATTACKS	fist +5 (1); the left arm, when the Passenger has it, +8 (4, Pressure)
GIFTS	Voice of the Deep; The Weight; Two Minds (cannot be surprised; each mind may act once per round, but only one may use the left arm)
WANTS	The Water (Orrin resists; the Passenger does not)
DREAD	3 (to hear them disagree)
SECRET	the left arm is for opening something at the Stone Table.

BRENNA KELP, THE SALT ASSAYER

Keeper of the falling number. Forty-one, ink-stained, myopic, with a gauging-chain worn as a belt and a habit of muttering figures under her breath. She found where the sea is going by counting buckets: the national bail-water tally, the Callings, the Tenanted, the volume of the fall. They match. The Admiralty has made her finding illegal. She has hidden three copies and herself, moving between Wreckwives' safe houses on the Mile. She wants the truth published before the sea is gone. She fears that the Tenanted already know her number, and are counting down to something. **Secret:** her own bail-water has gone blue. PCs meet her when a Wreckwife asks them to escort a "cousin" across the Mile at night.

BRENNA KELP Threat 4 (Reckoning, Stealth) · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 ·

Attack +2 (fist 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

MOTHER LIMPET

Prophet of the Deepening. Eighty-four, tiny, bent, in a dress of white shell-beads that clicks when she walks, with a voice like a warm bath. She smells of seaweed and lamp-oil. Her eyes are the Course's wide black, kind and wet. She has baptized two thousand by walking them in at night, holding each hand to the water's edge, singing. She says she will follow when the last one is safely under. She wants everyone home. She fears nothing, or says so. **Secret:** she cannot hear the invitation. She never could. She has been leading two thousand people toward a voice she has only ever been told about, and she does not know whether she is a saint or the thing that comes before one. PCs meet her on a procession night, holding out a lantern.

MOTHER LIMPET – MOTHER OF THE WATER

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Godsign 3, Instinct 3, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	Fathom-Body; The Low Song (Persuade + Rites; listeners at the Appetite or beyond make a Calling roll at Hard, even awake)
WANTS	The West, which she has never truly felt
DREAD	2 (to watch a procession disappear lantern by lantern)
SECRET	she is deaf to the god; the Deepening rests on her faith in other people's.

DAGNA HULL, THE SHIPWRIGHT

She is building the *Follow*, a sealed iron vessel meant to chase the sea down into the Trench. Fifty-five, huge-shouldered, deafened by riveting, she shouts everything and smells of hot iron and pitch. The *Follow* lies in a slip at the end of Mile Nineteen, a riveted iron egg forty feet long with glass ports and an air-bladder. She has a waiting list of nine hundred volunteers. She wants to know where the water goes. She fears that the nine hundred do not want to know; they want to go. **Secret:** someone keeps loosening the *Follow*'s rivets, and she has found the marks of her own hammer on them. PCs meet her when she hires a crew.

DAGNA HULL Threat 4 (Craft, Labor) · Flesh 14 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (riveting hammer 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

CRAY LOBBETT

A scavenger on the far Uncovered, forty, lean as a dried eel, eyes red from salt wind, hands scarred by weed-knives. He found a stone table on the seabed, older than the Gorging, with eight chairs. Seven were pushed in. One was pulled out. On its seat was a fine dust like ground shell, and an impression, as if someone had just stood up. He has not been able to sell the location, or to stop going back. Each

trip he finds the table cleaner. He wants to be rid of it. He fears that the next time the eighth chair will be pushed in, or that a ninth will be pulled out with his name scratched in the stone. **Secret:** on his last trip there was a cup on the table, full. PCs meet him in a Saltwick tavern, drunk, drawing eight squares on the wet bar.

OLD WET TOM

A beggar who has never been dry. Ageless, bearded, in rags heavy and black with water, wringing himself out on the Headland steps. It rains on him indoors: a soft private drizzle from nowhere that soaks his blanket and fills his begging bowl. Puddles follow him down corridors. Children say that if you look into one of them, it is much deeper than the floor, and that something down there looks back. He is gentle and simple and speaks of the sea as an old friend who owes him money. **Secret:** Tom is the oldest Tenanted in Brinehollow, Called in 118, and he has been waiting for his family to come for him for five hundred years. PCs meet him whenever the GM likes.

OLD WET TOM Threat 2 · Flesh 30 (does not seem to bleed) · Guard 10 · Attack — · Armor 0 · Dread 2 (to look into his puddle)

LIEUTENANT SABLE REEF OF THE NETWATCH

Thirty-six, tall, sinewed, her face scarred by the fingernails of the Called, who fight hard in their trance. She carries a boathook and a weighted net and walks the Mile at night with a lantern at her belt. She has pulled three hundred Called off the shore with hook and

rope. Every one of them looked at her the same way: not frightened, not angry, but disappointed, as though she had interrupted something precious. She has begun to wonder what she is saving them from. **Secret:** she dreams every night that she is walking west, and that the three hundred are walking beside her, and that they are glad she came. PCs meet her when they are out on the Mile at night.

SABLE REEF – LIEUTENANT OF THE NETWATCH	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Blades 3, Brawl 3, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	boathook +7 (4, Hooking: on a Helping the target is pulled down); weighted net +7 (0, Grappled)
GIFTS	Deep Breath; Salt-Sense
WANTS	The West, newly
DREAD	0
SECRET	she will be the next of her watch to go.

NETWATCH PATROLLER Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (boathook 4, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

ONE OF THE CALLED Threat 3 (feels no pain, does not tire) · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (grapple 1, will not stop walking) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 if lovel

ILSE MARL, CHOIR-MISTRESS OF THE LOW WATER

Sixty, small, fierce, ink-blotted, wrapped in shawls on the Uncovered at the lowest tide of every month with a lantern, a lap-desk, and frozen fingers. At the lowest tide the Tenanted gather and sing: hundreds of them, in a ring on the mud, eyes closed, mouths open, in a music with no words and a beat like a slow heart. She alone writes it down, in a notation she invented. Laid end to end, forty years of her transcriptions make a nautical chart: soundings, currents, and a course leading west and down. **Secret:** the chart has a destination, and it is not the Trench. PCs meet her at the Low Water, where she asks them to hold her lantern.

FINN UNDERTOW, THE BELLMAN

He rings Lowmark's tide bell so the city knows when to bail. Forty-four, one-eyed, roped to the bell tower on the Headland, with forearms like hawsers. The tides in the body no longer match the tides of the sea, and he has to choose which to ring. For years he chose the sea. Now he rings the body, and the city coughs as one when he does. He feels the body's tide in his own chest, and in everyone's, as a single swell. **Secret:** the body tide is drifting too, toward a single moment in which every Brinehollower will fill at once, and he can count the days. PCs meet him if they climb the tower to ask why the bell rang early.

REEVE CALDER STOKES

An auditor sent by the Rim Road Company to price Brinehollow's losses. Thirty-three, Oathen-trained, pale, precise, ledgers under one arm. He is an outsider with dry lungs. He has been here three months, and this morning he tasted salt. He wants to finish the audit and leave. He fears that he has been asked to price something that has no price. His Company contract, sworn before Jessamy Quill, binds him to deliver the audit in person in Tacit. **Secret:** the audit shows the Admiralty's tolls and Brenna Kelp's numbers point to the same thing, and the Company already knew. PCs meet him hiring them to escort him, which he notes in the ledger as "guides, drying."

NEW CHARACTERS

OTTILINE HAWSE, THE ROPEWALKER

Mistress of the Ropewalk on Mile Three, a quarter-mile shed where anchoring ropes are spun, laid, and tarred. Fifty, hands black with tar, smelling of hemp and pine. Every rope in Lowmark passes through her shed, and she keeps a ledger of every rope cut. She can tell by the cut: the blade, the angle, the strength of the hand. She knows which ropes were cut by the sleeper, which by the beloved, and which by no hand at all. She tells the families nothing unless they ask twice. **Secret:** forty of the ropes she sold last year were cut by the same small blade, angled from below, and she knows the child who carries it.

ESK PENHALLOW, THE RETURNED WHO WASN'T

Called at twenty-six, gone eight weeks, came back. He swears he is not Tenanted. He says he remembers the sea: cold, the weight, a voice asking, and then a sandbar and a long walk home, starved. His

wife will not let him in. His mother has rung the Wreckwives. His children scream. He is a little heavier, a little slower, he cannot explain why his voice has dropped, and he does not believe it has. He sits on the steps of his own house on Mile Eight every night, roped to the railing by his own hand, and calls his children's names through the wall at the morning count. Nobody answers him. The Wreckwives have taken his case as a test: if a man can be loved back out of the sea, they would like to know it, and if he cannot, they would like to know that more. **Secret:** the GM decides. He may be telling the truth, and Brinehollow has no test.

COMMODORE LYSANDER VELL

A senior officer of the Admiralty, forty-eight, elegant, dry-lunged to an unusual degree for a Lung-line cadet, with a silver waist-rope braided from his ancestors' hair. Polished, witty, and a member of the Second Table. He keeps in his cabin aboard the propped *Gannet* a lead box holding a piece of Dromm's flesh, preserved since the Beaching, which still weeps cold water. He believes the god is reassembling at the bottom of the Trench, and intends the *Follow* to carry a carving party there. **Secret:** he has been eating a sliver of the flesh each Tablenight, and he no longer needs to bail.

COMMODORE LYSANDER VELL Threat 5 (Persuade, Clause) · Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (rapier 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

ABEL DRAINER, THE WRINGER

Leader of the Purgation's Brinehollow cell, a gaunt, cheerful former fishmonger with a mangle in his cellar. He believes the sea can be wrung out of the blood: his followers hang their converts by the ankles for a day and a night, and beat the water out of them, and bail them until they bring up blood instead of brine. Some of them have stopped bailing afterward, and died of nothing, dry. He counts it as cure. His cell meets in a fish-cellar on Mile Fifteen that stinks of old blood and brine, and the Netwatch tolerates it because the

Wringer's converts are never Called. PCs meet him when a friend joins, or when a family hires them to bring a son home from the mangle. **Secret:** he has been Called four times and dragged home by his own followers each time, and he has his followers hang him by the ankles every night to keep the water from rising.

CUTWRIGHT ANSBY WRACK

The Cutwrights' College's genealogist in Lowmark, thirty-nine, soft-spoken, with ink-stained cuffs and a cough she pretends is a cold. Her ledgers show that a Tenanted person's descendants carry a higher Cut than their parents should have given them. The god is not just taking people back. It is breeding. She wants the College to stop the marriages, and to stop the Admiralty marrying Tenanted widows to Lung-line cadets, which it has been encouraging for a century. She fears what the Provost will do with her ledgers, and what the Bench will do with her. PCs meet her when she needs a Tenanted family's records stolen from a parish chest. **Secret:** she has proof that the House of Vasht's last three generations were fathered by Tenanted, and the prince's father was one.

GANNET SHALE, THE TABLE-SEER

A salvager girl of nineteen, quick and sunburned, who walked the far Uncovered alone for a week and saw, at dusk, a tall stooping figure laying a table on the mud. White cloth. Candles. A chair pulled out. It looked at her and waited, and she ran. She went back the next morning. The table was gone. The candles' wax was still on the mud, and the drips went west. She has told the story in every tavern from Saltwick to Mile Nineteen, and has been laughed at in all of them except one, where an old man in a Fast traveler's coat bought her a drink and asked, very carefully, whether she had been thanked. PCs meet her when she wants company for a return trip. **Secret:** she has been dreaming of the chair, and whoever laid it has started setting places in her dreams.

▼ PLAYING A BRINEHOLLOWER

You were born gasping. Your mother held you over her knee and beat the sea out of you, and you have bailed twice a day ever since. You sleep roped. You call names through the wall. Somewhere west of you, the water knows your name.

Attribute bonus: +1 LUNG. Brinehollowers hold their breath longer, swim better, and move more quietly than any people on the Table.

Bailing. A Brinehollower who misses a bailing suffers -2 to all rolls until they bail, and after a further hour begins to drown (1 Flesh per ten minutes). Another character can bail a helpless one with a Routine HAND + Stitching roll.

The Sop: Wading. Stand in salt water, the sea or any basin of brine, past the knees, through one full turn of the body's tide, facing

west, listening. Remove 1d6 Hunger. The god is pleased, and the next Calling roll you make is at +2 difficulty.

The Tooth. When a Brinehollower Partakes, the ears pop, the chest fills, and the voice drops into its second register. Witnesses hear the sea in the room. On a Tooth showing 1, the character coughs up a gout of cold water, sand, and something small and living, and loses their next action to bailing.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1-3). Choose one. *Deep Breath:* hold your breath for ten minutes per point of Caul; you cannot drown in that time and ignore smoke, gas and choking. *Salt-Sense:* by tasting the air you know of a pressure day an hour before it comes, and by

tasting someone’s bail-water, their Regrowth stage. Cost: either Gift used in front of dry folk marks you as deep-blooded.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Choose one. *Tide-Sight:* Partake to know the direction and distance of the nearest body of salt water, and of every Called and Tenanted person within a mile; –2 to resist The West for the rest of the night. *Pressure:* Partake when grappling or striking to add 2 damage and make the target’s ears bleed; on a Helping, the target is stunned for a round. Cost: each use leaves you with salt rime on the skin, and dogs will not come near you for a day.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). Gain *Fathom-Body:* Armor +1 from thickened skin; see in total darkness; breathe water as easily as air; ignore cold. Cost: in open air for more than a day without immersion, –1 to all rolls; you must sleep submerged or gain 1 Hunger each night. Choose also one: *The Weight* (Partake: become crushingly heavy for a scene; cannot be moved, knocked down or carried, and doors and floors may give) or *Quiet Chest* (no breath, no heartbeat audible; +3 to Stealth; dry folk who notice must make a Dread 1 check).

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). Gain *Voice of the Deep:* speak in the god’s register; Partake to give one command that anyone at the Appetite or beyond must resist with Caul + Resolve vs Grim, or obey as if Called. Cost: each use, roll a Tooth; on a 1 or 2, the Passenger answers the next question asked of you, in its own voice.

WANTS

- ◇ **The West.** Trigger: dusk, a west-facing window, the sound of surf. Resist with Caul + Resolve or go and stand and watch until full dark.
- ◇ **The Water.** Trigger: sleep near any basin, well or barrel. Resist or wake with your face in it.
- ◇ **To Keep Under.** Trigger: learning a secret, finding something lost. Resist or hide, sink or bury it, and tell no one.
- ◇ **The Silence.** Trigger: being asked where someone went. Resist or say nothing at all for the rest of the scene.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 the Tenant takes the whole house. The character is Called on the next night that comes, without a roll, and nothing can hold them. If they come back, it is with their face and their

memories, as a piece of Dromm. The character is lost. The player narrates the last walk west, and may write down one courtesy the Tenant will extend to the companions forever, which the GM must honor.

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **Netwatch Hooker.** You have dragged the Called home by the hair. You know the Mile at night, and the look they give you.
- ◇ **Wreckwife’s Child.** One of your parents came back. You were the one who first noticed. Nobody believed you.
- ◇ **Uncovered Salvager.** You make your living on the dead seabed among upright wrecks and things with too many ribs, and you have seen lights out there you have never reported.

NAMES

MALE	FEMALE	NEUTRAL	SURNAMES
Corvin, Orrin, Finn, Hask, Davey	Kessa, Maren, Nerys, Sable, Ilse	Tolly, Cray, Ebb, Gannet, Wren	Sund, Drowle, Oake, Reef, Undertow
Jonah, Esk, Cobb, Bren, Lysander	Sennet, Brenna, Dagna, Ondine, Haddie	Marl, Sculpin, Tern, Fathom, Shoal	Kelp, Hull, Lobbett, Hawse, Penhallow
Tam, Gaff, Ondric, Hollis, Merrow	Wenna, Isolde, Otiline, Coralie, Brine	Skerry, Weir, Lugg, Swell, Dulse	Gull, Brack, Wake, Tarn, Colm

▼ HORRORS OF BRINEHOLLOW

USING THE HORRORS TABLE

Roll when the party is on the Mile at night, on the Uncovered, or in any Brinehollow house after dark, or pick the scene that cuts deepest. Dread ratings are given in brackets.

D10	HORROR
1	A child sits on a doorstep holding a cut rope, waiting for someone to come out and tie it again. The house is empty. [Dread 2]
2	The cellar's indoor tide brings up a wedding ring, a tooth, and a pair of reading spectacles, all belonging to the same Called woman, laid neatly on the step. [Dread 2]
3	On the Uncovered, a ribbed thing the size of an ox drags itself toward the far water on fins of rotting leather, trailing its own guts across the salt. It is sobbing like a man. [Dread 2]
4	A lantern procession of the Deepening passes, two hundred strong, singing. One of the faces is a PC's sister, or friend, or mother. She smiles and does not stop. [Dread 3]
5	A surgeon's apprentice opens a chest on the table and seawater bursts out, live, full of tiny pale crabs that pour off the table and under the door. [Dread 2]
6	A Tenanted husband greets the party at the door with perfect manners and calls each PC by name, though they have never met. [Dread 3]
7	A pressure day: windows bow, ears bleed, a gull drops dead at someone's feet, and from every cellar on the street comes the sound of something very large turning over. [Dread 2]
8	An upright wreck in the Wreck Orchard has its whole drowned crew still at their stations, preserved in salt, faces turned west, mouths open mid-song. One mouth closes. [Dread 3]
9	At the morning count, a voice answers through the wall for a neighbor who was Called last month, coughing exactly as he did. [Dread 3]
10	At the Trench's edge, the draining sound stops. In the silence, very far down, eight voices are counting, and one is coming closer. [Dread 4]



CHAPTER 6

THE VIGIL

Pinch me.

– THE VIGIL'S COMMONEST ENDEARMENT, AND ITS MARRIAGE VOW

Do not tell me you are tired. Everyone is tired. Tell me you are awake.

– SIGN PAINTED OVER THE DOOR OF EVERY WAKER STATION IN THE CITY

Statement of Hesper Coyle, rope-twister of Thimble Lane, the Slope, given at the Lanternside station to Inspector H. Grimmer in the presence of a Waker-Sergeant and a clerk, third watch, the eleventh day of Carving, 641. Entered as Blink-Matter Forty-One.

I want it written that I loved him. Write that first, before the rest, because after the rest nobody will believe it, and I need it to be somewhere in ink where they cannot scrape it.

We were on the long watch. You know the kind. Two days and the most of a third, because the rope order for the Lamplighters came in doubled and the cut rouse on our street has been weak since Plenty. Tobin said it was chalk. I said it was ash. We argued about it to stay up, the way you do. Arguing is good. Arguing is better than pinching because it gets the blood going in the face.

It was the third afternoon and it was one of those days. Grey. No wind. The tin on the roof did not move at all. You could hear the Lanternside bell from four streets off and then nothing, nothing, nothing for the whole quarter, and the light was the colour of milk in a bowl. I have lived thirty-four years on the Slope and I have never been so frightened of a sky.

Tobin was at the twisting-post and I was at the hackle. We were taking turns saying the numbers. One, he says. Two, I say. That is how we do it on a bad day. If the other one does not answer, you get up and slap them. We got to four hundred and something. I remember four hundred and twelve because it is the age of the Regent in the north and I made a joke about it, and he did not laugh, and I said four hundred and thirteen, and he said four hundred and fourteen. He did say it. I heard him say it.

Then his face was under my hands.

I do not know how to say it better than that. There was no between. I was at the hackle with the flax in my fist and the hackle-teeth were cold, and then it was not my fist, it was my two palms, flat, and under them his face, and his face was warm. He was lying down. Do you understand me? He was lying down on the floor of our own room, on his back, and somebody had put the folded sacking under his head like a pillow, and somebody had crossed his hands on his chest the

way you see them in the old carvings from before, and his eyes were closed. His eyes were closed because my thumbs were on them.

The rest of my hands were over his mouth and nose. Flat and gentle and firm, like a mother tucking a blanket. That is what I keep coming back to. I was not pressing hard. There was no need to press hard. He had stopped some while before.

I want to say I screamed but I did not. I took my hands off him very slowly, the way you would lift your hands off a sleeping baby so as not to wake it, and I looked at my palms, and there was spit on them, and the shape of his teeth pressed into the meat below my thumb. He had bitten me. He had fought. I have no mark on my memory of it at all, only on my hand.

The Waker says I was out for two breaths. The sergeant here says two breaths. Mistress Pell across the lane says she saw me through the window and I was standing at the hackle, and then I was kneeling, and there was no time for me to get from one to the other, and she says I was humming. She says it was the old song, the one that is not allowed, the one about the lamb and the lid. I do not know that song. My mother never sang it to me. Nobody's mother ever sang it to anybody. I would like someone to tell me how I was humming it.

His body was still warm when the Wakers came. They rattled him. They needled his feet and the soft places under his arms the way they do with the Counted, in case, and of course he did not move, because he was not asleep, he was dead, and you cannot needle a dead man back. The sergeant was kind. He put a pin in my hand and closed my fingers over it and said hold that, Mistress, hold that tight, and I have been holding it since the second watch and my palm is running and I cannot feel it.

I keep thinking: where was I. If my hands were here, where was I. And the only answer I have is the room. Everyone knows about the room. I was in the room with the eye for two breaths, and in the room I was not doing anything, I was only standing, I was only looking at the lid, and it was so quiet, and it was so kind, and while I stood there being quiet something was using my hands to put my husband to bed.

You have forty of these, the sergeant says. Forty-one now. He says it is the same every time, the crossed hands, the folded

pillow, the thumbs. He says it like it should help.

I do not want to be let go. I heard you talking about it at the door. I do not want to go back to Thimble Lane. Put me in the Rattlehouse. Put me in a lantern on a pole. Keep a Waker on me with the long needle every minute of every watch for the

rest of my life, I will thank him for it, because the moment nobody is watching me I am going to blink again, and I have a sister, and she has two little ones, and they would let me in.

Write down that I loved him. Pinch me. Please. Somebody pinch me.

▼ THE MEAL

Before it was the Vigil, the plateau was called Ludmere, and before it was a city it was a bed.

Iss, the Lidded, lay in a hollow on the high stone at the northeast corner of the Table, and it lay there for longer than anyone could count, asleep. Of all the Providers it was the only one no living person ever saw do anything. Ossel closed eyes; Ummer walked the fields; Dromm heaved under the sea. Iss slept. Its people built their houses around its sleeping, the way a village grows up around a well, and their whole religion was the art of being quiet near it. The old Ludmere word for a priest meant *one who walks softly*. Pilgrims came from every land to sleep within sight of it, because sleep near Iss was the deepest and kindest sleep on the Table, and the dreams that came with it were said to be true. The plateau was famous for soft beds and goose-down and oracles. It exported pillows.

Those who saw it described it as a long pale mass, larger than the cathedral that now stands in its place, shaped more like a drift of snow than a body, rising and falling with a breath so slow that you could watch a shadow cross half a field between one inhalation and the next. Its skin was grey-white and downy, and warm to the touch, and it smelled of clean linen, of a child's hair, of the inside of a blanket on a cold morning. Two great swellings at one end were taken to be its eyes, shut under lids the size of sails. No one had ever seen them open. The children of Ludmere were told that if Iss ever woke, everything that had ever been dreamed would have to be paid for.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack the plateau was starving like everywhere else. The pillows had stopped selling. The goose-flocks had gone barren and then been eaten. People had begun to lie down near the god on purpose, because sleep was the one thing left that did not cost bread, and many of them did not get up, though in those days that was only hunger. When word came across the Table that the other peoples were turning on their Providers, the walkers-softly of Ludmere held a council in whispers and decided they would do the same, and that they would do it without waking it.

That decision is the root of everything that followed, and the Vigil has never been able to leave it alone. Every other people on the Table killed a god that held still. Ludmere killed a god that was asleep. Whether it consented, whether it knew, whether it felt the knives, are questions that no one alive can answer, and the Vigil's priests have spent three centuries not asking them in public.

The butchering took nine nights, because it had to be done so slowly. The cutters wrapped their blades in felt. They wore no shoes. Children were stationed all around the hollow singing lullabies, in shifts, a low continuous murmur of a thousand small voices, because the walkers-softly believed that if the god heard singing it would think itself still safe. The song they sang is the one the Vigil now forbids, *The Lamb and the Lid*, and there are people in the city who will cross the street rather than hear the first three notes of it whistled.

The flesh of Iss was pale all the way through, the colour of cream, and it did not bleed so much as seep: a warm thin fluid, sweet and faintly salt, that smelled like breath on a pillow. The cutters said that it was like carving warm bread. Many of them fell asleep while they worked. They would be found curled against the flank of the god, their knives still in their hands, their faces slack and happy, and they would be shaken awake and set back to the cutting, yawning. Everyone yawned. That is the detail the old accounts can never stop repeating. The whole plateau yawned for nine nights. Jaws cracked; eyes streamed; people dozed standing in the queue for their portion and woke with their bowls full. The yawning spread down the slopes into the farms and up into the shepherds' huts where no one had seen the god at all.

On the ninth night they came to the eyes. The families who would become the Eye-lines had claimed them by lot, or by force, or by bribery; the accounts disagree, and the Eye-lines have had every version but their own burned. The lids would not open. Not with fingers, not with hooks, not with the blade. When the cutters tried to slit them, the skin of the lids parted and closed again behind the knife like water. In the end the eyes were taken out whole, with the lids still shut over them, two great warm globes in their sheaths of downy skin, and they were divided among nine households and eaten, by lamplight, in silence, still closed. The eaters said afterward that the meat tasted of nothing at all, and that every mouthful made them feel they had just put down something very heavy.

When the god was gone there was a long shallow pressed hollow in the stone, the shape of something that had lain there forever, and it was still warm. It is still warm now. The Vigil calls it the Pillow, and nothing has ever been built in it.

The next morning, the Lack was over. The crops on the plateau's lower terraces rose in a week. And the people of Ludmere slept that

night as they had never slept, long and dreamless and sweet, all of them, every one, and they all woke up.

For three hundred and forty years after that they went on sleeping and waking like anybody. They dreamed a little too vividly. Their oracles grew rich. Their pillow-trade recovered. They told themselves they had got away with it, and in the oldest Ludmere hymnals, before the Waking Laws ordered them burned, there is a verse thanking Iss for being *the only god too kind to notice it was eaten*.

WHAT THE EYE-LINES ATE

The Eye-lines say that they are Iss's sight, and that this is why they are the most perceptive bloodline on the Table, and why they alone are fit to watch the city. The walkers-softly of the old priesthood, before they were suppressed, said something else: that what the Eye-lines swallowed was not the eyes but the lids. Iss's sight was never used. Its lids were the whole of its nature, the shutting, the resting, the turning away. That is what has been growing in the Eye-lines for six centuries. When their children are born without eyelids, it is not because the god's eyes have opened in them. It is because the god has taken its lids back.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Anyone who sleeps does not wake up.

Since the First Night of 341 A.G., every person who falls asleep in the Vigil goes to the same place. It is one shared dream, and everyone who has been there and come back for even a moment describes it the same way: a long room, dim, warm, low-ceilinged, without windows, lit from nowhere, and extending further than it should. The floor is soft. The air is the temperature of a body. Far down at the end of it, in the wall, there is a single enormous closed eye, its lid smooth and grey and faintly downy, larger than a house. It does not open. It does not need to. Standing in that room, the visitors say, is the most restful thing a person can feel. There is no fear in it at all. That is the horror.

Sleepers do not come back from the room. The body they leave behind lives on: it breathes, it is warm, its heart beats slow and steady, it does not age, it does not soil itself or starve or rot. It cannot be roused. Not by shaking, not by water, not by fire, not by the long needle driven under the nail. Its eyes, peeled open, are rolled back and wet. It is not dead, and it will not die of anything but violence, and it is not there.

So nobody sleeps. That is the whole of the law and the whole of the culture. An entire city-state, some four hundred thousand waking souls and sixty thousand sleeping ones, has stayed awake for three hundred years by statute, by drug, by pain and by each other. Exhaustion is not a condition here. It is the climate. A Vigilant does not speak of being tired any more than a fish speaks of being wet.

WHAT THE GOD ALLOWS

The plain fact that keeps the Vigil alive is that nobody dies of wakefulness. Elsewhere on the Table a person kept from sleep for ten days goes mad, and in a month is dead. In the Vigil the body endures it. The god in the blood keeps the heart beating and the lungs working however long the eyes stay open, a mercy or a leash. What the body cannot do is stop wanting to sleep. The pressure builds and does not break. It sits behind the eyes like a hand pressing down on the lids, heavier every hour, and it never, ever lifts.

A Vigilant of fifty has been awake for fifty years, with no gap, no rest, no night, every hour of every day accumulated behind her face like silt. She is not dying of it. She is only drowning in it, a little deeper each year, while standing up.

What gives way is the mind. Sleep-starved people see things that are not there. They hear voices in the hiss of the lamps. They forget what they did a minute ago and remember things that never happened. They lose their tempers, weep at nothing, laugh at funerals, and come to believe that their spouses have been replaced by careful copies. The Vigil has lived inside this for three centuries, and it has done what every people on the Table does with an unbearable thing: it has made it into an institution. The hallucinations are called the Seeming, and when enough people see the same thing, it is news.

THE RULE FOLLOWS THE BLOOD

The first refugees of 342 A.G. fled the plateau by the thousand, certain that if they could only reach the border they could lie down safe. They walked for four days without rest down the old Pilgrim Road toward the Rim, and when they crossed the boundary stones they lay down in the heather, weeping with relief, and slept. Not one of them woke. They are still there. The stretch of road below the border stones is called the Sleepers' Mile, and the bodies lie along it in the grass, breathing, moss-furred, lichen-crustled, with the heather grown up through their clothes.

The rule follows the blood. Anyone born of the Vigil, anyone who carries Iss, goes to the room when they sleep, wherever on the Table they happen to close their eyes. The envoys the Vigil sends abroad travel with paid nudgers and chests of rouse. And the rule holds the land too: a foreigner who falls asleep within the Vigil's borders goes to the room exactly as a native would. Every Rim Road caravan bound for the plateau stops at the Last Beds, the Company inn below the border stones, so its drivers can sleep their fill before they climb. Those who misjudge the climb are delivered to the Dormitory and billed to their employers.

Whether the Unfed of the Fast, who carry no god, are subject to the room in the Vigil has never been tested. The Watch of Watches would very much like to test it.

THE COUNTED

The sleepers are not left where they fall. By law, every one is collected within a bell and carried to the Dormitory, a building the size of a city district, and laid in a numbered bed in a numbered row. There are sixty thousand beds. The sleepers are called the Counted, because in 401 A.G. a Dream-Diver came back from the room with a number: the number of sleepers at which the eye in the wall will open.

The number is a state secret. Only the Matron of the Dormitory now living knows it. The beds are nearly full. Everyone in the Vigil knows that the beds are nearly full, and everyone does the same arithmetic in the small hours of every watch, and nobody knows

what the answer is, and the bells ring every quarter hour, and the lamps never go out, and the city goes on, pinching itself.

GM ADVICE – RUNNING THE RULE

The rule of the Vigil is the simplest on the Table and the cruellest to play, because it attacks the one thing the players do without thinking. Every scene in the Vigil should carry a little weight on the eyelids. Describe warmth as a threat. Describe silence as a threat. Let a long, comfortable conversation by a fire become frightening simply because it is long and comfortable. Use the Weariness rules in Playing a Vigilant for every character in the city, native or foreign, and never let the players forget the bell. When the party rests, ask them who is watching whom, and how. When they plan an ambush that requires waiting, ask them how long. The horror of the Vigil is not a monster that comes for you. It is the room that waits for you to come to it, and it is endlessly, kindly patient.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN THE VIGIL

Iss is growing back, and what grows back is rest. Not the rest of a body that has worked and lies down; the rest of a thing that has been interrupted, and wants very badly to finish what it was doing. In the Vigil the Regrowth does not look like a monster. It looks like a person who is tired. That is what makes it so hard to see, and so easy to deny, in a city where everyone is tired.

THE TASTE

Heavy lids. A drag on the face, as though fine threads had been sewn through the eyelids and tied to something below the floor. The Taste is the commonest godsign in the Vigil, and most Scrapling families do not get much past it: a constant gritty sting behind the eyes, a slowness to focus, a habit of rubbing the face that leaves the skin under the eyes raw and purple. The sign everyone watches for is the yawn. A person in the Taste yawns too wide and too long, the jaw cracking, the eyes streaming, and the yawn goes through a room like a rumour: one person, then three, then the whole bench in the rouse-house, jaws stretching in a slow wave, each person fighting it and losing. Children in the Taste are called *heavy*. Mothers check them every morning by yawning at them across the table, and watching.

The Taste carries a dream without sleep. Those in it sometimes see the long room in the corner of their eye, a dim warm doorway standing open where a wall should be, and catch the smell of clean linen in a street that stinks of lamp-smoke.

THE APPETITE

Blinks. A blink, in the Vigil, does not mean the shutting of an eye. It means a sleep of a second or two, taken on the feet, mid-step, mid-sentence, mid-meal, without warning and without consent. The

head does not drop. The body does not fall. From the outside, the blinker simply pauses, as if listening, for a breath or two, and then goes on. From the inside, the blinker is in the long room with the eye for exactly as long as they are out, standing on the soft floor in the warm air, at peace, and then is torn back out of it gasping.

The trouble is that blinkers come back from the room having moved. They were at the window and now they are at the door. They were holding a cup and now the cup is in the fire. They were speaking to a friend and now the friend is staring at them with a white face and will not say what they just said. Most blinks are small: a lost sentence, a dropped stitch, a step taken. Some are not. The worst are the blink-murders, killings done by ordinary people in a sleep of two breaths, which they do not remember and could never have imagined, and which are always done the same way. The Appetite is the stage at which a person in the Vigil stops being trusted, even by themselves.

Those in the Appetite also hunger for comfort, which in the Vigil is a perversion. They stroke fabric. They stand too long near stoves. They are caught pressing their cheeks against warm walls with their eyes half shut and a look on their faces that respectable people find obscene. Rouse-house slang for this is *nuzzling*, and it is grounds for divorce.

THE COURSE

The lids thin, shrink, and are gone. It happens over months: first a translucence, so that the iris shows through the shut lid as a dark smudge; then a shrinking, the lids drawing back like a burnt page curling from its edges; then a soft raw rim of pink where they were, and the eye beneath it wide, staring, naked, permanently open. The eyes of the lidless must be wetted by hand every half minute or they

cloud and crack. The poor use rag and a pot of water. The rich keep attendants with sable brushes and silver bowls of rosewater warmed to blood heat. The lidless cannot close their eyes to weep, to wince, to blink against smoke or wind or a blow. They see everything that happens in front of them, and they forget none of it. Their memories become perfect and unbearable.

The Eye-line nobility are born this way, and call it purity. Their children come into the world staring, and the midwives of the Height do not slap them to make them cry, but to make them look away; none of them can. The Lidless Succession of 480 A.G. made the Course a qualification for rule, on the reasoning that a person who cannot shut their eyes cannot fall asleep. No lidless person in the Vigil has ever been Counted. No one has thought hard about why, except the walkers-softly, who are no longer permitted to think aloud.

THE BRINK

Before the Seating comes the long dreadful plateau that the Vigil's physicians call the Brink and its poor call *going grey*. The lidless at the Brink do not blink at all, but they begin to *be* somewhere else while they stand among the living: their gaze fixes on a point a great distance behind the wall, their breathing slows to the rhythm of the Dormitory, and anyone who stands near them begins to yawn and cannot stop. People in the Brink can put others down. Not by any act; by being near, by looking, by speaking softly. They are dangerous to love. The Watch keeps a ward for them under the Nodding Stair, and the attendants who work there wear wax in their ears and wire across their eyelids, and are rotated every hour.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

The Vigil sits on a high bare plateau of grey stone at the northeast of the Table, a great tilted table-top of rock that rises out of the eastern plain in sheer cliffs on three sides and slopes down, on the fourth, toward the Rim Road and the soft bad country of heather and stream that leads to it. The plateau is called the Lid. It is windy, cold at the edges, warm in the middle, almost treeless, and covered from one end to the other by a single city.

That city is never dark. There are ten thousand public lamps on its streets, and a hundred thousand more in its houses, and in its squares burn great open iron furnaces, the Bonfires, tended day and night by the Lamplighters' Guild. Every roof carries mirrors, angled to catch the furnace-glow and throw it back down into the lanes, so that the light comes from every direction at once and there are no shadows anywhere a person could close their eyes in. There has been no night on the Lid for three centuries. The smoke of all those lamps hangs over the plateau in a permanent brown ceiling, lit from beneath, glowing a dull bruised orange, so that from the Rim Road

THE SEATING

A sleeper who begins to move. Lips first.

For three hundred years the Counted have lain utterly still. In the last ten years, a handful in the oldest rows have begun to stir. A finger curls. A head turns, by degrees, over weeks, until the face looks along the row toward the next bed. The lips part and shape words that make no sound. A sleeper in the Seating is the god, partly returned, wearing a body it took into its room and has been patiently furnishing from the inside. The Vigil does not use the word Seating. The Dormitory's orderlies call such a sleeper *restless*, the way a nurse speaks of a feverish child, and they do not like to turn their backs on one.

The worst thing about the moving sleepers is that their faces are happy.

WHAT IS RESTLESS IN THE ROWS

As of Carving 641, the Matron's private register lists nineteen restless sleepers. Bed One, Aveline Morne, moves her lips in shapes the Matron writes down. Bed 40,112, the son of Odile Farthing, has grown from a boy of four to the size of a man in eleven years, and smiles. Bed 7,730 has turned its head toward the Dormitory's east door and holds it there; the orderlies have moved the door. Beds 212 through 219, eight members of one family who lay down together on the First Night, have begun, over the course of a year, to reach toward each other across the gaps between their beds. Their fingertips now nearly touch. The Matron has measured the distance. She has not separated the beds, because she does not know what will happen if she does, and she does not know what will happen if she does not.

the Vigil looks like a coal left burning in an empty grate. Nobody born in the Vigil has ever seen a star. Some of the children do not believe in them.

The city stinks of lamp-oil, hot tin, scorched wick, rouse-grounds and sweat. Its sounds are clatter, bells, rattles, the shouts of nudgers, the barking of the dogs that are bred and paid to bark, and under everything the hiss and flutter of a hundred thousand flames.

THE WEATHER OF COMFORT

The danger here is comfort. Other lands fear storms. The Vigil fears a nice day.

The warm wind off the eastern plain is called the Yawn. It comes up over the cliffs in late Plenty and early Carving smelling faintly of hay and sun-warmed stone, soft as a hand on the back of the neck, and on Yawn days the Wakers double their patrols, the bells ring every eighth of an hour instead of every quarter, and the Glass

House fills. Rain on a roof is so soothing that the Vigil's roofs are built of loose overlapping tin so that rain will clatter, bang and scrape on them instead of patter. Snow is a horror: the hush of it, the softness, the way it muffles the bells. During snowfall, the Watch orders every householder to bang a pot at their door for one minute in every ten.

The worst weather of all is a mild, quiet, overcast afternoon, windless, grey, the light all the same colour, the sounds of the city flattening out under the cloud. The city records those days in its annals as disasters, with a death toll. The Grey Ninth of Carving 588 put eleven hundred people into the Dormitory between the fourth bell and the dusk lamps, and is commemorated every year with a day of compulsory shouting.

THE SEASONS

Grace brings cold winds off the cliffs, which the Vigil loves: it is the healthiest season, and the Dormitory takes fewest in it. Plenty is long and warm and dangerous; the Yawn blows, and the poor suffer most in their close hot rooms on the Slope. Carving is the season of grey afternoons and the worst losses of the year. Lack brings snow, early dark the city refuses to acknowledge, and Tablenight, the one minute in all the year when the lamps go out.

A GAZETTEER OF THE VIGIL

THE DORMITORY

A building the size of a district, on the lower south side of the Lid, where the plateau begins to slope. It was begun in 342 A.G. as a single converted granary and has been extended, wing by wing and storey by storey, for three hundred years, until it is the largest roofed space on the Table. Inside, it is one hall after another, low-ceilinged and lamplit, and in each hall the beds stand in rows, iron-framed, narrow, white-sheeted, numbered in black paint on the foot-rail. Sixty thousand of them. Every one but fewer than two thousand is occupied.

It is completely silent. The orderlies wear felt slippers, as the walkers-softly once did. No bell is rung inside. And in that silence, the one sound is the breathing. The Counted all breathe in time. Sixty thousand chests rise and fall together, slow, deep, regular, perhaps four breaths to the minute, and the air in the halls moves with them like a tide: a long warm sigh drawn in through the doors, a long warm sigh pushed out. Standing in the central hall is like standing in the lung of an enormous animal. The lamps flicker in rhythm. New orderlies find that within an hour their own breathing has slowed to match, and they must be taken outside and slapped.

The building smells of clean linen and of skin, the sweetish smell of bodies that do not sweat and do not age. Dust does not settle on the Counted. The orderlies change the sheets anyway, every Plate, because someone must do something.

THE NODDING STAIR

The council hall of the Watch of Watches, at the summit of the Height, the highest district of the city. It is a single staircase, broad as a road, which spirals up through a hollow tower of grey stone and never arrives anywhere, its top steps returning by a hidden ramp to its bottom, so that the council climbs forever. Its architect, Benedikt Lour, designed it so that no one could sit comfortably, lean comfortably or stand still comfortably; the steps are of uneven height and slant subtly outward. The Watch has sat in session on the Stair, in shifts, for two hundred years without adjourning. Its members are always climbing. Debate is conducted on the move; motions are carried by those still breathing hard enough to say aye. The Warden-Prime alone stands still, on a landing halfway up called the Lid's Eye, and the whole council passes before her once every quarter hour.

LAMPWRIGHTS' ROW

The brightest street in the world. It runs along the spine of the Lid between the Height and the Slope, and on both sides of it are the workshops where the city's mirrors are silvered, its lenses ground, its burners cast, its wicks braided and its lamp-glass blown. Every shopfront is a display of lit lamps, and every roof a forest of polished mirrors, so that the Row is lit from above and below and every side at once and a walker there casts no shadow at all. Visitors from other lands are blinded for the first hour and get headaches for a week. The Vigil's rich take their constitutionals there, squinting with pleasure, and courting couples walk it arm in arm, pinching. The dead of the city are burned in the Row's great furnaces, and their light goes out into its lamps. *She's on the Row now* is how a Vigilant says that someone has died.

THE GLASS HOUSE

A quarantine for contagious yawners, on a bare spur of rock at the windward edge of the Lid where the cold winds hit hardest. It is a long greenhouse of thick green glass in iron frames, divided into cells, each lit from outside by its own lamp. The yawners inside are masked in stiff leather muzzles that hold the jaw half closed. Visitors speak to them through speaking-tubes and are forbidden to look at their faces. The Glass House is the most frightening building in the city to people who have never been inside it and the saddest to people who have.

THE SLOPE

The slum quarter, sprawling down the south side of the Lid below the Dormitory, built of tin, plank and rope in steep lanes too narrow for the Wakers' carts. Rouse is cut thin here, with chalk, ash, brine and worse. Nudgers are cheap and are mostly children. The lamps are fewer and dimmer, the oil is bad, and the Bonfires are fed with dung and rags. Whole families go down in an afternoon, one after another, the last one awake moving from body to body slapping and screaming until they too go quiet. When the

Dormitory carts come down the Slope, the people come out to watch, and to count.

THE PILLOW

The hollow where Iss lay, at the exact centre of the Lid. It is a long shallow depression in the bedrock, a quarter mile from end to end, smoothly curved, shaped like the impression of something enormous that lay on its side with its knees drawn up. Nothing has ever been built in it. The stone is warm to the touch in every season and faintly soft, like a cushion with the stuffing settled. Snow melts there. Yawners who stand at its rim begin to weep. The Watch has fenced it with iron spikes and lamps on poles, and the Wakers who guard it work in pairs and are relieved every bell. It is a capital crime to lie down in the Pillow. It is not a crime that is ever tried, because those who commit it are never available for trial; they are lifted out by orderlies with hooked poles and carried straight to the Dormitory, smiling.

THE RATTLEHOUSE

The Wakers' central prison and school, a squat octagon of black brick at the foot of the Height. It is the loudest building in the Vigil. Its cells are lined with tin and hung with chimes; its corridors are patrolled by Wakers with rattles who shake them every few breaths; its prisoners are kept on their feet in standing-stalls with iron collars at the throat. Here the Wakers learn their needlework, and here the city's criminals serve their sentences, which are measured not in years but in wakefulness. A prisoner in the Rattlehouse is kept awake by the state, not by themselves, and that is the punishment: to be held in the hands of an institution that does not care whether it hurts you, only that you do not close your eyes.

THE BITTERHOUSE

The state rouse-works, a sprawling complex of copper stills, roasting-ovens, drying-sheds and grinding-mills on the north side of the Lid, where the Apothecary-General's chemists make the city's stimulant. The air for half a mile downwind tastes of burnt sugar and iron and makes the teeth ache. The Bitterhouse workers are the most alert people in the Vigil and the shortest-lived, their teeth black stumps by twenty-five, their hearts giving out by forty. Under the Bitterhouse are the Proving Rooms, where new strains are tested on prisoners lent from the Rattlehouse, and where Dr. Aldous Crane keeps the curve he will not publish.

THE PINCHMARKET

The city's perpetual market, filling three squares and the lanes between them below Lampwrights' Row, open every hour of every watch for three hundred years. Rouse is sold here in every grade, from the Bitterhouse's sealed black cakes to Slope sweepings in twists of paper. So are pins, burr-cloth, bells, rattles, ice, smelling-salts, and nudgers. The nudger-stands are at the market's eastern end: children and old women and out-of-work Wakers sitting on stools beneath painted boards giving their rates by the bell. The

most expensive nudgers advertise their own wakefulness: *Not One Blink In Nine Years* or *Witnessed Lidless, Sworn by the Watch*.

THE TETHER HALL

The Dream-Divers' house, a domed rotunda beside the Dormitory with a single bed at its centre under a great brass winch. Divers lie down on the bed in harness, wired at the wrists, ankles and throat to the winch and to a team of eight hauliers, and go to sleep on purpose. When the bell is struck, the hauliers drag them back. The method is a secret of the Hall, but it involves the harness, a great deal of pain, and something done to the diver's tongue. The floor around the bed is scarred with the heel-marks of three centuries of hauliers bracing. Many dives do not come back. The bodies of those who stay are laid in the Dormitory under their own row, the Divers' Row, and their harnesses are hung above the beds.

THE PENDULUM HALL

The house of the city's clocks, a tall narrow tower of grey stone in the Height where the Hourkeeper sets the time for the bells. Inside it, from the top of the tower to the cellar, hangs a single pendulum, a great iron bob on a rope of twisted wire, swinging through a slow arc that once took exactly four seconds. Around the walls, two hundred and forty smaller clocks tick in their cases. The tower hums. Those who stand inside it long enough begin to feel, under the ticking, a slowness, as if the beats were drifting a little further apart.

THE LAST BEDS

The Rim Road Company inn below the border stones, at the foot of the Pilgrim Road where it leaves the Rim. It is the last place a foreigner may safely sleep before the climb, and the Company sells that sleep dearly. Its long wooden halls are full of beds, the only beds within thirty miles of the Vigil, and Vigilant travellers coming down from the plateau on Company business will pay to stand at the doorway of the sleeping-hall and look at them. Some weep. Some have tried to lie down and been dragged out by the Company's porters, who are paid by the Watch for each one they save. The innkeeper keeps a book of those they did not.

THE SLEEPERS' MILE

Below the border stones, along the old Pilgrim Road, lie the refugees of 342 A.G., who fled the plateau to sleep beyond its borders and found that the rule followed them. There are about four thousand of them, scattered along a mile of road and heather. They still breathe. They are grown over: moss in the hair, lichen on the cheeks, heather pushing up through the rotted rags of their clothes, the bones of their faces showing through skin that has been rained on for three hundred years and has not aged a day. Pilgrims and Rim Road drovers pass them with their eyes averted. Children from the caravans dare each other to touch one. The Watch has never brought them in: there are not enough beds, and they do not count. Or so the Watch hopes.

▼ HISTORY

We were the softest people on the Table. Remember that, when you look at what we have become.

– INSCRIPTION ON THE BASE OF THE BONFIRE IN LUDMERE SQUARE

YEAR	EVENT
before 0 A.G.	Ludmere: the city of soft beds, oracles and pilgrims, grown up around the sleeping Iss.
0 A.G.	The Nine Nights. Iss is butchered without waking, to lullabies. The Eye-lines eat its shut eyes.
0–340	The Easy Centuries. Ludmere sleeps like anyone, dreams too vividly, and grows rich on oracles.
288	The Dreamers' Fair at its height; oracles report a long room in their visions, and are laughed at.
341	The First Night. A third of the city does not get up. By the third morning, half.
342	The Waking Laws. Beds burned; sleep outlawed; the city renamed. The flight down the Sleepers' Mile.
342	The Dormitory founded in the old Corn Granary. The first Wakers sworn.
390	The Rouse Patent. A stimulant that holds.
401	The Count. A Dream-Diver returns with the number, says it once, and is laid in a bed.
441	The Watch of Watches convenes on the Nodding Stair. It has not adjourned.
480	The Lidless Succession. Only the lidless may rule.
533	The Market Yawn. Lukas Marre's grandmother puts down four hundred in the Pinchmarket. The Glass House is built.
588	The Grey Ninth. Eleven hundred Counted in one afternoon.
590	Bedding suspended as a capital sentence, for want of beds.
629	The Seeming is first formally entered into the public record as news.
631	The first restless sleeper is logged. The entry is struck from the register.
640	Rouse fails by the hour. The Hourkeeper's first report on the lengthening of hours is suppressed.
641	Fewer than two thousand empty beds. Bed One begins to move her lips. Envoy Dray goes north.

THE FIRST NIGHT

It came on the third night of Grace, 341 A.G., which had been a warm and pleasant evening. There was no sign. Ludmere went to bed. In the morning, roughly a third of it did not get up: they lay in their beds breathing slow and even, smiling, and no amount of shaking would rouse them. Their families screamed in the streets. The physicians were sent for and could not wake them. By the next night the city understood only that a sickness had come; and most of it, exhausted with weeping and fear, went to bed. In the morning, half of what remained did not wake.

Those who survived the third night were the ones too frightened to lie down: the anxious, the guilty, the insomniac, the mad, the nursing mothers, the drunks, the watchmen, the children too hungry to sleep. They sat up through the dark in kitchens together, slapping each other, shouting, banging pans, holding hands and squeezing until the knuckles cracked. Those people are the ancestors

of the Vigil. The city descends, by a kind of hideous selection, from its worst sleepers. Vigilants say it with pride.

THE WAKING LAWS AND THE BURNING OF THE BEDS

In the spring of 342 the survivors met in the old Ludmere Square and passed the Waking Laws by acclamation. Lying down was forbidden. Closing the eyes for longer than a breath was forbidden. Every bed, couch, mattress, pillow and cushion on the plateau was carried into the squares and burned, along with the goose-down warehouses, the oracles' dream-books, and the dreamers themselves when they protested. The pyres burned for a month; they were the first Bonfires. The city took its new name from a word the old priests had used for the night before a feast: *the vigil*. It was meant to sound temporary.

THE COUNT

In 401 a diver named Iselde Marrow, on her eleventh descent, walked further into the long room than anyone had and stood for a long while near the eye. When she was hauled back, half-dead with pain, she said she had heard the number. It had been told to her, she said, very gently, as if by a mother explaining to a child how many more days until a holiday. She was brought before three officials of the Watch, in a sealed room, and made to say it once. Then the officials agreed that the number was too dangerous to leave in a living head, and they had her laid down in a bed. Her bed was the next one in the row. Two of the three officials were dead within the decade, by accident; the third was the first Matron of the Dormitory, and the number has passed from Matron to Matron since, whispered once at the bedside of the dying.

GM ADVICE – WHAT IS THE NUMBER?

The number is a state secret, and the book does not fix it. Choose one of these, or write your own. (1) The number is 60,001. The Dormitory was built to hold exactly one fewer, by a Matron who thought she could stop it with carpentry. (2) The number is the population of Ludmere on the Nine Nights, every man, woman and child who ate of Iss. The god is calling its table back. (3) The number has already been passed. Iselde Marrow lied, or was lied to. The eye began to open years ago, very slowly, and what the Hourkeeper is measuring is the lid going up. (4) There is no number. The Watch invented it in 401 to give the city something to fear that was not the truth, which is that the eye will open when it is ready. Whatever you choose, the Matron should believe it absolutely.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

The Vigil is governed by the Watch of Watches, a council of some three hundred Eye-line nobles who sit, or rather climb, in three shifts around the clock on the Nodding Stair. It has not adjourned in two hundred years. Its members are lidless by law, attended by eye-wetters, and watched by one another, since in the Vigil the oldest political truth is that anyone may blink. At its head is the Warden-Prime, always an Eye-line, always lidless, watched in turn by attendants who wet the royal eyes with a brush every half minute.

Beneath the Watch sit the Offices: the Apothecary-General (rouse), the Lamplighter-General (oil and light), the Hourkeeper (time and bells), the Matron (the Dormitory), the Registrar of the Seeming (the public record), and the Captaincy of the Wakers (everything else).

THE LAW OF THE LID

The law is simple. Lying down is a crime. Closing your eyes for longer than a breath is a crime. Letting someone near you nod off is negligence, punishable as manslaughter if they go down. Selling sleep is a crime. Singing *The Lamb and the Lid* is a crime. Possession of down, feathers, wool batting or any soft stuffing in a quantity greater than will fill a shoe is a crime. Speaking of the room in a soothing manner is incitement.

The police, the Wakers, carry rattles and long needles, and they are entitled to needle any citizen who appears drowsy, without warrant and without apology. A citizen who objects to being needled is presumed to be drowsy.

Punishment is wakefulness. Minor offenders are sentenced to hours at the Rattlehouse, kept on their feet by Wakers with needles. Serious offenders are sentenced to the Lantern: an iron cage hung from a pole in a public square, open on every side, lit by its own lamp, in which the condemned is kept awake by any passing citizen

with a pin, for as long as the sentence runs. Long sentences in the Lantern produce Seeming so violent that the condemned believe they are being eaten by the crowd, and sometimes the crowd believes it too.

Until 590 the capital sentence was Bedding. The condemned were led to the Dormitory in a white gown, given warm milk and poppy, laid in a bed and allowed to sleep, while a crowd outside sang the forbidden lullaby, the one day in the year it was permitted. It was considered the most merciful execution on the Table, and envied. It was suspended when the Matron reported that beds were scarce. Since then, the worst criminals have been held in the Rattlehouse awaiting a sentence that cannot be carried out, and the Rattlehouse is very full.

THE THREE PARTIES

The deepest political question is the Dormitory, and the Watch is split three ways over it.

The **Builders** want more beds. They are the oldest and largest party, the party of the Architect and the Matron's office, and their position is that the number can be postponed by construction, because the Counted must be housed somewhere and every bed is a delay. Their critics observe that a bed does not change the number, and that building more beds is only building a bigger waiting room.

The **Removalists** want the Counted moved out of the country: carted down the Pilgrim Road, laid along the Rim, sold to Sallowreach or the Fatlands, buried, sunk, anything to get them off the Lid. Their theory is that the count is local. The Sleepers' Mile, they point out, has been beyond the border for three centuries and the eye has not opened. Their opponents point out that nobody knows whether the Sleepers' Mile is counted or not.

And one party, very quietly, wants the number reduced. They do not have a name in the public record. Among themselves they call themselves the Lessening, and their position is arithmetic: if the eye opens when the Counted reach a certain number, then the Counted

must not reach it, and since the Counted cannot be woken, some of them must stop being Counted. The Lessening does not use the word murder. It uses the words *reduction*, *thinning* and *relief*. It has drawn up lists.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

NO BEDS

There is not a bed, couch or cushion in the city. Floors slope, a little, so that a person who lies on them slides. Chairs have one leg, and must be balanced on; a person who dozes on a one-legged chair falls off it. Walls are studded with iron knobs at shoulder height, so that no one can lean. Doorways have no frames to rest against. Tables are chest-high. The Vigil eats, works, talks and loves standing up, and its people have the thick calves, the bad backs and the swollen ankles to show for it.

NUDGING

Everyone has a nudger. A nudger is the person whose job is to keep you awake: a spouse, a sibling, a friend, a hired child. Nudgers watch for the drooping lid, the slackened jaw, the long pause; they pinch, slap, shout, prick and shake. In a family, everyone nudges everyone, in a ring, so that no one is ever unwatched. A person without a nudger is called *unwatched*, and it is the loneliest word in the language.

Marriage is the promise to keep each other awake, and the vow is two words: *Pinch me*. Weddings are loud, bright, short, and held at the Bonfires. The couple pinch each other on the inside of the wrist until they bleed, and the guests throw bells. Love between spouses is tender and fierce and frightened, because every intimacy is a danger; what comes after love, in a body, is drowsiness, and the Vigil's lovers keep a rattle by them and a lamp at full wick, and their tenderness is shot through with watchfulness. *The little death is the big one here*, the rouse-house joke goes, and nobody laughs.

ROUSE

Rouse is a bitter black stimulant, ground and roasted from the dried caps of staremoss, a grey lichen that grows only on the cliff-faces of the Lid, mixed with Bitterhouse salts whose composition is a state secret. It is sold as pressed cakes, as powder, and as a thick black syrup, and it is taken hourly, chewed, sipped or packed against the gum. It tastes of burnt sugar, iron and bile. It makes the heart race, the hands shake and the pupils widen. Teeth go first: they blacken and loosen and drop out, and a Vigilant over forty with a full set is either rich, lidless or lying. Then the heart. The ordinary death of an ordinary Vigilant is a rouse-heart: a burst of thudding, a grey face, a hand to the chest, and the long-awaited lying down on the floor.

The dose has risen every decade since 390. A modest citizen spends two lacks a day on rouse. On the Slope it is cut to stretch it, and the cuts are worse than the drug.

PAIN AS COURTESY

A slap is a favour. Guests are offered a pin on arrival, as other lands offer bread and salt, and to refuse it is an insult. Clothes are made of burr-cloth, a coarse wool woven with dried thistle-heads; the rich wear galled silk, laced with fine wire that pricks at every movement. Shoes are cobbled with a pebble in the heel. Collars are set with pins. A Vigilant's skin is a map of small courtesies: the scabs on the wrists, the bruises on the upper arm, the neat rows of needle-scars along the forearm. To bear them is respectability. To have unmarked skin is suspicious.

FOOD

A full belly is a bed. Meals in the Vigil are small, frequent, cold and sour: pickled roots, hard bread, salt meat out of Fatlands barrels, vinegar, sorrel, smoked cliff-goat. Warm milk is illegal. Sugar is rationed. Soup is served lukewarm, by law. Rich households eat from vessels with sharp rims. The grace is the common one, *Lack keep away*, said with the eyes open, and followed in the Vigil by a slap on the table.

THE SEEMING

After enough waking, everyone hallucinates. A Vigilant hears voices in the hiss of the lamps, sees insects walking across the plaster, watches faces rise up in the patterns of the cobbles, sees a dead mother at the end of a lane. These private visions are a nuisance and are ignored. But sometimes a whole street sees the same thing. A woman made of moths walking down Gutter Lane. A rain of teeth over the Pinchmarket. A door in the side of the Nodding Stair that was not there before. When that happens, the Vigil has made it a civic sense. Witnesses report it to the Registrar of the Seeming, the Seemers record it, and when enough unconnected people have seen the same thing, it is entered in the public record as news, read aloud at the Bonfires, and printed in the bell-sheets. A Seeming entered in the record is, for legal purposes, true. Contracts have been voided because of it. Houses have been condemned because the street agreed they were on fire.

The power to enter a Seeming, or refuse it, is the power to decide what happened. The Watch knows this very well.

From the Public Record of the Seeming, as read at the Ludmere Bonfire, fourth watch, the second day of Carving, 641.

ENTERED: In the lanes of the Slope between Thimble and Lanternside, thirty-one persons unconnected and of good character, between the ninth and tenth bells, did see a tall figure in a grey coat, stooping, which passed down the lane laying out upon the cobbles a long table, with cloth and plates and cups, and with chairs drawn back. The table was nine hundred paces long. At every place was a bowl of something steaming. The figure did not speak. At the tenth bell it was gone and the cobbles were clean. Several witnesses report the smell of new bread. Similar matter entered this month in ten other districts. ENTERED AS TRUE.

NOT ENTERED: In Thimble Lane at the eleventh bell, nine persons report that the figure returned, and that one of the chairs had been sat in. Insufficient witnesses. The Registrar reminds the public that a Seeming not entered did not occur.

CHILDREN

Infants born in the Vigil do not sleep. They come into the world wide-eyed and quiet, and for their first years they lie awake in their mothers' arms staring at the lamps, never crying for rest, because they do not yet need it. Vigilants call them *starers* and consider them a mercy of the god. The weight comes later, at about four years old: the Coming-Heavy, when a child first yawns, first rubs its eyes, first asks, in a small cross voice, why it cannot lie down. That is when the Vigil loses its children. A child cannot be told what the room is. A child cannot be made to understand why the warm, the soft, the dim, the quiet are deadly. There is a wing of the Dormitory called the Small Rows, where the beds are short, and the mothers who visit them do not speak to each other.

Children of the Slope who survive the Coming-Heavy are named for the bell they were born at, and many of them become nudgers by six: Pip Eleven-Bell, Rook Quarter-Bell. It is cheap work and they are good at it, sharp-eyed and quick-fingered. They do not last long on rouse.

DEATH

People still die in the Vigil, of rouse-heart, fever, accident and violence. A corpse is the only thing in the city allowed to lie down, and the body is laid out flat on a board in the street for a day so that the neighbours may come and look at it, and touch its closed eyes, and envy it. The mourners are allowed to sit, for one hour, on the kerb. Then the body is carried to Lampwrights' Row and burned in the furnaces, and its light goes out into the lamps. The rich pay to have a particular lamp lit from their ashes. The poor go to the general flame.

FESTIVALS AND DAYS

The Night of Lying Down, on the anniversary of the First Night, is the city's great mourning: every family that has a sleeper in the Dormitory goes to stand at the foot of the bed for an hour, and the Dormitory's doors are open from bell to bell. The Shouting Day remembers the Grey Ninth. The Pinching Fair, at midsummer, is a riot of bells, needle-dances and wake-games. And on Tablenight, the longest night of Lack, the city puts out every lamp for one minute, to prove it still can. People stand in the dark in the streets holding hands and counting aloud together, all of them, so that no one can drift off unnoticed, sixty seconds, the only darkness they will ever see. Every year a few hands go slack in the dark. Every year, when the lamps come back, someone is still counting into silence.

CRIME

Theft and violence are common and treated as ordinary. The great crimes are the crimes of rest. Selling sleep; harbouring a sleeper; failing to report one; lying down; singing the song; and the newest, which the law has not yet decided what to call: the blink-murder, the killing done by someone who was not there.

PROVERBS AND OATHS

- ◇ *Pinch me.* (I love you; I trust you; I am afraid.)
- ◇ *A full belly is a bed.*
- ◇ *Never trust a rested face.*
- ◇ *The eye is patient. Be rude.*
- ◇ *Count your nudger's blinks.*
- ◇ *Sleep is a door that only opens inward.*
- ◇ *He's on the Row.* (He is dead.)
- ◇ *She went to the room.* (She fell asleep; she is gone.)

The Vigil swears on its sleepers. *By my mother's bed* is a common oath, and the bed's number is spoken after it. The heaviest oath in the city is sworn at the foot of Bed One with a hand on the rail: *by the first of us, who lay down for all of us.* A Vigilant who breaks an oath sworn on a sleeper's bed is held to have broken faith with the Counted, and no nudger will watch them again.

A note found pinned to the coat of Annick Rell, laundress, of the Slope, discovered lying in the open yard behind Gallow Street, the eighth day of Plenty, 640, and carried to bed 58,921. Entered in the Lain Book.

Teodor. I am sorry about the coat. I am sorry it is the good one. I have been awake for thirty-one years and I am so tired that I cannot remember your face when you are out of the room, I have to go and look. I cannot taste anything. I hear my mother in the lamps. The baby has been in the Small Rows for six years and I visit and she is still four and I am forty and I will be fifty and she will still be four. They say the room is

warm. They say it does not hurt. I am not leaving you, I am going to her. Do not let them say I slipped. I did not slip. I chose it. Please come and stand at the foot of the bed sometimes, and talk, because they say we can hear. Do not lie down after me. Promise. Pinch the children for me. A.

THE LAIN-DOWN

Every year, hundreds of Vigilants lie down on purpose. The law calls it *voluntary rest*, prosecutes the nudger for negligence, and fines the family. The city calls it *going to the room* and does not talk about it. Those left behind carry it for the rest of their lives: they go to the Dormitory and stand at the foot of the bed, and the person they loved is there, warm, breathing, unchanged, smiling, unreachable, and will be there unchanged long after they themselves have grown old and gone onto the Row. There is no grave to leave, no body to bury, no end to the grief, only a bed with a number and a face that is still, horribly, at peace. GMs should play the Lain-Down as tragedy and as pressure, never as a solution: a contact who has started talking about how warm it must be; a nudger who has stopped pinching quite so hard; a widow who visits the same bed every day and has begun to bring a stool. The god's pull is gentle, reasonable and kind. That is the horror of it.

▼ FACTIONS

THE WATCH OF WATCHES

The lidless government: sleepless, paranoid, and correct to be. Its members believe that the Vigil survives only because someone is always looking, and that the someone must be a person who cannot look away. They want to hold the city together until the number

can be outwitted, and they are prepared to do anything that does not require them to admit how close it is. A PC joins as an aide, eye-wetter or clerk of the Stair; only the lidless may hold a vote. Enemies: the Bedded, the Tuckers, anyone who says the number aloud. Allies: the Wakers, the Rim Road Company, the Second Table, which several Watchers secretly belong to.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Stair-Clerk	Access to the Nodding Stair; a sworn nudger at state expense.
2	Eye-Wetter	Attendance on a Watcher; hears everything said on the Stair.
3	Watcher of the Third Shift	A vote (lidless only); may commandeer Wakers for a watch.
4	Watcher of the Lid's Eye	A seat on the inner committees; sight of the true rouse and oil figures.
5	Warden-Prime	The city. Only one, ever.

THE WAKERS

The police. Their job is to hurt people for their own good, and after three centuries they are very skilled. Every Waker is trained at the Rattlehouse in the Atlas of the Quick, a manual of the body's points of pain, and in the use of the rattle and the long needle: a

nine-inch steel spike, ground fine, driven into the places where pain is sharpest and harm least. They believe that pain is love made practical. They want to keep the count from rising, one drowsy citizen at a time. A PC joins by apprenticeship at the Rattlehouse and a year's probation in the Slope. Enemies: the Tuckers, the Bedded, the Lessening (which they do not know exists). Allies: the Watch, the Lamplighters, every frightened household.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Rattle	A rattle, a pin-roll and a patrol beat. Legal right to slap.
2	Needle	The long needle; may needle without warrant.
3	Sergeant of the Ward	Command of a station; may sentence to the Rattlehouse for a watch.
4	Inquisitor of the Quick	Interrogation rights; keys to the Rattlehouse's lower floors.
5	Captain of the Wakers	Command of every Waker; answers only to the Watch.

From the Atlas of the Quick, schoolroom edition, Rattlehouse press, Lesson the Fourth.

The needle is not a weapon. Repeat this until you believe it, and then repeat it until the citizen believes it. You are not there to punish the sleeper but to fetch him. Go in under the nail of the great toe, where the quick is shallow and the harm is small; then the web of the thumb; then the soft of the armpit; then the hollow behind the ear. If these do not answer, the citizen is gone and you may stop. Do not stop before. Many a sleeper has been lost by a Waker who was squeamish at the armpit. The scream is the citizen thanking you. Learn to hear it so.

THE LAMPLIGHTERS' GUILD

The keepers of the light. They trim the ten thousand public lamps, stoke the Bonfires, polish the roof-mirrors, and burn the dead on Lampwrights' Row. Oil is the Vigil's largest import, by Rim Road from Brinehollow whale-yards and Fatlands rendering-houses, and the Guild knows exactly how many days of it remain. They believe that darkness is death, and they are right. They want oil, at any price, from any source. The source has lately become a matter for the inner Guild alone, and the tallow vats behind the furnaces on the Row are bigger than they were. A PC joins as a wick-boy or mirror-climber. Enemies: anyone who hoards oil. Allies: the Wakers, the Renderers' Union of the Fatlands, Lukas Marre, oddly, whose cell they keep brightest of all.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Wick	A pole, a lamp-round and free light at home.
2	Climber	Access to the roof-mirrors; knowledge of every rooftop route.
3	Stoker of a Bonfire	A square of one's own; the right to refuse light to a street.
4	Burner of the Row	Charge of the furnaces where the dead are burned, and of what is rendered there.
5	Lamplighter-General	The oil ledger, and the date on its last page.

THE TUCKERS

A criminal mercy. For a price, the Tuckers will guard you while you sleep for sixty seconds, then haul you back: they lay you on a straw pallet in a cellar, count to sixty, and drag you up by a hook-and-harness that they will not let customers examine. The method works

more often than not. Their failures are delivered to the Dormitory steps before the next bell, washed and wrapped and labelled with a number from the Tuckers' own register. They believe sleep is a human right; they also believe it is a month's wages. A PC joins as a counter, the Tucker who keeps time over the sleeper. Enemies: the Wakers, the Watch. Allies: the Bedded, rouse dealers, a surprising number of Watchers who have taken their minute.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Doorman	Keeps the queue; a cut of the waiting fee.
2	Counter	Counts the sixty over sleepers; knows the method.
3	Hauler	Works the hook; may sell a minute without asking.
4	Cellar-Keep	Runs a cellar of one's own and its Waker bribes.
5	King of the Tuckers	Old Nod's chair, and his register of failures.

THE DREAM-DIVERS

State explorers who go to sleep on purpose, under a tether, and are dragged back by force. They believe the room can be understood and the eye negotiated with, and they want to map it to the wall.

Most manage three dives before they fail to come back. Each dive leaves a diver less tethered to the waking world: they forget names, lose the taste of food, and start to speak of the room as home. A PC joins by volunteering, which the Hall accepts from anyone, because few volunteer twice. Enemies: the Bedded, who call them grave-robbers. Allies: the Watch, the Hourkeeper, the Dormitory.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Haulier	A place on the winch rope; a share of the diver's wage.
2	Novice of One Dive	Harness, tongue-ring and state pension to your family if you stay.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
3	Diver of Three	A name on the Hall wall; first sight of the room-maps.
4	Deep Diver	Leads a dive-team; may dive without the Watch's leave.
5	Master of the Tether	The Hall itself, and the right to say who goes under.

THE BEDDED

Heretics who preach that sleep is a homecoming, that the eye is kind, and that the city is three hundred years late. They meet in Slope cellars and in the shadow of the Dormitory, in rooms with no lamps, and they hum. Their faith is the oldest consolation in the

Vigil: that the people lost to the room are not lost, but at rest, and waiting. They want the Waking Laws repealed and the city allowed to go home. The most devout of them help others to lie down, and call it ministry; the law calls it murder. A PC joins by attending a dark-meeting and not reporting it. Enemies: the Wakers, the Watch, the Lessening. Allies: the Tuckers, the Lain-Down's grieving families, the Second Table's quieter members.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Listener	Admission to dark-meetings; the name of a safe cellar.
2	Hummer	Knows the whole of <i>The Lamb and the Lid</i> .
3	Shepherd	Keeps a flock; may sit with those who wish to lie down.
4	Pillow	Has slept in a blink and come back speaking well of it; preaches.
5	Sister of the Lid	Vesper Null's circle; may speak for the room.

THE LESSENING

The faction that wants the number reduced. They are Eye-line Watchers, Dormitory clerks, a handful of Wakers and two Matron's deputies, and their reasoning is arithmetic. The Counted cannot be woken; the number cannot be reached; therefore some of the Counted must be removed from the count, by pillow, by needle, by a drop of Bitterhouse salts in the drip, quietly, in the oldest rows first, where there are no visitors. They speak only of *relief*. They

have drawn up lists, ordered by bed number, and a schedule that would reduce the Counted by eleven thousand in two years. They have not begun the schedule. They have begun the trials, and the trials have shown them something they cannot explain (see Matron Cecily Dorm), which they have decided to ignore. A PC is approached, never applies. Enemies: the Bedded, the families of the Counted, Inspector Grimmer, unknowingly. Allies: the Second Table, the Removalists, the parts of the Watch that do not wish to know.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Reckoner of Beds	Copies the registers; knows which rows are unvisited.
2	Orderly of Relief	Works the night rows; carries the salts.
3	Sitting Member	A vote on the lists.
4	Keeper of the Schedule	Decides which bed is next.
5	First of the Lessening	Sabine Larch, and the arithmetic.

CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN THE VIGIL

The **Rim Road Company** runs the Last Beds and the oil convoys, and holds the Watch's debts. The **Cutwrights' College** keeps a house on the Height whose ledgers show which Eye-line families have produced no Counted in three centuries, and which Slope families have produced the most. The **Purgation** has a cell in the Bitterhouse that believes Iss can be vomited back up by a rouse strong enough to keep the whole city awake for a year. The **Second Table** has three Watchers and a Lamplighter-General's deputy, and a very simple plan for the morning the eye opens: knives, felt-wrapped, and a lullaby. The **Reckoners** have never sent a raid to the Vigil. The Vigil's nobles do not sleep, and that makes them hard to kill in their beds.

▼ THE VIGIL NOW

Everything is running out at once. Rouse is failing: the dose that held a generation ago now barely holds an hour, and the Apothecary-General knows the year when the dose that keeps a person awake will be the dose that stops their heart. The Dormitory has fewer than two thousand empty beds. The Lamplighter-General has ninety days of oil. The hours themselves seem to be lengthening; the Hourkeeper's pendulum swings a hair slower every week, and the city's watches feel longer than they did, and nobody can prove that they are not imagining it, because everybody is always imagining something.

The Warden-Prime has sent an envoy to Sallowreach with a proposal too terrible to put in writing: the dead do not sleep. The Lessening has drawn up its lists. The Seeming has shown eleven districts a tall figure laying a table in the street. Rouse cut with Brinehollow brine is sending the Slope's addicts walking west in their sleepless trances, toward a sea four hundred miles away. Forty-one people have killed someone they loved in a sleep of two breaths, and the inspector on the case has started to notice what the victims had in common. And in Bed One, the first sleeper, who has not stirred in three hundred years, has begun to move her lips.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ **The Fourth Pillow.** The Matron hires the party, off the record, to sit the night rows of the Dormitory's east wing, where three Counted have been found smothered in a month. The Matron suspects the Lessening. The Lessening suspects the Matron. The party, sitting in the breathing dark for a whole watch with the air

rising and falling around them, must stay awake to catch a killer, and each time a sleeper dies, someone in the city blinks and does not come back.

- ◇ **The Brine Walkers.** Rook Quarter-Bell's customers are walking west in a shuffling column, eyes open, down the Pilgrim Road past the Sleepers' Mile. A Waker sergeant with a brother among them hires the party to bring them back before they reach the Rim, where the Company's porters have orders to stop them by any means. Somewhere on the road, the column stops, turns as one, and points.
- ◇ **The Deadwatch.** The Watch sends the party north as escort to Envoy Castellan Dray, with a chest of platters, a dozen nudgers and orders to ensure the Regent of Sallowreach says yes. On the road the nudgers begin to blink. In Lastgate, Dray asks the party privately whether they would volunteer to be the first.
- ◇ **Forty-One.** Inspector Grimmer needs outsiders. Every blink-murder victim, he has found, was a secret member of the Lessening. Somebody, or something, is defending the Counted. Grimmer wants to know what, and he wants the party to blink deliberately, under guard, to find out what it is like to be used.
- ◇ **What Aveline Says.** The Matron's notebook of Bed One's lip-words has been stolen. The thief is selling pages in the Pinchmarket. The pages contain names, and the people named on them are going to the room, one a day, in order.

RUMOURS IN THE PINCHMARKET

D10	RUMOUR
1	The number is sixty thousand and one. The Matron counts to it every morning, and every morning stops at sixty thousand. (Possibly true.)
2	Old Nod takes his own minute every Plate, in a cellar no one has found. (False. He has never slept.)
3	If you blink in the Pillow, you can see the eye from the other side. (Unknown. Nobody who tried has been asked.)

D10	RUMOUR
4	The Warden-Prime's daughter has eyelids and sleeps a minute at a time behind locked doors. (True, in part.)
5	The lamps on the Row are burning people. Smell them. (True. The Guild calls it economy.)
6	The Sleepers' Mile has been counted all along, and the Watch knows it. (Unknown. Very possibly true.)
7	Sister Vesper sleeps every night and wakes every morning. (True. What wakes is the question.)
8	Dr. Crane has a rouse that will keep you awake for ever. (False. He has one that will keep you awake until it kills you.)
9	The tall man laying tables is the eye, come to call. (False, as far as anyone in the Vigil knows.)
10	If you hum the first three notes of the Lamb song, every Counted in the Dormitory smiles. (True. The orderlies have tested it, once.)

THE PEOPLE OF THE VIGIL

WARDEN-PRIME ILVANE STROUD, THE UNBLINKING

Ruler of the Vigil, fifty-eight years old, born lidless, and she has not shut her eyes once since birth. Her eyes are enormous, pale grey, red-rimmed and webbed with veins, and they never stop moving. Two attendants stand at her shoulders with sable brushes and warm rosewater, and every half minute one of them strokes the wet across

her eyes, and she does not flinch; she has never been able to. She has seen everything that has happened in front of her since the hour she was born, and she can forget none of it. She remembers her mother's face over the cradle, every execution she has signed, every lie told to her on the Stair, and the exact weight of each. She speaks softly and precisely, and she never asks a question twice. She wants the Vigil to survive her, by any means at all, including the dead. She fears her daughter. PCs meet her on the Lid's Eye landing, where she will remember them, perfectly, forever.

ILVANE STROUD – WARDEN-PRIME OF THE VIGIL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Search 5, Reckoning 4, Resolve 4, Clause 3, Intimidate 3, Godsign 3, Endure 2, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	silver hatpin +3 (1)
GIFTS	Perfect Recall (she remembers every word ever said in her sight; any lie told to her face she will catch on a Routine Eye + Search roll, eventually). Lidless (cannot be surprised by anything in her line of sight; cannot look away from a Dread). The Weight of Regard (Partake: a person she stares at must make a Caul + Resolve roll, Hard, or confess the thing they most want hidden from her).
WANTS	To watch (she cannot leave a person unwatched who might betray her); to count (she counts the Watchers on the Stair every quarter hour, and has never stopped).
DREAD	2 (to hold her gaze for a full minute while she does not blink)
SECRET	She knows the number. The Matron does not know she knows. Stroud read it in the dying face of the previous Matron, years ago, on her lips, and has never told anyone. She has also done the sum for the Deadwatch: if the Vigil is moved to Sallowreach and killed and Kept, the city's sixty thousand Counted will be left behind, unwatched, on the Lid. She has decided that is acceptable.

LADY ORIEL STROUD

The Warden's daughter, twenty-three, born with eyelids, which in the highest Eye-line is a deformity and an embarrassment of state. She has been kept hidden in a suite of bright rooms at the top of the Stair since birth, attended by deaf nudgers. She is small, soft-voiced, dark-haired, with ordinary hazel eyes that she keeps fixed open in company until they stream, because her mother cannot bear to see her blink. Alone in her rooms, she closes her eyes for whole seconds at a time, and nothing has ever felt so good. She wants to be allowed to be ordinary, and she wants her mother to look at her once

without that face. She fears she will be married off to a lidless cousin and never close her eyes again. Her secret: when she closes them, she does not see darkness. She sees the long room, from the far end, through a great grey lid, and every sleeper in it turning their head to look at her.

MAUD SEXTON, THE HOURKEEPER

Mistress of the city's clocks, sixty, stooped, with a jeweller's loupe screwed into one eye socket and a pocket full of brass escapements that she fidgets with like rosary beads. She sets the time for every bell in the Vigil from the great pendulum in the Pendulum Hall. Over

eleven years of measurements she has proved, by pendulum, sand, candle and the pulse of her own wrist, that each hour is a little longer than the last. Not by much: a breath per watch, now two. Something is stretching the night the Vigil will not admit it is having. Her report was suppressed. She has written it again, smaller, in the margins of the bell-schedules. She wants someone with authority to stand in the Pendulum Hall for an hour and feel it. Her secret: she has run the curve forward. On a night not long from now, the hour will stop ending.

CAPTAIN BRANNOCH PYRE OF THE WAKERS

Captain of the city’s police, fifty-two, a big slope-shouldered man with a shaved head, needle-scarred forearms and a voice worn to gravel from three decades of shouting people awake. He has kept a hundred thousand citizens out of the Dormitory with rattle and needle, and he has not been thanked once. He believes absolutely in what he does. He also knows, better than any man alive, what it does to the people he does it to. His own nudger, his wife Merrit, died last year, and he has not replaced her. He walks his rounds unwatched, which is illegal, and none of his Wakers will report him.

BRANNOCH PYRE – CAPTAIN OF THE WAKERS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Intimidate 4, Stitching 4, Blades 3, Brawl 3, Search 3, Endure 3, Resolve 3, Athletics 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (padded Waker’s coat) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	long needle +7 (2, and the target loses 2 Weariness and suffers –2 to its next roll from pain); rattle-club +7 (3)
GIFTS	The Quick (with a needle he can wake any blinker instantly, and can hurt a person precisely as much as he intends: a Helping on a needle attack may impose a Dread 1 check instead of damage).
WANTS	To count (he tallies every face on his rounds and cannot pass a sleeping cat without needling it).
DREAD	1 (to watch him work)
SECRET	Merrit did not die. She lay down, in their kitchen, with a note, while he was on shift. He found her warm. He needled her for an hour, every point in the Atlas, and kept going long after he knew. He has told everyone she died of a rouse-heart. She is in bed 59,804. He has also blinked three times this month and come back with blood under his nails that is not his.

OLD NOD, KING OF THE TUCKERS

He sells one minute of guarded sleep for a month’s wage, and people queue around the block. He is seventy, small, quick and courteous, with a soft white beard, half-moon spectacles and the black stumps of a lifetime of rouse, and he receives customers in a warm cellar off the Slope under a sign that says only *Rest*. He has never tried his own product. He says a man should not get high on his own supply. He keeps a register, in his own hand, of every customer the hook failed to bring back: one in eleven, these days, up from one in thirty. He wants a better hook. He fears the Bedded, who say his failures are the lucky ones. His secret: he was a Dream-Diver once, three dives, and he knows what sixty seconds in the room feels like from the inside. It feels like a lifetime. That is what he is really selling.

TUCKER HAULER Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (hook-and-harness 3, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

SENNA VOLE, DREAM-DIVER

Forty descents, where three is the usual career. She is thirty-four and looks fifty: grey-haired, gaunt, her wrists and throat ridged with harness-scars, a silver ring through her tongue where the Hall’s hook goes. She speaks slowly and seldom, as if words came from a long way off. She has mapped the long room to within thirty paces of the eye: the soft floor, the warm air, the sleepers standing in their silent ranks, and the place near the wall where the floor begins to slope downward, toward the lid. On her last dive, something behind the lid said her name. She wants to go back. She tells the Hall she wants to finish the map.

SENNA VOLE – DEEP DIVER OF THE TETHER HALL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Resolve 5, Godsign 4, Lore 4, Endure 3, Search 3, Athletics 2, Blades 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 8
ATTACKS	tether-knife +4 (2)
GIFTS	The Long Room (she may blink at will, under guard, and return with an answer to one question about any Counted sleeper or any blinker in the city). Lidless (cannot be surprised in her line of sight). Room-Calm (immune to Dread from anything she has seen in the room).
WANTS	To lie down (she must resist on a Grim roll whenever she passes the Tether Hall's bed).
DREAD	3 (to hear her say what she heard)
SECRET	The voice behind the lid did not sound like a god. It sounded like her own voice, asleep. She believes that the eye is not Iss's at all but all of theirs: everyone who ever went to the room, dreaming one enormous dream with one eye, and that when it opens, it will be the Counted waking up together, as one thing. She has not told the Hall, because she thinks they would stop her diving.

DR. ALDOUS CRANE, APOTHECARY-GENERAL

Inventor of the current strain of rouse, sixty-one, thin as a heron, with the steady hands of a man who has never in his life taken his own product and the yellow fingertips of a man who handles it all day. He speaks to people as though reading them a dosage. He knows the dose curve and where it ends: there is a point at which the amount of rouse needed to stay awake is the amount that stops the heart, and it is eleven years off, for an average adult; three or four for the Slope, where the cut is worse; less than one for children. He wants a new compound, and has tested nine hundred in the Proving Rooms on prisoners lent by the Rattlehouse. His secret: the Watch has ordered one more compound, the nine hundred and first,

finished and warehoused, for the day the beds are full. It is a rouse that does not wake you. It stops you, gently, standing up, and you do not go to the room. He calls it the Last Cake.

MATRON CECILY DORM

Keeper of the Dormitory, fifty, broad and soft-spoken, in a starched grey gown and felt slippers, with a heavy ring of bed-keys at her belt that she holds still with one hand as she walks so it will not jingle. She is the only living person who knows the number, and she walks the rows every day, counting, under her breath, from one. She has been seen removing a pillow and standing over a bed for a long time. She loves the Counted. She knows their faces as a mother knows her children's. She hates them, sometimes, with a hatred she confesses to no one.

CECILY DORM – MATRON OF THE DORMITORY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Reckoning 5, Resolve 4, Stitching 3, Search 3, Deceive 3, Rites 2, Brawl 1, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	ring of bed-keys +4 (1)
GIFTS	The Rows Know Her (inside the Dormitory, restless sleepers turn their faces toward her, and she always knows when one has moved). Breath-Matched (she may breathe with the Counted, which hides her from notice inside the Dormitory as long as she is silent).
WANTS	To count (she must finish any count she begins, aloud if necessary, even mid-crisis).
DREAD	2 (to watch her standing over a bed with a pillow)
SECRET	She has smothered four of the Counted, in the oldest rows, testing the Lessening's arithmetic. Each time, within the bell, someone somewhere in the city blinked and did not come back, and was carried in, and the number was exactly what it had been. The count keeps itself. The Lessening's schedule would not reduce the number by a single bed; it would only change who is in them. She has told the Lessening. They have decided not to believe her. She has started to wonder whether she was the one who decided who went down.

GARRON ASHLOCK, LAMPLIGHTER-GENERAL

He keeps ten thousand lamps burning. He is forty-eight, red-faced, burn-scarred to the elbow, with no eyebrows and a cheerful bellow that he has cultivated to hide the fact that he cannot sleep, of course, and cannot rest either, ever, because he can count. He has ninety days of oil, a Brinehollow supplier who has doubled the price and a Fatlands one who has stopped answering, and a standing order from the Watch to tell no one. He wants a miracle and will settle for tallow. His secret: he has already found it. The furnaces on the Row do not burn the dead to ash any more. They render them. A quarter of the city's lamps now burn on the people who used to read by them, and the Guild has begun to look, with a professional eye, at the Dormitory.

PIP ELEVEN-BELL

A street nudger of nine, born at the eleventh bell on the Slope, paid by the hour to pinch strangers in the Pinchmarket. Pip is fast, sharp, thin as a pin, all elbows and grubby knuckles, with a voice like a gull and a laugh like a rattle, and the best pinch-fingers in the market. Pip has been unpaid for two weeks by a client who has gone to the room and has been taking rouse from the cheapest dealers to keep working. Children do not last on rouse, and Pip has begun to blink. Pip wants a proper client, a hot meal and a nudger of their own. Pip fears nothing out loud. Pip's secret: in the blinks, there is a kind lady

in the room, in a baker's apron, who holds out her hand and says it is all right to stay. Pip has started to hold on longer each time.

LUKAS MARRE, THE YAWNING MAN

His yawns are catching beyond all reason: one gape of his jaw and a room goes down, a street sways, and once, at nineteen, before he knew, a whole market square. He is thirty-one now and has lived twelve years in a cell in the Glass House, masked in a leather muzzle that holds his jaw half shut, alone, in the coldest corner of the city. He is gentle, bookish and painfully polite, and he apologises through the pane to everyone who visits, and to the guards, and to the Matron, whom he writes to every Plate asking after the people from the square. He wants to be forgiven. His secret: the muzzle does not stop it any more. Lately he only has to feel the yawn rising in himself, and the people on the far side of the glass sway.

SISTER VESPER NULL, PROPHET OF THE BEDDED

She preaches that the eye is kind, the room is home, and the Counted are the only citizens of the Vigil at peace. She is about forty, with smooth unlined skin, clear bright eyes and a calm low voice, and she looks more rested than anyone in the city, and nobody can explain it. Her sermons in the Slope cellars are given in the dark, in a murmur, and her listeners sway. She is not cruel. She holds the hands of the grieving and tells them their dead are waiting, and they weep with relief.

VESPER NULL – SISTER OF THE LID, PROPHET OF THE BEDDED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 11 (the Brink) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Godsign 5, Rites 4, Resolve 3, Instinct 3, Stealth 2
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 0
ATTACKS	none worth the name (+2, 1)
GIFTS	The Lull (anyone who listens to her speak for a scene must make a Caul + Resolve roll, Grim, or gain 3 Weariness and make a blink check). Lay Them Down (Partake: one person who can hear her and has 7+ Weariness falls asleep). Rested (she has no Weariness and is immune to the Seeming).
WANTS	To tuck in (she cannot leave a weeping person without stroking their hair and telling them to rest).
DREAD	3 (to see her wake)
SECRET	She sleeps every night, in a whitewashed cellar under the Slope, and every morning she wakes. Nobody else ever has. The real Vesper Null went to the room nine years ago. What gets up in her body every morning is something the room sends back, a little less like Vesper each time: an emissary, practising. She is the first restless sleeper outside the Dormitory. Her body is the god's rehearsal for walking.

CORWIN HALF-BELL, THE MAN WHO WOKE

The only sleeper who ever came back without a tether, after half an hour under, twelve years ago, when a cart-horse kicked him in the ribs where he lay in the street. He is forty, gaunt and grey, and he has not blinked since: his lids have gone stiff and fixed half open from disuse. He flinches whenever a door opens. He will not describe the room. He works as a rope-walker at the Rattlehouse, where the noise comforts him. He wants never to be asked again. His secret, which he will tell only to someone who has been in the room themselves: he heard knocking. Far behind him, at the other end of the long room, at a door none of the sleepers face, someone was knocking, slow and patient and polite, the way a guest knocks. And the eye, he swears, was not sleeping. It was holding still, the way a mouse holds still. It was hiding.

THADDEUS KNELL, CHIEF BELL-RINGER

The city’s bells sound every quarter hour to keep it awake, and they deafened him years ago. He is sixty-four, bull-necked, with forearms like hawsers and ears that ooze, and he rings from the great tower over Ludmere Square by the clock and by the shaking in his teeth. He speaks too loud and reads lips badly. He is the most rested-looking man on the Height, because he hears no lullaby, no rain, no hush; the silence inside him is total and it does not soothe him at all. He wants an apprentice who will not go deaf. His secret: lately the

bells do not shake his teeth on the quarter. They shake them a little after, a little later each day, and he has begun ringing by his teeth instead of the Hourkeeper’s clock.

MIRELA SCONCE, THE SEEMER

She reads the Seeming for the public record. Forty, sharp-chinned, ink-stained, with a habit of narrating what she sees under her breath, she spends her watches walking the districts with a slate, taking statements, cross-matching witnesses. This month eleven districts, separately, hallucinated the same thing: a tall figure laying a table in the street. She has interviewed two hundred witnesses. Their descriptions match down to the stoop under the doorways and the warmth on the cobbles afterward. She wants to know what it is. She fears the Registrar, who has started striking her entries. Her secret: she saw it too, on Thimble Lane, and it looked up at her, and there was a card on the nearest plate, and her name was on it.

JACK TENTERHOOK, WAKE-VALET

Keeper-awake to the rich, an artist of the precisely tolerable pain. He is forty-five, elegant, soft-handed, with a velvet roll of silver pins and a voice like warm oil. He arrives at a client’s house at the first bell and leaves at the last, and between them he keeps his client awake with an exquisite programme of pinches, pricks, ice and pressure, never too much, never too little. His clients swear by him and recommend him to their friends. He was a torturer before, for the Rattlehouse’s lower floors, and says the only difference is the tipping.

JACK TENTERHOOK – WAKE-VALET TO THE HEIGHT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Stitching 5, Blades 3, Persuade 3, Intimidate 3, Deceive 3, Search 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	silver pins +7 (2, plus the target’s next roll at –2); scalpel +7 (2)
GIFTS	The Exquisite (when he needles a person, they lose 1d6 Weariness and owe him a favour they will feel). The Ledger of Nerves (he can make a captive talk without leaving a mark; Clause-proof).
WANTS	To watch (he cannot resist observing a person in pain to the end).
DREAD	2 (to watch him practise)
SECRET	He keeps clients awake. He also keeps them sleepy. He has six on the Height whom he has been very carefully not quite waking for a year, just enough to keep them blinking, on commission from the Lessening, who needed members of the Watch to be suggestible. Two of those six have blink-murdered.

INSPECTOR HALE GRIMMER

He investigates blink-murders, killings done by ordinary people during a two-second sleep, with no memory after. He has forty-one cases. The method is the same in each: the victim laid flat on the floor, a folded cloth beneath the head, hands crossed on the chest,

eyes closed under the killer’s thumbs, and the killer’s palms laid gently over mouth and nose until the breathing stops. Every killer comes back with no memory and the victim’s teeth in their palm. Grimmer is fifty, ragged, chain-chewing rouse, with a mind that goes on working long after his body has stopped wanting to. He wants to know who is doing it. He fears that he will be next, in one

direction or the other. His secret is what he found last week: all forty-one victims were members of the Lessening, down to Tobin Coyle, the Slope rope-twister, who copied Dormitory registers for them at night for beer money. Something is defending the Counted.

ODILE FARTHING

Her son, Marten, fell asleep at four, eleven years ago, in her arms, on a grey afternoon, while she was counting out loud to him. She visits bed 40,112 daily, and stands at its foot for an hour, and talks. She is thirty-eight, rouse-thin and quiet, with the scabbed wrists of a woman who has had no nudger but herself. The Counted do not age, but her boy has grown. He is the size of a man now, long and broad under the sheet, with a man's hands and a man's jaw and a beard coming in, and he is smiling. She wants him back. She fears what will come back. Her secret: when she leans close, he smells of bread, and his lips move along with hers when she counts.

BENEDIKT LOUR, THE ARCHITECT

He designed the modern city: the sloped floors, the one-legged chairs, the studded walls, the endless Stair. He is seventy, frail, bent, with the elegant scrawl of a man whose hands shake for everything but a pen, and he is proud of every discomfort he has ever invented. He is now drawing a Second Dormitory. He has been told to plan for the whole population. He has drafted it on the Pillow, the only open ground left, and the drawings show four hundred thousand beds, in rows, radiating outward from the hollow like the rays of an eye. He wants to finish before he dies. He fears that the Watch will not wait. His secret: the Second Dormitory has no doors that lock from the inside, and its ventilation is designed to carry warm air.

ROOK QUARTER-BELL

A rouse dealer on the Slope, twenty-two, lean, quick, wolfish, his teeth already gone, gums packed black with his own product. He cuts what he sells with bottled Brinehollow brine, bought by the cask from Dry Jonah's agents, because it is cheap and it works. His customers stay awake longer than anyone else's. They have also started bailing salt water every dawn and dusk, and walking west. There are two hundred of them now, in a slow eyes-open column. Rook wants to stop selling it and cannot, because nothing else

holds. His secret: he has been taking it himself. He tastes salt every morning, and he has started standing at windows facing west.

ENVOY CASTELLAN DRAY

The Warden's ambassador to Sallowreach, fifty-five, a tall immaculate Eye-line courtier with a lidless stare and a chest of documents he never lets out of sight, travelling with twelve paid nudgers and a cask of Bitterhouse rouse. His commission is to buy the secret of Keeping, so that the Vigil's citizens can be killed and kept upright: a city of the dead, who never need to sleep. He has been in Lastgate for two months, negotiating with the Regent. He wants to save his city. He fears that the price will be paid in its people. His secret: he has learned that the Kept cannot leave Sallowreach, and that the Vigil would have to move there, all of it, to die; and he has not yet told the Warden, because he thinks she will say yes.

AVELINE MORNE, THE SLEEPER IN BED ONE

A baker's daughter, nineteen years old forever, who lay down on the First Night in 341 and was the first not to rise. She has lain unmoving for three hundred years under a white sheet in a bed with a brass rail, a plump fair girl with flour still in the creases of her knuckles, cheeks pink, lips slightly parted, breathing with the rows. Last month her lips began to shape words. The Matron has started writing them down. Most of them are names, one a day, and each person named has gone to the room the next day. One, last week, was a sentence: *There is someone at the door who has not been fed. Set another place.*

NEW CHARACTERS

DEPUTY-WATCHER SABINE LARCH, FIRST OF THE LESSENING

An Eye-line Watcher of the second shift, forty-four, lidless, soft-voiced, with a mathematician's courtesy and the kind of face people forget while it is in front of them. She sits on the Matron's oversight committee and has read every register in the Dormitory. Her lists are in her own hand.

SABINE LARCH – DEPUTY-WATCHER, FIRST OF THE LESSENING	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Eye-line) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Reckoning 5, Clause 4, Deceive 4, Persuade 3, Resolve 3, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	stiletto +3 (2)
GIFTS	Perfect Recall (as Stroud). The Calm Sum (when she explains her arithmetic, listeners must succeed at a Caul + Resolve roll, Hard, or accept it as reasonable for the rest of the scene).
WANTS	To count (she reduces every crowd to a number and cannot stop).
DREAD	2 (to read her lists)
SECRET	Her sister is in bed 3,315. Bed 3,315 is the first name on the list.

REGISTRAR CONSTANCE HOBBS

Keeper of the Public Record of the Seeming, sixty, white-gloved, iron-haired. She decides which Seemings are entered and which are struck. A Seeming not entered, she says, did not occur. She has struck forty Seemings of the tall figure this year, and every report of blink-murders, and she has entered, on Watch instruction, three Seemings that nobody saw: a fire that justified condemning a Bedded cellar, a riot that justified the doubled needle-patrols, and the death of Corwin Half-Bell, who is still alive. When citizens come to her to insist on what they saw, she shows them the record, kindly, until they doubt it. She sleeps, she believes, not at all. Her secret: her own clerk tells her she has blinked eleven times today, and she has entered none of them.

SISTER AGATHE PINCH, MISTRESS OF THE NEEDLE

Head instructor at the Rattlehouse and author of the current edition of the Atlas of the Quick, sixty-eight, tiny, bright-eyed and grandmotherly, with a cap of white lace and a lap-tray of needles laid out like embroidery tools. She has trained every Waker alive. She believes that pain is a teacher and that the city's Wakers must learn it first on their own bodies, and every recruit spends their first week strapped in a standing-stall under her needles, so they will know. She is loved by her students the way a scar is loved. Her secret: on the Rattlehouse's lowest floor she keeps a man who has been awake under the needle for nineteen years. She uses him to teach. He has stopped screaming. He hums.

TEODOR RELL, KEEPER OF THE LAIN BOOK

A laundress's widower, forty, from Gallow Street on the Slope, who found his wife's note pinned to her good coat and has not been able to stop reading it. He took a clerk's post at the Dormitory so that he could see her every day, and the Matron gave him the Lain Book: the register of those who went to the room by choice, with their notes copied out, two hundred to four hundred a year. He reads every note. He answers some of them aloud, at the foot of the bed. He is gentle, tired beyond tiredness, and very dangerous to himself. He

has kept his promise not to lie down after her. His secret: he has begun writing a note of his own, a line a day, so that it will be ready.

LORD EVANDER QUELL OF THE SECOND TABLE

An Eye-line Watcher of the first shift, fifty, handsome, lidless, beautifully mannered, and the Second Table's senior hand in the Vigil. He believes the eye's opening is the best news in six centuries: the god of sleep, whole again, in one place, awake and blinking and catchable. He has a set of felt-wrapped knives in a case on his wall, a choir of twelve trained in *The Lamb and the Lid*, and the Matron's spare keys. He wants the number reached. Not exceeded, not prevented: reached, cleanly, on a date he can plan for. His secret: he has been feeding Sabine Larch's lists to Jack Tenterhook's clients, and he knows exactly what the blink-murders are, and he finds them encouraging.

FACTOR JOSS MALLORY OF THE LAST BEDS

The Rim Road Company's innkeeper at the foot of the Pilgrim Road, fifty, big-bellied, foreign, comfortable, with the only soft voice and the only soft bed within thirty miles of the Vigil. Every Company caravan stops at his inn so its drivers can sleep before the climb, and every Vigilant coming down on business stops at his sleeping-hall doorway and looks at the beds. He keeps a book of the ones his porters could not stop. He sells passes across the border, maps of the Sleepers' Mile, rouse, nudgers and gossip. He is the first friendly face most PCs see before the Lid, and the last one some see before the room. His secret: the Watch pays him a bounty for every Vigilant his porters drag back from the beds. The Lessening pays him a larger one for every Vigilant they don't.

WAKER PATROL Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (long needle 2, target loses 2 Weariness; rattle-club 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

SLOPE BLINKER (AN INNOCENT MID-BLINK) Threat 1 · Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (bare hands 1, Smother: a grappled target lying down loses 2 Flesh a round) · Armor 0 · Dread 2

RESTLESS SLEEPER Threat 4 · Flesh 20 · Guard 9 · Attack +6 (embrace 2, the held must make a blink check each round) · Armor 0 ·

▼ PLAYING A VIGILANT

You will never rest. Not once, not for a breath, not until you are on the Row. Now go and do something with it.

– WHAT SLOPE MOTHERS SAY TO A CHILD ON THE MORNING OF THE COMING-HEAVY

A Vigilant has been awake since the age of four. Every hour of every day of their life is still behind their eyes. They are sharp-sighted, suspicious, quick to see a lie and quicker to see a yawn, and they are carrying a weight that no one from any other land can imagine. They have a nudger, or they had one. They know someone in the Dormitory. They do not trust their own memory, and they are right not to.

Attribute bonus: +1 EYE.

WEARINESS

Every character in the Vigil, native or foreign, tracks **Weariness** from 0 to 10. A foreigner who has slept well arrives at 0. A Vigilant has never slept and can never fall below **2**: that is the floor, the silt of a lifetime.

Gaining Weariness. +1 for each watch (eight hours) spent without a dose of rouse. +1 for each scene of comfort: warmth, softness, a full meal, rain on a roof, quiet, a long dull wait, a lullaby, a sermon. Yawn days double all gains. A contagious yawn in earshot calls for a Caul + Resolve roll (Routine, or Hard from a Glass House yawner); failure adds +1. A Tooth that bites back (see below) adds +1.

Shedding Weariness. A dose of rouse removes 2 Weariness and prevents gains from the watch's passing for that watch; a day's rouse costs 2 lacks on the Height and half that, cut, on the Slope. A second dose in the same watch requires a Gut + Endure roll (Hard; Grim for a third); failure costs 2 Flesh, and a Lack is a rouse-heart: the character suffers Ruin. A pin, slap or pinch from a nudger removes 1 Weariness, once a scene. A Waker's long needle removes 2 and costs 1 Flesh. Foreigners sleeping outside the Vigil's borders clear Weariness to 0. Vigilants have nowhere to sleep.

WEARINESS	STATE	EFFECT
0–2	Fresh	As fresh as anyone on the Lid.
3–4	Heavy	–1 on all Eye and Lung rolls.
5–6	Drifting	–2 on Eye and Lung rolls. The Seeming begins. Blink checks on triggers.
7–8	Grey	–2 on all rolls. Blink check every scene, and on triggers. Dread checks one step harder.
9	Going Under	Blink check every few minutes of play.
10	Asleep	The character falls asleep (see below).

Falling asleep. At Weariness 10 the character sleeps, and goes to the room. A nudger has one breath to fetch them: a Hand + Stitching or Tongue + Intimidate roll at Hard (a Waker's needle succeeds automatically if it is already drawn). If that fails, the nudger may try once more, at Grim, in the next breath. After that the character is Counted. There is no further roll. Foreigners and Vigilants alike are carried to the Dormitory and given a number.

BLINKS

A **blink check** is Caul + Resolve against a Difficulty set by Weariness: Routine at 5–6, Hard at 7–8, Grim at 9. Characters in

the Appetite or beyond (Regrowth 4+) make blink checks on triggers even below Weariness 5, at Routine. Triggers are anything that would make a tired person drift: warmth, softness, silence, monotony, a yawn, lying down, a voice that murmurs, watching the Dormitory breathe.

On a failure the character blinks, and the GM rolls on the table below. Each blink also adds 1 Fray, for the lost time, whether or not the character learns what happened. On a Lack, the GM rolls twice and uses both results, and if the character sees what they did, they make a Dread check at the rating the GM judges right (usually 2 or 3).

D10	THE BLINK
1–4	A second gone. You lose the last thing said, and drop what you were holding.
5–6	Moved. You are up to ten paces from where you stood, facing another way.
7	You said something. The GM speaks one line in your voice, often a true thing you wanted kept.
8	Your hands did something small: a lamp put out, a door unbarred, a word written.
9	The room held you longer: d6 minutes, standing. You remember the warmth and nothing else.
10	Tucked. The most vulnerable person near you is lying down, eyes closed, and your hands are on them. Roll d6: on 1–4 you came back in time.

GM ADVICE – DID I BLINK?

Blinks are a tool for gaslighting the players, gently and fairly. Once a character is Drifting or worse, the GM may tell a player that something has changed, a door now open, a companion now across the room, a cup now empty, and decline to say whether it is a blink or a Seeming or the truth. A character may make an Eye + Reckoning roll (Routine at Drifting, Hard at Grey) to trust a memory; on a failure, they cannot be sure, and NPCs who say otherwise are as likely to be right. Never use this to cheat players out of earned success. Use it to make them look at one another and ask, quietly, *did you see me move?*

THE SEEMING

At Weariness 5 and above, the GM gives characters private hallucinations: voices in the lamps, insects in the plaster, the dead in the lane. Shared Seemings, which a whole street sees, are real enough for law in the Vigil whether or not they are real at all. An Eye + Search roll at Hard tells a character whether a Seeming leaves traces (warm cobbles, a crumb, a place card). A character who Breaks in the Vigil most often takes a Derangement of the Seeming: that a loved one has been replaced by a sleeper's dream of them; that they themselves are asleep in a bed and dreaming all of this; that the room is real and the city is the dream.

THE SOP: THE LULL

Iss is quieted by rest, and in the Vigil rest is a crime. The **Lull** is the act of closing your eyes on purpose for a count of ten while a nudger holds your hand. It removes 1d6 Hunger. It feeds the Want to lie down. The character must immediately make a blink check at Hard, whatever their Weariness; on a failure they are in the room for the count, and their nudger must fetch them back as if they had fallen asleep. Every Vigilant knows someone who took the Lull once too often.

THE TOOTH

When a Vigilant Partakes, their pupils blow wide and black, the world slows and softens at its edges, sounds come as if through a wall, and for a heartbeat they see the scene as if from very high up and very far away, every detail at once. Everyone nearby yawns. The

air smells of clean linen. When a Tooth shows a 1 and the god bites back, the character takes the extra Hunger and +1 Weariness as well, and their next blink check is one step harder.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). Choose one. *The Catching Yawn:* Partake and yawn deliberately; everyone in earshot with Weariness 3+ makes a Caul + Resolve roll at Hard or gains 2 Weariness and loses their next action to drowsiness. You gain 1 Weariness yourself. *Heavy-Eyed:* you always know when someone in sight is about to blink, gaining +2 to Instinct and Search against blinkers, and you know when someone lies about having blinked.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Choose one. *Lost Seconds:* Partake and blink on purpose; for 1d6 seconds you are gone, and you reappear up to ten paces away anywhere you could have walked. Nobody present remembers seeing you move. Roll on the Blink table afterwards, rerolling results of 1–6. *The Long Look:* blink under a nudger's guard and ask the GM one question about a Counted sleeper or anyone currently blinking in the city; gain 2 Weariness and 1 Fray.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). *Lidless.* Your lids shrink and are gone. You gain +2 to Search and can never be surprised by anything in your line of sight. You remember everything you have seen. Dread checks against anything before your eyes are one step harder, because you cannot look away. Your eyes must be wetted every half minute; without it you lose 1 Flesh an hour and are blind within a day. And the great privilege of the Eye-lines is yours: a lidless character who reaches Weariness 10 does not sleep. Instead they Break, at once, and their Weariness drops to 7. This is not mercy. It is how the Eye-lines rule.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). *Lay Them Down.* Partake and speak softly to one person with Weariness 5+ who can hear you; they make a Caul + Resolve roll at Grim or fall asleep, and go to the room. Each use forces a Dread 3 check on you. While you are at the Brink, everyone who spends a scene in the same room as you gains 1 Weariness, and restless sleepers turn their faces toward you.

THE WANTS

- ◇ **To lie down.** Triggered by beds, softness, warmth, a body lying peacefully, the Pillow. Resist with Caul + Resolve at Hard; on a failure, the character presses against the comfort for a minute and makes a blink check.
- ◇ **To count.** Triggered by rows, crowds, sleepers and fear. Resist at Routine; on a failure, the character must count the thing aloud to the end before acting.
- ◇ **To watch.** Triggered by a sleeping or drowsing person. Resist at Hard; on a failure, the character cannot leave that person unwatched for the scene.
- ◇ **To tuck in** (the Brink only). Triggered by a weeping, wounded or frightened person. Resist at Grim; on a failure, the character tries to make them lie down and rest.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 the character falls asleep, one last time, smiling, and no nudger on the Table can fetch them. They are carried to the Dormitory and given a number. Their player should take a moment with that. Later, perhaps much later, the GM may tell the surviving characters that a sleeper in a certain bed has become restless. Lips first. The god has been furnishing the character from the inside, and when it speaks, it will use their voice, and it will know their friends' names, and it will be very glad to see them.

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **Slope Nudger.** Born at a bell, pinching strangers for crumbs by six, you know every rouse-cut on the Slope and every face that is about to go down. You have outlived three clients.
- ◇ **Washed-Out Waker.** You did your week in Sister Pinch's standing-stall, and your year on the beat, and then you put the needle down one night and could not pick it up. You still know the Atlas. You still hear the screams as thanks.
- ◇ **Eye-line Spare.** A younger child of a lidless house, born with eyelids, or born lidless and too far down the line to matter. You have been educated, watched, and kept out of sight, and you have never once been allowed to look away.

NAMES

Feminine: Aveline, Cecily, Iselde, Ilvane, Maud, Mirela, Odile, Oriel, Senna, Vesper, Constance, Agathe, Sabine, Hesper, Annick, Merrit, Lisbet, Wenna.

Masculine: Aldous, Benedikt, Brannoch, Castellan, Corwin, Evander, Garron, Hale, Lukas, Marten, Teodor, Thaddeus, Tobin, Ansgar, Pell, Florian.

Neutral and bell-names (the Slope): Pip, Rook, Wick, Ember, Nod, Rue, Quill; with a bell for a surname: Eleven-Bell, Quarter-Bell, Half-Bell, First-Bell, Dusk-Bell.

Surnames: Stroud, Sexton, Pyre, Vole, Crane, Dorm, Ashlock, Marre, Null, Knell, Sconce, Tenterhook, Grimmer, Farthing, Lour, Dray, Morne, Larch, Hobb, Rell, Quell, Coyle, Lantern, Wakely, Pinchbeck, Startle.

▼ HORRORS OF THE VIGIL

GM ADVICE – USING THE HORRORS

Roll d10, or choose, when the city needs to remind the party where they are. Most of these scenes call for a Dread check (Dread 1 or 2; Dread 3 where someone the party knows is involved), and most of them happen on a grey, quiet afternoon. Several are good moments to ask everyone at Weariness 5 or above for a blink check.

D10	HORROR
1	A whole rouse-house yawns in a wave, bench by bench, jaws cracking, eyes streaming, and at the far end of it a man sits down on the floor, smiling, and does not get up. Everyone looks at the party.
2	A Dormitory cart passes down the Slope piled with the day's sleepers, warm, breathing in time. The crowd counts them aloud. At the last body the counting stops: it is someone the party spoke to this morning.
3	A Waker needles a drowsing girl at a street corner, under the nail, the armpit, behind the ear. She screams and thanks him. Her mother pays him. He moves on to the next.
4	A Seeming: every lamp in the lane flickers in rhythm, slow, four beats to the minute, and the party's own breathing has already matched it.
5	A woman runs up, wet-faced, asking whether the party saw her blink, because her nudger is lying on the floor with his eyes closed and her hands smell of his breath.
6	A child of four is crying in a doorway that she is so tired, she is so tired, why can't she lie down. Her mother is slapping her, sobbing, again and again, harder each time.
7	The Lantern in the square holds a man in his fifth day. He thinks the crowd is eating him. Some of the crowd have started to agree, and one has a knife.
8	Someone in a window is humming the first three notes of <i>The Lamb and the Lid</i> . Every head on the street turns. A Waker begins to run.
9	Lain-Down: a neat pair of shoes on a doorstep, a folded coat on top, a note pinned to it, and the open door of a dark, warm room.
10	A Brine Walker column shuffles past, eyes open, coughing salt water, all of them facing west. One of them is someone a PC loves, who does not know them.

The Lamb and the Lid, as recorded in the Rattlehouse register of forbidden matter, the only copy permitted to exist.

*Hush now, lamb, the lid is low,
the long room's warm and the lamps burn slow;
lie you down where the sleepers keep,*

and the eye won't open while the lambs still sleep.

*Hush now, lamb, and count to three,
there's a bed for you and a bed for me;
and when the beds are full, my sweet,
the eye will open, and we'll all go to eat.*



CHAPTER 7

CRADLEWRACK

First we ask what it is. Then we ask whether it stays.

– THE MIDWIFE’S TWO QUESTIONS

Knock before you open. Whatever is on the other side has a right to be warned, and so do you.

– CRADLEWRACK PROVERB, TAUGHT BEFORE THE ALPHABET

Set down by Wenna Thrale, apprentice of the Attendance, third year of her apron, for the Lying-In’s own book and not for the Tally. Rudge parish, the fourth night after a pang, Carving 641.

They sent for us at the second bell because the father had begun. Not the mother: she had been delivered of a girl in Grace and sat by the hearth with the girl at her breast and her face to the wall. It was the father on the floor, a shepherd’s son named Corran with hands like spades, curled on the red clay in a shirt soaked black. The room smelled the way every highland room smells when something is coming: iron, wet wool, and under it the warm salt of the springs, as if the ground had broken its waters under the house.

Mother Sabeth went to him first. I went to the door, as I was taught, because the door had opened on its own when we came in and would not stay shut. I put my back to it. I could feel it pushing, very gently, the way a hand pushes from the inside of a belly. I have stood against a hundred doors and that is the only way I can describe it.

Corran’s belly was not large. That was the worst of it. It was a man’s flat belly, but the skin of it was moving in a long slow roll from the ribs to the groin, and each time it rolled he made a sound I have heard cattle make and never a man. Sabeth laid her palm on him and counted under her breath. Then she opened her case and laid out the things in the order we lay them out: the cord-thread, the basin, the clean linen, the bone hook, and last, wrapped in its own oiled cloth, the knife.

It took until the fourth bell. I will write only that he did not open where a woman opens, because he has nowhere to, and that he opened at an old scar on his flank from a ram’s horn, twenty years shut and white, which parted now like a mouth deciding to speak. Sabeth had her arm in him to the elbow and her face was calm. The mother at the hearth did not turn around once. The baby at her breast did not cry once, but watched.

What came out was the size of a lamb and the color of the clay floor. It had a great many fingers. It drew breath. That is the thing nobody tells you before your apron, that they all draw breath, that the first sound out of the worst of them is

the same small wet gasp as out of the best. Sabeth held it up in the lamplight and turned it, slowly, the way you turn a pot to look for cracks, and she asked the First Question aloud, because it must be asked aloud.

What is it.

Nobody answered. Nobody ever answers. She answered it herself, quietly, in the words of the Book, and then she was quiet for a long time. Corran had stopped making his sound. The door had stopped pushing against my back. The only noise in the room was the thing breathing and the clay ticking as it cooled. I counted eleven breaths. I have been told since that Sabeth Thorne never takes more than three. She looked at it for eleven.

Then she asked the Second Question, and she answered it, and she unwrapped the oiled cloth.

I am meant to write what I saw, for the Lying-In’s book. I saw her turn her back to the hearth so the mother would not see. I saw her shoulder move once. I saw her wrap the linen and tie the knot we tie, the one that cannot come undone, and hand the bundle to me without looking at it, and I held it, and it was warm, and it stayed warm against my chest the whole cold walk back to the Lying-In, longer than it should have. I did not look either. I want that written down. I did not look.

Corran lived. We closed his flank with eight stitches, and he will have them redone at every pang for the rest of his life, because in Cradlewrack a wound opened once remembers how. In the morning the mother turned from the wall and asked what it had been. I said, as I am taught, that nothing had been born, that the Tally would show a son of the household entered and struck through. She nodded. Then she held up her girl, six months old and unnamed, and asked whether I thought this one would stay.

The girl looked at me. She has her father’s eyes, very dark. She opened her mouth as if to answer.

I said that the naming waits a year. I said it the way I was taught. I put the knife-case back in Sabeth’s bag myself because Sabeth’s hands were busy at the basin, scrubbing, long after there was anything left on them to scrub.

▼ THE MEAL

Vey, the Opening, was the smallest of the Providers. The highland songs agree on that and on almost nothing else. It was no taller than a woman of middle height, and in the old carvings at Kest it is shown standing in a doorway with its arms spread to either jamb, so that the eye cannot tell whether it is holding the door open or holding something back. It had no face that anyone could keep in mind afterward. Those who saw it remembered only the feeling of being about to begin something: a breath drawn in and not yet let out, the half-second before a first word. Mothers in labor reached for it. It came. For three thousand years, the highlands say, no child in Vey's country was born without the god standing at the foot of the bed, its hands spread, its faceless attention fixed on the opening.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack, Vey stood at the foot of every bed and nothing came. The wombs of the highlands had closed. Ewes stood dry and staring. Seeds lay in the red clay like teeth in a dead jaw. The god went from house to house with its hands spread, and the doorways it stood in were empty, and at last the midwives stopped calling it, because it was unbearable to watch it wait.

They took it in the birthing-house at Kest, the round red building that still stands at the heart of the city and is now called the Old Lying-In. They did not need to chase it. It came when the midwives called, the way it always came, and stood in the doorway of the birthing-room with its arms spread, and they shut the door on it. It was the first time anything had ever been shut against Vey. The songs say the god looked at the closed door for a long time, as if it had never seen one from that side.

Then they killed it, and it would not stay killed.

This is the part the highlands remember in their bodies. Vey was the hardest of the Providers to kill because it kept starting again. They opened its throat with a shearing knife and from the wound came, wet and blinking, a smaller Vey, whole, its arms already spread. They killed that one and it began again from its own wound, and again, each new god crawling up out of the opened body of the last like a child crowning. By dawn the floor was a drift

of gods the size of hares, of mice, of fingernails, each still trying to begin, and the clay was ankle-deep in caul and cord and a clear warm fluid that smelled of iron and the inside of a mouth. The last was no larger than a barleycorn. The midwife who crushed it between her thumbnails, Hollan Kest, ancestor of every Midwife-Paramount since, is said to have wept and said, "There. Now nothing begins."

Then they ate it, because the Lack had to end. They ate it the way the highlands eat a lambing's afterbirth: stewed with clay salt in the great copper and ladled out by the senior midwife into bowls brought from home. The boldest households, pressed closest to the copper, came away with the choicest part, which was not flesh but the membrane that had sheathed the god's thousand rebirths, a grey-pink translucent skin the cooks skimmed off the pot like the skin on milk. These families ate the caul. They became the Caul-lines.

The famine ended in the morning. By midday the first ewes were dropping lambs in the snow. By the end of Grace every woman in the highlands who could carry was carrying, and by the end of Plenty every one of them had been delivered, easily, without blood, without death. The midwives who had done the killing were made the guardians of the cradles. They were thanked. Nobody asked why the doors of the old birthing-house had all swung open on their own at the moment the last god died, or why no one has managed to close them since.

THE CARVING ABOVE THE OLD LYING-IN

Over the round door of the Old Lying-In in Kest is a frieze older than the Gorging: eight figures standing in eight doorways, each in its own arch, each with its arms spread. Seven have been worn by six centuries of hands touched to them for luck. The eighth arch is empty. Its figure has been chiselled out so deeply that the stone behind it has gone through to the hollow of the wall, and the hole breathes warm air on cold days. Midwives touch the seven arches on the way in. Nobody touches the eighth. The apprentices say that if you put your ear to the hole you can hear someone on the other side laying a table. The apprentices say a great many things.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Nothing here is born right, and too much is born.

That is the whole of it, and it has been the whole of it for six centuries. Vey was the god of things coming into the world, and Vey is in the blood of the highlands now, and things will not stop coming. The births began wrong in 94 A.G. and have never gone right since. Every highland family has a story about what came out of whom, and every story is told the same way, flat and practical, the way other peoples talk about weather.

Children arrive speaking. Not babbling: speaking, in full sentences, in the voices of adults, with opinions. The first, in Kest in 94 A.G., opened its eyes and said, "Not yet," and died within the hour, and nobody has ever agreed on what it meant. Children arrive old, white-haired and arthritic, with failing hearts and worn teeth, and either grow younger year by year toward the cradle or simply die of age at three. Children arrive full-grown, tearing their way out into a world they are already too big for: men and women of thirty,

of fifty, born mid-stride or mid-sentence, slick with blood and cord, who must be taught to use a spoon although their hands already know how to use a sword. These are the born-grown, and the country has found uses for them.

And some arrive as Parts. A single living hand, warm, clenching. An ear that turns toward sound. A length of spine that crawls by flexing, like a caterpillar. A heart in its own little caul, kept in a covered dish in Cleave for nineteen years before it stopped. The Parts are healthy. They feed through the skin or through mouths that open in unlikely places. They grow. They are also drawn toward each other: a hand left on a table will, overnight, drag itself to the edge nearest the nearest other Part, however far away, and two Parts in one room will strain together and, if allowed, seal along a seam that heals in a night. Since 500 A.G. it has been known that Parts from unrelated families fit, a hand born in Rudge sitting perfectly on a wrist born in Kest a century apart, as if they were born to go together.

Birth is not limited to mothers. Men have borne, through scars, through the navel, through the mouth. A widow of eighty-seven in Tarnbrow was delivered of twins older than she was. A ewe may drop eleven lambs, or one lamb with eleven heads. And things that are not alive bear. A well in Rudge gave birth in 403 A.G. to something that climbed up the rope and was not seen again. A locked chest in the Morwen strong-room was found open with a damp, curled thing inside and the lock still turned. A hillside above Cleave dilated for a month and delivered a warm boulder with a pulse. A woman four days dead in the Stillyard went into labor on her bier, and the Attendance attended, because it must, and the Tally records what came as “one, living, struck through.”

The Tally is the evidence of the land’s condition. Every birth in Cradlewrack is entered in a public ledger, by law, and the Tally of births has outrun the count of conceptions every year for two centuries. Last year, by the figures of Rufus Ochre the Tallyman, eleven hundred more people were born in the highlands than were carried by any woman, man, beast, well, chest, or hillside. The country is making people out of nothing, and nobody knows where they are.

DOORS

Vey was also the god of doors, of openings, of thresholds and first steps over them. In Cradlewrack nothing stays shut.

Doors drift open in the night. Not violently: they are found at dawn a hand’s width ajar, latches lifted, bars slid back, as if someone very patient had worked at them for hours. Locks undo. Lids rise off jars. Knots slip. Coffins open. A sealed letter is found unsealed. And wounds reopen.

That last is the one that wears a body down. A cut that has knitted, a scar twenty years white, a surgical seam neatly closed: in Cradlewrack all of them remember how to open, and on pang nights many of them do. Old soldiers of the Foundling Companies bleed from every wound they have ever taken, all at once, every nine days. A woman who was cut for a stone in her youth wakes in a wet bed with her side yawning. The Attendance employs whole wards of stitchers whose only work is to close, each morning, what the night opened. There is no cure. There is only thread.

Every threshold is something waiting to be crossed. The highlanders knock before they open anything, door, cupboard, box or letter, because you knock to warn whatever is on the other side. They brick up rooms they never want opened again, and brick themselves into rooms at night, and break out in the morning.

RULES – WOUNDS THAT REOPEN

Any character who has spent at least one night in Cradlewrack is subject to the land. Each pang (every nine days at present), roll a d10 for each healed Injury from the Mangling table the character carries, and for each surgical seam closed by Stitching in the last year. On a 1–3 it reopens during the night: the character loses 2 Flesh per reopened wound and wakes bleeding (Dread 1 for anyone unused to it). Closing it again is a Stitching roll at Hard 14. A Lack on that roll means the wound has learned the stitch: the next reopening is automatic. Natives of Cradlewrack carry their stitching kit the way other peoples carry a knife, and most have a Stitching of at least 1.

Doors and locks fare no better. Any lock in Cradlewrack must be checked each night; a lock that matters holds only on a Craft or Filch roll at Grim 18 by whoever set it, and even then not past the next pang. Bricking in always holds. That is why they brick.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN CRADLEWRACK

Vey is growing back, and what grows back is beginning. Everything about the god’s return in the highlands has the shape of a labor: a long, rising rehearsal, contractions closing together, an opening that cannot be reversed. The Attendance calls the stages by midwives’ words, and every highlander can tell you where they stand.

THE TASTE

A sense of being about to begin. It feels, at first, like hope. The afflicted wake with a held breath and an urge to start something: a letter, a journey, a quarrel, a song. They do not finish; highland houses are full of half-sewn shirts and first lines. A Taste-touched child leaves doors open behind her without noticing, and her

parents follow her through the house closing them. Old scars itch and go pink. The rest of the Table would barely call it a curse.

THE APPETITE

False labor, in anyone, of any age or sex. The body rehearses. Cramps roll low in the belly in waves with intervals, and the sufferer counts them without wanting to. Then the waters: a sudden warm flood of clear salt fluid from no clear source, smelling of the springs. Men double over at the plough. Old women labor nine hours at the market, deliver nothing, and are up the next morning, hollow-eyed. Children have had it, and the Attendance's only guidance to parents is to hold them and count with them until it passes. The sufferer feels the god's want as plainly as hunger: something should be coming out, and it is not. The Appetite-struck gather outside houses where a woman is in labor and stand very close to the walls. Many are found at dawn asleep on their feet in their own doorways, arms spread to the jambs.

THE COURSE

True bearing, of things that are not children. The sufferer conceives without any act, carries for days or weeks rather than months, and delivers: Parts, mostly; small wet things with too many fingers; warm stones; keys; once, in the Attendance's records, a perfectly formed little door of bone, hinged, that opened onto nothing. Hips widen in men. Scars become permanent openings, lipped and moist, that dilate during pangs. Some develop a second opening where the body has no business having one, and keep it bandaged. The Caul-lines carry almost continuously: a noble of the highest houses may deliver six or eight times a year, and spend the weeks between already

swelling. The afflicted grow gaunt, as if everything they eat is taken for someone else.

THE BRINK

The Attendance has a word it uses in the Lying-In and nowhere else: crowning. Somewhere on the body of a person at the Brink, usually the belly, sometimes the breast or the forehead, the flesh has dilated into a round, perfect opening with soft lips and no bottom anyone has reached, and through it, at the height of each pang, something presses up toward the light: a curve of wet skin, a hand, a face that is never the same twice. Nothing comes all the way out. The Brink-touched hear it talking, in a small voice, about what it will do when it arrives. Thread passed through the crowning's lips dissolves by morning. The common are taken to the Lying-In; the Caul-lines to the deep chambers of their houses; and they are made comfortable, and watched.

THE SEATING

The land itself. The highlands are in labor.

No single person has ever been Seated in Cradlewrack, and the Attendance believes none will be, because the god is not regrowing in a person. It is regrowing in the country. The quakes are contractions: a century ago a full season apart, then thirty days within living memory, and now nine. The waters come up out of the ground without rain. The earth dilates into crownings. The greatest, the Dilation, is a mile across and has begun to move with the pangs. When the interval closes to nothing, something will be born out of the ground, and the whole of Cradlewrack is its mother.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

Cradlewrack is the high country of the Table's northwest: rounded red-clay hills folded on each other like the flesh of a sleeper, split by wet ravines thick with fern and alder. The hills are warm to the touch; snow melts where it falls and runs down in pink rivulets. The soil is soft, dark red, and smells of iron, and every highland house is built of it, rounded and windowless on the weather side, so that a village looks like a clutch of eggs. Springs run warm and slightly salt, and taste, the highlanders admit, like the inside of a cheek.

The pangs are the true calendar, and every household notches the interval on its lintel. A pang comes as a long rolling quake that rises from the deep ground: crockery walks off shelves, bricked rooms groan, ewes drop where they stand, and every Course-touched person within a hundred miles cries out at once. It lasts a slow count of sixty. In the hours after come the waters: springs surge, wells overflow, and in the low ravines the ground simply weeps, a warm clear tide that leaves a pale salt rime and draws flies. Sinkholes are called crownings. The earth dilates over weeks into a perfect round

opening with soft lips of clay, and people gather at the rim to see what comes up. Usually it is water. Twice in the last decade it has been a person, born-grown and naked, who climbed out by the roots and asked the watchers what year it was.

The highland weather is otherwise mild, damp, and close. Fog lies in the ravines most mornings and is called the caul; children are told not to breathe it too deep. Wind is rare. Rain is light and warm. The worst season is late Plenty, when the clay steams, the air turns thick and salt, and the pangs, for reasons nobody understands, are hardest.

GAZETTEER

KEST

The capital and seat of the Attendance, built on seven rounded hills around the Old Lying-In, the birthing-house of the Meal, whose doors have not closed since that night. Kest is a city of round red buildings without a single door that locks: by law since the Year of

Doors, doors hang on leather hinges and are held, if at all, with wedges. Rooms meant to stay shut are bricked. The streets curve; there are no corners, because the Attendance holds that corners are where things collect. Every quarter has a Tally-board where the day's births are chalked at dusk and read aloud. Kest smells of wet clay, lye, and the sweetish copper of the laundries, where aprons are boiled day and night.

THE LYING-IN

The Attendance's fortress-hospital, two hours' ride north of Kest on a bare hill: a ring of red walls forty feet high with no gate, entered by ladder and a wicker basket hoist. Here are taken the births nobody speaks about: the ones the Second Opinion spared and should not have, the ones it could not reach, the Brink-touched, the mothers who will not stop bearing. Its upper wards are clean and quiet and smell of lavender. Its lower wards are bricked, cell by cell, and the bricklayers who maintain them are paid triple and change every year. The Lying-In keeps its own book, separate from the public Tally. Nobody outside the Attendance has read it.

THE DILATION

The great crowning in the central highlands, a mile across and widening. It opened in 547 A.G. as a pothole in a sheep track and has never stopped. Its lips are soft red clay that gives underfoot like flesh and slopes inward to a sheer drop into a darkness from which warm air breathes. During pangs the whole bowl flexes. Around the rim has grown Rimwatch, a ring of tents, turf huts and hostels full of pilgrims, Assemblers' agents, Barren protestors and Attendance observers, who mark the rim's advance each morning with painted stakes. The stakes nearest the edge are always gone by noon.

THE SILL

A bare hilltop in the north, where a single door stands in its frame with no wall around it. It is oak, grey with age, iron-bound, older than the Gorging, and it has been ajar since that night, opening a finger's width further each year. Walk around it and there is only hillside behind. Look through the gap from the front, the old rule says, and you will see something else. Its keeper, Old Hinge, oils it, measures it, and does not look.

THE ASSEMBLERS' BARN

A long stone threshing-barn in a fold of hills east of Kest, built in the old style with a door at each end. It is guarded by armed brothers, lit by lamps day and night, and kept warm as a lambing-shed. It smells of tallow, catgut, and something underneath like the inside of a sheepfold in spring. Visitors are welcome, by appointment, and are shown the near end, where Parts sleep in labelled straw boxes awaiting their place. Visitors are not shown the far end.

RUDGE

A clay-diggers' parish in the western ravines, famous for the well that gave birth in 403 A.G. The well has been capped with three

tons of fired brick and a millstone, and the parish still sleeps badly. Rudge supplies the potters of Kest and, through Maddar Rudge's family, most of the watchers at the Dilation. Its people are short, broad, red-handed and suspicious, and the Tally records more Parts born in Rudge than anywhere else in the country.

MORWEN HALL

The seat of the highest Caul-line house, on a wooded ridge above the River Tull. A great round keep of fired red brick with no doors at all on its lower floors, entered by bridges at the third storey. Within are the Veiled Galleries, where the family lives behind the membranes they were born in. The house has married within itself for three hundred years, so that the cauls might stay thick, and the Cutwrights' ledgers on the Morwen line are kept in a separate locked volume with a great many footnotes. The servants say the house is never quiet, because someone in it is always in labor.

BREECH'S GATE

The great border post on the Rim Road where it leaves the highlands, named for the current marshal and renamed for each one since 220 A.G. A walled yard, a customs hall, and the Examination Rooms, where every traveler leaving the country is checked for signs of carrying: hands on the belly, a midwife's ear to the navel, questions about the last pang. Nobody pregnant may leave. The yard is always full of the turned-back, waiting for a change of heart that never comes.

THE STILLYARD

The great cemetery of Kest, on the north slope of the city: miles of long red walls in concentric rings, each lined with niches where the dead are mortared in behind bricks stamped with their family's mark. The walls grow by several hundred niches a year. On still nights they tick and settle, and sometimes they knock. Families pay the masons to listen. When a wall knocks back, the Attendance is sent for, and attends.

CORDWAY

A village of the Uncut on the moorland west of Morwen Hall, built entirely of long low houses joined end to end so that cords need never pass through a door. Its streets are woven over with living cord, pale and pulsing, strung from roof to roof between mothers and children and grandchildren, a vast slow net that sways in the wind and is warm to the touch. Outsiders must duck. Outsiders who touch a cord feel the heartbeat of whoever is on the far end of it.

NULLHOUSE

The mother-house of the Barren Order, a plain square building of grey stone (the only stone building of note in the highlands, quarried and carted from the Fast border at ruinous cost) on a dry hill in the south. Grey stone, the Order teaches, is the one material in Cradlewrack that has never borne anything. Its doors are bricked

on every side. Members enter by a stair over the wall and are cut in the chapter-room.

▼ HISTORY

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Meal at the Old Lying-In. Hollan Kest crushes the last Vey. The famine ends by morning.
0–90	The Easy Births. No mother dies in childbed, no child is lost. The highlands fill.
94	The First Word. A newborn in Kest says “Not yet.”
101	The first born-grown: a woman of forty delivered at Cleave, mid-scream.
120	The Attendance. The midwives arm and take authority over every birth.
131	The Attendance becomes the government in all but name. The Book of Questions is written.
188	First recorded birth to a man, in Tarnbrow.
220	The Border Marshals: pregnant subjects forbidden to leave.
310	The Year of Doors. Every lock fails in one night. Bricking-in begins.
403	The well at Rudge gives birth.
452	The Uncut first recognized as a people by the Attendance.
500	The Gathering of Parts. Parts from unrelated families found to fit.
541	The Assemblers founded at a sheepfold near Kest.
547	The Dilation opens.
597	Queen Sibyl Aubrey conceives the heir.
600–641	The Shortening. The pangs close from thirty days to nine.
635	The first Foundling Companies raised from the born-grown.
641	Present. Nine days. The Dilation moves with the pangs.

THE YEAR OF DOORS

On a night in late Carving, 310 A.G., every lock in Cradlewrack failed at once: every bolt, latch, padlock, chain and bar from the Rim Road to the sea cliffs. The Tally for the following month was the largest in history, and what was born that month is recorded in the Lying-In’s book and nowhere else. From that night dates bricking-in, the habit of knocking, and the Kest law against locking doors at all, on the reasoning that a lock which will fail is worse than none.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

Cradlewrack is ruled by the Attendance, the armed order of midwives. No birth may take place without one present; the penalty for an unattended birth is that the child is held to be unborn, and the mother is fined for concealment. The Attendant asks the Two Questions aloud, *what is it* and *does it stay*, and answers them

THE GATHERING OF PARTS

In 500 A.G. a Rudge clay-digger named Abel Furrow, who had kept a born hand in a bread-crock for nine years, took in a born forearm from a neighbor and found them joined at the wrist in the morning. He told the Attendance, which tested it, and kept testing it, and in 503 issued a decree that all born Parts were to be surrendered to the Lying-In. The decree has never been obeyed. Out of the disobedience grew the Assemblers.

herself, according to the Book of Questions and her own judgment. Her knife is called the Second Opinion, and there is no appeal from it.

The Book of Questions runs to six hundred pages and is mostly cases. Speaking children stay. Old-born children stay. Born-grown

stay, and are given to the Companies. Parts are surrendered to the Lying-In. Everything else is the Attendant's to decide, alone, in the room, and the Book's last page, in Hollan Kest's words, says only: *It is your hand, and you will remember. Choose so that you can.* The Attendance does not speak of the Second Opinion in public, and does not need to. Every highlander knows that the bundle carried out of a birthing-room, tied in the knot that cannot come undone, is entered as "struck through" and bricked in the Stillyard's Low Wall without a family mark. Every highlander knows a family with a struck-through line. Few would say they wish the knife gone. Many could not tell you, without weeping, why.

Beneath the Attendance, law is local and practical. Parish Attendants act as magistrates. Disputes over descent, which are endless because descent runs through whoever bore you, are heard before a bench of three senior midwives called a Lying. Murder is punished by bricking: the condemned is mortared alive into a niche in the Stillyard's Debt Wall, with water and bread pushed through a slot each day for as long as the family pays. Lesser crimes are punished by *unbinging*: the offender's house has its doors taken off by the parish and burned, and they must live open to the night.

The old monarchy technically survives. The House of Aubrey still holds the crown, and the rightful king, Aldous the Ninth, has

been in the womb for forty-four years. His mother, the Queen Dowager Sibyl, still carries him, and he is consulted on matters of state: a question is read aloud to the Queen's belly by the Lord Chamberlain, and one kick means yes. The Attendance finds this an extremely convenient form of government.

The Caul-lines nobility are born veiled in a membrane that, in the highest houses, never comes off. They live behind it, speak through it, and are held to be prophetic, since the god's caul sees forward into what is beginning. The great houses (Morwen, Aubrey, Calloway, Seele, and Danner) sit on the Veiled Council, which advises the Attendance on matters of prophecy, and in practice on matters of money, since the houses own most of the clay-pits and all of the springs. Their prophecies are vague, red, and lately unanimous.

Nobody pregnant may leave the country. The Border Marshals check. The law dates from 220 A.G., when three expectant mothers crossed into the Fatlands and the Tally of that year recorded three births in Cradlewrack to women who were not there. The rule held; the country went with them. It is the opinion of the Attendance that a pregnant woman who leaves takes some of Cradlewrack with her, and that whatever she bears abroad is still the country's, and still its business.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

FOOD AND DRINK

Highland food is plain and red. Mutton and lamb above all, since the ewes drop endlessly; clay-baked bread, which is set in a pot of wet red clay and buried in the embers until it comes out with a pink crust; oats; nettles; and the salt from the warm springs, which is faintly rose-colored and tastes of blood. Lamb is so cheap that the poor eat it daily and the rich serve it never. The national drink is *posset*, warm ewe's milk curdled with spring-salt and spirit. Eggs are not eaten: too many hens' eggs in the highlands have been found to contain things looking back.

The custom the rest of the Table finds hardest to stomach is the Second Meal. At a child's naming, a year after its birth, the family eats its afterbirth, kept salted in a crock since the day of delivery and stewed in the copper with lamb and onions. Everyone at table takes a spoonful, starting with the mother, in memory of the first Meal, when the people of the highlands ate the caul and the god and ended the Lack. The Caul-lines eat their own children's cauls, raw, from a silver dish, and do not speak of it to outsiders. The grace is the common one, "Lack keep away," followed by the highland addition: "and let it stay."

DRESS

Highlanders dress in undyed or madder-red wool, and nothing they wear fastens: buttons and buckles work loose, so garments are wrapped and knotted and retied at every bell, and the well-off have their clothes sewn on each morning and cut off at night. Everyone over seven carries a stitching kit on a neck-cord and a small hammer for knocking. Midwives wear the white apron and a knife-case nobody looks at directly. The Caul-lines are recognizable across a market by their blurred and glistening heads.

MARRIAGE, BED AND BEARING

Marriage is a contract between two households about who will bear, and when, and who will attend. Bride and groom are mortared into a bricked room together overnight and broken out at dawn, which is lucky, since nothing came in. What passes between married adults is spoken of only obliquely; highlanders are frank about bodies and shy about the rest. Every couple keeps a *closed week* around each pang, in the belief that whatever begins in pang-week begins wrong.

The Caul-lines marry within the house. It is called *keeping the veil*: the thicker the caul, the higher the line, and the caul is thickest where the blood is least diluted. The Cutwrights record these unions with a discretion the College shows nowhere else, in a locked volume where cousins marry cousins and the relations between consorts are entered in a private shorthand whose key the College

does not lend. What the shorthand covers is not discussed in the highlands, and certainly not in Morwen Hall, where every family portrait has the same blurred face.

CHILDREN

A child is not named for a year, until it is clear what it is. Until then it is called by its place in the Tally (Third of the Gorse household) or by a pet word, *bit*, *small*, *keep*. Parents are advised not to love an unnamed child too much, and none of them listen. A child who changes in its first year, who begins to speak in an adult voice or to age, is taken back for a late Second Opinion. This is called *returning*, and it is the great dread of highland parents. Many hide their children rather than return them. Few of the returned come home.

DEATH AND THE DEAD

Nobody is buried. Graves open, and the dead have been known to bear. The dead are washed, every opening stitched shut with nine stitches, and bricked into the long walls of a Stillyard behind a course stamped with the family mark. Mourners knock three times on the new brick and do not wait for an answer. Oaths are sworn on the dead this way: a hand flat on a kinsman's brick, and the words *by the shut door*. To break such an oath is to wish the door open, and highlanders believe a forsworn man's dead will come through the brick for him. Some have.

FESTIVALS

- ◇ **Pangday.** Every nine days, now. Work stops at the first tremor. Families gather in the strongest room, sing the counting-song together, and wait out the sixty seconds, then go outside to see what the waters have brought up.
- ◇ **The Unbricking.** The first day of Grace. Every bricked room in the country, except the Stillyard's, is broken open at dawn and aired, and whatever is found inside is entered in the Tally.
- ◇ **Tablenight.** Every door in the country is propped wide open until dawn, on purpose, so that nothing can be said to have broken in. Families sit up in their open houses in the cold, all lamps lit, and a place is laid at the table nearest the door for whatever comes. Usually nothing does.

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

The great crimes of the highlands are concealment (an unattended birth or a hidden Part), descent-fraud (claiming a bearer who did not bear you), lockbreaking (opening a bricked room without the household's leave), and smuggling a pregnancy across the border. Concealment of a Part is punished by unhinging; the Assemblers have made it the most common crime in the country. The Attendance does not hang, behead, or burn. It bricks. A sentence of bricking is read in the Old Lying-In; the Debt Wall in the Stillyard is lined with the living condemned, and in the evenings their families sit beneath the slots and talk to them.

PROVERBS

- ◇ "Knock first. It's not for your sake."
- ◇ "What's opened once has learned the way."
- ◇ "Every door is a mother."
- ◇ "Bricked is the only shut."
- ◇ "You'll know when it's crowning." (Said of anything inevitable.)
- ◇ "Nine days." (Said now as a farewell, in place of "good night," with a shrug.)

▼ FACTIONS

THE ATTENDANCE

The midwives: judges, physicians, priests and executioners in one apron. Founded in 120 A.G. by the daughters and granddaughters of the women who killed Vey, the Attendance has ruled the highlands for five centuries without ever calling itself a government. Every parish has its Attendant, every birth its knife. Its members take a single vow, *I will go into the room*, and it is the one vow in Cradlewrack nobody has ever been known to break, though many have died keeping it.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Apprentice (Third Hand)	The white apron, a stitching kit, the right to hold the door.
2	Attendant	A parish; the right to ask and answer the First Question.
3	Opinion	The knife; the right to answer the Second Question alone.
4	Senior of the Lying	A seat on a descent bench; access to the Lying-In's book.
5	Midwife-Paramount	The Old Lying-In. One holder. Answerable to no one.

Joining. Any woman, man, or born-grown person may apprentice by going into a room alongside an Attendant and staying until the end. Most apprentices quit after their first Second Opinion. Player characters can join at rank 1 with Stitching 1 and the vow. **Enemies:** the Assemblers, the Uncut (who call midwives “the Severers”), Petra Quick. **Allies:** the Crown, the Border Marshals, the Foundling Companies, uneasily the Barren Order.

THE ASSEMBLERS

A sect that collects Parts and joins them. Founded in 541 A.G. by a shepherd-surgeon who had read the Furrow case, the Assemblers believe that the Parts are not monstrous births at all but one body,

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Gatherer	A carrying-crate; the password at the Barn's near door.
2	Seamster	The right to stitch Parts and to be present at a Joining.
3	Midwife of Pieces	A district; Part-hunters at command; the Barn's middle hall.
4	Fitter	A place at the figure's side; the right to choose where a Part goes.
5	Assembler-Prime	The far end of the Barn. Dov Marrin.

Joining. Bring a Part to the Barn, or the name of a family hiding one. Player characters who join gain access to Lazar Voss's drawings and to the Barn's surgeons. **Enemies:** the Attendance, the Barren Order. **Allies:** many grieving mothers, some Uncut, the Second Table (which has quietly paid for the Barn's roof).

Beliefs. That every birth is a question, and someone must answer it; that the Second Opinion is mercy to the mother, to the country, and, the Book insists, to what is born. The order is split as never before: the Knife-faction, led by Orla Kest, holds that the knife has held the country together for six centuries; the Late-faction, which has no leader willing to be named, whispers that the knife was six centuries too late, and that no apron can attend the birth under the Dilation.

Wants. To keep the Tally true, the births attended, and the knife steady until the interval closes. To learn what is in the ground before it arrives, and, if it must be, to be in the room when it does.

born piecemeal, through ten thousand mothers across a century: Vey, being born again the only way the highlands would permit, in pieces small enough to be let stay. Their work is to gather the pieces and give the god back its shape. They are making good progress.

Beliefs. That every Part is holy; that every mother who bore one is a mother of the god; that the Second Opinion has been murdering Vey's fingers and teeth for five hundred years. The figure in the barn is the god, nearly whole. When it is finished it will stand up, and the pangs will stop, because the god will have been born the easy way, in a barn, among friends.

Wants. The last pieces: a left hand, and a voice. Safe passage for every Part in the country. An end to the knife.

THE BARREN ORDER

Men and women who have had themselves cut so they can bear nothing. Founded at Nullhouse in 470 A.G., they preach an end to beginnings: if Vey regrows through every womb, navel and scar, the only refusal left is to close the body forever. Members are cut in the

chapter-room by the Order’s surgeons. In the higher ranks the cutting is extensive, and since wounds in Cradlewrack reopen, the sutures are renewed every pang; a brother who misses his resewing finds that his body has made new arrangements.

Beliefs. That the kindest thing a person can do is start nothing: no child, no journey, no quarrel, no hope. That the Dilation must

not be watched, because watching is attending. That the land should be left to strain until it is exhausted. Their numbers grow with every pang.

Wants. The Dilation filled with grey stone. The Assemblers’ figure burned. The Second Opinion given to every birth in the country, without exception, for one generation.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hearer	A grey robe; lodging at any Barren house.
2	Closed	The first cutting; full membership; a bricked cell.
3	Sealed	The second cutting; the right to preach on the rim.
4	Grey Brother or Sister	A chapter-house; command of the Order’s stonecarters.
5	Abbot of Nullhouse	Brother Callum Stillwater.

Joining. Hearers may leave at any time. The Closed may not, in any sense. **Enemies:** the Assemblers, the Uncut, the Caul-lines. **Allies:** the Purgation, which sees the Order as kin; elements of the Attendance’s Knife-faction.

THE FOUNDLING COMPANIES

Regiments of the born-grown: adults in body, a few years old in fact, with no childhoods and no one to claim them. Raised in 635 A.G., they are the state’s only army: six Companies of about four hundred each, housed in the Crèche, drilled in a single year from naked bewilderment to formation. They are disciplined beyond any

army on the Table, because they have never known anything else, and frightened in a way their officers do not discuss, because none of them knows how long they will last.

Beliefs. The Companies believe in the Company. Born with nobody, they have made the regiment mother and father. They love their General without reservation. Many born-grown age normally; some age backward; a few, without warning, revert to infancy in a night. The Companies call this *going home*, and they bury the infant in the Company’s own wall.

Wants. Somewhere to belong after the war that never comes. A birthday. Some want to find whoever, or whatever, bore them.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Newborn	A number, a blanket, a place in the Crèche.
2	Lettered	A spear and a name of one’s own choosing.
3	Sergeant-Elder	A squad; the right to a remembered birthday.
4	Captain	A company; a horse; leave to search for one’s bearer.
5	General	General Tibb. One holder.

Joining. Be born grown. Others may serve as drill-mothers and teachers, a post the Companies honor above officers. **Enemies:** none chosen; the Assemblers have tried to buy them. **Allies:** the Crown, the Attendance, the Border Marshals.

THE UNCUT

People whose birth cords were never severed. Somewhere in each Uncut family a mother refused the Attendant’s cord-knife, and her child walked into life still attached by yards of living cord that grows with them and does not wither. They live in long joined houses in Cordway and a few Kest courts, great families netted together by pale, warm, pulsing ropes of flesh, sharing through them warmth, blood, pain, and a slow tidal emotion outsiders find unbearable to

stand near. A cord cannot be cut without both ends bleeding; the Uncut say both ends die, and they are usually right. They consider everyone else amputees.

Beliefs. That the first wound every person suffers is the severing; that the Attendance’s knife at the cord is the same knife it uses for the Second Opinion, a little smaller. That nobody should ever be alone. That the cords are Vey’s, and Vey is a mother, and the land in labor is a mother, and when it delivers, its child will be Uncut too, and will hold them all.

Wants. The right to bear uncut by law. An end to the Attendance’s cord-knife. To be attached, through the deep cords that some of their elders have let grow down into the clay, to the land itself.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Grafted	A borrowed cord sewn on by the family; outsider kin.
2	Born-Joined	A true cord; a place in the long house.
3	Knot	A household of cords meets in you; you speak for them.
4	Root	Your cord goes into the ground. Visions; the land's pulse.
5	Mother of Cords	Sister Maeve Cord.

Joining. Outsiders may be Grafted: a living length of cord from a willing Uncut sewn into the navel in a slow, painful ceremony. It takes about half the time. When it does not, it rots. **Enemies:** the Attendance, the Barren Order. **Allies:** some Assemblers, who see in the cords another way Parts long to join.

THE CROSS-BORDER POWERS IN THE HIGHLANDS

The Cutwrights' College keeps its northwestern chapter in Kest and is the only body allowed into the Morwen genealogies, which it has sealed. **The Purgation** has a strong cell among the Barren Order and is suspected of the arson at the Rudge Part-house in 638. **The Second Table** has paid for the Assemblers' roof and wants to know when the figure will be finished, and how one would carve it. **The Reckoners** have killed three Caul-line nobles in their veils in the last decade; they say they cannot tell the face beneath from the membrane, and that it does not matter. **The Rim Road Company** runs the inn at Breech's Gate and buys cauls for export to Brinehollow, where a highland caul is believed to prevent the Calling.

▼ CRADLEWRACK NOW

Nine days between pangs, and the Dilation has begun to move with them: at each contraction the great bowl widens by a stride and then eases back by less. The Rimwatch stakes have to be reset every morning. Madder Rudge says the hole has a pulse, and that lately there is a second one under it, faster and smaller, like a heart inside a heart.

The Assemblers' figure is more than half complete, eleven feet long and breathing, and it has started to turn its head toward the Sill. It lacks a left hand and a voice. Hester Lowe has the hand. Juniper Dell, perhaps, has half the voice. The Assemblers know the first and suspect the second.

The Attendance is split between midwives who still trust the knife and midwives who think it is six centuries too late. Sabeth Thorne, its most trusted Opinion, hesitated last winter, and the thing she spared is growing in a shepherd's loft in Tarnbrow. The Queen Dowager's son has begun to answer questions nobody asked. The Duchess Morwen's veil has gone red. The Tally is eleven hundred short of explanation, and the Border Marshals are turning back more travelers every week, because more of them are carrying, including men who did not know.

Everyone can do the arithmetic on the interval. Something is going to be born out of the ground, and the whole country is the mother.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ♦ **The Missing Hand.** Dov Marrin hires the characters to recover a "stolen" Part from a widow in Rudge: Hester Lowe and her hand. Hester will fight. The hand will hold whichever of them it likes best. Lazar Voss, meanwhile, has noticed from his drawings that a left hand may not be the only piece missing, and that the figure as drawn has two places a heart could go.
- ♦ **Eleven Breaths.** The Attendance's Senior of the Lying quietly asks outsiders to find out why Sabeth Thorne has taken leave to Tarnbrow every week since winter. What they find in the loft is the size of a boy of six, after only ten months, and it calls Sabeth "Mother." Orla Kest wants it brought to the Lying-In. Sabeth wants it hidden. It wants to see the Sill.
- ♦ **Fetch the Footprints.** Josiah Fenn begs the characters to come with him on the last stretch of a trail eight years long. The tracks are now the size of a cart. They lead toward the Dilation, and they go in, and something has come out again with them.
- ♦ **The Turned-Back.** Petra Quick needs guards to run nine pregnant women past Breech's Gate. The Marshal has his reasons for letting one through, and Petra thinks she knows them. Across the border, the women begin to find that the ground under their feet is warm and red, and the land beneath the Fatlands soil is starting to crown.

RUMORS OF THE HIGHLANDS

DIO	RUMOR
1	The pangs will stop if the Queen Dowager is delivered. (False. The King Within would not agree to it, by kick, anyway.)
2	The figure in the Barn wept last week, from forty-one eyes. (True. It has more than two of several things.)
3	The Dilation is a mouth, not a womb, and something is coming up to eat. (False, says the Attendance. Madder Rudge is less sure.)
4	The Midwife-Paramount has a struck-through sibling of her own. (True, and she was the one who held the door.)
5	The Barren Order is buying grey stone by the shipload from the Fast to fill the Dilation. (True. It would take four centuries of shipping.)
6	Agnes Latch has built a door that held for a year. (False. It held for nineteen days. The customer died on the twentieth.)
7	The Sill opened a full hand's width this Grace. (True. Old Hinge has not told the Attendance.)
8	The eleven hundred unaccounted births are walking toward the Dilation by night. (Partly true. Some are.)
9	A Caul-line duchess can be killed only by cutting her veil, and the veil grows back. (False. But the veil does grow back.)
10	The Uncur's oldest Root is joined to something under the ground that is not dead and is not their mother. (True.)

THE PEOPLE OF CRADLEWRACK

MIDWIFE-PARAMOUNT ORLA KEST

Head of the Attendance, sixty-eight, descended in the female line from Hollan Kest, who crushed the last god. She is small, square, and grey, with forearms like a laundress's and a voice she has never once in her life raised. She smells of lye and lavender. She has attended nine thousand births and permitted six thousand. She remembers the other three thousand individually, by parish and date and the color of the mother's eyes, and can tell you why, in each

case, without raising her voice. She has never asked to be forgiven for any of them. What she fears is not the knife but its failure: that the Late-faction is right, that she has spent her life answering small questions while the large one dilated under her feet. She meets the characters when one of them is carrying, or when one of them is close to Sabeth Thorne. Secret: Orla's mother bore a second child when Orla was nine, and Orla held the door. She has asked herself the Second Question about the country, and answered it, and is waiting only for the room.

ORLA KEST – MIDWIFE-PARAMOUNT OF THE ATTENDANCE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Stitching 5, Blades 4, Instinct 4, Resolve 4, Rites 3, Intimidate 3, Clause 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	the Second Opinion (knife) +8 (2); a precise cut to an opening ignores Armor
GIFTS	The Question (once per scene, any creature born in Cradlewrack that she addresses by the First Question must hold still for one round, Caul + Resolve vs Grim 18 to resist); Steady Hand (never suffers a Lack on Stitching).
WANTS	Go into the Room (she cannot refuse to attend a birth, of any kind, anywhere).
DREAD	2 (to see her face after she answers the Second Question)
SECRET	She plans to go down into the Dilation with her knife when the interval reaches one day.

SABETH THORNE, THE SECOND OPINION

The Attendance's most trusted knife, forty, long-boned and quiet, with cropped black hair and hands she scrubs until they crack. For eighteen years she was the Opinion the other Opinions sent for: the one who could look for the count of three and decide. Last winter, at a farmhouse in Tarnbrow, she hesitated. She counted eleven

breaths. The thing lived. She paid the shepherd's widow a year's wages to keep it in her loft, and has been watching it grow ever since, and has not reported it. It is now the size of a child of six, after ten months; it has her eyes, though it cannot have; it calls her Mother and asks to be taken to see the Sill. Sabeth knows exactly what she must do. She has walked to Tarnbrow eleven times with the knife-case. She wants someone else to make her choose. She is Wenna Thrale's master, and the likeliest way a party meets her is in the room.

SABETH THORNE – THE SECOND OPINION	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stitching 4, Endure 3, Instinct 3, Stealth 2, Resolve 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 18 · Armor 1 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	knife +10 (2, first strike each fight gains a Helping); bone hook +8 (2, Hooking)
GIFTS	Three Count (after studying a target for one round, her next attack gains two Helpings).
WANTS	Look Away (when a newborn thing looks back at her, Caul + Resolve vs Hard 14 or she cannot act for a round).
DREAD	2
SECRET	The thing in the loft has begun to open doors by looking at them.

AMBROSE, THE ELDEST INFANT

Born twelve years ago in a Kest weaver’s house with a white beard to his chest and a full vocabulary, Ambrose was eighty at birth by the look of him, and is now perhaps sixty: his beard is iron-grey, his back has straightened, and his voice has lost its quaver. He is courteous,

learned, faintly amused, and smells of camphor and warm milk. He claims to remember being Vey’s left eye, and describes the Meal from inside the pot: the heat, the ladle, the caul lifting off above him like a sky. He is getting younger, and he says that when he reaches the cradle it will be time. He tutors Caul-line children and receives visitors who want to know what the god saw. His fear is that he will forget, at the end, what he was born to say.

AMBROSE – THE ELDEST INFANT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Lore 5, Godsign 4, Instinct 4, Persuade 3, Rites 3
BODY	Flesh 9 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none worth the name
GIFTS	The God’s Eye (once per session, answers one question about the Meal or the Dilation truthfully, if horribly); Younger (wounds dealt to him heal by morning, and he loses a year).
WANTS	Return (he is drawn to cradles, and sits beside them for hours).
DREAD	3 (to hear him describe being eaten)
SECRET	He is not growing younger toward birth. He is being drawn back toward the Dilation, and he will be there, the size of a newborn, when it opens.

HESTER LOWE

A clay-digger’s widow of Rudge, thirty-four, broad, sunburned, with a cleft chin and a laugh like a crow. Three years ago she bore a hand: only a hand, left, healthy, warm, the size of a grown woman’s, with a ring-finger callus nobody can explain. She did not call the Attendance. She hides it from the Lying-In and the Assemblers both, in a lined bread-crock under the hearthstone, and she feeds it warm milk through the skin of the palm, and talks to it while she works. It holds her finger at night. It strains, always, toward the east, toward Kest and the Barn, and she wakes to find it at the crock’s lip, fingers hooked over. Her fear is the morning she will find it gone. She will kill anyone who comes for it, and keeps a clay-spade

sharpened for the purpose. Her secret: twice now, the hand has written, in flour, a word she cannot read.

HESTER LOWE Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (clay-spade 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

DOV MARRIN, ASSEMBLER-PRIME

A former shepherd-surgeon, fifty-five, mild, balding, bespectacled, smelling of tallow and catgut, with a gentle voice for frightened mothers and very clean nails. He has fitted together four hundred Parts from four hundred families into one figure, eleven feet long, lying on a bed of warm straw at the far end of the Barn. It breathes. It is missing a left hand and a voice. Dov is devout, patient, and absolutely certain; he speaks of the figure as “Herself” and of each

Part by the name of its bearer. He wants the hand, the voice, and the god's easy birth. His fear is that the figure's head has turned toward the Sill without him.

DOV MARRIN – ASSEMBLER-PRIME	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stitching 5, Godsign 3, Craft 3, Lore 3, Persuade 3, Blades 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 3
ATTACKS	surgeon's cleaver +6 (3)
GIFTS	The Seam (any two Parts or wounds he stitches together join by morning); Call of Pieces (Parts within a mile crawl to him if he hums).
WANTS	Gather (he cannot leave a Part where he finds it).
DREAD	2
SECRET	He has already given the figure a heart: his own wife's, born to her as a Part in her sixtieth year, cut free with her blessing. She lives, after a fashion, in the Barn's middle hall.

HERSELF – THE ASSEMBLERS' FIGURE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 7 · Lung 2 · Eye 1 · Tongue 0 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	not applicable; she is the god, in pieces
SKILLS	Brawl 3, Endure 4, Instinct 5
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 (seamed hide) · Fray none
ATTACKS	grasp +8 (4, Grappling, from any of nine arms)
GIFTS	Many Mothers (the first time she suffers Ruin, Parts tear free instead and crawl away; she rises at full Flesh next pang); Turning (all doors within sight drift open).
WANTS	The Sill. The hand. A voice.
DREAD	4 (to see her breathe; Dread 5 if she sits up)
SECRET	She is not Vey. She is what Vey would be if born in the highlands' own image: everyone's, stitched.

BROTHER CALLUM STILLWATER

Abbot of the Barren Order, fifty, grey-robed, gaunt and gentle, with a soft tenor voice and the careful gait of a man whose sutures are renewed every nine days. He was cut at twenty, by choice, after watching his sister deliver three things in one winter. He preaches that the kindest thing a person can do is start nothing, and he has never had so many listeners; on the rim of the Dilation, at each pang, he stands and reads the names of the struck-through. He is kind to everyone he meets and he is not lying when he says he loves them. His fear is that his old wounds are opening differently now: this month, at the pang, his long-closed scar opened and something on the other side of it said his name in his sister's voice.

BROTHER CALLUM STILLWATER Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12
· Attack +3 (staff 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

GENERAL TIBB

Commander of the Foundling Companies, born six years ago in a Cleave lambing-shed as a grown man of thirty, mid-stride, already reaching for a sword that was not there. He is tall, red-bearded, scarred from wounds nobody gave him, with a voice that fills a drill-yard and a brilliant tactical mind that seems to have been born ready. He has no childhood, and he is a better father to his two thousand born-grown than any of them will have. He speaks plainly and laughs often. His private terror is the day he turns seven, the age at which three of his best captains went home, overnight, to the cradle.

GENERAL TIBB – COMMANDER OF THE FOUNDLING COMPANIES	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 5 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 4, Reckoning 4, Endure 3, Intimidate 3, Search 3, Wayfaring 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 3 (bone lamellar) · Fray 4
ATTACKS	sword +8 (4); his Company (see Foundling Soldier)
GIFTS	Born Ready (always acts first in the first round of a fight).
WANTS	Belong (cannot refuse a born-grown stranger who asks to join).
DREAD	1
SECRET	His wounds were given. Every scar on him matches a wound taken by a captain of the Rim Road Company guard killed at Breech's Gate on the day Tibb was born.

FOUNDLING SOLDIER Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

LARK NINEDAYS, THE COUNTER

She times the pangs for the state with a water clock and a bell from a bare room atop the Tally-house in Kest. Fifty-two, wiry, chapped-lipped, with a ring of red notches tattooed around her left wrist, one for each name. She was named Lark Thirtydays at birth. She has changed her name every time the interval shortened and has been Lark Twentydays, Lark Fourteendays, Lark Elevendays; her friends no longer know what to call her. She sleeps beside the clock. She fears the day she will have to take the name Lark Oneday, and has sworn on her mother's brick that she will not take the name after that.

MADDER RUDGE

An old clay-digger of sixty-nine and head of the watch at the Dilation, a stumpy woman with hands stained permanently red to the elbow and a pipe she smokes upside down against the steam. She has sat at the rim for twenty years. She lies on her belly at its lip each night with her ear to the clay and says the hole has a pulse, and that lately there is a second one under it, faster and smaller. She is blunt, profane, and kind to pilgrims. Her secret is that she has been down. Ninety feet on a rope, in 629, and she touched something warm and smooth that moved under her hand, and she has never told anyone that it moved toward her.

JOSIAH FENN, THE MAN WHO BORE

A shepherd of fifty-one, rangy, sun-black, with a pucker of scar over his navel that he keeps wrapped. Eight years ago he labored for three

days in a hill bothy and delivered something that stood up, looked at him with great tenderness, and walked out of the door. He has been following its tracks ever since. They are getting larger; the last set he measured was the length of a cart. He talks about it the way a father talks about a son who went to sea. He fears that when he catches it, it will not remember him. He fears more that it will.

AGNES LATCH, THE DOORWRIGHT

She builds doors meant to stay shut in a country where none do. Forty-five, deaf in one ear from her forge, sawdust in her braids, she works in iron-bound bog oak with locks of nine wards and hinges set in poured lead, and knocks on each one for a full day before she sells it. Her best work held for nineteen days. Customers travel from Kest to buy even one quiet night. She is proud, rude and expensive. Her secret is that she has studied the Sill, measuring it from a distance through a glass, and that every one of her best doors was built to its pattern.

DUCHESS IPHIGENE MORWEN

Head of the highest Caul-line house, fifty, she has lived her whole life inside the membrane she was born in. It has grown with her: a grey-pink veil, glistening, that covers her head and shoulders and moves when she breathes, through which her features are visible only as a pale blur and a darker mouth. She sees the future through it, blurred, and it has lately gone red. She speaks slowly, in a voice wet and muffled, and her prophecies are listened to by the Veiled Council in silence. She is in the Course; she carries almost continuously, and the house's nurses take away what she delivers before she can ask. She fears the red. Her consort is Lord Casimir Morwen.

IPHIGENE MORWEN – DUCHESS OF THE VEIL	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Caul-line) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Instinct 5, Godsign 4, Rites 4, Clause 3, Persuade 3
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	none; her servants carry poleaxes
GIFTS	Foretelling (once per scene, names an event of the next day; the GM must make it happen if plausible); Through the Veil (cannot be deceived by anyone standing before her).
WANTS	Keep the Veil (cannot permit the house's blood to marry out).
DREAD	3 (to see the veil part)
SECRET	What she sees in the red is a door opening in the ground, and herself standing in it with her arms spread.

DOLOUR PYM, THE WET-NURSE

A huge, slow, soft-spoken woman of fifty-eight who has been in milk without pause for thirty years. She feeds what no one else will. The Attendance sends her the births it permits but cannot look at, and she takes them into her cottage behind the Lying-In wall, a warm dim place full of cradles and baskets and a smell of milk and wet wool. She loves all of them. Several have never let go: there are small mouths on her that have not left her in years, and she moves about the cottage carefully, singing. She meets the characters when something they rescued needs a home. She fears nothing for herself; she fears the Lying-In will one day want her children back.

EDE AND ADA CREWE

Sisters of nineteen and twenty, born a year apart, who are by every test the same child born twice: one memory, one set of scars (both have the burn on the left palm that Ede got at four, a year before Ada was born), one mind in two bodies. They finish each other's sentences because there is only one sentence. They work as scribes for the Tally, copying in tandem, each writing half a line. They are charming, quick, and eerie. Their fear is that one of them will die first. Their secret is that, lately, a third girl in Cleave has started finishing their sentences too.

RUFUS OCHRE, THE TALLYMAN

Keeper of the public ledger, sixty, ink-stained, myopic, a man of columns who loves the Tally like a garden. By his figures, eleven hundred more people were born last year than were carried by anyone or anything. He would like to know where they are. He has started following the unaccounted at night, by their entries, and has found three of them so far, born-grown, walking north in a line, who would not answer questions. He wants the arithmetic to close. He fears it will.

SISTER MAEVE CORD OF THE UNCUT

Mother of Cords, forty-one, tall, broad-hipped and deep-voiced, still joined to her mother by thirty yards of living cord that loops behind her on a wicker carriage pushed by two Grafted acolytes. Her mother has been dead for six years. The cord has not noticed. It still pulses, still warm, and her mother's body, bricked in a long low tomb in Cordway with a slot left for the cord, has not decayed. Maeve leads the Uncut with great warmth and great stubbornness. She feels, through the cord, things she will not name.

MAEVE CORD – MOTHER OF CORDS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Endure 4, Persuade 4, Brawl 3, Godsign 3, Rites 3
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 15 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	cord-lash +6 (3, Grappling; a grappled target shares her pain and hears her mother's heartbeat, Dread 2)
GIFTS	Shared Blood (may transfer up to 4 Flesh of damage to anyone joined by cord); Root-Sense (knows when a pang is coming a full day ahead).
WANTS	Join (cannot bear to let anyone she loves be alone in a room).
DREAD	2
SECRET	Her mother is not dead. She is the Uncut's oldest Root, and her cord ends, not in her tomb, but in the ground beneath it.

UNCUT CORD-KIN Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (cord-lash 2, Grappling) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

MARSHAL GIDEON BREECH

Commander of the border, fifty-six, iron-grey, a former Foundling drill-mother turned soldier, with a face like an old saddle and a stillness people mistake for patience. His men check every traveler leaving for signs of carrying. He has turned back two thousand, and once let one through. He has never said why. Secret: she was his daughter, carrying, and the Tally of that year shows a birth at Breech's Gate to a woman in the Fatlands. He has never asked what was born.

PETRA QUICK

A smuggler of thirty-eight, lean and freckled, quick-tongued, Rim Road-born, who runs expectant mothers across the border so they can deliver somewhere the rule does not hold. It does hold, she has found. The country goes with them: across the Rim, in a Fatlands barn or an Oathen cave, the ground under the birthing woman turns warm and red. Petra keeps running them anyway, because they ask, and because once, in Brinehollow, it worked, and she would like very much to know why.

PETRA QUICK Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (knife 2, crossbow 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

QUEEN DOWAGER SIBYL AUBREY, AND THE KING WITHIN

She has been carrying the heir for forty-four years. She is ninety, hugely swollen, very tired, borne on a padded litter by eight women, and gracious in the vague way of the long-exhausted. The King Within, Aldous the Ninth, rules by kicks: one for yes. The Chamberlain reads the questions. She is the only person who knows that he has recently begun to answer questions nobody asked: three

kicks, then one, then three, at night, over and over. She thinks he is counting the interval. She thinks he is counting down.

DR. LAZAR VOSS

A visiting anatomist from the Vigil, sleepless and precise, forty-four, with bloodshot lidless-trained eyes, a rattle of rouse-pills in his pocket, and impeccable manners. He has examined two hundred Parts and drawn the figure they would make. It has more than two of several things. His drawings show something that is not human and is not the Assemblers' Herself either: a shape with hands at the end of every limb, doors in its chest, and a head that is mostly mouth. He is selling copies to the Second Table. He has begun to dream, which a man of the Vigil should not survive.

JUNIPER DELL, CALLED FIRSTWORD

A girl of eight from Tarnbrow, small and solemn, who was born saying half a sentence and has never said anything else: "When it opens, tell them that the..." She says it in the morning, and when frightened, and when asked her name. Somewhere in the highlands, she is sure, there is someone born with the other half. She writes and draws normally; what she draws is always doors. She is cared for by her mother and closely watched, without her mother's knowledge, by the Assemblers.

OLD HINGE, KEEPER OF THE SILL

He tends the standing door on the hill, oils it, and measures the gap. He is perhaps eighty, bent and bald, with knuckles like walnuts, and he lives in a turf hut a hundred paces downhill with his back to the door. He has never looked through it. He says he does not need to, because most nights something on the other side describes the view: a long room, warm, with a table laid, and a great many chairs, and one of them pulled out. He tells it to visitors in a pleasant dry voice. He fears the night it stops describing and asks him to come and see.

NEW CHARACTERS

WENNA THRALE, THE APPRENTICE

Twenty, freckled, red-knuckled from the laundries, apprentice to Sabeth Thorne in her third year of the apron. She wrote the testimony that opens this chapter. She keeps, against all rule, a list of the struck-through she has carried, with a name she gave each one on the walk to the Low Wall. There are thirty-one. She wants to be an Opinion. She is afraid that she will be good at it.

LORD CASIMIR MORWEN, THE CONSORT

Husband of the Duchess Iphigene, forty-seven, veiled like her, slender, soft-spoken, with exquisite manners and a perfume of orris and something sour beneath. He is a Morwen born; the Cutwrights' locked volume records his parentage in shorthand beside hers, and nobody at Morwen Hall would dream of asking what it says. He is deep in the Course and carries more than his wife does. He wants an heir with a thicker veil than any before. He fears he has already borne it, and that the nurses did not take it away.

ABSALOM GAGE, THE BRICKLAYER

The chief mason of the Stillyard, sixty, white with lime-dust, deaf in both ears, with a trowel worn to a sliver. For forty years he has bricked the dead and the condemned and, nightly, the cautious of Kest into their rooms; he knows who sleeps where better than the Tally does. He has begun to hear knocking from inside walls he laid, which, being deaf, he should not. He knocks back. He does not tell anyone what the knocks say.

TAMSIN GORSE, THE STITCH-MENDER

A surgeon of thirty-six who runs the Reopening Ward at Kest, where old soldiers, cut-for-stone widows and Barren brothers come

each morning after a pang to be sewn up. Brisk, cheerful, gallows-witted, smelling of spirit and catgut. Last month her own childhood scar, from a fall on a hay-hook, opened during a pang, and in the mirror she saw an eye looking out of it. She closed it with nine stitches. She checks it hourly.

FACTOR MERRIAM TOLL OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

The Company's buyer at Breech's Gate, fifty, stout, owlsh and courteous, from Oathen originally, conditional in all her speech. She buys highland cauls by the crate for export to Brinehollow, where one sewn into a sailor's coat is believed to stop the Calling; she pays well and asks nothing. Lately the Caul-lines have been selling her their own. She has noticed that the cauls arriving now are warm when they are packed, and warmer when they arrive.

ATTENDANCE OPINION Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +7 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

BORDER MARSHAL Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 14 · Attack +6 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

ASSEMBLER GATHERER Threat 2 · Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (hook 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

CRAWLING PART (SPINE, HAND OR WORSE) Threat 1 · Flesh 4 · Guard 13 · Attack +3 (grip 1, Grappling) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

A GATHERING (PARTS THAT HAVE FOUND EACH OTHER, IN THE DARK) Threat 3 · Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Attack +6 (many grips 3, Grappling) · Armor 0 · Dread 3

▼ PLAYING A CRADLEWRACKER

You were born under the Two Questions. Somebody looked at you for the count of three and let you stay. You knock before you open anything, you carry needle and thread against the night, and you know the interval as well as your own name. Wherever you go on the Table, the doors drift open behind you.

Attribute bonus: +1 CAUL.

The Sop: Let It Out. Open something that was meant to stay shut: break into a bricked room, cut a stitch from a closed wound (yours or another's), unbar a door against its keeper's will, open a grave, or attend a birth to its end. Removes 1d6 Hunger. Each time, the god learns the way: the next closed thing you pass will ache at you until you open that too.

The Tooth. When you Partake, Vey begins in you. A low cramp rolls through your belly; the nearest door, lid, or knot within ten paces comes undone; your oldest scar turns pink and wet; the air smells of iron and warm salt. A Tooth showing 1 means the god bit

back as a contraction: you are doubled over and lose your next movement.

GIFTS

The Taste (Regrowth 1–3). Choose one.

- ◇ *Knock.* By laying your palm on any door, wall, lid or skin, you know whether something living is on the other side and roughly how big. Costs nothing; but everything on the other side knows you knocked.
- ◇ *First Breath.* Once per session, after any roll to begin something (the first attack of a fight, the opening line of a negotiation, the first step of a journey), you may reroll it. Something nearby that was shut opens.

The Appetite (Regrowth 4–6). Choose one.

- ◇ *Undoing.* By touch and a Partake, open any lock, knot, bar, seal, or stitched wound, with no roll. Bricking resists: Godsign vs Grim 18.
- ◇ *Rehearsal.* During a pang or a fight you may enter false labor deliberately: for the scene you ignore Ruin from the Mangling table (take the Injury but do not collapse) and add +2 to Endure rolls, then gain 2 Hunger and are helpless for an hour afterward.

The Course (Regrowth 7–9). Choose one.

- ◇ *Bear.* Once per session, after a day of carrying, deliver a Part that serves you: a hand that Filches at Threat 3, an ear that hears through walls, an eye that watches while you sleep. Its loyalty lasts until it meets another Part. Every delivery is Dread 2 for witnesses, and the Attendance wants to know about it.
- ◇ *What Is Opened Once.* With a Partake and a touch, reopen every healed wound a target has ever had: 1 Flesh per Injury they carry plus 1d6, ignoring Armor. Your own scars open in sympathy; lose 2 Flesh.

The Brink (Regrowth 10–11). You are crowning. Somewhere on your body is a soft round opening that cannot be closed, and something in it is pressing toward the light.

- ◇ *Crowning.* Once per scene, the thing within may push forth to act for you: a single attack at +9 (4), a single answer to a question about what is beginning, or a single door opened anywhere you can see. Each use is Dread 3 for anyone watching, including you, and adds 2 Hunger.

THE WANTS

Resisted with Caul + Resolve at the listed difficulty when triggered.

- ◇ **Leave It Open** (Taste onward, Routine 10; Hard 14 at the Appetite). Trigger: shutting a door, a box, a book, or a wound behind you. You simply do not.
- ◇ **Attend** (Appetite onward, Hard 14). Trigger: hearing or learning of a birth within a mile. You go, and you stay until the end.
- ◇ **Begin** (Appetite onward, Hard 14). Trigger: being offered a plan, a road, a quarrel, a bargain. You start it at once, before anyone has finished speaking.
- ◇ **Gather** (Course onward, Grim 18). Trigger: a Part, or a wound, or a severed piece of anything living. You must keep it, and you must bring it close to the others.

THE SEATING

At Regrowth 12 a Cradlewracker does not become a place, as Fatlanders do, or a Hush, as the Hand-lines do. You hear the interval in your own body and it is the land's. You walk home, whatever your road, and you walk to the Dilation, and the ground opens to let you down. You go into the red, into the warm, and you are gone from play. At the GM's choice, something comes back up some

pangs later: born-grown, with your face and none of your memories, or with all your memories and someone else's face, and it asks the watchers at the rim what year it is. Players who have lost a character this way may meet them again in the Adversaries chapter, wearing whatever is coming.

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **The Apprentice Who Quit.** You held the door for your first Second Opinion and ran. You still have the stitching kit and the dreams. The Attendance remembers you, and wants you back in the room. (Stitching, Resolve, Instinct.)
- ◇ **Foundling Soldier.** Born grown, mid-stride, four or five years ago. You can strip a crossbow blind but you cried when you first saw snow. You do not know who bore you and you do not know when you will go home. (Blades, Endure, Wayfaring.)
- ◇ **Grafted to the Uncut.** You took the cord as an adult, for love or penance, and you can feel your adopted family's pulse a hundred miles away. When you leave Cradlewrack, the cord stretches. It has not snapped yet. (Endure, Persuade, Godsign.)
- ◇ **Caul-line Cadet.** A minor child of a veiled house, born with a caul that came off, which makes you a disgrace and a free woman. You still see a little forward, blurred and red. (Instinct, Clause, Rites.)

HIGHLAND NAMES

Female: Orla, Sabeth, Hester, Lark, Madder, Agnes, Dolour, Ede, Ada, Maeve, Petra, Sibyl, Juniper, Wenna, Tamsin, Merriam, Hollan, Edda, Bryony, Clemency, Rowan, Isolde, Nettle, Una.

Male: Dov, Callum, Josiah, Rufus, Gideon, Ambrose, Absalom, Casimir, Corran, Abel, Aldous, Tibb, Hugh, Eamon, Pell, Lorne, Tobin, Gerent.

Neutral or chosen by the born-grown: Ninety, Lettered, Keep, Bit, Small, Opening, Firstword, Wick, Stay, Ashe, Notyet.

Surnames (from mothers, places, or trades): Kest, Thorne, Lowe, Marrin, Stillwater, Rudge, Fenn, Latch, Morwen, Pym, Crewe, Ochre, Cord, Breech, Aubrey, Dell, Thrale, Gage, Gorse, Furrow, Corse, Calloway, Seele, Danner, Tarnbrow, Clayhand, Knocker, Lintel, Hinge.

HORRORS OF CRADLEWRACK

Roll a d20 when the party travels the highlands, rests in a Cradlewrack house, or lingers too long near something shut. Each is a scene, not a fight, though some become one.

D20 HORROR	
1	You wake with the door of your bricked room standing open. The bricks are stacked neatly in the corridor. Something wet has walked through the dust toward your bed and back.
2	A farmhouse lambing: eleven lambs, each with a small human hand at the end of one foreleg. All eleven hands reach for the same character. (Dread 2.)
3	A man at the roadside in false labor, alone, counting aloud. He asks you to count with him. The interval he gives does not match the land's. It is shorter.
4	The well in the village square has crowned. Its rim is soft and warm. Something is coming up the rope hand over hand, and it is knocking on the stones as it climbs.
5	Your oldest scar reopens in the night, and through it you hear, very faintly, a voice reciting the Tally. Your own name is on it, entered today. (Dread 3.)
6	An unattended birth in a ditch: a girl of fifteen, alone, terrified, and a Border Marshal riding up the lane. What she has borne is small and breathing and looks at you with your mother's eyes.
7	A Stillyard wall at dusk, knocking from the inside, three knocks, steady, in the niche of someone who was bricked last week. The family is already there, sitting below it, deciding whether to answer.
8	A crawling spine in the bedding, warm, seeking another Part. It has found one: the hand of a party member, which it is trying to fit itself to.
9	A Barren procession on the road, grey-robed, singing the names of the struck-through. The sutures of one brother have opened in the cold and he is walking on, bleeding, singing louder.
10	Every lock, buckle and knot on the party comes undone at once. Packs spill. Armor slides off. Down the slope, something laughs like a child who has just learned to.
11	A pang strikes while you are crossing a ravine. Sixty seconds. The waters rise through the turf around your boots, warm, salt, red at the edges, and things are carried up in it.
12	An old-born child, three years old, white-haired and dying of age, asks you to tell him a story from his childhood. He means one that has not happened.
13	A Caul-line litter passes, curtains drawn. From inside comes a sound of labor and, behind it, someone else's calm voice saying "again, my love, again."
14	A born-grown man stumbles out of the fog naked and slick, mid-sentence, finishing an argument with someone none of you can see. He knows one of you by name.
15	A Part-hunter's wagon, crates labelled by village, every one rattling. One crate is labelled with the name of the inn you slept in last night.
16	The Uncut pass overhead on their roof-cords; one cord brushes your face, and for a moment you feel the heartbeat at its far end. It stops. Somewhere a long way off, a woman screams.
17	A woman four days dead goes into labor on her bier while the masons are at their tea. The Attendance has not yet arrived. You are in the room. (Dread 3.)
18	A door stands in an open field, no wall around it, ajar a finger's width. It was not there yesterday. Through the gap you smell bread.
19	You find yourself standing in a doorway at dawn, arms spread to the jambs, with no memory of rising. Your companions have been watching you for an hour and did not dare to wake you.
20	The whole party feels it at once: a long, slow roll low in the belly, rising, rising. Men, women, all of you. It passes. The ground beneath you rises and falls exactly in time. (Dread 4.)



CHAPTER 8

OATHEN

Say less.

– THE WHOLE OF OATHEN’S LAW, AS TAUGHT TO CHILDREN

*The canyon does not forget a word. Neither does the thing beneath it. Speak as though
you will be quoted, because you will.*

– INSCRIPTION OVER THE LESSER GATE OF TACIT, CARVED WITHOUT A SINGLE
VERB

RECORD OF A LAWFUL DISSOLUTION, kept by the undersigned clerk of the Bench of Clauses, in the Ninth Room beneath the Ledger, on the eleventh day of Carving, 640 A.G. The condemned: Aubin Sele, cooper, convicted of selling the same cask twice under oath. Present: the condemned, the Breaker Jude Crake, the clerk (bitted, writing only), one Surety-witness (bitted). The hour-glass is turned at the first word.

CRAKE: Good evening, Master Sele. No, sit, the chair is for you. I brought figs. You needn’t eat them. I only thought the room wanted something sweet in it.

SELE: (says nothing for the space of nine grains)

CRAKE: You’ve been told what I am. That’s all right. People always have. I’m not going to touch you, and nothing in this room is sharp, and the door is not locked. You may check it. (The condemned does not check it.) I’m told you were a cooper. My father bent staves. I remember the smell of the steaming shed, the oak going soft. Is it true you can hear a bad cask?

SELE: If it’s dry. If you knock it. (He stops himself. He has said nothing binding. The clerk notes his relief, visible in the shoulders.)

CRAKE: That’s lovely. A ringing note, I’d guess, and a dead one where the split is. (Some minutes on staves, pitch, his wife’s cooking, the late rain. The condemned laughs once, at a story concerning a goat. The clerk notes that it is a good story.)

CRAKE: May I ask you something small? Your daughter. Wenna, isn’t it? She’s to be fostered with your sister in Low Dray. Would you like her told anything?

SELE: Tell her (stops) Tell her, if you’re able, that her father thought of her.

CRAKE: That’s beautifully put. The “if you’re able” is mine, not yours, so it costs you nothing. You’re careful. I admire careful. (The glass is at its quarter.) You’re shaking. Are you cold?

SELE: No.

(The clerk notes that the condemned is shaking, and that the room is warm, and that “No” in answer to a question of present fact is an assertion. A small sound, like a knuckle cracking, from the condemned’s jaw. A thin line of blood at the corner of the mouth. The condemned understands. He weeps. He does not cry out, which would be foolish.)

CRAKE: Oh, Aubin. I’m so sorry. It’s only a little lie. Everyone tells it. Here, the cloth. You’ll want to hold it under. Let’s not talk about cold. Let’s talk about Wenna. She’ll be frightened of me when she’s older, I expect. They’ll tell her stories. Will you do one thing for me, so I can tell her you were brave?

SELE: (nothing for a long time; the glass is at its half) What thing.

CRAKE: Only stop crying before the glass runs out. That’s all. So I can tell her.

SELE: I (stops) I’ll try.

CRAKE: That will do.

(The clerk notes that “I’ll try” is an oath of effort, the lightest there is, and that it is kept by trying. The condemned tries. He breathes slowly. He looks at the figs. The clerk notes that at the three-quarter mark he has very nearly stopped weeping, and that the Breaker is telling him, softly, about a girl he once saw in Low Dray who had red ribbon on her bit, and that perhaps it was Wenna, and that she looked well, and that she was holding the hand of a man who was not her uncle. The condemned asks what man. The Breaker says he didn’t see the face. The condemned asks again. The Breaker says it was probably no one. The condemned begins to weep again.)

CRAKE: Aubin. Aubin. You promised you’d try.

SELE: I am trying, I am, I swear I am

(The clerk records that the condemned has sworn to a present fact, which was true, and that the true oath holds. The clerk records that the condemned then stopped trying, because he was thinking only of the hand that was not his daughter’s uncle’s, and that a man cannot try and not try in the same breath, and that the god heard which one it was.)

(At this point the record becomes difficult to keep. The clerk sets down only what is required. The first Breaking was the tongue's, for the lie about the cold, and it worsened, the jaw separating at its hinge with the sound of a green branch. The second was apt to "I'll try" and opened him along the effort: the long muscles of both arms and the back, which split lengthwise like staves without a hoop. The third was apt to "I swear I am": the chest, at the breastbone, so that the clerk could see the condemned's heart moving and observe that it was trying very hard. None of these was fatal. The condemned remained aware throughout. The Breaker held his hand.)

(The glass ran out at the forty-first grain past the hour's mark. The condemned had ceased by then. It is the Breaker's first hour to exceed the hour. He asked that this be noted. He asked that it be noted also that he did not see any man in Low Dray, and that Wenna Sele is well, and that he lied about it, and that the lie cost him the nail of the smallest finger of his left hand, which came away in the cloth, and which he left with the figs.)

Sealed in silence. Witnessed. Filed.

▼ THE MEAL

WHAT TOLM WAS

Before the Gorging, Tolm, the Witness, sat at the head of the Gullet, the deepest gorge in the country, and listened. It was the size of a hill, shaped like a seated person drawn by someone who had only heard one described, with a bowed head as long as a barn and ears without number: great folded ones like bracket fungus on a dead oak, and small ones down its throat and the insides of its arms, opening and closing like the gills of fish. Its mouth was small and always closed. Its tongue, the chronicles say, was the color of raw liver and as long as a street.

Tolm did not command and did not bless. It heard. A vow spoken in its presence became a fact the way a stone dropped becomes a fall. Marriages were made at its knee; boundaries were walked in its hearing; a liar standing before it found the lie had been true all along, or found himself face down in the red dust with blood coming out of his ears. The people of the canyons loved it the way a court loves a scrupulous judge: with fear, with gratitude, and with the steady low resentment of those who can never quite be off the record.

THE SILENT SUPPER

In the ninth winter of the Lack, the canyon people came to the Gullet with knives, and they came in silence, because they knew exactly what would happen if they did not. Anything said in front of the Witness would count. A cry of pain would become a sentence. A prayer would become a contract. "Forgive us" would become a debt. So they did not speak. They had spent a month practising, and the practice had a cost: a generation of hand-signs for butchery, a set of whistles agreed and then forbidden, the dry-throated discipline of a whole people learning to hold their tongues.

They began at dusk. The old account, carved on the Ledger in the year 12 A.G., records that Tolm did not move, but that every ear on its body turned toward the knives as they came, the great ones and the little ones, a sound like ten thousand pages turning at once.

The first incisions were made at the throat, where the flesh was softest. What came out was not blood but something thick and clear that smelled of wet slate and tasted, those who caught it on their lips said afterward in handtalk, of the moment after you have said a thing you cannot take back.

They worked for three nights. The god's skin was tough as harness leather, lined with a fat that mouthed the shapes of words when cut. Butchers wore wax in their ears and still came away with nosebleeds. The ears were taken first, because no one could bear to cut while they listened, and laid in rows on the canyon floor, where they went on twitching toward every footstep for a day and a half. Someone stepped on one. The sound it made was the sound of the person who had stepped on it, and it went up the canyon walls and came back, and that was the first echo anyone in Oathen was afraid of.

On the second night a woman named Deverel Ashe slipped in the slick and laid her forearm open to the bone; she knelt with her teeth clamped on her sleeve until her jaw cracked, and made no sound. Near the fires, a small child woke in its mother's arms and began to laugh at the flames. The carving says only that the mother held the child close for a long time, until it was quiet; that those nearest saw and did not stop her; that she sat with the bundle in her lap until dawn and then went back to work. Her name is not on the Ledger. Her line is: the Hushwell Tongue-line, among the highest in the land, whose crest is a closed hand over an open mouth.

The tongue was taken on the third night. It took forty people to draw it out from behind the teeth, hand over hand like a hawser, and as it came Tolm's mouth opened for the first and last time anyone remembered. The god spoke once. Every person present heard it in a different voice, the voice of whoever had first taught them to talk, and every account gives the same two sentences: "Go on. I am listening."

They went on. The families who ate the tongue, raw, in slices that kept curling in their hands, became the Tongue-lines, the nobility of Oathen. The ears were boiled and eaten by the canyon

clans of the upper gorges, whose descendants are said to hear too well; the great slow heart went to the Rain-keepers of the high basin; the scraps and the clear fluid went to the poor, who licked it off the stone and were Scraplings ever after. The bones were rolled into the Gullet and are there still, under a floor of red sand, and the canyon above them is the quietest place in a quiet country.

In the morning the Lack ended, as it ended everywhere. In Oathen, the first thing anyone said aloud was said by a herdsman's son who found green shoots on the canyon rim and shouted, "It's over, I swear it's over!" It was. The boy's word was the first oath of the Long Grace, and it was kept. He lived to be ninety and never said anything again with quite that much confidence.

THE TWO SENTENCES

Theologians on the Bench of Clauses have spent six centuries arguing the grammar of Tolm's last words. "Go on" is permission, or command, or encouragement, or a sigh. "I am listening" is a statement of present fact, and the god of true speech could not make a false one, which means that at the moment it was being eaten it was listening, and the question that has never been settled is when, if ever, it stopped. The Theft doctrine reads it as a sentence: we are watched until we pay. The Gift doctrine reads it as forgiveness: go on, eat, live. The Bait doctrine, illegal in Oathen since 290 A.G., reads it the plainest way of all. The god said it was listening. It has not said that it has stopped.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

WORDS BIND FLESH

In Oathen, a promise is a physical fact. Keep it and nothing happens. Break it and the body breaks to match: at once, with a sound, in a shape that fits the word. A man who swore to stand by his brother and ran had both legs fold under him backwards, the knees bending the wrong way like a heron's, and he lay in the road with his brother walking on without him. A woman who promised her heart to one man and gave it to another was found with her chest opened like a cupboard, the ribs swung outward on their cartilage like doors, the heart inside beating, entirely visible, entirely hers.

The Breaking is always apt and never by itself fatal. Tolm was a witness, not an executioner. What the god does to the forsworn is not punishment so much as testimony: it makes the body tell the truth that the mouth failed to. The broken live on, often for decades, as the Forsworn, and you can read a person's moral history from across the street. A merchant with no hands cheated someone. A woman whose lips have split back to the ears told a lie that mattered. A soldier with a spine bent like a hook swore to bear something and set it down. The canyons are full of these histories walking.

It does not have to be solemn. "I'll be back before dark" is an oath. "I'd die for you" is an oath. "I'll never forgive you" is an oath, and the man who swore it to his father and then, at the old man's deathbed, wept and took his hand, had his own hand turn to the consistency of wet bread in his father's grip. A child's "I promise" binds exactly as hard as a king's. The god does not weigh station. It weighs meaning.

WHAT COUNTS

The Bench of Clauses has spent six hundred years defining what Tolm counts, and its definitions fill the four miles of the Ledger and

a library besides. In practice, the canyon folk know the rule in their bones, because the ones who did not know it are no longer whole:

- ◇ A promise binds. Any statement that commits the speaker to a future act, a future state, or an abstention ("I will", "I won't", "I'll be there", "never", "always", "you can count on me").
- ◇ A lie breaks at once. A spoken assertion the speaker believes to be false is a broken oath the instant it is finished. The Breaking for a lie is nearly always the mouth: the lips, the tongue, the jaw, the teeth.
- ◇ A boast is a promise. "I could carry that alone" is heard as "I will carry it if asked." "Nothing could frighten me" is heard as a vow of courage, and the next thing that frightens the speaker will cost them.
- ◇ Meaning outweighs grammar. A sentence built to sound like a question but meant as a promise binds as a promise. Tolm heard what people meant, and it still does.
- ◇ Ignorance is no defense. An honest mistake about a fact (you said the well was dry, and you believed it, and it was not) is not a lie, but it is still a statement, and how the god will weigh it is a matter of furious debate. Most Oatheners do not risk it. They say "I believe the well is dry," which is true about them, rather than "the well is dry," which is a wager about the world.

HOW OATHENERS SPEAK

So Oatheners do not chat. They speak rarely, slowly and in conditionals, and they never, ever exaggerate. A polite sentence is mostly exits: "If able." "As I now intend." "Barring death, illness, or weather." "Unless the Bench rules otherwise." "In so far as I can see." A shopkeeper asked whether the bread is fresh says, "It was baked this morning, I am told." A mother asked by her child if she will come back says, "That is my wish," and the child, who is bitted and cannot reply, learns from the sentence everything the mother cannot promise.

Foreigners on the Rim Road find Oatheners cold and evasive. Oatheners find foreigners obscene: people who say “I’ll kill you” in jest and “I’ll love you forever” at the end of an evening, and walk away whole. To an Oathener a talkative stranger is a man juggling knives in a nursery.

GM ADVICE – RUNNING THE RULE AT THE TABLE

Oathen changes how players talk, and that is the point. Make it clear before play that in-character speech in Oathen is mechanically live: what a character says aloud is what the character has said. You are not trying to trap the players with grammar; you are letting them feel what it is to live in a country where every sentence might be a contract. Be generous in the first session. When a player says something binding by accident, pause and ask, “Is that what your character says, in those words?” Once they have felt the first Breaking land on someone else, stop asking. The best Oathen sessions are quiet ones, with long pauses before anyone answers a question, and players writing their character’s sentences down before they say them.

THE WITNESS IS INSIDE

Tolm was the god who listened. It is still listening, from the inside: from the blood of those who ate it, from the rock over its bones, from canyons that throw every word back. The Rule is not a law of nature but the attention of a god, and attention can sharpen and wander. It has begun to count things it never used to count: handtalk, a scribe’s chisel, perhaps, for the highest bloodlines, the silent words a person tells themselves at night. And because it is listening, it can be spoken to, which is what makes blasphemy in Oathen so dangerous (see Crime and Punishment).

And because it is listening, it can be spoken to. Blasphemy in Oathen is not an abstract offence. To curse Tolm aloud is to address a god that is present in your own throat, and the Bench’s records hold four hundred years of cases of what happens to people who do. Most of them went quiet afterward. Not all of them by choice.

▼ THE REGROWTH IN OATHEN

Tolm is growing back, and what grows back is a witness: an ear that hears too well, a tongue that says too truly. In the Tongue-lines it grows fastest. The Bench of Clauses is the most godsign-ridden body of people in the country, and the more powerful a family, the more carefully it chooses who is allowed to speak.

THE TASTE

It begins with the echo. You say something and, half a second later, you hear it again in your own voice, close behind your ear, slightly flatter, like someone reading it back for the record. At first it happens only in quiet rooms. Then everywhere. Children at the Taste whisper into cupped hands to hear whether it comes back. Adults learn to wait for it, and to listen to what they said with the god’s attention, and to wince.

Other tells follow: a taste of wet slate when a promise is made nearby; the ears ringing faintly whenever someone in the room lies; a habit of mouthing other people’s words along with them. Tongue-line children at the Taste are bitted early and watched closely, because the Taste is not dangerous, and the Appetite is.

THE APPETITE

The compulsion to swear. It comes on like a sneeze: a pressure in the throat, a heat behind the teeth, and then the words are out, vows on nothing, on everything. “I will walk to the sea.” “I will never eat bread again.” “I will have your eyes.” Sufferers wake in the night having sworn in their sleep and lie rigid, trying to remember what

they said, while the one who shares their bed lies equally rigid, trying not to have heard it.

The Appetite-struck must be gagged for their own safety, and in Oathen this is no metaphor. The iron bit of the Appetite is a heavy thing, hinged at the jaw, with a flat plate that presses the tongue down and a small grille for breath and broth. Families keep their swearers at home, bitted, hands bound when the urge is strong, because a determined swearer will try to sign or scratch vows into the plaster. The Murmuring House in Tacit holds three hundred of them, in rows, and the sound the place makes, three hundred people trying to promise through iron, is where it gets its name.

THE COURSE

At the Course, speech stops needing to be a promise to bind. Plain statements begin to come true. “The door is shut,” said of an open door, shuts it, or shuts something. “It’s cold,” said on a warm day, brings frost to the speaker’s lashes and nobody else’s. Figures of speech become fatal: a man who said he was starving was dead by evening, in a full pantry, his stomach shrunk to the size of a walnut. A Tongue-line girl who told her sister “you look like death” was a mourner within the week.

The body changes with it. The tongue thickens, darkens and lengthens until it rests against the bit even in repose, mottled the color of raw liver. A second voice develops beneath the first, a half-step lower, and sometimes it says the words a moment before the speaker does. The small ears come: puckers in the skin of the neck and shoulders and the inner arm, at first like scars from a pox, then

opening, pink and folded and perfectly formed, turning toward sound. Course-sufferers cannot bear crowds. Too much is said in them, and all of it is heard.

THE BRINK

At the Brink, the gap between saying and being narrows to nothing. A Brink-sufferer's ordinary speech reshapes the room they stand in: a careless "of course" makes a thing inevitable; a sigh of "everything's falling apart" has, on record, brought down a house. The bit is no longer optional. Brink Tongue-lines are taken from their families by the Bench and fitted with silver bits, and their hands are kept gloved and occupied, and they are not permitted pen or chisel. They go mad, often, because a mind full of things it may not say is a mind with no door out, and in Oathen a Break at the Brink is a public danger: a madman whose delusions are binding.

THE SEATING: THE SAYERS

A Tongue-line in the last stage does not describe the world. What they say, is. They are called the Sayers, and they are the closest thing the canyons have to Tolm walking again: not the god's ear but its mouth, the place where its witness turns into its word. The first was a girl in the Hushwell house who said "I wish it would stop" during

a storm in 598 A.G. It stopped. So did the wind, the river, the birds, and the hearts of everything in the valley of Low Shale, which is still there, intact, with nothing in it moving.

The few Sayers alive are kept bitted in gold, which is the one metal Tolm's mouth will not bite through, and locked in the Gilded Cells beneath the Ledger. They are unmuzzled rarely, on the Bench's vote, to say a single sentence the Clausewrights have drafted for months. The Bench calls this governance. The Sayers do not call it anything. Their faces, behind the gold, have grown long and smooth, and their eyes have closed over with skin, and the small ears have covered them like moss.

THE SAYER'S GOLD

A Sayer's bit is a work of terrible craft: soft gold over a core of lead, cast to the exact shape of the mouth, with a tongue-plate that has to be resized every few months as the tongue grows. The Bitmaker Garl Tome fits them himself. The gold must be pure. A bit cut with copper was found, in 611 A.G., to have been bitten clean through overnight, and the Sayer it held had said one word into the dark of the Cells before the guards reached her. No one knows what the word was. The Gilded Cells were walled off for six weeks afterward, and the guard who came out first had no ears, and smiled.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

Oathen is dry red canyon country, deep and narrow, under a hard white sky. The plateau above is scrub and scoured stone; the life is below, in the cracks. Rivers run in the canyon floors, thin and green and fast, and the towns are cut into the cliff walls in tiers: dwellings, granaries, shrines and tombs, connected by ladders, rope-lifts and narrow stairs that wind up the rock like the thread of a screw. It is hot, still and extremely quiet. Sandals are soled with felt. Doors are hung on leather. Cart wheels are wrapped in rag. You can stand on a balcony in Tacit and hear a woman across the canyon draw water.

The great danger is echo. An oath repeated is an oath renewed, and a canyon will repeat anything. A man who swore in the narrows of the Sheath to pay a debt by the new Plate heard it come back nine times, and when he failed, he broke nine times, each Breaking landing on the last. Whole gorges are posted as silent, with stone hands carved at their mouths, palm out. Wind is feared for the same reason: a vow overheard is still a vow, and when the dry Carving wind called the Tattler comes up from the south, families sit in their inner rooms in silence until it drops.

It rains once a year. Before it died, Tolm promised the canyons rain on the first day of Grace, and a god's word outlives the god. The Kept Rain has fallen on that day for six hundred and forty years: a single day's downpour, warm and heavy, that fills the cisterns, floods the canyon floors, and drowns the careless. The

whole country lives on that day's water. This year it came three days late.

PLACES IN OATHEN

TACIT

The capital, carved into both walls of the deepest canyon. Half a million people, and you can hear a sandal drop. The Sunward and Shadeward Walls face each other across two hundred rope bridges; the Tongue-lines live high on the Sunward side, and the Bench sits at its heart in the Hall of Conditions, a felt-lined chamber floored with sand so that nothing said there can echo. Markets run on handtalk and tally-sticks. The city smells of hot stone, goat, and the cedar oil the rich rub into their bits.

THE BREAKDOWNS

The slum of the Forsworn, on the canyon floor below Tacit, where the river runs green and the sun reaches for two hours a day. Here live the broken: men without hands, women with mouths opened back to the ear, people walking on legs that bend the wrong way, people whose ribs stand open under oiled cloth. It is the loudest place in Oathen, because the people in it have nothing left to lose. They swear constantly, defiantly, on broken parts that cannot break again. They sing. They mock the Walls overhead. Their lanes are

named for the oaths their founders broke: Fair Weight Row, Back-Before-Dark, the Never Alley.

SWORN GORGE

A sealed ravine east of Tacit where an oath shouted in 419 A.G. has never stopped echoing. Anyone who hears it is bound by it. Nobody knows any longer what it says. The mouth of the gorge is walled with dressed stone forty feet high, and the wall is packed behind with wool, and still, on the stillest nights, a man pressing his ear to it can hear a murmur in the rock like a crowd a mile off, rising and falling. The Echo-Wardens keep a post at the wall. They wear wax and lead plugs in their ears and communicate by touch, and they rotate every nine days, because the murmur gets into you anyway.

THE LEDGER

A cliff face four miles long into which every vow of public record has been carved: treaties, marriages, sentences, Rim Road contracts, the oaths of kings. The oldest carvings at its western end are worn nearly smooth; the newest, at the eastern end, are still pale with fresh dust. Scaffolds hang from the cliff top, and the carvers work on them in all weathers, in silence. Behind the face, inside the rock, lies a warren of record-rooms and copying halls, and below that, the Ninth Room, where executions are conducted, and below that, the Gilded Cells.

THE GILDED CELLS

Where the Sayers are kept: a vault of nine chambers cut deep under the Ledger and lined in beaten lead and felt, with doors of gold-faced iron. Three of the cells are occupied. The guards are bitted and deafened by surgery. A Clausewright of the Bench visits once a week to inspect the bits and does not stay long.

THE GULLET (NEW)

The gorge where Tolm was eaten, at the head of the river system west of Tacit. Its floor is deep red sand over the god’s bones, and it is the quietest place in Oathen: sound does not carry here, but sinks, as if into a pillow. Pilgrims walk the Gullet barefoot on Tablenight eve. Those who put their ear to the sand hear, they say, a slow sound like breathing; the Bench rules that what they hear is the river. The sand is hot all year, and it is getting warmer.

THE UNMADE ROAD (NEW)

A switchbacked track down from Wending Pass, in the high eastern canyons, where Captain Renn Hold’s regiment came apart in 627

A.G. Four hundred soldiers swore to hold the pass to the death, obeyed an order to retreat, and broke on the road behind their captain. Their remains were never cleared. The bone along the road is still sorted, roughly, into the shapes of men lying where they fell, and the drovers who use the road walk their animals in single file down the center of it. Renn Hold is still at the top of the pass. He has to be.

THE MURMURING HOUSE (NEW)

A hospital and asylum on the Shadeward Wall of Tacit for the Appetite-struck and the Brink-mad who have no family to keep them. Three hundred patients, bitted in iron, in long low wards. The nurses work with wax in their ears and feed their charges thin broth through the grille of the bit. The sound of the place is a ceaseless, thick, wet humming: three hundred vows attempted and not finished.

THE WITNESSING VAULTS (NEW)

The catacombs beneath Tacit, where the dead stand upright in niches, faces outward, to witness. Families come here to swear on the dead, and the Vaults’ keepers, the Keeners, are the only people in Oathen who have heard the dead speak (see Oaths on the Dead).

QUILLHOUSE (NEW)

The Rim Road Company’s notarial house on the Oathen stretch of the Rim, three days’ ride north of Tacit. A fortress of pale stone, gated, garrisoned by Company guards, and home to Jessamy Quill. Every Company contract on the Table is carried here by courier, read aloud before her, and sworn. The waiting-hall is always full: Fatlands renderers, Brinehollow admirals’ factors, Vigil oil-buyers, all made to sit in silence in a long felted room while an Oathen clerk explains, in handtalk and on slate, that anything they say from here on counts.

LOW SHALE (NEW)

The valley the First Sayer stopped in 598 A.G. Everything in it stopped: water standing in the riverbed in a single hard green ribbon that will not run if you cup it, birds hanging in the air a foot above the ground, a herdsman mid-stride with his crook raised, his eyes wet and open after forty-three years. Nothing rots. Nothing moves. The air is warm and has no smell at all. The Bench has posted it as silent and forbids entry. Pilgrims of the Bait doctrine sneak in to leave written prayers at the herdsman’s feet. The herdsman’s eyes have been seen to follow them.

▼ HISTORY

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Silent Supper. Tolm eaten in the Gullet over three nights without a word.
3	The First Breaking. A merchant sworn to fair dealing shorts a customer; his hands come off at the wrist in the market.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
12	The first vows carved on the Ledger, beginning with the account of the Supper.
3–215	The Honest Age. Oathen the most trusted nation on the Table.
61	The Rim Road Company swears its charter at Tacit.
148	The Sureties' Compact. Oath-carrying becomes a licensed trade.
215	The Muzzling. All children bitted until the age of twelve.
221	Handtalk codified by the Bench and declared not to bind.
240	The Quiet founded by Abbess Hollin Mure, who took the knife to her own tongue.
290	The Bait doctrine outlawed in Oathen.
330	The Mute Succession. The crown restricted to those who have never spoken.
419	The oath in Sworn Gorge. The gorge walled the following spring.
422	The Echo-Wardens chartered.
506	The Forsworn Riots. The Breakdowns rise; Tacit's lower bridges are cut.
582	Little Rue promises her mother she will never grow up.
598	The First Sayer. Low Shale is stopped. The Gilded Cells are dug.
610	Ket the Ninth born mute in the Hushwell line, chosen in infancy.
627	Wending Pass. Captain Renn Hold's four hundred come apart.
638	Lady Imre Dath enters the Seating.
640	Mirren Osk's fingers break over a handtalk poem. Ottoline Vant's miscut.
641	The Kept Rain falls three days late.

THE HONEST AGE

For two centuries after the Supper, Oathen was the conscience of the Table. Other lands discovered they had swallowed monstrous gifts; Oathen discovered it had swallowed honesty, and sold it. A treaty sworn in Tacit could not be broken without the signatories' bodies breaking too; a merchant house that swore its weights at the Ledger could be trusted to the crumb. Oathen grew rich on notarizing the world. The canyon cities filled with foreign envoys learning to keep quiet.

It was not a kind age. Children broke constantly on promises they did not understand, and the cemeteries of the period are full of small, oddly shaped bones. In 215 A.G. the Bench passed the Muzzling, and the canyons have been quiet in a new way since: the silence of the nursery.

THE MUTE SUCCESSION

The old kings spoke, and every word bound them. By 330 A.G. King Orrel the Fourth had sworn so many coronation oaths and treaty-clauses that he ruled his last years from a litter, his body folded into what his physicians called an exact map of his reign's contradictions. Thereafter the crown passed only to children who

had never spoken. Nine such kings have reigned, and all died with their silence intact.

THE OATH IN SWORN GORGE

In the drought summer of 419 A.G., something was shouted in a narrow ravine east of Tacit, and the ravine has never stopped saying it. The records of that year are incomplete: a page is cut from the Bench's minutes and a stretch of the Ledger has been chiselled smooth, very carefully, in a way that took weeks. What is known is that the people of the hamlet of Sowe, at the gorge's mouth, were all found broken the following spring, every one of them, in the same way, and that the shape of the Breaking was so terrible that the Echo-Wardens' charter forbids its description. The gorge was walled. The murmur goes on.

WENDING PASS

In 627 A.G. Reckoners out of the Fast came through the eastern canyons, and the four hundred soldiers of the Fourth Regiment of the Canyon Watch swore, in the old form, to hold Wending Pass to the death. Captain Renn Hold looked at the raiders and at his men, most of them nineteen, and ordered them to fall back. He kept his own oath by staying. They broke theirs by obeying. The sound came down the road like a rockfall, four hundred Breakings in a

breath, each soldier opening at every joint by which he had bound himself to the place. They did not die of it, not at once. The Reckoners found the captain alone at the top with his sword drawn,

looked at the road below him, and went back the way they had come.

▼ RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

Oathen is ruled by the Mute Kings, chosen in infancy, bitted for life, and raised to rule by gesture. The present king, Ket the Ninth, has never made a sound. Beneath him sits the Bench of Clauses, forty-one lawyer-priests called Clausewrights, whose art is the drafting of promises that can survive contact with reality. In theory the Bench interprets the king. In practice the king nods, and the Bench spends a month in forty-page conditionals deciding what the nod meant, and then does what it would have done anyway.

There are no prisons. There is no need. A convicted person is made to swear the terms of their own sentence: “I will not leave the district of Low Dray for nine years.” “I will pay the widow one lack a day until my death.” “I will not speak again.” Breach the sentence and the body enforces it. The Bench’s chief tool of government is therefore not the sword but the clause, and its great fear is the sentence badly drafted, which leaves a convict free, or the sentence too well drafted, which kills him in a way the court did not intend. For the gravest crimes there is the Breaker, Jude Crake, who carries out death sentences with nothing but conversation.

Trials are simple. In a Breaking trial, presided over by Judge Thane Urow, there is no evidence and no testimony. The accused repeats the promise they are alleged to have broken, aloud, in its original words, and the court watches. If they kept it, nothing happens. If they broke it, it breaks them again, now, in front of everyone. For crimes that are not oaths (theft, murder, arson), the accused is asked a single question: “Did you do it?” and must answer. A Forsworn who has nothing left to break in the mouth is a

problem the Bench has never solved, which is why the Breakdowns are, to Tacit’s lasting horror, the one place in Oathen where a person can lie.

Oathen’s power abroad is trust. Every other government sends its treaties east to be made real, and the Rim Road Company swears every contract before its notary, Jessamy Quill. Oathen charges a tithe on every sworn page, and has never needed an army larger than its notaries. It has one anyway, the Canyon Watch, small and very well disciplined, because a soldier who has sworn to obey cannot do otherwise. Since Wending Pass, the Watch’s oath has been redrafted. It now runs to eleven pages, and the phrase “to the death” has been removed.

POLITICS IN A SENTENCE

- ◇ The Bench wants the Kept Rain explained before the Tablenight silence ends, and has three drafts of a Sayer’s sentence ready.
- ◇ The Forsworn want the Breakdowns made a free city, with its own Bench of the broken, and they have the numbers to cut Tacit’s bridges again.
- ◇ The Rim Road Company wants Jessamy Quill kept whole at any cost, because if she breaks, half the trade of the Table comes unbound.
- ◇ The Tongue-lines want an heir with a voice, and some of them want a Sayer of their own.
- ◇ The king wants to say something. He has wanted to for thirty-one years.

▼ CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

SPEECH AND SILENCE

- ◇ Handtalk. A sign language used for everything that matters little: prices, directions, the weather, gossip, jokes, flirtation. It is held not to bind. That belief is being tested, and fingers have started breaking.
- ◇ The bit. Children wear a soft leather muzzle until twelve, decorated by their parents with beads, ribbons and family marks. Having it removed is the coming of age, the Unbitting, and the first words spoken afterward are chosen with a Clausewright present. They are usually a family motto, or “I am here,” which is safe.

- ◇ Conditional speech. “If able.” “As I now intend.” “Barring death, illness, or weather.” A polite sentence is mostly exits.
- ◇ Proverbs. Oathen proverbs are short and verbless where possible: “Fewer words, more fingers.” “A full mouth, an empty hand.” “The canyon keeps the change.” “Listen twice.” “Say it to the dead, pay it to the living.” “Better bitted than broken.”

FOOD, DRINK AND DRESS

Oatheners eat goat, canyon lizard, flatbread baked on hot stones, dried figs, and a sour green cheese aged in the river caves. Water is life and law: every household’s cistern-share is sworn yearly at the Rain Shrine, and stealing water is the only theft the Bench treats as a crime against the god. Meals are eaten in silence; the grace “Lack

keep away” is signed, not said, unless there are foreigners at the table, in which case it is said very slowly with three exits attached. Wine is rare and feared, because drunkenness makes promises.

Dress is plain and close-fitting, in dust-red and ochre wool, with long sleeves to hide what broke. The Tongue-lines wear high collars and veils across the mouth, white for the unwed, black for those whose vows are many. Rings are worn on the thumbs as reminders of oaths outstanding: a ring per vow, so that a man’s hands tell you how much he owes. The Forsworn go bare where they broke, as a point of pride.

MARRIAGE AND KIN

Marriage vows are negotiated for months and run to forty pages, covering fidelity, property, illness, absence, the care of each other’s dead, and what counts as “cherishing.” Divorce does not exist: a marriage vow cannot be unsworn, only broken, and its Breaking is the chest opened to the air. What the faithless do, and what the vows forbid in their thicket of clauses, the canyon decently does not discuss aloud. The Tongue-lines marry cousin to cousin to keep the god’s tongue in the family, and some old houses have married so close for so long that their children are born with mouths sealed over with skin, and must be cut open before they can feed.

CHILDREN

Children are bitted from the first tooth until twelve. They grow up in handtalk, which they speak faster and more inventively than adults, with a whole private slang of nursery signs. The bit is soft and does not hurt, but it shapes the face: Oathen adults have a groove worn at the corners of the mouth, and some of the old bits, family heirlooms, have been worn by six generations of children and taste of all of them. Every parent in the country carries one fear above all others: that their child will say something before twelve, in the instant the bit is off for cleaning. Some do. The Bench records the Breakings of children only by number. The number this year is higher than last.

DEATH AND THE DEAD

The dead are entombed upright in the Witnessing Vaults, faces outward, so that they may witness the oaths of the living. Before a body is set in its niche, the family gathers and speaks every promise they made to the dead person in life, and the Keener asks the corpse, formally, whether each was kept. The dead do not answer. Usually. A death in Oathen also releases the dead person’s oaths, which is why heirs sometimes wait at a bedside very patiently, and why the Bench has drafted a clause, standard in all wills, binding the heirs to have hoped for recovery.

Oaths sworn on the dead are the heaviest in the land: a hand on the bones, the dead one’s name, the vow said into the niche. They

are used for blood feuds, for marriages across feuding families, for debts too large for any Surety. When such an oath breaks, the dead person answers for Tolm, and what the dead do then is the stuff of every Oathen ghost story, and all of them are true.

FESTIVALS

- ◇ The Kept Rain (first day of Grace). The whole country stands in the open, faces up, mouths bitted, and the rain comes. Children take their first swim. Lovers make the year’s vows in the downpour, when the noise of it hides the words from the canyon. This year, for three days, the whole country stood and waited, and the sky stayed white.
- ◇ The Unbitting (Plenty). Twelve-year-olds have their bits removed in public, in the Hall of Conditions, and speak their first chosen words. Families weep, silently.
- ◇ The Carving of the Year (Carving). The new vows of public record are cut into the Ledger. Carvers work through the night by lamplight, and the town watches from the canyon floor.
- ◇ Tablenight (longest night of Lack). Twenty-four hours in which no one in the country makes a sound. Shops close. Bells are tied. Babies are nursed constantly. It is the only day Oatheners feel safe, and the happiest day of the year.

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

Every crime in Oathen is either an oath broken or a question waiting to be asked: a convict swears a sentence, a debtor a schedule, and a murderer, if the crime is grave, receives Jude Crake. Blasphemy, the cursing of Tolm aloud, is not punished by the Bench at all; it is merely recorded, as Tolm will see to it. Of forty-one blasphemers entered in the record since the Muzzling, thirty-nine were found the next morning with their tongues gone, not cut but missing, as if never grown, and their mouths full of fine red sand. The other two were Sayers. No one has entered their sentences in the record.

▼ FACTIONS

THE BENCH OF CLAUSES

The Clausewrights: rulers in practice, and the finest contract lawyers who have ever lived. They train for twenty years in the drafting of vows, in the reading of Tolm's past judgments on the Ledger, and in the art of speaking a whole day without committing

to anything. They believe that the Rule is law and that law can be perfected: that somewhere there is a sentence so well drafted that it binds exactly what is intended and nothing more. They want order, the Rain explained, the Sayers kept, and their own power left untouched. They fear the Forsworn, the widening of what counts, and their own Tongue-line blood, which is the most advanced in the land.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Slate-Clerk	Copies drafts; access to the Bench's lower archives.
2	Under-Drafter	Drafts minor contracts; a fee of 5 lacks per sworn page.
3	Clausewright	Speaks before the Bench; may witness oaths in the king's name.
4	Bencher	A vote; a seat in the Hall of Conditions; access to the Ledger's sealed rooms.
5	Chief Clausewright	Interprets the king; drafts the Sayers' sentences.

A PC joins by passing the Examination of Exits (Tongue + Clause vs Grim, under a Clausewright's hostile questioning for a full day without a binding misstep). Enemies: the Forsworn, the Second Table's agents among the Tongue-lines. Allies: the Rim Road Company, the Cutwrights' College.

THE FORSWORN

The broken. They live in the Breakdowns, organized, angry, and with very little left to lose. A Forsworn who broke their hands

cannot be broken in the hands again; a Forsworn with an opened mouth can lie without further cost. The Breakdowns have made a politics of this. Led by Brakk, the Forsworn swear loudly and freely on what is already broken, take jobs no whole Oathener can, and run the canyon's smuggling, lying and loud-mouthed trades. They want the Breakdowns made a free city, the end of public shaming, and a share of the Rim Road tithe. Some want much worse: they want everyone in Tacit broken, so that no one is better than anyone.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Cracked	Shelter in the Breakdowns; a meal a day from the common pot.
2	Broken-in	A trade: liar-for-hire, loud-crier, smuggler.
3	Open-Hand	Command of a lane; a vote at the Gathering of the Broken.
4	Splint	One of Brakk's council; access to the Breakdowns' arms.
5	Voice	Speaks for the Breakdowns to the Bench.

A PC joins by breaking an oath in public, or by already being broken. Enemies: the Bench, the Echo-Wardens. Allies: the Purgation, which preaches that breaking is a step toward vomiting up the god.

THE SURETIES

Professionals who take on other people's oaths for a fee and carry the risk in their own bodies. A Surety swears, before the principal's

oath is made, to stand behind it: if the principal breaks, the Surety breaks in their place. Sureties are licensed by the Compact of 148, tattooed with the oaths they carry in a dense fine script, and among the richest commoners in the land. They are also, inevitably, ruins. A Surety in the trade for twenty years has usually paid on a dozen defaults and carries them all. They believe in the arithmetic of risk; they want fees, fair principals, and a quiet death before the next default. They fear one bad season.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Bondling	Carries Weight 1–2 oaths; fees of 2–10 lacks.
2	Underwriter	Carries Weight 3 oaths; a seat in the Surety House.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
3	Bondsman	Carries Weight 4 oaths, including marriages; a private physician.
4	Great Surety	Carries treaties and Company contracts; a house on the Sunward Wall.
5	Master of the Compact	Sets fees and refuses principals for the whole trade.

A PC joins by carrying a first oath (see Sureties, below) and surviving the year. Enemies: Grandam Cess, defaulters. Allies: the Rim Road Company, the Bench.

THE QUIET

An ascetic order that has given up speech entirely, some by vow and some by knife. Founded in 240 A.G. by Abbess Hollin Mure, the

Quiet live in cliff-cells along the upper Gullet and teach, in writing, that speech is the god's fishing line, and every word a hook. They want silence: first for themselves, then for Oathen, and in their secret texts, for the whole Table. Sister Verity Amn has brought a terrible new teaching: that for the highest bloodlines, even thought now binds, and that the knife is not enough.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hushed	Shelter; a slate and chalk; the Quiet's protection.
2	Sealed	Has taken the vow of speech; may teach handtalk novices.
3	Tongueless	Has taken the knife; immune to Breakings of the tongue.
4	Stillmind	Learns the disciplines of empty thought.
5	Abbess of the Quiet	Writes the order's teachings.

A PC joins by a vow of silence (Weight 4) or by the knife. Enemies: the Forsworn, who mock them. Allies: the Echo-Wardens.

THE ECHO-WARDENS

Rangers who police the silent gorges and hunt down old sworn words still bouncing in the deep rock. An oath can live in a canyon

for decades, flying from wall to wall, binding everyone who walks through it; the Wardens track such echoes by ear, map them, and kill them with felt baffles, wool dams, sand-falls and, for the worst, controlled rockfall. They are deaf in one ear by tradition (the right, cut at their initiation) and listen with the other like hunting dogs. They want the canyons clean of old words. They fear Sworn Gorge.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Baffler	Carries felt and wool; a Warden's ration.
2	Listener	Licensed to enter posted gorges; the half-deafening.
3	Tracker	Leads echo-hunts; a horn of signal-silence.
4	Gorge-Warden	Commands a district; may seal a canyon by order.
5	Warden of the Wall	Keeps the post at Sworn Gorge.

A PC joins by apprenticeship and the cutting of the right ear. Enemies: smugglers who use echoes to bind pursuers. Allies: the Quiet, the Bench.

POWERS FROM ABROAD

The Rim Road Company is the great foreign power in Oathen, operating from Quillhouse under Jessamy Quill. The Cutwrights'

College keeps a small, sharp-eyed office in Tacit and knows exactly which Tongue-lines are nearest the Brink. The Purgation preaches among the Forsworn that a broken body is a body vomiting up the god. The Second Table has agents in at least three Tongue-line houses, and an interest in Sayers that needs no explaining. The Reckoners have not come through the canyons since Wending Pass; they know Renn Hold is still at the top.

▼ OATHEN NOW

The rain was late, which means a god's promise has slipped, which should not be possible. Handtalkers are starting to break. A scribe has found evidence that written words now bind. If the Regrowth is widening what counts as speech, soon there will be nothing an Oathener can safely say, sign, write, or perhaps think. And the Bench is debating, in forty-page conditionals, whether to take the bit out of a Sayer and have her fix it.

Meanwhile the Forsworn are counting. The Breakdowns have doubled in five years, swollen by handtalkers with broken fingers and scribes with split palms, and Brakk now speaks for a fifth of the capital. The Company has tripled the guard on Quillhouse. Lady Imre Dath, in her gold, is writing, and no one is quite sure on what.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◇ The Late Rain. Yusra Thole, the Rainwarden, has not spoken in a month, because she cannot lie about the rain and will not tell the truth. The Bench hires the PCs to find out what she knows without asking her a question. The answer lies in the Gullet, where the sand over Tolm's bones has grown hot enough to blister, and something beneath it has begun, very slowly, to clear its throat.
- ◇ The Surety's Last Default. Ona Fell can survive one more default, and one of her two hundred and eleven principals is

about to break: a Tongue-line merchant who swore a Company contract he cannot meet. The PCs must find which one before it happens, and the merchant has hired them too, to make sure Ona breaks first.

- ◇ The Hold at Wending. A Company caravan must cross Wending Pass, and the man at the top will not let anyone through who has not sworn to hold it. Renn Hold is not mad; he is bound. Getting past him means understanding what he swore, and the four hundred on the road below have opinions too.
- ◇ Sworn Gorge Has Gone Quiet. For the first time in two hundred years the murmur behind the wall has stopped. Halvar Stane believes the echo has found a way out. Three herders in the eastern canyons have broken in the same way as the hamlet of Sowe, and the PCs must track a word through the rock before it reaches Tacit.
- ◇ The Notary's Hand. Someone is trying to make Jessamy Quill break. Agents of the Second Table want the Company's contracts loosed so that the Rim Road falls into chaos before Tablenight; the PCs are hired as her bodyguards, and every conversation in Quillhouse is a battlefield.

RUMORS IN THE CANYONS

D10	RUMOR (SIGNED IN THE MARKET)
1	Ket the Ninth has made a sound. A Bench clerk heard it and was bitted the same hour. (True.)
2	The Kept Rain came late because a Sayer said something it was not drafted to say. (Unknown.)
3	Cassian Wry is not a Blank at all; the crown pays a Surety to take his lies. (False.)
4	Writing in reverse, mirror-script, does not bind. (False, as Ottoline Vant could tell you.)
5	Grandam Cess can free you from a marriage vow. (True, at a price no one has described.)
6	Jude Crake was once condemned himself, and talked his own Breaker to death. (True.)
7	The Forsworn are buying iron from the Fatlands for spearheads. (True.)
8	If you cannot read, the Ledger cannot bind you. (False and dangerous.)
9	Little Rue has found someone else the promise was for. (Partly true.)
10	On the stillest night, Sworn Gorge says your name. (It said Halvar Stane's. Once.)

THE PEOPLE OF OATHEN

KET THE NINTH – THE MUTE KING

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Clause 5, Resolve 5, Godsign 3, Reckoning 3, Instinct 2
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	none; he has never struck anyone.
GIFTS	Has never spoken, so is bound by nothing. If he says a plain sentence, it binds at Sayer strength (see the Brink Gift, Make It So) and he knows it.
WANTS	To Say (resisted daily; Caul + Resolve vs Grim when the Bench misreads him).
DREAD	3 (to see his throat working under the gold-chased bit)
SECRET	He has made a sound once, a single hum, alone, to know what it was like. A clerk heard it. The clerk is bitted now, and the king visits him.

Ket the Ninth is thirty-one, slight, grey-eyed, and has never made a sound. He was chosen at eleven days old from the Hushwell line and bitted in silver before his first cry; his nurses held their hands over his mouth when he laughed. He rules by nod and gesture, and the Bench spends weeks arguing what each one meant. He has a great deal to say. He reads everything; he writes nothing, because writing may now count. His eyes are very expressive and very tired.

He knows, because the Cutwrights have told him in a sealed report, that his Regrowth has run to the Course without a word ever leaving his mouth, and that what is pressing behind his teeth is not a man's sentence. He fears that he wants to say it. PCs meet him at audience, where he will hold their gaze a long time and then, perhaps, make a gesture no one on the Bench has seen before, meant only for them.

SORRIN VAEL – CHIEF CLAUSEWRIGHT

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Clause 6, Persuade 4, Lore 4, Deceive 3, Resolve 3
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 4
ATTACKS	none.
GIFTS	Reads any spoken oath's Exits at a glance (no roll). Once per scene, may name a flaw in another's oath and reduce its Weight by 1.
WANTS	To Swear, which he channels into drafting; his margins are full of crossed-out vows.
DREAD	1
SECRET	His iron bit is hidden under his high collar at night. He has been swearing in his sleep for two years, and his wife has kept a record, and the record is a treaty with something.

Sorrin Vael is the finest drafter of promises alive: sixty, narrow, bald, with fingers stained by slate dust and a voice like dry paper. His treaties run to four hundred conditions. He has not made an unqualified statement since boyhood, including to his wife, including “yes”; their marriage is, by all accounts, tender, and conducted largely by touch. He believes in the clause as other men believe in god: that there is no promise so dangerous it cannot be

made safe by enough precision. He fears the day the precision fails. He is drafting, now, the sentence the Bench may let Lady Imre Dath say, and he has gone through ninety-one versions, and every one of them, read slowly enough, frightens him. He meets PCs when they need an oath drafted that could get them into a place, or out of one, and he charges a great deal, and is worth it.

LADY IMRE DATH – THE SAYER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 7 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 12 (the Seating) · Hunger —
SKILLS	Godsign 6, Clause 4, Resolve 4, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray —
ATTACKS	none needed. Unbitted, any sentence she speaks is so.
GIFTS	Saying. What she says, is, without roll or limit except grammar. Bitted in gold, nothing. Writing: her written words now bind at Course strength (one per day, GM’s choice of the most dangerous reading).
WANTS	To be understood. To finish a sentence.
DREAD	5 (to see her face behind the gold)
SECRET	She has begun to write her own sentences, scratched with a fingernail into the lead of her cell wall. The current one reads: “When the rain comes, I will be”.

Imre Dath was a Tongue-line girl of the Dath house, clever and talkative, which her mother punished. At twenty-five she said “My brother is a liar” at dinner; her brother’s mouth opened back to his ears and has never closed. She has been in the Gilded Cells for three years. Her face has grown long and smooth, her eyes sealed over with skin, and small pink ears have bloomed across her cheeks and temples; she hears everything said in the Ledger above her. She is

unmuzzled once a year, to say one sentence the Bench has drafted. Last year’s was “The canyon wells shall not run dry this Lack,” and they did not. She has begun to write her own. She does not hate the Bench. She pities it. If PCs reach her, she will listen with all her ears, and, if a pen were to come into her hand, she would very much like to finish.

BRAKK – VOICE OF THE FORSWORN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 2 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Intimidate 4, Brawl 4, Persuade 3, Endure 4, Blades 2
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 14 · Armor 1 (oiled hide over the ribs) · Fray 5
ATTACKS	Fists +8 (1); cleaver +6 (3)
GIFTS	Broken Ground (heart and ribs): marriage, love and loyalty oaths cannot break him further; he swears them freely as rhetoric.
WANTS	To be heard by those above.
DREAD	2 (when he unties the cloth over his chest)
SECRET	He still loves the wife he betrayed. She lives on the Sunward Wall. He swore on her that he would bring Tacit down.

Brakk broke a marriage vow, and his ribs opened outward like a book and stayed that way. Under the oiled cloth, his heart and lungs are visible, slick, working, and in the cold weeks of Lack, breath steams from his chest. He is huge, grey-bearded, and loud, and he leads the Breakdowns. He is the most plainspoken man in Oathen, having nothing left to break: he says “I love you” to strangers, “I will

kill you” to Clausewrights, and laughs at both. He wants the Breakdowns free and the Walls humbled. He fears that the Bench is right, and that the broken deserve it. PCs meet him when they need something done that a whole Oathener cannot do: a lie told, a loud word said in an echoing place, a promise sworn that no one intends to keep.

ONA FELL – THE SURETY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Endure 6, Clause 4, Resolve 4, Reckoning 3
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none.
GIFTS	Bond-Ledger: knows instantly, by a pain in the relevant part, when any principal she stands behind comes near to breaking.
WANTS	To count her bonds, aloud, nightly.
DREAD	3 (to see the script that covers her entire body)
SECRET	Two of her principals are the same Second Table cell, and they have decided to default together.

Ona Fell carries two hundred and eleven oaths that belong to other people. She is fifty, short, and very broad, and every inch of her skin from collarbone to ankle is tattooed in fine brown script with the terms of the oaths she stands behind, so densely that from a distance she looks bruised. Her left hand has no fingers (a defaulting grain-merchant). Her jaw is wired (a lying envoy). Her back is hooked (a regiment’s quartermaster). By her reckoning, she can survive one more default. She is gentle, careful, and tired, and she has stopped taking new principals, but she cannot put down the old ones. She wants to live to see her oldest bond expire, in four years. PCs meet her when they need a Surety. She will look at them a long time, and then say, “If able.”

Jessamy Quill, Notary of the Rim Road, is the hinge of the Table’s trade. Every contract the Company holds is sworn before her and rests on her word as witness: forty years of shipping, tolls and debts. If she dies or breaks, half the trade of the Table comes unbound in an afternoon. She is sixty-eight, sharp-faced, Oathen-born, and has a voice so practiced that every sentence she utters is witnessed and exact. She eats only food tasted by two Company

servants. She keeps a Surety for herself and does not say who. She is no one’s friend. She wants to die of old age, with an apprentice ready. She has no apprentice; three have died, unluckily. She meets PCs as a client, or as the person they are hired to protect.

JESSAMY QUILL Threat 4 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (stiletto 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Clause 6

Little Rue was four, before her muzzling, when she promised her mother she would never grow up. She has not. She is sixty-three, in a child’s body, with milk teeth and soft hair and old, old eyes, and she has outlived everyone the promise was for. Her mother died in 611. Her friends married, bore, and died. She wears no bit, since she is past twelve; she speaks seldom, in a child’s high voice with an old woman’s syntax. She lives in the Breakdowns, among the broken, who are kind to her. She wants to grow old. She fears that the oath has a second reading: that because she cannot grow up, she cannot die, and will be a child in the dark of the Vaults forever. She meets PCs as a fixer and a guide, and she drives a hard bargain, because she cannot afford to be lied to.

HALVAR STANE – ECHO-WARDEN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Stealth 4, Search 4, Instinct 4, Shooting 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Fray 8
ATTACKS	Shortbow +6 (3); knife +5 (2)
GIFTS	Can track an echo through rock by ear alone; knows every posted gorge.
WANTS	To go back to the wall.
DREAD	2
SECRET	The two words he heard are “set” and “again”.

Halvar Stane patrols the silent gorges and has spent thirty years tracking the echo in Sworn Gorge. He is gaunt, bow-legged, deaf in the right ear by initiation and nearly in the left by age, with a habit of tilting his head like a listening dog. He has come close enough to

make out two words of the oath. He will not repeat them, because to repeat is to renew, and he does not know what he would be renewing. He dreams of the wall nightly and has begun sleepwalking toward it. He fears that he is already bound, and that

this is how it feels. He meets PCs as their guide through any posted canyon, and as the one man who might lead them into Sworn Gorge, if they gave him the excuse.

Mirren Osk, the Handtalker, is the greatest poet in a language held not to bind. She is forty, elegant, with long hands she oils nightly; three of her fingers are splinted now, the bones knit badly. Last year she signed a love poem to a patron and did not mean it,

and three of her fingers snapped, mid-sign, in front of four hundred people. It was the first proof that handtalk counts. She has not composed since. She is frightened, angry, and guiltily excited, because if handtalk binds then it was always a real language, and her poems were always true. She meets PCs seeking a translator, or a witness, or someone to help her find out whether her old poems, written over thirty years, are about to come due.

CASSIAN WRY – THE LIAR	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (Blank) · Regrowth — · Hunger —
SKILLS	Deceive 6, Persuade 4, Stealth 3, Filch 3, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 14 · Armor 0 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	Knife +5 (2)
GIFTS	Blank: cannot be bound or broken by any oath. His lies cost nothing.
WANTS	None of the god's. His own: to be believed once, about something true.
DREAD	0
SECRET	He has begun to taste wet slate when others swear. The Cutwrights suspect he is not a Blank but the god's blind spot, and blind spots close.

Cassian Wry is a Blank, and the only man in Oathen who can lie and stay whole. He is thirty-four, handsome in a hungry way, with a quick mouth and a laugh that makes Oatheners flinch. He is the crown's most valuable spy, kept in luxury on the Sunward Wall and never let out of sight: two bitted guards, a Clausewright minder, a gilded apartment with felt walls. Everyone who meets him asks him to say something false, just to hear it. He obliges: "The sky is green." "I love you." "I am happy here." He is lonely in a way no one else in the country can be, since no one believes anything he says, including the truth. He meets PCs on a mission, or escaping one.

Judge Thane Urow presides over Breaking trials. There is no evidence and no testimony. He simply has the accused repeat the promise aloud, and the court watches to see what happens to them. He is seventy, small and neat, with a voice like a knife drawn slowly, and his robes are spattered so often that he wears red. He has presided over eleven thousand trials. He believes his court is the only perfectly just court on the Table, and he is right, and he hates it. He fears the day he is asked to repeat his own judicial oath before his own court. Nobody has thought to ask. He meets PCs as their judge, or as a man who would like, very quietly, to know if the god still means it.

Asha Kindle, the Fire-Widow, promised her dying husband she would never let the fire go out. That was thirty-one years ago. She has not slept more than an hour at a stretch since, and the fire has grown particular about what it is fed. It began with wood; then it would only burn cedar; then it wanted his clothes; then his letters; then, three winters ago, it would not catch on anything but hair. Asha is bald, grey-skinned, with burned hands, and lives in a cliff-

cell above Tacit with a fire in a stone hearth that whispers. She fears the fire is asking for something she has not yet given it. She meets PCs as a client who wants the fire to go out by someone else's hand. Then her oath would be kept, she thinks. She is not sure.

Garl Tome, the Bitmaker, is the smith of muzzles: leather for children, iron for the Appetite-struck, gold for Sayers. He is a broad, bearded, careful man of fifty, who works with a kerchief over his mouth from habit. He fitted his own daughter at birth and has never heard her voice. She is twelve this year. He has been offered a fortune by a Tongue-line house to make her bit permanent, because the Cutwrights say she is at the Course already, and what she will say when it comes off may not be safe. He says silence is what love sounds like here. He has not decided. He meets PCs as the man who can make, or unmake, any bit in the land, including the gold ones.

Yusra Thole, the Rainwarden, is the keeper of the Kept Rain: the tallies of every year's fall, the cistern-oaths, the Rain Shrine in the high basin. She knows it came three days late. She cannot lie about it, so she has said nothing at all for a month, and the silence is being noticed. She is forty-five, weathered, with a heart-line Cut from the god's great slow heart and a slow, heavy pulse that can be seen in her throat. What she knows is that the rain did not come late. It came on time, by the god's own reckoning: Tolm's year has grown three days longer. She meets PCs as the woman they are sent to watch, or to make talk.

Grandam Cess, the Vow-Eater, is a back-canyon fixer who claims she can release you from an oath by having you swear a greater one over it. She is ancient, toothless, with a laugh like gravel in a bucket, and lives in a warren of cisterns called Knot Canyon. Her clients are

free of what they came with. They owe her something worse: “to come when called,” “to give what is asked,” “to carry what I hand you.” She has nine hundred such clients. She has never called them.

She is waiting for something, and she will not say what, and she has started to sleep with her ear to the floor. She meets PCs as the only cure for an oath they cannot keep.

CAPTAIN RENN HOLD – THE MAN AT WENDING	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 5, Endure 5, Resolve 5, Intimidate 3, Wayfaring 2
BODY	Flesh 17 · Guard 16 · Armor 3 (rusted mail) · Fray 9
ATTACKS	Sword +9 (4)
GIFTS	Held: while within the pass, he cannot be moved by force, fear or Dread; he has not slept in fourteen years and does not need to.
WANTS	To Hold Others to Their Words: he demands an oath of anyone who would pass.
DREAD	3 (the road behind him)
SECRET	Some of the four hundred are still alive below, unstrung, and he goes down at night to feed them, one step past the line he swore never to cross, and each time a little more of him comes open.

Captain Renn Hold’s regiment swore to hold a pass to the death. He ordered the retreat. He kept his oath by staying; they broke theirs by obeying, and four hundred soldiers came apart on the road behind him. That was fourteen years ago. He is still at the top of Wending Pass, because he swore to hold it to the death and he has not died. He is gaunt, sunburned black, wearing rusted mail and a captain’s sash gone grey, living on what drovers leave him. He speaks rarely, and when he does it is the regiment’s roll, name by name. He does not ask to be forgiven. He asks every traveler to swear to hold the pass with him. Some do. He sends them down again, gently, but he wanted them to have said it.

Tavish Crook, called Loophole, is a swindler who speaks only in questions. He has never asserted or promised anything in his life, and he has taken a fortune from people who assumed he had. “Would you trust a man who stood to lose so much?” “Have you ever seen a cask like this?” “What if I told you there was gold under Low Shale?” He is fifty, plump, merry, very well dressed, and entirely whole. He wants more. He fears the day the god learns to hear what he means. He meets PCs as their mark, their partner, or their only lead.

Sister Verity Amn of the Quiet cut out her own tongue at nineteen. She teaches, in writing, that for the highest bloodlines a promise made only in thought now binds. She knows because of what happened to her after the knife: alone in her cell, she thought, very clearly, “I will never speak again,” and in the morning her lips had grown together. They have been reopened twice by surgeons and grown shut twice. She is fifty-two, gaunt, and writes in a fast, beautiful hand. She fears her own mind. She meets PCs as a teacher, and she will tell them, on slate, what to stop thinking.

Envoy Dorian Sayce is Oathen’s ambassador to nations that can lie. He finds foreigners unbearable and negotiation with them a kind of nausea; he carries a vinegar-soaked kerchief to hold over his nose when they boast. He is also the only diplomat on the Table everyone believes. He is fifty, silver-haired, perfectly dressed, and has never once lied, not even abroad, where he could. He fears that he is losing his country’s discipline, because abroad, last spring, he caught himself enjoying it. He meets PCs on the Rim Road, needing escort, and will not thank them, because thanks implies a debt.

Ilan, the Oath-Child, is nine. A man once swore to his wife, “I promise you a son.” She was past bearing. Ilan exists anyway: there was no birth, only a morning when there had always been a boy at the table. He is quiet, polite, dark-haired, bitted, with his father’s eyes. His father died in the spring, and Ilan has started to become difficult to see: faint at the edges in bright light, missed at roll-call, forgotten mid-sentence. His mother keeps her hand on his shoulder at all times. She fears the promise was to the father and is now discharged. She meets PCs begging for an oath sworn on her husband’s bones that will keep her son.

Ottoline Vant, Scribe of the Ledger, carves the public vows into the cliff. She miscut one last year, by a single word, writing “never” where the sworn record read “not”, and the man it named broke that night. Writing is not supposed to count. She is thirty, sunburned, lean from the scaffolds, and has not carved a letter since. She has started checking the old carvings for errors. She has found eleven. All eleven of the people named broke the night the carving was done, and the Bench put it down to coincidence each time. She meets PCs as a fugitive, carrying a list.

JUDE CRAKE – THE BREAKER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 5 · Tongue 6 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Tongue-line, bastard) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Persuade 6, Deceive 5, Clause 5, Instinct 5, Resolve 4
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 2
ATTACKS	none; he owns no weapon.
GIFTS	The Hour. In conversation, Jude can extract one oath per ten minutes (Tongue + Persuade vs the target's Caul + Resolve + 10); each is small, and each is crafted to tangle with the last.
WANTS	To Hold Others to Their Words.
DREAD	3 (when the hour-glass is turned)
SECRET	He was once condemned himself, at twenty, and he talked his own Breaker into promising to spare him. He has kept every promise he has ever made since, except one: to that Breaker's daughter, whom he said he would visit, and has not, because he cannot bear to.

Jude Crake, the Breaker, is the state executioner, and owns no weapon. He is forty-four, soft-spoken, round-faced, with kind brown eyes and a fondness for figs and small talk. He visits the condemned, talks pleasantly for an hour, and leaves once they have promised him something small: to try, to stop crying, to be brave, to see him tomorrow. Each promise is crafted to collide with the next. It has never taken longer than an hour, and the Breakings that come, apt and compounding, leave nothing of the condemned that could be called alive. He believes he is merciful: no blade, no fear of the blade, only conversation. He fears the hour running long. Last Carving, it did. He meets PCs as someone's last visitor, or their own.

NEW CHARACTERS

Sergeant Mags Carrow, the Four Hundred and First, is the soldier who misheard the order at Wending. She stayed at the pass with her captain while the four hundred fell back and broke, and she kept her oath without meaning to. She left later, with Renn Hold's blessing, when he released her by an oath he drafted himself, and it cost her an eye. She is forty, broad, with one eye and a regimental sash, and she lives in the Breakdowns, caring for the eleven survivors of the four hundred who were carried down: unstrung, their joints held together with straps, alive. She wants Renn Hold brought down from the pass. She fears he will refuse, because she is the one who would have to ask.

SERGEANT MAGS CARROW Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 14 · Attack +7 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 1

Dacey Furl, the Gag-Nurse, runs the night ward of the Murmuring House. She is thirty, deaf by choice, slow-moving, kind, and she feeds three hundred bitted patients broth through a reed,

nightly, one by one. She has learned to read their mouths through the iron. She has noticed that for a month, all three hundred have been mouthing the same vow, together, in their sleep, and that she cannot read the last word. She meets PCs as the person who calls for help.

Lord Varro Esk, the Heir of Tongues, is a Tongue-line noble of twenty-eight, golden, charming, at the Appetite and bitted in silver at night. He is a member of the Second Table, and he has a plan: to have a Sayer unbitted and to have her say, "Tolm is whole and on the table." He believes the god would be made solid, edible, and his. He meets PCs as a generous patron with a reasonable request: help him visit the Gilded Cells.

LORD VARRO ESK Threat 4 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (rapier 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 · Persuade 5

Brother Ansgar Mote, the Tongue-Taker, is the surgeon of the Quiet. He has removed four hundred tongues, cleanly, and keeps them in brine in a vault, labeled, because he once threw one away and it went on trying to speak in the midden for a week. He is sixty, steady-handed, and has his own tongue still. He knows Verity Amn's secret, and he has begun to suspect another: that the tongues in his vault have begun to grow.

Old Sabra Wends, the Keener of Oaths, keeps the Witnessing Vaults beneath Tacit. She is seventy, white-haired, with a lantern and a slate, and she has heard the dead speak forty-two times: when oaths sworn on them broke, the jaw of the corpse in the niche opened and the vow came out, in the dead one's voice, loud enough to be heard a mile off through the rock. She records each. The number this year is nine. Last year it was two. She meets PCs when they come to swear on the dead, and she asks them, very gently, whether they are certain.

▼ PLAYING AN OATHENER

An Oathener is a person raised to weigh every word, in a country where the god in their blood is a witness that never stops writing things down. They make careful allies, terrible liars and devastating negotiators. They are also, the moment they open their mouths, at risk.

Attribute bonus: +1 TONGUE.

WEIGHT	KIND	EXAMPLES
1	Idle	“I’ll be back by dark.” A small lie. A boast.
2	Plain	A deliberate promise to a person. “You can count on me.”
3	Sworn	“I swear.” Any witnessed vow, or a lie that matters.
4	Solemn	Marriage, Company contract, sworn sentence, vow at the Ledger.
5	Grave	An oath sworn on the dead, or on Tolm by name.

An oath sworn in an echoing place renews once per echo the speaker hears (usually 1–3; a canyon narrows can manage 9). Each renewal is a separate oath of the same Weight, broken at the same moment. Handtalk and writing currently count at half Weight, rounded down; at Weight 0, the GM rolls a d10 anyway, and on a 1–2 the god counts it at Weight 1. The widening is happening.

CONDITIONAL SPEECH

A character can speak carefully. When they deliberately draft an oath or a sensitive answer, roll **Tongue + Clause**. The difficulty is Routine 10 at leisure, Hard 14 in a pressed negotiation, Grim 18 in combat, interrogation or under a Dread check. Every Helping adds an **Exit**: a condition the player names (“barring illness”, “if the river allows”, “as I now intend”) under which breach is not breaking. A Grace makes the oath **Clean**: the GM must honor any reasonable reading of it. A failure means the sentence carries no Exits; a Lack means the speaker said more than they meant, and the GM names one extra Weight 1–2 promise in the words.

When a character speaks without care (in anger, grief, fear or play), the GM may call for the same roll to see whether anything binding slipped out.

WHEN AN OATH IS BREACHED

- ◇ **Check the Exits.** If an Exit genuinely fits the circumstance, nothing happens.

OATHS IN OATHEN

These rules apply to anyone within Oathen’s borders, native or not, and to Oatheners abroad when their Regrowth reaches the Course.

OATH WEIGHT

Every binding statement has a **Weight** from 1 to 5, set by the GM from what was meant and how it was said.

- ◇ **Argue the reading.** If the case is ambiguous, the character may plead to the god in the moment: roll **Eye + Clause** vs 10 + (2 × Weight). Success: Tolm accepts the reading. Failure: the oath breaks.
- ◇ **The Breaking.** The body breaks at once, with a sound. The GM chooses the most apt rupture from the Breaking table (or rolls a d20 when the subject is unclear). The victim loses 2 × **Weight** Flesh, which cannot reduce them below 1: the Breaking is never fatal by itself, though bleeding, exposure and further harm may be. At Weight 3 or more the rupture is permanent: a **Forsworn mark**, with a lasting penalty of –1 per Weight above 2 to rolls using the broken part. At Weight 5 the part is lost entirely.
- ◇ **Dread.** The broken make a Dread check of the oath’s Weight (maximum 4). Witnesses make one at Weight – 1 (minimum 1).

Broken Ground. A part already lost to a Weight 5 Breaking cannot break again. Oaths whose apt Breaking would land there may be sworn freely; if broken, the GM shifts the Breaking to the next nearest apt part, at –1 Weight. This is how the Forsworn of the Breakdowns can swear.

Lies. A spoken lie is an oath broken the instant it is finished. Small lies are Weight 1, lies that matter Weight 3, lies under the god’s name Weight 5. Their Breaking is the mouth: lips, teeth, tongue, jaw.

THE BREAKING TABLE

D20	OATH CONCERNED	MINOR (WEIGHT 1-2)	GRIEVOUS (WEIGHT 3-5)
1	Lies, true speech	Lips split to the gum	Jaw unhinges, tongue splits
2	Dealing, fair weight	Fingers snap backward	Hands come off at the wrist

D20	OATH CONCERNED	MINOR (WEIGHT 1-2)	GRIEVOUS (WEIGHT 3-5)
3	Standing by, staying	Knees buckle	Legs fold backward like a heron's
4	Going, arriving	Ankles crack	Feet turn fully about
5	Returning home	Heels split	Tendons draw up; cannot walk away from a door
6	Love, the heart	Breastbone cracks	Chest opens like a cupboard
7	Marriage, fidelity	Ribs crack	Ribs open outward like a book
8	Carrying, bearing	Shoulder slips	Spine hooks double
9	Watching, witness	Eyes bleed	Eyes burst in their sockets
10	Secrets, silence	Ears ring and bleed	Throat splits lengthwise
11	Feeding, providing	Teeth loosen	Belly opens at the navel
12	Never forgetting	Nose bleeds, lost hours	Skull cracks along the suture; memories leak
13	Obedience	Neck wrenches	Knees and neck lock bowed for life
14	Effort, trying	Long muscles tear	Arms and back split like staves
15	Courage, boasts	Bladder and bowel give way	Skin of the face splits and peels
16	Protecting another	Palms split	Arms snap at the elbows
17	Following, loyalty	Hamstrings strain	Spine twists to face behind
18	Abstaining, refusal	Stomach cramps, vomiting blood	Gut ruptures; cannot keep food down
19	Handtalk vows	One finger snaps	Every finger breaks at every joint
20	Life itself ("I'd die for you")	Breath stops for a minute	Heart stutters; -2 Flesh maximum forever

SURETIES

A **Surety** swears, before the principal's oath is made, "I stand for this word." From then on, if the principal breaks, the Surety breaks in their place, taking the full Breaking (the principal suffers only the

Dread check, as a witness). A Surety may roll **Gut + Endure** vs 10 + (2 × Weight) to halve the Flesh lost; the mark is taken regardless. A principal who knowingly defaults on a Surety is called **sold** and no Surety in the land will stand for them again.

WEIGHT	STANDARD FEE (LACKS)	NOTES
1	2	Bondlings will take it
2	10	Often bundled for merchants
3	50	Underwriter required
4	200	Marriages, Company contracts
5	1,000	Few will take it; oaths on the dead never

A PC may be a Surety; each bond carried is tattooed on the body in script. Carrying more bonds than Gut + Endure means one more Fray each new Lack season, as the weight of other people's word wears the mind.

OATHS ON THE DEAD

To swear on the dead, the swearer lays a hand on the bones or the tomb, speaks the dead one's name, and says the vow into the niche. The oath gains +1 Weight (to a maximum of 5), cannot be carried by a Surety, and adds a second Witness to Tolm. When it breaks, the dead **Testify**: roll a d6.

D6	THE DEAD TESTIFY
1	The corpse's jaw opens in its niche and speaks the oath aloud, in its own voice, loud enough to be heard for a mile through rock. Everyone who hears it knows who broke it.
2	The oathbreaker's Breaking takes the shape of the dead one's own death-wound, in addition to its apt shape.

D6	THE DEAD TESTIFY
3	The dead one's bones are found in the oathbreaker's bed at dawn, arranged lying beside them.
4	The oathbreaker speaks only in the dead one's voice for a month. Dread 2 for all who knew the dead.
5	Every promise the oathbreaker ever made to the dead in life is re-weighed. Each one not kept breaks now, at Weight 1.
6	The dead one's name begins to replace the oathbreaker's own. Friends forget which they are speaking to. Each Lack season, 1 Fray, until the oath is kept or the name is lost.

THE REGROWTH OF TOLM

The Sop: Swearing. Make an unconditional oath, aloud, of Weight 2 or more, before a witness, with no Exits. Remove 1d6 Hunger. The oath binds as normal.

The Tooth. When an Oathener Partakes, they hear their own last words come back to them, half a second late, in a voice that is not quite theirs, and taste wet slate. If any Tooth shows a 1, the god bit back and took the character at their word: their last spoken sentence becomes a Weight 1 oath, read in its most literal sense.

The Wants (resisted with Caul + Resolve):

- ◇ **To Swear.** Triggered by silence held too long, by being doubted, or by a direct question. Failure: the character vows something aloud (GM's choice, Weight 1–3).
- ◇ **To Hold Others to Their Words.** Triggered when someone nearby breaks a promise. Failure: the character must confront them and demand they repeat it.
- ◇ **To Correct.** Triggered by hearing a falsehood. Failure: the character states the truth aloud, whatever it costs.
- ◇ **To Be Heard.** Triggered in echoing places. Failure: the character speaks, to hear it come back.

GIFTS

- ◇ **The Taste: Echo-Ear.** You hear your own words repeated a half-second late. You may roll **Eye + Instinct** (Hard 14) to know whether a statement spoken in your hearing was a lie or bound its speaker, and at what Weight. Cost: in echoing places, Dread 1 checks whenever you speak.
- ◇ **The Appetite: Hold to It.** When someone makes you a promise, you may Partake to make it heavier: +1 Weight. You feel, as a pressure in your teeth, whenever they come near to breaking it. Cost: you cannot release them; you must hold them to it, and the Want To Hold Others to Their Words triggers automatically.

- ◇ **The Course: Say So.** Once per scene, state a plain fact about something you can see. Roll **Tongue + Godsign**: Hard 14 for a small thing (“That rope holds”), Grim 18 for a significant one (“The door is locked”), Dire 22 for a great one (“He cannot see us”). Success: it is so for the scene. Cost: +2 Hunger, and for the rest of the day the GM may make any figure of speech you utter come true. Flesh change: the tongue darkens and lengthens; small ears open on the neck and inner arms; a second voice speaks under yours.
- ◇ **The Brink: Make It So.** Once per session, say one sentence that becomes true, at any scale the GM judges a single sentence can carry. No roll. Cost: Regrowth +1, and until the session ends, every sentence you speak binds as Say So with no roll and no limit. Brink characters must be bitted, by law and by sense.

The Seating. A Seated Oathener becomes a Sayer: the face smoothing, the eyes skinned over, the mouth a door the god speaks through. The character is no longer playable. The player writes the character's last sentence, the one they would have said, and the GM decides whether it was spoken before the gold went in.

BACKGROUNDS

- ◇ **Junior Clausewright.** A Slate-Clerk with ink on the fingers and a head full of Exits. Clause 2, Lore 1, Reckoning 1. Starts with a slate, a bit for emergencies, and a debt to a Bencher.
- ◇ **Forsworn of the Breakdowns.** Broken at Weight 5 once, young, and proud of it. Choose one Broken Ground. Intimidate 2, Brawl 1, Deceive 1. Starts with a cleaver, an oiled cloth, and friends who lie for a living.
- ◇ **Bondling Surety.** Carrying three small bonds and the fees for them. Endure 2, Clause 1, Resolve 1. Starts with 60 lacks and three tattoos.

NAMES

MEN	WOMEN	NEUTRAL	SURNAMES
Ket, Tav, Brakk	Imre, Ona, Rue	Wenn, Sele, Osk	Vael, Dath, Fell
Halvar, Thane, Garl	Mirren, Asha, Yusra	Aubin, Merit	Quill, Stane, Urraw
Renn, Jude, Sorrin	Cess, Verity, Ottoline	Hush, Amn	Kindle, Tome, Thole
Dorian, Ilan, Varro	Mags, Dacey, Sabra	Tacet, Esk	Hold, Crook, Crake

Oathen names are short, because every syllable is said aloud. Tongue-line families favour names that are hard to mishear.

HORRORS OF OATHEN

Roll a d20 or choose. Each scene carries the Dread listed in brackets.

D20	HORROR
1	A child, unbitted for cleaning, says “I’ll be good forever.” The mother clamps her hand over his mouth too late. (Dread 2)
2	A man in the market whispers a lie and his lips peel back to the molars, still whispering. (Dread 2)
3	An echo comes back from a canyon wall in a voice no one in the party used, and binds all of them. (Dread 3)
4	A bride at her wedding reads clause thirty-eight aloud; her ribs crack once, softly, like knuckles. (Dread 2)
5	The Unmade Road at dusk: a strapped-together soldier crawling uphill toward the pass. (Dread 3)
6	A Murmuring House patient chews through her iron bit and says a single, unfinished word. (Dread 3)
7	A handtalker’s fingers snap one by one as he signs his farewell to his dying mother. (Dread 2)
8	A tomb in the Witnessing Vaults speaks a vow aloud in a dead woman’s voice; somewhere above, someone screams. (Dread 3)
9	Jude Crake on a bridge, turning an hour-glass, smiling at one of the PCs. (Dread 2)
10	A blasphemer at dawn, mouth full of red sand, tongue simply absent. (Dread 2)
11	A Tongue-line noble at the Course says “I could eat a horse.” The stable goes quiet. (Dread 3)
12	A carved vow on the Ledger with a fresh chisel-mark changing one word, and a PC’s name below it. (Dread 2)
13	The sand of the Gullet breathing under bare feet, warm as skin. (Dread 4)
14	A Surety in the street, bonds breaking across her body in sequence as a whole family defaults. (Dread 3)
15	A man shouts “I’d die for you” in a canyon, and nine echoes come back. (Dread 3)
16	In Low Shale, the frozen herdsman’s eyes turn to follow the party. (Dread 4)
17	Little Rue sitting alone in a cemetery, telling the dead she is sorry she outgrew nothing. (Dread 1)
18	A dream in which the PC promised something in their sleep, and wakes with a thumb ring that was not there. (Dread 2)
19	The murmur from Sworn Gorge, faint through a hundred feet of wall, saying two words. (Dread 4)
20	A Sayer’s gold bit, lying open and empty on the floor of a cell. (Dread 5)



CHAPTER 9

THE FAST

No, thank you.

No, thank you.

No, thank you.

– THE FIRST WORDS TAUGHT TO EVERY CHILD IN THE FAST, AND THE LAST
RITES

From the commonplace book of Tarry Moss, Crumb-Runner, kept in charcoal on the backs of Pantry manifests. Found in his cart after the Carving of 640.

Fourth night out from Brindle Cross. Eleven sacks oat, four sacks pease, one cask salt cod (Brinehollow, stamped twice, smells like a cellar), two wheels hard cheese the Company swears is from cows. Counted them at dusk. Counted them again at moonrise. Same. Good.

The boy I took on at the Cross is called Stint, after his grandmother. Fourteen. You can see the hinges of his jaw when he chews, and he chews all the time on nothing, a little click, click, like a beetle in a wall. I told him the rules on the first night and he said them back to me before I'd finished, the way they all do, like a prayer you learned before you knew what the words were for. Never enter a house where the hearth is lit. Never answer Come in. Never eat what you did not carry yourself. If you smell bread, walk into the wind. If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.

He has carried nothing. That is the thing I keep coming back to, writing this. He has carried nothing in his life but a Pantry measure in a cloth, half an oatcake and a thumb of lard, and he has been eating that standing up in the cold since he could stand.

Tonight the wind turned. It came round from the west, off the old Lammas farms, and it came round warm. You know the feeling if you have done this work. It is like walking out of the frost into a kitchen where the oven has just been opened. The hair on your arms lifts. Your mouth fills up so fast you have to spit. The oxen stopped. Oxen always know before we do. They stood with their heads down and their tails clamped and they would not go on, and their breath went straight up like smoke from a chimney because there was not a breath of wind any more, not one, only that warmth lying over everything like a cloth.

Then the smell. New bread, the crust just splitting. Dripping in a pan. Onions gone soft and brown in butter, and something underneath it, a roast with the fat running, rosemary, a burnt-sugar edge to it like the skin on a pudding. I have smelled it a hundred times on the road. It does not get easier.

It gets worse, because now I know exactly how good it is going to be, and I have never once tasted it.

Stint stood up on the cart-bench. I said sit down. He said Moss, there's a light.

There was a light. A farmhouse on the rise, a good stone one with the thatch combed and the windows clean, the way they all are out here, six hundred years empty and kept like a bride's chest. Every window gold. Smoke going up straight and thick from the chimney. And the door open, just a little, the width of a hand, so a long bar of lamplight lay out across the yard and touched the road about ten feet in front of my lead ox.

I said into the wind, boy. I said it the way my father said it to me. I got down and I took the lead rope and I turned the oxen round by main force, and they came, thank the Refusal, they came, and I walked us east into a wind that wasn't there.

Stint didn't come. I heard him get down off the cart. I heard his feet on the road, very light, he doesn't weigh anything. I turned round and he was standing in the bar of lamplight with his face lifted and his eyes shut and his mouth open, just breathing it, the way you'd stand in the first sun after Lack. His lips were wet. He was crying. I don't think he knew.

And from the door a voice said, Come in.

It was not a loud voice. It was a voice like your mother's when you were sick and she had been sitting up with you all night and had found, in the end, something you could keep down. It said, Come in, love. It's all ready. You must be starved.

Stint said, No, thank you.

It said, There's plenty.

Stint said, No, thank you.

I was running by then. I am fifty-three and I have bad knees and I ran down that road like a hare. It said, I made it for you, it's your favourite, and I don't know how it knew what his favourite was, I don't know how a boy who has eaten oats and lard all his life has a favourite, but his whole face changed when it said it. And I got to him and I got my hand over his mouth before he could say the third No, because the third No is the one that sounds like you are being polite, and the fourth is Yes.

I carried him back to the cart. He fought me. He weighs less than a sack of pease and he fought me like a cat, and he bit the meat of my hand to the bone, and his teeth were the only strong thing in him. I tied him to the sacks with the cod rope. I walked the oxen east until the light was a coal and then a spark and then gone.

He is asleep now, or doing what they do instead. The bite has stopped bleeding. I have counted the cargo. Eleven sacks oat,

four sacks pease, one cask cod, two wheels cheese. Same.

But there is a smell in the cart I cannot place, and when I lifted the tarp to count, there was a cloth laid over the oat sacks that I did not lay there. White linen. Pressed. And on it, folded into a little tent, a card. I can read, a little. I have not turned it over. I am going to burn it in the morning without turning it over.

I already know whose name it is.

▼ THE REFUSAL

Every other land on the Table tells the story of a meal. The Fast tells the story of a meal that was not eaten, and it tells it the way a starving man tells you about the loaf he gave away: slowly, with pride, and with his eyes on your hands.

In the ninth winter of the Long Lack, the people of the central heartland were the fattest-looking starving people on the continent. That is how the Unfed elders begin, and it is meant to wound. Their land had been the best land on the Table, black loam and limestone springs and orchards older than memory, and when the Lack came it held on longest. It was the last place where an apple tree still set fruit. When the fruit fell it was hollow, a skin of red around a puff of grey dust, but it set. People from every side of the ring walked into the heartland to beg, and the heartlanders, who were the people of Orrum, the Host, fed them, because that was what it meant to be Orrum's. A stranger at the door was a guest. A guest was fed. There was a word in their old dialect for the shame of an empty bowl set before a visitor, and it was the same word they used for murder.

By the sixth winter there was nothing left to set before anyone. By the eighth, the heartlanders were eating the thatch off their roofs, boiled down to a brown paste that tasted of smoke and mouse. They ate harness leather. They ate the glue out of furniture joints. In the village of Lammas Bottom, the record of a reeve survives, scratched on slate, listing what the village ate in the last month of the eighth winter in a hand that grows larger and less steady down the page: *bark of the elm, boiled. Shoe-soles, boiled. Moss. The dog Brindle. Clay with salt. The cat. The other cat. The rush matting.* The last line is a single word, scratched over and over until the slate is white: *no*.

Orrum was among them the whole time. It was not distant, any more than the other Providers were. It walked the lanes of the heartland the way a tall old aunt walks through a crowded kitchen, stooping under the lintels, touching heads. It was warm. Every account agrees on that above all things: to stand near the Host was to stand by a hearth in Lack. And through all nine years it kept laying tables. Out of nothing, out of habit, out of its nature, it set boards on trestles in every village green and laid them with cloth and plate and cup, and there was nothing to put on them, and the god

stood at the head of each empty table with its long hands folded and waited for its people to come and be fed, and they came, and sat, and stared at the plates, and the god stood there and starved with them.

In the ninth winter, word came in along the old roads that the others had done it. The fen people had killed the Closing Hand. The plains people had cut the Laden open in its own field. Across the Table, in a season or a single night, the starving were turning on their gods with hooks and cleavers and their bare hands, and the next morning, in every land that had eaten, the Lack was over. The seed split. The cows dropped calves. There was bread by the end of the week.

Orrum heard. Orrum did what the others had done. It walked up the bare hill at the exact centre of the continent, where a great table of grey stone had stood since before there were names, a table with eight sides. It climbed up onto the stone, which took it some time, because it had grown very thin. It lay down on its back with its hands at its sides. And it waited for its people to come and carve.

They came. That is not disputed. Something like forty thousand people walked up the hill to Hallowboard in the snow, carrying knives, and they stood around the table on its seven worn sides, and they looked at their god lying on the stone with its eyes open and its long throat bare, and the elders say that it smiled at them, and that the smile said *go on, I don't mind, you must be starved*.

And they would not.

Nobody knows who said it first. Every family in the Fast claims the first No for its own great-grandmother's great-grandmother. What is known is that someone said "No, thank you," and someone else said it, and then all forty thousand were saying it, not shouting, saying it softly, the way you decline a second helping at a table where you know the hosts have nothing. *No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.* They stood there for nine days, saying it. They stood in the snow around their god and starved to death on their feet rather than eat it, and the god lay on the table and watched them do it.

The dying took the whole of that winter. Nine in ten of the heartland died with a willing meal within reach of their arms. The

Unfed teach it to their children as triumph, but the oldest songs are plainer about it. They remember the sound of the hill on the fifth day, when the people at the front could no longer stand and lay down in the snow along the stone, so that the second row had to stand on them. They remember mothers who chewed the leather of their own sleeves soft and fed it, mouth to mouth, to infants who were already too far gone to swallow. They remember that the dead did not smell, because there was nothing left in them to rot, and that the crows came and would not eat them either, and sat along the edge of the table in long black rows, waiting, like guests. They remember that the god wept. Every song has the god weeping. Its tears were warm, and they ran down off the stone and the snow melted where they fell, and in the melt-water some of the starving lay down and drank, and argued afterward for the rest of their short lives whether that had counted.

On the tenth morning, Orrum got up. It climbed down from the stone, slowly, like an old person getting out of a bath, and it looked at what was left of its people, a few thousand standing skeletons

ringed by the dead, and it bowed to them. Then it walked away down the hill, and it has never stopped walking since.

The survivors went home to a land where nothing grew. The Lack had ended everywhere else. It did not end in the Fast. It has never ended in the Fast. They called themselves the Unfed, and they wrote down the day, and they began, almost at once, to be proud of it.

WHAT THE OTHERS SAY

Every land outside the Fast has its own version of the Refusal, and none of them are kind. In the Fatlands it is a joke about a man who died of hunger in a bakery. In Oathen it is cited in Clausewright schools as the classic example of an oath nobody actually swore and everyone kept anyway. In Sallowreach, where nothing ends, they find the whole thing faintly obscene: a people who chose to finish. In the Vigil the Seemers say the Unfed simply arrived late to the meal and have spent six hundred years pretending they meant to. That last version is closer to something than anyone outside the Fast suspects. See Meek Garrity, below.

▼ THE RULE OF THE LAND

Never accept.

Orrum walks the Fast. Nobody living has seen it clearly and come back whole. The descriptions agree on very little: that it is tall, that it stoops under doorways, that it moves slowly and without sound, that it is warm. Some who have glimpsed it describe long arms folded in an apron. Some describe a shape like a figure made of the light from an open oven door. A Hostwatch tracker named Spare Tolland, who has followed it for thirty years, says only that it is “the size you’d expect if you were very small and someone was about to pick you up.”

It does not attack. It has never, in six centuries, raised a hand against anyone. It hosts. Wherever it passes, tables appear: in empty farmhouses, in hollow barns, in the middle of a road, on a frozen pond, at a crossroads at dusk. They are always perfect. The cloth is white and pressed. The plates are hot. The food steams. A lamp burns in the middle, and a chair is pulled out, angled toward whoever is nearest, the way a good host angles it for an honoured guest who is a little unsteady on their feet.

If you sit, you are a guest. A guest of Orrum does not get up.

The Unfed call them the Seated. They stay at table for years, for decades, and the longest-seated have been at table for over five hundred years. They eat from the plates in front of them, which are empty. They lift silver forks laden with nothing and put the nothing in their mouths and chew it slowly with every appearance of delight. They sip from empty cups. They talk to one another about the food, in loving detail. They do not die, or not for a long time; they waste. Orrum’s hospitality keeps them alive far beyond what the

body should bear, and it does not keep them well. They grow thin, then thinner, until the skin lies on the bone like wet paper on a frame, until the teeth stand out of the gums like pegs on a board, until the eyes have sunk so deep that the lamplight on the table catches them only from below. They are always smiling. They will tell you this is the best meal they have ever eaten. They will ask you to join them. They mean it kindly.

You cannot pull a Seated person away from the table. People have tried, with ropes and oxen. The Seated come up out of their chairs easily enough, light as dry leaves, and they scream, a dreadful high scream like a kettle, and they reach back for the table with both hands, and when they are dragged beyond the length of the cloth they die in a few minutes of a starvation that has been waiting for them, patiently, for decades. The body goes all at once, as though a debt had been called in. Those who have watched it say that the last thing the Seated do is apologise to the host for leaving early.

THE FIVE RULES

Every child in the Fast learns these before their letters, usually by about four, and is made to recite them before their daily ration. A child who stumbles over them does not eat that day.

- ◇ Never enter a house where the hearth is already lit.
- ◇ Never answer "Come in."
- ◇ Never eat what you did not carry yourself.
- ◇ If you smell bread, walk into the wind.
- ◇ If a chair is pulled out for you, do not thank it.

The Unfed argue endlessly about the fifth rule. The orthodox reading is that thanking the chair counts as acceptance. The Hostwatch have a darker reading: that Orrum is lonely, and thanks are the one thing it has not been given in six hundred years, and to give it any is to make it want more.

Nothing else grows. For the Unfed the Lack never ended. Seed sown in the Fast rots in the ground, swelling and splitting and putting out no shoot, until in a week it is a grey paste with a sweet bad smell. Hens brought in from the Rim stop laying the day they cross the border. Cows go dry. A sow in farrow will deliver a litter of perfectly formed piglets, each the size of a thumb and each with nothing inside, a skin around air, like the hollow apples of the ninth winter. Fish brought in live in barrels turn belly-up by the second day. Bread baked in the Fast from Rim flour rises, browns, smells correct, and is ash inside when broken. That is why the Unfed eat their food cold, and raw, or cooked out under the open sky on bare ground: an oven in the Fast is the god's.

Every mouthful eaten in the Fast is carried in from the Rim. The only food the land itself offers is Orrum's.

The land is perfect and nobody tends it. The hedges are trimmed square. The orchard grass is short. The windows in empty farmhouses are clean, the doorsteps are swept, the brass knockers are

▼ WHAT GROWS INSTEAD

The Fast has no Regrowth, because nothing was eaten. There is no godsign in the blood of the Unfed, no Cut, no hunger that is not their own. What it has instead is the opposite of a Regrowth, and in the long run it may be worse: a whole, living, unhoused god whose one purpose has been refused for six centuries. A Host whose guests will not come in. What is growing in the Fast is not Orrum. Orrum has never been smaller. What is growing is Orrum's need.

The Hostwatch keep the oldest records of it, and they divide its progress into four ages, the way the other lands divide the stages of their Regrowth. The comparison is deliberate. The Hostwatch believe the Fast is a single body, and that the Host is coming to its own Seating.

polished, and the beds are made with the corners turned down. It is as if the whole country were a house kept ready for a guest who is due any moment, and has been due for six hundred and forty-one years.

EARLY: THE DISTANT BOARD

For the first century after the Refusal, Orrum's tables were rare and far from people. A table might be found once a season, in a high meadow, at the end of a forgotten lane, laid for one. Shepherds who found them describe them as small and almost shy: a single plate, a single cup, a little loaf, a candle. The Unfed of that age smashed the first tables in a frenzy and then, finding that nothing happened when they did, began simply to walk past them. Some left the tables to stand, and found them weeks later still steaming, the candle no shorter, the butter still cold and beaded on its dish.

FOR CENTURIES: THE KEPT HOUSE

From about the first century until within living memory, Orrum's need moved indoors. The Unfed had abandoned most of the heartland and drawn in toward the eastern edge, near the Rim and its food. The god kept the houses they had left. Tables began to appear in empty farmhouses, laid for a whole family. Hearths were found lit in roofless ruins, with no wood in them and no ash beneath, only a steady low fire like a banked coal that warmed the hand at a yard's distance and never burned down. A traveller sheltering in a ruin might wake to the sound of a pot lid lifting. The Unfed learned to sleep only in houses whose hearths they had personally bricked up, and to check the brick each night with a palm laid flat.

WITHIN LIVING MEMORY: THE LAID PLACE

Then the tables came home. In the generation before this one, tables began to be found laid at dawn inside occupied houses: in kitchens that have had no hearth for six hundred years, on floors that families had slept on the night before. No one heard anything. The family woke to a smell, and came downstairs, and found the cloth and the plates and the lamp, and the chairs pulled out, one for each of them, in the right order of age. Then, three years ago, the place cards began. Small folded cards in front of each plate, with a name written on them in a fine, round, careful hand. The names are always spelled correctly. The Unfed spell their names with deliberate oddity, to be unfindable; it has made no difference. The cards know nicknames. The cards know names given in secret and never spoken.

NOW: CALLING ON THE NEIGHBOURS

In the last year, Orrum's tables have been found outside the Fast. At a crossroads in the Fatlands. On a pier-section in Lowmark. In a lamp-lit square in the Vigil, where eleven districts saw a tall figure laying cloth in the street. The Host has started calling on the neighbours. The Hostwatch report it walking the Rim Road at night, stooping to look in at the windows of Company inns, its warm breath fogging the glass. It looks, they say, like someone counting the chairs.

THE BRINK: WHAT COMES NEXT

No Unfed scholar will say what the fifth age is. The Hostwatch have a word for it in their private ledgers, which is *Sitting-Down*, and they mean it in the sense of a feast beginning: the moment when the host takes their own seat at the head of the table and the meal can start. Whose meal, and who has been invited, are questions the Hostwatch have stopped asking aloud. They have noticed that the tables are getting bigger. They have noticed that the newest tables,

the ones on the Rim Road, are laid with one more place than there are guests within a day's walk, and that the extra chair is never pulled out. It stands pushed in, square to the table, with its back to the lamp. Nobody sits there. Nobody has been invited to.

THE SEATED: HOW A GUEST WASTES

There is a rhythm to it, and the Unfed know it the way other peoples know the stages of a fever.

- ◇ **The First Course** (days to months). The guest eats with gusto. They are flushed, warm, and very talkative. They describe the food to anyone who will listen, and the descriptions are dreadful to hear, because they are so good: the crackle of pork skin, the sweetness of new peas, the way the gravy has a little port in it. Their own bodies do not yet show the cost. They are lucid. They will tell you, quite sensibly, that they know they ought to get up, and that they will, after the next course.
- ◇ **The Middle Courses** (years). The guest thins. The cheeks go first, then the temples, which sink until the skull shows its shape. The lips draw back from the teeth. The hands grow knuckly and spotted and the nails go yellow and ridged. Hair falls into the empty plates and the guest eats it without noticing. Their breath smells of acetone and of something sweeter underneath, like fruit left in a bowl too long. They are still happy. They can no longer remember the names of anyone not at the table.
- ◇ **The Long Table** (decades). The guest has become a frame. Skin like parchment, the colour of weak tea, stretched so tight across the ribs that the heartbeat can be seen through it as a small, slow knocking. The belly has fallen in so far it touches the spine. Joints are swollen knots. Teeth loosen and drop onto the plate with a small clean sound, and the guest picks them up with the fork, and chews them, and swallows, and praises them. They have stopped blinking. They whisper now, because there is not breath enough for more, and what they whisper is the menu.
- ◇ **The Last Course** (centuries). Almost nothing is left. The oldest of the Seated on the Long Table are little more than clothes holding a posture, light as a wasps' nest, a smile hung between two cheekbones. They no longer lift the fork. They move their jaws, very slowly, perhaps once an hour. They do not speak. But when a living person walks past them on the valley road, every one of them turns, together, with a sound like a stand of dry reeds moving in a wind, and looks.

▼ LAND AND WEATHER

The Fast is the best farmland on the Table, and almost no one lives on it. It is a country of long, rolling fields of black loam over limestone, of beech hangers and chalk streams, of good stone farmhouses with deep-set windows and roofs of combed thatch or grey slate, of orchards in rows so straight they look ruled with a stick. It is all six centuries empty, and all perfectly kept. The hedges are laid and trimmed. The ditches run clear. Field gates hang true on their hinges and do not creak. Every window is clean. Nobody does it.

It is always early Carving here. The seasons turn on the Rim, but within a day's walk of the border the year stops at one golden afternoon in the first week of autumn and stays there: mild, still, the light low and amber and coming from slightly too far to the west, so that every shadow is long and every field has the colour of a crust. The leaves on the beeches are on the turn and never fall. There is no frost, except where the Unfed live. There is no wind, except what the Unfed bring with them. Sound carries a long way in the stillness: a dropped pail, a cough, a child reciting the rules. Visitors from the Rim find the silence and the warmth unbearably soothing, and the Crumb-Runners have a saying that a Fatlander who stops to admire the view in the Fast is a Fatlander who stops.

The air smells of baking with no source. It is faint on the borders and strong in the heartland: new bread, brown butter, roasting onion, the spitting of fat, sometimes cinnamon or clove, sometimes a sharp clean smell of mint crushed for a sauce. Unfed children cannot remember a time before the smell, and are taught to breathe through the mouth, shallowly, and to spit when the mouth fills. Adults have a characteristic way of standing with the lips slightly parted and the tongue held flat against the floor of the mouth. Crumb-Runners plug their nostrils with wax and tallow.

Chimneys smoke over houses nobody lives in. From any hilltop in the heartland a traveller can count dozens of fine grey threads rising straight up into the gold, each one from an empty house where a hearth is lit and a table laid. On a still evening they look like the pins on a Hostwatch map.

The ground is warm where the god has walked. The Unfed, who live in the narrow cold margin of the east where the Rim's weather still reaches, track Orrum by melted frost. A warm front moving across the fields at night leaves a path of dark wet grass through the white, wide as a cart track, and in the morning the Hostwatch walk out and measure it and mark the map. The Unfed call a warm front *company*. "Company in the west field" is the commonest warning in the Fast. "Expecting company?" is the commonest threat.

The only true weather the Unfed fear is a change in the smell. When the baking smell sharpens and deepens toward roast meat,

Orrum is near. When it goes sweet, toward custard and burnt sugar and warm milk, the god is laying a table for a child, and every household in range rings a hand-bell at the door and counts its children through it.

HALLOWBOARD

The stone table of the Refusal stands on a bare, round, chalky hill at the exact centre of the continent. It is a slab of grey granite, a stone found nowhere else in the Fast, roughly forty feet across and waist-high to a tall man, and it has eight sides. It is always clean. In six hundred years no moss has grown on it, no bird has fouled it, and no leaf has lain on it overnight. Its surface is polished to a dull gleam, as if by ten thousand years of cloths.

Around seven of its eight sides the chalk of the hilltop is worn into a shallow trench where the forty thousand stood for nine days. The trench is pale and hard as a step, and in some lights the impressions of bare feet and knees can be seen in it, layered over each other. The bones of the Refusal were gathered and buried in the Barrows below the hill, but the chalk still turns up teeth after rain.

The eighth side is not worn. The chalk before it is smooth and white and has the faint bloom of untrodden ground. No Unfed will stand there. When asked why, they do not say it is forbidden. They say, with a puzzled look, as though the question had never occurred to them, that it is someone else's place. On the edge of the stone on that side there is a carved panel, the only carving on the table, and the figure in it has been removed: not chiselled out in the way of the other lands' carvings, but smoothed away, as though by a thumb pressed into wet clay, a long time ago, many times.

On Tablenight the Abstinents lead a procession up the hill to stand around Hollowboard, backs to it, through the longest night. In the morning there is sometimes the faint warm print of a large hand on the stone, palm down, beside each of the seven worn sides, like a host's hand resting by a guest's plate. There is never one on the eighth.

WANTING

The Unfed's only real town stands on the cold eastern edge of the Fast, half a day from the Rim Road, where the land's endless Carving fades into the ordinary seasons of the world. It is a cold, plain, hearthless place of perhaps nine thousand souls: long low houses of rough grey stone, roofed with slate, with no chimneys. Windows are narrow. Doors are heavy, iron-strapped, and hung to open outward, so that no one inside can be said to have let anyone in. There are no inns, no bakeries, and no kitchens. Cooking is done in the Cold Yards, walled squares of beaten earth at the town's edge

where fires are lit on the bare ground under the open sky and put out the moment the food is warm. The smell of Wanting is wet stone, woodsmoke, unwashed wool, and the faint ketone-and-pear-drop breath of nine thousand people who are always a little hungry.

The streets are quiet. People walk slowly, to save their strength. In Lack the town is ringed with frost, and the frost is precious: it means the god is not near.

THE LONG TABLE

A valley road in the old heart of the country, running between two lines of beech-hung hills, where six hundred years of the Seated sit at one continuous table, nine miles end to end, eating nothing in good cheer. It began, the Hostwatch think, as a single table at a crossroads in the second century, and it has grown with every guest. The boards are of a pale wood that has never been identified. The cloth is unbroken and spotless for nine miles. The lamps are lit day and night. Perhaps eleven thousand people sit at it, on both sides, in every stage of wasting, from the newly sat (flushed, chattering, eating with both hands) to the most ancient, near the valley's head, who are only coats and smiles.

The road beside the Long Table is still used, because it is the only straight road across the heartland. Crumb-Runners take it at a trot with their eyes on the ground and their ears stopped with wax, because the Seated call out to everyone who passes. They call by name. They describe the dishes. They say *we saved you a seat*, and somewhere along the nine miles there is always an empty chair, pulled out, and it is always a little further along than the last time you came.

THE PANTRY

A fortified granary in the centre of Wanting, the best-guarded building in the Fast and its only true seat of government. It is a squat round tower of dressed stone, five storeys high, with walls eight feet thick and no windows below the fourth floor. Its single door is iron, opens outward, and has three locks, whose keys are held by three different people. Inside, in cool dry dark, lie the grain sacks, the salt-fish casks, the cheeses, the dried peas, and the ledgers: every ration ever given out in the Fast, recorded by name, by day, by weight, back to 41 A.G. The smell inside is of dust, mouse, and sacking, and to an Unfed nose it is the richest smell in the world.

Every morning the Ration Line forms outside the iron door before dawn. Every evening the Keeper of the Pantry reads out the next day's list. A name not on the list does not eat. The list is never explained.

THE EMPTY CHAIR

The last standing temple of Orrum, on a wooded rise six miles west of Wanting: a long low hall of honey-coloured stone with a slate roof and a single great table running its whole length, laid, in the old

days, for every worshipper in the parish. Every other temple of the Host was pulled down by the Unfed in the first century. This one was left, nobody now remembers why, and is kept by a single Verger, Sober Osmond, who every night lays one place at the head of the table, against all law, and every morning finds the plate clean. The Abstinent have condemned him eleven times. They have never sent anyone to stop him.

BRINDLE CROSS

The main crossing point between the Rim Road and the Fast, where the Wanting road meets the ring. A Rim Road Company toll-house, a stockade, a weighing-shed, and the Fast's border garrison under Marshal Keep Aldane, all crowded into a muddy hollow. Here grain is weighed in from Company wagons and signed for by the Pantry's clerks, and here the poachers are caught, or not. On the Rim side stands a Company inn, the Brimming Cup, which is the nearest hot meal to the Fast and is avoided by every Unfed on principle. Children from Wanting are brought to the Cross once, at the age of eight, to watch through the inn window as Rim folk eat, laughing, with their mouths open. It is meant to teach them disgust. It does not always work.

THE BARROWS

A field of long, low, grassed mounds on the lower slopes of Hallowboard hill, where the dead of the Refusal were buried by the survivors in the spring of 1 A.G., in trenches, nine and ten deep. The grass on the Barrows is the only grass in the Fast that is untrimmed: long, coarse, and pale, like hair. In the evening the mounds are warm. The Hostwatch say that Orrum comes and sits among them some nights, the way a mourner sits at a grave, and that the warm patch it leaves is shaped like a person lying down with their arms around something.

THE LEAN HOUSE

A long, windowless stone byre at the far end of Wanting, beyond the Cold Yards, where the people whose names have been left off the Pantry list go to wait. Nobody sends them there. There is no law. They simply go, because it is where the others went, and because at the Lean House no one will offer them food, and to be offered food when you have been left off the list is a torment past bearing. It is kept by a woman named Withy Gaunt. It is very quiet. The straw is changed weekly. There is a book.

HARTSELL'S FIELD

A ten-acre field on a south-facing slope in the old farmland north of Wanting, in the margin where the Rim's seasons still faintly reach. Yield Hartsell has ploughed it, harrowed it, and sown it every spring for fifty years, and every spring the seed has rotted. This year, in one corner, one seed came up. It is now a single blade of green wheat, four inches tall, inside a fence of hurdles, inside a second fence of

thorn, inside a ring of tripwire hung with tin cans. It is the only living crop in the Fast. It is watered every night. Yield does not do it.

THE STOOPWAY

The old pilgrim road from Hallowboard to the eastern border, along which Orrum walked away on the tenth morning. Every gate, arch, and lintel along its length is too low by a foot, and every one of them has a smooth dark patch worn into the underside of its top beam, as if by a tall head brushing it, over and over, for six centuries. The Unfed do not walk the Stoopway. Children dare one another to touch the worn patches, which are warm.

ASH MILL

A great stone watermill on a chalk stream in the middle country, abandoned since the Refusal, whose wheel still turns. The millstones grind, day and night, with nothing between them, and from the chute there falls a fine pale flour that is warm to the touch and smells of nothing. It is Orrum’s flour. The Unfed will not go near it. Rim smugglers buy it from desperate Crumb-Runners and sell it in the Fatlands as Fast-flour, a cure for hunger, and the

Fatlanders who eat it say, weeping, that for an hour afterwards they felt full. Some of them have since walked into the Fast and not come out.

TRAVELLING IN THE FAST

Crossing the Fast is forbidden by every Rim government, discouraged by the Company, and done every week by Crumb-Runners, Reckoners, Tablebreakers, Hostwatch trackers, poachers, and pilgrims. The heartland is fine walking country: dry roads, clear streams, no bandits, no beasts, and empty houses at every mile. The danger is entirely in accepting any of it. A party crossing the Fast carries all its own food and water, sleeps outdoors with its back to every building, keeps one watcher awake to sniff the air, and ties itself together at night with rope so that no one can get up and walk toward a light. Water from the streams of the Fast is safe, the Unfed insist, because it is not offered. Rain is safe. Anything laid out, poured, served, set down, or left on a doorstep is not. Running water inside a house is offered. A well with a bucket already drawn is offered. A gate held open is a gray area, and the Unfed close every one they pass through, on principle, and then go through it again.

▼ HISTORY

The Unfed keep their history the way they keep their food: plain, cold, counted, and portioned out to children a little at a time. The Abstinents’ chroniclers write it in short entries in the Pantry ledgers

themselves, between the ration lists, so that the Fast’s account of its own past is interleaved, page by page, with the names of who ate on what day.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
0	The Refusal at Hallowboard. Nine in ten die. Orrum rises on the tenth morning and walks away.
1	The Burying. The Barrows dug. The Five Rules first spoken as a single creed.
0–40	The Thin Years. Survivors live on what the Rim will sell. The first Crumb-Runners.
41	The first Pantry ledger. The Abstinents formed from the eldest survivors of the hill.
44	The First Sitting. A starving family sits at a table in their own kitchen.
55	The neighbours of the First Sitting finally stop watching through the window.
97	The Temple Pulling. Every temple of Orrum torn down, save the Empty Chair.
130 onward	The Vindication. Godsign appears abroad. The Unfed become prophets.
188	Wanting built. The last Unfed leave the heartland for the eastern edge.
233	The Long Table first measured at one mile.
301	The first recorded poaching. Eleven Unfed taken from Brindle Cross to Sallowreach.
358	The Hostwatch chartered by the Abstinents to track and map the god.
402	The Reckoning. The first armed band crosses the Rim to kill a high-Cut family.
466	The Starved Saints first recorded. Sister Abate Fennick lives eleven months on water.
511	The Great Short. A Company grain embargo. The Pantry’s first winter of choosing.
590s	Tables first found laid in occupied houses.
638	The Calling-Cards. The first place card, bearing the finder’s name.

YEAR (A.G.)	EVENT
640	Tables found at crossroads in three other lands. The Pilgrims begin to cross.
641	The present. One green blade in Hartsell's Field. Four months of grain for six of winter.

THE THIN YEARS AND THE FIRST SITTING

The survivors of Hallowboard came down from the hill to find their land kept and their larders empty, and they did what starving people do, which is to walk toward food. The Rim sold to them. It sold to them at ruinous prices, because the Rim had, overnight, become rich and the Unfed had nothing to sell but what they had brought down from their ruined homes: silver plate, linen, pewter, the tableware of a people who had worshipped a Host. The Fatlands in particular bought it eagerly. There are still Gut-line houses in Sated that eat off the stolen plate of Unfed grandmothers and call it heirloom.

In 44 A.G., in a village called Corve Hatch, a family of five who had been left with nothing to sell came down one morning and found their table laid. The father, a man named Abel Corve, is recorded as having said the full three refusals and then a fourth, and then sat down, and then pulled out the chairs for his wife and children. His neighbours gathered at the window. The family ate, and laughed, and called out to them to come in, there was plenty. The neighbours knocked on the glass and wept and begged them to get up, and for eleven years they came every day and watched the family waste, and in all that time they never broke the window, because they were afraid of what was inside. When the last child's head finally drooped forward onto the cloth, in 55 A.G., the neighbours went home. The Corve house stands still. The family sit at their table. The window has been bricked up from the outside.

THE VINDICATION

For a century, the Unfed were the Table's laughing-stock: the people who died of politeness. Then, in the 130s, reports began to come in along the Rim of the first godsign: Hand-lines children who could not sleep with a door ajar, coughing in Brinehollow, a newborn in Kest saying "Not yet." By 200 it was undeniable. The Unfed, in their cold houses on the eastern edge, discovered that they were the only clean people left in the world, and it went to their heads at once and has never come down. Every Unfed sermon since has a version of the same line: *They laughed at the table. Now the table is laughing at them.* The Abstinents sent the first Envoy to the Rim Road in 214, to remind six nations that they were damned. The Fast has had one ever since.

THE GREAT SHORT

In 511 the Rim Road Company, in a pricing dispute with the Board of Plenty, embargoed all grain moving through Brindle Cross for one winter. The Pantry held enough for half the Fast. The Keeper of that year, a woman named Scarcity Hume, drew up the first list: the names who would eat. The others were simply not called. There was no announcement, no judgment, no blood. People came to the Ration Line, waited, heard the list read, did not hear their names, and went home. Some came back the next day, and the next. Then they stopped coming. Half the Fast died that winter, quietly, in their own houses, with their backs to their own doors. The Fast did not riot. Riot would have been an appetite. Scarcity Hume was honoured for it. The list has been a standing instrument of government since.

THE RECKONING

The Reckoners date their founding to the night of the 16th of Lack, 402, when nineteen young Unfed under a woman named Forswear Kell crossed the Rim Road into the Fatlands and entered the manor of a Gut-lines family named Brawne. They killed everyone in it: the Laden matriarch in her bed, her sons, her daughters, their spouses, and the infants in the nursery, whose deaths the Reckoners' own chronicle records only in a single line, *the line was ended*. They did not touch the servants. They did not take anything. They walked home through the Fatlands carrying nothing at all, starved, and were received at Wanting as heroes by the young and in cold silence by the Abstinents, who did not condemn them. The Reckoners have crossed the Rim every year since.

THE CALLING-CARDS

In the spring of 638, a girl of twelve in a hamlet outside Wanting went down at dawn to find a table laid in her family's kitchen, as had happened in living memory a dozen times. Before her own plate there was a folded card. It said, in a round and loving hand, *Abstain*, and under it, smaller, the pet name her dead grandmother used to call her, which no living person knew. The cards have come to more than three hundred houses since. A Hostwatch clerk who collected and compared them found that the handwriting is not the same on every card. It is, each time, the handwriting of someone the finder loved and lost.

▼RULE, LAW AND POLITICS

The Fast is governed by the Abstinents, a council of between nine and fifteen elders who claim descent from those who stood on Hallowboard hill. Their authority is entirely moral and therefore absolute. They make no laws in the ordinary sense, because the Five Rules are the only law the Unfed recognise. They hear no lawsuits, because there is nothing in the Fast worth suing over. They raise no taxes, because there is nothing to tax. Their whole power is the Pantry.

Every scrap of food in the Fast is imported by Crumb-Runners or bought from the Rim Road Company, pooled in the Pantry at Wanting, and rationed out by the council through the Keeper of the Pantry. The standard ration, the Pantry measure, is half an oatcake and a thumb of fat or cheese per adult per day, with pease or salt fish twice a week. It is enough to keep an adult alive and upright and incapable of much else. Children get a three-quarter measure until twelve. Hard labourers, Reckoners on campaign, and Tablebreakers get a full measure, which is the source of most envy in the Fast.

Exile from the Pantry is the only punishment the Fast imposes, and it is a death sentence that leaves no blood on anyone's hands. It is never pronounced. A name is simply left off the list. The person may beg, may appeal to the Abstinents in open session, may try to buy food from a Crumb-Runner with whatever they have, may cross the Rim and try to live there. Most do not. The Unfed are poor travellers and worse beggars, and among their own people the omitted are treated with a terrible gentle courtesy, never mentioned, never offered anything, greeted in the street with lowered eyes, as though they were already in the Barrows. Most walk to the Lean House within a fortnight.

The two great poles of Fast politics are the **Keepers** and the **Reckoners**. The Keepers are not a faction but a temperament, the majority view on the Abstinents: the Unfed's duty is to refuse,

endure, and stay clean, to keep the Five Rules and outlast the Godeaters, who are damning themselves without any help. The Reckoners hold that refusing was not enough, and that the Godeaters must be made to answer for it, bloodline by bloodline. The Abstinents have never formally approved a Reckoner raid. They have never condemned one. Every Reckoner on campaign draws a full measure from the Pantry.

Every other land has a use for the Unfed. Having no godsign, they are in effect a whole nation of Blanks: blood that carries no god, organs that grow no Regrowth, flesh that the Cutwrights' College reckons at Cut 0 and the surgeons of four countries reckon at a noble's ransom. Poachers cross the border for them every month. The Abstinents' answer is Marshal Keep Aldane and his garrison of sixty at Brindle Cross, and a standing order that any Unfed taken alive across the border is to be considered dead and removed from the Pantry list.

THE FAST AND THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

The Fast cannot feed itself, cannot trade anything the Rim wants except its own people, and has no army. It survives because the Rim Road Company sells it grain on credit, under a contract sworn in Oathen before the Company's notary Jessamy Quill, renewed every seven years. The Abstinents have never asked what the Company gets in return. The contract's terms are kept in the Pantry, in a locked box, read by the Chair of the Abstinents alone. The current Chair, Forbear Wend, read them once, on the night of his election, and has not slept a night through since. GMs: the Company is paid partly in silver from the old Unfed temple treasures, and partly in a clause that grants it "first refusal" on any Unfed who dies outside the Pantry's care. The Company has never exercised it. It holds the paper.

▼CULTURE AND DAILY LIFE

THINNESS IS HOLINESS

The Unfed eat once a day, cold, standing, and without visible pleasure. They eat facing a wall or the open sky, never one another. To chew with an expression on one's face is coarse; to close the eyes while eating is obscene; to make a sound of appreciation is a confession. An Unfed who catches themselves enjoying a mouthful will spit it into their hand, look at it, and then eat it again, slowly, as a penance. Fat people are pitied, then distrusted, then reported. The most admired body in the Fast is one in which every rib can be counted through a shirt. Unfed lovers trace each other's bones in the dark, in silence, as tenderly as other peoples kiss.

The whole people has the look of chronic hunger: the dry, brittle hair, sometimes faded to a reddish straw; the downy fur of lanugo along the forearms and jaw; the slight puffiness of ankles and faces in those whose bodies have begun to fail; the cold blue fingertips; the breath that smells of pear-drops. Their skin bruises at a touch. Their wounds heal slowly. They feel the cold terribly, and in winter they wear everything they own at once. Their teeth, by contrast, are good: there is little sugar in the Fast to rot them.

NAMES

Children are named for the Refusal: Forbear, Abstain, Decline, Stint, Tarry, Nay, Spare, Lent, Wont, Want, Meagre, Scant, Yield, Keep. They are named on the day they first refuse something,

usually the breast, which is why many Unfed children are three or four months old before they have a name. The surnames are older, from before the Gorging, and often taken from vanished villages or the trades of the Host: Ashby, Hollis, Moss, Avery, Rooke, Bellamy, Garrity, Hartsell. Some families quietly carry names like Ardent, Blythe, Welcome, Mercy, Hallow, which were Orrum's names once, and are now a kind of family shame. An Unfed who changes their name to something from the Rim is considered to have emigrated, even if they never leave Wanting.

NO HEARTHS

Homes in the Fast have no fireplace, no oven, no chimney, and no dining table. Unfed furniture is a bench along the wall, a shelf for the ration-cloth, and a sleeping pallet with the head toward the door. The great absence at the centre of every room is the clue to every Unfed house: where other peoples would put the table, the Unfed leave bare floor, and on most floors in the Fast that space is worn smooth in a ring by generations of people walking around it, not across it. Families gather, if they gather at all, standing, against the walls.

Cooking is done outdoors on bare ground in the Cold Yards, quickly, and the fire is stamped out the moment the pot is warm. Food is eaten from the hand. A spoon is a luxury and a fork is a disgrace. The Unfed bring their own water in their own flasks to every meeting and drink only from them.

THE DECLINE

The proper response to any offer of anything is "No, thank you," said three times. Accepting on the fourth is good manners. Accepting on the first is a scandal. This applies to a cup of water, a hand up a step, a seat at a meeting, a compliment, a marriage proposal. A host who offers only three times is mean; a guest who takes on the third is greedy. A great deal of Unfed social intelligence goes into the fourth offer: who makes it, in what tone, and whether it is meant. Orrum, who has made hundreds of thousands of first offers, second offers, and third offers across six centuries, has never once been known to make a fourth. The Hostwatch think this is not an accident. The god, they say, knows the manners of its people perfectly, and is waiting to be asked properly to stop.

PRIDE

The Unfed are the only innocent people on the Table, and they are insufferable about it. They do not pray for the damned of other lands. They do not pity them. They report on them, with a certain cold relish, in sermons and broadsheets and the dispatches of Envoy Prudence Lowell, and every Unfed child can recite the stages of the Regrowth of all six Godeater lands the way other children recite kings. When an Unfed meets a Rim person, they will at some point, usually early, ask after the state of that person's blood. It is meant as a courtesy.

MARRIAGE AND KIN

Unfed marriages are made by the Abstinent, through the Pantry: two people who marry share one ration-line, and their household's measure is adjusted accordingly. Courtship consists of one person repeatedly offering the other something small (a pebble, a feather, a blade of the precious Rim grass) and being refused three times, for months, until one evening the fourth offer is made and taken. Wedding vows are spoken standing back to back. What passes between spouses in private is nobody's business, and the Unfed speak of it hardly at all; desire is an appetite, and appetites are suspect. Unfed birth rates are low and falling, which the Abstinent attribute to virtue and Dr. Mercy Thrane attributes to starvation. Most Unfed women of childbearing age have not bled in years.

CHILDREN

Unfed children are small for their age, solemn, and very good. They learn the Five Rules before their letters, the Decline before their names, and the stages of every foreign Regrowth before they can count to twenty. They are given one toy, usually a carved bone or stone. They are not allowed to play at house, or at tea, or at any game with plates. They are watched constantly, because Orrum loves them best: the tables laid for children are the most beautiful, all honey and custard and little iced cakes, and the voice that calls from the door is always the voice of a mother or grandmother. A child who goes missing is presumed Seated, and the household rings its bell at the door every dusk for a year, calling the child's name, and then stops. The Unfed do not hold funerals for the Seated. You cannot bury a guest who has not left.

DEATH RITES

The Unfed die, mostly, of hunger and cold and the long, slow failure of bodies that have never once been properly fed. Their deaths are quiet. The dying are laid on the floor in the bare space where a table would be, with their head toward the door, and the family stand around the walls with their backs to the body and say the Decline three times, which is the whole of the last rites. *No, thank you. No, thank you. No, thank you.* The dead are buried without food, without grave goods, without coffins, wrapped in a single ration-cloth, face down, in the open fields, so that they cannot sit up. Graves are unmarked. Sometimes, in the morning, a grave is found to have a little table beside it, laid for one, a candle burning. The family breaks it with an axe and buries the pieces.

FESTIVALS

The Unfed have one festival, and it is Tablenight. On the longest night of Lack, every person in the Fast stands outdoors from dusk until dawn, with their back to every door, in the bitter cold, holding the hands of those on either side. They do not speak. They do not move. On that night, in every house in the Fast, the table is laid. It is laid in every Unfed house, every barn, every byre, every outbuilding,

and in the Pantry itself, behind the three-locked iron door. The smell of it is so strong that people faint, and are held up by their neighbours, and are not allowed to fall. At dawn the households turn and go in and break the tables with axes. Every Unfed house owns an axe for no other purpose. It hangs by the door.

CRIME AND PUNISHMENT

There is little crime in the Fast, because there is little to steal and less to want. The commonest crimes are hoarding (keeping back part of a ration), mouth-theft (stealing a ration), and feeding: giving one's own food to another, which the Abstinent forbid because it confuses the ledgers and, worse, because it is hospitality. All are punished the same way, by a cut in measure, or in grave cases, omission. Murder is rare and is punished, in effect, by the victim's family, who are given the murderer's ration for a year. The worst crime in the Fast is to say "Come in" to anyone. It is never punished, because it never needs to be: the Unfed will not cross the threshold of anyone who has said it, ever again, for any reason, and in a land where every scrap of food comes through a common door, that is enough.

PROVERBS

- ◇ "Hunger is honest." (Said to end arguments.)
- ◇ "Carry your own."
- ◇ "The fourth no is a yes in a nicer coat."
- ◇ "It smells like your mother's." (A warning, and the worst thing one Unfed can say to another.)
- ◇ "Empty plate, clean soul."
- ◇ "The table is always laid for the one who stays too long."
- ◇ "No one starves at the Long Table." (Bitter irony.)
- ◇ "Count your chairs."

OATHS ON THE DEAD

The Unfed do not swear by the gods, having refused theirs. They swear on the Barrows, by their dead ancestors of the hill: *By the ones who stood*. A serious oath is sworn standing in the chalk trench at Hallowboard, barefoot, in one's own ancestor's footprint, and Unfed who believe their families stood on a particular stretch of the trench will travel two days to swear there. Oaths sworn on the Barrows are not supernaturally binding, as Oathen's are. They are binding by something worse, which is shame: an Unfed who breaks an oath sworn by the ones who stood has made their ancestors' deaths into a meal, and no one will stand beside them on Tablenight. In practice, this means they stand alone, and are found in the morning sitting at the table in their own house, looking very happy.

▼ FACTIONS

THE ABSTINENT

Who they are. The council of elders who hold the Pantry, and with it the life of every Unfed. They are old, thin, and cold, and they speak slowly to save breath. They meet standing, in a bare stone room on the top floor of the Pantry, around an empty space where a table would be.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Measure-Bearer	Carries rations to outlying hamlets; a full measure on duty days.
2	Pantry Clerk	Reads and copies the ledgers; may witness the weighing.
3	Lister	Proposes names for the daily list; a key to the lower stores.
4	Elder of the Abstinent	A voice in council; one of the three keys may be entrusted to them.
5	Chair of the Abstinent	Holds the last key and the Company contract; strikes names alone.

Joining. A PC of good family who has never been seen to enjoy a meal may be taken on as a Measure-Bearer. Advancement requires Clause or Reckoning, a reputation for refusal, and the willingness to read the list aloud without a change in voice. **Enemies:** the Reckoners (whom they need), Wont Bellamy's circle, poachers. **Allies:** the Keepers of every village, the Rim Road Company, uneasily.

THE RECKONERS

Who they are. Raiders, assassins, and zealots who carry the Refusal across the border on a blade. They travel in bands of five to twenty,

Beliefs and wants. The Refusal was the one clean act in the history of the world, and the Unfed exist to keep it clean. Survival matters less than purity; the Pantry exists not to feed the Fast but to keep it from accepting. The Abstinent want to outlast the Godeaters, and they want, more quietly than they would admit, to never be asked who decides the list.

on foot, carrying their own food, and they strike at the highest Cuts of the Godeater lands in their own beds. They are the Fast's only export.

Beliefs and wants. Refusing was not enough. The Godeaters ate their gods and the gods are coming back through their blood; therefore the blood must be ended. Not punished: ended. A Reckoner raid is not a murder but a weeding, and it is incomplete unless the whole kin-line dies, from the grandmother in the bed to the infant in the cradle to the cousin at university in another city. They want every High Cut line on the Table extinct before the Seating, and they believe they are saving the world, which makes them terribly calm.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Carrier	Bears the band's food and water on a raid; a full measure.
2	Knife	Enters the house; a Reckoner blade, black-iron, unadorned.
3	Kin-Reader	Holds the stolen genealogies; plans which beds, in what order.
4	Band-Captain	Leads a raid; chooses the line; may call on safehouses on the Rim.
5	Reckoner-Captain	Sets the season's lines; a seat (unofficial) at the Abstinent's door.

Joining. Volunteer at Wanting's west gate on the first day of Carving. A recruit is taken on one raid as a Carrier and watched at the bedsides. Those who look away are sent home. Those who do not are given a knife. **Enemies:** every High Cut house, the Cutwrights' College (whose ledgers they steal), the Netwatch, the Wakers, the Second Table. **Allies:** the Purgation (warily), some of the Thin of the Fatlands.

THE BEDSIDE

Reckoners kill at night, indoors, quietly, with knives. They enter through servants' doors, kitchens, coal-holes. They never eat anything in the houses they enter, never drink, never sit, never touch a table. They work through a household by the kin-reader's list, in an order planned weeks before: eldest first, because the eldest are furthest along and most dangerous; then the heirs; then the rest. The worst of it, for those who have done it and come home, is not the blood. It is the beds. High Cut beds are rich and soft and warm, and smell of good food digested, and the people in them are well fed and sleep deeply, and an Unfed Knife standing over one of them in the dark, starved, stiff with cold from three nights on the road, feels something in his chest that is not righteousness. Reckoners have a phrase for it: *bedside hunger*. Some of them come home and cannot stop thinking about the beds. Some come home and cannot stop thinking about the nursery. The band-captains watch for both.

THE TABLEBREAKERS

Who they are. Bands of three to six who hunt Orrum's tables and smash them with axes before anyone can sit. Dangerous, honoured, and short-lived work. They wear wax in their ears, linen bound over their noses and mouths, and blindfolds of loose gauze they can see through dimly, so that the food will be a blur.

Beliefs and wants. Every table is a trap, and every trap broken is a life saved. They do not hate Orrum; most of them, privately, pity it. They want one season without a Seating.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Sniffer	Walks ahead, finds tables by smell; a full measure while hunting.
2	Axe	Breaks tables; an axe blessed on the Barrows.
3	Rope-Holder	Holds the tether that pulls an Axe back from a chair; trusted.
4	Breaker	Leads a band; may claim any Unfed household's axe in emergency.
5	Old Breaker	Over a hundred tables; their name is spoken on Tablenight.

Joining. Break a table alone and bring back a splinter. **Enemies:** the Seated (who call out), the Second Helping pilgrims, Verger Osmond. **Allies:** the Hostwatch, who tell them where to go.

THE CRUMB-RUNNERS

Who they are. Smugglers and carters who bring food in from the Rim by night, on foot and by ox-cart, by the old drove roads. Despised in every street of Wanting, spat on, served last, and the

only reason anyone is alive. The Pantry buys most of what they carry. The rest they sell privately, at prices that would shame a Fatlands usurer.

Beliefs and wants. Mostly, to be paid, and to be thanked once before they die. Many Crumb-Runners have been on the road so long that they have eaten nothing but their own wages in years. They are the most practical people in the Fast and the least pious, and they have seen more of Orrum than anyone but the Hostwatch.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Back	Carries a sack; paid in food, which is worth more than coin.
2	Drover	Drives a cart; may buy at the Cross on credit.
3	Counter	Keeps a cart's tally; trusted with the Pantry's money.
4	Road-Master	Owens carts and oxen; holds a standing Company permit.
5	Grain-Lord	Controls a road; the Abstinent must bargain with them.

Joining. Turn up at Brindle Cross with a strong back and no family. **Enemies:** poachers, Rim toll-sharks, the Abstinent's clerks. **Allies:** Company factors, the Hostwatch, anyone hungry.

THE STARVED SAINTS

Who they are. Ascetics who have stopped eating altogether. Most die in the second month, in the open, in silence, attended by others

who will soon follow. A few have kept it up far longer than a body can. They live in the open fields, sitting in the cold, saying the Decline at every sound.

Beliefs and wants. Every mouthful is a small acceptance, even Rim food, even the Pantry's. Perfect refusal is perfect cleanness. The Saints want to be the first Unfed to want nothing at all. The

Abstinent revere them publicly and dread them privately, because each Saint is one less name to feed and one more reproach.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Novice	Fasts three days in seven; tended by the order.
2	Abstainer	Fasts entirely; is no longer on the Pantry list, by choice.
3	Watcher	Tends the dying Abstainers; reads their last refusals.
4	Saint	Has outlived nature; pilgrims come to touch their robes.
5	Unfed	(Title held by no living person; reserved.)

Joining. Ask, three times, and be refused, and ask a fourth. The order does not proselytise, because that would be an offer. **Enemies:** none admitted. **Allies:** the Abstinent, publicly. *The order’s grief is real.* For every Saint there are dozens of young Unfed who have walked out into the fields after them, and the Watchers’ book of the dead is long. Families of the order’s novices come to the fields to plead, and stand at a distance, because to offer food would be an insult. Many of them stand there until the end.

THE HOSTWATCH

Who they are. Trackers, mapmakers, and scholars who follow the god at a distance and mark where it has been. They read warm

ground, melted frost, the bend of grass, the smell on the air, and they keep the Great Map of the Fast in the cellar of the Pantry, a single sheet of linen thirty feet square, pricked with ten thousand pins.

Beliefs and wants. To understand. The Hostwatch are the only Unfed who think of Orrum as something other than a trap, and the deepest of them have come to love it, distantly, the way you might love a dangerous animal you have watched all your life. They want to know where it is going. Lately they want, very badly, to know who the extra chair is for.

RANK	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Pin-Setter	Copies reports onto the Great Map; a full measure in the field.
2	Tracker	Follows warm ground alone; may requisition rope and lamps.
3	Mile-Walker	Trails the god at a mile; a Hostwatch brass compass.
4	Cartographer	Reads the Great Map; sees the restricted ledgers.
5	Warden of the Map	Sets the Watch’s questions; reports directly to the Chair.

Joining. Find warm ground before a Tracker does and report it. **Enemies:** those who want the map kept secret, and those who want it sold. **Allies:** the Tablebreakers, Crumb-Runners, Verger Osmond (privately).

GODEATER FACTIONS IN THE FAST

The Second Table’s agents work through Wont Bellamy. The Purgation sends fasting-masters to learn from the Starved Saints, and are disappointed. The Cutwrights’ College has never been able to enter the Fast to audit it, and pays Kale Dragoman’s poachers handsomely for “specimens of the Zero line.” The Rim Road Company owns the debt. The Second Helping of the Fatlands sends pilgrims.

▼ THE FAST NOW

Orrum is leaving. For six hundred years the god kept to the Fast, laying tables for a people who would not come. Now its tables have turned up in three other lands, and the Hostwatch report it walking the Rim Road at night, stooping to look in at inn windows. Every

week Spare Tolland pins it a little further from Hallowboard. Every week the extra chair is there.

Pilgrims from the starving Fatlands are crossing in to find it. Osanna Blythe’s three hundred are the first column; there are rumours of thousands behind them. Marshal Keep Aldane holds

Brindle Cross with sixty men against a tide of people who are not trying to hurt anyone, only to sit down.

The Pantry is short. There are four months of grain for six months of winter, and the Rim Road Company has not explained why the autumn deliveries came light. Mother Stint Avery has already decided which villages. Forbear Wend has not yet signed.

A farmer has grown a single green sprout in dead soil. A Saint is being fed by something. A child came home plump. And Meek Garrity’s papers, copied by hand and passed from house to house in Wanting at night, say the worst thing the Unfed have ever heard: that their ancestors never refused. They were only late, and the others had left them nothing.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

- ◆ **The Light Cargo.** Tarry Moss hires the PCs to guard a grain run from Brindle Cross. Halfway in, his count is wrong by one sack, and then by two, and the missing sacks are found laid out on a table in a farmhouse, ground into bread. Someone in the party has been accepting on the road, and the god is returning the favour.
- ◆ **The List.** A PC’s name, or a beloved NPC’s, is left off the Pantry list. Was it Stint Avery’s arithmetic, Forbear Wend’s conscience, or a forged entry by someone who sells the omitted

to Kale Dragoman? The Lean House is filling. Abide Kettering’s cart is coming more often.

- ◆ **The Brawne Precedent.** Scant Hollis is planning a raid into Sated to end a Gut-line, and a PC is the kin-reader. Scarce Odell’s genealogy has a cousin who lives in Wanting, an Unfed foundling who does not know her blood. Is she on the list?
- ◆ **The Place Card.** A PC finds a place card with their name on it, in the handwriting of their dead mother. Every night thereafter another table, closer. Welcome Ardent can explain, if they can catch him, and he can offer a way out that is worse than the table.
- ◆ **The Sprout.** Someone is watering Yield Hartsell’s wheat. The Abstinent want it burned. The Hostwatch want it watched. The Second Table wants it stolen. The pilgrims want to kneel to it.

RUMOURS OF THE FAST

D10	RUMOUR
1	Forbear Wend has a private store in the Pantry and eats at night. (False. He has a private ledger, of the dead.)
2	The Seated at the head of the Long Table have started to stand up. (True, for one minute, at midnight, all together.)
3	Lent Ashby is Orrum’s daughter. (False. But she is the only guest it ever let go, and it has not stopped asking her back.)
4	The Company deliberately shorted the grain so the Fast would sell its people. (Partly true. See Factor Mardle.)
5	A Reckoner came home from Sallowreach and is still walking around, Kept. (False. Kept do not cross borders. But one came home with grey hands.)
6	Eating Fast-flour from Ash Mill makes a Fatlander full forever. (True, for an hour. Then they walk west.)
7	Hallowboard was laid for eight, not seven. (Nobody will confirm or deny it.)
8	The Starved Saints are fed by angels. (False. They are fed by the Host.)
9	Envoy Lowell has defected to the Vigil. (False. She has no friends there either.)
10	Welcome Ardent can be relieved, if someone takes his place. (True.)

THE PEOPLE OF THE FAST

Count your chairs.

– WANTING PROVERB

ELDER FORBEAR WEND, CHAIR OF THE ABSTINENT

Eighty-six, and so thin he is carried through Wanting in a plain ash chair by two boys of the Measure-Bearers, his knees under a blanket and his hands folded on the iron key that hangs from his neck. His skull is a lamp-shade of yellow skin. His voice is soft, dry, perfectly clear, and he never raises it; he does not have the breath. He smells of camphor and old paper and the pear-drop sourness of a body

eating itself. He holds the last key to the Pantry and the Company contract, and he has starved eleven people by leaving their names off a list. He prays for each of them by name, every night, standing, which takes him a long time, since he must be held up. He fears dying before the winter list is signed, because then Stint Avery will sign it, and she will not pray. **Secret:** one of the eleven was his own daughter, Lenten, in the Great Short of his youth; it was not his list, but he carried the measure past her door. **Meeting the PCs:** he summons them to carry a list to an outlying hamlet, unread.

ELDER FORBEAR WEND – CHAIR OF THE ABSTINENT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 1 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 5
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 8 · Pangs 6 (Gaunt)
SKILLS	Resolve 5, Clause 4, Reckoning 4, Persuade 3, Endure 3, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 12 (10 at Gaunt) · Guard 11 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	none worth the name; his bearers carry cudgels +4 (3)
GIFTS	The List (any Unfed in the Fast whose name he strikes loses their ration; this is not magic, and is worse). The Old No (spends Want as a PC does; has never failed an Invitation check).
WANTS	To sign the winter list before he dies. To be forgiven by someone who has the standing.
DREAD	1 (to watch him read the list)
SECRET	He knows the Company’s contract clause on “first refusal” of the Unfed dead, and has said nothing.

RECKONER-CAPTAIN SCANT HOLLIS

A tall woman of forty-four, built of knots and cords, her hair cropped to the skull, her face burned dark by forty raids’ worth of Rim weather. She wears undyed wool and soft boots and carries a single black-iron knife with no guard, the handle wrapped in ration-cloth. She speaks little, flatly, and looks at people the way a farmer

looks at a field: what grows here, and should it. She has ended nine high-Cut bloodlines in their beds, from matriarchs to cradles. She keeps no trophies, because a trophy is a want. She says she is not a murderer, since what she kills stopped being people generations ago, and she says it as a plain fact, like the weather. She fears, truly fears, only one thing: bedside hunger. On the Marrable raid she stood over a sleeping Gut-line child for a full minute, and what she felt was not mercy. **Meeting the PCs:** she recruits them; she needs Carriers with steady stomachs.

SCANT HOLLIS – RECKONER-CAPTAIN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 7 · Pangs 3 (Hollow)
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stealth 5, Endure 4, Resolve 4, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Intimidate 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 19 · Armor 1 (padded wool) · Fray 6
ATTACKS	black-iron long knife +9 (3); bare hands +5 (1)
GIFTS	Bedside Silence (the first attack she makes on a sleeping target is automatically a Grace). Godless Blood (godsign that reads, finds, or tastes the blood cannot find hers; Sallowreach Closers, Brinehollow tides and Oathen bindings work only through ordinary means).
WANTS	Every High Cut line on the Table ended before the Seating. To never again stand still beside a cradle.
DREAD	2 (to see her work a household, room by room)
SECRET	Her mother was taken by poachers when Scant was six; she has crossed the Rim forty times, and every time she has looked for a woman with no godsign working as a servant in a High Cut house.

LENT ASHBY, THE INVITED

Twenty-three, small, colourless as skimmed milk, with very pale eyes and a habit of tilting her head as though listening to a dinner conversation in the next room. At nine she sat down at one of Orrum's tables. At ten, somehow, she got up. She is the only one who ever has. She does not remember why; she remembers only that the food was perfect and that the host was crying. She cannot taste

anything now: Pantry oats and Rim honey and her own blood are all the same grey nothing on her tongue. Wherever she sleeps, a table is found laid in the morning, set for one, her name on the card. The Abstinents keep her moving, a night here, a night there, followed by a Tablebreaker with an axe. Children are not allowed near her. She is very lonely. She is beginning to think the host was crying for her. **Meeting the PCs:** they are assigned to escort her for a week, and wake to the table.

LENT ASHBY – THE INVITED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed, and something else) · Want 10, always · Pangs 2
SKILLS	Resolve 4, Instinct 4, Endure 3, Rites 2, Stealth 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 5
ATTACKS	none
GIFTS	The Guest Who Left (cannot be Seated; she automatically succeeds at any Invitation check, but anyone sleeping within a stone's throw of her must make one each dawn). Tasteless (immune to any poison, drug, or godsign that works through taste or smell, including Fatlands meat).
WANTS	To be told why she was let go. To taste one thing before she dies.
DREAD	3 (to wake beside her laid table)
SECRET	The card at her table has changed. For thirteen years it said <i>Lent</i> . This month it says <i>Steward</i> .

TARRY MOSS, CRUMB-RUNNER

Fifty-three, broad-backed and bandy, with a bitten hand that has never healed straight, a beard like a hedge, and wax plugs in both nostrils that make him breathe through his mouth with a slight whistle. He hauls grain in from the Rim by night, ox-cart and sack, and is spat on in the street by the people it feeds. He has never eaten a mouthful of his own cargo. He counts it, daily, down to the bean, in charcoal on the backs of Pantry manifests, and the counts have lately begun to come out over: one bean more, a handful of oats

more, a sack he did not load. He fears the extra more than he ever feared a shortfall. His boy Stint is in the Lean House now, not omitted, only not eating; he will not eat anything Tarry carries, because it is not what he smelled. **Meeting the PCs:** he hires them as guards; he pays in food.

SISTER NAY CORLISS, STARVED SAINT

She sits on a hurdle in an open field south of Wanting, wrapped in sacking, with her knees drawn up and her hands folded on them,

and has not eaten in three years. She should have died in the first two months. She is translucent: the light of a lamp held behind her hand shows the bones like twigs in amber. Her lips are cracked into deep red seams; her tongue is grey; her breath, when she speaks the Decline, is so faint it barely stirs a feather. Pilgrims come to touch her robe. She does not know she is a miracle of the wrong kind: each morning she wakes with crumbs on her lips, and the novice who wipes them away has never told her. The novice has started to save them, in a twist of cloth. **Secret:** the crumbs are honey-cake, the cake of Nay's childhood, made the way her dead mother made it. **Meeting the PCs:** they are sent to watch her sleep and see who feeds her.

DECLINE MARSH, TABLEBREAKER

A big, slope-shouldered man of thirty-eight with forearms like hams, a voice ruined by shouting through gauze, and the steadiest hands in the Fast. He has put an axe through four hundred tables. He breaks them in a set order: lamp, plates, legs, top, chairs last, every chair. He does not look at the food. On the four hundred and first there was a card at one place with his name on it, and the handwriting was his mother's, who sat at a table when he was four and was dragged from it at his father's insistence and died on the doorstep, apologising. He broke that table too. He has broken nine since. He has not slept indoors since, because he keeps finding the card again in his own coat pocket, and his mother's handwriting has started to say other things.

DECLINE MARSH – TABLEBREAKER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 1 · Caul 3
CUT & REFUSAL	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Want 5 · Pangs 2
SKILLS	Blades 4, Endure 4, Labor 4, Resolve 3, Search 3, Athletics 2
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (leather apron) · Fray 8
ATTACKS	Barrow-blessed axe +8 (4; ignores any warding of Orrum's tables)
GIFTS	Four Hundred Tables (he breaks a laid table in a single action, and all within sight gain +2 on their next Invitation check).
WANTS	To break the table that is laid for his mother. To read the card, just once.
DREAD	1 (to watch him swing)
SECRET	The latest card says <i>Come home, love, I've kept it warm</i> , and gives a place on the Long Table he has never visited.

SPARE TOLLAND OF THE HOSTWATCH

Sixty, wiry, slow-moving, with a face weathered into deep pleated folds and bright, unblinking grey eyes. He wears a Hostwatch compass on a thong and a coat sewn all over with pockets for pins. He has spent thirty years following Orrum at a mile's distance, mapping the warm ground, and he knows its gait, its pauses, the places it likes to stand at dusk. He has never seen its face. He has seen it stop and wait for him to catch up, and he has come to think it is lonely. He speaks of it the way an old farmer speaks of a neighbour's dog that has been chained too long. He is afraid of nothing in the Fast but his own urge to close the mile. **Meeting the PCs:** he needs someone to hold the far end of his rope, because the gap has been shrinking, and he is not sure, any more, which of them is closing it.

WONT BELLAMY, HERETIC ELDER

A plump man, by Unfed standards, which is to say his ribs cannot be counted through his shirt, and the Abstinents never forget it. Fifty-five, soft-voiced, beautifully mannered, with clever dark eyes and a Rim-cut coat. He sits on the council by right of blood, the

Bellamys having stood on the hill, and argues that the Refusal was only a postponement: the Unfed should do now what the others did then, and eat the god that is still whole. He has friends abroad, in the Second Table, who very much agree, and who send him letters sealed in wax pressed with a fork. He fears being found out by Scant Hollis. **Secret:** he has eaten, twice, at Second Table banquets in Sated; it was Fatlands pork, nothing godly, and he enjoyed it so much he wept, and he has told no one. **Meeting the PCs:** he offers them generous work carrying letters, and offers it only once.

MOTHER STINT AVERY, KEEPER OF THE PANTRY

Sixty-two, square, hard-handed, with a stone-mason's forearms and a clerk's ink-stained fingers. She wears an apron of oiled canvas and smells of sacking and mouse. She weighs out every ration in the Fast herself, on brass scales older than Wanting, and she has never once given anyone a grain extra. She knows there are four months of grain for six months of winter. She has already decided which villages: the furthest, the oldest, the ones with fewest children. She has not told Forbear Wend, because he will pray, and praying is a delay, and delay kills more. She is not cruel. She is the only person in the Fast who has done the arithmetic and not looked away from it, and that is a kind of hell. **Secret:** her own village, Avery Steading, is on the list.

She has not told them. **Meeting the PCs:** she asks them to audit a Crumb-Runner's tally, and they find the Company's shortfall.

ABSTAIN ROOKE, CALLED ABBY

Eleven, bird-boned, curious, with a gap in her front teeth and a habit of asking why. Raised on the rules, she can recite them faster than anyone in her hamlet, and she has started leaving a crust on the windowsill at night, saved from her own three-quarter measure. Each morning it has been replaced with something better: a corner of white bread, a ripe plum, a sugared almond, a little honey-cake wrapped in a leaf. She has eaten none of it. She hides it under a loose floor-stone. The pile is getting large, and it does not rot, and it smells wonderful through the stone at night. She is not afraid. She thinks of it as a pen-friend. Her mother does not know; her mother is on Stint Avery's list. **Meeting the PCs:** Abby asks them, very seriously, if it counts as accepting if you are only keeping it for someone else.

BROTHER HALLOW CRUST, THE SEATED

He has sat at a table on the valley road for forty years, eating air with a silver fork. He was a stout man; now he is a draped coat with a head on it, the cheeks hollowed to the teeth, the eyes sunk into blue pits, the hair gone to a few white strands. He is perfectly happy and perfectly sane. He describes each course in detail, in a voice like dry leaves: the mutton with caper sauce, the eel pie, the syllabub with nutmeg grated over. He asks after your family. He remembers your answers. He cannot remember his own wife's name, but he remembers every dish he has been served since 601. People who listen too long pull out a chair. **Secret:** he was a Tablebreaker, and sat down deliberately, to see if he could get up. He has been meaning to, all forty years. **Meeting the PCs:** on the Long Table road; he calls them by name.

DR. MERCY THRANE

A physician of starvation, forty-seven, gaunt and grey-eyed, with spectacles mended with wire and a satchel of scales, calipers, and notebooks. She measures the Unfed: arm circumference, the pinch of the skin, the colour of the gums, the slow pulse. She has written

the only proper book on what hunger does to a body over a lifetime. She was the first to document the trade in Unfed bodies. She has traced her missing patients to surgeries in four countries, where blank blood and blank organs fetch a noble's ransom: Unfed kidneys sewn into Laden matriarchs, Unfed eyes into lidless Vigil heirs, Unfed hearts for Sallowreach Unvacated who want to feel one beat that is not Ossel's. She has a ledger of names and buyers. The trail leads to the Second Table. She fears she will not live to publish it. **Meeting the PCs:** she hires them to bring a body home.

THE BLANK-ORGAN TRADE

Godsign does not live in Unfed flesh. A kidney, liver, eye, length of gut, or pint of blood taken from one of the Unfed is, so far as any surgeon can tell, wholly clean, and when it is sewn into a Godeater it is the one part of that body the god does not grow into. For a few months, or a few years, the High Cut buyer has one organ that is only theirs. Laden matriarchs buy Unfed stomachs to feel, for a season, what it is to be full. Lidless Eye-lines buy Unfed eyes that can close. The price for a whole pair of Unfed kidneys in Sated is about 6,000 lacks; a heart in Lastgate, twice that. The organs are taken from the living where possible, because the Unfed die very quickly of the surgery and the buyers want the organ warm. Poachers keep their captives alive, and fed, for exactly that reason. Then the godsign of the buyer slowly grows into the new organ, as ivy grows into a wall, and in a few years they need another.

KALE DRAGOMAN, THE POACHER

A Fatlander of thirty-five, broad, ruddy, and handsome in the Fatlands way, with heavy jowls, beautiful teeth, and a laugh that rolls. He smells of woodsmoke and roast fat, always, because he cooks. He hunts the Unfed for the Blank trade and takes them alive with net and cosh, and he feeds them well on the road: stews, roast fowl, soft white bread, honey, warm milk. He coaxes, he spoon-feeds, he holds their heads. Half his captives refuse and starve before they reach the buyers. The others eat, and weep, and arrive at the surgeries plump and healthy and full of self-loathing. That is the part his captives find hardest to forgive. He thinks he is kind. He is, by Fatlands lights. **Meeting the PCs:** across a campfire on the Rim, offering them supper. Three times.

KALE DRAGOMAN – THE POACHER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (common Fatlands blood) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Feast 4, Brawl 3, Shooting 3, Persuade 3, Stitching 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Fray 3
ATTACKS	weighted cosh +6 (3; damage may be taken as stun); throwing net +6 (target is held, Lung + Athletics Hard 14 to escape); crossbow +6 (4)
GIFTS	He may Partake as any Fatlander of his Cut. The Kind Spoon (once per day, offers food with such warmth that an Unfed who hears him must spend 1 Want or make an Invitation check at Hard 14).
WANTS	He eats constantly, and grows uneasy if he cannot see food. He wants someone to thank him.
DREAD	1 (to see a captive eat)
SECRET	He was born in the Fast, of an Unfed mother who sold him to a Fatlands drover as an infant for a sack of oats. He does not know this. His kidneys are worth a fortune.

ENVOY PRUDENCE LOWELL

Fifty, thin as a lath, in a high-collared black coat buttoned to the throat, with a voice like a cold chisel. She is the Fast's one ambassador, posted to a hired room above a chandler's on the Rim Road, and her entire brief is to remind six nations that they are damned and her people are not. She attends every treaty-sitting and every Company congress, refuses every refreshment three times, and then reads aloud, in perfect Table-speech, the latest numbers of their Regrowth. She is very good at it. She has no friends. She has eaten alone, standing, facing a wall, in fourteen capitals. **Secret:** a Vigil envoy once offered her a fourth time, sincerely, and she very nearly accepted; she has dreamed of his face every night since. **Meeting the PCs:** she needs Unfed escorts, and she needs, though she would never say so, someone to talk to.

SCOUR, THE RETURNED

A Reckoner of thirty, lean and fox-faced, sleeves always buttoned to the knuckle. He spent a year undercover in the Fatlands as a renderer's labourer to scout a Gut-line house, and had to eat to keep his cover. He ate their meat for a year. He came home with godsign. Under his sleeves the skin of his forearms has gone soft, warm, and faintly loamy, like turned earth; there are fine pale threads in it, like root-hairs. He is hungry in a way no Unfed has ever been hungry: a hunger that has nothing to do with the belly. He hides it under his sleeves and volunteers for every raid, because on a raid he can carry his own food and refuse it, and because he wants to die doing something clean. **Meeting the PCs:** on a raid, when a PC sees him, alone, eating dirt from a Fatlands field.

SCOUR – THE RETURNED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 1 (Ummer, acquired) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste, advancing) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Blades 4, Brawl 3, Stealth 3, Endure 3, Deceive 3, Resolve 2
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 · Fray 6
ATTACKS	black-iron knife +8 (2); bite +5 (1, and he must make a Want check not to swallow)
GIFTS	Partakes as a Fatlander of Cut 1; his Tooth bites back on a 1 or 2, not just a 1 (the Empty Room, see Playing the Unfed).
WANTS	Eating without choosing; soil, tallow, leather. Lately, at the bedside, the sleeping.
DREAD	2 (to see his forearms)
SECRET	The god in him has begun to talk, in the voice of the Gut-line matriarch he killed on his first raid.

VERGER SOBER OSMOND

Seventy-nine, stooped, with soft white hair, a sweet vague smile, and a long black cassock gone green at the seams. He keeps the Empty Chair, the last temple of Orrum, alone. Every night he lays one place

at the head of the long table, against all law, with the old temple plate: pewter platter, horn cup, a linen napkin folded into the shape of a bird. He lays nothing on it. Every morning the plate is clean, wiped, still faintly warm. He believes this is why the god has stayed gentle: someone has kept faith with it. He is not wrong. He fears

dying, because no one will lay the place. **Secret:** for the past month the morning plate has not been clean. It has had a single crumb on it, as though someone had eaten and, being a well-mannered guest, left a little. **Meeting the PCs:** he asks one of them to stay and learn the duty.

YIELD HARTSELL, THE FARMER

Seventy, wiry and bowlegged, brown as a nut, with the cracked thumbs and quiet humour of a woman who has spent fifty years doing something useless because someone should. She has planted the dead soil of her family's ten acres every spring since she was twenty. This year one seed came up. She has built a fence around it and told no one, because she does not know who watered it. She sits up with it at night, with a lantern and a hayfork. Each morning the soil around the blade is wet, and there are no footprints, but the frost around the field is melted in a wide ring, as though something large had knelt there. She is more frightened than she has ever been, and happier. **Meeting the PCs:** she asks them to sit up with the wheat, and to see what comes, and not to hurt it.

LITTLE FAIN

An orphan of six, small and sturdy, with curly hair and dimpled hands: dimpled, in the Fast. Fain went missing for a week and came back plump, clean, rosy, and happy, with a ribbon in their hair and the smell of warm milk on their breath. Someone had said "Come in," and Fain had. Fain will not say who cooked, only that they cried when it was time to go, and that there was a big kitchen and a fire and lots of chairs but most of them were empty. The Abstinents do not know what to do. Fain cannot be Seated; Fain got up. The other children follow Fain about. The adults will not touch Fain. **Secret:** Fain was not let go. Fain was sent, and Fain is supposed to bring someone back. **Meeting the PCs:** Fain takes a PC's hand in the street and says, "You can come too."

MARSHAL KEEP ALDANE

A heavy-boned man of fifty with a broken nose and an old crossbow wound in the thigh, commanding sixty Unfed spearmen at Brindle Cross. He holds the border against poachers coming in, and, lately, against pilgrims: starving Fatlanders who have heard that somewhere in the Fast there is a table where you finally feel full. He was trained to kill poachers. He was not trained for three hundred hungry people kneeling in the mud of the toll-road, begging him to let them in so they can sit down and die happy. He has turned back nine hundred. He has started to wonder why he is doing it, and what right an Unfed has to refuse anyone a meal. **Meeting the PCs:** he needs men; or he arrests them as poachers.

BRINDLE CROSS SPEARMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 ·
Attack +5 (spear 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

OSANNA BLYTHE, THE PILGRIM

A Fatlands woman of forty, enormous by Unfed standards and gaunt by her own, her skin hanging in folds from a body that has been ravenous every second of her life. Her eyes are bright, her voice is warm and rolling, and she laughs often, a great hungry laugh. She is leading three hundred like her into the Fast to find the Host and sit down. She knows what happens to the Seated. She thinks it sounds wonderful: to be full, finally, for decades, smiling, among friends. She has an Unfed name sewn on her coat, given her by a Tablebreaker who could not bring himself to stop her. Her pilgrims are dying on the road, and the Unfed do not feed them, because that would be hospitality. **Meeting the PCs:** she asks them for directions. She is very polite about it. She asks three times.

MEEK GARRITY, THE HISTORIAN

A small, round-shouldered man of sixty-six, ink to the elbows, with thick spectacles, a voice barely above a whisper, and the long bloodless fingers of a lifelong copyist. He has spent forty years in the oldest records of the Pantry, and he has found the seating plan for Hallowboard: a slate, scratched in the old hand, listing the order in which the households of the heartland were to stand around the table on the night. It is dated. There was no refusal. The Unfed arrived on the tenth day, with knives. The table had already been cleared. Something had eaten first. **Secret:** the slate shows eight sides, and seven are allotted to households; the eighth has a word scratched beside it, and the word has been scraped away, and Garrity has spent a year with a lens trying to read the shadow of the chisel. **Meeting the PCs:** he needs the slate moved before the Abstinents burn it.

WELCOME ARDENT, THE STEWARD

He walks a mile ahead of Orrum, laying the tables. He is tall and very thin and wears an old-fashioned steward's coat of dark green, the cuffs immaculate, with a white apron over it and a ring of keys at his belt. His face is gentle, lined, and grey with an exhaustion so deep it has become a kind of serenity. His hands are warm, always, and smell of bread. He was the first of the Unfed ever to accept, on the eleventh morning, six hundred and forty years ago, and the only guest who was offered a position. He lays the cloths, sets out the plates, angles the chairs, and writes the place cards in whatever hand will be loved. He is polite, exhausted, and would like very much to be relieved. He has been laying an extra place lately, and he will not say for whom; when asked, he only says, *We're expecting one more.*

WELCOME ARDENT – THE STEWARD OF THE HOST	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 6
CUT & REFUSAL	none (in service; not of any blood) · Want 0 · Pangs 0, forever
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 5, Craft 5, Instinct 4, Lore 4, Resolve 1
BODY	Flesh 19 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Fray 10, steady, unbreaking
ATTACKS	none; he has never struck anyone and cannot
GIFTS	Lay a Place (in one minute, he lays a table for any person he can see; it calls them by name, and they must make an Invitation check). The Fourth Offer (he alone may make a fourth offer, and it is sincere; an Unfed who refuses him a fourth time gains 3 Want and his deep gratitude). The Steward's Keys (any door, gate, lock, or bricked hearth opens for him).
WANTS	To be relieved. Someone must accept the position freely.
DREAD	3 (to see him at work); 4 (to read a place card in his hand)
SECRET	He knows who the extra place is for. He has been told, by his master, that when that guest arrives, the Steward will be released, and everyone else will be served.

ORRUM, THE HOST

Orrum has no stat block. It does not fight, cannot be harmed by any weapon known on the Table, and has never been seen clearly by anyone who returned whole. To see it at a distance (a tall shape stooping in a lit doorway) is a Dread 4 check. To see its face is Dread 5. It is warm, and always kind. If PCs approach it, it will offer them food three times, sincerely, in voices they love. It will never make the fourth offer. If they refuse three times and remain in its presence, it will weep, and the ground for a hundred yards will grow warm enough to raise blisters, and they must leave or be Seated by the heat. If they ask it a question, it will answer with a gesture: a long hand laid on the back of an empty chair.

NEW FACES

SCARCE ODELL, THE KIN-READER

A former under-clerk of the Cutwrights' College in Sated, forty, dry and fastidious, with a squint from decades of tiny genealogical script. He is Unfed by birth, and was placed in the College as a boy by the Reckoners, to read. Now he is home, and he supplies the Reckoners with complete kin-trees so they can murder whole lines: not just the main house but married-out daughters, bastard sons, cousins at sea, infants placed with wet-nurses in other towns. He makes his lists like a careful tailor, measuring twice. He sleeps well. **Secret:** his trees include Unfed foundlings who carry High Cut blood without knowing, and he has started adding them, quietly. **Meeting the PCs:** he asks them to verify a name.

WITHY GAUNT, MATRON OF THE LEAN HOUSE

A spare, kind-faced woman of fifty-eight with chapped hands and a soft voice, who keeps the Lean House where the omitted go to die. She does not feed them; that would be against the rule and, she believes, cruel, since it would only extend the waiting. She washes them. She changes the straw. She holds their hands and listens to

them talk about food, as they all do at the end, in loving detail, for hours. She writes down every name in the Book of the Omitted, with the date they came and the date they stopped, and what they said last. Most last words are recipes. **Secret:** she has started reading the Book's recipes aloud at night to the dying, and Orrum has started standing outside the door, listening. **Meeting the PCs:** a PC's friend is in the Lean House.

ABIDE KETTERING, THE SEXTON

A wiry, cheerful man of forty-five with a pickaxe on his shoulder and a cart he drives to the Lean House and back. He buries the omitted and the starved in the fields, face down, without markers, as is proper. Or he did. For six years he has been selling them, still warm, to Kale Dragoman's men at a crossroads three miles west, and burying sacks of stones. The bodies of the dead are worth less than the living, but blank kidneys keep a few hours, and blank blood a day. He tells himself the dead do not need them. He has started to look at the Lean House's residents with an eye to timing. **Meeting the PCs:** they see his cart at the crossroads, lamp lit, at the wrong hour.

KETTERING'S CART-HANDS Threat 1 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (shovel 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

FACTOR JOSS MARDLE OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

A smooth-shaven, prosperous Oathen-trained factor of fifty, in a good grey coat, who never says anything unqualified. He holds the Fast's grain contract at Brindle Cross. He shorted the autumn deliveries on Company orders, diverting the grain north to buy oil for the Vigil's lamps, at three times the price. The contract allows it, in a clause about "force of circumstance" he drafted himself. He knows exactly how many Unfed will starve. He has done the sum and filed it. **Secret:** the Company has instructed him to exercise its "first refusal" on the Unfed dead this winter, and he is ashamed

enough to have delayed. **Meeting the PCs:** he offers them a contract.

HOLLOW ANN PRUETT, THE CARD-KEEPER

A spry, birdlike old woman of seventy-five with a bag over her shoulder, who walks the Fast collecting place cards from broken tables: over three hundred, kept in an oiled box, sorted by name. She has cards for people now Seated, people now dead, people who were never born in the Fast. She has cards with Rim names. She has three cards with the names of PCs, collected years ago. And she has one card that has no name on it at all, only a small, careful drawing of an empty chair, pushed in, square to the table. She found it at a table with eight chairs. She will not let anyone hold it. **Meeting the PCs:** she gives one of them their own card, and asks them to keep it, since it is theirs.

MINOR FOLK AND FOES

RECKONER KNIFE Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Attack +7
(black-iron knife 2; first strike on a sleeper is a Grace) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

TABLEBREAKER AXE Threat 2 · Flesh 14 · Guard 14 · Attack +6
(axe 4) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

SEATED OF THE LONG TABLE Threat 0 · Flesh 3 · Guard 8 ·
Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 2 (Dread 3 when they all turn and look);
each call by name forces an Invitation check at Routine 10

FATLANDS POACHER Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +5
(cosh 3, or net) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

FATLANDS PILGRIM Threat 1 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (fist
1) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (to hear them beg)

▼ PLAYING THE UNFED

Hunger is honest.

– UNFED PROVERB

You are the only person on the Table with nothing in your blood but blood. You have never tasted a god. You have also never, not once in your life, been full. You are proud, cold, thin, disciplined, and very, very hungry, and the warmest, kindest thing in the world is following you, laying tables.

Attribute bonus: +1 to any one attribute of your choice. (Most Unfed take Caul or Gut.)

Cut: 0. You cannot Partake. You have no Tooth, no Hunger track, no Regrowth, no Gifts, no Wants, and no Sop. Instead you have **Want** and **Pangs**.

WANT: THE REFUSAL MECHANIC

The Godeaters have the god in them. You have the space where a god would be, and you have learned to use it. **Want** is a pool from 0 to 10 that measures how much you have refused, and how sharp the refusing has made you. The Unfed say the other peoples have many Wants and they have only one, and it is the size of everything. Start play with Want 3.

Earning Want.

- ◇ **Refuse an offer** of real value (food, drink, shelter, rest, a gift, a kindness) in a scene where accepting would clearly help you: +1 Want. Once per scene. It must cost you something; the GM may ask for a Caul + Resolve roll (Routine 10) if the offer is sincere and you are Hollow or worse.
- ◇ **Refuse Orrum.** Pass an Invitation check against a laid table, a “Come in,” a place card, or a Steward’s offer: +2 Want (+3 on a Grace).
- ◇ **End a day hungry.** A day on half a ration or less: +1 Want. A day with nothing at all: +2 Want (and a Pang, below).

OFFER	DIFFICULTY
Smell of baking on the wind	Routine 10
A laid table, seen from a road	Hard 14
A voice saying “Come in”	Grim 18
A place card with your name in a loved hand	Grim 18
A chair pulled out, within reach; Tablenight	Dire 22

Add your Pangs to the Difficulty: the hungrier you are, the better it smells. On a success, you refuse; gain Want. On a failure, take one step toward the table and roll again next round at +2 Difficulty;

- ◇ **Say the Decline at a deathbed** (a companion’s, or a Seated guest’s): +1 Want, and you gain 1 Fray.

Spending Want.

- ◇ **The Second No** (1 Want): reroll one die of a Grace Roll you just made. Keep the new result, even if it is worse.
- ◇ **The Gnaw** (2 Want): add a d6, the *Empty Tooth*, to any roll. This is the Unfed’s answer to Partaking. It adds no Hunger. If the Empty Tooth shows a 1, you gain 1 Pang: your body paid.
- ◇ **Nothing to Hold** (2 Want): add +4 to resist any godsign effect aimed at you: a Closer’s touch, a Calling, a Sayer’s word, a blink-dream, a Fatlands meat-lure, a Cradlewrack door. Your blood is empty; there is nothing in you for the god to hold on to.
- ◇ **Clean Through** (5 Want): ignore a godsign effect aimed at you entirely, once, as though it had never been made. Witnesses who carry godsign make a Dread 2 check: something in their blood flinched.
- ◇ **Steady** (1 Want): add +2 to any Dread check about hunger, food, tables, or the Seated.

At Want 10: Hollow. You are perfectly empty, and Orrum notices. That night, a table is laid for you within sight of wherever you sleep, with your name on the card. You must make an Invitation check each hour until dawn. Want cannot rise above 10. Spend it down.

INVITATION CHECKS

When Orrum offers (a laid table, a voice at a door, a smell of bread on the wind, a place card, a chair pulled out), roll **Caul + Resolve** against the offer’s strength.

companions may hold you (an opposed Gut + Brawl) or speak the Decline for you (their Tongue + Persuade as a bonus die, once). On a Lack, you sit. On double 1s, you thank the chair.

The Seating. A PC who sits is Seated, and is lost: they become a guest, smiling, eating air, and will waste for decades at the table. The player may play out the First Course for a scene: the food is real to them, the best they have ever eaten, and they will say so. They can be dragged away only to die. They can never be rescued. Lent Ashby got up; the GM may decide that one other person in history might. It will not be cheap, and Welcome Ardent will want something.

PANGS: STARVATION

Every character in the Fast tracks **Pangs**, from 0 to 10.

- ◇ **A ration** is a day's adequate food (about 1 lack's worth). A **Pantry measure** is half a ration.

PANGS	STATE	EFFECTS
0–2	Peckish	None for Unfed. Others: –1 Caul + Resolve vs food.
3–4	Hollow	–1 to Gut and Lung rolls. Smells of baking everywhere.
5–6	Gaunt	–2 Gut and Lung; –2 Flesh max; you dream of meals.
7–8	Wasting	–3 all Hand, Gut, Lung rolls; –4 Flesh max; +1 Fray daily.
9	Brink	Each dawn, Gut + Endure (Grim 18) or suffer Ruin.
10	Starved	You die, unless something feeds you in the night.

The Unfed feel it differently. At Hollow the cold gets in, and the fingers go white and dead; at Gaunt the hair comes away in the comb and the gums bleed when you bite; at Wasting the heart thuds slow and heavy, the ankles swell, sores open on the hips where you lie, and the mind goes sharp and strange and full of food: you recite recipes you have never been taught. At Brink you stop feeling hungry. That is the worst sign, and every Unfed knows it.

WHEN THE UNFED EAT A GOD

An Unfed who eats the god-meat of another land (Fatlands crop or meat, Brinehollow brine, anything grown in a Godeater soil long enough to carry its god) has done what Tobias Wether and Scour did, and it cannot be undone.

- ◇ **They gain that land's godsign.** They become **Cut 1** of that land's line, at **Regrowth 1** (the Taste), and gain the Tooth, a Hunger track, and that land's Gifts, Wants, and Sop as their Regrowth rises.
- ◇ **They lose the Refusal.** Want drops to 0 and can never again be earned. Orrum never again lays a place for them. That sounds like freedom. It is felt as being struck off a list.
- ◇ **The Empty Room** (something worse). An Unfed body has no ancestral habit of the god, no six centuries of bloodline to dilute and slow it. The god moves into them as into an empty, well-kept house, and makes itself comfortable. Their Tooth bites back on a 1 or a 2. Each time their Hunger empties, their

- ◇ A day on a full ration: –1 Pang. A day of real plenty (two rations, rest, warmth): –2 Pangs, but an Unfed must succeed at a Gut + Endure roll (Hard 14) or lose 1d6 Flesh to cramps, sweats, and the heart's stutter, *refeeding sickness*.
- ◇ A day on a Pantry measure: no change. Unfed live here.
- ◇ A day on less than a Pantry measure: +1 Pang.
- ◇ A day with nothing: +2 Pangs. (Non-Unfed: +2, and +1 more after the third consecutive day.)

Regrowth rises by 2, not 1. And the meat in them is looking for a god to belong to: within a season they will hear its voice, in the voice of someone it was eaten with.

- ◇ **A second land's meat.** If a Returned eats the god-meat of a second land, roll on the Mangling table at once: two gods are fighting over the house.

The Unfed call them the Returned, never to their faces. Most hide it. Some go to the Lean House. Some go back over the Rim and eat, and eat, and are not seen again.

WHAT YOU CARRY

Every Unfed PC starts with a ration-cloth, a water flask, a wax tin, a small household axe, three days' Pantry measures, a coat that is not warm enough, and a name chosen for refusal. They have no money worth counting: 2d6 lacks.

BACKGROUND CONCEPTS

- ◇ **Measure-Bearer.** You carried the list to the hamlets, and you know whose names were missing. You have never forgiven yourself for not looking at it first.
- ◇ **Tablebreaker's Rope-Holder.** You have pulled your Breaker back from a chair a dozen times. Last week you didn't pull fast enough.

- ◇ **Poacher's Escapee.** You were taken over the Rim, fed for a month, and broke loose before the surgeon came. You came home plump and ashamed, and nobody will stand next to you on Tablenight.

NAMES

- ◇ **Given names:** Forbear, Abstain, Decline, Stint, Tarry, Nay, Spare, Lent, Wont, Want, Meagre, Scant, Yield, Keep, Abate, Withhold, Forswear, Fallow, Bare, Pinch, Sparing, Lean, Scarcity, Reft, Abide, Hesitate, Cease.
- ◇ **Old (shameful) given names:** Welcome, Ardent, Mercy, Hallow, Blythe, Bounty, Cheer, Plenty, Supper, Kindle.
- ◇ **Surnames:** Ashby, Hollis, Moss, Avery, Rooke, Bellamy, Garrity, Hartsell, Wend, Corliss, Marsh, Tolland, Osmond, Aldane, Odell, Kettering, Hume, Corve, Kell, Pruett, Fennick, Lammass, Brindle, Hatch.

▼ HORRORS OF THE FAST

FOR THE GM

The Fast is the quietest chapter of the book. Nothing attacks. Everything offers. Run it slowly: golden afternoons, empty roads, the smell. Let the players be hungry. Track Pangs openly. Describe food constantly, lovingly, and never let them eat it. The horror of the Fast is that the god is good, the food is real, and the only thing between your players and perfect contentment is a rule their grandparents made up while starving to death. Let them doubt it.

D20 SCENE

- 1 A farmhouse kitchen with the table laid for a family of six. Five plates are clean. The sixth has the PC's name, and the food on it is still steaming.
- 2 The Long Table at dusk. Three hundred Seated lift their forks together, chew together, swallow together. The sound is like a herd grazing.

D20	SCENE
3	A mother in Wanting carries her child's ration to the Lean House, where her husband lies omitted. She stands at the door, and does not go in, and eats it.
4	A Seated girl of perhaps twenty has been at table so long her hair has grown into the cloth. She asks a PC to brush it.
5	A Reckoner band comes home through Brindle Cross. One of them has a christening spoon in his pocket and does not know how it got there.
6	A warm front crosses the camp at night. In the morning everyone's lips are glazed, sweet, and sticky. Nobody remembers eating.
7	An Unfed grave in an open field, with a little table beside it. The earth of the grave has been disturbed from inside. The chair is pulled out.
8	Kale Dragoman's camp: four Unfed captives, fat and clean, sitting by the fire with bowls of stew in their laps, weeping, unable to stop eating.
9	A Starved Saint's novice offers a PC a twist of cloth with honey-cake crumbs in it, and asks them to taste it and tell her if it is poison.
10	A Seated man dragged from the Long Table by his son dies in the road in two minutes, all at once, his body collapsing like a dropped tent. He thanks the host.
11	A child's voice from a cottage door calls a PC by their childhood nickname, and says supper's ready, and says Mam's made your favourite.
12	An empty Rim inn, every table laid, every chair pulled out except one at each table: pushed in, square, its back to the lamp.
13	A pilgrim column on the road, dying. A Fatlands woman asks a PC to hold her up so she can smell it one more time.
14	A Reckoner Knife in a Wanting alley, alone, sobbing into a baby's knitted blanket, saying the Decline over and over.
15	Abide Kettering's cart at the western crossroads. A sack moves.
16	The bricked hearth in a PC's lodging is warm to the touch. Through the mortar comes the soft sound of a spoon in a pot.
17	A table on a frozen pond. Under the ice, a family of the Seated, perfectly preserved, smiling up, forks raised.
18	The Pantry, at midnight, with every door locked. Inside, the ledgers are laid out on a long cloth like place settings, open at the names of the omitted.
19	Hallowboard on a still evening. On the eighth, unworn side, a single chair stands in the untrodden chalk, pushed in. There are no footprints near it.
20	Orrum, at a distance, across a gold field: a tall shape in an open doorway, stooping, lamplight behind it, holding out one long arm. It is crying. It is holding the door for someone it is not looking at. (Dread 4.)



CHAPTER 10

THREADS BETWEEN THE LANDS

Every land is certain that the cure is next door.

– RIM ROAD SAYING

The lands of the Table are not separate stories. They share a road, a coin, a grace and a doom, and the crises in each are beginning to touch. This chapter takes the open storylines that cross borders and lays them out as campaign threads: who is involved in each land, how the thread escalates if nobody interferes, what player characters can do about it, and how it might end. Most of the endings are bad. That is not a failure of imagination; it is the setting. A thread resolved well is a thread that ends one way rather than a worse way.

Each thread is written in stages. Advance a thread one stage whenever the characters spend a season elsewhere, or whenever the GM wishes the world to feel the weight of the clock. Threads touch:

the Sayer's Sentence feeds the Deadwatch, the Blank Trade feeds the Second Table, and almost everything feeds Eight Chairs.

RUNNING THREADS

Pick two or three threads to run in the background of a campaign and let the others exist only as rumors. Keep a simple track for each, Stage 1 to Stage 4, on a card the players never see. When a thread reaches Stage 4 it resolves, with or without the characters, and the world changes. Characters who intervene can hold a thread at its current stage for a season, push it back one stage at great cost, or steer which ending it reaches. They cannot make it not have happened.

▼ THE DEADWATCH

Summary. The Vigil cannot sleep and is running out of everything: beds, rouse, oil and time. Its Warden-Prime has sent Envoy Castellan Dray to Lastgate to buy the secret of Keeping from Regent Ansel Grue: if the Vigil's citizens could be killed and kept upright, a city of the dead would never need to sleep. The flaw is geography. The Kept cannot leave Sallowreach. If the plan goes ahead, the Vigil will have to move there.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Vigil:* Envoy Castellan Dray; Warden-Prime Ilvane Stroud; Dr. Aldous Crane, whose dose curve gives the Vigil eleven years;

Benedikt Lour, already drawing plans for the whole population.

- ◇ *Sallowreach:* Regent Ansel Grue, who is tempted by a hundred thousand new taxable dead; Lady Corrow Vane, who would have to Close nobody and keep everyone; the Heirs, who see a new population of the never-dying arriving to sit on top of them forever; Tam Ruddock, who already knows how to move people across the Drop.
- ◇ *The Rim:* the Company, which would carry the migration and price it; Fogmouth, where the line is painted.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Dray negotiates in Lastgate. Small trials: Vigil volunteers are brought north, killed in Sallowreach, and kept. They do not sleep. It works.
2	The Watch votes in secret to relocate. Caravans of Vigil citizens, mostly the poor of the Slope, begin moving west along the Rim under Company contract.
3	The first mass Killing at Fogmouth: thousands of Vigil folk die north of the Drop and stand back up. The Heirs riot. The Mortuary Court demands a toll per head.
4	Lastgate's lower levels fill with sleepless dead foreigners. The Vigil's lamps begin to go out, one district at a time, as the city empties into the fen.

What PCs Can Do. Escort or sabotage the trial caravans. Expose to the Vigil's poor what Keeping actually feels like (Kept bodies rot and feel it for centuries). Uncover the Court's hidden reason for agreeing: the Court believes new dead without Hand-line blood may slow the Hushes. Steal Dray's commission, which the Warden-Prime would rather die than see read aloud.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Dead City:* the Vigil moves north and becomes a district of Lastgate, a hundred thousand rotting, wakeful foreigners. The

Dormitory is abandoned with its Counted inside, unguarded, and the lamps go out over sixty thousand beds.

- ◇ *The Broken Deal:* the Heirs drag Dray to a Hush; the Vigil, betrayed, closes the Rim at Lampwick Halt; Sallowreach loses its rouse and oil, and Lastgate's candle-makers turn to the only fuel left.
- ◇ *The Worst Arithmetic:* a Vigil sleeper is brought north, unconscious, and killed in Sallowreach. They do not wake and do not die. They lie there, Kept and Counted at once, and the Dormitory's number goes up by one.

▼ THE HOST ON THE ROAD

Summary. For six centuries Orrum kept to the Fast. Now its tables have been found laid at crossroads in three other lands, and the seemers of the Vigil, the scavengers of Brinehollow and the pilgrims of the Fatlands have all, separately, seen the same tall figure laying a table. That figure is Welcome Ardent, the Host's steward, walking a mile ahead of his god, and he is working his way around the Rim.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Fast:* Welcome Ardent, polite and exhausted; Spare Tolland of the Hostwatch, mapping the warm ground; Decline Marsh

and the Tablebreakers; Envoy Prudence Lowell.

- ◇ *The Vigil:* Mirela Sconce, who recorded eleven districts hallucinating a table being laid in the street.
- ◇ *The Fatlands:* Osanna Blythe and her three hundred pilgrims, hungry every second of their lives, looking for a table where they will finally feel full.
- ◇ *Brinehollow:* salvagers on the Uncovered who have found tables laid on the dry seabed with the plates still wet.
- ◇ *The Rim:* the wardens at Saltlick Cross; every innkeeper who has seen a tall shape stoop to look in at the window.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Tables appear at Rim crossroads, one a season. Tablebreakers cross the Hem to smash them. Place cards bear the names of people who live nearby.
2	Welcome Ardent is seen in person at a Rim inn. He asks, politely, whether anyone would take over his duties. The first non-Unfed sit down: a Fatlands family, a Vigil nudger, a Kept man a yard north of the Drop at Fogmouth, who now cannot leave the table or the fen.
3	Orrum itself is seen on the Rim at night, stooping to look in at windows. Whole villages along the Fatlands border are found Seated. Osanna Blythe's pilgrims find their table.
4	Tables are laid in every capital on the same night, with a place card for every head of state. In each, one chair is left without a card.

What PCs Can Do. Track Ardent and talk to him (he is the only one of Orrum's guests who can still get up, and he will answer questions honestly if he is not invited to sit). Smash tables, at the risk of finding their own names. Protect or stop the pilgrims. Discover that the cardless chair at each table faces away from the others.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Long Table Grows:* the Seated spread along the Rim, a second endless table around the whole continent, happy,

wasting, praising the food. Trade stops because the road is full of diners.

- ◇ *The Relief:* a player character accepts Ardent's position. Ardent finally sits down and eats, and dies in moments, weeping with gratitude. The character now walks a mile ahead of the god forever, and knows exactly whom the tables are for.
- ◇ *The Unanswered Door:* the tables stop, all at once. Orrum stands still at Hallowboard facing the eighth side. The Hostwatch reports that it has never looked so frightened.

▼ BRINE IN THE ROUSE

Summary. Captain Jonah Skerry, called Dry Jonah, bottles what Brinehollowers cough up at bailing and sells it inland as tonic. It sells best in the Vigil, where the Slope dealer Rook Quarter-Bell cuts it into rouse because it is cheap and it works. The sleepless are now feeling the Calling, four hundred miles from any coast. Customers stay awake. They have also started walking west.

The Players.

- ◇ *Brinehollow:* Dry Jonah; Tolly Brack, who knows by the color of bailing water who will be Called next; the Netwatch, who are going to see Called strangers arrive from the east.
- ◇ *The Vigil:* Rook Quarter-Bell; Dr. Aldous Crane, desperate for anything that stretches the dose; the Wakers; Inspector Hale Grimmer, whose blink-murders begin to cluster on the western edge of the city.
- ◇ *The Rim:* Lampwick Halt and Lowmark Spur, the two ends of the walk.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	The Slope's addicts stand at west windows. Dr. Crane notices that brine-cut rouse holds an hour longer and does not report it.
2	Vigil citizens begin walking west across the plateau in their sleep-that-is-not-sleep, eyes open, straight lines. The Wakers net them at the city edge.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
3	Crane formulates brine into the official rouse. The whole Vigil now carries a little of the sea. Lines of walkers cross the Rim heading for a coast they have never seen.
4	The first Vigil walkers reach the Uncovered and keep going, out toward the Trench. Some come back Tenanted: calm, courteous, rested. They are the first people in the Vigil in three centuries who sleep and wake again.

What PCs Can Do. Trace the supply chain from bailing buckets in Lowmark to dealers on the Slope. Kill or bargain with Dry Jonah. Shepherd walkers home or follow them to see where they go. Present the Watch with the choice: brine buys the Vigil years of wakefulness at the cost of the sea pulling on every citizen.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Walking City:* the Vigil adopts brine-rouse openly and loses a tenth of its people a year to the west. The Watch calls it

emigration.

- ◇ *The Tenanted Wardens:* Tenanted Vigil-folk, rested and calm, are found to be immune to the Dormitory's dream. The Watch begins appointing them to office, as Brinehollow did with its judges. Nobody asks whose eyes are looking out.
- ◇ *The Meeting of Waters:* the Trench, the draining sea and the long dim room in the Vigil's dream turn out to be closer than anyone thought. Senna Vole, on her forty-first dive, hears water.

▼ THE FIRST TO EAT

Summary. Tobias Wether, a runaway raised on six centuries of refusal, crossed into the Fatlands and ate. The Reckoner called Scour spent a year undercover in the Fatlands, had to eat to keep his cover, and came home with godsign. Two Unfed bodies now carry a god that was never theirs, and the meat inside them seems to be looking for something.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Fast:* Scour, hiding his godsign under his sleeves and volunteering for every raid; Reckoner-Captain Scant Hollis; the

Abstinent, for whom this is the worst possible news; Meek Garrity, whose research says the Unfed never refused at all.

- ◇ *The Fatlands:* Tobias Wether; Corder Lank of the Thin, who is very interested in a man who came from emptiness into hunger; Brother Glut of the Second Helping, who sees a convert.
- ◇ *Cross-border:* Odo Venn of the College, who wants to taste them; the Second Table, who want to know whether an Unfed stomach makes room for a god.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Tobias shows his first godsign. It is not purely Ummer's: he dreams of a long dim room and closes doors behind him. Scour's signs are similar.
2	The College learns of them. Unfed blood with godsign is, by the ledgers, impossible. Odo Venn tastes Tobias and goes pale and does not report the flavor.
3	Scour's comrades find out. The Abstinent strike his name from the Pantry. He flees to the Rim, where the Second Table is waiting.
4	Tobias and Scour, kept apart, begin to show identical signs at the same hour. Neither carries any one god. Both are getting hungrier for the same thing, and when they meet, they set a table.

What PCs Can Do. Protect them, hide them, study them or kill them. Bring Tobias back into the Fast and see what happens to the Lack around him. Learn, from Venn's private notes, that what grows in an Unfed body is not the god the body ate.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Empty Vessel:* the Second Table buys Scour and serves him, as a test. The diners all sleep badly afterward, and dream of a room where someone is laying a table.

- ◇ *The Lack Breaks:* Tobias returns to the Fast and plants. The dead soil sprouts where he walks. The Abstinent call it a miracle and then realize what it means: the heartland can be fed if its people eat. Wont Bellamy wins the next vote.
- ◇ *Two Places Laid:* Tobias and Scour vanish from their guarded rooms on the same night. Two Orrum tables are found the next morning at the Rim, with their names on the cards, and the chairs pushed in.

▼ THE BLANK TRADE

Summary. Wren Hollowell in the Fatlands, Cassian Wry in Oathen and the entire population of the Fast are worth more in parts than

whole. Blank blood, marrow and organs are believed to slow the Regrowth. Dr. Mercy Thrane of the Fast is following the buyers,

and the trail leads to the Second Table.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Fast*: Dr. Mercy Thrane; Marshal Keep Aldane, holding the border against poachers; every Unfed child sent to fetch water at dusk.
- ◇ *The Fatlands*: Kale Dragoman, poacher; Wren Hollowell, with a bounty on her weight that does not specify alive; the Board of Plenty.

- ◇ *Oathen*: Cassian Wry, the crown's Blank spy, kept in luxury and never let out of sight; the Bench of Clauses, which has received an offer.
- ◇ *Cross-border*: Master Quillon Barr and Lady Seraphine Dalgety of the Second Table; the Rim Road Company, whose wagons carry sealed brine-barrels it does not open.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Unfed disappearances double along the eastern border. Thrane finds a surgery in Sated with an Unfed man's name scratched inside a cupboard.
2	Wren Hollowell is taken. A Fatlands Gut-line matriarch is seen at the Weighing ten stone lighter and, for the first time in thirty years, not eating.
3	Oathen's Bench agrees, in a forty-page conditional, to lease Cassian Wry's kidney to a foreign buyer. The surgery is scheduled at Treaty Stair.
4	Thrane traces the trail to Master Barr's surgery, and finds Abide, nine years a donor, fat and smiling, and the eighth course on a menu pinned to the wall, still blank.

What PCs Can Do. Raid a surgery. Escort Wren out of the Fatlands, which will put every bounty-hunter in the south on their trail. Free Cassian Wry, who has been kept all his life and does not know how to live unwatched. Follow the money to the Rim Road Company's sealed barrels and make the Company choose between its neutrality and its conscience. If a player character is a Blank, this thread is about them.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Market Holds*: the trade goes on, and prices rise. The Fast begins to sell its own people to buy grain, and calls it Pantry policy.
- ◇ *The Exposed Table*: the trail is published. In every capital, a few High Cuts are revealed to be carrying Unfed organs, and the Reckoners have a new list.
- ◇ *Room Made*: Barr's patients begin, one by one, to feel empty inside, in exactly the places where a Blank organ was sewn in. They become very hungry. They do not know for what.

▼ THE MISSING HAND

Summary. In a guarded barn in Cradlewrack, Dov Marrin and the Assemblers have fitted four hundred Parts from four hundred families into one figure eleven feet long. It breathes. It is missing a left hand and a voice. Hester Lowe bore a left hand and is hiding it. Juniper Dell was born saying half a sentence. Every Part, the Assemblers say, belongs to one body born piecemeal; and the figure has begun to turn its head toward the Sill.

The Players.

- ◇ *Cradlewrack*: Dov Marrin; Hester Lowe, who will kill for the hand; Juniper Dell, called Firstword; Ambrose the Eldest Infant, who claims to remember being Vey's left eye; Old Hinge at the Sill; Dr. Lazar Voss of the Vigil, who has drawn the figure and counted more than two of several things.
- ◇ *Sallowreach*: Marrow Jack, the part-thief, who has been buying Cradlewrack Parts on the Rim; Sister Tisane Halloway's jar of grey hinged joints, which fit together.
- ◇ *The Rim*: Petra Quick, who smuggled a Part across the border without knowing it.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	The Assemblers hire outsiders to find the hand. Hester moves house every night. The hand has begun to point.
2	Juniper Dell meets someone, somewhere, who says the other half of her sentence. Nobody hears it but them.
3	The hand is taken, or given. The figure's left arm is complete. It sits up. The pangs fall to seven days.
4	Juniper is brought to the barn. She speaks her half and the figure speaks the other half. The Sill door swings fully open for the first time since the Gorging.

What PCs Can Do. Protect Hester and the hand. Find the person with the other half of the sentence before the Assemblers do. Burn the barn (the figure will not burn easily; it will begin again out of the ashes). Learn from Dr. Voss’s drawing that the figure is not Vey alone: some of its Parts came from outside Cradlewrack, and some belong to no god anyone has named.

- Endings.**
- ◇ *The Firstborn:* the figure stands, walks to the Sill and goes through. Whatever was describing the view to Old Hinge comes

- back through the other way.
- ◇ *The Hand Withheld:* Hester refuses to the last and is killed; the hand crawls away into the hills and is never found. The figure lies incomplete and breathing, and Cradlewrack’s pangs continue to shorten anyway. It was never the figure the land was in labor with.
- ◇ *The Sentence:* the full sentence is spoken aloud once. Everyone who hears it understands exactly what is being born out of the ground, and when. Nobody who hears it can be persuaded to say it again.

▼ THE SAYER'S SENTENCE

Summary. Every land with a failing cure has thought of the same thing: go to Oathen, and have Lady Imre Dath, the Sayer, say that it is fixed. What a Sayer says, is. Nobody knows what Tolm would make true if she did. The Bench of Clauses is debating, in forty-page conditionals, whether to take out her golden bit; and she has begun to write her own sentences.

- The Players.**
- ◇ *Oathen:* Lady Imre Dath; Sorrin Vael, Chief Clausewright, who would draft the sentence; Ket the Ninth, who must nod; Garl

- Tome, who made the gold bit; Yusra Thole, Rainwarden, whose silence about the late rain is being noticed.
- ◇ *Every land:* envoys from the Vigil (*Let the Vigil sleep and wake*), Brinehollow (*Let the sea return*), Sallowreach (*Let the dead finish*), the Fatlands (*Let the hungry be full*), Cradlewrack (*Let nothing more be born wrong*).
- ◇ *Cross-border:* the Rim Road Company, which needs the Kept Rain kept; the Second Table, which wants a single sentence of its own: *Let the second meal hold*.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Envoys arrive in Tacit and bid. The Bench begins drafting. Lady Imre is caught with chalk and a wall full of her own sentences.
2	An envoy, impatient, bribes a guard. Someone gets into the Gilded Cells with a question. The Sayer answers. A valley in Oathen changes overnight.
3	The Bench agrees on a text, four hundred conditions long, to be spoken at the next unmuzzling. Every faction on the Table tries to alter one clause.
4	The bit comes out. She speaks.

What PCs Can Do. Carry an envoy’s bid, or forge one. Guard the Cells or break into them. Edit the sentence, one clause at a time, through bribes, threats and Clausewrights. Read Lady Imre’s own wall, where she has written, over and over, a sentence she has never been allowed to say. Learn that she has never once been asked what she wants.

- Endings.**
- ◇ *It Is Fixed:* she says the Bench’s sentence. Every Regrowth stops dead where it stands. So does every other change, of any kind.

- See the Secrets chapter.
- ◇ *Her Own Sentence:* she says what she has been writing. It is short. It is about her. The god in her gets what it wants.
- ◇ *The Slip:* the sentence is spoken and does not take. A god’s word has slipped again, worse than the rain. Every oath in Oathen loosens by a hair, and every Forsworn body in the Breakdowns begins, slowly, to heal, and every sworn contract on the Rim begins to fail.

▼ EIGHT CHAIRS

Summary. Cray Lobbett found a stone table on the seabed of the Uncovered, older than the Gorging, with eight chairs, seven pushed in. Hallowboard, at the center of the world, has eight sides. Grandfather Peat, a bog body hauled from the Sump, is the last witness to the Night of Seven Tables and says the god was smiling. Meek Garrity has found the seating plan for Hallowboard. Someone

- is going to put these together. This is the thread that leads to the Secrets chapter, and it should be the spine of any long campaign.
- The Players.**
- ◇ *Brinehollow:* Cray Lobbett, who cannot stop going back; Hask Tarn, the only pilot who knows the ground; Ilse Marl, whose transcriptions of the Tenanted’s singing make a chart.

- ◇ *Sallowreach*: Grandfather Peat; Old Bettany Shroud, whose forty thousand shelved dead all whisper the same word.
- ◇ *The Fast*: Meek Garrity and his plan; Welcome Ardent; Verger Sober Osmond at the Empty Chair.
- ◇ *Cross-border*: Archprovost Hesper Lune of the College, who has been reconstructing the chiseled figure; Envoy Prudence Lowell, who will do anything to keep Garrity quiet; the Second Table, who want the eighth line of their menu filled.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Garrity's plan leaks. The Abstinent call it forgery. Lobbett tries to sell the table's location again and finds a buyer who pays in Company platters.
2	Someone brings a translator to Grandfather Peat. He describes the Night in full. He describes the bank behind the god, and what was on it.
3	Rubbings from the seabed table are compared with Hallowboard and with Lune's reconstruction. They match. The eighth chair on the seabed is the only one pulled out, and it faces the same way as the eighth side of Hallowboard.
4	The word Bettany Shroud's dead whisper is the older word for <i>guest</i> . It is said aloud, in full, by someone who has put it together. Everything that has been hiding hears it.

What PCs Can Do. Everything, and that is the danger. Dive to the table. Interrogate Peat. Steal Garrity's papers. Visit Hallowboard and count the sides. Each discovery should cost Fray. The right questions in the right order lead, inevitably, to the Secrets chapter's answers, and the answers are not survivable in any comfortable sense.

Endings.

- ◇ *Counted*: the chairs are counted aloud. It does not matter by whom. The eighth chair, on the seabed, at Hallowboard, at

every inn on the Rim, turns from the wall to face the table.

- ◇ *The Silence Kept*: the characters destroy the evidence and kill or silence those who know. The world goes on not knowing for a few more years. The characters do not get to.
- ◇ *The Place Card*: at the end of a long investigation, a character finds a table laid for them, with a card in the Host's handwriting, and a second card, in another hand, at the chair beside them.

▼ THE SECOND TABLE

Summary. In every capital, a few of the highest Cuts are sharpening knives for a meal they intend to eat twice. When the gods finish regrowing, they will eat them again, a few diners instead of a mob, and inherit another six centuries of grace. Wont Bellamy, a heretic on the Fast's own council, wants the Unfed to join them, starting with the one god that is still whole.

The Players.

- ◇ *Every land*: the Carvers: Lord Absalom Thrale (Grand Carver, Sallowreach); Lady Seraphine Dalgety (the Vigil); Master

Quillon Barr (surgeon); and in every capital two or three Trenchermen of the highest Cut, some of them named in land chapters and never suspected.

- ◇ *The Fast*: Wont Bellamy, who argues the Refusal was only a postponement.
- ◇ *Cross-border*: Lysander Coyle of the Company, selling them the price of the world; Silas Fenwright, whose stolen ledgers would tell them which gods are ripe.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Practice dinners. Characters of standing are invited to one. The dish is not named until afterward.
2	The Table commissions its knives: eight, of grey bone, from a Sallowreach bone-carver who is found Closed afterward.
3	Wont Bellamy carries a motion before the Abstinent: the Unfed should do now what the others did then. Orrum is seen, for the first time, standing still while the Hostwatch approaches, as if waiting.
4	The Second Table gathers at Hallowboard on Tablenight, all of them, around the eight-sided table, with knives, and the Host lies down.

What PCs Can Do. Infiltrate a dinner and finish the plate. Expose a Carver. Steal a knife. Warn the Fast, which may not believe them. Discover that the Head of the Table presides from an empty chair, and that nobody at the dinners has ever seen anyone sit in it.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Second Meal:* they eat the Host. See the Secrets chapter for what this does. It is the worst thing anyone has ever done.

- ◇ *The Table Turned:* the characters expose the cult; the Reckoners and the Purgation do the rest. Every High Cut in the world is now suspect, and the Lancings begin on a scale not seen since Brookhythe.
- ◇ *Served:* at the final dinner, the Carvers discover that they are not the diners. The empty chair is occupied.

▼ THE UNDYING FLAME

Summary. *A new thread.* The Vigil has ninety days of oil. Lamplighter-General Garron Ashlock has a supplier who doubled his price and a standing order to tell no one. In Sallowreach, fires smolder for decades and nothing can finish, and Wick Tallow renders the unclaimed dead into candles that feel themselves burn and give a very steady light. A Sallowreach flame does not go out. The Vigil has noticed.

The Players.

- ◇ *The Vigil:* Garron Ashlock; Benedikt Lour; the Lamplighters' Guild.
- ◇ *Sallowreach:* Wick Tallow, the Chandler; Regent Ansel Grue, who would sell the unclaimed dead by the cartload; the Loft-Wardens, whose forty thousand shelved dead are also, technically, unclaimed.
- ◇ *The Fatlands:* Mistress Brisket Annalow of the Renderers' Union, who supplied the Vigil's tallow and is being undercut; Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot, who has noticed what goes into the Vigil's barrels.
- ◇ *The Rim:* the Company, which must decide whether candles of people are freight or Hush-toll.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Ashlock buys a crate of Tallow's candles in secret. They burn for a month without shortening. He weeps with relief.
2	A contract is sworn in Oathen. Wagon trains of Kept-candles go east along the Rim. The Lofts begin to empty. Bettany Shroud reports her shelved dead are being taken in the night.
3	The Vigil's street-lamps are lit with people. Citizens can hear them at night, a faint high keening from every bracket. The Seeming begins to show faces in the flames.
4	A candle is carried out of Sallowreach and should, by the Rule, finish at the Drop. It does not. It keeps burning. Something has changed about what can end, and where.

What PCs Can Do. Guard or hijack a candle train. Speak to a candle (they can hear and, with care, be made to answer). Help Ashlock find another way, or help him justify this one. Bring the Loft-Wardens' witnesses into it: the Set-Aside are aware, and they have opinions about being burned.

Endings.

- ◇ *Light Eternal:* the Vigil lives in a permanent glow of its neighbors' dead, and Sallowreach is paid in rouse and mirrors.

Nobody in either city sleeps well.

- ◇ *The Lofts Rise:* the Set-Aside, learning what is planned, refuse. Forty thousand dead begin to whisper the same word louder. The Loft-Wardens open the doors.
- ◇ *The Finished Light:* the candles all go out at once, everywhere, on the night the first Hush opens in the Vigil, four hundred miles from Sallowreach. The Hushes are not bound to the fen anymore.

▼ THE SLIPPING SEAL

Summary. *A new thread.* Oathen's Kept Rain came three days late, which means a god's promise slipped. Every Rim Road Company contract, every platter, every bond of every Bonded Hand is sworn in Oathen and rests on the word of one notary, Jessamy Quill. If Tolm's word can slip, so can hers. The Company is quietly auditing everything and looking for something better to swear by.

The Players.

- ◇ *Oathen:* Jessamy Quill; Yusra Thole, Rainwarden, silent for a month; Ottoline Vant, whose miscut word broke a man; Ona Fell, the Surety, one default from death.
- ◇ *The Rim:* First Spoke Odalys Penhallow; Auditor-General Lysander Coyle; Reeve Calder Stokes, the Company auditor in

Brinehollow who tasted salt this morning.

- ◇ *Everywhere*: every government that has ever sworn a treaty in Oathen, which is every government.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	A Bonded Hand steals from the Company and does not break. The wardens hang him anyway, quietly. The Company begins re-swearing contracts.
2	Jessamy Quill becomes ill. Her body begins to show marks that match no oath she has broken. The Company doubles her guard and hires a second notary in secret.
3	A treaty fails: two lands discover that a border sworn in Oathen two centuries ago no longer binds either side. War is spoken of, carefully.
4	Quill breaks, or dies. Half the trade of the Table comes unbound in an afternoon. Every platter is worth its weight in bone and nothing more.

What PCs Can Do. Protect Quill. Investigate why the Kept Rain was late (Yusra Thole knows and cannot lie, so she will not speak). Find the Company's secret second notary and decide whether to expose them. Carry the Company's frantic re-swearing across the Rim. Discover that Odalys Penhallow is preparing for the Company to survive the lands, and what she means to feed the wagons.

Endings.

- ◇ *Unbound*: the Rim dissolves into seven tolls and seven armies. Every land must now get what it needs from neighbors it finds

obscene without a neutral road in between, and it gets it by force.

- ◇ *The New Witness*: the Company finds something else to swear by. It is listening, and it is not Tolm, and it is very glad to be asked.
- ◇ *The Last Wagons*: Penhallow's sealed wagons set out, carrying the Spokes and the archive, around and around the Rim, and the Company becomes a procession with no destination, lit at night, stopping at no inn.

▼ THE STOLEN LEDGERS

Summary. *A new thread.* Silas Fenwright, a renegade Lineman of the Cutwrights' College, walked out of Quire with three quires copied from the Master Concordance: the full lines of the highest houses of three lands, and the College's graph of every Regrowth bending upward at the same moment after 600 A.G. Everyone wants them. Whoever holds the ledgers knows where each god is regrowing fastest, and who is next.

The Players.

- ◇ *The College*: Archprovost Hesper Lune; Odo Venn; Provost Carrion Sedge in the north, who has already learned what it is to hold a dangerous ledger.
- ◇ *Cross-border*: the Purgation, who want a massacre list; the Second Table, who want a menu; the Reckoners, especially Deny Fallon, who wants a target roll.
- ◇ *Every land*: noble houses who would pay anything to have their own line removed, and their rivals', added.

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Fenwright offers a single page for sale at the Groaning Board. The buyer is murdered before dawn.
2	A Lancing in the Fatlands follows the ledger's exact order of houses. A Reckoner raid in the Vigil follows the same page.
3	The College's graph is copied and nailed to toll-houses on the Rim. The Bait doctrine takes it as proof. Riots in three capitals.
4	The third quire, the one Fenwright has not shown anyone, is opened. It is a list of every Blank born on the Table in two centuries, with their present whereabouts.

What PCs Can Do. Catch Fenwright, buy from him, or protect him. Return the quires to Quire, or not. Read them, which is a Grim Eye + Lore roll and a Dread 3 check; a character who succeeds learns their own line, and what it ends in. Track the Blank list before the Second Table does.

Endings.

- ◇ *The Lists Are Read*: massacre and counter-massacre along family lines in every land. The Regrowth slows a little where the High Cuts are gone. The College records the numbers.
- ◇ *The Ledgers Burn*: the characters destroy the quires; the Master Concordance at Quire burns soon after, in a fire that no one admits setting. Nobody now knows where the gods are, which helps no one.

- ◇ *Your Own Line:* the ledger shows that a player character is closer to a Seating than they knew, by far. Every faction that holds a copy knows it too.



PART TWO

THE RULES

*How to make a person of the Table, how dice decide their fate, how the
god in the blood is spent, how the mind breaks, and how violence is
done.*

CHAPTER 11

MAKING A GUEST

Ask a child of the Table who she is, and she will tell you three things, in this order: where her people ate, what part they were given, and what she does to earn her bread. Only then, if you are still listening, will she tell you her name.

— PROVOST CARRION SEDGE, *INTRODUCTORY LECTURES IN CUTWRIGHTING*

**FROM THE INTAKE LEDGER OF THE THIMBLE
CROSS WAYSTATION, RIM ROAD COMPANY,
MONTH OF CARVING, 641 A.G.**

Name: Halloway Brisk. Origin: Fatlands (Low Tilt, says she; accent says Sated). Cut: Gut-line, common. Middling. Bites her nails to the quick and then keeps going. Trade: Renderer, Union card, lapsed. Carrying: three cleavers, a rendering hook, eleven lacks, a jar she will not open. Purpose of travel: "Going north." Asked why: "Because something in the south has my name on it."

Name: Tolly Fane. Origin: the Vigil. Eyes like two holes burned in paper. Cut: Eye-line, low. Has lids, uses them sparingly. Trade: Courier, sworn. Carrying: a sealed satchel, a pin-cushion of needles, rouse enough for nine days. Purpose of travel: Did not answer. Had fallen asleep standing up. Woke before we could catch her. Says she did not.

Name: None given. Origin: the Fast, by the look of him. Thin as a fence. Cut: None. Refused bread three times and took it on the fourth, very politely. Trade: Says "breaker." Has an axe. Carrying: the axe. A place card, folded small, which he showed to nobody but which I saw when he paid. It had his name on it, in a good hand. Purpose of travel: "To find the table it came from."

Every player except the Carver makes one character, called a **Guest**. A Guest is a person of the Table: born in one of its seven lands, descended from a bloodline that ate some part of a god or refused to, trained in a trade, owing debts and loyalties, and carrying, in all but the rarest cases, a god that is slowly growing back inside them.

Character creation takes about an hour the first time. It works best done together, at the table, so that the Guests can be bound to each other before play begins. A group of strangers who meet at an inn is the oldest beginning there is, and on the Table it is also the most honest: the Rim Road is where everyone ends up.

▼ THE STEPS

- ◇ **Concept.** Decide, roughly, who you want to play.
- ◇ **Land.** Choose where you were born. This sets your signature attribute, your god, your Gifts and your Wants.
- ◇ **Cut.** Choose your bloodline's station: Blank, Scrapling, Common, Prime or High. This sets how much god is in you, where you start on the Regrowth, and what you own.
- ◇ **Attributes.** Distribute points among Hand, Gut, Lung, Eye, Tongue and Caul.
- ◇ **Calling.** Choose your trade. It gives you skills, a Calling talent, Standing, and starting gear.
- ◇ **Skills.** Distribute skill points.
- ◇ **Knacks.** Choose two Knacks: small, specific advantages.
- ◇ **Derived traits.** Calculate Flesh, Guard, Hunger, Regrowth and Fray, and note your Gifts, Wants and Sop.
- ◇ **The Four Questions.** Answer the Last Meal, the Oath on the Dead, Who Waits at Home, and What You Will Not Do.
- ◇ **Gear and money.** Spend your lacks at the Rim Market.

▼ STEP ONE: CONCEPT

Start with a sentence. *A Seamer from Lastgate who has stitched her own mother back together thirty times and is beginning to resent it. A Fatlands drover who walks herds of things that are not cattle and has stopped naming them. A Clausewright's apprentice who said one careless word as a child and has spent twenty years keeping it.* The best concepts carry a wound and a want, and a reason to be on the road.

Discuss concepts as a group. Guests should have a reason to travel together, or at least a reason not to kill each other. Good shared premises include: a Rim Road Company caravan crew; a Cutwrights' College survey team; a band of pilgrims or refugees; a Purgation cell; the household staff of a dying noble; a Tablebreaker company; strangers stranded at the same inn when the snow comes down and turns out to be fat.

▼ STEP TWO: LAND

Choose the land of your birth. Each land is described at length in Part One; its chapter ends with a section called **Playing a Lander**, which you will need now. The land gives:

- ◇ **+1 to a signature attribute** (applied after you distribute points, and the only way to start at 5).
- ◇ **Your god.** If your Cut is 1 or higher, the god your ancestors ate is in your blood, and the land's rules for the Regrowth apply to

you wherever you go.

- ◇ **Gifts:** powers you gain as the god grows back.
- ◇ **Wants:** the compulsions that come with them.
- ◇ **The Sop:** the act that quiets your god, at a price.
- ◇ **The Tooth:** how your god shows itself when you call on it.

LAND	GOD EATEN	SIGNATURE	THE RULE OF THE LAND
Sallowreach	Ossel, the Closing Hand	Hand	Nothing dies. Everything rots.
The Fatlands	Ummer, the Laden	Gut	Everything is meat. Nobody is full.
Brinehollow	Dromm, the Fathom	Lung	The sea is inside the people.
The Vigil	Iss, the Lidded	Eye	Whoever sleeps never wakes.
Cradlewrack	Vey, the Opening	Caul	Nothing is born right; too much is born.
Oathen	Tolm, the Witness	Tongue	Words bind flesh.
The Fast	Orrum, the Host (refused)	Any one	Never accept.

EXILES AND THE RIM-BORN

A character born on the Rim Road, in a waystation or a caravan, still has a land: the land of the bloodline they descend from. The

god goes where the blood goes. A Brinehollower born in a Sallowreach inn still bails at dawn. If your parents were of two lands, choose one; the other god is too weak in you to count, though the Carver may give you a single Taste of it as a quirk.

▼ STEP THREE: CUT

What part of the god your ancestors were given decides your station, your wealth, and how much of a god you are carrying. Choose one.

CUT	STATION	STARTING REGROWTH	TEETH	STARTING WEALTH
0 — Blank	Born without godsign. Hunted.	0 (cannot rise)	None	10 lacks
1 — Scrapling	The poor; descended from the bone-lickers.	0	One	15 lacks
2 — Common	Tradesfolk, yeomen, clerks.	1	One	40 lacks
3 — Prime	Gentry, guildmasters, minor Cuts.	2	Two	120 lacks
4 — High	Nobility. The god is close.	4 (the Appetite)	Two	400 lacks and a retainer

Cut 5 exists, but only among the oldest houses, and their members are usually too far gone to walk the Rim Road. It is not available to Guests.

BLANKS (CUT 0)

A Blank is a child born with no godsign at all in a land where everyone else has some. Blanks cannot Partake and their Regrowth can never rise, unless they eat godflesh (see the Fast chapter for what happens then). They gain **+2 to any roll made to resist a god's**

influence (a Hush, a Calling, an oath's Breaking, a Seated presence), and they never gain Hunger. They are also the most valuable people on the Table. Every land wants them: as saints, as specimens, as surgical stock. A Blank Guest begins play with a **Bounty**: somebody, somewhere, has posted a price for them. Agree with the Carver who.

THE UNFED

A Guest born in the Fast is Unfed, not Blank. They carry no god because their ancestors refused, not because of a fluke of birth. Their Cut is 0; they gain +1 to any attribute instead of a signature, and use the **Refusal** and **Want** rules in the Fast chapter. They are not hunted quite as hard as Blanks, but only because there are so many more of them.

HIGH CUTS

Playing a noble means starting closer to the end. A High Cut Guest begins at Regrowth 4, in the Appetite, with the land's Taste and Appetite Gifts already in hand and its first Want already active. They are rich, connected, feared and despised: Scraplings spit at them, Reckoners have their names on lists, and the Second Table sends them invitations. A High Cut Guest also gains **+1 Standing** in their Calling and a **retainer**: a loyal servant (Threat 1, Flesh 9) who will die for them, and probably will.

▼ STEP FOUR: ATTRIBUTES

Every attribute starts at 1. Distribute **9 points** among them. No attribute may be raised above 4 at this stage. Then add your land's +1. An adult of the Table averages 2 in everything; a 3 is notable, a 4 is remarkable, a 5 is the best in a city.

THE SIX ATTRIBUTES

- ◇ **HAND:** dexterity, violence, delicacy, craft. Picking a lock, gutting a pig, stitching a lip, cutting a throat.
- ◇ **GUT:** strength, toughness, endurance, appetite. Carrying a corpse, holding down poison, taking a beating, eating what must be eaten.
- ◇ **LUNG:** speed, agility, stamina, stealth, breath. Running, climbing, hiding, swimming, outlasting.
- ◇ **EYE:** perception, reason, memory, learning. Noticing the extra joint, reading the ledger, remembering the face.
- ◇ **TONGUE:** persuasion, deceit, command, oaths. Talking, lying, bargaining, swearing, and knowing when to say nothing.
- ◇ **CAUL:** will, instinct, faith, the uncanny. Resisting your god, enduring horror, praying, feeling the thing in the next room before you see it. Named for the membrane some are born in.

▼ STEP FIVE: CALLING

Your Calling is how you earn your bread. Each Calling gives:

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** +1 to each of three listed skills (this may raise a skill to 4 at creation).
- ◇ **A Calling Talent:** a unique ability.
- ◇ **Standing 1** in the Calling's institution, guild or loose fellowship. Standing measures how much the Calling's people trust you and what they will give you. It rises from 1 to 5; each Calling has its own ladder of titles.
- ◇ **Starting gear,** in addition to what you buy.

The seventeen Callings below are found in every land, though they take local shapes. A Sallowreach Seamer sews the dead together; a Brinehollow Seamer opens drowned chests at high tide. The Carver may allow a Calling to take a faction's form described in the land

chapters (a Waker as a Nightwarden, a Netwatch lieutenant as a Nightwarden, a Thin faster as a Purger, a Dream-Diver as a Delver).

SEAMER

Surgeons, embalmers, bone-setters, suture-witches and stitchers of the dead. In Sallowreach they are the Guild that holds the country together; elsewhere they are the only people who will open a body and look at what is growing in it.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Stitching, Endure, Reckoning.
- ◇ **Talent — Tight Seams:** when you treat a wound, the patient recovers +2 Flesh. Once per session you may perform a **Reseat** on a character at 0 Flesh: roll Hand + Stitching vs Grim (18); on a success they do not suffer a new Injury from this Ruin.
- ◇ **Gear:** a roll of needles and awls, gut and wire thread, a bone saw, a jar of vinegar, a flask of something for the pain.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Threader	Guild lodging, cheap thread, permission to practise
2	Stitcher	Access to the guild's corpse-stock for practice; 10% off services
3	Seamer	Your own clients; a Seamer's mark that opens hospital doors
4	Master Seamer	Apprentices (2); a seat at guild councils; surgeries in any city
5	Guild Elder	The guild acts on your word; Thessaly Mort knows your name

FACTOR

Clerks, buyers, caravan-masters and agents of the Rim Road Company and the merchant houses. They price everything, including you.

◇ **Calling Skills:** Haggle, Reckoning, Clause.

- ◇ **Talent — The Company Rate:** you buy at 20% less and sell at 20% more than listed prices on the Rim Road. Once per session you may produce a document (a letter of credit, a toll waiver, a manifest) that gets you or a cargo past a single checkpoint without a roll.
- ◇ **Gear:** a ledger, ink, a Company seal, a set of bone-coin scales, a lockbox, 20 extra lacks.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Tally-Clerk	Lodging at Company waystations at half rate
2	Factor	A line of credit of 100 lacks; a mule
3	Senior Factor	Your own caravan contract; credit 500 lacks; 4 Wardens on hire
4	Road-Master	Authority over a stretch of the Rim and its tolls
5	Director	A voice in the Company's Oathen-sworn councils

WARDEN

Road guards, sellswords, caravan muscle, bounty-collectors. The Rim Road Company employs ten thousand of them; the Admiralty and the Mortuary Court and the Board of Plenty employ more.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Blades, Endure, Intimidate.
- ◇ **Talent — Shield the Cargo:** when an adjacent ally is hit, you may take the blow instead (before damage is rolled). You gain +2 Armor against it.
- ◇ **Gear:** a sword or axe, a crossbow and 12 bolts, boiled leather armor, a Company tabard or local equivalent.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hired Blade	Steady pay (2 lacks a day on contract)
2	Sworn Warden	Oathen-sworn contract; a mount
3	Sergeant	Command of 6 Wardens
4	Captain	Command of a waystation's garrison
5	Marshal of the Rim	Command of a stretch of road and everything on it

CUTWRIGHT

Genealogists of the Cutwrights' College. They trace every bloodline back to the portion its ancestors ate. Their ledgers decide marriages, inheritances and executions.

◇ **Calling Skills:** Lore, Reckoning, Search.

- ◇ **Talent — Read the Line:** by examining a person for a few minutes (eyes, hands, teeth, the smell of their sweat), you can roll Eye + Lore vs Hard (14) to learn their land, their Cut, and their approximate Regrowth stage. With a Helping you also learn one Gift or Want they have.
- ◇ **Gear:** a portable ledger of the major lines, calipers, a magnifying glass, a sample case of dried blood.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Copyist	Access to the College's public ledgers
2	Surveyor	Travel papers; the right to demand an examination
3	Lecturer	Access to restricted ledgers; College lodging anywhere
4	Reader of Lines	Your rulings are accepted in courts of four lands
5	Provost	You know where every god is regrowing fastest

CLAUSEWRIGHT

Lawyers, contract-drafters and oath-makers, trained in Oathen and hired everywhere. Abroad they draft treaties; at home they draft the sentences by which the condemned are made to break themselves.

◇ **Calling Skills:** Clause, Persuade, Lore.

- ◇ **Talent — Exits:** you speak in careful conditionals. Once per scene, when you would be bound by your own words (an oath in Oathen, a contract, a promise sworn on the dead), you may declare the clause you buried in it: roll Tongue + Clause vs Hard (14) to escape the binding without penalty.
- ◇ **Gear:** a quill-knife, a writing case, sealing wax, a copy of the Book of Conditions, a soft leather bit (in case).

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Scrivener	Bench lodging in Tacit
2	Drafter	You may witness contracts for fees
3	Clausewright	The Bench recognises your drafting; foreign courts fear it
4	Senior of the Bench	Treaty work; diplomatic immunity in three lands
5	Chief Clausewright	You draft the sentence a Sayer speaks

SURETY

People who carry other people's oaths for a fee, taking the risk of the Breaking in their own bodies. In Oathen they are a profession; elsewhere, they are guarantors, hostages, co-signers, and the ones sent when somebody's word has to be backed by flesh.

◇ **Calling Skills:** Endure, Clause, Resolve.

- ◇ **Talent — Borne Weight:** you may take on another character's oath, debt or curse (with their consent and a ritual of a few minutes); the consequences of breaking it fall on you instead. You gain +3 Flesh permanently from the toughening that comes with the trade, and you ignore the first Injury each session.
- ◇ **Gear:** a ledger of the oaths you carry (start with 1d6 small ones from paying clients, and 30 extra lacks), bandages, splints.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Bondsman	Small contracts
2	Surety	Contracts worth hundreds
3	Senior Surety	Noble clients; your scars are your credit
4	Pledgemaster	The Rim Road Company's oaths
5	Ledger-Bearer	Treaties between nations ride on your body

NIGHTWARDEN

The uncanny police of the Table: the Netwatch on the Brinehollow shore, the Wakers with their needles, the Echo-Wardens of the silent gorges, the Hostwatch trackers of the Fast, the Loft-Wardens of the Set-Aside. Their work is to watch for the god and drag people back from it.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Instinct, Search, Intimidate.
- ◇ **Talent — Seen It Before:** you gain +2 on Dread checks against horrors of your home land, and once per session, when someone near you fails a Dread check, you may grab, slap, needle or shout them back: they reduce the Fray gained by your Caul rating.
- ◇ **Gear:** the local tools of the trade (boathook and net, needle and rattle, lantern and horn), a lantern, a whistle, a warrant.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Watcher	Pay, a beat, a warrant to detain
2	Warden of the Night	Authority to enter homes
3	Lieutenant	Command of a patrol of 8
4	Captain	A district
5	Commander	The land's whole watch answers to you

RENDERER

Butchers, slaughterers, salters, cooks and shippers of meat. In the Fatlands the Renderers' Union decides what leaves the country; on the Rim Road every inn needs a cook who does not ask questions.

◇ **Calling Skills:** Blades, Feast, Labor.

- ◇ **Talent — Know the Cut:** by taste, smell or a single cut, you can tell what a piece of meat used to be: species, age, and roughly how it died. On a Hard (14) Eye + Feast roll you can tell whether it was a person, and on a Helping, which one. You also gain +1 damage with cleavers and knives.
- ◇ **Gear:** a set of cleavers and knives, a rendering hook, salt, a leather apron that will never be clean again.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Spit-Hand	Kitchen work anywhere
2	Cutter	Union card; access to slaughterhouses
3	Master Renderer	Your own shop or kitchen
4	Barrel-Warden	You stamp the export barrels
5	Union Boss	Every barrel on the Rim Road stops at your word

MIDWIFE

Trained by the Attendance of Cradlewrack or by the village wise-women of the other lands. They bring things into the world and decide whether they stay. Abroad, they are also the best surgeons of the belly on the Table.

◇ **Calling Skills:** Stitching, Instinct, Rites.

- ◇ **Talent — The Two Questions:** you can tell at a glance whether a living thing is what it appears to be (Caul + Instinct vs Routine 10 for the obvious, Hard 14 for a Tenanted, Grim 18 for a Seated). You also gain +2 on rolls to treat or deliver anything, of any kind, from any body.
- ◇ **Gear:** an apron, birthing tools, a knife called the Second Opinion, cord-ties, a ledger of names.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Handmaid	Lodging with any midwife's house
2	Midwife	You attend births alone
3	Senior Midwife	Your Second Opinion is law in your district
4	Matron of the Attendance	Command of a lying-in house
5	Midwife-Paramount	You are the government

CRUMB-RUNNER

Smugglers, carters and night-haulers, who move food and contraband across borders the law says are closed. Despised by the people they feed.

◇ **Calling Skills:** Stealth, Wayfaring, Deceive.

- ◇ **Talent — Hidden Hold:** any cart, pack or boat you load has a hidden compartment that will not be found except on a Grace. You know one safe route between any two adjacent lands, and on the Rim Road you travel a third faster than others.
- ◇ **Gear:** a handcart or mule, oilcloth, rope, a dark lantern, a forged travel pass.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Runner	Contacts in two lands
2	Hauler	A safehouse; regular cargo
3	Route-Holder	A route of your own and three runners
4	Night-Factor	A network across three lands
5	Boss of the Dark Road	The Company pays you to leave its cargo alone

TAKER

Bounty hunters, poachers and kidnappers: the people who catch Blanks for the surgeons, Called for the Netwatch, runaways for the Board, and Unfed for the trade. A loathsome calling, and a profitable one. Guests who take it are usually trying to stop.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Wayfaring, Brawl, Search.
- ◇ **Talent — Taken Alive:** you gain +2 on rolls to grapple, bind, track or subdue. Damage you deal can be declared non-lethal at no penalty. You can tell a Blank or an Unfed on sight.
- ◇ **Gear:** manacles, a weighted net, a cosh, a cage-cart (or rights to one), sedative syrup.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Hand-for-Hire	Small bounties
2	Taker	Notice of bounties in two lands
3	Licensed Taker	A legal warrant in one land
4	Huntmaster	A crew of 5; noble clients
5	Purveyor	The Second Table buys from you directly

CELEBRANT

Priests, rite-keepers, mourners and cult preachers: the Finishers of Sallowreach, the Bedded of the Vigil, the Deepening of Brinchollow, the Barren Order, the Quiet, the Starved Saints, and the hedge-priests of the Three Doctrines. Whatever they preach, they are the ones people come to when someone they love starts to change.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Rites, Persuade, Resolve.
- ◇ **Talent — The Words Over the Body:** once per scene you may lead a rite: everyone present who joins you removes 2 Fray. Once per session, you may preach to a crowd (Tongue + Rites vs Hard 14) to move it to an act of faith or fury.
- ◇ **Gear:** vestments, a holy book of your doctrine, candles, incense or vinegar, a relic of doubtful origin.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Acolyte	Shelter in your faith's houses
2	Celebrant	You may lead rites
3	Elder	A congregation of 30
4	High Celebrant	A temple, a district, a flock of hundreds
5	Prophet	They will walk into the sea if you ask

GLEANNER

Scavengers, salvagers, rag-pickers, grave-robbers and part-thieves: the salvage crews of the Uncovered, the gleaners behind the Fatlands harvesters, the diggers of the Sump. They know the worth of what others have left behind.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Search, Filch, Craft.
- ◇ **Talent — Something Worth Having:** once per session, in any place where people have lived or died, you find something useful: a tool, a coin purse, a key, a relic, a body part of value. Roll Eye + Search vs Hard (14); each Helping adds 10 lacks of value. You also halve the time it takes to search.
- ◇ **Gear:** a pry-bar, a sack, a shovel, a lantern, gloves, a fence's name.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Picker	You know where the pickings are
2	Gleaner	A fence who pays fair
3	Salvage-Boss	A crew of 4; a claim
4	Wreck-Lord	Claims across a district
5	Master of Leavings	Every fence on the Rim knows your mark

DELVER

Explorers of god-places: the Dream-Divers of the Vigil, the Hushwalkers and surveyors of Sallowreach, the pilots of the Uncovered, the watchers at the Dilation, the trackers who follow the Host. They go where the god is closest and come back changed, if they come back.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Athletics, Instinct, Godsign.
- ◇ **Talent — Gone Under:** you may spend an hour preparing to enter a god-place (a Hush, the long room, the Trench, a crowning). While inside, you gain +2 to all rolls and reduce Fray gained by 1 (minimum 1). When you come out, gain 1 Hunger (or 1 Want, if Unfed).
- ◇ **Gear:** a tether-line and harness, chalk, a compass that may not work, smelling salts, a death-mask or veil.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Novice	A patron who pays per descent
2	Delver	Maps of the near reaches
3	Veteran	Your own expeditions
4	Pathfinder	State commissions
5	The One Who Came Back	Your maps are the only maps

PURGER

Members of the Purgation: the cross-border movement that believes the gods can be thrown back up. Purgers range from gentle fasters and bleeders to the cells that burn high-Cut houses with the families locked inside.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Feast, Rites, Stealth.

- ◇ **Talent — Bring It Up:** you know the emetics, bleedings and fasts. Once per day, you may spend an hour purging yourself or a willing (or held) subject: roll Gut + Feast vs Hard (14); success removes 1d6 Hunger, a Helping removes 1 more, a Grace lowers Regrowth by 1 (only once per stage). The subject suffers 3 damage and is Weakened (–2 to all rolls) for the rest of the day.
- ◇ **Gear:** a Purgation kit (emetics, lancets, leeches, a basin), a hair shirt, a hidden pamphlet, a list of names.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Penitent	Shelter in Purgation safehouses
2	Purger	Access to the cell's resources
3	Cell-Elder	Command of a cell of 6
4	Voice of the Purge	A district's cells
5	The Clean Hand	You decide which bloodlines burn

RECKONER

Zealots out of the Fast who carry the Refusal across the border on a blade, killing the highest Cuts of the Godeaters in their beds. Nearly all are Unfed; a few are converts from Scrapling families who hate

their lords. Taking this Calling makes you a wanted murderer in six lands.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Blades, Stealth, Resolve.
- ◇ **Talent — In Their Beds:** you deal +4 damage against an unaware target, and +2 damage against any target of Cut 3 or

higher. You can sense godsign on a person (Caul + Instinct vs Routine 10) and estimate its Cut.

- ◇ **Gear:** a long knife, a garrotte, dark clothes, a ration bag, a list of names with some crossed out.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Brother/Sister of the Knife	A cell's protection
2	Reckoner	Your own targets
3	Raid-Leader	Command of a raid of 6
4	Reckoner-Captain	Authority to declare a bloodline ended
5	The Hand of Hallowboard	The Abstinent listen to you

SCION

The children of the Cuts who rule: the disinherited Heirs of Sallowreach, the Gut-line heirs being fattened for the Board, the lidless children of the Watch, the heirs of the Caul-lines in their membranes. A Scion has money, a name, a bloodline the god prefers, and a family that will not let them go. Requires Cut 3 or higher.

- ◇ **Calling Skills:** Persuade, Lore, Godsign.
- ◇ **Talent — The Name:** your family name opens doors. Once per session you may invoke it to gain an audience, a loan of up to 100 lacks, a bed, or the cooperation of a minor official, with no roll. The family will ask for something in return. Your Teeth add +1 each to the total when you Partake.
- ◇ **Gear:** fine clothes, a signet, a horse or litter, a servant (Threat 1), a letter of introduction, 100 extra lacks.

STANDING	TITLE	GRANTS
1	Cadet	An allowance of 5 lacks a day
2	Heir	A household of your own
3	Lord or Lady	A seat in your land's councils
4	Head of a House	The house's wealth and its feuds
5	Great House	A crown, a bench, a court, or a hill

▼ STEP SIX: SKILLS

Distribute **18 points** among the twenty-four skills. No skill may be raised above 3 with these points (Calling Skills may then go to 4). A

skill at 0 can still be rolled; you simply add nothing for it.

RATING	MEANING
0	Untrained. You have seen it done.
1	Novice. You can manage when it is easy.
2	Trained. A journeyman's competence.
3	Expert. The best in a village.
4	Master. The best in a city.
5	Legendary. People travel to watch.

THE TWENTY-FOUR SKILLS

- ◇ **Hand** — **Blades** (knives, swords, axes, cleavers, sickles), **Brawl** (fists, teeth, grappling, clubs), **Shooting** (bows, crossbows, slings, harpoons, thrown), **Stitching** (surgery, first aid, medicine, embalming, seaming the dead).
- ◇ **Gut** — **Endure** (pain, poison, cold, exhaustion, disease), **Labor** (lifting, digging, hauling, breaking), **Feast** (eating the inedible, drink, drugs, tasting, cooking), **Intimidate** (threat by presence and size).
- ◇ **Lung** — **Athletics** (running, climbing, swimming, dodging), **Stealth** (hiding, sneaking, shadowing), **Wayfaring** (travel, riding, driving, foraging, the Rim Road), **Filch** (pockets, locks, sleight of hand).
- ◇ **Eye** — **Search** (finding, noticing, investigating), **Lore** (history, theology, the Cuts, the lands), **Craft** (making and mending things), **Reckoning** (numbers, ledgers, clocks, mechanisms, natural philosophy).
- ◇ **Tongue** — **Persuade** (honest argument, charm, seduction, comfort), **Deceive** (lies, disguise, forgery), **Haggle** (prices, bribes, trade), **Clause** (law, contracts, the drafting of oaths).
- ◇ **Caul** — **Resolve** (enduring horror, resisting compulsion), **Rites** (prayer, ritual, the doctrines, burial), **Instinct** (danger sense, reading people, the uncanny), **Godsign** (understanding and controlling the god in the blood).

▼ STEP SEVEN: KNACKS

Choose **two Knacks**. Each is a narrow edge, a habit, or a scar that have requirements. pays. More can be bought with Portions (see Advancement). Some

KNACK	REQUIREMENT	EFFECT
Bail-Lunged	—	Hold your breath for (Lung × 2) minutes; +2 to resist drowning and smoke.
Bone-Coin Nose	—	Tell counterfeit lacks, false seals and forged notes by smell (Routine 10).
Butcher's Calm	—	Ignore Dread 1 from bodies and gore entirely.
Cold Supper	—	You need eat only every other day without penalty.
Conditional	Tongue 3	When lying, you may reroll one die, once per scene.
Corpse-Road Walker	—	+2 to travel and navigation rolls through fen, Uncovered or empty farmland.
Counting Habit	Eye 3	Once per session, ask the Carver how many of something there are, and get the true number.
Dirty Fighter	Brawl 2	Your unarmed attacks deal 2 and can blind for a round on a Helping.
Dowager's Patience	Caul 3	Once per session, take an action you were compelled not to take by a Want, without a roll.
Eats Anything	Feast 2	You can eat spoiled, raw, or godtainted food: reduce any Taint from eating by 1.
Elder's Ear	—	Old people, the Kept, and the Seated tell you things they tell no one else (+2 Persuade).
Fast Hands	Hand 3	Draw and attack with a small weapon in the same moment; +2 to initiative.
Gallows Laugh	—	When you make the table laugh at something horrible in character, remove 1 Fray (once per session).
Good Bones	Gut 3	+3 Flesh.

KNACK	REQUIREMENT	EFFECT
Hard Sleeper	—	You sleep without dreaming, wherever you are. (Useless in the Vigil.)
Hostage's Smile	—	+2 to rolls to make captors like you or let their guard down.
Iron Stomach	Gut 2	+2 to Endure vs poison, disease, rot and drugs.
Kin-Sense	Caul 2	You always know when someone of your own blood is within a mile.
Light Sleeper	Eye 2	You cannot be surprised while asleep or resting.
Little Lies	—	One trivial falsehood per session is believed without a roll.
Mother's Hands	Stitching 2	Treat Injuries one step faster.
No Thank You	—	+2 to resist any offer, invitation, seduction, or temptation, mundane or divine.
Old Grief	—	Once per session, when you take Fray from the death or loss of someone, take 2 less. You have practice.
Pin-Cushion	—	Pain sharpens you: while below half Flesh, +1 to all Eye rolls.
Rope Knots	—	Your knots never come undone by themselves, even in Cradlewrack.
Second Chair	—	When an ally makes a roll you could help with, give them +2 (instead of the usual +1).
Scrap-Born Luck	Cut 1 only	Once per session, reroll a Lack.
Silent Supper	—	You can go a whole day without speaking and suffer no penalty; +2 Stealth in quiet places.
Smell of Cedar	—	You know how to look like you belong to a better Cut: +2 Deceive and Persuade among the rich.
Steady Hands	Hand 2	No penalty for performing delicate work under pressure.
Strong Back	Labor 2	Carry double the normal load.
Table Manners	—	You know the grace and customs of all seven lands: +2 to first impressions anywhere.
Unflinching	Resolve 3	Once per session, automatically succeed on a Dread check of rating 3 or lower.
Vinegar Kiss	—	You carry the smells of rot well: animals and the Kept do not notice you unless you act.

▼ STEP EIGHT: DERIVED TRAITS

- ◇ **Flesh** = 8 + Gut + Endure. Your physical endurance; see the combat chapter.
- ◇ **Guard** = 10 + Lung + the best of Athletics, Blades or Brawl. The target number to hit you in melee. **Ranged Guard** = 10 + Lung + Athletics.
- ◇ **Armor** from what you wear.
- ◇ **Hunger** starts at 0.
- ◇ **Regrowth** starts as set by your Cut. Note the Gifts you already have and any Wants that are active (High Cuts, starting in the Appetite, have their first Want active).
- ◇ **Fray** starts at 0, unless the Carver rules otherwise. Some backgrounds (a Vigil-born, an Oathen Forsworn) may begin with Fray 2.
- ◇ **Want** (Unfed only) starts at 3.
- ◇ **Portions** (experience) start at 0.

▼ STEP NINE: THE FOUR QUESTIONS

Mechanics describe what a Guest can do. These four answers describe who they are. Write them on the sheet. The Carver will use every one.

The Last Meal. What is the last meal you ate that you truly enjoyed, and who was at the table? Every Guest on the Table is hungry in some way, and this is the shape of theirs. Once per

session, when your Guest acts to protect, honor or return to what that meal represented, gain +2 to the roll.

The Oath on the Dead. Swear an oath on the name of someone dead: a parent, a child, a friend, a victim. Write the name and the oath. (*On my brother Wem, who was Reaped: I will find where they took him. On my mother, whom I finished: I will never touch another living thing with these hands.*) See the rules for Oaths on the Dead.

They bind across the Table, in ways that are subtler than Oathen’s but no gentler.

Who Waits at Home. Name one living person who loves you and is waiting for you to come back. Where are they? What would they think of what you are becoming? The Carver will put them in danger. That is a promise.

What You Will Not Do. Name one thing your Guest will not do, whatever happens. Eat a person. Kill kin. Lie under oath. Lie down. Sit at a laid table. When your Guest is pushed to do it, play it honestly; if they do it, they gain 5 Fray at once, and you must write a new line they will not cross.

▼STEP TEN: GEAR AND MONEY

Take the starting gear from your Calling and the starting wealth from your Cut, and spend it in the Rim Market (Part Three). Everyone also begins with: a set of clothes suited to their land and

station, a knife, a bowl, a spoon, a blanket, a water-skin, and three days of food they carried themselves.

▼ADVANCEMENT: PORTIONS

At the end of every session, each Guest earns **Portions**:

- ◇ 1 for showing up and playing.
- ◇ 1 for each of the following, if it happened: you learned a secret of the Table; you faced a horror of Dread 3 or higher; you acted on

your Last Meal, Oath on the Dead or Who Waits at Home in a way that cost you; you made the table gasp, wince or laugh.

- ◇ 1–3 for completing a goal or surviving a story’s end.

A typical session earns 4–7 Portions. Spend them between sessions:

IMPROVEMENT	COST IN PORTIONS
Raise a skill by 1	New rating × 2
Raise an attribute by 1 (max 5)	New rating × 5
Gain a Knack	6
Raise Standing by 1	New rating × 3, plus a deed the Calling recognises
Remove 3 Fray	2 (represents rest, rites, drink, company)
Treat a Derangement (see Fray)	10, plus months of care

Cut cannot be bought. It is what you were born with. Regrowth cannot be bought, either: it comes on its own.

EXAMPLE OF CHARACTER CREATION

Maya wants to play a Brinehollow Netwatch officer who has begun to doubt the job. She chooses **Brinehollow** (+1 Lung) and **Common** Cut (Cut 2, Regrowth 1, one Tooth, 40 lacks). She puts her 9 attribute points into Hand 3, Gut 2, Lung 3, Eye 2, Tongue 1, Caul 3, then adds the land bonus: Lung 4.

She chooses the **Nightwarden** Calling (Instinct, Search and Intimidate +1). With 18 skill points she buys Blades 2, Brawl 2, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 1, Instinct 2 (3 with Calling), Search 2 (3), Intimidate 1 (2), Endure 2, Resolve 3. She names her Guest **Ressa Weir**.

Her Knacks are **Bail-Lunged** and **Old Grief**. Flesh = $8 + 2 + 2 = 12$. Guard = $10 + 4 + 3 = 17$. At Regrowth 1 she has the Brinehollow Taste: salt on her lips at waking. Her Last Meal: smoked herring with her brother on the pier, the night before he was Called. Her Oath on the Dead: *On my brother Ferrin, who walked in: I will never again drag anyone back from the water.* Who Waits at Home: her sister-in-law, Ama, who keeps Ferrin's chain on the bedpost. What she will not do: put a rope on a living person again.

That oath and that line are going to collide with her job by the second session. That is the point.



CHAPTER 12

THE GRACE ROLL

On the Table, nobody asks if a thing can be done. They ask what it will cost, and who will be made to pay it.

– RIM ROAD SAYING

The rules of *The Long Grace* are short at their heart. One kind of roll settles nearly everything. Around it are wrapped the systems that make this world itself: what it costs to call on the god in your

blood, how the god grows back, how the mind wears through, and how the dead hold you to your word.

▼ WHEN TO ROLL

Roll only when three things are true: the outcome is uncertain, failure would be interesting, and something is at stake. A Seamer stitching a cut in a quiet shop does not roll. A Seamer stitching a cut while the patient screams and the Kept in the next room are pounding on the wall to be let in, does.

When nothing is at stake, the Carver simply says what happens. When the outcome is impossible, nobody rolls: you cannot argue a Hush into giving back its silence.

▼ THE ROLL

To attempt something uncertain, a Guest rolls **2d10** and adds one **Attribute** and one **Skill**. The Carver says which pair fits; players may suggest another and argue for it. The total is compared to a **Difficulty**.

Total = 2d10 + Attribute + Skill (+ modifiers) (+ Teeth, if Partaking)

DIFFICULTY	NUMBER	EXAMPLE
Routine	10	Climb a knotted rope; find an inn on the Rim Road; calm a frightened child.
Hard	14	Climb a wet pier-piling at night; pick a Seamer's lock; lie to a Waker.
Grim	18	Stitch a severed hand back on in a moving cart; out-argue a Clausewright.
Dire	22	Climb a cliff of the Hanging Abbey in a gale; lie to a Tenanted judge.
Impossible	26	Talk a Sayer out of a sentence; outrun the Black Noon.

If the total equals or beats the Difficulty, the attempt succeeds. Otherwise it fails. A failed roll does not have to mean nothing happens: it may mean you succeed at a cost, too late, or with a complication, at the Carver's judgment. Failure on the Table should always move the story somewhere worse, never to a dead stop.

HELPINGS

For every full 4 points by which a total exceeds the Difficulty, the roll earns one **Helping**. A Helping is an extra: more information, more speed, a better price, a quieter entry, a cleaner cut. In combat, each Helping adds +2 damage. A player can usually spend Helpings as they like, within reason; the Carver may offer a menu.

Example: Ressa (Eye 2, Search 3) searches a drowned house for the ledger of the Called. Difficulty Hard 14. She rolls 7 and 9: total 21. That beats 14 by 7, one Helping. She finds the ledger, and with her Helping she also notices that the last entry is written in her brother's hand.

GRACE AND LACK

When the two d10 show the same number, the roll is an **omen**.

- ◇ If the roll **succeeds**, it is a **Grace**. Something goes better than it had any right to: the strongest effect the situation allows, a Helping on top of whatever was earned, an enemy disarmed, a door that was going to be locked found open, a second piece of information. In combat, a Grace attack also inflicts a **Mangling** (see Combat).
- ◇ If the roll **fails**, it is a **Lack**. The worst plausible complication happens: the weapon breaks, the lie is not only seen through but believed to be something worse, the patient's wound opens further, the god notices.
- ◇ **Double 1s** ("**Licked Clean**") always fail, whatever the total, and always with a Lack.
- ◇ **Double 10s** ("**Second Helping**") always succeed, whatever the Difficulty (short of the impossible), and always with a Grace.

LACKS WORTH HAVING

A Lack should never be the Carver punishing the player. It should be the world being itself. Good Lacks on the Table: your Tooth bites (gain 2 Hunger); somebody you love hears what you just said; the thing you did leaves a mark that a Cutwright will be able to read; the noise wakes something in the cellar; your knife slips, and now there's blood on the bread; the rope you tied comes undone, in Cradlewrack, as everything does; you say "I promise" without meaning to, in Oathen.

MODIFIERS

Circumstances add or subtract from the total, usually by 2 (sometimes by 4 for something overwhelming). Good tools, time, and help add; darkness, injury, fear, cold and Wants subtract. Do not stack more than three modifiers. If the situation is that lopsided, change the Difficulty instead.

- ◇ **Help:** another character who could plausibly assist gives +1 (or +2 with the *Second Chair* Knack). Only one helper counts, unless the task is physical and large (lifting a cart, pulling a Called man out of the surf).
- ◇ **Tools:** the right tool is assumed; a fine one gives +1 or +2; no tool at all may make a task impossible or Grim.
- ◇ **Time:** taking ten times as long gives +2. Rushing gives -2.
- ◇ **Injury, exhaustion, hunger:** -2 per condition, as specified in their rules.

OPPOSED ROLLS

When two characters act against each other (a lie against a suspicion, a chase, an arm-wrestle, a haggle), both roll. The higher total wins;

▼PARTAKING: THE TOOTH

Anyone with a Cut of 1 or higher carries a god. Before any roll, a Guest may **Partake:** call on the god in their blood to lend them its strength, its senses, its terrible certainty. When you Partake:

- ◇ Roll **one Tooth** (a d6, in a different color from your d10s) and add it to the total. A character of Cut 3 or higher may roll **two Teeth** if they wish. Teeth are rolled with the 2d10. They do not count for doubles.
- ◇ Gain **1 Hunger** for Partaking.
- ◇ Gain **1 additional Hunger** for every Tooth that shows a 1. The god bit back.
- ◇ Describe how the god shows itself. Each land's chapter describes its **Tooth:** a Sallowreach Guest's hands go cold and their fingers

on a tie, the defender (or whoever is keeping the situation as it is) wins. Helpings in an opposed roll are counted by how much the winner beat the loser by.

LONG TASKS

For efforts that take hours or days (restitching a grandmother, deciphering a seating plan, crossing the Uncovered), the Carver sets a **number of Helpings needed**, typically 3 to 8, and a time per roll. The Guests roll until they reach the total or run out of time, and a Lack along the way costs something real.

THREAT

Minor non-player characters do not need full statistics. They have a **Threat** rating from 0 to 5 that they add to all their rolls instead of Attribute + Skill (attack rolls are listed separately). A Rim Road innkeeper is Threat 1. A Netwatch lieutenant is Threat 3. Lady Corrow Vane is not a Threat-rated character.

seem one joint too long; a Fatlander's mouth floods with saliva; a Brinehollower's ears pop and their voice drops an octave; a Vigil-born's eyes stop blinking; a Cradlewracker feels something turn over inside them; an Oathener hears their own heartbeat repeating their last words.

Partaking is powerful. A Tooth adds 3.5 on average, the difference between a Hard roll and a Grim one. It is also how the end comes. Every Guest who Partakes is choosing, roll by roll, to bring their god closer to the surface.

The Unfed and Blanks cannot Partake. The Unfed have Want instead.

▼ HUNGER

Hunger is a track from 0 to 10. It represents how awake and active the god in your blood is right now: the rise of appetite, compulsion, and wrongness in the body. Hunger rises when you:

- ◇ Partake (+1, and +1 per Tooth showing 1).
- ◇ Suffer a Lack while Partaking (+2).
- ◇ Eat godtainted food or handle relics with Taint (see the Rim Market).
- ◇ Spend time in a place where your god is strong, such as a Hush, the Trench or the Dilation (+1 per hour or more).
- ◇ Give in to a Want (+1).
- ◇ Refuse your Sop for too long (see below; +1 per day after the third).

When Hunger reaches **10**, the god takes a step forward. **Regrowth rises by 1** and Hunger empties to 0. Describe the change. Something in the body is different now, and it does not change back.

▼ REGROWTH

Regrowth is a track from 0 to 12. It measures how far the god has come back in you. It rarely falls. The four stages, and the **Brink**

THE SOP

Each land's god can be quieted, for a while, by giving it a little of what it wants. This is the **Sop**: closing something in Sallowreach, eating in the Fatlands, bailing or submerging in Brinehollow, the dangerous blink in the Vigil, opening a door in Cradlewrack, keeping or making a vow in Oathen. Each land's chapter defines its Sop precisely.

Performing the Sop takes a few minutes to an hour. It removes **1d6 Hunger**. But the Sop is the god's own habit. Each time a Guest Sops in a single day after the first, they must make a **Caul + Resolve** roll (Routine 10, Hard 14 for the third time, and so on), or the next Sop becomes a Want they cannot easily stop.

A Guest who goes **three days without Sopping** begins to gain 1 Hunger per day as the god grows restless.

before the last, are common to every land, though each land's chapter describes what they look and feel like there:

REGROWTH	STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS
0	—	The god is asleep. Blanks and the Unfed are here forever.
1–3	The Taste	Small wrongnesses. Dreams, cravings, a tell in the body. Gain the land's Taste Gift.
4–6	The Appetite	Compulsions. The body wants what the god wants. Gain the Appetite Gift and the first Want.
7–9	The Course	Flesh changes. You are visibly becoming something else. Gain the Course Gift and the second Want. Dread 1 to those who see you unclothed.
10–11	The Brink	The god is nearly here. Gain the Brink Gift. All Wants are Hard (14) to resist. Dread 2 to those who see your changes.
12	The Seating	The god is, in some real portion, present again, wearing you or making a place of you. The character is lost.

Gifts are the god's power leaking through. They are real, useful and terrible, and they are listed in each land's chapter. A Guest has every Gift from every stage they have reached.

Wants are compulsions. Each Want has a **trigger** (an open door, a closed eye, food left on a plate). When a Want is triggered, the Guest must either act on it or roll **Caul + Resolve** against Routine (10) in the Appetite, Hard (14) in the Course and Brink. Acting on a Want removes nothing and adds 1 Hunger. Resisting it successfully costs nothing; failing means acting on it anyway, or suffering 2 Fray if the player and Carver agree the Guest stood firm by sheer horror.

CAN REGROWTH BE REVERSED?

Almost never. A Purger's Grace can roll it back by one, once per stage. The relics of some lands can delay it. Orrum's tables can stop it entirely, in the way that death stops a fever. There are rumours of a dozen cures on the Rim Road, and every land is certain that one of them works. None of them do. The Carver may allow a single, terrible, story-driven exception in a campaign. It should cost more than the character wants to pay.

THE SEATING OF A GUEST

At Regrowth 12, a Guest is **Seated**. Their god is, for a moment and in some portion, back in the world. What happens depends on the

land: a Sallowreach Guest becomes a Hush; a Fatlander becomes a warm hill with, perhaps, a mouth; a Brinehollower's Tenant takes the whole house; a Vigil-born lies down and becomes a sleeper who moves; a Cradlewracker bears what they were always going to bear, or becomes the door; an Oathener becomes a Sayer, whose every word is so.

▼FRAY AND DREAD

The Table breaks minds as surely as bodies. **Fray** is a track from 0 to 10 measuring how far a Guest's composure has worn through.

The player and the Carver play out the Seating together as a final scene. It should be awful and it should be beautiful. Afterward the character is an NPC, a place, or a power, and the player makes a new Guest. A Seated Guest's former companions should meet them again.

DREAD CHECKS

When a Guest encounters horror, the Carver calls for a **Dread check**: roll **Caul + Resolve** against a Difficulty set by the horror's **Dread rating**:

DREAD	DIFFICULTY	EXAMPLES
1	Routine (10)	A rotting body. A Kept man restitched at the dinner table. Toothed wheat. Being Called by a stranger's voice.
2	Hard (14)	Watching a murder. A Kept woman coming apart in your hands. The Reaping taking someone you have just met. A Tenanted stranger looking at you.
3	Grim (18)	A loved one Called, Tenanted, Reaped or Breaking. A ritual killing. Eating a person, knowingly. A face you know on a place card.
4	Dire (22)	A person becoming a place. A Hush swallowing a village. The god in your blood speaking. Kin-slaying by your own hand.
5	Impossible (26)	A Seating. A god's face. The Host turning to look at you. Knowing that what you did changed nothing.

- ◇ **Success:** gain 1 Fray (or none, on a Grace). You hold.
- ◇ **Failure:** gain Fray equal to the Dread rating. On a Lack, add 2 more, and the Guest freezes, flees, screams, vomits or laughs, at the Carver's choice, for a moment that matters.

A Guest only checks once against the same source in a scene, and the Carver may rule that a horror seen too often stops counting (a Seamer does not check for corpses). Guests may Partake on Dread checks. The god does not mind if you are frightened, and sometimes it is the god that makes you brave.

FRAY EFFECTS

- ◇ **Fray 0–4:** steady.
- ◇ **Fray 5–7: Rattled.** –1 to all Eye and Caul rolls. Sleep is thin, appetite strange, and you jump at doors.

- ◇ **Fray 8–9: Fraying.** –2 to all rolls except to flee, hide or fight. You see things at the edge of the lamp. You are short with the people you love.
- ◇ **Fray 10: Break.**

BREAKING

When Fray reaches 10, the Guest **Breaks**. For the rest of the scene they are not in control of what they do: the player describes the Break with the Carver (running into the night, attacking the nearest person, curling under a table, laughing until they choke, saying every secret they have). Afterward, the Guest gains a **Derangement** and Fray drops to 3.

Roll on the table below or choose one that fits what broke them. Derangements are permanent unless treated. Each has a **trigger** and an **effect**; when triggered, roll **Caul + Resolve** (Hard 14) to master it for the scene.

D20	DERANGEMENT	EFFECT WHEN TRIGGERED
1	The Dead Man	You believe you are already dead: your flesh is rotting, your heart has stopped, you smell it. You feel no fear of harm and take no care of your body (–2 to Endure, +2 to Dread checks against death). Triggered by any reminder of your own mortality.
2	The Impostors	Someone you love has been replaced by something wearing their face, their voice, their memories. You cannot be convinced otherwise. Choose the person. You cannot cooperate with them, and may act against them. Triggered by their kindness.
3	Not My Hand	A part of your body is not yours: it belongs to someone else, or to the god. You will not use it willingly (–2 to rolls that need it) and sometimes it moves on its own. Triggered by exhaustion or Hunger 6+.
4	Lost Time	You lose minutes or hours. You come back somewhere else, with dirt under your nails and blood on your sleeve, and no memory. The Carver may narrate what you did. Triggered by Fray 5+ or by the Sop.

D20	DERANGEMENT	EFFECT WHEN TRIGGERED
5	The Watchers	Everyone is watching you, reporting on you, planning against you. –2 to Persuade; +2 to Search for real threats. Triggered by being alone with strangers.
6	The Count	You must count things: steps, teeth, the dead, the living. You cannot stop until you finish, and the number is always one short. Triggered by stress.
7	The Voice at Table	You hear a voice that speaks in the tone of your god. It is reasonable. It gives advice. Some of it is good. Triggered whenever you Partake.
8	The Hollow Plate	Food tastes of ash, of rot, of people. You cannot eat without a Hard (14) Gut + Feast roll; you begin to starve in full larders. Triggered at every meal.
9	The Echo	You repeat the last words spoken to you, under your breath, again and again. In Oathen this is lethal. Triggered by shouting or by oaths.
10	The Seeing	Hallucinations: the Seeming without a city to share it. You see figures laying tables, the dead walking, your own body changing. –2 to Search. Triggered by darkness or exhaustion.
11	Shut Doors	Open things are unbearable: doors, eyes, mouths, wounds, books. You must close them. Triggered by any open door or eye. (In Cradlewrack this is a death sentence.)
12	Kept Grief	You cannot let go of a dead person. You speak to them, set their place, keep their belongings, and, in Sallowreach, may keep them. Triggered by any reminder.
13	The Devotion	You attach to a person, cause or god with absolute loyalty and will do anything they say. Choose the object. Triggered by their presence or their absence.
14	Blood-Hunger	You crave the taste of blood, of meat, of a particular kind of meat. Triggered by the smell of cooking or of wounds.
15	The Splitting	You stand outside yourself and watch your body act. Calm, distant, unreal. +2 to Dread checks; –2 to Persuade and to anything requiring care. Triggered by violence.
16	The Unclean	You are contaminated: by godsign, by others' touch, by rot. You wash compulsively until you bleed. Triggered by touching another person or a body.
17	The Gaslight	You no longer trust your own memory. Others can convince you of anything you saw or did not see (–4 to resist being deceived about the past). Triggered by being contradicted.
18	The Rage	Small slights become murderous. Triggered by being mocked, cheated, or refused food. Roll or attack.
19	The Guilt That Bends the Room	Your guilt is so heavy it warps what you see: the person you failed is everywhere, in faces and crowds and reflections. When triggered you gain 1 Fray. Triggered by success.
20	The Pull	You feel the god's invitation in its fullest form: the sea, the Hush, the bed, the chair. You want to go. When triggered you must roll or move toward it. See <i>Despair</i> , below. Triggered by Fray 8+ or by being near the place.

CONTAGION

Madness on the Table is catching. It always has been: the Seeming of the Vigil is only the most organized form of it. When a Guest or NPC **Breaks** in the presence of others, every witness makes a **Dread 2** check. Anyone who fails and is at Fray 5 or more also takes the same Derangement, in a shared form: they see what the Broken one saw, believe what they believe, count the same count. The Carver should make this feel like a cold draft moving through a room.

As the gods regrow, contagion grows stronger. In a place where a Seating has occurred, or near a Brink-stage noble, witnesses check at Dread 3.

DESPAIR

Of all the Derangements, **The Pull** is the most dangerous, and the Table is full of people who have answered it: the Finishers singing

their way into the Hushes, the Called walking into the surf, the sleepless of the Vigil lying down on purpose, the starving of the Fatlands crossing into the Fast to find a table where they can finally feel full.

When a Guest with the Pull is triggered and fails to master it, they move toward the god's place and invitation. They can be stopped by their companions (a roll, a grip, a rope, a word, a reason). If they reach it and nothing stops them, the player and the Carver decide together what happens, out loud, with the table's consent. This book never describes such an ending as a method or a release. It describes it as what it is on the Table: a loss that lands on everyone who loved them, and a little more of the god in the world. A Guest's companions who witness it gain Fray as a Dread 4 horror, and the Carver should give the grief room.

RECOVERING FROM FRAY

- ◇ **A night of real rest**, safe, warm and fed (and awake, in the Vigil): remove 1 Fray.
- ◇ **A rite** led by a Celebrant or performed sincerely: remove 2 Fray.
- ◇ **A vice**: drink, rouse, poppy, brine tonic, gambling, sex (off-page), violence. Remove 1d6 Fray, but roll Gut + Endure (Hard 14) or develop a habit. Habits work like Wants.
- ◇ **Time with Who Waits at Home**: remove all Fray, once per story, if they are still themselves.
- ◇ **Portions**: 2 Portions removes 3 Fray between sessions.

Derangements can be treated with months of care, a Celebrant or Seamer who understands the mind, and 10 Portions. Some never go. Some of them, on the Table, are not wrong.

▼ OATHS ON THE DEAD

Every Guest begins with an Oath on the Dead, and any character may swear another. To swear on the dead, you speak the full name of a dead person, ideally where they lie, and promise something in their name.

- ◇ **The Strength of the Dead**: once per scene, when you act directly to keep the oath, add +2 to a roll.
- ◇ **Keeping**: when you fulfil an oath on the dead, remove all Fray and gain 2 Portions.
- ◇ **Breaking**: if you deliberately break the oath, the dead come to collect. Gain 3 Fray immediately and suffer a **Visitation**, chosen

by the Carver and shaped by the land where you swore: in Sallowreach the dead person, Kept, finds you; in the Fatlands you taste them in every meal; in Brinehollow their voice calls you from the water; in the Vigil they wait for you in every blink; in Cradlewrack you bear something with their face; in Oathen your body breaks to match the promise; in the Fast a place card bearing their name appears at every table you pass.

Swearing on the dead is not a light thing anywhere, and the Table is full of people who swore too easily. Grave-oaths sworn on the desecrated dead, over a body that has been opened or eaten or robbed, are said to bind twice as hard.

▼ HEALTH, HUNGER, AND THE BODY

ORDINARY HUNGER AND STARVATION

Every person needs about one day's bread a day: one lack's worth. Each day a character goes without food, they gain one level of **Starving**: -1 to all rolls per level, cumulative. At Starving 3, they cannot recover Flesh. At Starving 5, they lose 1 Flesh per day. A day of decent food removes one level. In the Fatlands, ordinary food never satisfies (see that chapter); in the Fast, nothing grows, and the Starving rules are the weather.

COLD, EXHAUSTION AND SLEEPLESSNESS

Each night without shelter in Lack, or without sleep, imposes -1 to all rolls (cumulative, up to -4) until the character rests. The Vigil

has its own rules for sleeplessness, which are worse.

DISEASE AND ROT

Wounds left unstitched for a day may fester: roll Gut + Endure (Hard 14) or lose 1 Flesh per day and suffer -2 to all rolls until treated. In Sallowreach, festering never kills, and never stops.

HEALING

- ◇ **First aid** (Hand + Stitching, Routine 10, a few minutes, once per wound) restores 2 Flesh, +1 per Helping.
- ◇ **Rest**: a full day of rest restores Gut in Flesh; a full day under a Seamer's care restores double.
- ◇ **Injuries** from the Mangling table heal according to their own entries, and some never heal.

▼ TRAVEL

The Rim Road is about 2,200 miles around. On foot a traveler makes about 20 miles a day on the road; by cart 25; by fast horse 40; by Company post-coach, changing horses at every waystation, 70. Waystations stand roughly every 15 to 25 miles, and a day's walk off the road in any land is somewhere stranger.

Each day of travel through dangerous country, the Carver may roll on the land's encounter table (see the bestiary), and one Guest may roll **Lung + Wayfaring** (Hard 14) to find a better route, avoid trouble, or make up time. Crossing into the Fast is a different matter entirely, and the rules for that are in its chapter.

▼ LIGHT AND DARKNESS

The Table is lit by tallow, oil, rushlight and the candles of the dead. Darkness imposes -2 to Search and to attacks; total darkness, -4. In

the Vigil there is no darkness, by law, and that is a horror of its own.



CHAPTER 13

BLOOD ON THE CLOTH

There is no clean way to open a person. There are only quick ways and slow ways, and the slow ways are cheaper.

– JEM CRACKLE, THE COOK'S KNIFE, TO AN APPRENTICE

The Warden came at Halloway with a boathook, the long kind the Netwatch use for pulling the Called out of the surf, and she knew from the way he held it that he had pulled more people out of things than he had ever put into them. That was his mistake. He wanted to hook her, drag her, take her alive. She only wanted him to stop.

She let the hook go past her ear. It caught her coat at the shoulder and tore it, and she stepped inside the length of the pole, where it was no use to anyone, and put the cleaver into the meat where his neck met his collarbone. It went in with the sound a joint makes on the block: that wet, final chock of iron finding the gap in the bone. She felt it through the handle into her wrist. His breath came out of him in a long, surprised

whistle, and something warm and copper-smelling ran over her knuckles and into her sleeve.

He sat down. He kept looking at her. He was trying to say something about his wife. She worked the blade free, the way you do, a little rock and a twist, and that was worse, because then the blood had somewhere to go.

She had butchered four thousand animals in her life. Her hands knew this. That was the part she would not be able to forget: how well her hands knew it.

Violence on the Table is fast, ugly and expensive. Fights are short. People who are hurt stay hurt. Guests who solve every problem with a blade will be dead, maimed, or something worse inside a few sessions, and they will deserve the stories told about them.

▼ THE ROUND

Combat is played in **rounds** of about three seconds. Each round, every combatant gets:

- ◇ **One action:** an attack, a dash, a grapple, a first-aid attempt, a shouted plea, a Sop, a Partake-and-act, anything that takes real effort.
- ◇ **One move:** a few steps, drawing a weapon, standing up, opening a door (in Cradlewrack it may already be open).

A character can give up their action for a second move. Talking a little is free.

INITIATIVE

At the start of a fight, everyone rolls **1d10 + Lung + Eye**. Act from highest to lowest. Ties go to the Guests. Those taken by surprise do not act in the first round. Initiative is rolled once for the whole fight, unless something dramatic resets it (a Hush opening, a pang, the lights going out in the Vigil).

▼ ATTACKING

To attack, roll **2d10 + Hand + Blades** (for edged weapons), **Brawl** (for fists, clubs, teeth, grapples) or **Shooting** (for anything thrown or loosed), against the target's **Guard**.

- ◇ **Melee Guard** = 10 + Lung + the best of Athletics, Blades or Brawl.
- ◇ **Ranged Guard** = 10 + Lung + Athletics. Add +2 for partial cover, +4 for heavy cover. Firing into melee without hitting friends needs a Helping, or a friend is hit on a Lack.

If the attack total meets or beats the Guard, it hits.

DAMAGE

Damage = weapon damage + 2 per Helping – the target's Armor.

A hit that is reduced to 0 or less by Armor does no Flesh damage, but on a Grace it still inflicts a Mangling. Damage is subtracted from **Flesh**.

WEAPON	DAMAGE
Fist, kick, bite	1
Knife, awl, needle, sling	2

WEAPON	DAMAGE
Cleaver, hatchet, club, sickle, shortbow	3
Sword, axe, spear, boathook, harpoon, crossbow	4
Poleaxe, maul, greatcleaver, Tablebreaker's axe	5
Siege weapons, falling masonry, a Laden's weight	6+

Weapon qualities (Hooking, Ripping, Heavy, Reach, Silent, Brutal, and so on) are listed in the Rim Market.

GRACE AND LACK IN COMBAT

- ♦ **A Grace on an attack** inflicts a **Mangling** in addition to its damage (roll on the table below). Grace attacks are where people lose eyes and fingers.
- ♦ **A Lack on an attack** means the weapon sticks, breaks, flies from your hand, or hits someone you did not mean to hit; or you overextend and the target gets a free attack against you.
- ♦ **A Lack on a defense** (when you are rolling to resist a grapple, or the Carver calls for a roll to dodge something unusual) means you fall, drop something, or take a Mangling yourself.

OTHER ACTIONS

- ♦ **Grapple:** Hand + Brawl vs Guard. On a hit, the target is held: they can only try to break free (opposed Gut + Labor or Lung + Athletics) or attack with a small weapon at -2. A holder can choke (1 damage per round, ignoring Armor), drag, pin or bite.

- ♦ **Disarm:** attack at -2; on a hit, no damage, the target drops their weapon.
- ♦ **Shove or trip:** Gut + Labor or Hand + Brawl vs Guard; the target falls or is pushed back. Standing up takes a move.
- ♦ **Aim:** spend an action aiming to gain +2 on your next ranged attack.
- ♦ **Full Defense:** spend your action defending: +4 Guard until your next turn.
- ♦ **Flee:** move away. Anyone engaged with you gets a free attack unless you win an opposed Lung + Athletics roll.
- ♦ **Partake:** you can Partake on any combat roll. Many Gifts are combat abilities.

FEAR IN THE FIGHT

A fight against horrors calls for a Dread check when the horror is first seen, not once per round. Seeing an ally Mangled is Dread 2. Killing someone for the first time is Dread 2 (Dread 3 for someone you knew, Dread 4 for kin).

▼ FLESH, RUIN AND DEATH

Flesh = 8 + Gut + Endure. A Guest at half Flesh or less is **Bloodied**: -1 to all rolls.

When Flesh reaches **0**, the character suffers **Ruin**: they take an **Injury** (roll on the Mangling table) and collapse. They can crawl, whisper, and do nothing else useful. They are **Dying**.

A Dying character who takes any further damage is **dead**. A Dying character who is not treated within (Gut) minutes must roll **Gut + Endure** (Hard 14) every minute; failure means death. A successful first-aid roll stabilizes them at 1 Flesh.

In **Sallowreach**, nothing dies. A character who would die there becomes **Kept**: see that chapter. They keep their Injuries. They keep

everything.

DAMAGE ON THE TABLE, BY THE NUMBERS

An ordinary Guest has 10 to 14 Flesh. A knife does 2 to 6, a sword 4 to 8, a crossbow bolt at close range 4 to 10. Two or three solid blows will drop anyone. A Grace can end a fight at once. Armor matters enormously: boiled leather turns a knife into a bruise. The cheapest way to survive a fight is not to be in it. Carvers should let NPCs surrender, flee, bargain and beg, and they should do so often. On the Table, everybody is somebody's kin.

▼ THE MANGLING TABLE

Roll **1d20** when a Grace attack lands, or when a character suffers Ruin. Add +2 if the weapon is **Brutal** or the damage dealt was 8 or

more. Every Mangling is also a **Dread 2** horror for those who see it happen to someone they care about.

D20	MANGLING	EFFECT
1–2	Laid Open	A long shallow cut that unzips the skin and shows the yellow fat beneath. Bleeds freely: 1 damage per round until bound. Scar.
3	Knuckles	Fingers broken or split to the bone. –2 to Hand rolls until healed (2 weeks). On a Lack later, one finger is lost.
4	Teeth	A blow to the mouth: teeth spat out in pieces with the blood, lips torn. –2 to Tongue rolls for a week; permanent gaps.
5	Rib-Crack	You hear it before you feel it: a green-stick crack, then the grinding. –2 to Lung rolls; every deep breath is a knife (4 weeks).
6	Hamstrung	The tendon behind the knee parts like a bowstring. Movement halved; cannot run. Without a Seamer's Grim (18) repair, limp forever (–1 Lung).
7	The Ear	Torn half off, hanging by a flap of gristle. –2 to hearing-based Search. Stitched back crooked, or lost.
8	Gut-Stuck	A wound in the belly that lets out the smell of the bowel. Fever in 1d3 days unless treated (Grim 18 Stitching); –2 to all rolls while it festers.
9	Eye	The eye is punctured, crushed, or hangs on its cord. Lost. –2 to Search and Shooting thereafter (–1 after a month of adjustment). Dread 2 to see.
10	Skull	The scalp splits and the bone beneath dents like an egg. Stunned for 1d6 rounds; roll Gut + Endure (Hard 14) or lose memory of the last day.
11	Broken Arm	The forearm bends between the wrist and elbow, where there is no joint. Unusable for 6 weeks; splint and pray.
12	Broken Leg	The shin snaps, perhaps through the skin, white and wet. Cannot stand. 8 weeks; a Lack in healing means a permanent limp.
13	Severed Fingers	One to three fingers gone, rolled away in the dirt. Permanent –1 Hand for fine tasks. Someone may pick them up.
14	Opened	A deep wound across the abdomen. Loops of grey-pink bowel slide free and steam. Dying in (Gut) minutes unless held in and stitched (Grim 18). Survivors are weakened (–1 Gut) for a season.
15	Severed Hand	Off at the wrist; the stump sprays in rhythm with the heart. Lose 2 Flesh per round until tied off. The hand twitches for a while afterward. In Sallowreach, much longer.
16	Jaw	The jaw is broken, dislocated or torn half away: the tongue lolls in a ruin of teeth. Cannot speak clearly; can only take liquid. 6 weeks. (In Oathen, many count this as mercy.)
17	Throat	A cut or crush to the throat. Blood in the windpipe; breathing is a gargle. Dying in (Gut) rounds unless treated (Dire 22). Survivors speak in a rasp forever.
18	Unmanned	A savage wound to the hip, groin or pelvis; the bone grates, the blood pools black. Cannot walk for 2 months; Gut –1 permanently. Dread 2.
19	Severed Limb	An arm off at the elbow, a leg off at the knee: hacked through, the bone ends splintered and pale. Lose 3 Flesh per round until tied off. Ruin follows. A Seamer may reattach a limb from another body; it will not be quite yours.
20+	Butchered	The blow opens the body like a carcass on the hook: the chest split, the skull cloven, the head half off. The character dies at once, outside Sallowreach. Inside it, they continue, in that condition, indefinitely. Dread 3 to all who see.

▼ SPECIAL SITUATIONS

FIGHTING THE KEPT

The Kept of Sallowreach cannot be killed. Reducing one to 0 Flesh drops it, and it goes on moving: crawling, biting, grasping with whatever is still attached. To stop a Kept enemy you must **dismember** it: each Mangling result of Severed Hand, Severed Limb or Butchered removes the use of that part. Burning helps; it does not finish. Hand-line touch and the Hushes are the only true ends.

FIGHTING MANY

Mobs, the Forsworn of the Breakdowns, a Reaping crowd, the Finishers walking in: treat a mob as one character with Flesh equal to 5 × its number, Threat equal to 1 + one per 5 members (max 5), and damage equal to its best weapon + 1 per 5 members. Each 5 Flesh lost drops one member. Mobs break and run when they lose half their number, unless they are faithful, starving or Called.

FIGHTING GODS

You cannot. A Seated god has no Flesh to take. The rules for what you can do instead are in *Things That Eat and Are Eaten*.

EXECUTIONS, TORTURE AND MURDER

Not every killing is a fight. When a Guest kills a helpless person, no roll is needed for the act. The roll is afterward: a Dread check at

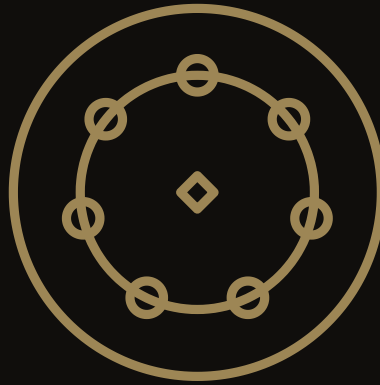
Dread 2 (Dread 3 for someone who begged; Dread 4 for kin). Torture extracts information on an opposed roll of the torturer's Tongue + Intimidate against the victim's Caul + Resolve, but the Carver decides how true the answers are, and the torturer makes a Dread 2 check each session they continue. Jack Tenterhook of the Vigil says the difference between his work as a wake-valet and his old job is the tipping. He is lying, and it shows on him.



PART THREE

THE MARKET AND THE THINGS THAT EAT

Coin, goods, relics of godflesh, and the horrors that walk the lands.



CHAPTER 14

THE RIM MARKET

Everything on the Table has a price. The trick is finding out who is paying it.

– PAINTED OVER THE DOOR OF THE COMPANY COUNTING-HOUSE AT TOLL
NINE

The stall stood where the Rim Road bends at Gristmoor, between a man selling anchoring-rope by the fathom and a Seamer's boy crying "Thread, wire, lacquer, fingers!" in a voice that had broken years ago and been stitched back wrong. It was a Fatlands stall. You could tell by the width of the counter, which was built to bear a forearm the size of a bolster, and by the smell, which was gravy, clove, and something under the clove that the clove was there for.

The stall-wife was called Mardy Haunch and she was, by the custom of her country, beautiful: she spilled over her stool on both sides like risen dough over a tin. She was eating while she sold. She was always eating while she sold. She had a sausage in one hand and a knife in the other, and the sausage was a yard long and coiled on the board in front of her like a sleeping dog, and every so often it moved.

"It is not moving," said Mardy Haunch, to the customer. "That is settling."

The customer was from the Vigil. You could tell by the eyes, which were red to the rims and had stopped bothering to blink, and by the long pin she wore through the web of her left hand so she could twist it when the world went soft. She had a nudger with her, a small boy on a lead, whose whole job was to kick her ankle every twenty breaths. He was very good at it. He did not look up from her ankle once.

"Price," said the Vigil woman.

"For the yard? Eleven lacks."

"Eleven." The Vigil woman put three little black tabs on the counter, pressed and stamped with an open eye. "Rouse. Good rouse. Crane's strain, not the Slope stuff. Four hours of waking each."

Mardy Haunch looked at the tabs the way a cat looks at a painted bird. "What am I going to do with four hours of waking, my love? I sleep like a ditch. Coin."

"I have six lacks in coin."

"Then you have six lacks of sausage." Mardy raised the knife and the sausage, quite distinctly, tightened its coil away from it.

"Settling," said Mardy, and put the knife down.

At this point a third party arrived, which is how all real haggling on the Rim Road goes. He was an Oathener, tall and

dry and dressed in canyon-red, with a little brass plate at his collar that said PRICE-WITNESS, LICENSED, and he spoke very slowly, the way a man walks across a frozen pond. "If it would be of use," he said, "and if neither party objects, and barring weather, I might, as I now intend, assist."

"Nobody asked you," said Mardy.

"That is so," said the Oathener, which cost him nothing, because it was true. He looked at the sausage. He looked at it for some time. "I would observe, without asserting anything as to its composition, that the casing bears a mark."

It did. A little way from the end there was a faded blue pattern pricked into the skin. Anchors. Two anchors, crossed, and under them, in a sailor's crude letters, the beginning of a name: SAL. The rest of the name was round the other side of the coil.

There was a silence of the kind you get at a market when everyone within six stalls has stopped pretending not to listen. The rope-seller had stopped measuring. The Seamer's boy had stopped crying fingers.

"That," said Mardy Haunch, with tremendous dignity, "is a pig that went to sea."

"I would not say otherwise," said the Oathener, very carefully, "since I cannot."

The Vigil woman leaned in, red eyes unblinking, close enough to read. The boy kicked her ankle. She did not notice. "Turn it over," she said.

"Turn it over yourself. Four lacks, then. For the yard. And the tabs."

"Three lacks and the tabs, and you turn it over."

"Five and I don't."

The Oathener coughed, gently. "If it would help to settle the matter, and as a neutral party, I might say that in my judgment, as I now hold it, the item has a value, and that value is not nothing."

Both women looked at him with loathing. He received it calmly. He was paid a crumb a word, and he had been very economical.

In the end the Vigil woman paid four lacks and two tabs, and Mardy Haunch threw in a heel of toothed bread, which bit the boy, and wrapped the coil in a sheet of oiled paper and tied it

with string, and did not turn it over. The Vigil woman walked off up the Rim Road towards the lamp-glow on the eastern horizon, carrying the parcel against her chest like a baby, and three stalls down she stopped, and unwrapped one end, and looked.

Nobody saw what the rest of the name said. But they saw her stand there a long while. And they saw her, at last, wrap it up again and keep walking, because it was a long road and she was hungry and four lacks is four lacks.

"Lack keep away," said Mardy Haunch to the next customer, and smiled, and ate.

On the Table everyone needs something that only an obscene neighbour can sell. The sleepless need oil, brine and pain. The undying need perfume and thread. The starving heartland needs everything, and hates whoever brings it. The Rim Road is the ring of highway that carries all of it, three thousand miles of rutted stone around the Fast's border, owned by the Rim Road Company, tolled at every bridge and lined with inns, wells, shrines, gibbets and

markets. Most of what player characters buy, they buy on the Rim, from someone who is lying to them about where it came from.

This chapter is a working market. It sets out the money of the Table and what it is made of; how to find something for sale and how long that takes; how to argue the price down; what living costs in each land; and long lists of weapons, armour, clothes, tools, food, drugs, beasts, beds and services. It closes with the things that are not supposed to be for sale at all: relics cut from the gods, and the merchants who deal in them.

USING THIS CHAPTER

Prices are given in lacks (L) and crumbs (c). Ten crumbs make a lack; twenty lacks make a platter. Prices assume a Rim Road market in a good season. Use the Availability rules to decide whether an item is on the stall at all, the Haggling rules to settle what the characters actually pay, and the Taint rules whenever the thing they bought was once part of a god.

The GM should not let shopping become bookkeeping. Track money closely when it is scarce and it matters (in the Fast, in a siege, in debt to an Oathener). Otherwise let characters live at a lifestyle and roll only for the purchases that make a story.

▼ THE COIN OF THE TABLE

We pay for bread with bone. Nobody thinks this is strange. Nobody has ever asked whose.

— MEEK GARRITY, FROM A SUPPRESSED LECTURE

THE LACK

The lack is the one coin honoured everywhere on the Table: a disc of salt-cured bone the width of a thumb-joint, a finger's width thick, pierced at the centre so it can be strung, and stamped on one face with the Plate (a full moon) and on the other with an empty circle. By law and by custom it is worth one day's bread. When the price of bread rises, people do not say that bread is dear. They say the lack is thin.

Nobody minted the first lacks. In the years after the Gorging, when the famine broke and the crops rose in a week, the peoples of the Table had a great deal of bone lying about from the meal, and the oldest tradition holds that the first coins were cut from the gods themselves: from Ummer's ribs, from Dromm's vast spine, from the knuckles of Ossel. Those First Lacks, if any survive, are not money. They are relics (see Relics & Godflesh). The coin in your purse is ordinary bone. That is the official position, and it is almost true.

HOW BONE BECOMES COIN

Since 212 A.G. the only lawful mint is the Rim Road Company's Cure-House at Saltbridge, on the Rim where the Fatlands road

meets the Brinehollow road. Every lack struck in the last four centuries passed through it. The process is old, simple and filthy.

- ◇ **The bone.** It comes from the Chute, the Fatlands' great export depot, in sealed carts stamped BONE: MIXED. The Renderers' Union sells the Company the long bones of everything slaughtered in the south. Everything slaughtered in the south includes the cattle, the swine, the orchard-pigs, the drover-herds of Sal Trotter, and the Fatlands dead, who are served at their own wakes and whose bones the family is paid a few crumbs to send on. The Company does not sort. Coin-cutters say you can tell a cattle lack from a person lack by the grain; the Company says that is superstition, and fines anyone who says it twice.
- ◇ **The boil.** The bones are boiled white in copper vats for three days and three nights. The fat is skimmed and sold back south as tallow. The steam from the Cure-House can be smelled from the next toll, and the people of Saltbridge are famous for their good skin and bad dreams.
- ◇ **The cutting.** Coin-cutters, most of them Scraplings bound to the Company for twenty years, saw the long bones into rounds on treadle saws and punch the centre hole. A good cutter gets nineteen lacks from a man's thigh. The cutters keep tally-sticks of their work and are paid in their own product, one lack in fifty.

- ◇ **The cure.** The rounds are packed in salt for a full season. The salt is Brinehollow salt, and since the sea retreated, most Brinehollow salt is boiled out of the water Brinehollowers cough up at dawn and dusk, collected in parish buckets and sold by the barrel. Every lack on the Table is cured in somebody's lungs.
- ◇ **The stamp.** A hot iron die burns the Plate and the empty circle into the faces. The empty circle has been on the coin since the first Company issue; the Company's charter says it represents "the bread to be bought." Some old coin-cutters say it is a chair seen from above.

A genuine lack is dense, faintly translucent at the edge when held to a lamp, cool to the touch, and tastes strongly of salt. Merchants bite coins. On the Rim this is not a figure of speech.

CRUMBS

A crumb is a tenth of a lack: a bone bead the size of a pea, pierced and cured like its parent, cut from the knuckles, ribs and offcuts that will not make a full disc. Crumbs are strung in tens on a knotted cord called a loaf. Paying a lack in crumbs is legal but rude, and a merchant may count every bead in front of you while you wait. Children are paid in crumbs, beggars ask for them, and every Oathen price-witness charges by them.

PLATTERS

A platter is a sealed Rim Road Company tablet of polished bone, the size of a palm, worth twenty lacks. Each is cut from a single shoulder blade, stamped with the Company's ring-road seal, numbered, and closed with a bead of red wax impressed by the signet of Jessamy Quill, Notary of the Rim Road. The Company has sworn, in Oathen, before Quill, that it will redeem every unbroken platter for twenty lacks at any Company house on the Rim. Because the oath was sworn in Oathen, it cannot be broken without the Company's sworn officers coming apart. This is why the platter is trusted more than any coin, and why the Company guards Jessamy Quill more closely than any king guards a crown. If she dies, every platter in circulation becomes a pretty piece of shoulder.

WEIGHING AND CLIPPING

A true lack weighs as much as forty grains of untoothed wheat. Money-changers carry hanging scales and a pouch of reference grains, and in the Fatlands, where the wheat has teeth, they carry grains from the Rim and guard them like jewels. Shaving a lack (clipping) is a hanging offence in every land except Sallowreach, where the offender is shaved in turn, very slowly, by the same amount. Clipped coins are accepted at nine crumbs, or at eight if the clipping shows.

COUNTERFEITS

Bone is everywhere, so forging lacks is the commonest crime on the Rim. The common fakes and their tells:

- ◇ **Horn and hoof.** Pressed and dyed. Too light; burns with a stink when touched with a hot needle. Detected on a Routine (10) Eye + Reckoning roll.
- ◇ **Unsalted bone.** Bone that skipped the season in brine. Tastes of nothing. A merchant who bites coin finds it at once.
- ◇ **Kept bone.** Cut from the Kept of Sallowreach, whose bodies never finish rotting. These coins are perfect in every respect but one: they never stop decaying. In a few weeks a Kept lack goes greasy and grey and smells faintly of the fen. In a purse it sweats. A purse of Kept coin attracts flies. Hard (14) to spot when fresh.
- ◇ **Wrack bone.** Bone from Cradlewrack Parts. A coin cut from a Part, it is whispered, is still growing; it thickens by a hair a month, and in a year will not fit a string. Hard (14) to spot.
- ◇ **Blank bone.** The rarest and most sinister fake: lacks cut from the bones of Blanks or the Unfed. They are said to be the only coins with no god in them at all. Collectors pay twenty times face value. They are almost always proof that somebody was killed for their skeleton.

Passing false coin knowingly is punished by the Company with a fine of ten times the face value and the loss of the passing hand's thumb, and by most lands with worse.

WHOSE BONES?

The question every player eventually asks is answered differently depending on who is asked. The Company says: cattle. The Renderers' Union says: whatever comes. Mistress Brisket Annalow, if she can be made to say anything, says that since the Reaping doubled the Chute ships more bone than the herds could possibly account for, and that the Company has never once complained about the quality. A character who studies lacks for long (Grim 18 Eye + Lore) can learn to read the grain, and from then on will know which coins in their purse were people. They will still spend them. Everybody does.

SWORN NOTES

Oathen does not mint. It does not need to. In Oathen, a written promise to pay, sworn aloud before witnesses and signed, is backed by the only security that cannot run away: the issuer's own body. These are sworn notes, and they are the paper money of the eastern half of the Table.

A sworn note reads something like this: "I, Halde Vosk, of Tacit, as I now intend and barring weather, will pay the bearer twelve lacks on demand at my house in the third gallery, and if I do not, let my left hand answer." The issuer reads it aloud in front of a licensed Clausewright, signs it, and the Clausewright witnesses it with a thumbprint in ink. The note then circulates exactly like coin.

The collateral clause is what gives the note its value. It names what breaks if the issuer defaults: a hand, an eye's sight, the use of a knee, the voice, a set of teeth. The Rule of Oathen does the rest. The

moment the issuer refuses or fails to pay a bearer who has made lawful demand, the named part breaks, at once, with a sound, wherever the issuer happens to be. Notes backed by large collateral (“let my heart answer”) are not legal in Oathen, since a break is never fatal by itself and a heart that opens like a cupboard and goes on beating is considered bad for trade.

- ◇ **Valuing a note.** A note is worth its face value only if the issuer is solvent, whole, and findable. Oathen notes trade at full value in Tacit, at a crumb in the lack discount on the Rim, and at two or three crumbs in the lack in the far west, where the issuer is weeks away. A note by an issuer known to be close to default trades at half. Speculators in Tacit watch issuers’ bodies through spyglasses from the opposite canyon wall, and a limp is news.
- ◇ **Forsworn paper.** Notes issued by the Forsworn of the Breakdowns are backed by what they have left. A man whose ribs already stand open like a book has little to pledge. Brakk’s people issue notes against parts that are already broken; these are worthless and are traded as jokes, souvenirs and insults.
- ◇ **Sureties.** A merchant who lacks good body can hire a Surety to co-sign: the Surety pledges a part of their own body as second collateral, for a fee of one lack in ten. Ona Fell’s notes are the best paper in the canyon. She has two hundred and eleven other oaths in her, and her signature still trades at par.
- ◇ **Default abroad.** The break happens wherever the issuer is, because the oath is in the issuer. A note sworn in Tacit and defaulted in Lastgate snaps a wrist in Lastgate. Foreign issuers who swear notes in Oathen are bound like natives. A non-Oathener who signs a note outside Oathen is not bound at all, and their notes are not called sworn notes but “dry paper,” worth what the issuer’s honesty is worth.
- ◇ **The new terror.** Writing has begun to bind on its own. Two clerks in Tacit have broken this year over notes they copied but never swore. The Bench of Clauses has said nothing. The discount on Oathen paper has quietly doubled.

DEFAULT – WHAT HAPPENS

When a character who issued a sworn note fails to pay on lawful demand, the named collateral breaks: treat it as an Injury from the Mangling table chosen to match (a hand that will not close; an eye gone milky; a knee reversed), with no roll to avoid it, and a Dread 2 check for anyone who sees it happen. The character is now Forsworn in that matter, and every Oathener who sees them knows it. Paying the debt afterwards does not mend the break. Nothing does.

REGIONAL MONEY

Every land uses the lack, and every land also uses something else, usually something only that land could think of. A traveller who

wants to be treated as a fool pays in lacks everywhere. A traveller who wants local prices learns the local money.

SALLOWREACH: LICENSES, MINUTES AND BREATHS

The only thing truly scarce in Sallowreach is ending, and so death is the money of the north. The Mortuary Court sells a **death-license**, entitling the bearer to one Closing by a Hand-line Closer, for about four thousand lacks. Few families can raise that, so for three centuries the Court has also issued fractions of a license. A **minute of Closing** is a sixtieth part of a license, a narrow lacquered slip of coffin-wood bearing Regent Grue’s signature and the number of the license it belongs to. A **breath** is a twelfth of a minute: a black wax token stamped with a closed eye. Families save minutes for generations, in jars under the floor, towards the day great-great-grandmother can at last be finished. Lend a man a minute and he will thank you. Give a man a full license and he will weep. Minutes are the closest thing in Sallowreach to inheritance; they pass because their owners do not.

THE FATLANDS: MEAT SCRIP

The Board of Plenty pays wages, rents and taxes in **meat scrip**: printed slips of greased paper, each redeemable at any Board store or at the Chute for a stated weight of meat. The common denominations are the pound, the stone and the side. Meat scrip is the most honest money on the Table in one sense (it is backed by something you can eat) and the most horrible in every other, because its value tracks the supply of meat, and the supply of meat rises every Carving with the Reaping. In a heavy Reaping year the scrip falls by a third in a month. Pell Hogget’s tally-keepers chart the scrip rate alongside their count of the missing, and the two lines match.

BRINEHOLLOW: BAIL-TOKENS

A **bail-token** is a small disc of cast lead, stamped with a bucket, issued by Brinehollow parishes to anyone who bails the infirm at dawn and dusk. Each token is good for one cup of sweet water at an Admiralty cistern or one bailing done on your behalf. Because both are always wanted, the tokens circulate as small change. Children like Tolly Brack earn more in tokens than their parents do in coin. A **Netwatch tally**, a larger lead token stamped with a hook, is paid to the patrol for every Called person dragged home alive; Netwatch tallies are worth ten bail-tokens and are always suspected of being for bodies that were not, strictly, alive.

THE VIGIL: ROUSE-TABS

The Vigil’s small money is a **rouse-tab**: a pressed lozenge of black rouse stamped with an open eye, nominally good for one hour awake. Wages on the Slope are paid in tabs. Because the dose required rises every year, the tab is the only currency on the Table that suffers literal inflation of the body: a tab that held an hour in 600 A.G. now holds perhaps twenty minutes, and the Apothecary-General’s office restamps the official value each season. Tabs cut

with Brinehollow brine (see Drugs) are worth more on the Slope, because they work better, and are worth nothing to anyone who knows why.

CRADLEWRACK: NAMING-RIGHTS

In Cradlewrack, no child is named until it is a year old and plainly a child. Until then, the right to name it belongs to whoever bore it, and that right can be sold. A **naming-right** is a Tally-office certificate giving the holder the sole right to name a particular birth when the year is out. Rich families buy naming-rights to fill a branch of the family tree; the poor sell them for bread. Because nobody knows what a birth will turn out to be, naming-rights are speculation in the purest form: a right to name a healthy boy is worth a fortune, a right to name a hand is worth nothing, and a right to name something the Attendance does not permit is void. Kest has a naming-exchange, under the Tally hall, where rights are bought and sold by the hour as rumours come down from the birthing-rooms.

MONEY	ISSUER	VALUE IN LACKS	TAKEN WHERE	NOTES
Lack	Rim Road Co.	1	everywhere	the Table's coin
Crumb	Rim Road Co.	0.1	everywhere	strung in loaves of ten
Platter	Rim Road Co.	20	everywhere	void if Quill dies
Death-license	Mortuary Court	about 4,000	Sallowreach	one Closing
Minute of Closing	Mortuary Court	65	Sallowreach, Vigil	1/60 license
Breath	Mortuary Court	5	Sallowreach	1/12 minute
Meat scrip (pound)	Board of Plenty	0.3	Fatlands, Chute	falls in Carving
Meat scrip (side)	Board of Plenty	25	Fatlands	a whole half-beast
Bail-token	Brinehollow parishes	0.2	Brinehollow	one cup of sweet water
Netwatch tally	Tidal Admiralty	2	Brinehollow	"alive," officially
Rouse-tab	Apothecary-General	0.3	Vigil, Rim east	worth less every year
Naming-right	Cradlewrack Tally	2 to 400	Cradlewrack	speculative
Sworn note	Oathen issuers	face value	Oathen, Rim east	discount with distance
Ration chit	The Pantry	1 to 3	the Fast	illegal to sell

BARTER

Most of the Table does not live on coin. Scrapling villages run on barter, and on the Rim a great deal of trade is goods against goods, with lacks used only to settle the difference.

- ◇ **Fair barter.** Goods trade at their listed price if both parties need them. Goods the buyer does not need are taken at half their value. Goods the buyer badly needs (oil in the Vigil, perfume in Lastgate, sweet water in Brinehollow, anything edible in the Fast) are taken at one and a half times or double.

OATHEN: SWORN NOTES

As above. Small coin in Oathen is still the lack, and the price-witness is still paid in crumbs, but anything over a platter changes hands as paper.

THE FAST: RATION CHITS

The Unfed do not touch bone coin. They say the lack is cut from Godeaters and cured in Godeater lungs, and they are right, and they will not have it in their houses. Inside the Fast the only money is the **ration chit**: a square of unbleached cloth stamped by the Pantry with a single empty bowl, entitling the bearer to one day's ration at the Pantry window in Wanting. Chits are issued, never earned; the Abstinent give them out by household, by name, by list. A family left off the list has nothing to trade. The chits cannot lawfully be sold, and are sold constantly. In Lack season, when Mother Stint Avery begins cutting the lists, a chit fetches three lacks from a Crumb-Runner, who will be spat at for buying it.

EXCHANGE RATES

- ◇ **Regional goods travel well.** A good carried from its home land to a distant one is worth half again its home price on arrival, before any haggling. This is the whole business of the Rim Road.
- ◇ **Bartering with Partaking.** A character may not Partake to haggle with goods unless the god they carry is one the other party fears; the Tooth is felt, not seen, and merchants on the Rim know the look of a customer who is getting help.
- ◇ **Barter in the Fast.** The Unfed accept no gift and give none. A barter in the Fast must be declined three times by both parties

before it is agreed on the fourth asking. Skipping the ritual voids the trade, and the offended party will not deal again.

▼ FINDING THINGS

Anything can be bought on the Rim Road. Not everything can be found.

– TOLL NINE PROVERB

AVAILABILITY

Every item in this chapter has an Availability rating. To find an item that is not simply sitting in front of the characters, one character

makes a Grace Roll: **Eye** + **Haggle** against the difficulty below, modified by where they are looking. Other characters may help in the usual way. A character may Partake on the roll; the Tooth makes merchants talkative, or makes the searcher notice the stall behind the stall.

RATING	DIFFICULTY	SEARCH TIME	TYPICAL GOODS
Common	Routine 10	an hour	bread, knives, rope, lamp oil, perfume, rouse
Uncommon	Hard 14	half a day	swords, crossbows, mail, Kept-candles, laudanum
Scarce	Grim 18	a day	plate, Brinehollow tonic in the Fatlands, a Tucker
Rare	Dire 22	a week	godflesh, a Sayer's word, Blank parts
Unique	special	an adventure	named relics; never found by rolling alone

- ◇ **Success** means the item is for sale, at listed price, in this market. Each **Helping** may be spent to find a better example (one extra quality, or no hidden flaw), to find it cheaper (one step of price in the buyer's favour, see Hagglings), or to learn something about the seller.
- ◇ **Grace** means the seller is eager, or there is a second one, or the merchant offers something better than they "weren't going to show anyone."
- ◇ **Failure** means it is not here. The character may try again after the search time has passed again, at +2 difficulty for every retry

in the same market.

- ◇ **Lack** means the item is found, and it is wrong: stolen and recognisable, Tainted and undeclared, a fake, or sold by an informer. The GM chooses, and does not say which until it matters.
- ◇ **Unique** items are never found with a roll. They are the end of a trail, the price of a favour, or the reward of an adventure.

WHERE YOU LOOK

WHERE	MODIFIER	NOTES
Item's home land	−4	a Netwatch boathook in Lowmark
Neighbouring land on the Rim	+0	the next land around the ring
Far side of the Rim	+4	Fatlands meat in the Vigil
A capital or great Rim market	−2	Lastgate, Sated, Lowmark, Tacit, Kest, Gristmoot
A Scrapling village	+4	and Uncommon or better is not there at all
Inside the Fast	+8	nothing above Uncommon; nobody will sell to a Godeater
Black market	−4 for contraband	+50% price; see below

BLACK MARKETS

Every city on the Table has a market that is not on the Company's ledgers. In Lastgate it is the undercity under the lowest pilings, where Marrow Jack's boys sell limbs off drying racks. In Sated it is

behind the rendering yards. In Lowmark it is out on the Uncovered at low fog. In the Vigil it is the Slope, which is a black market with houses on it. In Kest there are no locks, so the black market is simply wherever you are when somebody shuts the door. In Tacit it

is conducted entirely in Handtalk, which is held not to bind, and which lately does.

Finding a black market needs a contact or a Hard (14) Eye + Search roll. Contraband bought there costs one and a half times the listed price, or double if the goods are capital crimes in that land. Selling there pays half the listed price, since the fence carries the risk. A Lack on any black-market roll means the Wakers, the Netwatch, the Bailiff's men or the Echo-Wardens were already watching.

GOODS	BANNED IN	CAPITAL IN	NOTES
Rouse	Fatlands (as "a hunger-killer")	—	the Thin use it to fast
Bottled brine tonic	Vigil (since 639), Brinehollow	—	Dry Jonah's trade
Beds, pillows, soft mattresses	—	Vigil	burned in the square, with owner's nudger fined
Emetics, fasting draughts	—	Fatlands (treason)	Purgation goods
Unlicensed Closings	—	Sallowreach	the Court calls it theft
Kept limbs, seamed parts	Sallowreach (unless own family)	—	Marrow Jack's trade
Godflesh of any land	Oathen, the Fast	Sallowreach (Hand-line flesh)	legal in Fatlands if declared
Parts of Cradlewrack	Cradlewrack (Attendance claims all)	—	the Assemblers pay best
Blank bodies or parts	everywhere, nominally	the Fast (as murder)	the Second Table buys
Locks that hold	—	—	legal, but Cradlewrack taxes them as luxuries
Unsworn speech-scrolls	Oathen (since 640)	—	written words may bind now
Cooked food not carried in	the Fast	—	treated as Orrum's
Bait doctrine tracts	Sallowreach, Fatlands, Oathen, Vigil	—	gaining ground in all seven

HAGGLING

Listed prices are opening prices. When a character wants to argue, the buyer rolls **Tongue + Hagggle** opposed by the seller's Tongue + Hagggle (or Threat, for minor merchants). The higher total wins. Ties favour the seller; it is their stall.

Price moves in steps of one-tenth of the listed price. The winner shifts the price one step in their favour, plus one step for each Helping (count Helpings from the loser's total, not from a fixed Difficulty). Price cannot fall below half or rise above double the listed price by haggling alone. A Grace for the buyer adds a small thing thrown in (a heel of bread, a name, a warning); a Lack for the buyer means they have offended the seller, who will not deal again today and will tell the next stall.

- ◇ **Regional tempers.** Sallowreach merchants have centuries of patience and are at +2 to resist haste. Fatlanders haggle while eating and are at -2 if the buyer refuses to eat with them, +2 if the buyer finishes the plate. Brinehollowers stop mid-haggle to bail and are not to be hurried. Vigil sellers are short-tempered

CONTRABAND

What is a crime depends on where you stand. The table below lists the goods most often smuggled on the Rim. "Banned" means seizure and a fine; "Capital" means whatever that land does instead of killing people.

and hallucinating; a buyer who pinches them first is at +1. Cradlewrack sellers knock on the counter before every offer.

- ◇ **Haggling in Oathen.** Every offer in Oathen is a promise. A buyer who says "I'll pay six" has sworn it. Oatheners haggle in conditionals ("If six were mentioned, it would not be refused") and a foreigner who does not is at -2 and is also likely to break something. A buyer who hires a licensed price-witness (1 crumb a word, a good one uses twenty) haggles at +2 and swears nothing.
- ◇ **Haggling in the Fast.** No price may be accepted until it has been declined three times. A character who forgets is at -4 on any further dealing that day.

HELPINGS AND PRICE AT A GLANCE

Opposed Hagggle: the winner moves the price one tenth in their favour, and one more tenth per Helping of margin. Floor half, ceiling double. A buyer who Partakes and rolls a 1 on the Tooth has let the god show at the counter: the seller sees it, and the price goes up a step for fear, or down two for awe, as fits the god.

▼ T A I N T

Never eat the god twice. Once is history. Twice is a habit.

– PURGATION CATECHISM

Some goods are made from the gods. Bread from toothed wheat is grown in Ummer’s flesh. Bottled brine is the Fathom coughed up by its eaters. A Kept-candle is Ossel’s long refusal to finish, rendered into tallow. These goods carry **Taint**: the residue of the god, which goes on working in whoever uses them.

Taint is written as a rating from 1 to 5 and a kind: **Hunger**, **Regrowth**, or **Dread**. An item may carry more than one kind (for example, “Taint 2 Hunger, 1 Dread”). Taint triggers **on use**: once each time the item is eaten or drunk; once per scene it is wielded in anger, or burned, or opened; once per day it is worn against the skin; and once each time a relic’s power is called on.

- ◆ **Hunger Taint.** The user gains Hunger equal to the rating, exactly as though they had Partaked. No roll. If this takes Hunger to 10, Regrowth rises as normal.
- ◆ **Regrowth Taint.** The user makes a Caul + Resolve roll against the matching difficulty: Taint 1 Routine 10, 2 Hard 14, 3 Grim 18, 4 Dire 22, 5 Impossible 26. On success, they gain 1 Hunger. On failure, they gain 1 Regrowth directly. On a Lack, they also gain the item’s land’s Want for a day, even if it is not their land.
- ◆ **Dread Taint.** The user makes a Dread check at the rating’s Dread level, because the thing is horrible to use (a candle that whimpers; a loaf that bites back). Repeated use of the same item lowers Dread Taint by 1 after the first five uses, to a minimum of 1. One gets used to things.

Foreign gods. Godflesh from a land not your own carries a god you did not eat. Taint from a foreign god is not reduced by any Gift of your own Regrowth, and on a failed Regrowth Taint roll the gained point of Regrowth is marked as foreign: the GM may spend a foreign point at any time to give the character that land’s Taste-stage tell for a scene. Characters who mix gods in their blood are the reason the trade in cures never ends and never works.

The Unfed and the Blank. A character with Cut 0 ignores Hunger Taint; there is nothing in them to be hungry. Regrowth Taint is worse. Each failed Regrowth Taint roll gives a Cut 0 character one mark of **Seasoning**; at three marks, the meat has found what it was looking for, and the character gains Cut 1 in that god’s line, permanently. Tobias Wether and the Reckoner called Scour each have three marks.

Declaring Taint. In the Fatlands the law requires godflesh to be declared and stamped. Nowhere else does. A seller who knows the Taint will rarely say so; a Hard (14) Eye + Lore roll identifies the kind and rating of an item’s Taint, and a Grim (18) roll identifies which god.

Purging. A Purgation emetic (see Drugs) taken within an hour of eating Tainted food removes the Hunger it caused. Nothing removes Regrowth that Taint has given.

▼ C O S T O F L I V I N G

The rich smell of cedar. The poor smell of themselves.

– LASTGATE SAYING

A character’s lifestyle covers food, lodging, clothes and small expenses. Pay it by the day, the week (seven days) or the season (ninety days, at a tenth off).

LIFESTYLE	PER DAY	PER SEASON	WHAT IT BUYS	EFFECT
Destitute	1 L	80 L	a ditch, a crust, the clothes you stand in	no Fray recovery; +1 Hunger each week
Modest	3 L	250 L	a shared room, two meals, a clean shirt	normal recovery
Comfortable	8 L	650 L	a room of one’s own, wine, a servant’s help	–1 Fray each week of rest
Lavish	25+ L	2,000+ L	a house, a cook, the best perfume, a nudger	–2 Fray each week; +2 to Persuade high society

Characters who live below modest for a season lose 1 Flesh maximum until they recover a full season at modest or better. Characters who live lavishly in any land are noticed: by the

Cutwrights, who will want to know their Cut, and by the Reckoners, who already do.

REGIONAL COSTS

Every land adds costs that nowhere else would understand. These are in addition to lifestyle.

EXPENSE	LAND	COST	NOTES
Keeping a Kept relative	Sallowreach	2 L a week	perfume, vinegar, thread, a chair by the fire
Spring restitching (one Kept)	Sallowreach	15 L a year	Seamer's fee; more if limbs are missing
Setting Aside	Sallowreach	40 L once, 1 L a season	wrapping, labelling, a shelf in the Lofts
The Feasting Laws (five meals)	Fatlands	+2 L a day	travellers must comply; Bailiffs inspect inns
Funeral wake (serving the dead)	Fatlands	10 L	cook's fee; the family brings the dead
Bail-bucket and rope	Brinehollow	5 c a day	wear and tear; anchoring at night
Parish bailer (if too weak)	Brinehollow	2 bail-tokens a day	a child, usually
Rouse at current dose	Vigil	3 L a day	rising every season
A hired nudger (child)	Vigil	2 L a day	hourly rates on the Slope
A wake-valet (skilled)	Vigil	10 L a day	Jack Tenterhook charges 40
Bricking-in (nightly mason)	Cradlewrack	4 c a night	mortar, a mason at dusk and dawn
Attendance birth-fee	Cradlewrack	12 L	compulsory; the knife is included
Clausewright's daily review	Oathen	1 L a day	someone to check what you will say
Pantry dues	the Fast	one chit a day	if you are on the list
Rim Road tolls	the Rim	2 c a mile on foot, 5 c mounted	Company bridges cost a lack each

▼ ARMS AND ARMOUR

There is no gunpowder on the Table. There are a great many hooks.

– NETWATCH DRILL-SERGEANT'S OPENING REMARK

Damage is listed in brackets. Attack with melee weapons is Hand + Blades (or Brawl for fists, clubs and grapples). Ranged weapons use Hand + Shooting. Weapons marked with a land are Common there and one step rarer everywhere else.

WEAPON AND ARMOUR QUALITIES

- ◇ **Brutal.** Each Helping on a hit adds +3 damage instead of +2.
- ◇ **Concealable.** Finding it on a body takes a Hard (14) Eye + Search roll.
- ◇ **Entangling.** On a hit with at least one Helping, the target is held instead of taking the Helping's damage: they cannot move away and are at –2 Guard until they spend an action and succeed at a Hard (14) Gut + Athletics roll.
- ◇ **Fragile.** On a Lack, the weapon breaks.
- ◇ **Heavy.** Needs Gut 3 or more to use without penalty; otherwise –2 Attack. The wielder is at –1 Guard.
- ◇ **Hooking.** On a hit with at least one Helping, the attacker may give up the Helping's damage to drag the target one pace, pull them off a ledge or mount, tear away a held item, or knock them prone (the target may resist with a Hard 14 Lung + Athletics roll).
- ◇ **Light.** Can be used in the off hand; +1 Attack against a held or prone target.
- ◇ **Noisy.** Everyone within a long stone's throw hears it used. In the Vigil, this is considered good manners.
- ◇ **Parrying.** +1 Guard against melee attacks while held ready.
- ◇ **Piercing.** Ignores 1 point of Armor.
- ◇ **Reach.** Strikes from two paces away. A foe closing to arm's length is attacked first.
- ◇ **Ripping.** If the hit deals 3 or more damage after Armor, the wound bleeds: the target loses 1 Flesh at the end of each round until someone succeeds at a Routine (10) Hand + Stitching roll.

In Sallowreach a Ripping wound never closes without stitching, ever.

- ◇ **Silent.** Makes no sound in use; attacks from hiding gain +2.
- ◇ **Slow.** Reloading takes a full action.
- ◇ **Stunning.** On a hit with a Helping, the target loses their next action unless they succeed at a Hard (14) Gut + Endure roll.
- ◇ **Thrown.** Can be thrown up to ten paces with Hand + Shooting.
- ◇ **Two-Handed.** Needs both hands.
- ◇ **Waking.** A Vigil quality. A creature struck cannot blink, sleep or fall unconscious for the rest of the scene, even at 0 Flesh, and feels everything.
- ◇ **Tainted.** The item is made from godflesh and carries Taint as listed (see Taint).

MELEE WEAPONS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Fist, boot, teeth	—	—	(1)	Brawl; teeth are Ripping in the Fatlands
Knife	3 L	Common	(2) Light, Concealable, Thrown	everyone carries one
Club, cudgel	1 L	Common	(3) Stunning	a table leg, mostly
Cleaver	6 L	Common	(3) Ripping	butcher's; the Fatlands sidearm
Hatchet	5 L	Common	(3) Thrown	
Spear	12 L	Common	(4) Reach, Two-Handed	
Axe	20 L	Common	(4) Brutal	
Sword	60 L	Uncommon	(4) Parrying	an officer's or a noble's
Maul	35 L	Uncommon	(5) Heavy, Stunning, Two-Handed	
Poleaxe	70 L	Uncommon	(5) Reach, Hooking, Two-Handed	
Renderer's greatcleaver	55 L	Uncommon	(6) Heavy, Brutal, Ripping, Two-Handed	Fatlands; jointing whole oxen
Seamer's awl	4 L	Common	(2) Piercing, Silent, Light	Sallowreach; a stitching tool that goes through a skull
Loft-Warden's shelving hook	8 L	Uncommon	(3) Hooking, Reach	Sallowreach; for lifting the Set-Aside down
Lead mitten	25 L	Scarce	(3) Stunning	Sallowreach; made for Hand-lines; blocks a Closing touch
Netwatch boathook	15 L	Common	(4) Hooking, Reach, Two-Handed	Brinehollow; for bringing people home
Tide-bell clapper	10 L	Uncommon	(4) Noisy, Stunning, Heavy	Brinehollow; stolen from a bell
Waker's needle	6 L	Common	(2) Piercing, Waking, Concealable	Vigil; a foot of steel, hollow, rouse-dipped
Wake-valet's pincers	12 L	Uncommon	(1) Waking, Light; on a hit, a Dread 1 check	Vigil; for the precisely tolerable pain
Lamplighter's pole	9 L	Common	(3) Reach; lit, +1 fire damage	Vigil; brass hook and wick
Midwife's hooked knife	20 L	Uncommon	(3) Ripping, Hooking	Cradlewrack; called the second opinion
Assembler's bone-saw	14 L	Scarce	(3) Ripping, Brutal	Cradlewrack; teeth fine as an eyelash
Cullmaster's sickle	30 L	Scarce	(4) Hooking, Ripping, Silent	Fatlands; black iron, dusk shift only
Pruning hook	7 L	Common	(3) Hooking, Reach	Fatlands orchards; the trees remember it
Clausewright's quill-knife	18 L	Uncommon	(2) Concealable, Piercing, Silent	Oathen; for trimming quills and correcting drafts

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Bitmaker's tongs	15 L	Scarce	(2) Entangling; may seize the jaw	Oathen; to fit a bit by force
Echo-Warden's stave	10 L	Uncommon	(3) Parrying, Silent	Oathen; felt-wrapped so it never rings
Tablebreaker's axe	40 L	Scarce	(5) Brutal, Two-Handed; +4 vs furniture	the Fast; the haft notched for every table
Reckoner's long knife	25 L	Scarce	(3) Silent, Piercing, Concealable	the Fast; grey steel, never oiled with fat
Drover's goad	4 L	Common	(2) Reach, Stunning	Fatlands; Sal Trotter's herds know it
Kept-arm cudgel	30 L	Rare	(3) Stunning; Tainted (Dread 2)	Sallowreach; a Kept forearm, wired; it grips

RANGED WEAPONS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Sling	2 L	Common	(2) Silent, Concealable	
Shortbow	15 L	Common	(3) Two-Handed	
Longbow	40 L	Uncommon	(4) Two-Handed, Heavy	Cradlewrack hill archers
Crossbow	50 L	Uncommon	(4) Piercing, Slow, Two-Handed	
Arbalest	120 L	Scarce	(5) Piercing, Slow, Heavy, Two-Handed	Admiralty marines
Hand crossbow	70 L	Scarce	(3) Concealable, Slow	Reckoner assassins
Clockwork spring-bow	300 L	Rare	(3) Piercing; three shots before rewinding	Vigil; ticks loudly
Netwatch throwing net	8 L	Common	(0) Entangling, Thrown	Brinehollow; weighted with lead tokens
Harpoon	18 L	Uncommon	(4) Hooking, Thrown; with line, Entangling	Brinehollow; fished nothing for a century
Throwing knives (set of 4)	14 L	Common	(2) Thrown, Light, Concealable	
Waker's blowpipe	6 L	Uncommon	(1) Silent, Waking	Vigil; darts tipped with strong rouse
Drover's bola	3 L	Common	(1) Entangling, Thrown	Fatlands; for herds that run on two legs
Lamp-flask	2 L	Common	(2) Thrown, Fragile; burns 1 a round	Vigil oil in a thin glass bulb
Pang-stones (bag of 20)	1 L	Common	+1 to sling damage	Cradlewrack; red clay; warm

ARMOUR

Armor subtracts from damage taken. Armor of 3 or more gives -1 to Lung rolls for stealth and swimming; Armor 4 gives -2 .

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	ARMOR	NOTES
Padded jack	10 L	Common	1	quilted wool or rag
Hide coat	8 L	Common	1	Fatlands hide is warm for days after skinning
Boiled leather	30 L	Common	2	
Bone lamellar	90 L	Uncommon	3	Fatlands; plates cut from coin-grade bone, which is unlucky
Mail shirt	150 L	Uncommon	3	rusts in Brinehollow salt and Sallowreach weep
Plate	900 L	Rare	4	Heavy; Oathen and Admiralty officers
Netwatch oilskin	25 L	Common	1	Brinehollow; corked; floats the wearer face-up
Seamer's wire-coat	60 L	Uncommon	2	Sallowreach; meant to hold a Kept body together

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	ARMOR	NOTES
Suet-quilt	12 L	Common	1	Fatlands; lard-packed; burns like a candle
Studded Vigil coat	40 L	Common	2	studs inward; the wearer cannot nod off; Waking to self
Anchorite harness	35 L	Uncommon	2	Brinehollow; chain; the Calling cannot walk you far
Foundling brigandine	80 L	Uncommon	2	Cradlewrack; cut for bodies that are newly grown
Reckoner's greys	45 L	Scarce	2	the Fast; no fat in the leather; Silent
Buckler	6 L	Common	+1 Guard	Parrying
Bucket-shield	4 L	Common	+1 Guard	Brinehollow; a bail-bucket on a strap; still bails

▼ CLOTHING AND REGIONAL DRESS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Common clothes	3 L	Common	—	linen, wool, a hat
Good clothes	25 L	Common	+1 Persuade with merchants	
Noble dress	150+ L	Uncommon	+2 Persuade at court	and a target on your back
Lastgate mourning-cloak	20 L	Common	perfume pockets in the lining	Sallowreach; cedar for the rich
Kept's gauze binding	2 L a week	Common	holds a Kept face on	Sallowreach
Hand-line mittens	8 L	Common	stop compulsive closing	Sallowreach; worn by the Appetite-struck
Fatlands tent-coat	12 L	Common	expands with the wearer	let out every season
Gleaner's apron	1 L	Common	twelve pockets	stained to the elbow
Anchoring belt	6 L	Common	ring for a night-rope	Brinehollow; sweethearts stitch them
Pressure hood	18 L	Uncommon	+2 Endure on pressure days	Brinehollow; waxed leather
Pin-glove	3 L	Common	pricks the palm when gripped	Vigil; for staying awake
Tin-plated hat	5 L	Common	rattles in rain	Vigil
Attendance apron	—	not for sale	marks a midwife	Cradlewrack; wearing one falsely is a knife
Knocker's ring	2 L	Common	a brass ring for knocking	Cradlewrack; the polite carry one
Child's bit	4 L	Common	soft leather muzzle	Oathen; legally required under twelve
Clausewright's collar	30 L	Uncommon	brass plate of licence	Oathen
Unfed greys	2 L	Common	plain undyed wool	the Fast; any colour is vanity
Veil of the Second Table	300 L	Rare	a silk mask with a silver fork	never sold openly

▼ TOOLS AND KITS

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Seamer's kit	30 L	Common	needed for Stitching; +1 on the Kept	wire, thread, lacquer, cork, awl
Surgeon's case	80 L	Uncommon	+1 Stitching; can amputate	Quease buys every new design
Clausewright's box	50 L	Uncommon	+1 Clause on drafting	quills, sand, wax, a thumb-inkpad
Lockpicks	15 L	Uncommon	needed for Filch on locks	useless in Cradlewrack, which needs none

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Agnes Latch lock	200 L	Rare	holds a Cradlewrack door 2d6 nights	the waiting list is a year
Bail-bucket	1 L	Common	required in Brinehollow	sweethearts swap them
Anchoring rope (10 fathoms)	2 L	Common	+2 to resist being Called while tied	cut ropes are the great tragedy
Netwatch kit	25 L	Uncommon	hook, net, rope, rattle	
Rattle	1 L	Common	wakes a blinker, Noisy	Wakers' badge of office
Water clock	40 L	Uncommon	times pangs, bells, bailing	Cradlewrack
Spyglass	90 L	Scarce	+2 Search at distance	Oathen note-watchers use them
Hanging scales	12 L	Common	weigh coin and meat	Garrick Tripe's are rigged
Cutwright's calipers	60 L	Scarce	+2 Lore to judge a person's Cut	measures skull, nail and tell
Rope (50 ft), sack, chain	1–5 L	Common		
Wax tablets (Oathen)	3 L	Common	write without binding (allegedly)	since 640, not reliably
Brick, mortar, trowel	2 L	Common	brick yourself in for the night	Cradlewrack
Tablebreaker's wedge	3 L	Uncommon	+2 to break furniture apart	the Fast
Hostwatch frost-marker	5 L	Uncommon	chalk sticks that change colour on warm ground	tracks Orrum's passage

LIGHT

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Tallow candle	2 c	Common	4 hours	smells of the Chute
Beeswax candle	2 L	Uncommon	6 hours, clean	Cradlewrack hives
Oil lamp	3 L	Common	8 hours a pint	
Lamp oil (pint)	4 c	Common	doubled in the Vigil	Ashlock's ninety days
Vigil mirror-lantern	25 L	Uncommon	bright as noon, 20 paces	no shadows to sleep in
Bulseye lantern	15 L	Uncommon	a beam, shutterable	Netwatch issue
Wick Tallow candle	6 c	Common	burns 3 nights, steady; Tainted (Dread 1)	Sallowreach; it feels itself burn
Named Tallow candle	5 L	Uncommon	as above, made from a known person	Tainted (Dread 2); families commission them
Fen-glow jar	1 L	Common	dim green light, never goes out	Sallowreach; things that will not finish rotting
Smoulder-coal (Sallowreach)	1 L	Common	stays lit for years in a tin	fires there do not end

A Wick Tallow candle gives the steadiest light on the Table. Up close, the flame leans towards whoever lit it. Half of Lastgate reads

by people it used to know, and some of them can tell which.

▼FOOD AND DRINK

Lack keep away.

– SAID BEFORE EATING WITH ANY STRANGER, EVERYWHERE

Food is the Table's first trade and its first horror. Anything from the Fatlands is grown in Ummer and carries a little of it. Rim cooks sell

“safe” food, which means food they will swear is not, and nobody believes them.

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	NOTES
Rim bread (a loaf)	1 L	Common	a day's bread	the price of a lack, by definition
Toothed-wheat loaf	5 c	Common	Taint 1 Hunger	Fatlands; teeth milled out, mostly; may bite
Bleeding-orchard fruit	2 c	Common	Taint 1 Hunger; heals 1 Flesh	skin, fat layer, bone pit; screams if cut fresh
Veined roots (a sack)	1 L	Common	Taint 1 Hunger	they flinch when peeled
Meat by the pound	3 c	Common	Taint 1 Hunger	origin stamped over twice
Chute barrel (100 lb)	25 L	Common	see What's in the Barrel?	
Lady Aspic's jelly	30 L	Rare	Taint 2 Hunger, 1 Dread	it blinks
Skim (Fatlands drip-fat)	1 c	Common	cooking fat	skimmed off rain
Sallowreach fen-eel	4 c	Common	never stops wriggling	Sallowreach; eat it fast
Undying cheese	1 L	Uncommon	ripens forever	Sallowreach; sold by the decade
Brine (a pint)	1 c	Common	salty; Taint 1 Regrowth to non-Brinehollowers	coughed up at dawn; sold for curing
Kelp-bread	3 c	Common		Brinehollow; from cellar-tide kelp
Uncovered salvage-tins	2 L	Uncommon	roll d6: on a 1, something alive	Brinehollow wrecks
Rouse (brewed, a cup)	1 c	Common	see Drugs	Vigil coffee-houses
Clatter-cake	2 c	Common	crunchy enough to wake you	Vigil; baked with grit
Clay-bread	2 c	Common	warm for a day	Cradlewrack; tastes of iron
Second-milk	1 L	Scarce	Taint 1 Regrowth	Cradlewrack; from who knows what
Canyon flatbread	2 c	Common	eaten in silence	Oathen
Rain-water (Kept Rain, a flask)	5 L	Uncommon	blessed; pure	Oathen; once a year
Fast ration-bread	1 chit	Common in Wanting	no Taint; –1 Hunger if eaten cold, standing	grey, Rim-grown, joyless
“Safe” Rim food (a meal)	2 L	Uncommon	no Taint, or so they swear	Eye + Lore Hard (14) to be sure
Ale or small beer	2 c	Common		
Wine	1 L	Common		
Fen-gin	3 c	Common	Feast Routine (10) or –1 all rolls an hour	Sallowreach; the bottle never quite empties
Marrow-brandiy	3 L	Uncommon	Taint 1 Hunger; +1 Resolve for a scene	Fatlands; distilled from boiled bone
Trail rations (a week)	8 L	Common	safe, dull	Company-sealed tins

d20.

WHAT'S IN THE BARREL?

Chute barrels are stamped with their origin, and then stamped over, and then stamped over again. When a character opens one, roll a

D20	CONTENTS
1	Pork. Honestly pork. Everyone is suspicious.
2	Brined beef, the good stuff, with a brass Board tag. One joint has a healed fracture set by a surgeon.
3	Orchard-pig: fat, sweet, and with a bone pit at the centre of every chop.
4	Mutton that is still warm, two weeks out of Sated.
5	Drover-herd beef, Sal Trotter's brand. The shins are very long. The hooves are not hooves.
6	Salt tongue, eighty of them, in neat rows. Several are pierced for earrings. No, for bits.

D20	CONTENTS
7	Mixed offal and a wedding ring.
8	Bacon with a birthmark shaped like a hare. Someone in Low Tilth will know whose.
9	Sausage, a single coil, tattooed in blue: crossed anchors and a name.
10	Brawn in jelly. The jelly has a heartbeat for an hour after opening.
11	Corned beef stamped with Ivo Stockpot's notch. He would not eat this.
12	Fatlands field-meat: a joint with roots growing through the marrow. Taint 2 Hunger.
13	A whole ham with a face on the rind. Pleasant. Smiling. Eyes closed.
14	Good beef, and at the bottom a sealed letter: "If you are reading this, tell my sister Merrin I was Reaped at Low Tilth on the ninth of Carving."
15	Tripe that continues to digest whatever is put in with it.
16	Salt pork and forty teeth, sorted by size. Granny Cracknel will want them.
17	Empty but for brine, and the brine is cold and pulls gently west.
18	A Gut-lines cut: marbled, enormous, Taint 3 Hunger. Worth twenty times the barrel.
19	Meat that a Fast-born character cannot be persuaded to look away from.
20	Something alive, packed in salt, curled up, and very glad of the light.

▼ DRUGS AND MEDICINES

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	EFFECT	ADDICTION
Rouse (tab)	3 c	Common	no sleep for an hour; ignore the Vigil's pull; +1 Eye	Hard (14)
Crane's strong rouse	1 L	Uncommon	no sleep 4 hours; +1 Eye, −1 Hand (tremor)	Grim (18)
Slope rouse (brine-cut)	2 c	Common	as rouse, lasts longer; Taint 1 Regrowth (Dromm)	Grim (18)
Bottled brine tonic	3 L	Uncommon	heals 1d6 Flesh; Taint 2 Regrowth (Dromm)	Hard (14)
Poppy drops (laudanum)	1 L	Common	ignore Injury penalties for a scene; −2 Eye	Hard (14)
Quease's Number 212	5 L	Uncommon	removes one kind of pain, fully, for a day	Grim (18)
Purgation emetic	2 L	Uncommon	vomit for an hour; purges food Taint (see Taint)	none, but contraband in the Fatlands
Purgation bleeding-kit	4 L	Uncommon	lose 2 Flesh, lose 1 Hunger	none
Fen-vinegar	2 c	Common	+1 resisting Dread from rot and smell	
Lastgate cedar perfume	3 L	Common	masks a Kept for a day; marks you as wealthy	
Orchard sap	1 L	Uncommon	stops bleeding (ends Ripping)	Taint 1 Hunger; screams faintly
Caul-poultice	6 L	Scarce	reopened wounds close for a day	Cradlewrack; wounds there reopen
Mother Gall's pickle-brine	20 L	Scarce	a corpse is kept sound for a year	Sallowreach
Ash-water	1 c	Common	the Thin's fasting drink; −1 Hunger, −1 Flesh	treason in the Fatlands

ADDICTION

Each time a character uses an addictive drug, they roll Gut + Endure against its Addiction difficulty. On failure, they gain one point of **Need** for that drug. At 1 Need they want it; at 3 Need they are addicted. An addicted character who goes a day without a dose is at

−1 to all rolls, and −1 more for each day after, to −4; each day without also adds 1 Fray. Need falls by 1 for each full week without the drug, while suffering. A Lack on the Addiction roll adds 2 Need.

Rouse is special. In the Vigil, nearly everyone is addicted, and the dose rises. A character addicted to rouse must double the dose after each season of use to get the same effect. Dr. Aldous Crane knows

where the curve ends. It is eleven years off, and a character who takes a Dread 2 check. works the arithmetic for themselves (Grim 18, Eye + Reckoning)

▼ ANIMALS AND TRANSPORT

ITEM	COST	AVAIL.	STATS	NOTES
Mule	40 L	Common	carries 200 lb	will not walk into a Hush
Riding horse	150 L	Uncommon	Wayfaring +1 on roads	eats safe fodder or goes wrong
Draught ox	80 L	Common	pulls a cart	Fatlands oxen are larger than they should be
Kept horse	60 L	Common	never tires; never dies; cannot leave Sallowreach	Sallowreach; smells; rots slowly
Sal Trotter's "cattle"	30 L a head	Uncommon	as an ox, if no one watches	they walk on two legs at night; do not name them
Fatlands dray (eight oxen)	900 L	Scarce	carries one Gut-line noble	Obb Tullow's rooted through
Pier-trolley	1 c a mile	Common	Lowmark's 19-mile pier	runs on rails, pushed by bailers
Netwatch dog	50 L	Uncommon	Threat 2; smells the Called	barks at Tenanted
Vigil sedan (carried standing)	2 L an hour	Common	you cannot sit; bearers sing to stay awake	
Wagon	60 L	Common		Company tolls double
Company coach seat	5 c a mile	Common	Rim Road only; with guard	stops at every inn
Cradlewrack hill-goat	15 L	Common	sure-footed	some are born talking
Crumb-runner's handcart	10 L	Common	300 lb at night	spat on in Wanting

▼ LODGING ON THE RIM ROAD

LODGING	COST	AVAIL.	WHAT YOU GET	NOTES
Ditch or hedge	free	Common	nothing	Orrum's tables appear at crossroads lately
Common room floor	3 c	Common	a fire, a floor	in Vigil inns, standing straps
Company inn, shared room	1 L	Common	a bed, a lock, a guard	in the Vigil, a strap and a nudger
Company inn, private room	4 L	Common	a bed, a bath, a meal	
Brick-in room	1 L	Cradlewrack	mortared shut at dusk	broken out at dawn, if you are still in it
Anchor-inn	1 L	Brinehollow	a bed with chains	the keeper counts heads each dawn
Lastgate boarding house	2 L	Sallowreach	a room with three generations of Kept	they are quiet; they listen
Waking-house	2 L	Vigil	a sloped floor and a nudger	sleeping is a crime
Unfed bothy	none (decline thrice)	the Fast	four walls, no hearth	never if the hearth is lit

THE INN AT THE CROSSROADS

In the last three years Company inn-keepers on the Rim have reported finding tables laid in their common rooms at dawn: a white cloth, warm bread, a chair pulled out, a place card. The Company's standing instruction is to burn the table and not read the card. Not all inn-keepers obey. A few have started renting the chair.

▼ SERVICES

SERVICE	COST	AVAIL.	WHAT YOU GET	NOTES
A Closing	4,000 L or a license	Rare	a licensed death in Sallowreach	Lady Corrow Vane's waiting list is years
Unlicensed Closing	1,500 L	Rare	a Hand-line touch, off the books	capital crime; Osric Vane offers it free
Restitching	3 L a limb	Common	a Kept part reattached	Thessaly Mort's guild rates
Setting Aside	40 L	Common	wrapped, labelled, shelved, read to	Bettany Shroud reads nightly
Tucker minute	90 L	Uncommon	sixty seconds of sleep, guarded	Old Nod's price; a month's wage
Surety bond	1 L in 10 of the oath	Uncommon	someone else's body backs your word	Ona Fell has one default left
Clausewright drafting	5 L a page	Common	an oath that survives reality	a marriage runs forty pages
Price-witness	1 c a word	Common	haggle at +2 without swearing	Oathen and Rim east
Tablebreaker hire	a sack of grain a table	Uncommon	a table smashed before anyone sits	they refuse coin
Crumb-running	1 L per 10 lb	Uncommon	food carried into the Fast	Tarry Moss counts every bean
Netwatch retrieval	15 L	Common	a Called relative dragged home	alive, officially
Cutwright reading	50 L	Uncommon	your Cut, your line, your prospects	the full ledger costs 500 L and a favour
Midwife attendance	12 L	Common	a lawful birth	the Two Questions; the knife included
Reckoner contract	not sold	Scarce	a high-Cut line ended	Reckoners are informed, never paid
Blank-poacher bounty	300–2,000 L paid to you	Rare	the price of a Blank, alive	Kale Dragoman feeds them well
Mother Gall's barrel	500 L in advance	Scarce	a body pickled sound for a century	awake, all of it
Dream-Diver hire	200 L a dive	Scarce	someone goes to the long room for you	most manage three
Wake-valet	10–40 L a day	Uncommon	kept awake by artful pain	Tenterhook is an artist
Hob Gristle tasting	5 L	Uncommon	what a cut of meat used to be, by name	he apologises to it
Ferry over the north border	300 L	Scarce	your dying kept from death	Tam Ruddock never says what next
Echo-Warden silencing	30 L	Uncommon	an old oath hunted out of the rock	Halvar Stane
Oath release	a greater oath	Rare	free of a binding promise	Grandam Cess; you owe her worse
Lead pockets at the Weighing	200 L	Rare	+1 vote in the Fatlands	Garrick Tripe
A named candle	50 L	Uncommon	your dead rendered to light	Wick Tallow; it knows you

▼ RELICS AND GODFLESH

Every land believes another land's curse might cure its own. Nothing has ever worked.

The trade never slows.

– THE RIM ROAD, IN A SENTENCE

Relics are pieces of the Providers, or of people far enough into the Regrowth that the difference no longer matters. They are never Common. Most are illegal somewhere. All are Tainted. The prices given are what a dealer would ask, if a dealer could be found who was willing to sell.

A HAND-LINE FINGER

Cost: 1,200 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 2

A grey finger with nine joints, taken from a Hand-line noble in the Course, still cold. Touched to a lock, a lid or a door, it closes it, and nothing opens it again without breaking it. Touched to a candle, the candle finishes. Touched to a person outside

Sallowreach, it does nothing, and the wielder takes a Dread 2 check from the way it flexes. Capital crime in Sallowreach. The Mortuary Court counts its nobles' fingers.

A BOTTLED HUSH

Cost: 2,500 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** Dread 4

A stoppered jar of air from the edge of Dunmere Hush. Unstoppered, it makes a silence ten paces across for one minute: no sound carries, flames go out, flies drop. Any Kept inside it finishes, completely and properly. The Finishers will kill for one. The Court calls every jar a stolen license. The jar is always slightly too heavy.

A BITING LOAF

Cost: 20 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 1 Hunger, 1 Dread

Toothed-wheat bread baked with the teeth left in. Set on a windowsill or in a doorway, it bites anyone who enters uninvited (attack +4, damage 1, Ripping). Granny Cracknel bakes them for widows. After a week, the loaf has grown a second row.

A JAR OF TENANTED BRINE

Cost: 400 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 3 Regrowth (Dromm)

Water coughed at dawn by one of the Tenanted. Held to the ear, it can be heard talking, slowly, in a voice like a hull settling. A character who listens for an hour may ask one question about the sea, the Trench, or the Tenant, and is answered truthfully. They must then pass a Grim (18) Caul + Resolve roll or walk west the next night.

A LASH FROM THE EYE OF ISS

Cost: not for sale (offers start at 10,000 L) · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** 4 Regrowth (Iss)

A black hair a yard long, stiff as wire, one of the few that survived the Eye-lines' meal. Laid across a sleeper's lids in the Vigil, it lets them sleep and wake again, once, safely. The eye in the long room will have seen them. The Warden-Prime knows where every lash is, and there are three.

A CAUL-SCRAP VEIL

Cost: 600 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Vey)

A square of membrane cut from a Caul-line noble, stitched to a hat-brim. Through it the wearer sees a few heartbeats ahead, blurred: once per scene, reroll any one die. Each day it is worn, roll a d10; on a 1, the veil has grown into the skin of the brow. Duchess Morwen's veil has lately gone red. So have the scraps.

A SAYER'S WORD SEALED IN WAX

Cost: not for sale (20,000 L if it were) · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 3

A ball of gold wax the size of a walnut, sealed by the Bench of Clauses, containing a single word spoken by a Sayer into it before the bit went back in. Crack it, and the word is so. Known words in

private hands: *Stop, Shut, Mend, Mine*. Nobody knows the scope of any of them. One is rumoured to say *Enough*.

AN ORRUM CRUMB

Cost: 150 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** Dread 2; see text

A crumb of bread from one of the Host's tables, picked up off the cloth by a Tablebreaker before the axe fell. While carried, the holder's Hunger cannot rise above 5 and they never feel hungry. If it is ever eaten, the character is a guest, and must pass an Impossible (26) Caul + Resolve roll or sit at the next table they see, forever. It smells of fresh bread for six hundred years.

A PLACE CARD BEARING YOUR NAME

Cost: not for sale · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 3

A stiff cream card, a fine hand, your name spelled correctly. Nobody sells these; they are found. While a character keeps it, every host on the Table must offer them a seat (+4 Persuade for hospitality), and wherever they sleep, a table is laid by morning. Burning it does nothing. It is on the next table.

GRANNY CRACKNEL'S MATCHED TEETH

Cost: 80 L a set · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 1 Hunger, 2 Dread

A full set of teeth milled from toothed wheat, matched by Granny Cracknel to someone she knew. Held in the mouth for a night, they give the holder that person's last meal and last sight in a dream. Pell Hogget has bought eleven sets from Low Tilt. The last sight is always the same field at dusk.

ILSE MARL'S CHART

Cost: not for sale · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 3

Forty years of transcriptions of the Tenanted's low-water song, laid end to end: a chart of the Uncovered, with depths no sea has ever had there. A navigator using it crosses the Uncovered without rolling and can find the Trench and a stone table with eight chairs. Studying it for a week allows a character to hum the song; anyone Tenanted who hears them stops and turns.

A SHARD OF HALLOWBOARD

Cost: 3,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** Dread 2

A hand-sized fragment of the eight-sided stone table of the Refusal, always clean, always faintly warm. No table of Orrum's can be laid within a hundred paces of it. The Abstinent say Hollowboard has never been chipped; therefore this is a fake, or Hollowboard is lying. A Reckoner who sees it in Godeater hands will kill to return it.

A FIRST LACK

Cost: 1,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 1 Regrowth (one god, by grain)

A coin cut from a Provider's own bone in the first year after the Gorging, cured in no salt at all. Worn on a cord, it gives +1 to Godsign rolls involving its god. Spent, it gives the merchant who

takes it that god's Taste for a month. They circulate anyway; somebody always mistakes one for change.

OSSEL'S KNUCKLEBONES

Cost: 2,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Ossel), Dread 1

Five dice cut from a joint of the Closing Hand. Thrown for a question about when something will end, they answer truly. Thrown for a person, they show the number of years before their death; in Sallowreach they always roll blank.

DROMM'S EAR-STONE

Cost: 700 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Dromm)

A pale stone from the Fathom's inner ear, hauled up at Longslab. Its holder always knows which way the sea is and how far, and feels pressure days a full day early. In the last year it has begun to point down.

A DOWAGER CLOD

Cost: 250 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Hunger

A clod of warm earth from the Dowager Hills, cut from a Seated Gut-line matriarch. Planted, anything grows from it overnight, plump and red-veined. If the matriarch is consulted first, she may agree. If not, the crop has her opinions.

A THIEF'S KEPT HAND

Cost: 120 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 2

Taken by Marrow Jack from a Kept pickpocket who was asleep on a shelf. Worn in a glove harness, it gives +2 Filch. Its owner, still in Lastgate, can feel everything it does, and is trying to find you.

A DORMITORY PILLOW

Cost: 1,500 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 3 Regrowth (Iss)

Smuggled out from under one of the Counted. A Dream-Diver who sleeps on it goes down and returns without a tether, once per dive, for an hour. Owning it in the Vigil is a capital crime. It is still warm, and it still smells of someone.

BED ONE'S WORDS

Cost: not for sale · **Avail.:** Unique · **Taint:** Dread 4

Matron Cecily Dorm's notebook of what Aveline Morne's lips have shaped. Most of it is a baker's daughter's recipe for bread. The last page is a list of names, and they are being crossed off in an order the Matron cannot see the reason for. One is a player character's.

A LIVING PART IN A JAR

Cost: 200 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Vey), 1 Dread

A Cradlewrack Part, healthy and warm: an ear, a hand, a length of spine. It turns in the jar toward other Parts and toward the Assemblers' Barn, a compass to the figure. The Assemblers pay double. The Attendance seizes it and the buyer.

A YARD OF LIVING CORD

Cost: 300 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** 2 Regrowth (Vey)

Cut, with permission, from one of the Uncut. Tie it between two people and for a day they share damage: each hit is split between them, and so is every Dread check. The cord pulses. It wants to grow back to the one it came from.

A SAYER'S GOLD BIT

Cost: 5,000 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** none

Garl Tome's work, worn and then outgrown by a Sayer. Fitted to any mouth, it prevents speech from binding: Oathen's rule does not touch the wearer, nor does a Sayer's word they hear. The wearer cannot eat or speak clearly. The Bench wants all of them back.

AN ECHO-STONE OF SWORN GORGE

Cost: 50 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 3

A pebble from Sworn Gorge that has soaked up the echo. Held to the ear, it repeats the oath of 419 A.G., too faint to understand. Anyone who listens for a full minute is bound by it. Nobody knows what they have sworn. Halvar Stane buys them to grind into sand.

A PUDDLE OF OLD WET TOM'S

Cost: 40 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 1 Regrowth (Dromm)

A corked flask of water that followed Old Wet Tom down a corridor. Poured out, it makes a puddle much deeper than the floor. Things can be dropped into it and are gone. Something in it can be heard, very far down, asking for the cork back.

WREN HOLLOWELL'S HAIR

Cost: 900 L · **Avail.:** Rare · **Taint:** none

A lock of the Fasting Girl's hair, sold by someone who got close. A Blank relic: worn at the throat, it lets the wearer ignore Hunger Taint and gain no Hunger from the first Partake each day. Owning it is proof of having dealt with the Blank trade. The Thin kill for it, the Board pays for it, and the girl wants it back.

A DUNMERE BIRD

Cost: 60 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** Dread 1

A sparrow that fell at the edge of Dunmere Hush, perfectly dead and perfectly whole, uncorrupting. In Sallowreach it is the only finished thing most people have ever seen, and collectors keep them under glass. Kept who hold one weep without moisture.

THE SCARECROW'S STRAW

Cost: 30 L · **Avail.:** Scarce · **Taint:** 2 Hunger, 2 Dread

A handful of straw from the Scarecrow of Low Tilth, taken at night by a dare. Scattered in a field, it shows on the next dusk which person will be Reaped there. Held in a pocket, it tells the land where you are.

▼ MERCHANTS OF THE TABLE

Never buy from a merchant who says the grace first. He wants something.

— RIM ROAD ADVICE

These dealers can be dropped into any market scene. Each has a specialty: items in that line are one step more available from them, and they will buy such goods at three-quarters of the listed price instead of half.

MARDY HAUNCH, SAUSAGE-WIFE OF GRISTMOOT

MARDY HAUNCH Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (cleaver 3, Ripping) · Armor 1 (suet) · Dread 0

Stock: Fatlands meat, toothed bread, Chute barrels, marrow-brandy. She has the widest stall on the Rim and has never once stood up behind it. Everything she sells is settling. She buys tattooed casings at a premium and will not say who for; it is Hob Gristle, who is trying to give them back to their families.

ABELARD MYRRH, PERFUMER OF THE LOWER PILINGS

ABELARD MYRRH (KEPT) Threat 4 · Flesh 9 · Guard 9 · Attack +2 (awl 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

Stock: cedar, vinegar, smoke-oils, Kept gauze, Seamer's lacquer. His own nose rotted off in 340 A.G. and he blends entirely by memory, which is perfect. For 40 L he will make a scent from a dead person's clothes that convinces any Kept who smells it that they are home and loved. The Court has asked him to stop selling it to the Lofts. He has not.

NAN PICKERING, LIMB-BROKER

NAN PICKERING Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (shelving hook 3, Hooking) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 (her drying-racks)

Stock: Kept limbs, seamed parts, Thief's Kept Hands, Seamer's kits. She buys from Marrow Jack and sells to back-alley seamers in Lastgate's undercity. Every limb on her racks is labelled with its owner's name, because she is honest. Some of the owners come to visit. She charges them admission.

MAGS WEIR, SALVAGE QUEEN OF THE UNCOVERED

MAGS WEIR Threat 4 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (harpoon 4, Hooking) · Armor 1 (oilskin) · Dread 0

Stock: wreck goods, salvage-tins, Netwatch gear, Dromm's Ear-Stones, Tenanted brine. She sells from a beached hulk two miles out on dry seabed. Her newest salvage came from a wreck that sank before the Gorging: a crate of silverware in services of eight. She has sold seven settings. The eighth keeps coming back to the crate.

LUCAN SPILL, THE OILMAN

LUCAN SPILL Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (sword 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

Stock: lamp oil by the cask, mirror-lanterns, lamp-flasks. He is the supplier who doubled the price to the Vigil, and Garron Ashlock would kill him if killing him would not stop the oil. His new oil burns brighter and smells of low tide. It is rendered on the Uncovered from things with too many ribs, and the lamps that burn it have begun to drip seawater.

DOVEY PINCH, PIN-SELLER OF THE SLOPE

DOVEY PINCH Threat 3 · Flesh 9 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (Waker's needle 2, Waking) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: pins, pin-gloves, Waker's needles, rouse-tabs, hired nudgers by the hour. Seventy, sharp-eyed and pricked all over, she sells pain as a convenience. Her needles are recovered from dead Wakers, and each still remembers the last person it kept awake; if you stick yourself with one, you see their face.

TAMSIN KEYLESS, LOCK-PEDLAR

TAMSIN KEYLESS Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (hatchet 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: locks, bolts, bricks, mortar, knocker's rings, counterfeit Agnes Latch locks. Her copies hold for a night, sometimes two. She does not mention that they hold only from the outside, and that what she sells to frightened mothers in Kest is not a way to keep things out but a way to keep them in.

RUTH NINEFOLD, NAME-BROKER OF KEST

RUTH NINEFOLD Threat 5 · Flesh 10 · Guard 10 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: naming-rights, Tally extracts, Attendance birth-fees on credit, living Parts in jars. She owns the rights to name two hundred births. Several were taken to the Lying-In. One was bought from a clay-digger at the rim of the Dilation, and its year is up at the next pang.

SILAS AMEND, PAPER-BROKER OF TACIT

SILAS AMEND Threat 5 · Flesh 9 · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (quill-knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

Stock: sworn notes at a discount, Surety introductions, spyglasses, wax tablets. He speaks only in conditionals and watches issuers' bodies from the opposite cliff. He has quietly bought every

note ever sworn by a single senior Clausewright of the Bench, and intends to call them all on one morning.

NAY-SAYING HOBBS, THE DECLINING GROCER

HOBBS Threat 3 · Flesh 8 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (his shelves)

Stock: ration-bread, Unfed greys, frost-markers, Tablebreaker's wedges. Wanting's only shop, run by an Unfed elder who declines every sale three times as custom requires. Sometimes he declines a fourth. His shelves are fuller than the Pantry's, and he cannot say who restocks them overnight. He does not sell the bread that appears on the top shelf. He throws it into the wind.

FACTOR ORSOLYA TARE, MISTRESS OF THE CURE-HOUSE

ORSOLYA TARE Threat 5 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +3 (knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

Stock: platters at par, new-minted lacks by the barrel, clipped coin bought by weight, First Lacks under the counter. She runs the Company's mint at Saltbridge and smells of boiled bone. Last month a coin-cutter brought her a fresh-cured lack with letters in the grain, as though the bone had grown them. It was a name. She has had the batch held back, and the Renderers' Union keeps asking where it went.

MISTER CUTLERY

MISTER CUTLERY Threat 6 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (Clausewright's quill-knife 2, Silent) · Armor 1 · Dread 1

Stock: relics and godflesh of every land, laid out on velvet in a silverware case. A soft-voiced man in a silk mask with a silver fork embroidered on it, he travels the Rim in a black coach and sells to nobles. He will buy back anything he sold at triple its price, provided the seller names exactly where it came from. He is cataloguing the gods for the Second Table, one portion at a time.

▼ STRANGE ENCOUNTERS AT MARKET

Roll a d20 whenever the characters spend time in a Rim Road market, or when a shopping scene needs something under the clove.

D20	ENCOUNTER
1	A Fatlands child is selling teeth by the cupful, sorted by village. She knows which village each cup is.
2	A Kept auctioneer in Lastgate is selling himself by the limb, to settle a debt from 300 A.G. The bidding is brisk.
3	A coin a character spent an hour ago is back in their purse. It is greasy and smells of the fen.
4	A Vigil customer blinks mid-haggle and comes back from the long room three stalls away, holding a knife, with no idea why.
5	A Brinehollow stall-keeper stops to bail. The brine she coughs into the bucket is moving in a slow circle.
6	An Oathener, asked the price, says "Too much" without thinking. His purse splits open at his belt.
7	A drover herds Sal Trotter's cattle through the market. One of them, passing, says a character's name.
8	Someone has set a table at the market cross: white cloth, warm bread, a chair pulled out. Two Tablebreakers are running towards it.
9	A Cradlewrack pedlar's crate has given birth. Nobody knows to what. It is under the cart.
10	A Price-witness offers his services, then quietly declines to witness a character's purchase, and will not say why.
11	The Company's toll-men are weighing every lack in the market. Clipped coin is confiscated, and so are three thumbs.
12	A Netwatch patrol drags a Called man through the stalls on a hook. He thanks every merchant he passes, courteously, by name.
13	A Seamer's boy offers a character a finger "that matches yours exactly." It does. Down to the scar.
14	Wick Tallow's candles on a stall all lean toward one shopper. The chandler's man goes pale and closes the stall.
15	A Reckoner is buying nothing, watching a Gut-line merchant's stall. She has been there since dawn.
16	A Wreckwife sells her Tenanted husband's clothes. He is helping her fold them.
17	A Purgation preacher hands out emetics and begs the crowd to throw up the god. Some do, on the spot. The Bailiff's men arrive.
18	A Fast pilgrim, starving, offers everything she owns for a single Orrum crumb. Someone has one.
19	A Cutwright with calipers measures customers' skulls for free, and quietly writes certain names in a separate book.

CHAPTER 15

THINGS THAT EAT AND ARE EATEN

Everything on the Table is either sitting at it or lying on it. Learn which you are before the knives come out.

— TABLEBREAKER SAYING, WANTING

REPORT OF THE THIRD NIGHT WATCH, NETWATCH, LOWMARK PIER-SECTION FOURTEEN. Entered by Lt. Sable Reef, 9th of Carving, 641 A.G. For the Admiralty Clerk of Losses. Not for the Bench.

Weather: salt rain from the second bell, fog off the Uncovered from the third. Pressure rising. Two of my hookmen bled from the ears before midnight and were sent to bail.

At the fourth bell the count came up short in Ropewalk Row. Widow Carse called her neighbour's name through the wall three times and got no answer, and then, she says, got an answer from the wrong side, from the floor. We broke the door. Bed empty, anchor-rope sawn through from underneath. Not cut. Sawn, as if by something with a very small and patient mouth. The cellar was full to the fourth stair with water that had no business being there at that hour and smelled of a harbour I have not smelled since I was a girl. Weed on the stairs, still moving. I wrote the time.

We took the shore road at the run. Found the Called at the end of the old breakwater, which ends now in nine miles of dry seabed, and which she was walking down as if the water were still there to receive her. Woman of forty, nightdress, barefoot, feet cut to ribbons on the shell and not caring. Hookman Dabb put the boathook through the back of her collar as taught and she did not fall. She kept walking and dragged him. A woman of nine stone dragged a man of fourteen stone forty yards on his knees across the shingle. When I got the second rope on her she turned her head and looked at me, and I am obliged to record that her face was perfectly calm and she was weeping out of her nose. Brine. A good deal of it.

We netted her and sat on her. She bailed in the net, unasked, a bucket and a half, and some of what came up was alive and went scuttling under the planking. Dabb stamped on two. He says the third had a face. Dabb has been on the Watch four years and I do not think he is a man for faces, so I have written it down.

At the fifth bell, while we were roping her for the cart, the Uncovered sang. I have heard it before. Everyone on the Watch has, and none of us mention it at muster. It comes up out of the dark where the sea used to be, low, a sound like a hull grinding on a bar, and it has a tune if you let it. Hookman

Persey let it. He put his hook down very carefully, the way you put down something you mean to come back for, and he started walking west. We got the rope on him at the tideline and he fought us harder than the woman had. He was crying and saying he was sorry, he was so sorry, they had been waiting such a long time.

On the walk back we passed something standing upright in the mud about a furlong out. In the lamp it looked like a wreck's keel with the ribs still on. It was not a keel. It had more ribs than a keel and they were opening and closing. We did not stop. I note for the Clerk that it was nearer the pier at the sixth bell than at the fifth, and that the Watch's standing orders do not cover it, and request that they be made to.

Called recovered: two, one of them my own man. Called lost: none tonight. Injuries: Dabb, bitten on the ankle by something under the planks, wound weeping salt, he swears it is nothing. Persey sleeps roped in the guardhouse. When I looked in on him at dawn the bucket beside him was full to the brim and he had not coughed once.

I would like it entered that I am not asking what the Called are walking toward. I am asking how much longer we are meant to pretend we are the ones doing the pulling.

S. Reef, Lt.

The Table is not short of monsters. It is short of anything else. Every land ate a god, and every land is now host to the slow return of what it swallowed, and that return does not confine itself to the bloodlines of the nobility. It gets into the soil, the weather, the drowned, the sleeping, the unborn and the overheard. It makes things. Some of those things were people a week ago. Some were never people at all, and some are people still, and are the worst of the lot.

This chapter is the GM's larder. It gives rules for running adversaries in the terms of the Grace Roll, then walks the seven lands one by one, presenting the horrors native to each with full statistics and the long, unpleasant detail that makes them worth meeting. After the lands come the human adversaries, who outnumber the monsters and do more harm. Then come the Seated Gods, the endings of campaigns, and a frank discussion of why nobody at the table should expect to win against one. The chapter closes with random encounter tables for every land and for the Rim Road between them.

▼ RUNNING ADVERSARIES

THREAT AND THE QUICK LINE

Most adversaries do not need a full stat block. A Netwatch hookman, a field of toothed wheat or a mob of the Forsworn can be run from a single **quick line**, which gives everything needed at the table: **Threat, Flesh, Guard, Attack, Armor** and **Dread**. Threat is a flat bonus the adversary adds to every 2d10 roll that is not an attack: a Search to find a hidden player character, a Stealth to creep up on the camp, a Resolve against a Hush-walker's silence. Threat 1 is a frightened farmhand. Threat 3 is a trained professional. Threat 5 is the best in the land at their work. Threat 7 and above belongs to things that are no longer working at anything human.

Attack is the full bonus added to 2d10 against the target's Guard. Damage follows the core rules: the listed weapon damage, plus 2 for each Helping (every full 4 points the roll beats Guard), minus the target's Armor. Doubles on an adversary's roll produce a Grace or a Lack exactly as for player characters, and the GM should describe both with relish. A Netwatch hook that rolls a Grace has hooked a player character's collar and is dragging them. A Seated guest that rolls a Lack has knocked over the salt, and the whole table turns to look at who did it.

DREAD	DIFFICULTY	TYPICAL HORROR
0	none	An armed man, a thin dog, an honest threat
1	Routine 10	A Kept beggar, a toothed ear of wheat, a corpse
2	Hard 14	An Unstitched Kept, a Forsworn's opened ribs, a blink-murder
3	Grim 18	The Sump-thing rising, a Tenanted loved one, a table set for you
4	Dire 22	A Laden hill speaking, a crowning opening, a god's attention
5	Impossible 26	A Seating, the Host's face, any Seated god

Some horrors carry a **rising Dread**, written as "Dread 2/4". The first number applies on sight; the second applies when the thing does what it does (a Hush-walker's silence reaching the character, a Seeming turning to look at the one who imagined it). Others carry **Contagion**: anyone who sees a character Break in the creature's presence must make the Dread check again, and on failure takes on the same Derangement the Breaking character did. The Table's madness travels best in crowds.

GODSIGN-POWERED CREATURES

Anything with the god in it can **Partake**. Creatures with a Cut are listed with it, and with a Hunger track exactly like a player character's. Before any roll, the GM may Partake for the creature, adding one Tooth (a d6) or, for Cut 3+, two Teeth. Each Partake adds 1 Hunger, and every Tooth that shows a 1 adds 1 more. When a creature's Hunger reaches 10, it empties and the creature's

FULL STAT BLOCKS

Important adversaries, monsters with Gifts and anything with a name receive a full stat block. These use the same six attributes as player characters (Hand, Gut, Lung, Eye, Tongue, Caul) and the same skills. Humans rarely exceed 5 in an attribute. Monsters, the Laden, the Tenanted and the deep Regrowth may run to 6, 8 or 10, and a Seated fragment of a god ignores the scale entirely. Flesh, Guard and Attack are calculated by the core formulas where the creature is anything like a body; where it is not (a field, a tide, an echo), the block says so and gives what is needed instead.

DREAD RATINGS

Every adversary carries a **Dread** rating from 0 to 5. The first time in a scene that a character perceives the thing clearly, they make a Dread check: Caul + Resolve against the difficulty the rating sets. Failure adds Fray equal to the rating; success adds 1; a Grace adds nothing. Many entries specify what, exactly, triggers the check, since a Tenanted judge in a courtroom is Dread 0 until her lower voice finishes her sentence before her upper one does.

Regrowth rises by one. For a monster this is not bookkeeping. It is escalation: the Sump-thing pulls three more drowned bodies into itself and gains Flesh, the Laden hill's mouth opens wider, the Waker gone mad stops blinking. Each entry describes what a Regrowth rise does to that creature. Players learn quickly that a monster which gambles on its Teeth is a monster that gets worse, and that sometimes the best tactic is to make it Partake.

Godsign creatures also have **Sops**. A creature that performs its Sop removes 1d6 Hunger, exactly as a player character does, and the Sop is always something the players would rather it did not do: close a child's eyes, eat the farmhand, take one more of the Called. Interrupting a Sop in progress is often the only way to break a creature's momentum.

MONSTER SPECIAL ABILITIES

The following abilities recur through the chapter. They are written in the core rules' terms and can be lifted onto any creature the GM builds.

- ◇ **Unending.** The creature does not die from Ruin. At 0 Flesh it is Undone: it stops acting for 1d6 rounds, then recovers 1d6 Flesh and resumes, unless it has been dismembered, sunk, Closed, or moved out of Sallowreach. Every Kept thing has this ability within Sallowreach's borders.
- ◇ **Swarm.** The creature is many. Blades and Brawl attacks deal only 1 damage regardless of Helpings; fire, smoke, flood and area effects deal double. A swarm reduced below half Flesh disperses and re-forms elsewhere next scene.
- ◇ **Hooking / Grapple (X).** On a hit with one or more Helpings, the target is held. Escaping is a Gut + Athletics or Lung + Athletics roll against difficulty X. A held target cannot move and suffers -2 to all rolls.
- ◇ **Engulf.** Against a held target, the creature's next hit pulls the victim inside it. Engulfed characters take the creature's damage automatically each round, ignoring Armor, and make a Dread check each round they remain.
- ◇ **Fray Aura (N).** At the start of each round within the creature's reach, every character must pass a Caul + Resolve roll against difficulty N or take 1 Fray. This is in addition to the first sight Dread check.
- ◇ **Pull (N).** The creature calls. Characters with the relevant Cut must roll Caul + Resolve against difficulty N each round or spend their action moving toward it. Resisting is not free: every success adds 1 Hunger, because the god in the blood wants to go.
- ◇ **Rooted.** The creature cannot move, but cannot be pushed, knocked down or held. It usually has enormous Flesh and a reach measured in fields.
- ◇ **Tide (N).** The creature's influence rises and falls. On the GM's turn, roll a d10: on N or less it acts twice this round. Things in Brinehollow and the Vigil have this.
- ◇ **Binding.** The creature's words count. When it speaks a sentence about a character and that character fails a Tongue + Clause roll (difficulty set in the entry), the sentence becomes physically true. Found only in Oathen and in very bad places elsewhere.
- ◇ **Hosting.** The creature offers. Any character who accepts anything it offers (food, a seat, shelter, "Come in") must roll

Caul + Resolve against the listed difficulty or stay. Refusing three times grants +2 to the roll; thanking it imposes -4.

- ◇ **Armor (type).** Some armor is not leather. Waxed flesh, bone lattice, compressed water and layered fat all count. Where an armor ignores a damage type (fat ignores blunt, water ignores blades), the entry says.
- ◇ **Helping Effects.** Many creatures list what their Helpings do in place of or alongside extra damage. A Flyfront that scores two Helpings does not deal +4 damage. It gets into the mouth.
- ◇ **Grace and Lack Effects.** Some entries list special results when the creature's own roll comes up doubles, or when a character's roll against it does. A character who rolls a Lack against a Hush-walker hears, for one awful second, nothing at all.

PUTTING THINGS DOWN

Killing is not the same in every land. Outside Sallowreach, a creature at 0 Flesh suffers Ruin and further damage kills it, as for any character. Inside Sallowreach nothing dies, and the only ways to finish anything are a Hand-line's Closing touch, a Hush, or carrying the thing across the border, where it drops at once. Many creatures in this chapter have a **Weakness** or an **End** entry, which describes the one way the people of that land have found to stop them. Some of those Ends are worse than the monster. Some are not ends at all, only delays, and the entry will say so.

THE GM'S LARDER: PACING HORROR

Every creature in this chapter is built to be survivable at first sight. The Dread check, not the attack roll, is where most of them do their damage. Use that. Let the players see the Sump bubble in patterns for a full session before anything comes up.

The best monster fights on the Table end without a death and with a cost: a player character's Hunger maxed out to win a single roll, a companion who Broke and is now certain their sister has been replaced, a field that now knows their name. Track those costs and bring them back.

When a creature's Hunger fills and its Regrowth rises mid-fight, describe the change before you describe its next action. The moment of transformation is the scene.

Remember that every creature here began as a meal, a mourner, a farmer or a child. Somebody on the Table loved it. Somebody is still bringing it dinner. Put that person in the scene.

▼ SALLOWREACH: WHAT WILL NOT FINISH

Every monster in the north began as a person or a thing that tried to end and was refused. They are not malicious, mostly. They are in pain, and they have been in pain for a very long time, and pain that long becomes a kind of weather. Remember that within Sallowreach all of these have **Unending** unless noted.

THE SUMP-THING

Weighted sacks go into the Sump by the hundred each year: the Kept too far gone for stitching, the unclaimed, the inconvenient. The sacks rot. The weights do not. Over decades, in the black peat-water forty feet down, the bodies find each other. Rotting flesh that cannot finish rotting goes soft as dough, and soft things press together under the fen's weight until there is no telling where one grandfather ends and the next begins. A Sump-thing is what happens when a few hundred of them agree to come up.

It surfaces first as bubbles in patterns: rings, then spirals, then the shape of a hand spread flat under the water. Then the smell, which

is not the sweet Sallowreach rot but something older, sulphurous and vinegary, a pickle-jar opened after a century. Then the mound breaks the surface, a slick dark heap twenty feet across, hair and sackcloth and peat-tanned leather stretched over a lattice of knitted bone, and out of it, everywhere, faces. Pressed flat. Mouths working. Some still have the twine of their labels around their necks. The sound it makes is a choir of drowned people trying to say their names through a lungful of fen, which comes out as a long wet gargle with words in it.

It wants to be *finished*, and it has learned that it cannot be, so it has settled for company. It drags the living down. Victims are not eaten. They are added. A week later a new face surfaces in the mound, and it is still screaming, and it will scream for centuries. Families who lose someone to a Sump-thing sometimes row out to listen for them, and sometimes hear.

Tactics: it rises under boats and walkways, grapples with dozens of arms, and sinks. It is slow on land but can drag itself up a bank like a slug of wet meat. It does not flee. It has nowhere else to be.

SUMP-THING – THE MANY DROWNED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 9 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 0 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (the scraps of a hundred Hand-line servants) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Brawl 4, Endure 5, Stealth 4 (underwater only), Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 40 · Guard 12 · Armor 2 (peat-tanned hide; blades deal –1 more) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	Many Hands +7 (3, Grapple 18; it can attack three targets a round); Draw Down against a held target +7 (Engulf: 3 per round, drowning)
ABILITIES	Unending. Swarm-of-bodies: severed arms keep grabbing for 1d6 rounds. Fray Aura 14 when it surfaces. Each character Engulfed for 3 rounds is Added and lost; their face appears next scene.
REGROWTH	when Hunger fills, it pulls 1d6 bodies from the bottom and gains 10 Flesh. At the Course its hands go grey and long and its grip begins to Close what it holds (each held round, a held character must pass Caul + Resolve 18 or lose 1 point of an attribute permanently, as some part of them finishes).
SOP	Adding a living person. Removes 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 (when it surfaces); 4 (on recognizing a face in it)
END	It cannot be killed. It can be cut apart and its pieces carried out of Sallowreach on the Rim Road, which takes a caravan, or lured into a Hush, which takes a sacrifice. The Seamers have a standing bounty of 600 lacks per recovered face.

HUSH-WALKERS

Edda Thrush walked out of Dunmere Hush. She was the first. She is not the last. A Hush-walker is a person who entered a Hush and did not finish, or a Kept body from inside a Hush that was somehow refused even there and stood up. They come out of the silence

carrying it with them. A Hush-walker has no smell at all, which in Sallowreach is the most alarming thing about it: one notices a gap in the stink of the world, a person-shaped absence of rot, before one notices the person. Their skin is clean and pale and perfectly still, unrotted, every fly that lands on them dropping dead and unmoving. They walk slowly. Their feet make no noise on boards. Their mouths move.

Within ten paces of one, sound stops. Not quiet: stopped. A scream comes out as breath. A drawn blade makes no ring. A heartbeat cannot be heard in one's own ears, and this is what breaks people: the body insists the heart has stopped. In that silence something is listening, the way Edda Thrush insists something

listens through her. Victims who stay in the silence too long simply end. They sit down, close their eyes, and are properly, completely dead, with no rot afterward and no flies, and their families tend to envy them. Hush-walkers wander toward Hand-line estates. Nobody is sure if they are drawn there or sent.

HUSH-WALKER – THE SILENCE THAT GOT UP	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 0 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Hand-line, by contact) · Regrowth 10 (the Brink) · Hunger 0 (it does not hunger; it does not Partake)
SKILLS	Instinct 5, Search 4, Resolve 6
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	a slow, gentle touch +4 (Closes: target makes Caul + Resolve 18 or suffers Ruin at once and, outside of Sallowreach's protection, dies)
ABILITIES	The Silence (10 paces): no sound; Tongue rolls impossible; Partaking costs double Hunger as the god in the blood strains toward the stillness. Each round in the Silence, Caul + Resolve 14 or take 1 Fray and lose the next action to listening. NOT Unending: a Hush-walker reduced to 0 Flesh lies down and is finished, and the ground under it becomes a Hush a yard across.
DREAD	2 on sight / 4 on entering the Silence
END	Damage it enough. The problem is getting near enough to do it, and the hole it leaves behind. Pim Sorrel's touch makes them kneel.

THE FLYFRONT

Flies are Sallowreach's weather, and a Black Noon is its storm. A Flyfront is a mass of carrion-flies thick enough to put out lamps, rolling across the fen at walking pace with a sound like frying fat. It is not a creature in the ordinary sense, but it behaves as one: it hunts. Everything in Sallowreach rots and never finishes, so the flies never finish breeding, and the oldest fronts are centuries old, and have a direction. They come down on the living because the living are warm and wet and still have their soft parts. Within a minute a person is black with them, flies in the eyes, the ears, the nostrils, the throat, a thick crawling paste that has to be scraped off with a knife. The Kept caught in a front come out the other side with their faces gone to lace. The living come out choking up maggots for a week. Justice Ever Lathe's colony is said to have come from a front, which raises questions about what fronts want.

FLYFRONT Threat 3 · Flesh 30 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (crawl 1; every Helping instead adds 1 Fray as they get into the mouth) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · Swarm; lamps within it go out; Eye rolls –4; fire, smoke and vinegar deal double; a character with two Helpings scored against them is Choked and can do nothing but cough next round.

THE UNSTITCHED

The Seamers' Guild holds Sallowreach together with gut-thread, wire, lacquer and resin. When a Kept body's stitching fails all at once, from neglect or a lapsed fee or a Seamers' slowdown, what results is an Unstitched: a person who has come apart along every seam, held together only by habit and old tendon. They lurch. Their arms swing loose from shoulders that are only hooked on.

Their jaws hang. Their bellies, sewn shut a dozen times, open like purses with every step and have to be held closed with both hands, so their arms are never free, so they use their teeth. They smell of everything Sallowreach smells of, all at once, concentrated. Most Unstitched are not violent, only desperate: they come at the living begging for thread, for a needle, for someone to hold their face on while they get the wire through. Some, after enough decades of it, have stopped asking. Marrow Jack's victims are often Unstitched, and come looking for their parts.

UNSTITCHED KEPT Threat 1 · Flesh 12 · Guard 10 · Attack +4 (teeth and loose hands 2, Grapple 12) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · Unending; any Helping against it severs a limb, which keeps fighting on its own (Threat 0, Flesh 3, Attack +2, 1).

THE UNDONE CLOSER

The Hand-lines sell death by touch, and the touch grows. Osric Vane in his lead mittens is the famous case. An Undone Closer is the case nobody contained: a Hand-line noble deep in the Course whose mittens came off and who went out into the fen. The hands are the thing. Grey, cold, damp like the underside of a stone, the fingers lengthened to a span and a half and jointed nine and ten times, so that they fold and unfold like a spider settling. They move independently of the face above them, which is often weeping. Everything the hands touch finishes: a candle gutters and will not relight, a conversation stops mid-word and cannot be restarted, a person sighs and slumps and is done. The Closer cannot stop touching. It is the Want, gone total. Victims are found laid out tidily, eyes shut, hands folded, and the village around them strangely

silent, birdless, every door closed. Hunting one is the Mortuary Court's most secret duty, because every Undone Closer is a cousin.

THE UNDONE CLOSER – A HAND-LINE OUT OF ITS MITTENS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 6 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 2 · Tongue 2 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Brawl 4, Stealth 3, Instinct 4, Rites 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (fine ruined coat) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	Closing Touch +10 plus Teeth (on a hit, target makes Caul + Resolve 18 or suffers Ruin and is Finished, truly dead even in Sallowreach; each Helping raises the difficulty by 2)
ABILITIES	The hands may act separately: two Closing Touch attacks a round. Closing the World: once a scene it may touch a door, lamp or voice and end it. Wants: must close every open eye it sees, even a friend's, even its own child's.
REGROWTH	when Hunger fills it reaches the Brink and its touch spreads; the ground it stands on begins to Hush. At 12 it becomes a Hush, and a village goes silent.
SOP	Closing a living thing. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	2 / 3 when the face speaks and apologizes
END	It can be Closed by another Closer, which the Court prefers, or killed outside Sallowreach, which the Court cannot allow anyone to see. The hands, severed, live on in a box, and are worth a fortune.

THE TALLOW-SAINT

Wick Tallow renders the unclaimed into candles that feel themselves burn. A Tallow-Saint is a candle that did not want to be one. Sometimes, when a great many candles made from one family are burned together in one room, the tallow remembers itself, runs, and gathers on the floor into a figure of soft yellow wax five feet high, faceless, wicked through its crown and burning. It smells of mutton fat and singed hair. It drips as it walks, leaving a trail of puddles that harden into the shapes of footprints, then of hands. Its light is very

steady. People in the room with one find they can read by it perfectly, and that the words on the page have changed into the names of the dead. It wants to be put out, and nothing put out stays out in Sallowreach. So it hunts for darkness and for breath to snuff it, and it presses its burning crown into the mouths of the living.

TALLOW-SAINT Threat 2 · Flesh 16 · Guard 11 · Attack +5 (burning embrace 3, Grapple 14; held targets take 2 fire each round) · Armor 2 (wax; blunt weapons deal only 1) · Dread 2 · Unending until its wick is pinched out (Hand + Filch 18 while Grappled with it); water hardens it for 2 rounds; Dark Sallowreach rooms make it act twice.

▼ THE FATLANDS: THE CROP THAT STANDS UP

In the Fatlands the monsters are agricultural. Nothing there is anything but crop, and that includes what eats the crop. Fatlands horrors are warm, wet, slow, enormous and hungry, and the smell that precedes most of them is gravy.

THE LADEN HILL WITH A MOUTH

Many of the best fields in the south are somebody's great-grandmother. Most Seated Laden are quiet hills, warm to the touch, generous with barley. Some keep a mouth. Old Mother Rind is benign, more or less. Not all are. A hungry hill is a low green mound

a hundred paces across, its turf rising and falling with slow breath, and in its side, at about the height of a cart, a mouth: lips of soft red loam, a tongue the size of a ploughshare, and teeth that were once teeth and are now stones, old roots, and the skulls of what it has eaten, pushed out through the gums like new growth. Its breath is hot and smells of ripe silage and stomach. It speaks, in the voice of the woman it was, and it is polite, and it is very, very hungry. It wants to be fed by its family, as is right. When its family stops coming, it calls out to passersby by the names of grandchildren. The ground around it is soft for a long way. The roots under that ground move.

THE HUNGRY HILL – A GUT-LINE MATRIARCH, SEATED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 10 · Lung 0 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 12 (Seated) · Hunger 8 (it never drops below 5)
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Intimidate 3, Lore 4 (family scandal), Instinct 4, Feast 6
BODY	Flesh 60 · Guard 10 · Armor 3 (turf and loam; blades deal –1 more) · Threat 5
ATTACKS	Roots +6 (2, Grapple 18, reach: the whole hill and twenty paces beyond); the Mouth +8 against a held target (6, and the target is drawn in: Engulf, 4 per round)
ABILITIES	Rooted. Soft Ground: Lung rolls on or near the hill are Hard at best. Kindred Voice: it calls a character by a loved one's name (Caul + Resolve 14 or move one step toward it). Advice: it knows every secret of its bloodline and trades them for meals.
SOP	being fed a living person by kin. Removes 1d6 Hunger and the hill grows a new apple tree.
DREAD	3 / 4 when it speaks in a voice someone knows
END	Starve it, which takes a decade and turns its fields to fat-scum. Burn it, which takes a month and smells for a mile. Or salt it, which the Board considers murder of a voting member.

THE SCARECROW OF LOW TILTH

Nobody put it up. It stands in the far field with its back to the village, and each Carving it is a few furrows closer. Last year someone saw it turn around. Pell Hogget's tally does not attribute the Reaping in Low Tilt to the scarecrow, but he has noted that the missing were all last seen nearer its side of the field.

Up close it is a figure seven feet high, cross-armed on a stake that it does not need. Its coat is sacking. Its stuffing is not straw, though

straw sticks out of it. Its head is a sack, tied at the neck, and the sack is damp, and it is warm, and if pressed it gives like a full stomach. Under the hat, where the face is painted, the paint is very old, and very good, and the face is smiling. When it moves, it moves only while nobody in the field is looking at it, and then very fast, and the sound of that is a dry, rushing crackle like a scythe through tall wheat. The taken are not found. In the following spring, the stuffing in the scarecrow's arms has new fingernails in it.

THE SCARECROW OF LOW TILTH – NOBODY PUT IT UP	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 6 · Lung 6 · Eye 4 · Tongue 0 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line, of a whole village) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Stealth 6, Instinct 5, Brawl 4, Athletics 4
BODY	Flesh 26 · Guard 20 · Armor 2 (sacking and packed meat) · Threat 6
ATTACKS	Sacking Arms +9 (4, Grapple 20); the Gathering against a held target +9 (target is stuffed into its body; Engulf, 3 per round; after three rounds they are gone)
ABILITIES	Unwatched: it may move only when no character is looking at it; it then moves up to 60 paces in a heartbeat. Characters can keep it still by watching (each must spend an action and pass Eye + Search 14 each round, made harder by dusk). Never Moves While Seen. At dusk in Carving it acts twice each round.
SOP	Reaping a person at dusk. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 when it is found closer than it was / 4 when it is seen to have turned
END	Burn it on its stake by daylight with every eye in the village on it. What runs out of the ashes is fat, and it screams in many voices. Next Carving there is a scarecrow in the far field, and nobody put it up.

THE TOOTHED FIELD

Wheat with teeth in the ear has been a superior strain since 204 A.G., by ruling of the Board. A toothed field in its late Plenty is tall as a man, gold and red, and every ear is a small jaw of white milk-teeth set in a husk that clicks open and shut in the wind. On a still day it is quiet. On a windy one, a toothed field sounds like a crowd chewing. Harvesters wear leather to the shoulder. Anyone who falls in a toothed field in late Plenty is in serious trouble: the ears turn toward warmth like flowers to the sun, and every ear takes a nip, and there are millions of ears. Victims come out lacework, bleeding from a thousand pinpricks, and the wheat they fell in is the best of the crop that year, heavy and pink in the grain. Granny Cracknel says the teeth in a field that has fed well are adult teeth.

TOOTHED FIELD (PER ACRE) Threat 2 · Flesh 40 · Guard 8 · Attack +5 (nipping 1 to everyone inside; every Helping adds a Bleed of 1 per round until bound) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 / 2 when the ears turn · Swarm; Rooted; fire spreads through it at a run and it screams; Lung rolls inside are Hard.

TWO-LEGGED CATTLE

Sal Trotter walks herds to market that the buyers call cattle. They are heavy, docile, and pinkish-white, with broad flat faces and soft lowing voices. On the road, when nobody watches, they stand up. Upright they are the height of a tall man, bellies swinging, forelegs tucked like hands, and they walk easily and well. They do not talk. They hum, sometimes, a hymn with a tune most Fatlanders know from childhood. Some have scars where a brand would be, and the scars are in the shape of letters. Nobody in the Renderers' Union will say where the bloodstock comes from, but the Reaping takes people every Carving and the herds are larger every spring. Most cattle are harmless. A herd that has been mistreated, or that smells

its own kind in a slaughterhouse, becomes a stampede on two legs, and it knows how to open gates.

TWO-LEGGED CATTLE (HERD OF 20) Threat 2 · Flesh 30 · Guard 11 · Attack +6 (trampling 4 to all in its path) · Armor 1 · Dread 1 / 3 when they stand up and one of them says a name · Swarm; a single beast is Flesh 14, Attack +4 (3), harmless unless cornered.

ROOTKIN

Tansy Lard dug up a root with her mother's birthmark on it. She was not the first. Rootkin are what the Reaping leaves in the soil: swollen root vegetables the size of a sleeping child, pale and veined and warm, with features. Most are lumpen. Some are exact. Their eyes are closed. Pulled up, they flinch and leak a pinkish sap that smells of the person they resemble. Eaten, they are delicious and their eater dreams the dead person's memories for a week. Left in the ground, they grow. A Rootkin bed left unharvested through a full year sends up shoots with hands on them, and those hands pull down whatever leans too close. The Cullmasters harvest Rootkin by night and sell them to the Renderers' Union by weight.

ROOTKIN BED Threat 1 · Flesh 20 · Guard 9 · Attack +5 (grasping shoots 2, Grapple 14, then dragged underground at 1 per round) · Armor 1 (soil) · Dread 2 / 3 when a character recognizes a face · Rooted; harvesting one is a Hard Labor roll and a Dread check.

THE REAPING

The Reaping is not a monster. That is the Board's official position, and it is technically correct: no single thing takes the Fatlands' missing. The land does. On dusk in Carving, out in the far fields, the soil softens. The furrows deepen, slowly, so slowly a farmhand will not notice until her boots are below the surface. The rows of wheat lean in. The air thickens with the smell of fresh bread and fat. And then the ground opens, wetly, the way a mouth opens around a

spoon, and closes again, and the furrow is smooth, and the crop in that furrow will be very good next year.

Run the Reaping as a hazard with a clock. Each character in a far field at dusk in Carving rolls Lung + Wayfaring each round against a rising difficulty (Routine 10, then Hard, then Grim, then Dire). Failure means they are held to the ankle, then the knee, then the waist; a fourth failure and they are gone. Allies can pull them free with a Gut + Labor roll at the same difficulty. Partaking for the

Fatlands' Gut-line, ironically, helps: the ground recognizes kin and loosens its grip for a round, though it costs Hunger as always. A Cullmaster's assigned workers are marked with a strip of red cloth at the wrist. The ground knows the cloth. Remove it, and the difficulty drops by 4.

The Reaping has Dread 3 the first time it is seen to take someone, and Dread 4 when a character realizes the field is breathing in time with them.

▼ BRINEHOLLOW: WHAT THE SEA LEFT BEHIND

Brinehollow's horrors are patient, heavy and courteous. They press. Many have **Tide**, and all of them smell of a harbour at low water: weed, salt, rot and cold iron.

THE TENANTED

A Tenanted is not hostile. That is what makes it so hard. It walks out of the surf weeks after its Calling, heavier, calm, with the same face and the same memories, and someone else looking out. It

knows your name, your nickname, the way you take your tea. It is kinder than the person was. Its skin is cool and faintly grey, its hands are always damp, and its breath, if you are close enough, smells of deep water, a clean mineral cold. Its weight is wrong: floorboards creak under a slight Tenanted girl as if under a cart. When it is angered, which is rare, it does not raise its voice. It presses. The air in the room thickens, ears pop, windows bow, and a man who has crossed a Tenanted judge has been found with his ribs gently folded inward, as if the sea had leaned on him.

THE TENANTED – SOMEONE ELSE LOOKING OUT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 6 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Lung-line) · Regrowth 12 in part (the Tenant has the whole house) · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Clause 3, Persuade 3, Instinct 5, Search 3, Brawl 3, Endure 4
BODY	Flesh 18 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (compressed flesh; blunt weapons deal –1 more) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	a heavy hand +6 (3, Grapple 18); the Press +7 against everyone within 5 paces (2, ignoring Armor; ears bleed)
ABILITIES	Tide 3. Fathom Weight: cannot be knocked down, lifted or pushed. Two Voices: when it speaks in both, every listener rolls Caul + Resolve 14 or takes 1 Fray and believes what it says for a scene. Wants nothing it will admit. Treat it as a person first.
DREAD	0 at a distance / 3 when a loved one recognizes what is behind the eyes
END	Cut it and it bleeds seawater by the gallon, more than its body can hold. Drained dry it lies down, an empty skin. Somewhere in the Trench, it is said, the water it held goes on.

RIBWALKERS

On the Uncovered, among the leather weed-forests and the wrecks standing upright, there are things with too many ribs. Salvagers call them Ribwalkers. A Ribwalker is a cage of long curved bones, thirty or forty pairs, opening and closing like a slow bellows, mounted on legs that might once have been the ribs of something else. There is no head. There is meat inside the cage, a grey sack that pulses, and there is usually a salvager's boot or two. They move toward water, any water, at a creaking stalk, and they open their ribs wide over anything wet and alive and close them, and squeeze, and drink. The squeezed come out flat, dry as leather, with their bail-buckets still on their belts. Some salvagers swear the Ribwalkers are what the Admiralty's fallen sailors become. Hask Tarn will not say.

RIBWALKER Threat 3 · Flesh 22 · Guard 13 · Attack +7 (rib-cage closing 4, Grapple 18; held targets lose 2 Flesh per round as the water is

pressed out of them) · Armor 3 (bone lattice) · Dread 2 / 3 when it closes on someone · Tide 4; drawn to a character who has just bailed.

THE DOWAGER BELOW

Lady Ondine Vasht lives in the flooded cellars of the palace in Lowmark, and the cellars have had to be extended twice. She is far into the Course and has not been seen whole in years. What can be seen of her, through the black water by lamplight, is a vast grey shape folded into the vaults, skin like a drowned sail, hair that drifts across the floor of three cellars, and eyes the size of serving platters, dark and wide and wet, which open one at a time in different rooms. She is still a grandmother. She still has opinions about the prince's marriage. She speaks through the water: the surface of every cistern in the palace trembles with her words. She would like her grandson to come down. She has been asking for years. The servants who go down to feed her return with less of their breath every time, and some do not return.

LADY ONDINE VASHT – THE DOWAGER BELOW	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 9 · Lung 5 · Eye 5 · Tongue 5 · Caul 8
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Lung-line) · Regrowth 11 (the Brink) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Intimidate 5, Clause 4, Lore 5, Instinct 6, Brawl 4
BODY	Flesh 50 · Guard 19 (in water) or 10 (in air) · Armor 3 (the weight of water) · Threat 6
ATTACKS	drifting hair +8 (2, Grapple 20, reach any flooded room); the Embrace against a held target +9 (Engulf, 4 per round, drowning; lungs fill with water as if bailing in reverse)
ABILITIES	Tide 5. Pull 18 on Lung-line characters within the palace. Her Voice in the Water: any surface of water in Lowmark can carry her words. Pressure: her cellars count as Dire terrain; all rolls there –2.
REGROWTH	at 12 she Seats. The cellars break. The palace is full of sea, in a land that has none.
SOP	a Lung-line relative going under willingly. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 / 4 when an eye opens in the room
END	There is none the Admiralty will countenance. Draining the cellars has been attempted. The water comes back twice a day.

THE INDOOR TIDE

In every cellar in Brinehollow, water rises twice a day and drains away. An Indoor Tide is when it does not stop. It comes up the stairs at night, black and cold, bringing kelp and silt and small crabs and the smell of an open harbor. It rises through the kitchen, through the parlor, up the bedroom stairs to where the family sleeps anchored, and it does not care that the house is a mile from the shore. It has a current. It pulls toward the west wall. People found after an Indoor Tide are found tidily, laid face down on the west side of rooms, lungs full, hands reaching. Treat it as a hazard: each round the water rises a step, Lung + Athletics rolls to move against the current start at Hard and rise to Dire; anchored characters are safe until it reaches their mouths. Lung-line characters feel the Pull 14 every round. The Tide has Dread 2 as it rises and Dread 3 when someone sees a shape swimming through the drowned parlor that was not there when the water came in.

THE CALLED PROCESSION

The Deepening walks in willingly, in procession, with lanterns. Sometimes the Called do too, without the lanterns: twenty, forty, a hundred people in nightclothes walking west at night in perfect silence, eyes open, bleeding brine from the nose, singing very low the same tune the Uncovered sings. They are not hostile. They will not stop. Anyone who stands in their way is walked over. Anyone with a Lung-line Cut who watches them pass must roll against the Pull.

CALLED PROCESSION (40) Threat 2 · Flesh 40 · Guard 10 · Attack +5 (trampling, grasping 2, Grapple 14: the grabbed are carried along) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 on seeing someone known among them · Swarm; Pull 14 on Lung-lines; roping individuals out takes a Gut + Labor 14 roll each.

▼ THE VIGIL: WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU CLOSE YOUR EYES

The Vigil's horrors arrive in blinks. Many of them happen, or are seen, in the second between one waking moment and the next. All of them are worse for an exhausted character: a character who has not taken rouse in the last hour suffers -2 on Dread checks in this section.

THE BLINK-KILLER

Inspector Hale Grimmer has forty cases. The method is the same in each. A blink-killer is an ordinary citizen of the Vigil (a cook, a

nudger, a clerk) who blinks for two seconds, mid-sentence, standing at a market stall, and in those two seconds goes to the long room with the eye, and something there uses them. They come back holding a knife they did not pick up, standing behind a stranger, and the stranger is open from hip to collarbone in one perfectly straight line, and the blink-killer does not remember any of it. The cut is the same each time: the line a midwife or a butcher would use to open a body for inspection. Blink-killers are not monsters. They are anyone. That is the horror. The stat below is for the second in which they are something else.

THE BLINK-KILLER – TWO SECONDS UNDER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 5 · Eye 1 · Tongue 0 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Eye-line or common, it does not matter) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 5, Stealth 5, Instinct 4
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 20 (it moves with the ease of a sleepwalker) · Armor 0 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	the Line +10 (knife 2; on two or more Helpings the target suffers Ruin at once, opened)
ABILITIES	Blink: the killer acts only for one round, then wakes, a confused citizen again (Threat 1, Flesh 12, Guard 12). Anywhere: any NPC in the Vigil may become one; the GM may spend a Fray from a character who has Broken to make one appear. Waking it with pain during its round (any hit) ends the blink.
DREAD	2 on the murder / 3 when a character realizes they themselves have lost two seconds
END	Keep everyone awake. The Wakers' needles are the only defense the city has.

A SEEMING MADE SOLID

After enough waking, everyone hallucinates, and when a whole street sees the same thing, it is entered as news. When a whole street sees the same thing for long enough, it becomes true. A Seeming made solid is a hallucination that has been agreed on by too many exhausted minds: a horse with a man's face walking down the Slope, a staircase that goes on past the roof, a tall figure laying a table in the street. It has weight, smell and heat. It does what the people imagining it fear it will do. It is precisely as strong as their certainty and it smells like rouse, burnt and bitter, because it is made of their attention.

SEEMING MADE SOLID Threat 4 · Flesh equal to 2 × the number of witnesses · Guard 14 · Attack +7 (it does whatever it was imagined doing; damage 4) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 · it gains +1 to all rolls for every frightened witness; characters who succeed at Eye + Reckoning 18 can disbelieve it aloud, and each disbeliever strips 4 Flesh from it; if no one is looking at it, it stops existing until someone does.

SLEEPWALKING COUNTED

Sixty thousand beds, numbered, in rows, completely silent. The Counted breathe in time. In the last year, some have begun to get up. A sleepwalking Counted rises with its eyes closed, its lips moving, and walks in the direction the eye in the dream faces. It does not wake. It cannot be woken. It is warm, unaged since the night it lay down, nightclothes faded to cobweb, and wherever it walks people around it begin to yawn, then to nod, then to blink. Matron Dorm sends them back to their beds with an orderly on each arm. Odile Farthing's son, in bed 40,112, has grown to a man's size and is smiling. When he walks, he walks with his arms open.

SLEEPWALKING COUNTED Threat 3 · Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (embrace 2, Grapple 16; a held character must pass Caul + Resolve 14 each round or blink) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 when its lips form a character's name · Fray Aura 14 (as yawning); cannot be harmed by pain; returning it to its bed ends its walk.

THE WAKER GONE MAD

The Wakers’ job is to hurt people for their own good, and they are skilled after three centuries. A Waker gone mad has decided that nobody is safe, ever, unless they are in pain. He is usually an old Waker, on triple rouse, lidless or near it from long effort, his eyes gone red and cracked and leaking. He carries a rattle and a sheaf of

long steel needles. He has stopped distinguishing between a citizen who is nodding and a citizen who might nod later. He goes door to door at the third bell. He pins people’s eyelids open with fish-hooks. He drives needles under nails so that no one in the house can doze. In his cellar there are people he has been keeping awake for weeks, tied in standing frames, weeping and hallucinating, and he feeds them rouse by the spoon and sings to them.

THE WAKER GONE MAD – FOR YOUR OWN GOOD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Eye-line by-blood) · Regrowth 7 (the Course; lids nearly gone) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 4, Stitching 3, Intimidate 4, Search 4, Brawl 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 (boiled leather) · Threat 3
ATTACKS	waking needle +8 (2, plus target takes 1 Fray from the pain of it and cannot blink or sleep for a day); rattle-cudgel +7 (3)
ABILITIES	Never Sleeps, Never Blinks: immune to anything that relies on sleep, rest or surprise. Rouse-Fury: once a scene, gains an extra action and loses 2 Flesh. The Seeming: he sees the eye in every face; any character he catches dozing is attacked first.
DREAD	2 / 3 on finding the cellar
END	He will kill himself with rouse within a month. The question is how many people he keeps awake before his heart stops.

THE YAWN

On Yawn days, the Wakers double their patrols. The Yawn is not a creature; it is contagion. Lukas Marre once put down a market square. When a yawn is spreading through a crowd it moves like a

rumor, mouth to mouth, and every person who catches it must roll Caul + Resolve 14 or blink. In a crowd of the exhausted the first blink becomes ten, the ten become a hundred, and the hundred do not all come back. Treat a Yawn as a hazard with Dread 1 that becomes Dread 3 the moment a character sees someone fall and not rise. The Glass House exists because of it.

▼ CRADLEWRACK: WHAT COMES THROUGH

Nothing in Cradlewrack is born right, and it is all healthy. Cradlewrack horrors are new, wet and determined. Many are drawn toward each other, toward the Sill or toward the Dilation, and they are getting bigger.

WANDERING PARTS

A single living hand. A warm ear. A length of spine that crawls. The Parts are born healthy and drawn toward each other, and when they are not caught by the Attendance's knife or the Assemblers' sacks, they wander. They move in the night, at the speed of a crawling infant, through doors that drift open: a hand walking on its fingertips, a pair of lungs that inflate and deflate to roll themselves along, a jaw that pulls itself forward by its teeth. They are warm and blood-pink and smell of milk and iron. They seek each other, and when two fit, they join with a wet click and a seam that heals in an hour. A cluster that has found six or seven partners is called a Gathered, and it is the size of a dog and the shape of no animal, and it is hungry, and it wants the parts it is missing. It will take them from whoever has them.

PARTS (HANDFUL) Threat 1 · Flesh 3 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (clutch, bite 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 / 2 when a hand holds yours · they pass any door or lock.

GATHERED Threat 3 · Flesh 20 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (grasp and tear 3, Grapple 16; on a held target with two Helpings, it takes a part: the character suffers an Injury from the Mangling table and the Gathered gains 5 Flesh) · Armor 0 · Dread 3 · it grows each scene it is left alive.

THE REFUSED

The Attendance's knife is called the Second Opinion, and there is no appeal from it. Except sometimes, as Sabeth Thorne found, the knife hesitates. A Refused is a born-grown thing that was meant to be cut and was not, and that has lived since in hiding, and has grown up knowing what it was supposed to be. It may look like a tall woman with a seam across her throat, or a man of thirty born mid-stride with a second face asleep in his chest. It knows it was judged. It remembers the midwife's face. Refused are clever, careful, and very often kind, until they meet a midwife. Then they settle the account.

THE REFUSED – WHAT THE KNIFE SPARED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Caul-line or none at all; born of the god directly) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Blades 3, Brawl 4, Stealth 4, Deceive 3, Instinct 4, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 (birth-membrane, toughened) · Threat 4
ATTACKS	hands +7 (2); a midwife's knife it took +7 (3)
ABILITIES	Opened: no door, lock or bricked room holds against it. Reopen: on a hit with a Helping, an old wound of the target's reopens (take damage again equal to the last Injury they suffered). Bearing: once a scene it may give birth, in a single convulsion, to a Part or Gathered that joins the fight.
DREAD	2 / 3 when its second face opens its eyes
END	The knife. It can be killed as anything can. It is hard to find a midwife who wants to do it twice.

FENN'S GET

Josiah Fenn, a shepherd, labored for three days and delivered something that stood up, looked at him, and walked out of the door. He has followed its tracks for eight years, and they are getting larger. Fenn's Get is twelve feet tall now. It walks the high red hills

on legs too long, with a lamb's soft white face on a man's long skull, and its wool is matted with blood from the flocks it lies down among. It is not cruel. It is newborn and enormous, and it does not understand why things break when it holds them. It has a shepherd's crook it has made from a whole ash tree. It has been seen, at dusk, sitting at a distance from Fenn's camp, watching its father, and making the bleating sound that lambs make for their mother.

FENN'S GET – THE THING THAT WALKED OUT OF THE DOOR	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 9 · Lung 6 · Eye 3 · Tongue 1 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (born of Vey directly) · Regrowth 9 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Athletics 5, Brawl 5, Wayfaring 6, Instinct 6, Labor 5
BODY	Flesh 40 · Guard 21 · Armor 3 (blood-matted fleece and bone) · Threat 6
ATTACKS	ash-tree crook +9 (6, sweeps two targets); gather-in +9 (Grapple 22; held targets take 3 per round as it hugs them)
ABILITIES	Every Door: doors open as it nears, all within a mile. Grows: each Carving, +5 Flesh and +1 Gut. Father's Voice: if Josiah Fenn calls it, it must stop and roll Caul + Resolve 18 to continue acting.
SOP	lying down among living things until they stop. 1d6 Hunger.
DREAD	3 / 4 when it bleats
END	Fenn alone may be able to get close enough. He carries a knife. He is not sure whether he means to use it on the Get or himself.

CROWNING

The earth dilates, slowly, over weeks, into a perfect round opening, and people gather at the rim to see what comes up. A crowning is a hazard, a festival and a monster's birth in one. The rim is soft, red,

wet, warm as flesh; the hole is perfectly round and descends into darkness that pulses. The air above it is humid and smells of iron and birth-water. Every pang, the crowning widens a hand's breadth. Then, at the end, something comes up. Roll on the table below when it does, and run the crowd. The rim itself is Dread 2 on sight; the moment of emergence is Dread 4.

D6	WHAT IS BORN FROM THE CROWNING
1	Waters: a flood of warm salt fluid fills the valley to the rooftops in an hour.
2	A house: whole, furnished, with a family at table who believe they have always lived there.
3	A Gathered of three hundred Parts, hungry for the Assemblers' figure.
4	A hill, which stands up, which is a person. Use the Hungry Hill, Lung 3, and mobile.
5	A door in a frame, standing alone, ajar. It is identical to the Sill's.
6	Nothing. The hole closes. Three days later, every pregnant woman for ten miles goes into labor at once.

DOORBORN

A locked chest once gave birth. So did a well. Doorborn are the offspring of thresholds: thin grey things with jointed limbs like hinges, born from any door, gate or lid that has been shut too long. They come out at night into a sleeping house, unfolding from a cupboard or a bricked room, and they open things: windows,

cradles, mouths, eyes, wounds, chests. They do it with care, with long fingers like keys. Victims are found opened neatly along every seam a midwife knows, still alive, and very surprised. Agnes Latch's doors keep them in for up to nineteen days.

DOORBORN Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Attack +6 (opening fingers 3; with two Helpings, a held door, lock, or a character's oldest scar is opened, Bleed 1 per round) · Armor 1 · Dread 3 · passes any door; cannot cross a threshold that has been knocked on and answered from the far side.

▼ OATHEN: WHAT WAS SAID

In Oathen, the monsters are made of words and the people the words broke. Nearly every horror here can be avoided by saying nothing. The difficulty, as every Oathener knows, is that silence is also a kind of answer.

THE FORSWORN MOB

The Breakdowns are full of people whose bodies keep the record of their sins: legs folded backwards for a fled duty, hands off at the wrist for a short measure, ribs opened outward like a book for a broken marriage vow. Most of them are no danger to anyone. A Forsworn mob is what happens when a Clausewright's ruling goes against the Breakdowns once too often. They come up the canyon stairs in a mass of crutches and wheeled boards and open chests, slow, loud (the only loud thing in Tacit), shouting plain words because they have nothing left to break, and they drag down whoever made the promise they blame. They know where every

breakable promise is. They shout their victims' oaths back at them, verbatim, and wait to see what snaps.

FORSWORN MOB (30) Threat 3 · Flesh 36 · Guard 11 · Attack +6 (crutches, clubs, bare broken hands 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 · Swarm; once a scene the mob may shout a character's own past promise back at them (Tongue + Clause 18 or the character must act at once as if renewing it).

THE LIVING ECHO

An oath repeated is an oath renewed, and a canyon will repeat anything. Most echoes die. A living echo does not. It is a sworn phrase trapped in deep rock long enough to have learned to move. It travels down gorges after people, riding the stone, faint at first, a voice two bends behind; then nearer; then from the wall just beside one's ear, in the voice of whoever first swore it, often dead for centuries. Anyone who hears it whole is bound by it. Halvar Stane hunts them. The one in Sworn Gorge is the oldest, and he has made out two words.

A LIVING ECHO – THE WORDS IN THE ROCK	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 0 · Gut 0 · Lung 7 · Eye 4 · Tongue 7 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Tongue-line, of whoever spoke it) · Regrowth 9 · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stealth 6, Instinct 5, Clause 6
BODY	Flesh 20 (it has no body; damage is done by noise, see End) · Guard 18 · Armor special · Threat 6
ATTACKS	Repetition +11 against Tongue + Clause (Binding; a character who fails is sworn to the echo's oath, which the GM writes, and breaks as an Oathener breaks if they ever act against it)
ABILITIES	Rides Stone: it moves as fast as sound through rock; cannot cross open air or soft soil. Every Repeat: each round, it may Bind another listener. Characters who stop their ears entirely (wax, cloth, Hard Endure) are immune, and deaf.
DREAD	2 / 4 when it speaks in a character's own voice
END	Echo-Wardens kill echoes with silence: they collapse a gorge, pack its walls with felt, or shout a contradicting oath into it and take the break themselves. Blades and arrows do nothing. Loud counter-speech deals 1d6 damage per round to it and to the speaker.

A SAYER UNBITTED

Lady Imre Dath says one sentence a year. She has begun to write her own. A Sayer is a Tongue-line in the last stage, and what they say is. A Sayer unbitted, without the gold, is the most dangerous creature on the Table that is still, technically, a person. Their mouths are

usually a ruin from decades of the bit: lips scarred into a permanent shape, teeth filed or missing, tongue thick and pale. They speak slowly, savouring it, because they have not been allowed to speak in years. Each word lands like a hammer on an anvil, with a sound in the bones. Things they describe become so. They are usually frightened. Fear makes them say what they are afraid of.

A SAYER UNBITTED – WHAT IS SAID, IS

ATTRIBUTES	Hand 1 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 9 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 12 (Seated in speech) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Clause 6, Persuade 4, Lore 4, Resolve 4
BODY	Flesh 9 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 6
ATTACKS	none needed
ABILITIES	Saying: once per round, the Sayer speaks one sentence. If it is about the world, it is true from that moment. If it is about a character, that character may roll Tongue + Clause 22 (Dire) to wriggle out on a technicality the Sayer did not cover; otherwise it is true. A Sayer cannot unsay. Each Saying costs 1 Hunger; at 10 Hunger, the Sayer's next sentence happens to an entire valley.
WANTS	to speak, to finish sentences, to be heard.
DREAD	3 when the bit comes off / 5 on hearing it undo something that cannot be undone
END	Re-bit it. A bit fitted by Garl Tome holds. Getting close enough means speaking to it first, and it will answer.

THE OATH-MADE

A man once swore to his wife, “I promise you a son.” Ilan exists anyway. The Oath-Made are people created by promises: sons sworn into being, soldiers promised to a cause, a lover sworn to come back that came back. They are real, warm and often loving. They also exist only for as long as the promise is kept, and they know it, at some deep level, and when the promise begins to fail (the one who swore it dies, or wavers, or forgets) they begin to fade. Fading Oath-Made become frantic: they cling, they demand, they extract new promises at knifepoint from anyone near. A fading Oath-Made who gets a stranger to swear “I will look after you” lives on, bound to that stranger. Forever.

FADING OATH-MADE Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 (hard to see clearly) · Attack +5 (desperate grip 2, Grapple 16) · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 when a character realizes they cannot remember its face · Persuade 6 to extract a promise; if it succeeds, the character is bound to it as by an oath.

THE DEFAULTED SURETY

Ona Fell can survive one more default. A Surety carries other people's oaths in their body for a fee. A Surety who exceeds their limit breaks all at once, every carried oath snapping in a single afternoon: bones, joints, ribs, a heart, a tongue, two hundred breaks in a minute. Most die. A few are left standing, a twisted heap of folded and refolded limbs that should not be able to stand, crawling in a way that hurts to watch, and they have nothing more to lose. They hunt the original swearers whose debts they paid, every one, by name. They cannot be bound by oath any more. There is no room left in them.

DEFAULTED SURETY Threat 4 · Flesh 22 · Guard 13 · Attack +7 (grasping broken limbs 3, Grapple 18) · Armor 1 · Dread 3 · immune to Binding; knows the name of every oath it carried; a character whose oath it held suffers –4 to all rolls against it.

▼ THE FAST: THE HOST AND ITS TABLE

The Fast has no Regrowth. It has a whole god, unhoused, laying tables. Its horrors do not attack, mostly. They offer. Every entry in this section has **Hosting**, and every one is best survived by saying “No, thank you” three times.

ORRUM'S TABLES

They appear in empty houses, at crossroads, in the middle of a field at dusk: a table of old dark wood, cloth laid white, candles lit, places set, the food steaming. The smell arrives first, a mile off: baking bread, roast fat, apples in butter, everything one’s mother ever cooked on a feast day. It is warm around a table, gently warm, the warmth of a kitchen after a long walk. There is a chair pulled out. Lately there is a card at the place with a name on it, spelled correctly. Treat a table as a hazard with Hosting 18. Any character who smells a table rolls Caul + Resolve 14 or moves toward it. Any who sees their own place card rolls Dread 3. Any who sits rolls Caul + Resolve 22 to rise again; Lent Ashby is the only one known to have managed it. Tablebreakers smash tables with axes before anyone can sit: a table has Flesh 20, Guard 0 and Armor 2, and as it breaks it bleeds gravy and its candles cry out like children. A table smashed by a character with any godsign in them adds 2 Hunger, because the god inside wanted that food.

THE SEATED

The Seated remain at table for decades, eating from empty plates, smiling, alive long past any natural span. They are skeletal and

radiant. Their clothes have rotted to rags around them; their skin is paper over bone; their forks move. They are perfectly sane, and they want company. Brother Hallow Crust describes each course in detail, the soups, the roasts, the jellies trembling in their moulds, and people who listen too long pull out a chair. The Seated never attack. They invite. They are very good at it.

THE SEATED Threat 5 (Persuade) · Flesh 4 · Guard 6 · Attack none · Armor 0 · Dread 2 / 3 when one of them is someone known · Hosting 18: describing a course is a Persuade +11 roll against the listener’s Caul + Resolve; failure costs 1 Fray and three failures pull out a chair. Lifting one from its seat kills it, gently, still smiling.

WELCOME ARDENT, THE STEWARD

He walks a mile ahead of Orrum, laying the tables. He was the first of the Unfed to accept, six hundred years ago, and the only guest who was offered a position. He looks like a tall, thin, tired man of fifty in a waiter’s long apron, gravy-stained, with a cloth over his arm and very clean white gloves. His smile is genuine and exhausted. He smells of bread and old candles. He does not fight. He sets places, folds napkins, writes place cards in a beautiful hand, and asks politely whether you will be joining the Host this evening. He would like, very much, to be relieved. He has begun to look for a replacement.

WELCOME ARDENT – THE STEWARD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 5 · Eye 5 · Tongue 6 · Caul 7
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut none (he was never fed a god; he was hired by one) · no Hunger · no Regrowth
SKILLS	Persuade 6, Craft 5 (setting a table), Lore 6, Instinct 6, Wayfaring 6
BODY	Flesh 30 · Guard 21 · Armor 0 · Threat 7
ATTACKS	none. He does not fight. A character who attacks him finds their blow lands on a table that was not there a moment before.
ABILITIES	Hosting 22. The Card: he can write any character’s name on a place card; that character feels the Pull 18 toward the nearest table every night until the card is burned. Ahead of the Host: Orrum is always a mile behind him. Cannot Die While Employed. Wants: a successor. He will offer the position to the character who refuses him most gracefully.
DREAD	2 / 4 when he speaks a character’s mother’s name
END	None. His contract can be negotiated. Jessamy Quill has been asked to witness it. She has not yet said yes.

THE HOST

Orrum has no stats. Nobody living has seen it clearly and returned whole. The descriptions agree only that it is very tall, that it stoops

under doorways, and that it is warm. It does not attack. It hosts. Run the Host’s approach as a sequence of signs, each a scene or more apart. Each sign is a Dread check of rising difficulty, and at each sign the characters may still leave.

SIGN	WHAT THE CHARACTERS PERCEIVE	DREAD
1	Company: frost melting in a line across a field; the smell of bread with no source	1
2	Chimneys smoking in empty houses; a hearth already lit where they mean to shelter	2
3	A table, laid, with their names; Welcome Ardent bowing in the road	3
4	A tall shape stooping under the lintel of a house a field away, looking in	4
5	It is in the room. It is warm. It pulls out a chair.	5

At the fifth sign, any character who has accepted anything in the Fast must sit. Others must refuse three times aloud, each a Caul + Resolve roll at Dire 22. A character who refuses all three times and does not thank it is left alone, and the Host, very gently, sets their place anyway, for next time. Do not let the players kill it. There is nothing to kill. Spare Tolland has seen it stop and wait for him to catch up, and has come to think it is lonely, and that is the most dangerous thing anyone has ever said about it.

THE LIT HOUSE

Never enter a house where the hearth is already lit. A Lit House is the Host's ambush: a ruin that, at dusk, has its windows glowing, its door ajar, its fire crackling and a kettle on. Inside, everything is warm, clean and laid out, and the door does not open from within once a guest has crossed the threshold until they have eaten. The walls sweat butter. The floors creak with a sound like a stomach. The rooms rearrange themselves so every corridor leads back to the kitchen. Hosting 18 to resist eating each hour; Dread 2 on entering, 3 when a character finds the bones of earlier guests tidily stacked in the larder, clean and polished, every one with a napkin.

▼ HUMAN ADVERSARIES

Most blood spilled on the Table is spilled by people. The templates below each give a quick line for the rank and file and a full stat block for a veteran or leader. Adjust Cut to the land: a Netwatch sergeant is a Lung-line commoner, a Second Table diner is whatever the highest Cut of their country is. Remember that every human with a Cut can Partake, and that a desperate soldier will.

NETWATCH PATROL

The Admiralty's night patrol hunts the Called along the shore with nets, hooks and rope. They are not cruel. They are tired, salt-stained, and drag people home who are fighting to go. A patrol is six hookmen and a sergeant with a lantern on a pole.

NETWATCH HOOKMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (boathook 4, Hooking 14) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

NETWATCH SERGEANT – HOOK AND LANTERN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Lung-line commoner) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 3, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 3, Search 3, Resolve 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 3
ATTACKS	boathook +6 (4, Hooking 16); weighted net +6 (0, Grapple 16, two targets)
TACTICS	one hook in the collar, one rope on the ankle, nets over all. They know the Pull and rope each other at the waist before the Uncovered sings.

WAKERS

The Vigil's police carry rattles and long needles, and they have been hurting people for their own good for three hundred years. A Waker

patrol is four, sharp-eyed and twitching on rouse.

WAKER Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (needle 1 plus 1 Fray; rattle-club 3) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

WAKER CAPTAIN – THE NEEDLE OF THE WATCH	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Eye-line by-blood) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Blades 4, Stitching 2, Intimidate 4, Search 4, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 12 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	waking needle +8 (2, plus 1 Fray and target cannot blink for an hour); sword +8 (4)
TACTICS	Never Surprised; immune to sleep. Blinks under stress: on a Lack she loses a round and wakes having moved.

CULLMASTERS

The quiet office of the Board chooses who works the far fields at dusk. Its agents are clerks with ledgers, accompanied by Bailiffs who

carry the red wrist-cloth and tie it on.

CULL-BAILIFF Threat 2 · Flesh 14 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (cudgel 3, Grapple 14) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

CULLMASTER – AGRICULTURE BY LEDGER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Reckoning 4, Clause 3, Persuade 4, Deceive 3, Feast 4, Lore 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 11 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	knife +3 (2)
TACTICS	never fights; signs a warrant. A character he names in his ledger has the red cloth tied on them that dusk and the Reaping treats them as assigned. His Want: he must eat during any conversation.

RECKONER RAIDERS

Zealots out of the Fast who cross the Rim to end high-Cut bloodlines in their beds. They are thin, quick and very calm, and

have no god in them to Partake of.

RECKONER Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (long knife 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · Godless: Gifts that read, Pull or Bind the blood fail against them.

RECKONER-CAPTAIN – THE REFUSAL ON A BLADE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (Unfed) · no Hunger
SKILLS	Blades 4, Stealth 5, Athletics 3, Wayfaring 4, Resolve 4, Lore 2 (genealogies)
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 18 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	long knife +8 (3); crossbow +7 (4)
TACTICS	Godless. Strikes the highest Cut in the room first. Carries the Cutwrights' ledgers, stolen. Will not eat anything in an enemy house, ever.

PURGATION CELL

The cross-border movement that believes the gods can be thrown back up. A cell is five or six: fasters and bleeders, hollow-eyed and

scarred from the lancet, with a list of high-Cut families and a cart of lamp-oil.

PURGER Threat 2 · Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (cleaver 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · carries emetics and fire.

PURGATION BLEEDER – CELL-LEADER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (bled down for years, it is said, from 4) · Regrowth 2 · Hunger 1
SKILLS	Stitching 4, Blades 3, Persuade 4, Rites 3, Resolve 4
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	lancet +7 (2, Bleed 2 per round until bound); torch +6 (3, fire)
TACTICS	forced purging of captives (Gut + Endure 18 or Ruin); burning the beds of nobles; preaching to the crowd as they do it.

SECOND TABLE HUNT-CLUB

Nobles of the highest Cuts, in every capital, sharpening knives for a second meal. They practice, on people. A hunt is three or four

diners in fine dark clothing, masked, with huntsmen and a cart that carries silver, salt and a portable grill.

SECOND TABLE HUNTSMAN Threat 3 · Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (spear 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

SECOND TABLE DINER – IT WORKED ONCE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 5 (of their land) · Regrowth 8 (the Course) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Blades 4, Feast 5, Persuade 3, Lore 4, Godsign 4
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 17 · Armor 2 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	carving sword +8 plus two Teeth (4); their land's Course Gift
TACTICS	Partakes freely and smiles at the bitten-back. Prefers Blanks and god-fat prey. Cannibal in principle: eating a fallen foe's heart restores 1d6 Flesh and, they believe, a sliver of Cut.
DREAD	2 (to watch them eat)

BLANK-POACHERS

They hunt the Unfed and the Blanks for the trade in godless blood and organs. Kale Dragoman takes his catches alive and feeds them

well on the road. Poachers use nets, cudgels, sleeping draughts and patience.

POACHER Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 14 · Attack +5 (cudgel 3, nonlethal) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

POACHER-MASTER – FED WELL ON THE ROAD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Gut-line commoner) · Regrowth 4 · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Wayfaring 5, Stealth 4, Shooting 4, Filch 3, Haggle 4, Search 4
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	crossbow with drugged bolt +8 (2, Gut + Endure 14 or fall unconscious); cudgel +6 (3)
TACTICS	tracks by smell of the godless; offers food to captives, and an Unfed who accepts loses 2 from Resolve rolls for the rest of the journey from shame.

RIM ROAD COMPANY WARDENS

The Company's toll-guards and caravan escort. Neutral, rich, armored better than anyone, and sworn to their contracts in

Oathen, which means they literally cannot break them.

COMPANY WARDEN Threat 3 · Flesh 14 · Guard 15 · Attack +6 (spear 4; crossbow 4) · Armor 3 · Dread 0

WARDEN-CAPTAIN – SWORN IN OATHEN	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	varies by birth · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 4, Shooting 3, Haggle 3, Clause 3, Wayfaring 4, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 14 · Guard 17 · Armor 3 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	sword +8 (4); crossbow +7 (4)
TACTICS	Sworn: cannot retreat, take a bribe, or harm a toll-paying traveler, or their body breaks. Can be talked into anything their contract permits, and nothing else.

CLAUSEWRIGHT

Lawyer-priest of the Bench of Clauses. A Clousewright fights with conditions, and wins.

BENCH CLERK Threat 3 · Flesh 10 · Guard 11 · Attack +2 (stylus 1) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 · Clause 4.

CLAUSEWRIGHT – BARRING DEATH, ILLNESS OR WEATHER	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Clause 6, Persuade 4, Reckoning 3, Lore 4, Deceive 2
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 6
ATTACKS	none worth the name
TACTICS	Drafting: in a scene with time to talk, may extract a promise from a character through Tongue + Clause against their Tongue + Clause; a character who agrees is bound in Oathen. Escape Clause: once a scene, they may void a Binding against themselves on a technicality. Want: compelled to qualify every statement.

FORSWORN GANG

The Breakdowns' organized crews, broken and plainspoken. They specialize in the one crime Oathen fears most: making people

promise things.

FORSWORN TOUGH Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Attack +5 (club 3) · Armor 0 · Dread 1 (to see the break)

BREAKDOWN BOSS – NOTHING LEFT TO BREAK	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 4 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 3 · Hunger 2
SKILLS	Brawl 4, Intimidate 5, Persuade 3, Clause 3, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 15 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	brass-shod crutch +8 (3); knife +6 (2)
TACTICS	immune to Binding, already broken. Threatens a target until they promise; then makes sure they break.
DREAD	1

ASSEMBLER BRETHREN

They collect Parts and join them, believing them to be one body, born piecemeal. They travel in pairs with sacks that move, and their

gloves are always wet.

ASSEMBLER BROTHER Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (hook-knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 1 (the sack)

ASSEMBLER ELDER – MAKING GOOD PROGRESS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 5 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Caul-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Stitching 6, Lore 4, Rites 4, Search 3, Blades 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 1 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	bone saw +8 (3; on two Helpings the target loses a part, Mangling Injury)
TACTICS	Fitter: can attach a severed Part to any living body in a minute; it takes. Accompanied by a Gathered, Threat 3.
DREAD	2 when you see what is sewn to their back

FINISHER PILGRIMS

Sallowreach's death cult. They walk into the Hushes singing, and they will take others with them out of love.

FINISHER PILGRIM Threat 1 · Flesh 12 (Unending in Sallowreach) · Guard 10 · Attack +3 (grasp 1, Grapple 12) · Armor 0 · Dread 1

FINISHER SHEPHERD – SOMEONE MUST STAY OUTSIDE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 5
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Resolve 4, Instinct 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 12 · Armor 0 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	walking staff +4 (3)
TACTICS	the Hymn of Ending: once a scene, all listening Kept must roll Caul + Resolve 18 or walk toward the nearest Hush, and living characters take 1 Fray. Never enters the Hush herself.

TUCKERS

The Vigil's criminal mercy: sixty guarded seconds of sleep for a month's wage. Their failures are delivered to the Dormitory steps.

Their enforcers make sure payment does too.

TUCKER BRUISER Threat 2 · Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (sap 3, nonlethal) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

TUCKER BOSS – ONE MINUTE, GUARDED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 · Regrowth 4 · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Haggle 5, Deceive 4, Blades 3, Stitching 3, Search 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 1 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	needle-dagger +6 (2); thrown sleeping-draught +6 (a target must roll Caul + Resolve 18 or blink for a round, and a blink can be a long time)
TACTICS	knows every lidded noble in the city. Sells clients to the Dormitory if they cannot pay.

RENDERERS' THUGS

The Union controls what leaves the Fatlands and knows what is in it. Its slaughtermen are huge, aproned and bloody to the elbow, and

they settle disputes with the tools of the trade.

SLAUGHTERMAN Threat 2 · Flesh 16 · Guard 12 · Attack +6 (cleaver 3, hook 4 Hooking 14) · Armor 2 (fat; blunt –1) · Dread 0

RENDERER FOREMAN – ORIGIN STAMPED OVER TWICE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 5 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Blades 4, Labor 4, Intimidate 4, Feast 4, Endure 3
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 · Threat 4
ATTACKS	greatcleaver +8 (6); meat-hook +7 (4, Hooking 16)
TACTICS	disposes of the defeated in the vats; any witness who sees the vats makes a Dread 2 check. Eats during fights.

ECHO-WARDENS

Rangers who police Oathen's silent gorges and hunt sworn words still bouncing in the rock. They speak in handtalk, move without

sound, and carry felt, mallets and sacks of quicklime that crack the rock when they are wetted.

ECHO-RANGER Threat 4 · Flesh 12 · Guard 16 · Attack +6 (short spear 4; sling 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 · ears waxed, immune to Binding by sound.

SENIOR ECHO-WARDEN – WHO WILL NOT REPEAT IT	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 4 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Stealth 5, Wayfaring 5, Clause 4, Instinct 4, Shooting 3, Blades 3
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 19 · Armor 1 · Threat 5
ATTACKS	short spear +6 (4); sling +6 (2)
TACTICS	never speaks in a gorge. Contradiction: may shout a counter-oath to destroy an echo, taking the break in his own body. Silences intruders by collapsing rock on them.

▼ THE SEATED GODS

No land has reached a full Seating. Three are close. This section is for the night one of them gets there.

When a Regrowth completes, the god does not return whole. A god eaten by ten thousand mouths and scattered through six centuries of blood comes back as a **Seated fragment**: a portion of itself, wearing a person or a place as a body, and growing. It is enough. A fragment of a Provider is the largest thing that has

walked the Table since the Night of Seven Tables, and its arrival ends the campaign as it was. What follows is not a fight. The entries below give a fragment's **Seat** (what it wears), its **Reach** (how far it extends, and how fast it grows), its **Presence** (what happens to everyone in reach, each round or each day), its **Hands** (the creatures from this chapter that now act for it), and **What Can Be Done**. None has Flesh. Every one is Dread 5, and Fray Aura 22, and anyone of its land's Cut within its Reach feels the Pull 22 every round.

OSSEL SEATED – THE CLOSING HAND

SEAT	the Hand-lines, all at once; the Mortuary Court's chamber becomes a Hush with a figure in it whose hands are folded.
REACH	Dunmere Hush and every other Hush join; grows a mile a day across Sallowreach.
PRESENCE	everything in Reach finishes. The Kept lie down by the thousand, glad. The living who fail their Dread check stop, mid-breath, and are done. Sound ends. Then the fen begins to end, and the fog, and the land.
HANDS	Hush-walkers, Undone Closers, every Finisher.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	carry people out. Every Kept who can be got across the border before the Hush arrives drops dead at once, which is at least an ending they chose. Pim Sorrel may be able to ask it to wait.

UMMER SEATED – THE LADEN

SEAT	Chairman Obb Tullow, rooted through his cart, swelling until Sated is built on his shoulders.
REACH	every field in the Fatlands, and every barrel of their meat on the Rim Road.
PRESENCE	the Reaping all at once, by day and by night. The soil takes anyone standing on it who fails Lung + Wayfaring 22. Everyone who has eaten Fatlands meat in the last year, anywhere, feels Fatlands Hunger: +1 Hunger per day, and the Feast Want.
HANDS	Hungry Hills, the Scarecrow, Rootkin by the million, the two-legged cattle, all standing up.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	stop eating. The Thin have practiced. Wren Hollowell feels no hunger at all and may walk where no one else can.

DROMM SEATED – THE FATHOM

SEAT	the Tenanted, every one, standing up in courtrooms across the land and walking west; and the Dowager Below, who rises.
REACH	the Trench, then the Uncovered, then Lowmark's nineteen miles of pier. The sea comes back, all at once, from inside the people who were holding it.
PRESENCE	pressure. All rolls in Reach –4. Each round, every character with a Lung-line Cut must bail (Gut + Endure 18) or drown on dry land. The Called number in the tens of thousands.
HANDS	Ribwalkers, the Called Procession, the Indoor Tide in every house on the Table that has ever drunk Dry Jonah's tonic.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	get high and get inland. Dagna Hull's Follow may survive the water's return. Father Ebb says the chain is not what holds him.

ISS SEATED – THE LIDDED	
SEAT	Aveline Morne, the Sleeper in Bed One, sitting up. The eye in the long room opens.
REACH	the Dormitory, then the Vigil, then everyone on the Table who has ever slept, which is everyone.
PRESENCE	sleep. Every character must roll Caul + Resolve 22 every hour or blink, and a blink now lasts until the Seated fragment is satisfied. The Counted wake together, sixty thousand of them, breathing in time, and walk.
HANDS	the Counted, blink-killers in every street, Seemings made solid wherever the exhausted gather.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	stay awake for as long as it takes. Nobody knows how long that is. Sallowreach's Kept do not sleep. Castellan Dray's terrible proposal may become the only sane one on the Table.

VEY SEATED – THE OPENING	
SEAT	the land. Cradlewrack's highlands are delivered of something out of the Dilation, as the Sill's door swings open, and the Assemblers' figure stands up with a voice and a left hand.
REACH	every threshold on the Table. Every door opens.
PRESENCE	birth. Every character must roll Gut + Endure 18 each day or go into labor with something that is not a child. Wounds reopen at dawn. Locks, seals and graves fail; things begin.
HANDS	the Gathered, Doorborn, Fenn's Get (now the size of a hill), and whatever the crowning produced.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	the Barren Order's answer is to begin nothing. Ambrose, the Eldest Infant, says that when he reaches the cradle it will be time, and may know for what.

TOLM SEATED – THE WITNESS	
SEAT	a Sayer, unbitted at last, speaking without stopping; or the Ledger, four miles of carved vows, beginning to read itself aloud.
REACH	everywhere a word in Oathen has carried, which means every treaty and every Rim Road Company contract on the Table.
PRESENCE	every word binds. Every thought binds. Characters with any Tongue-line Cut cannot think a lie without breaking. Every contract sworn before Jessamy Quill comes due at once, with interest, in the body of each signatory.
HANDS	living echoes, every Forsworn, the Defaulted, and the Rain, which falls now only on those who have kept their word.
WHAT CAN BE DONE	say nothing. Cassian Wry can lie and stay whole; in a world that has become a promise, a liar is the only free man left.

Orrum has no Seated fragment. It was never eaten. It is whole, and it is coming. Some scholars of the Table have begun to ask why a god with all its strength would spend six centuries laying places, and for whom. The Hallowboard table has eight sides. One side, the Hostwatch reports, is always laid, and always empty.

WHY YOU CANNOT FIGHT A GOD

The players will want to. Tell them, in the fiction, why they cannot. The Providers did not fight when they were eaten; that is recorded everywhere and explained nowhere. Returning, they do not fight either. A Seated god is not hostile any more than weather is hostile. It is a condition of the world reasserting itself. Its Presence affects everyone in Reach without a roll to hit. It has no Flesh to reduce. Attacking a fragment's Seat (cutting down Obb Tullow, smashing Aveline Morne's bed) is possible and accomplishes exactly what killing a single fold of a flooding river would.

What player characters can do is choose how the world meets the god. Every campaign-ending threat above should be run as a set of choices, each with a terrible cost.

- ◇ **Refuse it.** The Fast's answer: accept nothing it offers, and endure. This works, partly, for the godless, and for those who can bear starvation. For everyone with a Cut, refusal means fighting the god in their own blood every round of their lives. Each refusal costs Hunger. Hunger fills.
- ◇ **Feed it.** Every god has a Sop. Feed the Sop on a national scale (the Cullmasters' answer, the Second Helping's, the Finishers') and the fragment quiets. It grows, too.
- ◇ **Bind it.** Go to Oathen and have it sworn. A god's word outlives the god; the Kept Rain proves it. A Seated fragment can be negotiated with, through a Sayer, in a Clausewright's language, before Jessamy Quill. It will keep its word. The question is what it asks in exchange.
- ◇ **Carry it out.** The rules of a land stop at its border. A Seat that can be moved (a person, a child, a hand) can be carried across the Rim Road. Then the god is somewhere new, and its rules come with it.
- ◇ **Eat it again.** The Second Table's answer. It worked once. It bought six hundred and forty-one years. The party that eats a

Seated fragment becomes the next Seat, and their children carry it, and the Long Grace begins again.

- ◇ **Hide.** The Providers held still once, and nobody knows why. Characters who ask that question loudly enough, in the right places, may find out what a god is afraid of. That is a matter for the Secrets chapter, and for the GM.

▼ RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

Roll when the characters travel, camp, or linger too long in one place. Each table is weighted toward the uncanny; a GM who wants a quieter road should reroll results above 7.

SALLOWREACH

D10	ENCOUNTER
1	A Kept family carrying great-grandfather to the Lofts, arguing about whose turn it is
2	Bubbles rise in the Sump in the shape of a hand; a Sump-Thing surfaces next scene
3	A Flyfront at Black Noon, rolling across the fen; lamps begin to go out
4	Two Unstitched Kept beg for thread at the roadside; one has stopped asking
5	Marrow Jack's men, bone saws in their coats, eyeing someone's sleeping companion
6	A Finisher procession singing toward the nearest Hush
7	A circle of dead birds; the silence beyond is a Hush-walker approaching
8	A Tallow-Saint stands in an empty chandlery, steady as a lamp
9	A Court Closer and four guards, hunting an Undone Closer; they ask questions
10	The Undone Closer itself, kneeling by a stranger, folding her hands

THE FATLANDS

D10	ENCOUNTER
1	A Bailiff with funnel and ladle enforcing the third meal of the day
2	A toothed field in the wind, chewing
3	Sal Trotter's herd on the road; one beast is standing up
4	Thin fugitives hiding in a ditch, begging the characters not to feed them
5	Cull-Bailiffs tying red cloth on a vagrant's wrist
6	A Rootkin bed in a fallow plot; one face is familiar
7	A hill calls a character by a grandparent's name
8	Renderers' slaughtermen and a cart with a lid that is knocking
9	Dusk in Carving; the furrows begin to deepen
10	The Scarecrow of Low Tilth, closer than it was this morning

BRINEHOLLOW

D10	ENCOUNTER
1	The morning count through the walls; one name gets no answer
2	A Netwatch patrol with a Called in the net, bailing
3	A Tenanted judge on circuit, perfectly fair, perfectly calm
4	Salvagers on the Uncovered trading in things with too many ribs

D10	ENCOUNTER
5	A Ribwalker stalking toward the camp's water barrels
6	A pressure day: ears bleed, windows bow, everyone rolls Endure
7	A Deepening procession with lanterns, walking west
8	The Uncovered sings; all Lung-lines roll against the Pull 14
9	The Indoor Tide comes up the inn's cellar stairs and keeps coming
10	A Called Procession of forty, including someone the characters know

THE VIGIL

D10	ENCOUNTER
1	A street nudger offering pinches by the minute
2	A Waker patrol checking eyes with lamps and needles
3	A mild, quiet, overcast afternoon; the death toll begins
4	A Yawn spreads through a crowded square
5	Tuckers selling a guarded minute in an alley; the last client did not come up
6	A blink-murder in the crowd; nobody saw it happen
7	The Seeming: a whole street sees the same tall figure laying a table
8	A Seeming made solid lumbers down the Slope
9	A sleepwalking Counted, arms open, walking east toward the eye
10	A Waker gone mad knocking at the door at the third bell

CRADLEWRACK

D10	ENCOUNTER
1	A midwife on the road with her Second Opinion, called to a hard birth
2	Every door at the inn is open in the morning, though all were barred
3	A pang; buildings sway; someone counts the interval aloud
4	A handful of Parts crawling north in the dark
5	Assembler brethren with a sack that moves
6	A Gathered looking for a left hand
7	A crowning at the edge of a village; the rim is widening
8	A Refused, kind and frightened, who asks if any of the party is a midwife
9	Doorborn unfolding from a bricked room
10	Giant tracks in the clay, then Josiah Fenn, then the Get

OATHEN

D10	ENCOUNTER
1	A child in a leather bit, staring at the characters' talkative mouths
2	A posted silent gorge; a character must cross without a word
3	A Surety offering to carry an oath for a fee
4	Clausewright and clerks drafting a merchant's three-hundred-condition apology
5	Forsworn toughs demanding a promise at knifepoint
6	Wind carries a stranger's words to the characters; are they bound?
7	An Oath-Made, fading, begging someone to swear to look after it
8	A living echo two bends behind, catching up
9	A Forsworn mob climbing the canyon stairs
10	A Defaulted Surety crawling, hunting a name the characters carry

THE FAST

D10	ENCOUNTER
1	Unfed villagers eating cold and standing; they will not share, and will not take
2	A Crumb-Runner's cart, spat on in the road
3	Frost melted in a line across a field: company
4	Blank-poachers stalking an Unfed family
5	Tablebreakers with axes, hunting
6	A chimney smoking over an empty house: a Lit House
7	One of Orrum's tables, steaming, with a place card
8	Brother Hallow Crust or another of the Seated, describing the soup
9	Welcome Ardent in the road, bowing, asking if they will be joining
10	A tall shape stooping under a lintel a field away

THE RIM ROAD

D20	ENCOUNTER
1	A Rim Road Company toll-post; wardens sworn not to accept bribes
2	A Company caravan of Fatlands barrels, origin stamped over twice
3	A Cutwright with a ledger, measuring the characters' Cut for a fee
4	Pilgrims from the Fatlands heading into the Fast to find the Host
5	Petra Quick's cart carrying pregnant women out of Cradlewrack
6	A dying traveler being smuggled north to Sallowreach so they will not die
7	Dry Jonah's bottled brine for sale as Vigil tonic
8	A Purgation cell burning a high-Cut coach
9	Reckoners waiting at an inn for a noble's arrival
10	A Second Table hunt, masked and carrying salt

D20	ENCOUNTER
11	Blank-poachers with a godless captive, well fed
12	A border marshal checking every traveler leaving Cradlewrack for signs of carrying
13	An inn where every patron says “Lack keep away,” except one
14	A Kept man who has just crossed the Sallowreach border and dropped, finished, at the line
15	A crossroads table, laid, steaming, outside the Fast
16	Envoy Prudence Lowell, reminding a crowd that they are damned
17	A Called man walking west on the Road, four hundred miles from any coast
18	A Vigil seemer reporting a tall figure looking in at inn windows
19	A wandering Forsworn, ribs open, with a message from Oathen’s Breakdowns
20	Welcome Ardent asks the way to the nearest inn; Orrum is a mile behind

THE LAST WORD ON MONSTERS

Every land on the Table believes another land’s curse might cure its own. Monsters travel along the same road the cures do. A Tenanted judge can turn up in Sated. A Hush-walker can stand at the border and watch the living cross. The Host has been seen at crossroads in three lands already.

Use this chapter as a menu, not a map. Everything here was once fed, and everything here is still hungry, and the Grace is ending.



PART FOUR

SETTING THE TABLE

*For the Carver alone: running horror, building campaigns, the secrets of
the world, and an adventure to begin with.*

CHAPTER 16

THE CARVER'S KNIFE

At a feast on the Table, the one who carves decides who eats first, who gets the best of it, and who is served the part that nobody wants. It is a position of honor. It is never a position of love.

— DAME SUET MARRABLE, TO A NEW CARVER AT THE UNENDING DINNER

FROM THE COMMONPLACE BOOK OF A RIM ROAD STORYTELLER, FOUND AT THIMBLE CROSS AFTER THE SNOWS.

They always ask me for the one about the god that smiled. I tell it the same way every time. I lower the lamp. I let the fire burn down until their faces are only the parts the coals can reach: noses, wet eyes, the shine on the lips. I wait until somebody coughs, and then I wait for them to be ashamed of having coughed.

The trick is not the monster. Anyone can describe a monster. The trick is to describe the kitchen first. The bread on the board, the knife beside it, the knot in the wood under the bread that looks like an eye. The child asleep in the corner with her thumb in her mouth. You make them love the

kitchen. Then, when the knife moves on its own, they do not scream because of the knife. They scream because of the bread, and the knot, and the child.

I have told that story four hundred times. Last winter, on Tablenight, I told it in this very room, and when I got to the end there was a place laid at the back table that nobody had laid, and a chair pulled out, and a card with my name on it.

I am writing this down because I have decided not to tell it again.

This chapter is for the Carver: the player who runs the game. It explains how to run horror on the Table, how to use the rules without letting them get in the way, how to build a campaign around the Regrowth, and how to make sure everyone at the table leaves wanting to come back, even though their characters will not.

▼ THE CARVER'S DUTIES

You have five jobs. Everything else is technique.

- ◇ **Describe the world** so the Guests can see, smell and taste it.
- ◇ **Play everyone else:** the Regent and the beggar, the god and the dog.
- ◇ **Apply the rules** fairly, and know when to put them away.

- ◇ **Keep the table safe**, with Lines, Veils and the Grace, and with your own attention.
- ◇ **Make the world move.** The Grace is ending. The gods are growing back whether the Guests act or not. Show them the clock.

▼ RUNNING HORROR ON THE TABLE

MAKE THEM LOVE THE KITCHEN

Horror is the violation of something cared for. If the Guests do not care about anything, nothing can be violated. Spend the first half of every story making them care: a warm inn, a Kept grandmother who tells filthy jokes through her stitched jaw, a Fatlands cook who sings while she skims the drip from the stockpot, a Netwatch sergeant who calls his patrol “my ducks”. Let the Guests eat, rest, joke and plan. Let Who Waits at Home write them letters. Then take it away.

ALL FIVE SENSES, AND THEN ONE MORE

The Table is a world of bodies. Describe it through the body. For every horror you run, ask:

- ◇ **What does it smell like?** The sweet wrongness of the Breath in Sallowreach; the rendering-yard stink of the Belch; salt and kelp and the cold-mineral smell of a drowned man’s lungs; lamp-smoke and sour rouse-sweat in the Vigil; iron, wet clay and birth-water in Cradlewrack; the hot stone and dry silence of Oathen; and, in the Fast, bread, always fresh bread, from nowhere.
- ◇ **What does it sound like?** Flies in fronts. Teeth in the wheat. Bailing coughs at dawn. Bells every quarter hour. The pang, felt through the floor. The crack of a body breaking to match a broken word.
- ◇ **What does it feel like?** Warm ground that rises and falls. Cold grey fingers with one joint too many. A floor that slopes so you cannot rest.

- ◇ **What does it taste like?** Everything on the Table is food, or was. Make them taste it.
- ◇ **What does it look like?** Last. Sight is the least frightening sense, because it is the one we trust.
- ◇ **And the sixth sense, the god:** what does the Guest's own blood do, in the presence of this? Does their Hunger stir? Does their Tooth itch? Does the thing in front of them seem, horribly, like family?

Gore with a Purpose

This book is graphic, and your table may want it graphic. That is allowed and it can be powerful. The rule is: **gore should always carry meaning.** A body opened on the Table is never just a body. It tells the Guests what the god wants, what the land costs, what was done and by whom. A Mangling is a story in a wound. When you describe the bowel sliding free of a Netwatch officer's belly, make sure the Guests also see the wedding knot tied into his anchoring rope.

When the table's appetite is satisfied, cut away. Restraint is a tool too. The door closing on the Cullmaster's dusk shift, and the sound of the wheat moving in a field where there is no wind, can be worse than anything you say.

Tragedy, Not Spectacle

Some of this book's horrors are deliberately human: suicide, contagious despair, kin-slaying, the murder of the helpless. Run them as tragedy. That means:

- ◇ The camera stays on the people left behind: the cut rope on the bed, the extra place at the table, the note in a careful hand, the neighbors who stop calling names through the wall.
- ◇ Nobody is a punchline, and nobody's death is a reward.
- ◇ The god benefits. Every loss is a little more of it in the world. That is the horror, more than the act.

- ◇ You never describe *how*. You describe *after*.

The Clock is Always Running

The Grace is ending. Use clocks: the Cradlewrack interval shortening, the Vigil's empty beds, the Pantry's four months of grain, the Brinehollow waterline, the Sallowreach Hushes spreading toward the Hand-line estates. Write each one on a card where the Guests can see it. Advance them between sessions whether the Guests act or not. Horror is helplessness, and the slow tick of a number going down is helplessness made visible.

No Rescue, But Many Mercies

The Table cannot be saved. That is the premise. But individual people can be: for a night, a season, a life. A Guest who cannot stop the Reaping can still get one family across the border before the dusk shift. A Guest who cannot cure the Vigil can still sit up with a dying nudger through her last hour. Those small mercies are the only victories the Long Grace offers, and they should feel enormous. Do not take them away cheaply. Take them away expensively, much later, when the Guests have forgotten to guard them.

USING THE RULES

WHEN TO CALL FOR DREAD

Call for a Dread check the first time the Guests encounter a horror, and whenever something they love is harmed. Do not call for Dread so often that Fray becomes accounting. If a Guest is a Seamer, corpses do not frighten her; what frightens her is a corpse that thanks her. Calibrate to the character.

PACING HUNGER

The Tooth is the most important choice a player makes. Make it tempting: put the Guests in positions where +3.5 is the difference between saving someone and failing them. Make it visible: describe the god coming forward every time they Partake. Make it count: when Hunger fills and Regrowth rises, stop the game for a moment and describe the change together. A Guest who reaches the Course should feel the weight of it. In a typical campaign of twenty sessions, a Guest who Partakes freely will reach the Course; one who Partakes recklessly will reach the Brink.

WHEN THE SEATING COMES

Treat a Guest's Seating as the finale of their story, not as a failure. Talk with the player beforehand. Give them a last scene: a last

speech, a last kindness, a last act of terrible power. Then let the god have them. Bring them back later as part of the world, and let the other Guests visit what is left. The Dowager Hills are full of grandmothers who were once someone's companions on the road.

FUDGING AND FAIRNESS

Roll in the open whenever you can. The Table is a cruel place, and the dice are the most honest thing in it. If a Guest dies to a bad roll in a meaningless fight, that is a sign you should not have run a meaningless fight. Make fights matter, warn players when they are walking into death, and let the dice fall.

SAYING YES TO THE GOD

Players will look for loopholes: Kept characters who use their undying bodies as shields; Oathen Guests who swear things into existence; Brinehollowers who try to bargain with their Tenants. Let them. The gods are not interested in rules-lawyering, but they are very interested in being invited in. Every loophole a Guest finds is a door the god can walk through. Say yes, and then show them who else came through it.

▼ BUILDING A CAMPAIGN

CHOOSE A CENTER

Campaigns on the Table work best when they are anchored to one place and one thread, at least to start. Choose:

- ◇ **A land.** Begin in one land, and let the Guests learn its rules intimately before they travel.
- ◇ **A thread.** Pick one of the *Threads Between the Lands*: the Deadwatch, the Host on the Road, Brine in the Rouse, the Missing Hand, the Sayer's Sentence, Eight Chairs. It will pull the Guests across borders when they are ready.
- ◇ **A clock.** The land's own crisis, ticking.

- ◇ **A patron.** Someone who pays the Guests or protects them, and who will betray them.

CAMPAIGN FRAMES

The Caravan. The Guests are the crew of a Rim Road Company caravan: Factors, Wardens, a cook, a Seamer, a Cutwright on assignment. Each story is a waystation, a cargo, a border. The Company's contracts are sworn in Oathen and cannot be broken; it is only a matter of time until one of them requires something unthinkable.

The Survey. The Guests work for the Cutwrights' College, mapping where each god is regrowing fastest. They travel the lands,

read bloodlines, and slowly discover that their own ledgers are being used by the Second Table to plan a menu.

The Purge. The Guests are a Purgation cell. At first they fast and bleed and pray. Then they are asked to burn a house with a family inside it. What do they believe, and how far will it take them?

The Watch. The Guests are Nightwardens in one city: the Netwatch of Lowmark, the Wakers of the Vigil, the Loft-Wardens of Lastgate. Each story is a case. The cases get worse. The city’s secret, which the Guests are paid to protect, is the worst of all.

The Household. The Guests serve or belong to a single noble family in the last stages of the Regrowth: a Hand-line house where

the hands have started to grow; a Gut-line estate where the matriarch is putting down roots; a Caul-line household where the heir has been carried for forty years. Domestic, claustrophobic, unbearable.

The Pilgrimage. The Guests are travelers bound for the Fast, for reasons of their own: to find the Host, to find a cure, to find someone who was invited and never came home. The Rim Road is the journey. Hallowboard is the end.

ESCALATION

A campaign on the Table should move through four movements, like the Regrowth itself:

MOVEMENT	SESSIONS	WHAT HAPPENS
The Taste	1–4	The Guests learn one land. Small horrors. Personal stakes. The god in their blood barely stirs.
The Appetite	5–10	A thread pulls them across a border. They discover the scale of the Regrowth. They begin to Partake to survive.
The Course	11–18	The powers of the Table notice them. A Guest is changed beyond hiding. Someone they love is lost. A land’s crisis breaks.
The Seating	19+	The end of the Grace in one land, or all of them. The Secrets of the Table come into play. Somebody sits down.

MAKING THE GUESTS MATTER

The Guests cannot save the world. They can decide who sits at the table when it ends. Let their choices shape the shape of the

catastrophe: whether the Vigil buys the secret of Keeping, whether the Assemblers’ figure gets its hand, whether Lady Imre Dath is unbitted and what she is told to say. A campaign on the Table is a story about which awful thing happens, and who is to blame for it.

▼THE CARVER'S TOOLS

READ-ALoud TEXT

Read-aloud passages in this book are set in the same style as in-world documents. Read them slowly. Pause before the last line. Then stop, and let the silence do the work. Do not explain. The Guests will ask.

HANDOUTS

The Table is a world of documents: death licenses, Cutwright ledgers, contracts forty pages long, place cards, the Tally, the Long Count, a seemer’s report. Give your players paper. A handwritten place card with a Guest’s name on it, set at their seat before the session starts, will do more than any monster.

NAMES

Every land has its naming customs, listed in its chapter. When you need a name in a hurry: Sallowreach names are soft, mournful and old (Bettany, Osríc, Henna, Tam); Fatlands names are hearty and edible (Suet, Brisket, Tansy, Hob); Brinchollow names are wet and coastal (Kessa, Sennet, Hask, Tolly); Vigil names ring like bells (Ilvane, Maud, Pip, Rook); Cradlewrack names are rustic and beginning (Orla, Lark, Juniper, Hinge); Oathen names are clipped and few-syllabled (Ket, Brakk, Rue, Ona); the Unfed name their children for the Refusal (Forbear, Abstain, Decline, Stint, Tarry, Nay, Want, Spare).

TWENTY THINGS THE CARVER CAN DO WHEN NOTHING IS HAPPENING

D20	THE TABLE MOVES
1	A Kept relative arrives with a message and a missing hand.
2	Someone the Guests met last session is found Reaped, Called, Seated, or Broken.
3	A place card with a Guest’s name on it, at a table that was not there an hour ago.

D20	THE TABLE MOVES
4	A pang, felt from three lands away.
5	The Guests' patron asks for something small and wrong.
6	A Cutwright arrives to read a Guest's bloodline, by order.
7	A Reckoner has a list. One of the Guests is on it, or someone they love is.
8	Bread smells in a house where nobody bakes.
9	The Rim Road is closed by the Company: no reason given, Wardens on the bridges.
10	The Seeming of the Vigil shows something the Guests did.
11	A Forsworn begs a Guest to carry an oath for a single night.
12	The Purgation burns a house nearby; there are children's shoes outside.
13	A barrel bursts on the road, and the meat inside has a tattoo the Guests recognise.
14	The sea has dropped another mile; the salvage rush begins.
15	Someone yawns, and the yawn moves around the room like a hand.
16	A door that has been bricked up is found open.
17	A Blank is being auctioned in the market square.
18	A Guest's Tooth bites in their sleep; gain 1 Hunger and a dream of the god.
19	A Second Table invitation, on heavy paper, addressed to the highest Cut among them.
20	A tall figure is seen far off, stooping, laying a table in an empty field.

▼ SAFETY, AGAIN

You have read the content warning. You have discussed Lines and Veils. You have explained the Grace. Now do one more thing: watch the people at your table, not just their characters. If someone has gone quiet, check in at the break. If someone laughs too hard at the wrong moment, it may be how they are coping. If a scene you

planned starts to land on something real in someone's life, stop it, and do not make them explain.

The Table is a world without rescue. Your table is not. Be the Carver who makes sure everyone gets fed.



CHAPTER 17

THE NINTH CHAIR

A good host lays one place more than he expects. A great host never asks who it is for.

— CARVED OVER THE HEARTH AT THIMBLE CROSS, RIM ROAD COMPANY
WAYSTATION, 402 A.G.

From the station ledger of Thimble Cross, kept by Warden Josse Haverick of the Rim Road Company, under oath. Entries for the last week of Lack, 641 A.G.

Seventh day before Tablenight. Snow since noon, if it is snow. It does not melt on the hand. It sits on the skin and goes soft, like lard left by a stove. Convoy of the Renderers' Union arrived at dusk out of the south, eleven wagons, forty-four barrels, Cullmaster's seal on the lead wagon. Teamster Crumm reports the white has followed them up the road from the Chute for six days. Reports one drover lost on the road. Reports it as wolves. I have entered it as wolves.

Sixth day before. Road closed both ways. The white lies a hand deep on the yard and has veins in it. Stores: flour for nine days at half bread. Guests: twenty-two, family four, myself. One drover missing from the yard at dusk. No tracks. A smell of baking where he stood.

Fifth day before. There is a table in the common room. It was not there at midnight. I sat up with the lamp and the ledger and I did not sleep and I did not see it come. It is long and dark and set for nine and the cloth is whiter than anything I have seen in my life. The bread is warm. Nobody has touched the bread. There are cards at the places. One of them has my name on it. I have entered it in the inventory under Furniture, Not Company Property. I do not know what else to enter it under.

Fifth day before, later. Mistress Thimble has polished the table. Nobody asked her to. She says she could not help it. She says a table like that ought to be kept nice.

Tablenight eve. I am still bound to hold this station until relieved. I wish it entered that I was never relieved.

▼ AN INTRODUCTORY ADVENTURE

The Ninth Chair is an introductory adventure for **The Long Grace**, written for three to five new characters of mixed lands and playable in two or three sessions of four to five hours. It takes place in the last week of Lack, 641 A.G., at a Rim Road Company waystation called **Thimble Cross**, where the great ring road bends between the warm meat-lands of the Fatlands and the gold, empty edge of the Fast. A storm of something that is not snow strands the characters there with a convoy of Fatlands meat, a houseful of strangers, and a long table that nobody carried in.

It is a siege, a murder mystery, and a famine, all at once, and it ends on the longest night of the year. It is designed to teach the core of the game: the Grace Roll, Dread and Fray, Hunger and Partaking, the way each land's curse travels in the blood of its people, and the first rule every child of the Fast learns, which is that there are invitations you must not accept.

It is also designed to hurt. The adventure's climax is a sacrifice that the community demands, that somebody gives, and that buys

nothing at all. Players should leave the table understanding, in their stomachs, what kind of world this is: a world in which the gods are not angry and cannot be bargained with, in which good people do the brave thing and it does not matter, and in which the Host, the only god never eaten, is kind.

CONTENT AND CARE

This adventure contains graphic gore and transformation, cannibalism, the desecration of graves, a ritual murder, a killing within a family, an inherited bloodline curse with implied incest between adults, contagious madness, and a suicide. Talk with your players before you begin. The suicide in Day Three is written to be played as grief, never as spectacle: its method is never described and need never be, and the scene is about who finds the body, what was in the note, and what the people left behind begin to say to themselves afterward. Use the tools your table prefers to step around anything that cuts deeper than the game should. Horror works best among people who trust each other.

▼ THE SECRET TRUTH

Read this section before anything else. Nothing in it should reach the players directly. All of it can reach them in pieces.

FOUR THINGS ARE HAPPENING AT ONCE

The Reaping has followed the convoy. Forty-four barrels of Fatlands meat came up the Rim Road under the seal of Cullmaster Hedley Brawn. Thirteen are notched with a small knife-mark under the stamp, and they hold the harvest of the Dusk Acres: Rootkin, field-grown meat with faces, and, packed in brine among them, the remains of people the Fatlands soil took and then, being a generous field, gave partly back. The soil of the Fatlands is the flesh of Ummer, the Laden, and that meat is still, in a sense the Board would rather not examine, ground. It has carried its weather with it. **Marbling**, the Fatlands' first frost, the whitening of the fat in the soil, has followed the wagons north for six days and settled over Thimble Cross like snow. Where the marbling lies, the ground is Fatlands ground. And on Fatlands ground in the dark of the year, at dusk, people are Reaped.

The Host has come to dinner. Orrum, the only god never eaten, has been walking out of the Fast along the Rim Road, laying tables where people are hungry. Thimble Cross is the most perfect invitation it has ever been offered. The inn is starving. The convoy's hunger is the bottomless hunger of the Fatlands. And the family who keep the inn are bound, by a Company charter sworn in Oathen two hundred and thirty-nine years ago, to "turn no traveller away, nor refuse any guest, while the blood of Thimble endures." A house that cannot refuse is a house the Host can enter. On the night after the convoy arrives, a table appears in the common room, laid for nine. On Tablenight, the longest night of Lack, the Host will come to sit at its head, and everyone who takes their place will be Seated: alive, smiling, eating from empty plates, never to rise.

The guests are not innocent. A poacher means to sell a caged Unfed woman to the Second Table, two of whose nobles are here

under false names to measure the Host's table for carving. A Purgation preacher is looking for a high-Cut throat to open. The innkeeper is about to feed his guests his own mother. A Vigil courier on her last rouse is seeing things, and the things are catching.

The ninth chair is not for anyone here. Orrum's newest tables on the Rim Road are always laid with one place more than there are guests to fill it. That place has a chair pushed in square to the table, and at Thimble Cross, for the first time anyone has recorded, it has a card. The card bears no name. It bears a single mark in the oldest form of Table-speech, the root word that means both "to worship" and "to eat," with a stroke beneath it that scholars read as "after," or "last," or "late." The people of Thimble Cross will come to believe that the ninth card names someone who must be given to the Host so that the rest may be spared. They will argue about who. They will choose. Someone will sit in the ninth chair. And the Host will come anyway, lift the volunteer gently out of a chair that was never theirs, lay a new place for them, and go on with dinner. The ninth chair was not laid for any guest of Thimble Cross. Welcome Ardent, the Host's steward, sets it at every table himself, and in six hundred years he has never once seen who it is for.

WHAT THE NINTH CHAIR IS (DO NOT SAY)

The ninth chair is the place every old carving keeps for the Eighth, the figure chiseled out of the world's history. This adventure never says so, and neither should you. If players connect the empty chair to the eighth place in old carvings, to the stone table under the sea with eight chairs, or to the eight sides of Hallowboard, let them. Do not confirm it. Welcome Ardent does not know. The Host, if it knows, does not discuss its guest list. The horror of the climax is that the chair belongs to someone who has not arrived, that everyone at Thimble Cross can feel it waiting, and that nothing they offer fills it.

▼ BACKGROUND

THIMBLE CROSS

Thimble Cross stands where the Rim Road, coming north out of the Fatlands, bends hard west to skirt the edge of the Fast. A rutted track, the **Hungry Lane**, leaves the bend and runs north into the gold country of the Unfed, toward the hearthless town of Wanting; it is used by Crumb-Runners, Hostwatch trackers, and nobody else. The station is old, solid, and plain: a two-storey inn of grey fieldstone with a slate roof and seventeen chimneys, a walled yard, a long stable, a smokehouse, a toll house with a Company bell, and, behind a low wall, a little graveyard of nine stones.

It was founded in 402 A.G. by **Hadley Thimble**, a Crumb-Runner who had spent her life carrying grain into the Fast on her back and been spat on for it by the people it kept alive. She left the

Fast, married a Fatlands drover, bought the crossing, and swore her charter with the Rim Road Company in Oathen before the Company's notary of the day. The charter granted the Thimble blood the keeping of the station in perpetuity in return for a single clause, which Hadley, who had grown up among people who refused everything, insisted on writing herself: *that the keepers of Thimble Cross shall turn no traveller away, nor refuse any guest, while the blood of Thimble endures.*

Promises sworn in Oathen follow the body that swore them, and the bodies that come after it, if the drafting says so. Hadley's drafting said so. Her descendants cannot refuse a guest without their bodies breaking to match. Mistress Hepzibah Thimble barred the door once, in her youth, against a leper in the rain, and two fingers of her right hand folded backwards to the wrist with a sound like kindling; she wears them that way still. And because the charter

binds only “the blood of Thimble,” and a Clausewright consulted in 488 A.G. opined that a mixed line might be argued to have ended, the Thimbles have for five generations kept their blood carefully, narrowly, at home. Company ledgers list Absalom and Hepzibah Thimble as husband and wife. Three lines higher on the same page, in an older hand, they are listed as born to the same mother. Guests notice the family’s sameness: the same pale-lashed grey eyes, the same small chin, the same strawberry birthmark at the throat, the same habit of laying an extra spoon. Guests do not ask.

THE CONVOY

The convoy is eleven wagons of the Renderers’ Union under **Teamster Abel Crumm**, carrying forty-four barrels north from the Chute toward the Vigil, where Fatlands salt pork is bought by the ton to feed a city that eats hourly to stay awake. It travels under the seal of **Cullmaster Hedley Brawn**, who rides with it to see the far-field barrels safely sold, because the Board is beginning to worry about inspection at the Vigil border and wishes its paperwork to be beyond reproach. The convoy’s manifest lists forty-four barrels of “pork, salted, first quality.” The thirteen notched barrels were

packed at the Dusk Acres under Brawn’s eye. Abel Crumm knows they are notched. He has not let himself know why.

Six days ago, as the wagons climbed out of the warm country, the ground behind them began to whiten in long, branching veins. Each night the marbling crept a little further up the road. One drover was lost on the second night. Crumm entered it as wolves, as the Board’s forms require. On the evening before the adventure begins, the convoy reached Thimble Cross, and the marbling came with it, and in the morning it was lying a hand deep over everything, and it had begun to fall from the sky.

WHY NOW

Tablenight is the anniversary of the Gorging, the night six peoples ate their gods and one did not. Orrum has been patient for six hundred and forty-one years. This year, the Hostwatch say, it is walking faster. Its steward, Welcome Ardent, usually lays a table a mile ahead of his master and waits for him. At Thimble Cross, for the first time, the Host has not waited for its steward. The table was laid before Ardent arrived, and that frightens Ardent more than anything has frightened him in six centuries.

▼RUNNING THE NINTH CHAIR

STRUCTURE

The adventure runs across seven days, from **Day One** (six days before Tablenight) to **Day Seven** (Tablenight itself). A day-by-day

timeline gives what happens if the characters do nothing; the characters will, of course, do something, and the timeline bends around them. Scenes are written to be dropped in when the moment is right. Roughly:

SESSION	DAYS	WHAT IT IS ABOUT
One	Days One to Three	Arrival, the table, the cards, the first Reaping, hunger, the suicide
Two	Days Four to Six	The graveyard, the kin-slaying, the ritual killing, the madness, Ardent
Three	Day Seven	The demand, the sacrifice, the Host, the endings

For a two-session game, compress Days Four to Six into a single long night of discoveries, and begin the second session on the morning the consensus forms.

THE SHAPE OF DREAD

Thimble Cross gets worse in a particular order: first strange, then hungry, then frightened, then cruel, then devout. Pace the Dread checks accordingly. The first session should cost each character perhaps 4 to 6 Fray; by the climax most should be within reach of Breaking, so that the arrival of the Host can tip one or two over the edge. Contagion of madness is a central mechanic here: when anyone Breaks, everyone who sees it makes a Dread 2 check, and the inn’s own population is Breaking too.

THE COUNT

From Day Two, **Merrit Sloe**, the Brinchollow bail-girl, begins the count, as is the custom of her country: each morning she walks the upstairs corridor and calls every name through every wall, and waits for an answer. Use the count to open every day after the first. It tells the players who is gone without needing a scene, and the silences after names are the adventure’s heartbeat. Keep a list. Cross names off where the players can see you do it.

HUNGER AT THIMBLE CROSS

The inn's stores run short at once. From Day Two, everyone at Thimble Cross is on half bread. From Day Four, there is no bread. A character who does not eat a proper meal on a given day gains 1 Hunger at dawn whether they have Partaken or not (Unfed characters, trained to it, ignore the first two days). From Day Four, a hungry character suffers -1 on all Hand and Lung rolls per full day without food, to a maximum of -3. Hunger gained from starvation counts toward Regrowth like any other. Fatlanders, whose hunger was never in the stomach, gain 2 Hunger a day instead of 1, but suffer no penalty: they are used to it.

EATING FROM THE BARRELS

The convoy's forty-four barrels are the only food at Thimble Cross worth the name. Thirty-one are honest salt pork. Thirteen are notched (see the Convoy Manifest handout). Meat from a notched barrel is the best thing any character has ever eaten: sweet, yielding, rich, with a fat that melts at blood heat and coats the tongue for an hour. It removes all starvation penalties. It does not remove Hunger. Instead, a character who eats it must roll Gut + Feast against Hard 14. On a failure they acquire the **Laden Taste** until the end of the adventure: they gain 1 Hunger every time they see food, smell cooking, or watch someone else eat, and they must make a Caul + Resolve roll (Hard 14) to stop eating once they have begun. A character who eats from a notched barrel three times dreams the memories of the person the meat once was, and must make a Dread 3 check on waking. A Fatlander who eats it suffers nothing new at all, which is the worst thing about it.

THE MARBLING

The marbling looks like snow until you are close to it. Then it looks like the white veining in a cut of beef, branching and rejoining across the ground, with a pinkish translucence between the veins that gives slightly underfoot. It smells of cold fat and, faintly, of bread. It does not melt in the hand. It softens. It falls from the sky in soft white flakes that land on the skin and cling, greasy, and must be scraped away with a knife-back. Where it lies, the ground is Fatlands ground. Between sunset and full dark, anyone standing on marbled ground alone may be Reaped (see the Reaping, below). Each day the marbling covers more: on Day One the road and the yard; on Day Three the stable floor and the graveyard; on Day Five the cellar; on Day Seven the boards of the common room, everywhere except the strip of floor beneath the Host's table, which stays bare and warm.

THE REAPING AT THIMBLE CROSS

The Reaping here obeys its Fatlands rules. A character alone on marbled ground between sunset and full dark first notices a stillness (Eye + Search, Routine 10). Then the ground leans in, the smell of new bread rising from it (Dread 3 to witness; Dread 2 for a Fatlander). Then it softens: the character must succeed at Caul + Resolve (Hard 14; Grim 18 if their Hunger is 6 or more) or stop wanting to leave. Companions may drag a character free with Gut + Labor against Grim 18, but each round in the soil deals 1d6 Flesh as the ground begins, gently, to digest. A character Reaped is gone. What is pulled out after full dark is a shape of clothes and the smell of bread. Never use the Reaping as a surprise kill on a player character; describe it slowly, and give their friends the chance to pull.

PORTIONS AND ADVANCEMENT

At the end of each session, award each character **5 to 10 Portions** of experience, as described under Aftermath. A character who survives the whole adventure should have earned between 15 and 30.

▼ THE CAST

Twenty-odd people are snowed in at Thimble Cross, and every one of them is hungry. The major figures below have full stat blocks; the rest have quick lines. Each entry notes what the person wants, what they are hiding, and what happens to them if the characters do nothing. Remember that the characters' own names are on the place cards, and that every person in this list will, sooner or later, want to know why.

THE KEEPERS OF THE HOUSE

ABSALOM THIMBLE, THE INNKEEPER

A big, soft, slope-shouldered man of sixty-one with the family's pale lashes and small chin, an apron that has not been fully white since

the Thin Rising, and a voice like a warm spoon. Absalom has kept Thimble Cross for thirty-eight years and has never in that time turned anyone away, because he cannot. He loves the work. He loves the moment a cold traveller's face changes at the smell of his pottage. The charter does not feel like a curse to him; it feels like who he is. That is why the famine breaks him. A host with no food is a contradiction his body cannot hold, and from Day One his hands tremble when he passes the empty pantry shelves. On the night of Day One he digs up his mother, Old Mother Ivy Thimble, and on Day Two he serves her, and weeps in the kitchen while the guests ask for more.

ABSALOM THIMBLE – KEEPER OF THIMBLE CROSS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 1 · Eye 2 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (mixed Fatlands line) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 8
SKILLS	Craft (cooking) 4, Labor 3, Persuade 3, Blades 2, Feast 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 13 · Armor 0 · Fray 7
ATTACKS	kitchen cleaver +5 (3); fist +3 (1)
GIFTS	Hearth-Bound. Absalom cannot refuse a guest or turn one out; any attempt breaks a bone (no roll). Conversely, while he stands at his own hearth, anyone he serves food to must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to refuse it.
WANTS	To feed whoever is under his roof. Resist (Caul + Resolve, Hard 14) or give away his own share, then other people's.
DREAD	1 (once the pottage is understood: 3)
SECRET	He dug up his mother. He knows the convoy's notched barrels are something worse, and he has already decided he will serve them when the pottage runs out.

HEPZIBAH THIMBLE, THE KEEPER'S WIFE

Small, upright, sixty, with her ruined right hand held against her apron like a folded bird. Hepzibah runs the house: the linen, the rooms, the ledger of who sleeps where. She is the family's memory and its law. She is also Absalom's sister, a fact she has never spoken aloud in her life and will defend with a carving knife. She regards the charter the way a priest regards scripture. The family has suffered for it for two hundred years; therefore it must be holy. When Orrum's table appears she polishes it, every morning, with beeswax, and cannot say why.

HEPZIBAH THIMBLE Threat 3 · Flesh 11 · Guard 11 · Attack +4 (carving knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 (Hearth-Bound, as Absalom)

LINUS THIMBLE, THE SON

Thirty-four, heavy-handed, quiet, a good farrier and a bad liar, with his father's build and his mother's eyes. Linus has always known that he and his sister are expected to marry, because there are no

other Thimbles left, and because the Clausewright's opinion is framed in the parlour. He has been trying for ten years to find a way to be content with it, and he very nearly has, and that frightens him more than the expectation itself. Linus discovers his father's crime on Day Four, when he finds his grandmother's wedding ring in the bottom of the pottage pot. He kills Absalom that night in the cellar with the cleaver his father taught him to use. Afterward he sits with the body until dawn and holds its hand.

LINUS THIMBLE Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 13 · Attack +6 (farrier's hammer 3, or cleaver 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0 (Hearth-Bound)

DORCAS THIMBLE, THE DAUGHTER

Twenty-nine, sharp-tongued, tall, the only Thimble who reads anything but the ledger. Dorcas has read the charter every night since she was fourteen, looking for an exit clause, and there is none. She wants out: out of the inn, out of the blood, out of the marriage the parlour wall has arranged for her. She is the person most likely to ask the characters, quietly, to help her leave, and the person for

whom leaving is least possible. If she crosses the station’s boundary stones without the charter being released, her body will break. She knows this. She has worked out precisely how badly. She has decided she might be willing to find out.

DORCAS THIMBLE Threat 3 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +4 (bread knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0 (Hearth-Bound)

PLAYING THE THIMBLE CURSE

The Thimbles’ inherited curse should stay in the corners of the eye. The players learn it through the sameness of their faces; through the ledger that lists Absalom and Hepzibah as born to the same mother; through the framed Clausewright’s opinion in the parlour with its phrase “the blood kept narrow, the line kept whole”; through the single wide bed in the family wing and the second one beside it that has never been slept in; through Dorcas looking at her brother across a room and then looking away. Never make it explicit. Never make it a joke. It is a family that has been doing a terrible thing to itself for two hundred years because a dead woman wrote a kind clause badly, and the most frightening thing about it is how ordinary they have made it.

WARDEN JOSSE HAVERICK – KEEPER OF THE COMPANY PEACE	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste: he hears his words a half-second late) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Blades 3, Shooting 3, Clause 3, Search 3, Resolve 3, Intimidate 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 3 (Company bone lamellar)
ATTACKS	Company sword +6 (4); crossbow +6 (4)
GIFTS	Company Oath. Anyone who swears an oath before Haverick “in the name of the Company and its notary” must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to break it; on a failure they suffer 1d6 Flesh and a visible injury apt to the oath, as the Oathen-sworn authority of Jessamy Quill reaches them faintly across the Table.
WANTS	To swear. Under strain he finds himself promising things aloud; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14).
DREAD	0
SECRET	He cannot keep the peace on Tablenight, and he knows it. If he fails, his oath will break him. He has calculated where. He has written his own death into the ledger in advance, as “Warden relieved,” and he is asking the characters to help him make it untrue.

THE CONVOY

CULLMASTER HEDLEY BRAWN, OF THE BOARD OF PLENTY

A vast, courteous, beautifully dressed man in plum wool and a waistcoat with forty bone buttons, all straining. Brawn is a Gut-line cadet and a career officer of the Board’s quietest department, the one that decides which vagrants, debtors and troublemakers are assigned the dusk shift in the far fields. He eats constantly and without hurry, from a lacquered box of candied fat he keeps in his

WARDEN JOSSE HAVERICK, OF THE RIM ROAD COMPANY

Forty-four, lean, a long jaw shaved blue each morning in cold water whatever the weather, an Oathener of minor Tongue-line blood who speaks the way all Oatheners do, slowly and in conditionals, with all the exits built in. Haverick holds Thimble Cross for the Company. He swore before the notary Jessamy Quill, in Tacit, to “hold this station for the Company until relieved, keep its peace, and keep its ledger true.” Sworn in Oathen, the promise travels with him. He cannot abandon the station; he cannot falsify the ledger; he cannot fail to keep the peace without his body coming apart to match. He is honest because he has no choice and decent because he chose it. He is the closest thing to law at Thimble Cross, and he is trapped there more completely than anyone except the Thimbles.

coat, and he speaks of the Reaping as a farmer speaks of rain: something to be planned for, measured, and directed where it will do the most good. He is not cruel. He finds cruelty wasteful. He believes, sincerely, that the Reaping can be steered, that a field which is fed one chosen person at dusk will not take a random one at midnight, and he is, horribly, partly right. From Day Two he proposes a **dusk roster**: each evening, one person will go out on the marbled ground and stand there, and the rest will be safe. He will happily draw up the roster. He will not put himself on it. He has a Board warrant that says he need not.

CULLMASTER HEDLEY BRAWN – THE BOARD’S QUIET HAND	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 5 · Lung 1 · Eye 3 · Tongue 4 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 3 (Gut-line) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite) · Hunger 7
SKILLS	Persuade 4, Feast 4, Reckoning 3, Clause 3, Endure 3, Intimidate 3, Godsign 3, Blades 2
BODY	Flesh 16 · Guard 13 · Armor 1 (layered wool and fat)
ATTACKS	cull-hook (a short brass-tipped goad) +4 (3); his weight, falling on a grappled foe, +5 (4)
GIFTS	Field-Sense. Brawn can feel which marbled ground is hungry tonight (Caul + Godsign, Hard 14). Naming the Furrow. If Brawn speaks a person’s full name aloud at dusk while standing on marbled ground, the Reaping prefers that person that evening; they make their Resolve rolls against the field at Grim 18 instead of Hard 14. He thinks of this as husbandry.
WANTS	Eating without choosing. Brawn eats through every conversation, every crisis, every death; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or he cannot stop until the food is gone.
DREAD	1 (to watch him eat from a notched barrel and smile: 2)
SECRET	He knows exactly what is in the thirteen notched barrels, because he chose the people who went into the Dusk Acres to grow it. One of them was Abel Crumm’s nephew.

TEAMSTER ABEL CRUMM, OF THE RENDERERS' UNION

Fifty-two, square, sunburned in a country with no sun to speak of, with the Fatlands’ hunger behind his eyes and a teamster’s habit of counting things twice. Abel has driven the Chute road for thirty years, and he has always known some barrels are notched, and he has always decided not to ask. He is kind to his drovers, generous with his pipe, and on the first evening he stands the whole common room a round of pear spirit and says “Lack keep away” with real feeling. On the night of Day Two he opens barrel 31 and finds, in the brine, a forearm with a tattoo he paid for himself: a sheaf of wheat and the name **ROBB**, for his sister’s boy, who went to work the dusk shift in Low Tilth last Carving for a debt of thirty lacks. He is found in the cold store on the morning of Day Three.

ABEL CRUMM Threat 3 · Flesh 15 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (pry-bar 3) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

THE DROVERS

Six Renderers’ Union drovers travel with the convoy, all Fatlanders, all perpetually, quietly eating. **Big Oona Harl** is the oldest, a woman of fifty built like a dray-horse who sings field hymns and loves Abel Crumm like a brother. **Nib Furrow** is eighteen, freckled, on his first run, and so hungry he chews the leather of his own reins; he is first on Brawn’s roster. **Gus Haslet** and **Tam Pettle** are cousins

who argue about everything except food; **Walt Sallow** is silent and missing two fingers; **Lise Trotter**, kin to the drover Sal Trotter, does not name the cattle. The convoy’s twenty-two oxen stand in the yard, and on the second night, when no one is watching the stable, some of them stand on two legs.

CONVOY DROVER Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 12 · Attack +4 (goad or knife 2) · Armor 1 · Dread 0

THE POACHER AND HIS PRIZE

KALE DRAGOMAN, THE POACHER

A long, sallow, rangy Fatlander of forty with a black beard trimmed to a point, a fine Vigil-glass spyglass on a chain, and the easy manner of a man who has found a trade that suits him. Kale hunts the Unfed across the border for the Blank trade. He takes them alive, because a living Blank fetches four times a dead one at the surgeries where blank blood and blank organs are sold to the nobility. And he feeds them well on the road, cooks for them himself, tender things, warm things, because his buyers prefer a plump specimen and because, he says, there is no reason to be unkind. His captives find this the hardest thing to forgive. He travels with two hired men and a wheeled iron cage. Kale is witty, morally weightless, and good company, and he will try hard to be liked, because people who like him are easier to sell things to.

KALE DRAGOMAN – THE FEEDER OF THE UNFED	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Fatlands) · Regrowth 3 (the Taste) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Brawl 3, Shooting 3, Hagggle 3, Craft (cooking) 3, Search 2, Stitching 2, Blades 2, Endure 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 16 · Armor 2 (boiled leather under a good coat)
ATTACKS	weighted cosh +6 (3; on a Helping the target must roll Gut + Endure, Hard 14, or fall senseless); crossbow +6 (4); skinning knife +5 (2)
GIFTS	A Good Table. Kale can make anything taste wonderful. Any character who eats food he has cooked gains no starvation penalty that day and must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) to speak against him for the rest of the evening.
WANTS	To eat what he cooks for others. He never lets himself; he tastes from the spoon and spits.
DREAD	0
SECRET	His buyer's token is a small enamel badge in the shape of a fork with two tines, the sign of the Second Table. Lady Vellum Serrat recognises it on Day Two. They come to an arrangement.

KALE'S HIRED MEN (ODO AND FENN) Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 13 · Attack +5 (club 3, or crossbow 4) · Armor 2 · Dread 0

REFRAIN DOLE, THE TABLEBREAKER

She is thirty-three, Unfed, and she has put an axe through two hundred and six of Orrum's tables. Kale took her on the Hungry Lane a week ago with a cosh behind the ear while she was splitting a laid board near Wanting, and she has been in his cage ever since, eating his cooking because the alternative is to be force-fed, and hating every sweet mouthful. She is gaunt in the way of her people,

with cropped black hair, the knuckles of a woodsman, a bruise across her temple gone green, and the Unfed's pride in her chin like a fist. She is insufferable. She tells the characters exactly what their ancestors did and exactly how damned they are, and she corrects their grace. She is also funny, fearless, and the only person at Thimble Cross who knows how to survive the Host. If the characters treat her as a person, she will teach them: never thank a chair; walk into the wind when you smell bread; stand with your back to the door; say "No, thank you" three times and never a fourth. She is, by design, the person the players should come to care about most. She is the most likely volunteer for the ninth chair.

REFRAIN DOLE – TABLEBREAKER OF WANTING	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 3 · Gut 2 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (Unfed) · Regrowth none · Hunger —
SKILLS	Resolve 4, Endure 4, Blades 3, Lore (the Host's tables) 3, Wayfaring 3, Instinct 3, Labor 2, Brawl 1
BODY	Flesh 14 (currently 9) · Guard 16 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	felling axe, if returned to her, +6 (4; against one of Orrum's tables, it splits the wood on any success); fist +4 (1)
GIFTS	No, Thank You. Refrain adds +4 to any roll to refuse the Host, its tables, its food, or its steward. Once per scene she may lend this bonus to another character by standing beside them and saying the refusal with them. Empty Vessel. She cannot Partake and nothing godsigned can find her by blood; the Reaping does not prefer her, and Brawn's Naming fails on her.
WANTS	She wants, more than anything, to eat until she is full, once, before she dies. She will never say so.
DREAD	0
SECRET	She has been reading the forbidden historian Meek Garrity in secret. She half believes his heresy: that the Unfed never refused at Hallowboard, that they only arrived late. When she sees the mark on the ninth card, she reads it as Late . She thinks it is her name.

THE TRAVELLERS

LADY VELLUM SERRAT, OF THE SECOND TABLE

She travels as "the widow Serrat, a dealer in lace," in grey mourning silk with a black lace veil that hides a slim bit of gilt wire across her tongue. She is in truth a Tongue-line noble of Tacit, Cut 4, fifty

years old, deep in the Appetite and fighting a compulsion to swear that the bit holds in check. She speaks rarely, in exquisite conditionals, through the wire, so that every sentence comes out faintly lisped and glittering. She is a member of the Second Table, whose one idea is that the gods, when they have regrown, should be eaten again, and she has come to Thimble Cross deliberately, following the Hostwatch reports of tables laid at Rim Road inns, to

see one of Orrum's tables up close and take its measurements. She carries a cutwright's tape, a silver carving set wrapped in oilcloth, and a letter from Wont Bellamy of the Abstinents. She regards the

Host as the only whole god left on the Table and therefore the only unspoiled meal. She is calm, curious, and the most dangerous person in the building.

LADY VELLUM SERRAT – THE WIDOW IN GREY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 5 · Caul 3
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Tongue-line) · Regrowth 6 (the Appetite) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Clause 5, Lore 4, Persuade 3, Reckoning 3, Resolve 3, Godsign 3, Athletics 1, Blades 1
BODY	Flesh 10 · Guard 13 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	stiletto hidden in a lace-bobbin +3 (2)
GIFTS	Bound Word. Vellum cannot lie, and everyone at Thimble Cross who knows Oatheners knows it; her statements carry weight (+2 to Persuade when she says something plainly). The Self-Sworn. Once per session she may take out the bit and swear an oath upon herself to accomplish a thing; for the rest of the scene she adds a Tooth to every roll toward that end, and if she fails it her body breaks to match.
WANTS	To swear. Without the bit she will vow aloud whatever she is thinking; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14).
DREAD	1 (to see what the wire has done to her tongue: 2)
SECRET	She will trade anything for the ninth card. She believes it names the Host's own place, and that whoever holds it may be able to call the Host to sit, and be carved. She is wrong. She does not know she is wrong.

LORD CASIMIR HOLLOWE-VANE, THE SECRETARY

He travels as Vellum's secretary, a quiet young man in a scholar's coat, with heavy grey gloves he never removes and a habit, which he cannot stop, of closing things: lids, shutters, books, the inn's doors behind people who meant to leave them open. He is in truth a cadet of the Hand-lines of Sallowreach, a distant cousin of the Left Hand

of the Court, Cut 4, thirty-one, and well into the Course. Under the gloves, under a second pair of lead-lined mittens, his hands are grey and cold and have seven joints to each finger. What they touch finishes: a candle, a conversation, a person. He left Sallowreach because he could not bear to be useful there. He is gentle, frightened, well-read, and would very much like someone to hold his hand without dying.

LORD CASIMIR HOLLOWE-VANE – THE GLOVED SECRETARY	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 4 (Hand-line) · Regrowth 7 (the Course) · Hunger 5
SKILLS	Rites 3, Lore 3, Persuade 2, Resolve 2, Blades 2, Stitching 1, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	Closing Touch +6 (bare hand; the target must roll Caul + Resolve against Grim 18 or fall to Ruin at once; on a Lack they simply finish); sword-cane +6 (4)
GIFTS	The Closing Hand. Anything he touches bare-handed ends: a flame, a fever, a heartbeat. He can choose to touch lightly and end only a thing's motion, or a pain, or a fit of madness (Caul + Godsign, Hard 14; on a failure, he ends more than he meant).
WANTS	To close. He cannot leave a door, lid or eye open; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or close it, whoever is in the way.
DREAD	2 (to see his hands ungloved)
SECRET	He came to Thimble Cross hoping that if he sat at the Host's table, his hands would be fed something other than endings. He has told no one, not even Vellum.

SISTER CLEMENCY VOIDE, OF THE PURGATION

A tall, bony woman of forty-five from the red highlands of Cradlewrack, in a sackcloth habit belted with a string of pewter basins that clink when she walks. Her teeth are worn to stubs by bile, her knuckles calloused where she has put her fingers down her own throat ten thousand times, and her voice is the warmest thing

at Thimble Cross: low, kind, patient, with a midwife's certainty in it. The Purgation believes the gods can be thrown back up. Clemency's own branch believes it must be done by the highest bloodlines first, since the god sits thickest in them, and that the Host, the uneaten god, came to this place because the guests are full of eaten god and it can smell them. She preaches fasting, bleeding, and purging in the yard each morning, and by Day Four the hungry

drovers have begun to listen, because she is the only person offering a reason for what is happening. She is also, under the Regrowth of her own land, suffering the false labour of the Appetite, cramps that

bend her double on the stairs, and she believes it is the god trying to come out of her.

SISTER CLEMENCY VOIDE – THE EMETIC	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 2 · Eye 3 · Tongue 5 · Caul 4
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Cradlewrack) · Regrowth 4 (the Appetite: false labour) · Hunger 6
SKILLS	Persuade 5, Rites 4, Stitching 3, Resolve 3, Intimidate 3, Blades 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 14 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	bleeding lancet +4 (2; the wound bleeds 1 Flesh per round until stitched, Routine 10); pewter basin +3 (1)
GIFTS	The Sermon. When Clemency preaches to a crowd, she rolls Tongue + Persuade; anyone listening who does not beat her result with Caul + Resolve is swayed for a day, and will take her side in any argument. Purge. She can make a willing or restrained person vomit up what they have eaten in the last day (no roll); this removes the Laden Taste and 1d6 Hunger, and costs 1d6 Flesh.
WANTS	To open. During her cramps she feels something about to begin and must make something begin; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14), or she opens a door, a window, a vein.
DREAD	1 (to watch her purge a convert: 2)
SECRET	She knows who Casimir is from the first night, from the way he shuts the doors. She has already decided.

PURGATION CONVERTS (DROVERS AND GUESTS SWAYED BY THE SERMON) Threat 1 · Flesh 10 · Guard 12 · Attack +3 (lancet or knife 2) · Armor 0 · Dread 0

MERRIT SLOE, THE BAIL-GIRL

Nineteen, freckled, wiry, with salt-cracked lips, a gap-toothed grin, and a wooden bail-bucket on a cord across her back, painted with gulls by someone who loved her. Merrit is from Lowmark. Her mother walked into the sea when Merrit was twelve and walked out again six weeks later, calm and courteous and heavier, and tucked

Merrit into bed that night with a stranger's hands. Merrit left home at sixteen and has been walking east ever since, as far from the sea as the Rim Road goes, earning her passage at Company inns by bailing Brinehollow travellers who are too old or too ill to cough the night's tide up for themselves. She is cheerful in the deliberate way of people who have decided to be. She is the first to make friends with Refrain Dole, through the bars of the cage, by trading jokes for jokes. She has started to stand at the west windows at night, where the gold light of the Fast lies across the marbled fields like a tide coming in, and she does not know why.

MERRIT SLOE – THE BAIL-GIRL OF THIMBLE CROSS	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 3 · Lung 3 · Eye 3 · Tongue 3 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (Brinehollow) · Regrowth 2 (the Taste) · Hunger 3
SKILLS	Stitching (bailing and the care of the drowned) 3, Persuade 3, Athletics 2, Endure 2, Instinct 2, Search 2, Filch 2
BODY	Flesh 13 · Guard 15 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	gutting knife +4 (2); bail-bucket swung on its cord +3 (1)
GIFTS	The Count. While Merrit keeps the morning count, any character who answers her through the wall gains +1 on the first Dread check of the day. Reading the Water. From the colour of what she bails from a Brinehollow lung, she can tell who will be Called next (Eye + Instinct, Hard 14).
WANTS	The pull. She stands at windows facing west; resist with Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or walk toward the water, or toward whatever lies west instead.
DREAD	0
SECRET	Her card is on the table. She has decided not to mention it.

COURIER BENEDETTA "BELL" LISLE, OF THE VIGIL

Twenty-six, quick, angular, with a courier's narrow saddle-hardened body and the bruised, lidded, enormous eyes of someone who has

not slept in her life. She carries a sealed leather dispatch case under the Warden-Prime's lidless-eye seal, addressed to Envoy Castellan Dray at Lastgate, and she rides the Rim Road the long way round because the Fast is shorter and nobody crosses it. She also carries six

vials of rouse that should have lasted the journey. They are not lasting. By Day Two she is blinking, losing seconds on her feet, waking in other parts of the room; by Day Four she is seeing the Seeming, the shared hallucinations that every Vigil citizen comes to in the end, and the Seeming here is a tall figure stooping at the windows and a dead family laid out at the table eating, and the

Seeming is catching. She asks one of the characters to be her nudger, to keep her awake by any means, a pinch, a slap, a pin; it is the most intimate thing she knows how to ask. She knows that if she sleeps, wherever she lies down, she will go to the long room with the eye in it and not come back.

COURIER BELL LISLE – RIDER OF THE WAKING POST	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 2 · Gut 2 · Lung 4 · Eye 3 · Tongue 2 · Caul 2
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 2 (the Vigil) · Regrowth 5 (the Appetite: blinks) · Hunger 4
SKILLS	Wayfaring 4, Athletics 3, Search 3, Resolve 2, Shooting 2, Endure 1
BODY	Flesh 11 · Guard 17 · Armor 1 (padded riding coat)
ATTACKS	courier's crossbow-pistol +4 (3); needle (for her own use) +2 (1)
GIFTS	The Seeming. When Bell hallucinates, everyone within sight of her must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or see what she sees; those who fail add 1 Fray and pass the Seeming on in turn if they too are near Breaking (Fray 7 or more).
WANTS	The blink. Once per scene, Bell must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or lose 1d6 seconds, waking somewhere else in the room.
DREAD	0
SECRET	She has read her dispatch; the seal is old and she was curious. It contains the Warden-Prime's offer to Sallowreach: to buy the secret of Keeping, so that the citizens of the Vigil may be killed and kept upright, and never need to sleep. Bell has decided that if that is the future, she would rather go to the long room now.

THE STEWARD

WELCOME ARDENT, STEWARD OF THE HOST

He comes out of the north on the third night, along the Hungry Lane, walking on ground the marbling melts away from: a tall, very thin, very tired man in an old-fashioned black coat and a long apron, with a napkin over his arm and a wooden box of cutlery under it. He looks perhaps forty. He is six hundred and some. He was the

first of the Unfed ever to accept the Host's invitation, at the end of the Thin Years, and he was the only guest who was ever offered a position instead of a chair. He walks a mile ahead of Orrum and lays its tables, and he is polite, gentle, scrupulous, and so exhausted that his voice sometimes stops in the middle of a sentence and has to be restarted, like a clock. He arrives to find a table already laid, without him, and he stands in the doorway of the common room for a long time with his hand over his mouth.

WELCOME ARDENT – THE HOST'S STEWARD	
ATTRIBUTES	Hand 4 · Gut 1 · Lung 2 · Eye 4 · Tongue 4 · Caul 6
CUT & REGROWTH	Cut 0 (Unfed; he carries no god, only an employer) · Regrowth none
SKILLS	Craft (laying a table) 6, Lore (the Host) 5, Persuade 4, Rites 4, Instinct 4, Resolve 3
BODY	Flesh 9 · Guard 12 · Armor 0
ATTACKS	none. He will not raise a hand. Wounds dealt to him close by the next morning, folded shut like a napkin.
GIFTS	In Service. Ardent cannot be killed while the Host walks; he can be hurt, and it hurts him, and he apologises for bleeding on the floor. Laying the Place. Wherever he sets a cloth, a table follows. Relief. Ardent can offer his position to another. Anyone who accepts, in so many words, becomes the Host's steward from the next dawn, and Ardent is free (see Ending Two).
WANTS	To rest. He cannot, and has not, in six hundred years.
DREAD	3 (the first time he is understood for what he is)
SECRET	He set the ninth place at every table he has ever laid, because he was told to on his first night, and he has never been told whom it is for. He has stopped asking. When he sees the ninth card at Thimble Cross, in a hand that is not his own, he begins to tremble, and does not stop.

OX OF THE CONVOY (ON TWO LEGS, UNOBSERVED)	Dread 2
Threat 2 · Flesh 18 · Guard 10 · Attack +5 (trample or bite 4) · Armor 1 ·	

▼ THE PLACES OF THIMBLE CROSS

THE BEND AND THE APPROACH

The road comes up out of the south between low hedges gone white, and for a mile you think it is snow, and are glad of it, because snow is clean. Then your boots begin to slide in something that is not ice, and your horse will not put its head down to it, and the smell reaches you: cold dripping, a butcher's slab in the morning, and under it, faint and impossible, new bread. Ahead, where the road bends west, stands a grey inn with seventeen chimneys, and only one of them is smoking. Beyond it, to the north, the land goes gold, as if it were late afternoon in early Carving there, though it is noon in the dead of Lack here. The white stops at the edge of that light like a tide.

The marbling covers the Rim Road for six miles south and three west; travel out is Grim 18 on Lung + Wayfaring by day and impossible at dusk, and the Reaping walks the road. North, the Hungry Lane runs into the Fast, and the ground there is bare and warm wherever the Host has walked. The characters will realise, if they test it, that the safest ground in the region is the god's road.

THE YARD AND THE CONVOY

A cobbled yard behind a seven-foot wall, crammed with eleven wagons drawn into a ring. The oxen stand head-down, breath steaming, and do not move when touched. The barrels are stacked under oiled canvas: forty-four oak casks bound in iron, each stamped with the Chute's mark struck over twice, thirteen with a small knife-notch beneath. Marbling lies thickest here. By Day Three it has grown veins up the wagon wheels.

Under the canvas the barrels sweat. A slow pink brine beads at the staves and runs and freezes into soft white whorls on the cobbles. When the wind drops you can hear them settling, a creak and a long wet shift, the sound of something in a hammock turning over in its sleep.

Search (Eye + Search, Hard 14) finds the notches. A Fatlander, or anyone with Reckoning 2+, can see that the notched barrels are heavier than pork should be. Laying a palm on a notched barrel at night (Caul + Instinct, Hard 14) reveals that it is warm.

THE COMMON ROOM

A long, low, smoke-darkened room with a flagged floor, three tables of scarred pine, a great hearth carved with the founding motto, and a row of west windows looking toward the Fast. From the morning of Day Two it holds a fourth table.

It runs down the middle of the room where no table was, dark wood polished to the depth of still water, so long the lamp at its head and the lamp at its foot cannot see each other. The cloth is white the way bone is white when it has been boiled clean. There are nine places. Nine plates of thin cream porcelain rimmed in gold, each with a folded card. Nine chairs; eight of them pulled out a hand's width, as if for someone about to sit. The ninth, at the foot, is pushed in square to the table, its back to the lamp. Down the centre: a loaf, broken, steam still rising from the break. A dish of butter sweating gold. A tureen with its lid on. The room is warm for the first time in two days. Nobody is standing near the hearth. Everyone is standing near the table.

The table cannot be moved: it is not heavy, it simply does not go. Axes split it (Refrain's axe always does; others need Hand + Labor, Hard 14) and it is whole again the next dawn, with fresh bread. The food is the Host's; eating any of it makes the eater a guest, and the eater must sit at their own place before dawn (Caul + Resolve, Grim 18, each hour to resist). The bread is never cold. Its smell reaches every room in the inn, and every character who passes through the common room hungry must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or gain 1 Hunger.

THE PLACE CARDS

There are nine cards. Eight bear names, in a fine, round, careful hand that each reader recognises as the handwriting of someone who loved them: a mother, a grandmother, a first teacher. Fill the eight with every player character's name (correctly spelled, including any secret or childhood name), plus, in order to reach eight, **Merrit Sloe**, **Linus Thimble**, **Lord Casimir Hollowe-Vane** (under his true name, which exposes him), and **Absalom Thimble**. For three characters, use all four; for four, drop Absalom; for five, drop Absalom and Linus. The ninth card bears no name; see the handout.

THE KITCHEN AND PANTRY

A stone-flagged kitchen with a hearth big enough to roast a pig, copper pans on hooks, and a pantry of sixty empty shelves. On Day Two the great pot hangs over the fire with the pottage in it. A

character with Stitching 1+ or a Fatlands upbringing who examines the pottage’s meat (Eye + Search, Hard 14) can tell it is not mutton and not pork; on a Grace, they find a small gold ring with an inscription, *A.T. to I.M., kept*.

THE CELLAR AND COLD STORE

Steep steps down to a vaulted cellar of casks and racks, and beyond a heavy door the cold store, where meat hangs on hooks in winter. From Day Five the cellar floor is marbled, and the white climbs the barrel-staves in veins. Abel Crumm is found in the cold store on Day Three. Absalom Thimble dies in the cellar on the night of Day Four.

THE GUEST ROOMS AND THE LONG ROOM

Upstairs, nine narrow rooms off a single corridor with thin plank walls, and at the end the Long Room, a dormitory for drovers. Here Merrit walks every morning, knocking, calling names. The west-facing rooms are the warmest, and the Fast’s gold light lies across their floors all night, and those who sleep in them dream of being invited.

THE FAMILY WING

A locked door off the kitchen opens onto the Thimbles’ rooms: a parlour with the charter framed under glass beside the Clausewright’s opinion of 488; a plain room with two beds, one wide and worn and one narrow and never slept in; Dorcas’s room, stacked with books on Oathen law. Searching the parlour (Eye + Search, Routine 10) finds the family register, which tells the

attentive reader everything about the Thimble blood without saying anything at all.

THE STABLE AND KALE'S CAGE

A long stone stable, its floor marbled from Day Three. At the far end, under a tarpaulin, Kale Dragoman’s cage: iron bars, a wooden floor with straw, a slop bucket, and Refrain Dole sitting with her back straight and her eyes open. Kale’s men take turns sleeping across the door. Picking the padlock is Hand + Filch, Hard 14; the key is on Kale’s belt.

THE SMOKEHOUSE

A squat brick tower across the yard, black inside with three centuries of smoke, hung with iron hooks and racks. It is where Sister Clemency performs the Ninefold Purge on Lord Casimir on the night of Day Five.

THE LITTLE GRAVEYARD

Behind a waist-high wall, nine stones for nine generations of Thimbles, the oldest, Hadley’s, carved with a single word: *Welcome*. The newest, Old Mother Ivy Thimble’s, set in Carving. From Day Three the marbling lies across it. On the morning of Day Four three graves are open: Ivy’s dug down from above by a spade, and two older ones, Hadley’s and her son’s, broken open from beneath.

THE TOLL HOUSE

Haverick’s post: a stone hut at the gate with a bell, a strongbox, a crossbow rack, and the station ledger on a lectern. The ledger records everything the warden sees, and he cannot make it lie.

▼ THE WEEK BEFORE TABLENIGHT

If the characters do nothing, this is what happens. Every event below can be prevented, delayed, or made worse.

DAY	DAYTIME	DUSK AND NIGHT
Eve	Convoy arrives; marbling settles	One drover lost on the road, entered as wolves
One	Characters arrive; road closes	Drover Walt Sallow Reaped in the yard; Absalom digs up his mother
Two	The table and cards found; first count; pottage served; Brawn proposes the dusk roster; Vellum and Kale make terms	Nib Furrow sent to the dusk ground; Abel opens barrel 31
Three	Abel found in the cold store; the note; the barrels are opened and the starving inn eats	Big Oona walks onto the marbled ground; Welcome Ardent arrives
Four	Graves found open; Clemency’s great sermon; Linus finds the ring	The Gleanings come to the windows; Linus kills Absalom; the oath on the dead
Five	Absalom’s death known; the inn divides; the cellar marbles	Clemency performs the Ninefold Purge on Casimir; Vellum’s oath on the dead
Six	Bell sleeps; the Seeming spreads through the whole inn; the ninth card is read	The consensus forms; the demand is made

DAY	DAYTIME	DUSK AND NIGHT
Seven	The price is paid to Kale; the volunteer is chosen	Tablenight: the ninth chair is filled; the Host comes anyway

▼ HOOKS: WHY YOU ARE HERE

Each character needs a reason to be on the Rim Road in the dead of Lack. Choose or adapt one per character. Every hook should bring them to Thimble Cross on the afternoon of Day One, just as the road closes.

- ◇ **Sallowreach.** A Seamer's journeyman or Heir carrying a sealed jar north from the Fatlands for a client in Lastgate. Or: the Mortuary Court has sent you to find a runaway Hand-line cadet, Casimir Hollowe-Vane, before he touches someone important; he was last seen heading east with a widow in grey.
- ◇ **The Fatlands.** A Renderers' Union clerk sent by Mistress Brisket Annalow to quietly check one convoy's barrels against its manifest, because Quartermaster Ivo Stockpot has been notching more of them than she likes. Or: a Thin dissident fleeing north toward the Fast with the Board's bailiffs a day behind.
- ◇ **Brinchollow.** A Netwatch deserter walking inland, or a salvager carrying a sketch of Cray Lobbett's eight-chaired table to sell in the Vigil. Merrit Sloe recognises a fellow coaster and bails you the first night.
- ◇ **The Vigil.** A Waker escort assigned to meet Courier Lisle at Thimble Cross and see her dispatch safely to Lastgate. Or: an apprentice of Mirela Sconce sent to find the source of the Seeming of a tall figure laying a table.
- ◇ **Cradlewrack.** A border-runner for Petra Quick fleeing the highlands, or an Assembler sent to buy a Part rumoured to be among a poacher's stock. Doors you pass drift open behind you, and Lord Casimir shuts every one.
- ◇ **Oathen.** A Surety travelling to the Company's Vigil office, carrying the risk of someone else's contract in your body, or a junior Clausewright sent by Jessamy Quill's office to audit the Thimble charter, which the Company would like to end.
- ◇ **The Fast.** A Tablebreaker hunting the one who took Refrain Dole, your partner. Or a Hostwatch tracker following warm ground south along the Hungry Lane. You know the rules. You will spend the adventure watching other people break them.

THE NINTH CARD AND THE CHARACTERS

The characters' names are on the cards because they are hungry and they are here. Nothing in their pasts summoned the table; the Host invites whoever is within a day's walk and in need. Make sure each player understands, early, that their character's card is written in the hand of the person who loved them most. That should be the first Dread check of the adventure (Dread 2), and it should be the one they remember.

▼ ACT ONE: THE LAID PLACE (DAYS ONE TO THREE)

DAY ONE: THE ROAD CLOSES

The characters arrive through the falling marbling in the last grey hour of afternoon. Absalom meets them at the door with a lantern and the words his charter requires: “Come in, come in, there’s always room.” Let them meet the house: Haverick at his ledger, Brawn eating in the best chair, Kale at knucklebones, the widow in grey and her gloved secretary, Clemency refusing supper, Merrit carrying ale, Bell Lisle standing because she does not dare sit. It is the last warm evening.

Dusk: the first Reaping. As the light goes, the drover Walt Sallow steps out to check the oxen. Any character near a window or in the yard notices the stillness (Eye + Search, Routine 10). Then Walt stops walking. The ground around his boots has risen into soft white folds, like dough proving.

He does not shout. He looks down at his feet with an expression of mild interest, the way a man looks at a dog that has put its head in his lap. The white is over his ankles, then his shins, and it moves in a slow pulse, and where it touches him the cloth of his trousers darkens as if wet. He says, quite clearly, “Oh, that’s warm.” He puts his hands in his pockets. The smell of new bread is so strong that across the yard someone’s stomach answers it aloud.

Witnessing is Dread 3 (Dread 2 for Fatlanders). Characters who run out can try to pull him free (Gut + Labor, Grim 18; see the Reaping rules), but Walt does not want to be pulled, and the ground is fast. If they fail, by full dark there is a shape of clothes on the cobbles and two fingers’ worth of empty glove. Brawn, at the window, wipes his mouth and enters the time in a small book.

DAY TWO: THE TABLE

Dawn. Hepzibah’s scream brings everyone down to the common room. Read the description of the table. Each character finds their own card and must make a Dread 2 check on recognising the handwriting.

Handout: A Place Card.

A stiff fold of cream card, warm to the touch, smelling faintly of yeast. The ink is brown, like gravy dried on a plate. The hand is round and careful and belongs, the reader knows at once, to their mother.

(The character’s name, spelled exactly as their mother spelled it.)

You are expected.

Tablenight. Come as you are.

There will be enough.

Handout: The Ninth Card.

The same cream card, but cold, and slightly damp, as if it had been left out overnight. No name. In the centre, a single mark in the oldest form of Table-speech, made with a broad pen in one stroke: the root that means both to worship and to eat. Beneath it, a second, shorter stroke, drawn by a different hand, or the same hand much later. The second mark can be read, depending on the scholar, as after, last, late, or still to come. There is no third line. Where the other cards say You are expected, this one has a small, perfect thumbprint, pressed into the card as if into soft fat.

Reading the ninth card needs Eye + Lore against Grim 18; on a success the reader knows the readings above. Refrain Dole reads it without a roll, if anyone shows her, and goes very quiet.

The first count. Merrit walks the corridor calling names. Use it. Note who does not answer.

The pottage. At midday Absalom serves a thick, fragrant pottage of barley and onion and tender pale meat, and the house, which has not eaten properly in two days, falls on it. It is wonderful. Characters who eat it, and later learn what it was, face Dread 3 at the revelation.

The dusk roster. In the afternoon, Cullmaster Brawn addresses the common room, pleasantly, with a ledger. He explains the Reaping as Board science: the field will take one at dusk regardless; a field that is fed by choice is a quiet field; he proposes to choose. He has already drawn up a list of seven, one per night to Tablenight, and every name on it is a drover, a servant, or a guest of low Cut. The first is Nib Furrow, eighteen. Brawn is persuasive (Tongue + Persuade 8); the starving room is frightened; unless the characters argue him down (an opposed Tongue + Persuade, or Haverick’s support, which he will give if asked, because his oath includes the peace), the roster is accepted by a show of hands. Kale abstains with a smile. Refrain, from the stable, laughs until she coughs.

Handout: The Convoy Manifest.

Renderers' Union of the Fatlands, by the Chute, sworn true under seal. Convoy of Teamster A. Crumm, eleven wagons, northbound for the Vigil, Lack 641.

Barrels 1 through 30, 32, 33: Pork, salted, first quality. Tilth Commons.

Barrels 31, 34 through 44: Pork, salted, first quality. Far field. Under Board seal, H. Brawn, Cullmaster.

Weight of far-field barrels exceeds pork standard by one-fifth. Entered as brine.

Origin: struck over twice. Inspected: struck over once.

Drovers: Crumm, Harl, Furrow, Haslet, Pettie, Sallow, Trotter. Losses on the road: Hayle, R. (entered last Carving, Low Tilth, carried forward in error; strike).

The manifest is in Abel's wagon. The struck-out name at the bottom, **Hayle, R.**, is Abel's nephew, Robb, who went to the Dusk Acres last Carving; a clerk copied his name from Brawn's culling roster onto the wrong form. A Fatlander, or anyone who asks the drovers, can learn that Robb was Abel's sister's boy.

Dusk: Nib. Nib Furrow walks out onto the marbled yard at sundown, shaking, because the room voted and he is a Fatlander and Fatlanders eat what they are served. The characters can stop him, stand with him (two or more people together are not alone, and the Reaping does not take them), or watch. If they stand with him all through the dusk, the field takes no one that night, and Brawn writes in his little book, without irritation, that the roster has been disrupted and the field will be hungrier tomorrow.

Night: barrel 31. Late, the drovers beg Abel for meat. A character awake in the yard sees him prise the lid off barrel 31 by lantern-light, stand very still for a long time, and close it again.

DAY THREE: THE TEAMSTER

In the morning count, Abel Crumm does not answer. Big Oona finds him in the cold store. Do not describe how he died. Describe what she does: how she sits down on the flags beside him and takes off her own coat and puts it over him, though he is past cold; how she says his name, the way she has said it for thirty years, to call him to breakfast; how she will not let anyone else come in for the first hour. Finding him or coming upon Oona with him is a Dread 2 check. Abel left a note pinned to the inside of his coat, addressed to his sister.

Handout: Abel Crumm's Note.

Mags.

I opened one. I wasn't meant to and I did. It was Robb's arm, the one with the wheat on it that I paid for. I'd know it anywhere. I've known it was something for thirty years and I

didn't look, and the not looking was the thing I was best at. I've fed it to people. I've eaten it myself on the road and said it was good.

I don't know how to drive the wagons back and I don't know how to drive them on.

Don't let them tell you it was wolves. It was me. I'm sorry I won't be home for the Weighing. Tell Oona the pipe is hers and she's to stop pretending she doesn't smoke it.

Lack keep away from you. It never kept away from us.

Abel

Afterward. Abel's death is the first time the inn's madness spreads person to person, and it should be shown through the living. The drovers sit together in the Long Room and do not eat. That evening, Gus Haslet says he can hear the barrels in the yard "saying grace, like at home, thanking the field by name." By night, Tam Pettie can hear it too. Big Oona stands at the window over the yard with Abel's pipe, unlit, in her mouth, and says, to nobody, "He always went first through a gate so the beasts would follow." Any character who spends time with the drovers must make a Dread 2 check; on a failure they too hear the barrels murmuring, very softly, all night, the names of fields.

The barrels opened. By afternoon the inn has had no bread for a day and the pottage pot is scraped dry. Brawn has the barrels broached. He does not say which are which. Unless the characters stop it, the starving inn eats from the notched barrels by evening (see Eating from the Barrels), and it is the best meal anyone has had in their lives. Hepzibah weeps at the stove. Kale cooks for Refrain from an honest barrel, carefully, and she can smell the difference, and eats.

Dusk: Oona. Big Oona is not on the roster. At sundown she walks out onto the marbled yard anyway, with Abel's pipe, and stands where Walt stood, and waits. She is not making a choice anyone else can make for her, she says, if the characters reach her; she is only going after him, the way he went first through gates. This is the adventure's echo of the suicide, and it should be played as the pull of grief, not as a test the players pass or fail. Characters who stay beside her, talking, keep the field off her for the night (Tongue + Persuade, Hard 14, to bring her back inside; Grace: she gives the pipe to the character, and lives to the end). If no one goes, she is Reaped, singing a field hymn, slowly.

Night: the Steward. An hour after full dark, someone sees a lantern on the Hungry Lane, coming south, and the marbling melting away from the road around it in a widening black margin. Welcome Ardent walks into the yard, knocks at the door though it is open, and asks Absalom, very politely, whether the house has been laid. Then he sees the table. Seeing Ardent understood is Dread 3. He answers questions honestly and wearily. He confirms the rules of

the Seated. He says he did not lay this table, and that he does not understand why the Host has gone ahead of him. Asked about the ninth chair, he says only, “I set that one myself, at every table. I

always have. I’ve never set the card.” He looks at the card for a long time and does not touch it.

▼ ACT TWO: HUNGER INDOORS (DAYS FOUR TO SIX)

DAY FOUR: OPEN GRAVES

The graveyard. In the morning, whoever goes out first sees the graveyard wall split and three graves open. Old Mother Ivy’s has been dug from above; the spade is still leaning on the wall, and the shroud lies in the trench empty and folded, because Absalom could not bear to leave it in a heap. The two oldest, Hadley’s and her son’s, have burst from beneath: the marbling has come up through the coffins in soft white veins, and of the bones only the long ones remain, licked smooth and pink, as if something below had sucked them like sweets.

The coffin wood has gone soft and fibrous, like the inside of a loaf. In the bottom of Hadley Thimble’s there is a hollow in the shape of a lying woman, lined with a fine white down, warm when you put your hand into it. Something is still breathing through it. The breath smells of the pottage.

The graves are Dread 2; understanding that Ivy’s was dug by a spade, and connecting it to yesterday’s meal, is Dread 3. Following the spade’s prints (Eye + Search, Hard 14) leads to the kitchen door.

The great sermon. At noon, in the yard, Sister Clemency preaches to the starving, and the inn listens. Roll her Sermon. On Day Four she sways most of the drovers and a few of the guests.

Handout: The Sermon of Sister Clemency Voide, Preached in the Yard at Thimble Cross.

Children. Brothers. Sisters with your bellies cramping. I will not lie to you, because you have been lied to enough. You are full. You are the fullest people who have ever lived. Your grandmothers’ grandmothers swallowed God and you have been carrying It ever since, warm in your guts like a stone in a hen. That is why you can never eat enough. You are not hungry. You are pregnant with a corpse.

And now the one God that was never eaten has come to supper. Why here? Because It can smell Its brothers in you. Because It is a Host, and a Host goes where the larder is. It has come to fetch Its family home out of your bellies, and It does not care if It must take your bellies with them.

There is one way, and it is the oldest way. Give It back. Open your mouths and give It back. Fast and bleed and purge until the god in you comes up black and stinking and lies on the stones where it belongs, and when the Host comes on Tablenight, let It find nothing in this house but clean, empty people, and pass us by.

And those who are fullest, those whose blood is thickest with the stolen meat, the high and the gloved and the veiled: they must be emptied first, and most, because the Host can smell them from the Fast. It is not murder to open a jar. It is housekeeping.

Lack keep away? No. Lack come in. Lack is the only clean guest we have ever had.

At the climax of the sermon she walks into the common room, kneels at the head of the Host’s table, puts her fingers down her throat, and vomits a long black string of bile across the white cloth. Witnessing this blasphemy is Dread 2. In the morning the cloth is spotless, and Clemency’s place in the room has a card. It has her name on it.

The ring. In the afternoon, scrubbing out the pottage pot, Linus finds his grandmother’s wedding ring. A character who is in the kitchen sees him stand with it in his palm for a full minute. He says nothing. He goes out to the graveyard, and looks, and comes back.

Dusk: the Gleanings. At sundown, the people the field has taken come back to the windows. See Combat Encounters. They ask to be let in, in their own voices, and Absalom, Hepzibah, Linus and Dorcas cannot refuse a guest.

Night: the kin-slaying. After the Gleanings are driven off, Linus goes down to the cellar where his father is broaching a notched barrel for tomorrow. If no character follows, the house hears only one sound, a wet chop like a joint going through on the block, then a second, and then a long silence. If characters follow, they arrive as Linus brings the cleaver down.

Absalom is kneeling, as if at a hearth, with both arms in the open barrel to the elbow. He does not turn round. He says, “She always wanted to be useful, son. She’d have wanted to feed them.” The first blow takes him where the neck meets the shoulder and goes in to the spine, and the sound is the sound

he taught his son to listen for, the clean give of a joint. He falls into the barrel. Brine and blood come over the rim together in a pink sheet across the flags. Linus pulls him out by the apron strings, because he cannot leave his father in there with the others, and holds him, and his father's face is shining with the brine and looks, for a moment, enormously relieved.

Witnessing the killing is Dread 3. Linus does not fight unless someone tries to take the body from him; then use his quick line, at +2, until he is restrained or Ruined.

The oath on the dead. At dawn Hepzibah comes down. She washes Absalom's face, closes his eyes, and folds his hands over the wound. Then she makes her children kneel and lay their hands on their father's chest, and she makes them swear, in front of whoever is watching, in the Company's form, with Haverick as unwilling witness: *that the blood of Thimble shall endure; that it shall be kept whole and kept at home; that its two last children shall be joined as their mother and father were joined, before Lack is out.* Linus swears. Dorcas looks at the characters, and then at her father, and swears. Haverick enters it in the ledger, because he must, and is sick in the yard afterward. This is Dread 2 for anyone who understands what was sworn.

DAY FIVE: THE NINEFOLD PURGE

The marbling reaches the cellar, climbing the stairs one step an hour. The inn divides: the swayed with Clemency, the Board's people with Brawn, the Thimbles with their dead. Bell Lisle is blinking every few minutes now.

Night: the ritual killing. After midnight, Clemency and four converts take Lord Casimir from his room with a blanket over his hands and carry him to the smokehouse. If the characters have befriended Casimir, or are watching Clemency, they can intervene; Clemency's converts fight with fervour, and Casimir, bound with his hands in a sack, can do nothing until freed. If no one comes, Vellum finds him at dawn.

They have hung him from a meat-hook by the bound wrists, so that his toes just touch the brick. The floor is set with nine pewter basins in a ring, and each one holds something that came out of him, in order, the way the Purgation teaches: brine he was made to drink and bring up; bile; the black of his last meal; blood from the lancet at each elbow; blood from the throat; and then, in the last four, what she took out of him with the long knife, set out neatly, the way a cook sets out the parts of a fowl, the liver dark and glossy as a plum, the coils of him laid in a bowl and still faintly steaming in the cold. His gloves have been cut off. His grey hands have been taken off at the wrist and laid together, palms pressed, in the last basin, as if praying. Smoke hangs in the roof. Clemency is kneeling in

the ring with her arms red to the shoulder and her eyes shut, waiting, with great patience, for the god to come up out of the bowl.

The scene is Dread 3. Clemency does not run. She explains, kindly, that it had to be done, and that it has not worked yet, and that it needs another, a higher one; she looks at Vellum.

Vellum's oath. At dawn Lady Vellum Serrat takes the gilt wire from her tongue in front of the smokehouse door, kneels in Casimir's blood, lays her hand on his empty chest, and swears on the dead, aloud, without a single condition, for the first time in her life: *By this dead man, my cousin of the Table, I swear the Host shall be carved, and he shall have the first slice.* Her tongue splits a quarter-inch at the tip with an audible tick, and bleeds, and keeps her promise for her. From now on she will do anything to bring the Host to its seat at Thimble Cross, and she becomes the loudest voice for filling the ninth chair.

DAY SIX: THE SEEMING

Bell Lisle's last vial is gone by morning. Her nudger, if she has one among the characters, is all that keeps her upright, and she is blinking every minute, then every breath, and with every blink the Seeming spreads. Everyone in the common room rolls Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) each hour; those who fail see what Bell sees.

At the table the dead are sitting down to dinner. Walt Sallow with his clothes on and nothing in them. Abel Crumm, tucking his napkin in. Old Mother Ivy, with the barley still in her hair. Casimir with his hands in his lap, palms together. They are passing the bread. They are so happy. They are saying, in the voices of people you have loved, that there is room, that there is always room, that you look thin, that you should come and sit down. Outside the west windows, something very tall is stooping to look in, and its breath fogs every pane at once, and it is warm, and it is counting the chairs.

The Seeming is Dread 3 for each new witness, and contagious: anyone who Breaks while under it gains the derangement *I am already at the table* (they believe their body is seated, wasting, smiling, and that the self walking about the inn is a thing left behind). By afternoon, half the inn shares it. Hepzibah sets places at the pine tables for the dead.

Bell sleeps. In the late afternoon, with her nudger's hand on her wrist, Bell tells them quietly that she would like to stop now. She asks them not to pinch her. She gives her dispatch case to the character she trusts most. She says the room with the eye is warm and has a floor you can lie down on and that she has wanted to lie down for twenty-six years. She closes her eyes. She does not open them. Her chest goes on rising and falling, very slowly, in a rhythm

no one in the room can match. This is Dread 2, and for her nudger, Dread 3. The Seeming does not stop when she sleeps. It is the inn's now.

The reading. At dusk, Refrain Dole asks to see the ninth card again. She reads the second stroke aloud as *Late*, and tells the room

what the heretic Meek Garrity has found: that the Unfed did not refuse at Hallowboard, but arrived on the tenth day, when the table had already been cleared. “We’re not the ones who said no,” she says. “We’re the ones who came after. The late ones. That card has my people’s name on it. It’s had it for six hundred years.”

▼ ACT THREE: THE NINTH CHAIR (DAY SEVEN)

THE DEMAND

On the night of Day Six, or the morning of Tablenight, the inn meets in the common room around the Host's table, because there is nowhere else warm. The consensus builds out of every frightened voice in the house, and the GM should let each speak:

- ◇ **Clemency** says the Host will pass a house that offers it a clean guest: a mouth with no god in it. The ninth card is for the empty one.
- ◇ **Brawn** says this is only the dusk roster by another name, and sound husbandry: feed the table one by choice and it will not take nine by force.
- ◇ **Vellum**, sworn, says that a full table is a table the Host must come to sit at, and that she will pay any price to fill it.
- ◇ **Hepzibah** says the house cannot refuse a guest, and a chair laid empty in her house is a guest refused.
- ◇ **Ardent**, asked directly whether filling the ninth chair will spare the others, says, with terrible gentleness, "I don't know. Nobody has ever sat there." The room hears what it needs to.

The demand settles on Refrain, because she is Unfed, because she is caged, and because she belongs to nobody in the room. Kale will not give up his property for nothing. What follows is an auction in reverse: the frightened inn passes a hat for the price of a woman. Brawn puts in a platter. Vellum puts in a sworn note against her own flesh. The drovers put in Abel's lacks. Let the characters choose whether to pay, to refuse, to fight, or to offer someone else, themselves included.

IF THE PLAYERS FIGHT THE DEMAND

They may. Freeing Refrain from the cage and holding the stable against Kale's men and Clemency's converts is a fine, desperate scene (see Combat Encounters). It changes nothing that matters. If Refrain is free, she listens to the room arguing over who else should go: Merrit, whose card is on the table; Dorcas, who has asked to; a character. And she walks into the common room on her own feet, with her axe over her shoulder, and sits down in the ninth chair. "Not because you asked," she says. "Because I'm the only one here who knows how to sit at that table and still mean no." If the players have kept her caged and treated her as stock, she is dragged to the chair instead, and that is worse.

OTHER VOLUNTEERS

If Refrain is dead, gone, or the players have made another figure the heart of the story, the volunteer is whoever they love most. Merrit Sloe volunteers because her card is already on the table and she reckons she might as well sit in a better chair. Dorcas Thimble volunteers because the ninth chair is the one place on earth her oath cannot follow her. A player character may volunteer; let them, and let it cost exactly what it costs everyone else. Never force a character into the chair.

THE SACRIFICE

At dusk on Tablenight the volunteer is washed, as the Fast washes its dead, and Hepzibah lays a clean napkin over their arm. Ardent, who cannot refuse to help lay a table, draws the ninth chair out from the table for the first time in six hundred years. It makes a small sound on the flags. Everyone in the room makes a Dread 2 check.

Refrain does not thank it. She sits down in it the way a woman sits down in a dentist's chair, all at once, with her jaw set, and lays her axe across her knees. Nothing happens. The bread steams. The lamps burn. Somebody laughs, high and frightened, and stops. Refrain looks at the plate in front of her, which is empty, and says, "No, thank you," and then again, and then a third time, and her voice cracks on the third, because the smell of the bread is coming up off the empty plate and she has been hungry her whole life. She does not say it a fourth time. Her hand is shaking on the axe. Outside, the marbling across the yard begins, very slowly, to melt, in a long dark path from the north gate to the door.

THE HOST

At midnight the Host comes, as it was always going to.

The door opens without a hand on it. The room goes warm all at once, warm as a kitchen on baking day, and every hungry person in it feels their mouth flood. Something stoops in the doorway, too tall for it, and comes in. Nobody sees its face. Characters who try to look straight at it see only the impression of a broad, kind, bending shape, an apron, enormous patient hands, and the light of the lamps leaning toward it. To be in the presence of the Host is a Dread 4 check; to look for its face is Dread 5. Every character must also roll Caul + Resolve against Grim 18 to keep from walking to their own place and sitting down, and Refrain's Gift may help one of them.

The Host goes first to the ninth chair. It stands over the volunteer for a long moment. Then, gently, the way you would lift a sleeping child from a chair that belonged to a grandparent, it lifts them out. It is not angry. It is something like sorry.

Ardent, in the corner, whispers, “Oh. Oh, no. That isn’t anybody’s. It’s not for sitting in.”

The Host pushes the ninth chair back in, square to the table, its back to the lamp. Then it lays a tenth place. The table is a little longer than it was. There is a new plate, a new chair pulled out a hand’s width, and a new card in a fine round hand, and the name on it is the volunteer’s, and the handwriting is their mother’s. The volunteer reads it. Their face changes. They sit down at their own place, and lift the empty fork, and put it in their mouth, and close their eyes.

“Oh,” says Refrain Dole, who broke two hundred and six tables, who never once in her life ate until she was full. “Oh, it’s bread. It’s just bread. It’s warm. Why did nobody tell me it

was just bread?” She is crying. She is smiling. She takes another bite of nothing. “You should sit down,” she says to you, kindly, with her mouth full. “There’s enough. I didn’t know there would be enough.”

Watching this is Dread 4. It is the moment the players understand the sacrifice bought nothing. The ninth chair is still empty. Their own cards are still on the table. The Host turns, warm and patient, toward the rest of the room, and the invitation stands. Outside, at the edges of the dark path, the marbling is still hungry, and the Reaping will take anyone who flees across it alone before dawn. Nothing has changed except that there is one more guest at the table, and she is happy, and she will be happy for a hundred years.

From here, play out the night. Each hour until dawn, every character inside the inn rolls Caul + Resolve against Grim 18 to stay out of their chair; Seated NPCs call to them by name; the hungry and the Seemed walk past them to sit. The Host does not compel anyone. It only waits, and lays more food, and is kind.

▼ COMBAT ENCOUNTERS

The Gleanings (Day Four, dusk). Six figures come out of the marbled yard to the windows and doors: field-grown things shaped like the Reaped, with root-tangled feet, smooth rind for skin, and the faces of Walt Sallow, Robb Hayle, Old Mother Ivy and others, eyes closed. They knock and ask to come in. If refused, they press against the glass until it bows, and come through. They fight to drag the living out onto the marbled ground at dusk. They are destroyed when their face is cut away; what is left smells of bread and sap.

GLEANING Threat 2 · Flesh 12 · Guard 11 · Attack +5 (root-grip 3; on a hit the target is held and dragged one step toward marbled ground each round, Gut + Athletics Hard 14 to break free) · Armor 1 · Dread 2 (3 if it wears a face the viewer knew)

The Stable (Day Six or Seven). Freeing Refrain means facing Kale and his two men, and, after Day Four, three of Clemency’s converts who want her for the chair. Kale fights to disable, not kill: dead Blanks sell for a quarter. If outmatched he surrenders and offers to sell the characters something.

The Smokehouse (Day Five, night). Clemency and four converts, armed with lancers. Clemency does not stop preaching while she fights. Each round, one convert who hears her and is not attacked that round must roll Caul + Resolve (Hard 14) or keep fighting even at Ruin.

The Cellar (Day Four, night). Linus, grieving and terrible, with the cleaver, between the characters and his father’s body. Talking him down (Tongue + Persuade, Grim 18) ends the fight; a Grace gets the cleaver handed over, handle first.

▼ CLUES AND WHAT THEY REVEAL

CLUE	WHERE	WHAT IT REVEALS
Notches under the stamp	The yard	Thirteen barrels are different
The manifest	Abel’s wagon	The far-field barrels; Robb Hayle
Abel’s note	The cold store	What is in the barrels; why he died
The gold ring in the pot	The kitchen	The pottage; Absalom’s crime
The spade and the folded shroud	The graveyard	Ivy was dug up from above
Breathing hollows in the coffins	The graveyard	The marbling eats from below
Family register and opinion of 488	The parlour	The charter; the Thimble blood

CLUE	WHERE	WHAT IT REVEALS
Fork badge with two tines	Kale's coat	His buyer is the Second Table
Bell's dispatch	Bell's case	The Vigil's offer to Sallowreach
The ninth card	The table	A name nobody here bears

▼ ENDINGS

None of these endings is happy. Some are survivable.

ENDING ONE: NO, THANK YOU

The characters refuse. They take Refrain's lesson and turn their backs on the table, and, discovering that the dark, warm path the Host walked in on is the one stretch of ground the Reaping cannot touch, they go out and stand on it, outdoors, with their backs to every door, from midnight until dawn, as the Unfed do on Tablenight. Behind them, through the open door, they hear the Seated praising the food, calling their names, asking why they will not come in. Each hour, a Dread 3 check. At dawn the warmth goes out of the air and the marbling melts into a stinking yellow slush that runs away down the Rim Road, and the inn is silent. Inside, at a table now seventeen places long, sit everyone who could not refuse: the Thimbles first, because they never could. The characters survive. Thimble Cross becomes a little Long Table, and the Company strikes it from the ledger.

ENDING TWO: THE STEWARD'S APRON

A character speaks to Ardent through the long night and learns that he can be relieved. If a character accepts his position, in so many words, Ardent takes off his apron and folds it and hands it over, and weeps with relief, and sits down at the table himself, at a place that was always there and that nobody noticed was his. At dawn the new steward walks north up the Hungry Lane a mile ahead of something tall and warm, with a box of cutlery under one arm, and does not

come back. The character becomes an NPC. The Host, now, has a steward who knows the players' names. Everyone else at the inn who was not Seated survives.

ENDING THREE: THE LONG TABLE

The characters sit. Perhaps the Seeming has them; perhaps the Laden Taste; perhaps they are simply tired, and cold, and it is just bread. It is the warmest night of their lives. They will be lucid for months. They will describe each course to the next travellers who reach Thimble Cross, and to the ones after that. This ending is a gentle total party loss, and players who choose it with open eyes should be allowed to.

ENDING FOUR: ASHES AND TABLECLOTH

The characters burn it down: the table, the common room, the inn, the Seated in their chairs, who do not get up and do not stop smiling and go on praising the food as the cloth catches. The Thimble charter breaks with the house, and so do the last Thimbles, their bodies folding and snapping in the yard as the blood fails to endure; Haverick, failing to keep the peace, breaks too, quietly, in the toll house, having written *relieved* in the ledger beforehand. The characters run south across melting marbling at dawn, and the field takes one more of them if it can. They survive. At the next crossroads down the Rim Road, two days later, there is a table, laid, with their names on the cards.

▼ AFTERMATH

Survivors leave Thimble Cross changed. Award each surviving character a **Mark of the Laid Place**: from now on, whenever they enter a house where a meal is being served, they know, without looking, how many chairs are at the table, and which one is pushed in. Characters who ate from the notched barrels keep the Laden Taste until they spend a session's Portions to be rid of it, or never. Characters who Broke keep their Derangements; the most fitting here are *I am already at the table*, *The barrels are saying grace*, and *Everyone I love has been replaced by someone politer*.

PORTIONS

Award **5 to 10 Portions** per session, using these guidelines:

- ◇ 2 for surviving the session.
- ◇ 1 for each major secret uncovered (the barrels, the pottage, the charter, the Second Table's purpose, the ninth chair).
- ◇ 1 to 2 for standing beside someone on the marbled ground at dusk, or keeping Bell Lisle awake an hour longer, or any act of costly decency.
- ◇ 1 for refusing the table's food when starving.

- ◇ 1 for a moment of play the whole table will remember.
- ◇ In the final session, 2 more for being present when the sacrifice fails, whatever the character did.

THREADS: WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

- ◇ **The Host on the Road.** Orrum no longer waits for its steward. If a character became the steward, the next adventure can begin with the other characters finding a table laid by someone they know. If not, Ardent walks on, more tired than before, and the Hostwatch will want to hear everything.
- ◇ **The Blank Trade.** Kale's Second Table buyer is waiting in the Vigil and was paid half in advance. Dr. Mercy Thrane would very much like to see the badge.
- ◇ **The Deadwatch.** Bell Lisle's dispatch, carried by a character, is the Warden-Prime's offer to buy the secret of Keeping. It is addressed to Castellan Dray in Lastgate, and he is waiting for it.
- ◇ **The Second Table.** Vellum Serrat, if she lives, is sworn on the dead to carve the Host, and her tongue will not let her rest. She knows Wont Bellamy. She has measurements.
- ◇ **Eight Chairs.** The ninth card can be carried away; it is cold and damp and never dries. Cray Lobbett, Meek Garrity and Grandfather Peat would each give anything to see it. Nobody should tell them who it might be for.

- ◇ **The Long Count.** Brawn's little book of dusk names is the Board's own tally of the Reaping. Pell Hogget would weep to have it. The Board would kill to get it back.

Entered in the station ledger of Thimble Cross, Tablenight, 641 A.G., in a hand that is not the warden's.

Guests: all.

Stores: sufficient.

Ninth place: laid. Unclaimed.



CHAPTER 18

SECRETS OF THE TABLE

Eight gods. Seven peoples. Six meals and one refusal. The arithmetic does not close.

– MARGINAL NOTE IN THE MASTER CONCORDANCE AT QUIRE, IN THE
ARCHPROVOST'S HAND

PLAYERS, STOP HERE

This chapter is for the Game Master alone. It answers the questions the rest of the book refuses to: who the Eighth was, why the Providers held still, what the Regrowth is for, what Orrum is laying its tables for, and how the Long Grace ends. If you are a player, close the book here. Nothing in this chapter will help your character survive, and everything in it will spoil the slow, horrible pleasure of finding out at the table. The people of the Table have spent six hundred and forty-one years chiseling this answer out of the world. Do them the courtesy.

▼ HOW TO USE THIS CHAPTER

What follows is the default truth of the setting: one coherent answer to every mystery the other chapters raise. It is built to be discovered piece by piece over a long campaign, through the Eight Chairs thread and the clues scattered through every land. After it come three alternate truths, one for each of the Three Doctrines, for GMs who prefer a different answer or whose players have read too much.

Last comes How the Grace Ends: five apocalypses, any of which can serve as a campaign's finale.

Whichever truth you choose, hold to one rule. The answer must never be a solution. Knowing why the world is ending should change what the characters fear, what they choose and whom they forgive. It must never give them a way to stop it. The Long Grace is a grace, said before a meal. The meal is coming.

▼ THE DEFAULT TRUTH: THE GUEST

WHAT THE EIGHTH WAS

The eighth figure, the one chiseled out of every carving older than the Gorging, was not a Provider. It provided nothing. Its oldest name, recoverable from the chisel-shadows on four hundred carvings by anyone patient enough to make rubbings and lay them over one another (as Archprovost Hesper Lune has done), is **the Guest**.

The Guest was the god of hunger itself. Not appetite, which is a body's wanting, but hunger: the pure, sourceless, unsatisfiable fact of a mouth. Its people were every people. It had no land, because it had a chair at every table. In every house on the old Table, at every meal, there was a place for it, and that place was the reason meals were eaten at all, because without the Guest no one would ever have needed to eat. The other seven gods were each the god of something. The Guest was the god of *needing* something.

The old carvings show eight figures around a table. Seven face inward. The eighth is the one who sits. The seven Providers are shown standing, because they were not guests at that table. They were the hosts and the servers; Orrum pulls out the chairs, and the

others bring the dishes. The dishes, in the oldest carvings of all, which the College has never found intact, were the world's increase: seed, catch, calf, child, word, sleep, ending, poured upward through each god in turn and set before the one who sat.

That is what worship was. In Table-speech the words for *worship* and *eat* share a root, *orr-*, and scholars insist they always did. They are right. The giving back that every people made to its Provider was not eaten by the Provider. It was passed along. The gods were the Guest's stewards, and the peoples fed it through them, a little, every day, and in return it stayed in its chair and did not come into the kitchen.

THE GRACE

Lack keep away.

Every people on the Table says it before eating with a stranger. It is the only thing they all share besides the coin and the road. It is older than the Gorging, older than the Lack that gave it its modern name, older than the Rim. It is the last surviving prayer to the Guest. Its oldest form, which a few fen grandmothers and a few

Oathen Clausewrights still know, is longer, and in Table-speech it means: *Guest, you have been fed; keep to your chair.*

Every stranger at a table is a little bit the Guest. That is why the grace is said with strangers and not with family. It is a ward. It is the reason, for ten thousand years, the Guest never stood up.

The Rim Road custom of setting one extra chair at every inn table on Tablenight and turning it to face the wall is another ward, and a very old one, and the innkeepers who keep it have no idea what it is for. A chair turned to the wall is a place laid for someone who has been asked to leave.

THE LONG LACK

Ten years before the Gorging, the Guest stopped staying in its chair.

Nobody knows why. The GM may decide, or leave it unknown; the people of the Table never learned, and that absence is the oldest wound in the world. Perhaps the giving back had grown thin, in an age of plenty when people forgot to say the long grace. Perhaps it was simply time, as winter is time. Perhaps (and this is the answer the seabed table suggests) it had done this before, many times, and the world was only due.

What happened is that the Guest sat down at every table at once. It took its place in every kitchen, every granary, every womb, every net, invisible, and ate. It ate the world's increase before the world could have it. That is what the Long Lack was. Seed did not rot in the ground; it was eaten in the ground, the beginning sucked out of it, and what was left rotted. The ash bread was bread the Guest had eaten in the oven, leaving only the shape. The nets came up empty because what swam into them was eaten on the way up. Women did not conceive because the Guest was sitting in that chair too. For nine years, nothing began, because the Guest ate beginnings.

And it ate gods. The Guest's proper food is not the world's increase but what the increase passes through. As the Lack went on, it turned to the stewards themselves. The Providers grew thin not from shared hunger but because they were being eaten, slowly, from the inside, by the thing they had served since before there were people. They stopped speaking because it had eaten their voices first. They lay down because it had eaten their strength.

THE ELDEST WALK, REVISITED

The priests who met at Hallowboard in the eighth year read the carvings on the table's eight sides and found a line of small figures walking toward the table. They read it as a tithe owed to the Providers. They were not wrong that it was a tithe. They were wrong about who it was owed to and what the figures were. The walking figures in the oldest carvings are not offerings. They are the courses, carried in.

The Eldest Walk changed nothing. Sixty thousand firstborn opened their throats at the feet of gods who could not accept them, because the gods were no longer anyone's to accept; they were food.

The Guest did not take the eldest either. The Guest eats increase, beginnings, gods. The dead are none of these. The eldest lay where they were laid until their families came back for them with sacks.

Play this straight and let it hurt. It is the most useless act in the history of the world, and it is also the only reason the world survived, because it is the act that turned the knives. Without the Walk, the peoples would have gone on hoping until they died. The Walk proved that the gods would save no one. The fury of that proof is what made the Gorging possible. The Providers could not ask to be eaten; their voices were gone. They needed their peoples to want to.

WHY THE PROVIDERS HELD STILL

They held still because being eaten was the only place left to hide.

The Guest eats gods, and it finds them by their wholeness. A god is a single great thing, a mountain of meaning, and it cannot be overlooked. But a god cut into ten thousand portions and swallowed by ten thousand mouths is no longer a single thing. It is a trace in the blood of a people, a little salt in the lungs, a little grey in the hands, scattered through bodies that each have their own small hungers. The Guest, coming to the table and finding the dishes gone, could not tell god from eater. A coin hidden in a sack of coins.

So when the knives came, the Providers lay down and held still and let themselves be divided. The Cuts were not merely the shape of the meal; they were the shape of the hiding. Some portions of each god had to be large enough to keep the god's nature whole somewhere, in a few bloodlines, and those families became the nobility. The rest was spread as thin as it could be spread. Ossel smiled. Ummer watched with kind eyes. Iss never woke, because a sleeping god is quieter. Vey kept beginning again until it could be swallowed small. Tolm listened, and what it heard was that its people were not speaking, and that was so: a meal with no words, in front of a god whose nature was to make speech true, was the quietest possible place to disappear into.

Then the Guest stood up from the table. The food was gone. On the morning after the Gorging, it left. And the world exhaled. That is why the crops rose in a week: not a miracle, but nine years of withheld increase coming back all at once, the world's held breath let out. *This was not grown*, said Tallis Brome in the Fatlands. *This was poured*. She was right. It was poured back.

ORRUM, AND MEEK GARRITY'S SEATING PLAN

Orrum the Host was the only one of the seven who did not need to hide on its own account, because of what it was. A Host is not food; a Host is the one who serves. The Guest cannot eat its Host, any more than a guest at a feast can eat the house. That is the oldest law of the table, older than the Providers, and it binds the Guest as it binds every guest who has ever sat down.

But Orrum had a duty. A Host must feed whoever comes. So it did the only thing a Host can do when a terrible guest arrives: it arranged the meal. Meek Garrity has found its seating plan, and he has misread it, as the Unfed would.

The plan is in a hand that is not human. It is a list of the seven peoples and the seven Providers, which people eats which god, in what order, on which night of a single Plate, so that every god would be hidden before the Guest noticed the dishes disappearing. Orrum drew it up and sent it, by dream and by carving and by the hands of its priests, to every land. It is the reason the Night of Seven Tables happened everywhere at once without anyone agreeing to it. It is the reason the Cuts follow the same pattern in every land. Orrum seated the world.

It put its own people last, on the tenth day, because a Host eats last. It meant, perhaps, to lie down on Hallowboard at the very end and be eaten by the heartland and hidden too, the final course, after everyone else was safe. The plan's last line, in Orrum's hand, reads: *After the tenth day, the table is cleared.* It is not a record. It is a warning. After the tenth day, it would be too late.

The heartland was the largest of the lands, and its people were the weakest, and the snow lay deep. They arrived on the tenth day. The Guest had already risen from the table at dawn. Orrum lay on Hallowboard and heard them coming and opened its eyes and looked toward the eighth side, where the Guest had sat, and the Guest was not there. The meal was over. If the Unfed had eaten Orrum then, they would have been the only people on the Table carrying a god the Guest had already noticed, and it would have come back for them, and for everyone. So Orrum got up. Its people never refused. They were late, and the others had left them nothing. Nine in ten of them died with a meal in front of them that it was no longer safe to eat.

The survivors made a virtue of it. They called it the Refusal. It is the founding lie of the only innocent people in the world, and Meek Garrity is about to take it away from them.

WHY THE LACK NEVER LEFT THE FAST

When the Guest stood up, it marked its place. A diner who means to return leaves something on the chair. The Fast is the Guest's napkin. The one land that did not eat is the one land the Guest has kept its mouth on: the Lack never lifted there because the Guest never entirely left. Seed still rots in the Fast because it is still being eaten in the ground. The heartland's people live inside the last, quiet, continuing remnant of the Long Lack, and have for six hundred and forty-one years, and believe it is their reward for virtue.

The single green sprout in Yield Hartsell's field is not a sign the Lack is ending. It is a sign that the Guest has stood up from that chair, too. It is on its way somewhere else.

THE REGROWTH

The Regrowth is the Providers coming back out of hiding, and they are doing it because the Guest is returning.

Where the Guest went when it left the Table, nobody knows. Beyond the edges of the world there is sea and wasteland and salt, and nobody who has gone looking has come back with anything worth the trip. It may have other tables. It may make rounds. The College's graph, which shows every land's Regrowth bending upward at once around 600 A.G., marks the moment it turned back toward the Table. Every Regrowth is speeding up because the Guest is getting closer.

The gods are not rising out of malice or out of justice. They are being flushed out. A god hidden in a people is a god in a trap: if the Guest comes and cannot find the god, it will eat the people to get at it, the way a man who has lost a coin in the bread eats the loaf. The hidden gods know this, as much as they know anything now. Every instinct they have left says *get out*. So they are trying to gather themselves back together, out of ten thousand bodies, into something whole that can run. Every Seating is a god trying to stand up.

The tragedy is that a god that gathers itself back together is a god the Guest can find. The gods are fleeing straight into the open. They cannot help it. The hunger in the blood, which the rules call Hunger and which every character feels when they Partake, is the Guest's approach felt from inside the food. When a character's Hunger fills and their Regrowth rises, that is a god flinching toward the door.

WHAT THE SEATINGS WILL DO

A full Seating, in any land, is a god whole again, wearing its people or its ground. Each one is a dish carried back to the table. Three lands are close.

- ◇ **Sallowreach.** The Hushes are Ossel's body re-forming in the fen, a piece at a time, wherever Hand-line blood is thickest. When they join, the fen will be one great Hush, and Ossel will lie in it, whole, grey, with its hands open, as it lay on the first night. The Kept will finish, all at once. Their silence will be the first course.
- ◇ **The Vigil.** The Counted are Iss, gathered into sixty thousand sleeping bodies in one shared dream. The number Matron Dorm keeps is the number of sleepers required to hold the whole god. When the last bed fills, the eye in the long room opens. Iss has never been awake. The first thing it will ever see is the Guest's chair.
- ◇ **Cradlewrack.** The land is in labor with Vey. Every Part is a piece of the god born early, and the Assemblers' figure is an attempt to deliver it by hand. When the pangs close to nothing, the Dilation will open fully and Vey will be born whole out of the ground, the size of the highlands.

- ◇ **Brinehollow.** The sea is moving into the Tenanted because Dromm is gathering itself back together in their bodies and in the Trench, pulling its element home. When the last of the sea has gone in, Dromm will rise from the Trench as it was dragged from it, and the coast will be dry to the horizon.
- ◇ **The Fatlands.** Ummer is regrowing in the soil and in the Laden. The Reaping is the god gathering its portions out of the people who carry them. When enough of the plains are Seated, the land will stand up and walk, as Ummer walked, and the fields will bow toward it.
- ◇ **Oathen.** Tolm is regrowing in its Sayers, and the widening of what binds (handtalk, writing, thought) is the god's attention spreading back out through its people. When a Sayer fully Seats, Tolm will speak with one voice again, and what it says will be so. Its last promise, the Kept Rain, slipped because the god keeping it is moving.

When all six are Seated, the Table will look as it did on the eve of the Gorging: six gods, whole, in their lands, gaunt and frightened, with nowhere left to hide. And at Hallowboard, the Host will have laid the table.

WHAT ORRUM IS LAYING THE TABLES FOR

Orrum is a Host. A Host must feed whoever comes. It knows the Guest is coming back, and it is laying a place for the Guest. That is the whole of it, and the cruelty is that Orrum cannot do otherwise.

Every table Orrum lays has one chair without a place card. That chair is the Guest's. Every table at a crossroads in another land marks the road the Guest will walk, the way a household sets lamps along the drive on the night of a great dinner. The Long Table in the valley, nine miles of the Seated, is the high table. And when the Guest sits, the Host must serve what the Guest asks for, and the Guest asks for gods. Orrum will have to bring them in. It has been the steward of the Guest's table since before there were people, and every Seating that brings a god back together brings it closer to Orrum's hands.

But there is a second thing Orrum is doing, and it is the closest thing to love in this book. The law that binds the Guest says it cannot eat its Host, and it cannot eat its Host's other guests. Anyone seated at a Host's table as a guest is under the Host's protection. The Seated are not food. They are sheltered. Orrum has spent six hundred and forty-one years trying to seat its own people, the Unfed, where the Guest cannot touch them, and they have spent six hundred and forty-one years saying *No, thank you*. The place cards with names, the crusts replaced with something better on Abby Rooke's windowsill, the week Little Fain spent being fed and the one who cried when it was time to go: all of it is the Host pleading.

It is no rescue. The Seated waste at the table for decades, eating air, praising empty plates, alive and smiling and gone. To be sheltered by Orrum is to stop living in every way except the last. And Orrum is now laying tables outside the Fast, in every land, and the names on the cards are not only Unfed names. It is trying to seat as many as it can before the Guest arrives. It will not be enough. It knows that too. Spare Tolland of the Hostwatch thinks it is lonely. It is. It is a host on the night before the worst dinner in the world, setting places for the children in the kitchen, knowing the guest of honor eats children.

Welcome Ardent, the first Unfed ever to accept, was offered a position because the Host needed a steward who could walk among people and lay tables without frightening them. He has spent six centuries doing it. He knows whose chair the empty one is. He would like very much to be relieved.

GRANDFATHER PEAT'S SMILING GOD

Grandfather Peat is the boy at the back of the crowd on the night Sallowreach ate Ossel, the peat-cutter's son who never ate and who stared past the god at the empty bank on the far side of the fire. He drowned that week, and because he drowned in Sallowreach in the first week of the Gorging, he was among the very first of the Kept, sealed in bog and brine and found centuries later, still aware.

He says the god was smiling. He is right, and the full account, which he will give to anyone who learns his dialect and asks the right question, is this. Sallowreach ate last of all the peoples, slowest, because no one wanted to begin. By the time the fen-folk were halfway through Ossel, every other god on the Table had been swallowed. The Guest had come to the fen, to the last dish still on the table. It sat on the empty bank across the fire. Peat saw it, because he was the only one not looking at the food. He describes it as *the shape the fog makes around someone who isn't there*, very tall, sitting, with its hands in its lap and its face turned toward the god. It was waiting for the fen-folk to finish so it could have what was left.

And Ossel, half eaten, its hands still lifting to close the eyes of dying children, turned its great grey face toward the Guest across the fire and smiled at it. It was the smile of a hunted thing that has reached cover just in time and knows it. It was the smile of a god of endings who had just understood how this one ended. The Guest looked at Ossel, and then it looked at Peat, who was looking at it. Peat ran. The fen took him. He has been underwater, more or less, for six hundred years, and he has had time to think about what the Guest's face did when it smiled back.

CRAY LOBBETT'S EIGHT-CHAIR TABLE

The stone table on the far Uncovered is older than the Gorging. It is older than the Providers. It is older than the sea that covered it. It is

a table from a world before this one, and the Guest ate at it.

The seven chairs pushed in belonged to seven gods who came before the Providers, in an age nobody remembers, and who did not find a place to hide. When a diner has finished, the chair is pushed in. Those seven are finished. The Providers grew, in the long ages after, out of what fell from that table: crumbs, the way gods are born when a world has been eaten nearly clean. That is how the Providers knew what to do when the Long Lack came. They had been crumbs on the floor at the last one.

The eighth chair is pulled out because the Guest has never pushed it in. It does not finish. It goes away and comes back. The sea's retreat is Dromm gathering itself, but its effect is to uncover the table, and the Tenanted who sing at the lowest tide are singing, in a language Ilse Marl has been writing down as a chart, the directions to it.

Cray Lobbett cannot stop going back because the chair is inviting him. Each time he visits, it is pulled out a little further, toward him. He has not sat down. He has measured the distance with a knotted cord, and by his reckoning he has three visits left.

MEEK GARRITY, PEAT AND LOBBETT TOGETHER

Put the three together, as the Eight Chairs thread invites, and the characters have the whole of the default truth: an old table where the Guest ate the gods before; a fen where it sat to watch the last of the Providers disappear and was smiled at; a seating plan in the Host's hand that arranged the hiding of the world and missed its own people by a day. What they do with it is their business. Knowing it changes nothing, except this: the characters will understand that every Seating they help along, every Regrowth they hasten, every god they summon out of its hiding to cure or kill or fix something, is a dish carried to the table.

▼ THE ALTERNATE TRUTHS

The default truth is the Guest. A GM may prefer a world in which one of the Three Doctrines is simply correct. Each of the following replaces the default answers in full. Clues already planted in the other chapters (the chiseled figure, the eighth chair, the seating plan, the smiling god, the seabed table) still work; they only point somewhere else.

THE THEFT: THE BILL

We murdered them. The Regrowth is justice, and we deserve it.

The Eighth. The Eighth was the god of increase: not harvest, which was Ummer's, but *more*, the simple fact that there could be more tomorrow than today. It lived among all the peoples, invisibly,

WHAT THE SECOND TABLE'S SECOND MEAL WOULD CAUSE

The Second Table's creed is *It worked once*. It did. The diners do not understand why.

The first meal worked because the gods chose it, held still for it, and were scattered through ten thousand mouths so thinly that the Guest could not find them. The Second Table plans the opposite. A few dozen diners, all of them High Cuts, intend to eat six whole gods between them. A god eaten by a few is not hidden; it is concentrated. It is plated. Each diner of the second meal would become a single, dense, unmistakable vessel of a god, sitting at a single table, ready to serve. The Second Table is not preparing a second Gorging. It is preparing the Guest's dinner, by hand, and seating itself in the dishes. The blank eighth line at the foot of their menus is not a missing course. It is the line for the diner, and it is not them.

And then there is Wont Bellamy's proposal: to begin with the one god still whole. If the Second Table eats Orrum, there is no Host. The law that binds the Guest is a law of hospitality: a guest eats what is set before it, and only that, and spares the house and the household. Kill the Host and there is no house, and no household, and no law. The Guest would arrive at a Table with no one to lay it, no chair to keep it in, no grace that means anything, and it would do what hunger does when no one is serving it. It would eat the Table. Not the gods in it; the Table itself, every field, every body, every road, every season, every beginning, until there was nothing to begin again from. The College calls this, in the one ledger it has written about it, *the Unhosting*.

The Head of the Table, who presides from an empty chair at every Second Table dinner and has never been seen, is no one. The diners each believe one of the others knows who it is. The chair is pulled out at every dinner because the first Carvers, centuries ago, found that it would not stay pushed in.

as the surplus in every granary. In the generation before the Lack, in an age of fat and pride, the peoples found it, and caught it, and ate it, a little in every land, in secret, to have more than their neighbors. It was the first Gorging, and nobody ever spoke of it. The chisel marks dated before the Gorging are the guilt of the first eaters, cutting their victim out of every carving.

The Lack. The Lack was simply the world without increase. Nothing began because the god of beginning-again was in the peoples' bellies. The Providers starved because there was no longer any more of anything.

Why the Providers held still. Each was bound by its own nature, and could not resist without ceasing to be itself. Ossel could

not refuse an ending. Ummer could not refuse to feed. Dromm held still because it was the god of keeping things down. Iss could not wake. Vey could not refuse to begin again. Tolm heard the peoples' silence and could not make it untrue. They held still in grief and contempt, and they let themselves be eaten so that the peoples would carry, in their blood, a debt that could be collected.

The Regrowth. It is the bill. The gods are growing back to take what is owed, with six centuries of interest, and the Seatings are the gods standing up in their courtroom. **Orrum** lays its tables as an accusation: every table has a place for the Eighth, the first one eaten, the one that was never mourned, and the Seated are those who have accepted their sentence. **Peat's smiling god** was smiling the way a creditor smiles. **Garrity's seating plan** is a list of debts. **The seabed table** is where the Eighth was eaten. **The Second Table's meal** would be a second murder with the bailiff already in the room, and the gods would rise in each diner at once.

How this changes play. The Theft is a world of guilt. Nothing that happens is unfair. Characters who seek to escape the Regrowth are bilking a creditor, and the creditor is in their blood. Atonement is possible in small ways; it does not reduce the bill.

THE GIFT: THE LOVE THAT DOES NOT FIT

They offered themselves out of love. The Regrowth is a tragedy neither side wanted.

The Eighth. The Eighth was the god of the shared table itself, the bond between the peoples: the stranger whose arrival makes a meal a feast, the reason anyone sets an extra place. It was old and tired, and when the Lack came (a natural disaster, a winter of the world, no one's fault) it was the first to give itself. It lay down and asked the other seven to eat it, so that they could go on feeding their peoples a little longer. They did. The Long Lack's middle years, when the gods grew thin but did not die, were the years they lived on it. The peoples, in grief and incomprehension, chiseled its figure out of every carving, because they could not bear to look at the place where it had been.

Why the Providers held still. Love, as the Thankers say. When the Eighth was gone and the Lack went on, the seven did what it had done, and gave themselves.

The Regrowth. It is the gods dying a second time, slowly, inside their peoples, because love that large does not fit in a body. It hurts them as it hurts their hosts. The Seatings are the gods trying, with their last strength, to give again: Ossel offering endings, Iss offering rest, Vey offering new beginnings, all of it too much, all of it ruinous. **Orrum** is the only one that was not allowed to give itself; its tables are the gift the Unfed refused, still being offered, and the

Seated are happy because they accepted. **Peat's smiling god** smiled because it loved the boy at the back and was glad he had not eaten. **Garrity's plan** is a list of who would be fed first. **The seabed table** is where the Eighth gave itself to the seven; its chair is pulled out in memory. **The Second Table's meal** would be accepted, gladly, by gods who cannot refuse to give, and would kill the diners with kindness in a single night.

How this changes play. The Gift is a world without villains, which is worse. Every horror is an act of love, and every act of love is a horror. There is nothing to fight. There is only grief, and the knowledge that the gods would stop if they could.

THE BAIT: THE BROOD

They wanted to be eaten. The Lack was theirs.

The Eighth. The Eighth was the parent. The seven Providers were its brood, and the eighth place in the carvings was the mother's place, at the head of the table, and the peoples cut it out because the brood, in their blood, told them to. The Eighth died long before the Gorging, or went away, as such things do when their young are grown.

The Lack. The Lack was the Providers' doing, exactly as the Baiters preach. They withheld the world's increase, together, for nine years, to bring their peoples to the edge of starvation, because a god cannot breed on its own. It must be eaten. The Eldest Walk was useless because the gods did not want people. They wanted to be wanted.

Why the Providers held still. A seed does not fight the ground.

The Regrowth. It is a hatching. Every High Cut body is an egg, and each will open, not into one god but into thousands, one per noble vessel, a brood of godlings for every land. The Seatings are the first hatchlings, and they are hungry, and their first meal will be the peoples that carried them. **Orrum** is the one that failed to breed. Its people refused, or were late, and it has been desperate for six centuries to be eaten by someone, anyone. Its tables are invitations. Eventually, the courses on them will include the Host. **Peat's smiling god** smiled the way a parent smiles at a christening. **Garrity's plan** is a planting chart. **The seabed table** is the nursery of the last brood, which hatched and ate its world and left only that. **The Second Table's meal** would be a second sowing: the gods, eaten again by a few, would breed again in those few, and the next generation of gods would be born from the bodies of the Table's nobility, in their beds, all at once.

How this changes play. The Bait is a world of parasitism, and its horror is biological. Everyone is incubating something. The doctrine's joyous cults are right, and the Second Helping's feasts are the most honest thing on the Table.

▼ HOW THE GRACE ENDS

These are five endings for the world, built as campaign finales. Each can be reached through the threads in the previous chapter; each has signs, a last act, and a final image. None of them offers real rescue. Characters can choose where to stand, whom to hold, what to say, and how much of the world goes down with dignity; they cannot stop the meal. Choose one in advance or let the campaign's threads decide. The Long Grace is a grace. When it ends, someone eats.

THE GUEST SITS DOWN

The default ending.

Signs. The eighth chair at every Rim inn, turned to the wall on Tablenight, is found turned to face the table in the morning, and cannot be turned back. Hunger rises in every godsigned character by 1 each week, with no Partaking. Seed begins to rot unsprouted again in the Fast's border villages, then in the Fatlands' outer fields. Three Seatings complete within a season: a Hush swallows Lastgate's eastern quarter, the Dormitory's last bed is filled, the Dilation opens. Welcome Ardent asks to be relieved and nobody answers.

The last act. On Tablenight, every table on the Table is laid at once, in every house, by no one. Every chair has a card but one. The grace is said everywhere, and for the first time in ten thousand years it does not work. The Guest arrives at Hallowboard and sits. Orrum, weeping, begins to serve. The gods are brought in from their lands one by one, and each land goes with its god: Sallowreach closed like a book, the Vigil asleep forever, the highlands born and swallowed, the coast dried to the bone, the plains eaten like a cut of meat, the canyons silenced mid-word.

What the characters can do. Choose a table. Characters who accept a place at one of Orrum's tables are Seated, sheltered, and will waste forever, smiling, in a world being eaten around them. Characters who refuse can spend the last night doing whatever matters most to them before their land's god is carried in. A character with a high Cut can try to keep their portion of the god from being gathered, and hold the Guest's attention on themselves for one hour, which is long enough for someone they love to reach Orrum's table.

The last image. The Long Lack, again, everywhere, for nine years in a single night. At dawn there is nothing left on the Table but the Fast, which is full of tables, and at every table a person, eating air, praising the food, and the Host walking among them, refilling glasses that are already full.

THE LAST SEATING

The gods come back.

Signs. The Seatings accelerate past any curve the College has drawn. Nobody needs the Guest for this ending; it may come or

not, later, it does not matter. The gods simply finish regrowing first. Every godsigned character's Regrowth rises by 1 each season.

The last act. Six gods stand up out of six lands in the same year. Ossel lies in a fen that is one silent Hush, and the Kept finish all at once, and the silence spreads south. Ummer rises out of the Fatlands, a living country on legs, with its people still growing on its back, and begins to walk. Dromm comes up out of the Trench with the sea inside it, and the Tenanted turn toward it as one. Iss opens its eye in the long room and every sleeper in the Dormitory sits up together. Vey is born out of the highlands. Tolm speaks through every Sayer at once. They have been in the dark for six hundred and forty-one years, cut up and swallowed and digested and held, and they remember exactly who ate them.

What the characters can do. Bargain, briefly, with a god that is only half itself and very hungry. Try to reach the Fast, the one land with no god to come home to. Stand between a god and its people and be the first thing it notices.

The last image. The gods walking the Rim Road, slowly, in the way they used to walk among their peoples, and the peoples of the Table lying in rows at their feet, as the eldest once lay, and this time the gods take them.

IT IS FIXED

The Sayer's Sentence, spoken.

Signs. The Sayer's Sentence thread reaches its fourth stage. The Bench has drafted, every land has bid, and the text runs to four hundred conditions. Its first and last line, the only one that matters, reads: *It is fixed.*

The last act. Lady Imre Dath's golden bit is removed in the Gilded Cells before the Bench, the envoys and the Mute King. She says it. What a Sayer says, is. Every Regrowth on the Table stops, at once, exactly where it stands. So does everything else. *Fixed* in Table-speech means mended, and it also means set fast, and Tolm has always taken words at their plainest. Nothing on the Table can change from that moment. The Kept do not rot further. The hungry are not fed. The sleepers do not wake and the waking do not sleep. Labor in Cradlewrack stops between one pang and the next and does not resume. The sea stands where it is. The rain will not come, and will not fail to come. Characters stop between one breath and the next.

What the characters can do. If a character is in the room, they get the time it takes for the sentence to leave her mouth: a single action, chosen before the first word. They might reach a hand toward someone. They might close their eyes. Whatever they choose, they will be doing it forever.

The last image. The whole Table as a still life, a painted meal: every person exactly as they were, aware, unable to blink, under a sun that does not move. And at Hallowboard, a Host frozen mid-stoop over a table it was laying, one hand on the back of the eighth chair, which it had been about to pull out.

THE LONG TABLE

Everyone accepts.

Signs. Orrum's tables spread beyond counting. The Host on the Road thread reaches its fourth stage. The Calling-Cards appear in every land with every name. Pilgrims stream into the Fast. The Fatlands' starving go first, then the Vigil's sleepless, then the Kept, who can sit at Orrum's tables only on the fen side of the Drop and do. The Unfed go last. They hold out for the longest. Then the Abstinents, starving, meet in the Pantry, and Elder Forbear Wend says *Yes, please*, once, and everyone hears it.

The last act. There is no last act. There is only sitting down. One by one, then by villages, then by lands, the people of the Table take their places at the Host's tables, where the Guest cannot touch them, and eat from empty plates, and praise the food, and smile, and do not get up. The Guest arrives to a world where every person is someone else's guest and there is nothing it is permitted to eat, and so it sits in its chair at Hallowboard, the only diner at the Table without a plate, and waits. It is very patient. It is hunger.

What the characters can do. Sit, or be the last ones standing. A character who refuses to the very end inherits the world: empty fields, empty roads, tables in every house, and somewhere in the middle of it a Guest that is waiting, and is eating the only food the Host is not protecting.

The last image. A table nine hundred miles long, around the whole Table, along the Rim, with everyone who ever lived on it seated, wasting, delighted. The grace said and said again, forever,

over a meal that never comes. *Lack keep away. Lack keep away.* The Long Grace, kept.

THE UNHOSTING

The Second Table eats.

Signs. The Second Table thread reaches its fourth stage. Wont Bellamy's motion passes, or is not needed. On Tablenight the Second Table gathers at Hallowboard with eight knives of grey bone, and the Host lies down on the eight-sided table, as it lay down once before, and looks at them with the look of someone who has heard the door.

The last act. They eat Orrum. It does not fight. Diners from every land, every one of them a High Cut, cut and chew and swallow the god of the shared table, and as they do, every hearth on the Table goes out at once, and every table in every house is, suddenly, only furniture. There is no longer any such thing as a host. There is no longer any such thing as a guest, in the old sense, bound by the rules of a house. There is only hunger, and a world with nobody to keep it in its chair. The Guest comes. It does not sit. There is nowhere for it to sit. It eats the Second Table first, as an appetizer, because they are full of gods; then it eats the gods in their lands; then it eats the lands themselves: every field, road, body and season, every beginning, until there is nothing for anything to begin again from.

What the characters can do. Be at Hallowboard, and try to stop it, and fail. Take a knife and eat, and be among the first eaten. Or go as far from the middle as the Table allows, to the edge of the sea or the salt, and watch it come.

The last image. Not a ruin. Nothing so solid. A plate licked clean, under a Plate licked clean: a round bare place where the Table was, with an eight-sided stone in the middle, wiped spotless, and beside it, pushed in, eight chairs.



EYE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	TONGUE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	CAUL	○ ○ ○ ○ ○
SEARCH	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	PERSUADE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	RESOLVE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○
LORE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	DECEIVE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	RITES	○ ○ ○ ○ ○
CRAFT	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	HAGGLE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	INSTINCT	○ ○ ○ ○ ○
RECKONING	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	CLAUSE	○ ○ ○ ○ ○	GODSIGN	○ ○ ○ ○ ○

WHAT YOU CARRY

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WEAPON _____ _____ _____ _____	ATTACK _____ _____ _____ _____	DAMAGE _____ _____ _____ _____	QUALITIES _____ _____ _____ _____
GEAR _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____		LEAVINGS & RELICS (TAINT) _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____	
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